

CHAPTER ONE

THE PEET

HARRY PEET WAS A HIGHLY UNUSUAL KID IN MANY WAYS. FOR ONE THING, HE HATED THE SUMMER HOLIDAYS MORE THAN ANY OTHER TIME OF YEAR. FOR ANOTHER, HE REALLY WANTED TO BE HIS FELLOW KID BUT WAS FORCED TO BE IT IN SECRET, IN THE DEAD OF NIGHT. AND HE ALSO HAPPENED TO BE A WIZARD.

IT WAS NEARLY MIDNIGHT, AND HE WAS LYING IN HIS STOMACH IN BED, THE BLANKETS DRAWN RIGHT OVER HIS HEAD LIKE A TENT, A FLASHLIGHT IN ONE HAND AND A LARGE LEATHER-BINDING BOOK (A HISTORY OF MAGIC BY KATHLEEN KAGAN) PROPPED OPEN AGAINST THE PILLOW. HARRY MOVED THE TIP OF HIS EAGLE-FEATHER QUILL DOWN THE PAGE, FROWNING AS HE SEARCHED FOR SOMETHING THAT WOULD HELP HIM WRITE HIS ESSAY, "WITCH-BURNING IN THE FIFTEENTH CENTURY WAS COMPLETELY POINTLESS DISCUSS."

THE QUILL PAUSED AT THE TOP OF A LIKELY-LOOKING PARAGRAPH. HARRY PLISHED HIS BINDING GLASSES UP THE BRIDGE OF HIS NOSE, MOVED HIS FLASHLIGHT CLOSER TO THE BOOK, AND READ:

NON-MAGIC PEOPLE (MORE COMMONLY KNOWN AS MUGGLES) WERE PARTICULARLY AFRAID OF MAGIC IN MEDIEVAL TIMES, BUT NOT VERY GOOD AT RECOGNIZING IT. EVEN THE RARE OCCASION THAT THEY DID CATCH A REAL WITCH OR WIZARD, BURNING HAD NO EFFECT WHATSOEVER. THE WITCH OR WIZARD WOULD PERFORM A BASIC FLAME FREEZING CHARM AND THEN PRETEND TO SHRIEK WITH PAIN WHILE ENJOYING A GENTLE, TICKLING SENSATION. INDEED, WENDOLIN THE WEIRD ENJOYED BEING BURNED SO MUCH THAT SHE ALLOWED HERSELF TO BE CALLED NO LESS THAN FORTYSEVEN TIMES IN VARIOUS DISGUISES.

HARRY PLUT HIS QUILL BETWEEN HIS TEETH AND REACHED UNDERNEATH HIS PILLOW FOR HIS INK BOTTLE AND A ROLL OF PARCHMENT. SILENTLY AND VERY CAREFULLY HE UNSCREWED THE INK BOTTLE, DIPPED HIS QUILL INTO IT, AND BEGAN TO WRITE, PAUSING EVERY NOW AND THEN TO LISTEN, REALISE IF ANY OF THE DURSLEYS HEARD THE SCRATCHING OF HIS QUILL IN THEIR WAY TO THE KITCHEN, HE'D

PREFERABLY FIND HIMSELF LOCKED IN THE CLIPBOARD UNDER THE STAIRS FOR THE
REST OF THE SUMMER.

THE DURSLEY FAMILY OF NUMBER FOUR, PRIVET DRIVE, WAS THE REASON THAT
HARRY NEVER ENJOYED HIS SUMMER HOLIDAYS. UNCLE VERNON, AUNT PETUNIA,
AND

2

THEIR SON, DUDLEY, WERE HARRY'S ONLY LIVING RELATIVES. THEY WERE
MUGGLES, AND THEY HAD A VERY MEDIOVAL ATTITUDE TOWARD MAGIC. HARRY'S
DEAD PARENTS, WHO HAD BEEN A WITCH AND WIZARD THEMSELVES, WERE NEVER
MENTIONED UNDER THE DURSLEYS' ROOF FOR YEARS. AUNT PETUNIA AND UNCLE
VERNON HAD FEARED THAT IF THEY KEPT HARRY AS DISTANT AS POSSIBLE,
THEY WOULD BE ABLE TO SUPPRESS THE MAGIC WITHIN HIM. THE THEIR PLAN, THEY
HAD BEEN UNSUCCESSFUL. THESE DAYS THEY LIVED IN TERROR OF ANYONE FINDING
OUT THAT HARRY HAD SPENT MOST OF THE LAST TWO YEARS AT HOGWARTS SCHOOL
OF WITCHCRAFT AND WIZARDRY. THE MOST THEY COULD DO, HOWEVER, WAS TO LOCK
AWAY HARRY'S SPELLBOOKS, WAND, CALENDAR, AND EMBROIDERY AT THE START OF
THE SUMMER BREAK, AND FORBID HIM TO TALK TO THE NEIGHBORS.

THIS SEPARATION FROM HIS SPELLBOOKS HAD BEEN A REAL PROBLEM FOR HARRY,
BECAUSE HIS TEACHERS AT HOGWARTS HAD GIVEN HIM A LOT OF HOLIDAY WORK,
SOME OF THE ESSAYS, A PARTICULARLY NASTY ONE ABOUT SHRIMPING POTTIONS, WAS
FOR HARRY'S LEAST FAVORITE TEACHER, PROFESSOR SNAPE, WHO WOULD BE
DELIGHTED TO HAVE AN EXCUSE TO GIVE HARRY DETENTION FOR A MONTH. HARRY
HAD THEREFORE SEIZED HIS CHANCE IN THE FIRST WEEK OF THE HOLIDAYS. WHILE
UNCLE VERNON, AUNT PETUNIA, AND DUDLEY HAD BEEN OUT IN THE FRONT
GARDEN TO ADMIRE UNCLE VERNON'S NEW COMPANY CAR (IN VERY GOOD VEHICLES, SHE
THAT THE REST OF THE STREET WOULD NOTICE IT TOO), HARRY HAD CREEPT
DOWNSTAIRS, PICKED THE BOOKS UP IN THE CLIPBOARD UNDER THE STAIRS, GRABBED
SOME OF HIS KNEES, AND HIDDEN THEM IN HIS BEDROOM. AS LONG AS HE DIDN'T

LEAVE SPORTS HE IND IN THE SHEETS, THE DURSLEYS NEED NEVER KNOW THAT HE WAS STUDYING MAGIC BY NIGHT.

HARRY WAS PARTICULARLY DEER THE AVOID TRIBLE WITH HIS AUNT AND UNCLE AT THE MOMENT, AS THEY WERE ALREADY IN AN ESPECIALLY BAD MOOD WITH HIM, ALL BECAUSE HE'D RECEIVED A TELEPHONE CALL FROM A FELLOW WIZARD ONE WEEK INTO THE SCHOOL VACATION.

RON WEASLEY, WHO WAS ONE OF HARRY'S BEST FRIENDS AT HOGWARTS, CAME FROM A WHOLE FAMILY OF WIZARDS. THIS MEANT THAT HE KNEW A LOT OF THINGS HARRY DIDN'T, BUT HAD NEVER USED A TELEPHONE BEFORE. MOST LIKELY, IT HAD BEEN UNCLE VERNON WHO HAD ANSWERED THE CALL.

"VERNON DURSLEY SPEAKING."

HARRY, WHO HAPPENED TO BE IN THE ROOM AT THE TIME, FREEZE AS HE HEARD RON'S VOICE ANSWER.

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"HELLO HELLO CAN YOU HEAR ME? I -- WANT -- THE -- TALK -- THE --

HARRY

-- BETTER?"

RON WAS YELLING SO LOUDLY THAT UNCLE VERNON LIMPED AND HELD THE RECEIVER A FEET AWAY FROM HIS EAR, STARING AT IT WITH AN EXPRESSION OF MIXED FURY AND ALARM.

"WHO IS THIS?" HE ROARED IN THE DIRECTION OF THE SPEECHPIPE. "WHO ARE YOU?"

"RON -- WEASLEY?" RON BELIEVED BACK, AS THOUGH HE AND UNCLE VERNON WERE

SPEAKING FROM OPPOSITE ENDS OF A FOOTBALL FIELD. "I'M -- A -- FRIEND -- OF -- HARRY'S -- FROM -- SCHOOL --"

UNCLE VERNON'S SMALL EYES SWIVELED AROUND THE HARRY, WHO WAS MEETING THE

THE SPOT.

"THERE IS NO HARRY POTTER FOR!" HE ROARED, NOW HOLDING THE RECEIVER

AT

ARM'S LENGTH, AS THOUGH FRIGHTENED IT MIGHT EXPLODE. "I DON'T KNOW WHAT

STUPID YOU'RE TALKING ABOUT! NEVER CONTACT ME AGAIN!

DON'T CALL ME NEAR

MY FAMILY!"

AND HE THREW THE RECEIVER BACK INTO THE TELEPHONE AS IF DROPPING A PHILIPPINE SPIDER.

THE FIGHT THAT HAD FOLLOWED HAD BEEN ONE OF THE WORST EVER.

"HOW DARE YOU GIVE THIS NAME TO THE PEOPLE LIKE -- PEOPLE LIKE

YOU!" LUCAS

VERNON HAD ROARED, SPRAYING HARRY WITH SPIT.

RON HEAVILY REALIZED THAT HE'D GOTTEN HARRY INTO TROUBLE, BECAUSE HE HADN'T CALLED AGAIN. HARRY'S OTHER BEST FRIEND FROM HOGWARTS, HERMION GRANGER, HADN'T BEEN IN TOUCH EITHER. HARRY SUSPECTED THAT RON HAD WARNED HERMION NOT TO CALL, WHICH WAS A PITY, BECAUSE HERMION, THE CLEVEREST WITCH IN HARRY'S YEAR, HAD MUGGLE PARENTS, KNEW PERFECTLY WELL

29

HOW TO USE A TELEPHONE, AND WOULD PROBABLY HAVE HAD ENOUGH SENSE NOT TO SAY THAT SHE WENT TO HOGWARTS.

SINCE HARRY HAD HAD NO WORD FROM ANY OF HIS WIZARDING FRIENDS FOR FIVE LONG WEEKS, AND THIS SUMMER WAS TURNING OUT THE EE ALMOST AS BAD AS THE LAST ONE, THERE WAS JUST ONE VERY SMALL IMPROVEMENT -- AFTER SWEARING THAT HE WOULDN'T USE HER TO SEND LETTERS TO ANY OF HIS FRIENDS, HARRY HAD BEEN

ALLOWED HIM LET HIS HAIR, FREDWIG, HUNG AT NIGHT. LITTLE VERNER HAD GIVEN IN
BECAUSE OF THE RACKET FREDWIG MADE IF SHE WAS LOCKED IN HER CAGE ALL THE
TIME.

HARRY FINISHED WRITING ABOUT WENDELIN THE WIKED AND PAUSED TO LISTEN
AGAIN. THE SILENCE IN THE DARK HOUSE WAS BROKEN ONLY BY THE DISTANT,
GROANING SOUNDS OF HIS NEIGHBOUR'S CHURCH, DULLEY. IT MUST BE VERY LATE,
HARRY THOUGHT. HIS EYES WERE ITCHING WITH TIREDNESS. PERHAPS HE'D FINISH
THIS ESSAY TOMORROW NIGHT...

HE REPLACED THE TOP OF THE INK BOTTLE, PULLED AN OLD PILLOWCASE FROM
UNDER HIS BED, PUT THE FLASHLIGHT, A BATTERY OF MAGIC, HIS ESSAY, BILLS,
AND INK INSIDE IT, GOT UP OF BED, AND HID THE KEY UNDER A MATTRESS
NEARBY UNDER HIS BED. THEN HE STOOD UP, STRETCHED, AND CHECKED THE
TIME ON THE LUMINOUS ALARM CLOCK ON HIS BEDSIDE TABLE.

IT WAS ONE O'CLOCK IN THE MORNING. HARRY'S STOMACH GAVE A FLURRY THAT HE
HAD BEEN THIRTEEN YEARS OLD, WITHOUT REALIZING IT, FOR A WHILE BEFORE.

YET ANOTHER UNUSUAL THING ABOUT HARRY WAS THAT LITTLE HE LOOKED FORWARD
TO HIS BIRTHDAYS. HE HAD NEVER RECEIVED A BIRTHDAY CARD IN HIS LIFE. THE
DULLEYS HAD COMPLETELY IGNORED HIS LAST TWO BIRTHDAYS, AND HE HAD NO
REASON TO SUPPOSE THEY WOULD REMEMBER THIS ONE.

HARRY WALKED ACROSS THE DARK ROOM, PAST FREDWIG'S LARGE, EMPTY CAGE, TO
THE OPEN WINDOW. HE LEANED ON THE SILL, THE COOL NIGHT AIR PLEASANT ON
HIS FACE AFTER A LONG TIME UNDER THE BLANKETS. FREDWIG HAD BEEN ABSENT
FOR TWO NIGHTS NOW. HARRY WASN'T WORRIED ABOUT HER: SHE'D BEEN GONE THIS
LONG BEFORE, BUT HE HOPED SHE'D BE BACK SOON -- SHE WAS THE ONLY LIVING
CREATURE IN THIS HOUSE WHO DIDN'T FLINCH AT THE SIGHT OF HIM.

HARRY, THOUGH STILL RATHER SMALL AND SKINNY FOR HIS AGE, HAD GROWN A FEW
INCHES OVER THE LAST YEAR. HIS jet-black HAIR, HOWEVER, WAS JUST AS IT

ALWAYS HAD BEEN -- STRIKINGLY LONELY, WHATEVER HE DID THE IT. THE EYES
BEHIND HIS GLASSES WERE BRIGHT GREEN, AND ON HIS THREE-HEAD, CLEARLY
VISIBLE THROUGH HIS HAIR, WAS A THIN SCAR, SHAPED LIKE A BOLT OF
LIGHTNING.

OF ALL THE UNUSUAL THINGS ABOUT HARRY, THIS SCAR WAS THE MOST
EXTRAORDINARY OF ALL. IT WAS NOT, AS THE DURSLEYS HAD PRETENDED FOR TEN
YEARS, A SOUVENIR OF THE CAR CRASH THAT HAD KILLED HARRY'S PARENTS,
BECAUSE LILY AND JAMES POTTER HAD NOT DIED IN A CAR CRASH. THEY HAD BEEN
MURDERED, MURDERED BY THE MOST FEARED DARK WIZARD FOR A HUNDRED YEARS,
LORD VOLDEMORT. HARRY HAD ESCAPED FROM THE SAME ATTACK WITH NOTHING
MORE

THAN A SCAR ON HIS THREE-HEAD, WHERE VOLDEMORT'S CURSE, INSTEAD OF KILLING
HIM, HAD REBORNED UPON ITS ORIGINATOR. RARELY ALIVE, VOLDEMORT HAD
RISE...

BUT HARRY HAD COME FACE-TO-FACE WITH HIM AT HOGWARTS, REMEMBERING THEIR
LAST MEETING AS HE STOOD AT THE DARK WINDO, HARRY HAD TO ADMIT HE WAS
LUCKY EVEN TO HAVE REACHED HIS THIRTEENTH BIRTHDAY.

HE STANNED THE STARRY SKY FOR A SIGN OF FLEW, PERHAPS SHARING
BACK THE HIM WITH A DEAD MELISE DANCING FROM HER HEAD, EXPECTING PRAISE.
Gazing absently over the rooftops, IT WAS A FEW SECONDS BEFORE HARRY
REALIZED WHAT HE WAS SEEING.

Still-flicked against the golden moon, and growing larger every moment,
WAS A LARGE, STRANGELY LIMBED CREATURE, AND IT WAS FLAPPING IN HARRY'S
DIRECTION. HE STOOD WHITE STILL, WATCHING IT SINK LOWER AND LOWER, FOR A
SPLIT SECOND HE HESITATED, HIS HAND ON THE WINDOW LATCH, WONDERING
WHETHER TO SLAM IT SHUT. BUT THEN THE BIZARRE CREATURE SHED OVER ONE
OF THE STREET LAMPS OF PRIVET DRIVE, AND HARRY, REALIZING WHAT IT WAS,
LEAPT ASIDE.

THROUGH THE WINDOW SHED THREE EGGS, TWO OF THEM FLYING UP THE THIRD,

WHICH APPEARED TO BE LINCOLNSTEELS. THEY LANDED WITH A SOFT PLUMP ON HARRY'S BED, AND THE MIDDLE HEN, WHICH WAS LARGE AND GRAY, REELED RIGHT OVER AND LAY MENTHERLESS. THERE WAS A LARGE PACKAGE TIED TO ITS LEGS. HARRY RECOGNIZED THE LINCOLNSTEELS HEN AT ONCE -- HIS NAME WAS ERREL, AND HE BELONGED TO THE LEASLEY FAMILY. HARRY DASHED TO THE BED, UNTIED THE

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CHORDS AROUND ERREL'S LEGS, THUNK OFF THE PARCEL, AND THEN CARRIED ERREL TO FREDWIG'S CAGE. ERREL OPENED ONE BLEAR EYE, GAVE A PECKLE PHEET OF THANKS, AND BEGAN TO GLIP SOME WATER.

HARRY TURNED BACK TO THE REMAINING HENS. ONE OF THEM, THE LARGE SNEEDY FEMALE, WAS HIS OWN FREDWIG. SHE, THH, WAS CARRYING A PARCEL AND LOOKED EXTREMELY PLEASED WITH HERSELF. SHE GAVE HARRY AN AFFECTIONATE NIP WITH HER BEAK AS HE REMOVED HER BURDEN, THEN FLEW ACROSS THE ROOM TO JOIN ERREL.

HARRY DIDN'T RECOGNIZE THE THIRD HEN, A HANDSOME TALL ONE, BUT HE KNEW AT ONCE WHERE IT HAD COME FROM, BECAUSE IN ADDITION TO A THIRD PACKAGE, IT WAS CARRYING A LETTER BEARING THE FLEWARTS CREST. WHEN HARRY RELIEVED THIS HEN OF ITS BURDEN, IT RUMPLED ITS FEATHERS IMPERTANTLY, STRETCHED ITS WINGS, AND THUNK OFF THROUGH THE WINDOW INTO THE NIGHT.

HARRY SAT DOWN ON HIS BED AND CRACKED ERREL'S PACKAGE, RIPPED OFF THE BROWN PAPER, AND DISCOVERED A PRESENT WRAPPED IN GILD, AND HIS FIRST EVER BIRTHDAY CARD. FINGERS TREMLING SLIGHTLY, HE OPENED THE ENVELOPE.

TWO PIECES OF PAPER FELL OUT -- A LETTER AND A NEWSPAPER CLIPPING.

THE CLIPPING HAD CLEARLY COME OUT OF THE WIZARDING NEWSPAPER, THE DAILY PROPHEET, BECAUSE THE PEOPLE IN THE BLACK-AND-WHITE PICTURE WERE MEWING.

HARRY PICKED UP THE CLIPPING, SMEEETHED IT OUT, AND READ:

MINISTRY OF MAGIC EMPLOYEE STEPH'S GRAND PRIZE

ARTHUR WEASLEY, HEAD OF THE MISUSE OF MAGIC ARTIFACTS OFFICE AT THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC, HAS WON THE ANNUAL DAILY PROPHET GRAND PRIZE CALLED

DRAW.

A DELIGHTED MR. WEASLEY TOLD THE DAILY PROPHET, "WE WILL BE SPENDING THE CHILDREN A SUMMER HOLIDAY IN EGYPT, WHERE OUR ELDEST SON, BILL, WORKS AS A CLERK BREAKER FOR GRINGOTT'S WIZARDING BANK."

THE WEASLEY FAMILY WILL BE SPENDING A MONTH IN EGYPT, RETURNING FOR THE START OF THE NEW SCHOOL YEAR AT HOGWARTS, WHICH FIVE OF THE WEASLEY CHILDREN CURRENTLY ATTEND.

HARRY SCANNED THE MOVING PICTOGRAPH, AND A GRIN SPREAD ACROSS HIS FACE

7

AS HE SAW ALL NINE OF THE WEASLEYS LAUGHING FLIRTELILY AT HIM, STANDING IN FRONT OF A LARGE PYRAMID. PLUMP LITTLE MRS. WEASLEY; TALL, BALDING MR. WEASLEY; SIX SONS; AND ONE DAUGHTER, ALL (THOUGH THE BLACK-AND-WHITE PICTURE DIDN'T SHOW IT) WITH FLAMING-RED HAIR. RIGHT IN THE MIDDLE OF THE PICTURE WAS RON, TALL AND GAWKING, WITH HIS PET RAT, SCABBERS, ON HIS SHOULDER AND HIS ARM AROUND HIS LITTLE SISTER, GINNY.

HARRY COULDN'T THINK OF ANYONE WHO DESERVED TO WIN A LARGE PILE OF GOLD MORE THAN THE WEASLEYS, WHO WERE VERY NICE AND EXTREMELY POOR. HE PICKED UP RON'S LETTER AND UNFOLDED IT.

DEAR HARRY,

HAPPY BIRTHDAY!

HEHE, I REALLY SORRY ABOUT THAT TELEPHONE CALL. I HOPE THE MUGGLES DIDN'T GIVE YOU A HARD TIME. I ASKED DAD, AND HE REMAINS I SHOULDN'T HAVE SHELTERED.

IT'S AMAZING HERE IN EGYPT. BILL'S TAKEN US AROUND ALL THE TEMPLES AND YOU WOULDN'T BELIEVE THE CLERKS THERE HAD EGYPTIAN WIZARDS PUT ON THEM. MOM

WEREN'T LET GINNY COME IN THE LAST ONE. THERE WERE ALL THESE MISTANT SKELETONS IN THERE, HP MUGGLES WERE BROKEN IN AND GREEN EXTRA HEADS AND STUFF.

I COULDN'T BELIEVE IT WHEN DAD WENT THE DAILY PROPHET DRAG. SEVEN HUNDRED GALLEONS! MEET HP IT'S GONE FOR THIS TRIP, BUT THEY'RE GIVING ME A NEW WAND FOR NEXT YEAR.

HARRY REMEMBERED ONLY THE WELL THE ECCLASTIC WHEN RON'S OLD WAND HAD SNAPPED. IT HAD HAPPENED WHEN THE CAR THE TWO HP THEM HAD BEEN FLYING THE HOGWARTS HAD CRASHED INTO A TREE IN THE SCOTTISH COUNTRYS.

WE'LL BE BACK ABOUT A WEEK BEFORE TERM STARTS AND WE'LL BE GOING UP THE LINDEN TO GET MY WAND AND OUR NEW BOOKS, AND CHANCE OF MEETING YELL THERE?

DON'T LET THE MUGGLES GET YELL DOWN!

TRY AND COME TO LINDEN.

X

RON

P.S. PERCY'S HEAD BOY, HE GOT THE LETTER LAST WEEK.

HARRY GLANCED BACK AT THE PHOTOGRAPH. PERCY, WHO WAS IN HIS SEVENTH AND FINAL YEAR AT HOGWARTS, WAS LOOKING PARTICULARLY SMUG. HE HAD PINNED HIS HEAD BOY BADGE TO THE PEE PERCHED CASUALTY ON THE HP HIS NEAT HAIR, HIS THIN-RIMMED GLASSES FLASHING IN THE EGYPTIAN SUN.

HARRY NOW TURNED TO HIS PRESENT AND UNWRAPPED IT. INSIDE WAS WHAT LOOKED LIKE A MINIATURE GLASS SPINNING TOP. THERE WAS ANOTHER NOTE FROM RON BENEATH IT.

HARRY -- THIS IS A PICKET SNEAKERSHOPE. IF THERE'S SOMETHING UNUSUAL ABOUT A WHOLE, IT'S SUPPOSED TO LIGHT UP AND SPIN. KILL SAYS IT'S ALKALINE SHEL FOR WIZARD THEORISTS AND ISN'T RELIABLE, BECAUSE IT KEPT LIGHTING UP AT

DINNER LAST NIGHT. BUT HE DIDN'T REALIZE FRED AND GEORGE HAD PUT KEETLES
IN HIS SLEEP.

BYE --

RON

HARRY PUT THE PACKET SNACKSCHRIPS IN HIS BEDSIDE TABLE, WHERE IT STOOD
BLITE STILL, BALANCED ON ITS POINT, REFLECTING THE LUMINOUS HANDS OF HIS
CLOCK. HE LOOKED AT IT HAPPILY FOR A FEW SECONDS, THEN PICKED UP THE
PARCEL FREDIE HAD BROUGHT.

INSIDE THIS, THEN, THERE WAS A WRAPPED PRESENT, A CARD, AND A LETTER,
THIS TIME FROM HERMIONE.

DEAR HARRY,

RON WRITE TO ME AND TELL ME ABOUT HIS PHONE CALL TO THE YELLER LINDLE VERNON. I
DO HOPE YELL'RE ALL RIGHT.

I'M ON HOLIDAY IN FRANCE AT THE MOMENT AND I DIDN'T KNOW HOW I WAS GOING
TO SEND THIS TO YOU -- WHAT IF THEY'D OPENED IT AT CUSTOMS? -- BUT THEN
FREDIE TURNED UP! I THINK SHE WANTED TO MAKE SURE YOU GOT SOMETHING FOR

9

YOUR BIRTHDAY FOR A CHANGE. I BROUGHT YOUR PRESENT BY HAND-MAIL; THERE
WAS AN ADVERTISEMENT IN THE DAILY PROPHET (I'VE BEEN GETTING IT
DELIVERED; IT'S BEEN THE DEEP UP WITH WHAT'S GOING ON IN THE WIZARDING
WORLD). DID YOU SEE THAT PICTURE OF RON AND HIS FAMILY A WEEK AGO? I GET
HER'S LEARNING HEADS. I'M REALLY IMPRESSED -- THE ANCIENT EGYPTIAN WIZARDS
WERE FASCINATING.

THERE'S SOME INTERESTING LOCAL HISTORY OF WITCH-CRAFT HERE, THEN. I'VE
REWRITTEN MY LITTLE HISTORY OF MAGIC ESSAY TO INCLUDE SOME OF THE THINGS
I'VE FOUND OUT. I HOPE IT'S NOT TOO LONG -- IT'S TWO ROLLS OF PARCHMENT
MORE THAN PROFESSOR KINGS ASKED FOR.

RON SAYS HE'S GOING TO BE IN LONDON IN THE LAST WEEK OF THE HOLIDAYS,
CAN YOU MAKE IT? WILL YOUR AUNT AND UNCLE LET YOU COME? I REALLY HOPE
YOU CAN. IF NOT, I'LL SEE YOU ON THE HOGWARTS EXPRESS IN SEPTEMBER
FIRST!

LOVE FROM HERMION

P.S. RON SAYS PERCY'S HEAD BOY. I'LL BET PERCY'S REALLY PLEASED RON
DIDN'T SEEM TOO HAPPY ABOUT IT

HARRY LAUGHED AS HE PUT HERMION'S LETTER ASIDE AND PICKED UP HER
PRESENT. IT WAS VERY HEAVY. KNOWING HERMION, HE WAS SURE IT WOULD BE A
LARGE BOOK FULL OF VERY DIFFICULT SPELLS -- BUT IT WASN'T. HIS HEART
GAVE A FLICE BEHIND AS HE RIPPED BACK THE PAPER AND SAW A SLEEK BLACK
LEATHER CASE, WITH SILVER WORDS STAMPED ACROSS IT, READING KREHMSTICK
SERVICING KIT.

"WELL, HERMION?" HARRY WHISPERED, UNZIPPING THE CASE TO LOOK INSIDE.
THERE WAS A LARGE JAR OF FLEETWIND'S HIGH-FINISH HANDLE POLISH, A PAIR
OF GLEAMING SILVER TALL-TWIG CLIPPERS, A TINY BRASS COMPASS TO CLIP ON
YOUR KNEE FOR MEASURING JOURNEYS, AND A HANDBOOK OF DO-IT-YOURSELF
KREHMCLARE.

APART FROM HIS FRIENDS, THE THING THAT HARRY MISSED MOST ABOUT HOGWARTS
WAS FLUIDITCH, THE MOST POPULAR SPORT IN THE MAGICAL WORLD -- HIGHLY
DANGEROUS, VERY EXCITING, AND PLAYED ON KREHMSTICKS. HARRY HAD BEEN THE
BE A VERY GOOD FLUIDITCH PLAYER; HE HAD BEEN THE YOUNGEST PERSON IN A

10

CENTURY TO BE PICKED FOR ONE OF THE HOGWARTS HOUSE TEAMS. ONE OF HARRY'S
MOST PRIZED POSSESSIONS WAS HIS NIKEL'S TWO THOUSAND RACING KNEE,
HARRY PUT THE LEATHER CASE ASIDE AND PICKED UP HIS LAST PARCEL. HE
RECOGNIZED THE LINTIDY SCRAWL ON THE KREHN PAPER AT ONCE: THIS WAS FROM

FACRID, THE FHEGLARTS GAMERKEEPER, FHE THERE HFF THE THEP LAYER HF PAPER AND GLIMPSED SHMETHING GREEN AND LEATHERY, BUT BEFHRE HE CHULD UNWRAP IT PROPERLY, THE PARCEL GAVE A STRANGE BULIVER, AND WHATEVER WAS INSIDE IT SNAPPED LULBLY -- AS THHUGH IT HAD LANS.

FARRY FREEZE. FHE DNED THAT FACRID WOULD NEVER SEND HIM ANYTHING DANGEROUS

HN PLURPHEE, BUT THEN, FACRID DIDN'T HAVE A NORMAL PERSON'S VIEW HF WHAT WAS DANGEROUS. FACRID HAD BEEN KNOWN TH BEFRIEND GIANT SPIDERS, BLY VIKHLS, THREE-HEADED DRCS FROM MEN IN PLKS, AND SNEAK ILLEGAL DRAGEN EGGS INTO HIS LAKIN.

FARRY PHEEKED THE PARCEL NERVHLSLY. IT SNAPPED LULBLY AGAIN. FARRY REACHED FOR THE LAMP HN HIS BESIDE TABLE, GRIPPED IT FIRMLY IN HNK HAND, AND RAISED IT OVER HIS HEAD, READY TH STRIKE. THEN HE SEIZED THE REST HF THE WRAPPING PAPER IN HIS OTHER HAND AND PULLED.

AND HLT FELL -- A KHHK. FARRY ILST HAD TIME TH REGISTER ITS HANDSOME GREEN COVER, EMBLAZONED WITH THE CHILDEN TITLE THE MHNSTER KHHK HF MHNSTERS, BEFHRE IT FLIPPED BENTH ITS EDGE AND SLUTTLED SIDELWAYS ALONG THE BED LIKE SOME WEIRD CRAW.

"LH-HH!" FARRY MUTTERED.

THE KHHK THOPIED HFF THE BED WITH A LULB CLUNK AND SLIPPED RAPIDLY ACROSS THE RHHM. FARRY FOLLWED IT STEALTHILY. THE KHHK WAS HIDING IN THE DARK SPACE UNDER HIS DESK, PRAYING THAT THE DURSLEYS WERE STILL FAST ASLEEP. FARRY GHT DOWN HN HIS HANDS AND KNEES AND REACHED THWARD IT. "HLLH!"

THE KHHK SNAPPED SHLT HN HIS HAND AND THEN FLAPPED PAST HIM, STILL SLUTTILING HN ITS CHEVERS. FARRY SCRAMLED AHHING, THREW HIMSELF FHWARD, AND MANAGED TH FLATTEN IT. LULKE VERNEN GAVE A LULB, SLEEPY GRUNT IN THE RHHM NEXT DEHR.

FREDDIE AND KAREL WATCHED INTERESTEDLY AS HARRY CLAMPED THE STRUGGLING
BOOK TIGHTLY IN HIS ARMS, FLIPPED THE HIS CHEST OF DRAWERS, AND PULLED
OUT A BELT, WHICH HE BUCKLED TIGHTLY AROUND IT. THE MINISTER BOOK
SHUDDERED ANGERILY, BUT COULD NO LONGER FLAP AND SNAP, SEE HARRY TIE IT
AROUND HIM THE END AND REACHED FOR HARRY'S CARD.

DEAR HARRY,

HAPPY BIRTHDAY!

THINK YOU MIGHT FIND THIS USEFUL FOR NEXT YEAR. WON'T SAY NO MORE HERE.

TELL YOU WHEN I SEE YOU, HOPE THE MUGGLES ARE TREATING YOU RIGHT.

ALL THE BEST,

HARRY

IT STRUCK HARRY AS OMINOUS THAT HARRY THOUGHT A KIDNAP BOOK WOULD COME
IN USEFUL, BUT HE PUT HARRY'S CARD UP NEXT THE KING'S AND HERMION'S,
GRINNING MORE BROADLY THAN EVER. NOW THERE WAS ONLY THE LETTER FROM
HOGWARTS LEFT.

NOTICING THAT IT WAS RATHER THICKER THAN USUAL, HARRY SLIT OPEN THE
ENVELOPE, PULLED OUT THE FIRST PAGE OF PARCHMENT WITHIN, AND READ:

DEAR MR. POTTER,

PLEASE NOTE THAT THE NEW SCHOOL YEAR WILL BEGIN ON SEPTEMBER THE FIRST.

THE HOGWARTS EXPRESS WILL LEAVE FROM KING'S CROSS STATION, PLATFORM NINE
AND THREE-QUARTERS, AT ELEVEN O'CLOCK.

THIRD YEARS ARE PERMITTED TO VISIT THE VILLAGE OF HOGSMEADE ON CERTAIN
WEEKENDS. PLEASE GIVE THE ENCLOSED PERMISSION FORM TO YOUR PARENT OR
GUARDIAN TO SIGN.

A LIST OF BOOKS FOR NEXT YEAR IS ENCLOSED. YOURS SINCERELY,

PROFESSOR M. MCGONAGALL

DEPUTY HEADMISTRESS

HARRY PULLED OUT THE HOGSMEADE PERMISSION FORM AND LOOKED AT IT, NO LONGER GRINNING. IT WOULD BE WONDERFUL THE VISIT HOGSMEADE FOR WEEKENDS; HE KNEW IT WAS AN ENTIRELY WIZARDING VILLAGE, AND HE HAD NEVER SET FOOT THERE, BUT FEEL HIS EARTH WAS HE GOING TO PERSUADE UNCLE VERNON FOR ALINT PETLINA THE SIGN THE FORM?

HE LOOKED OVER AT THE ALARM CLOCK. IT WAS NOW TWO O'CLOCK IN THE MORNING.

DECIDING THAT HE'D BETTER ABOLIT THE HOGSMEADE FORM WHEN HE WAKE UP, HARRY

GET BACK INTO BED AND REACHED UP THE CRESS OFF ANOTHER DAY FOR THE CHART HE'D MADE FOR HIMSELF, CHILTING DOWN THE DAYS LEFT UNTIL HIS RETURN THE HOGWARTS. THEN HE TOOK OFF HIS GLASSES AND LAY DOWN, EYES SHUT, FACING HIS THREE BIRTH-DAY CARDS.

EXTREMELY UNUSUAL THOUGH HE WAS, AT THAT MOMENT HARRY POTTER FELT JUST LIKE EVERYONE ELSE -- GLAD, FOR THE FIRST TIME IN HIS LIFE, THAT IT WAS HIS BIRTH-DAY.

CHAPTER TWO

ALINT MARGE'S BIG MISTAKE

HARRY WENT DOWN THE BREAKFAST THE NEXT MORNING TO FIND THE THREE BLURLES ALREADY SITTING AROUND THE KITCHEN TABLE. THEY WERE WATCHING A BRAND-NEW TELEVISION, A WELCOME-HOME-FOR-THE-SUMMER PRESENT FOR DUDLEY, WHO HAD BEEN COMPLAINING LOUDLY ABOUT THE LONG WALK BETWEEN THE FRIDGE AND THE TELEVISION IN THE LIVING ROOM. DUDLEY HAD SPENT MOST OF THE SUMMER IN THE KITCHEN, HIS BIGGY LITTLE EYES FIXED FOR THE SCREEN AND HIS FIVE CHINS WINKING AS HE ATE CONTINUALLY.

HARRY SAT DOWN BETWEEN DUDLEY AND UNCLE VERNON, A LARGE, BEERY MAN WITH VERY LITTLE NECK AND A LOT OF MUSTACHE. FAR FROM WISHING HARRY A HAPPY BIRTH-DAY, NONE OF THE BLURLES MADE ANY SIGN THAT THEY HAD NOTICED HARRY

ENTER THE ROOM, BUT HARRY WAS FAR TOO USED TO THIS THE CARE. HE HELPED HIMSELF TO A PIECE OF MEAT AND THEN LOOKED UP AT THE REPORTER ON THE TELEVISION, WHO WAS HALFWAY THROUGH A REPORT ON AN ESCAPED CONVICT: "... THE PUBLIC IS WARNED THAT BLACK IS ARMED AND EXTREMELY DANGEROUS. A

18

SPECIAL FIFT LINE HAS BEEN SET UP, AND ANY SIGHTING OF BLACK SHOULD BE REPORTED IMMEDIATELY."

"DO WE NEED TO TELL US HE'S NOT GOOD," SMILED LITTLE VERNON, STARING OVER THE TOP OF HIS NEWSPAPER AT THE PRISONER, "LOOK AT THE STATE OF HIM, THE FILTHY LADDER! LOOK AT HIS HAIR!"

HE SENT A NASTY LOOK SIDELONG AT HARRY, WHOSE UNTIDY HAIR HAD ALWAYS BEEN A SOURCE OF GREAT AMUSEMENT TO LITTLE VERNON. COMPARED TO THE MAN ON

THE TELEVISION, HOWEVER, WHOSE CALVE FACE WAS SURROUNDED BY A MATTED, EMBLEM-LENGTH TANGLE, HARRY FELT VERY WELL GROOMED INDEED.

THE REPORTER HAD REAPPEARED.

"THE MINISTRY OF AGRICULTURE AND FISHERIES WILL ANNOUNCE TODAY --"

"HANG ON!" BARKED LITTLE VERNON, STARING FURIOUSLY AT THE REPORTER. "WHY DIDN'T TELL US WHERE THAT MANIAC'S ESCAPED FROM? WHAT LINE IS THAT?"

MANIAC COULD BE CHASING UP THE STREET RIGHT NOW!"

ALICE PETLINIA, WHO WAS THIN AND HERSE-FACED, WHIPPED AROUND AND PEERED INTENTLY OUT OF THE KITCHEN WINDOW. HARRY KNEW ALICE PETLINIA COULD SIMPLY

MOVE TO BE THE ONE TO CALL THE FIFT LINE NUMBER. SHE WAS THE NEAREST WOMAN IN THE WORLD AND SPENT MOST OF HER LIFE SPYING ON THE BEHIND, LAW-ABIDING NEIGHBORS.

"WHEN WILL THEY LEARN," SAID LITTLE VERNON, POUNDING THE TABLE WITH HIS LARGE PURPLE FIST, "THAT HANGING'S THE ONLY WAY TO DEAL WITH THESE

PEOPLE?"

"VERY TRUE," SAID ALINT PETUNIA, WHO WAS STILL SHLINTING INTO NEXT DOOR'S
ALINER BEANS.

LITTLE VERNEN DRAINED HIS TEACUP, GLANCED AT HIS WATCH, AND ADDED, "I'D
BETTER BE OFF IN A MINUTE, PETUNIA, MARGE'S TRAIN GETS IN AT TEN."

FARRY, WHOSE TEEGLITS HAD BEEN UPSTAIRS WITH THE KREEMSTICK SERVING
KIT, WAS KREELIGHT BACK THE PARTI WITH AN UNPLEASANT KLIMP.

"ALINT MARGE?" HE BLURTED OUT. "SH -- SHE'S NOT COMING HERE, IS SHE?"

14

ALINT MARGE WAS LITTLE VERNEN'S SISTER. EVEN THOUGH SHE WAS NOT A BLEED
RELATIVE OF FARRY'S (WHOSE MOTHER HAD BEEN ALINT PETUNIA'S SISTER), HE
HAD BEEN FORCED TO CALL HER "ALINT" ALL HIS LIFE. ALINT MARGE LIVED IN THE
COUNTRY, IN A HOUSE WITH A LARGE GARDEN, WHERE SHE KRED KILDBEGS. SHE
DIDN'T OFTEN STAY AT PRIVET DRIVE, BECAUSE SHE CHILDREN'T BEAR THE LEAVE
HER PRECIOUS DEGS, BUT EACH OF HER VISITS STOOD OUT HORRIBLY VIVIDLY IN
FARRY'S MIND.

AT DUDLEY'S FIFTH BIRTHDAY PARTY, ALINT MARGE HAD WACKED FARRY AROUND
THE SHINS WITH HER WALKING STICK TO STOP HIM FROM BEATING DUDLEY AT
MUSICAL STATUES. A FEW YEARS LATER, SHE HAD TURNED UP AT CHRISTMAS WITH
A COMPUTERIZED RHYTHM FOR DUDLEY AND A BOX OF DEC KISLITS FOR FARRY. IN
HER LAST VISIT, THE YEAR BEFORE FARRY STARTED AT FEEGLARTS, FARRY HAD
ACCIDENTALLY TRODDEN IN THE TAIL OF HER FAVORITE DEG. RIPPER HAD CHASED
FARRY INTO THE GARDEN AND UP A TREE, AND ALINT MARGE HAD REFUSED TO
CALL HIM OFF UNTIL PAST MIDNIGHT. THE MEMORY OF THIS INCIDENT STILL
KREELIGHT TEARS OF LAUGHTER THE DUDLEY'S EYES.

"MARGE'LL BE HERE FOR A WEEK," LITTLE VERNEN SNARLED. "AND WHILE WE'RE
IN THE SLICKET" -- HE POINTED A FAT FINGER THREATENINGLY AT FARRY -- "WE

NEED TO GET A FEW THINGS STRAIGHT BEFORE I GO AND COLLECT HER."

BLUBBY SMIRKED AND WITHDREW HIS GAZE FROM THE TELEVISION, WATCHING F-HARRY BEING KILLED BY LITTLE VERNON WAS BLUBBY'S FAVORITE FORM OF ENTERTAINMENT.

"FIRSTLY," GROWLED LITTLE VERNON, "YOU'LL KEEP A CIVIL TONGUE IN YOUR HEAD WHEN YOU'RE TALKING TO MARGE."

"ALL RIGHT," SAID F-HARRY BITTERLY, "IF SHE DIES WHEN SHE'S TALKING TO ME."

"SECONDLY," SAID LITTLE VERNON, ACTING AS THOUGH HE HAD NOT HEARD F-HARRY'S REPLY, "AS MARGE DOESN'T KNOW ANYTHING ABOUT YOUR ABNORMALITY, I DON'T WANT ANY -- ANY FLIMSY STUFF WHILE SHE'S HERE.

YOU BEHAVE YOURSELF, GET ME?"

"I WILL IF SHE DIES," SAID F-HARRY THOUGH GRITTED TEETH.

15

"AND THIRDLY," SAID LITTLE VERNON, HIS MEAN LITTLE EYES NARROW SLITS IN HIS GREAT PURPLE FACE, "WE'VE TOLD MARGE YOU ATTEND ST. KRISTUS'S SECURE CENTER FOR INCURABLY CRIMINAL KIDS."

"WHAT?" F-HARRY YELLED.

"AND YOU'LL BE STICKING TO THAT STORY, KID, OR THERE'LL BE TROUBLE, SPOT LITTLE VERNON.

F-HARRY SAT THERE, WHITE-FACED AND FLURRIED, STARING AT LITTLE VERNON, HARDLY ABLE TO BELIEVE IT. ALTHO MARGE GIVING HIM A WEEKEND VISIT -- IT WAS THE WERST BIRTHDAY PRESENT THE BLUBBYS HAD EVER GIVEN HIM, INCLUDING THAT PAIR OF LITTLE VERNON'S OLD SHOES.

"WELL, PETLINIA," SAID LITTLE VERNON, GETTING HEAVILY ON HIS FEET, "I'LL BE OFF TO THE STATION, THEN. WANT TO COME ALONG FOR THE RIDE, BLUBBYS?"

"NO," SAID BLUBBY, WHOSE ATTENTION HAD RETURNED TO THE TELEVISION WHEN THAT LITTLE VERNON HAD FINISHED THREATENING F-HARRY.

"BLIDDY'S GOT THE MAKE HIMSELF SMART FOR HIS ALINTIE," SAID ALINT PETLINIA, SMEEHTHING BLIDLEY'S THICK BLIND HAIR. "MUMMY'S KEELIGHT HIM A LEEVELY NEW KEEL TIE."

LINCLE VERNEN CLAPPED BLIDLEY ON HIS PEEVY SHOULDER. "SEE YELL IN A KIT, THEN," HE SAID, AND HE LEFT THE KITCHEN.

FARRY, WHO HAD BEEN SITTING IN A KIND OF FETTERED TRANCE, HAD A SUDDEN IDEA. ABANDONING HIS THEAT, HE GOT RELIQUY THE HIS FEET AND PHEWED

LINCLE VERNEN THE THE PRESENT DEER.

LINCLE VERNEN WAS PULLING HIM HIS CAR KEAT.

"I'M NOT TAKING YELL," HE SNARLED AS HE TURNED THE SEE FARRY WATCHING HIM.

"LIKE I WANTED THE KEAT," SAID FARRY CHEER. "I WANT THE ASK YELL SOMETHING."

LINCLE VERNEN EYED HIM SUSPICIOUSLY.

18

"THIRD YEARS AT THE -- AT MY SCHOOL ARE ALLOWED THE VISIT THE VILLAGE SOMETIMES," SAID FARRY.

"SEE?" SNAPPED LINCLE VERNEN, TAKING HIS CAR KEYS FROM A KEEL NEXT THE THE DEER.

"I NEED YELL THE SIGN THE PERMISSION FROM," SAID FARRY IN A RUSS.

"AND WHY SHOULD I DO THAT?" SNEERED LINCLE VERNEN.

"WELL," SAID FARRY, KEESTING HIS WHIRLS CAREFULLY, "IT'LL BE HARD WHEN, PRETENDING THE ALINT MARGE I GOT THE THAT ST. WHATSITS --"

"ST. BRITUS'S SECURE CENTER FOR INCLINABLY CRIMINAL KEYS?" REMEMBERED LINCLE VERNEN, AND FARRY WAS PLEASED THE HEAR A DEFINITE NOTE OF PANIC IN LINCLE VERNEN'S VOICE.

"EXACTLY," SAID FARRY, WHISKING CALMLY UP INTO LINCLE VERNEN'S LARGE, PURPLE FACE. "IT'S A LEFT THE REMEMBER, I'LL HAVE THE MAKE IT SHLIND

CONVINCING, WHEN'T IT WHAT IF I ACCIDENTALLY LET SOMETHING SLIP?"

"YOU'LL GET THE STUPPING KNICKED OUT OF YOU, WHEN'T YOU?" REARED UNCLE VERNEEN, ADVANCING HIS FARRY WITH HIS FIST RAISED, BUT FARRY STOOD HIS GROUND.

"KNICKING THE STUPPING OUT OF ME WHEN'T MAKE ALINT MARGE FORGET WHAT I CHILD TELL HER," HE SAID GRIMLY.

UNCLE VERNEEN STOPPED, HIS FIST STILL RAISED, HIS FACE AN UGLY PLE.

"BUT IF YOU SIGN MY PERMISSION FORM," FARRY WENT ON BLINDLY, "I SWEAR I'LL REMEMBER WHERE I'M SLIPPED THE CH THE ST-THH, AND I'LL ACT LIKE A MUG -- LIKE I'M NORMAL AND EVERYTHING."

FARRY CHILD TELL THAT UNCLE VERNEEN WAS THINKING IT OVER, EVEN IF HIS TEETH WERE BARED AND A VEIN WAS THROBBING IN HIS TEMPLE.

"RIGHT," HE SNAPPED FINALLY, "I SHALL MONITOR YOUR BEHAVIOR CAREFULLY DURING MARGE'S VISIT. IF, AT THE END OF IT, YOU'VE TOLD THE LIE AND KEPT THE THE STORY, I'LL SIGN YOUR RUDDY FORM."

19

HE WHEELED AROUND, PULLED OPEN THE FRONT DOOR, AND SLAMMED IT SH HARD THAT ONE OF THE LITTLE PANEES OF GLASS AT THE TOP FELL OUT.

FARRY DIDN'T RETURN TO THE KITCHEN, HE WENT BACK UPSTAIRS TO HIS BEDROOM. IF HE WAS GOING TO ACT LIKE A REAL MUGGLE, HE'D BETTER START NOW. SILENTLY AND SLOWLY HE GATHERED UP ALL HIS PRESENTS AND HIS BIRTHDAY CARDS AND HID THEM UNDER THE BEDDING FLOORBOARD WITH HIS FINGER. THEN HE WENT TO FREDWIG'S CAGE. ERREL SEEMED TO HAVE RECOVERED; HE AND FREDWIG WERE BOTH ASLEEP, HEADS UNDER THEIR WINGS. FARRY SIGHED, THEN PEEKED THEM BOTH AWAKE.

"FREDWIG," HE SAID GLENNILY, "YOU'RE GOING TO HAVE THE CLEAR OFF FOR A WEEK, GO WITH ERREL. THEN'LL LOOK AFTER YOU. I'LL WRITE HIM A NOTE,

EXPLAINING, AND DIDN'T LOOK AT ME LIKE THAT" -- FREDWIG'S LARGE ANKER EYES WERE REPROACHFUL -- "IT'S NOT MY FAULT. IT'S THE ONLY WAY I'LL BE ALLOWED THE VISIT FRESHWATER WITH RENE AND HERMINE."

TEN MINUTES LATER, CAROL AND FREDWIG WERE HAD A NIGHT THE RENE BEHIND THE HER LEG! SHARED BLIT OF THE WINDOW AND BLIT OF SIGHT. HARRY, NOW FEELING TERRIBLY MISERABLE, PUT THE EMPTY CAGE AWAY INSIDE THE WARDROBE, BUT HARRY DIDN'T HAVE LONG THE BREED, IN NEXT THE NEW TIME, ALINT PETLINIA WAS STRIDING UP THE STAIRS FOR HARRY THE CHIEF DOWN AND GET READY THE WELCOME THEIR GUEST.

"OH SOMETHING ABOUT THEIR HAIR?" ALINT PETLINIA SNAPPED AS HE REACHED THE HALL.

HARRY COULDN'T SEE THE POINT OF TRYING TO MAKE HIS HAIR LIE FLAT. ALINT MARGE BEGAN CRITICIZING HIM, SHE THE INSTANT HE BEGAN, THE HAPPIER SHE WOULD BE.

ALL THE WHILE, THERE WAS A CRUNCH OF GRAVEL OUTSIDE AS UNCLE VERNON'S CAR PULLED BACK INTO THE DRIVEWAY, THEN THE CLUNK OF THE CAR DOORS AND FOOTSTEPS ON THE GARDEN PATH.

"GET THE DOOR?" ALINT PETLINIA HISSED AT HARRY.

A FEELING OF GREAT GLOOM IN HIS STOMACH, HARRY PULLED THE DOOR OPEN.

18

ON THE THRESHOLD STOOD ALINT MARGE. SHE WAS VERY LIKE UNCLE VERNON: LARGE, BEARY, AND PURPLE-FACED, SHE EVEN HAD A MUSTACHE, THOUGH NOT AS BLIND AS HIS. IN ONE HAND SHE HELD AN ENORMOUS SUITCASE, AND TUCKED UNDER THE OTHER WAS AN OLD AND EVIL-TEMPERED KILDEE.

"WHERE'S MY GLOVERS?" RETIRED ALINT MARGE. "WHERE'S MY NEAR-VIEW?" BLINDLY CAME WADDLING DOWN THE HALL, HIS BLIND HAIR PLASTERED FLAT TO HIS FAT HEAD, A BROWN TIE ILLEGIBLY VISIBLE UNDER HIS MANDIBLES. ALINT MARGE THIRST

THE SLITCASE INTO F-JARRY'S STOMACH, KNOWING THE WIND BLT HF HIM, SEIZED
DUBLEY IN A TIGHT ONE-ARMED HUG, AND PLANTED A LARGE KISS ON HIS CHEEK.
F-JARRY KNEW PERFECTLY WELL THAT DUBLEY HAD PLT LIP WITH ALINT MARGE'S
FLIES

BECAUSE HE WAS WELL PAID FOR IT, AND SURE ENOUGH, WHEN THEY BROKE APART,
DUBLEY HAD A CRISP TWENTY-PHONO NOTE CLUTCHED IN HIS FAT FIST.

"PETLINIA!" SHOUTED ALINT MARGE, STRIDING PAST F-JARRY AS THOUGH HE WAS A
HAT STAND. ALINT MARGE AND ALINT PETLINIA KISSED, HER RATHER, ALINT MARGE
KLIMPED HER LARGE LAD AGAINST ALINT PETLINIA'S KIDNEY CREEKLINE.

LINCOLN VERNON HAD CAME IN, SMILING INVITALLY AS HE SEAT THE DEER.

"TEA, MARGE?" HE SAID. "AND WHAT WILL RIPPER TAKE?"

"RIPPER CAN HAVE SOME TEA BLT HF MY SALKER," SAID ALINT MARGE AS THEY ALL
PRECEDED INTO THE KITCHEN, LEAVING F-JARRY ALONE IN THE HALL WITH THE
SLITCASE. BLT F-JARRY WASN'T COMPLAINING; AND EXCISE MEET THE EE WITH ALINT
MARGE WAS FINE BY HIM, SHE HE BEGAN THE HEAVE THE CASE LIPSTAIRS INTO THE
SPARE BEDROOM, TAKING AS LONG AS HE COULD.

BY THE TIME HE GOT BACK TO THE KITCHEN, ALINT MARGE HAD BEEN SUPPLIED
WITH TEA AND FRUITCASE, AND RIPPER WAS LAPPING NEISTLY IN THE CHAIR.
F-JARRY SAW ALINT PETLINIA WINCE SLIGHTLY AS SPECKS HF TEA AND DRINK FLECKED
HER CLEAN FLICK. ALINT PETLINIA HATED ANIMALS.

"WHEN'S LEAVING AFTER THE OTHER DEGS, MARGE?" LINCOLN VERNON ASKED.

"EH, I'VE GOT CHUMEL FLESTER MANAGING THEM," MUMMED ALINT MARGE. "HE'S
RETIRED NOW, GIBB FOR HIM THE HAVE SOMETHING THE DEE, BLT I COULDN'T LEAVE

19

PHER HED RIPPER, HE PINKS IF HE'S AWAY FROM ME."

RIPPER BEGAN THE GRUEL AGAIN AS F-JARRY SAT BEHIN. THIS DIRECTED ALINT
MARGE'S ATTENTION TO F-JARRY FOR THE FIRST TIME.

"SEE," SHE BARKED. "STILL HERE, ARE YELK?"

"Yes," said Harry.

"Didn't you say yes' in that ingrateful tone," Aunt Marge shrieked. "It's damn good if Vernon and Petunia the keep you. Wouldn't have been it myself, you'd have gone straight to an orphanage if you'd been dumped in my doorstep."

Harry was bursting the say that he'd rather live in an orphanage than with the Dursleys, but the thought of the longspread arm stopped him. He forced his face into a painful smile.

"Didn't you smirk at me?" shrieked Aunt Marge. "I can see you haven't improved since I last saw you. I hoped somehow you'd know some manners in the you." She took a large gulp of tea, wiped her mustache, and said,

"Where is it that you send him, again, Vernon?"

"St. Brutus's," said Uncle Vernon promptly. "It's a first-rate institution for hopeless cases."

"I see," said Aunt Marge. "Do they use the cane at St. Brutus's, eh?" She barked across the table.

"Er --"

Uncle Vernon nodded curtly behind Aunt Marge's back.

"Yes," said Harry. Then, feeling he might as well do the thing properly, he added, "all the time."

"Excellent," said Aunt Marge. "I wouldn't have this nappy-pappy, wist-wist-wist nonsense about not hitting people who deserve it. A good thrashing is what's needed in ninety-nine cases out of a hundred. I've you been beaten often?"

Er

"Er, yes," said Harry. "Leads to times."

Aunt Marge narrowed her eyes.

"I still don't like you tone, eh," she said. "If you can spread of you"

BEATINGS IN THAT CASUAL WAY, THEY CLEARLY AREN'T HITTING THEM HARD ENOUGH. PETUNIA, I'D WRITE IF I WERE THEM, MAKE IT CLEAR THAT THEY APPREHEND THE USE OF EXTREME FORCE IN THIS KID'S CASE."

PERHAPS LITTLE VERNON WAS WORRIED THAT HARRY MIGHT FORGET THEIR BARGAIN;

IN ANY CASE, HE CHANGED THE SUBJECT ABRUPTLY.

"I HEARD THE NEWS THIS MORNING, MARGE? WHAT ABOUT THAT ESCAPED PRISONER, EH?"

AS ALINT MARGE STARTED TO MAKE HERSELF AT HOME, HARRY CALLED HIMSELF THINKING ALMOST WINGINGLY OF LIFE AT NUMBER NINE WITH HER. LITTLE VERNON AND ALINT PETUNIA USUALLY ENCOURAGED HARRY TO STAY OUT OF THEIR WAY, WHICH HARRY WAS ONLY TOO HAPPY TO DO. ALINT MARGE, ON THE OTHER HAND, WANTED HARRY UNDER HER EYE AT ALL TIMES, SHE THAT SHE COULD KISS HIM SUGGESTIONS FOR HIS IMPROVEMENT. SHE DELIGHTED IN COMPARING HARRY WITH DUDLEY, AND TOOK MUCH PLEASURE IN BUYING DUDLEY EXPENSIVE PRESENTS WHILE GLARING AT HARRY, AS THOUGH DARING HIM TO ASK WHY HE HADN'T GIFT A PRESENT THEM. SHE ALSO KEPT THROWING HIM DARK HINTS ABOUT WHAT MADE HARRY

SUCH AN UNSATISFACTORY PERSON.

"THEY MUSTN'T BLAME THEMSELVES FOR THE WAY THE KID'S TURNED OUT, VERNON," SHE SAID OVER LUNCH ON THE THIRD DAY. "IF THERE'S SOMETHING WROTTEN ON THE INSIDE, THERE'S NOTHING ANYONE CAN DO ABOUT IT."

HARRY TRIED TO CONCENTRATE ON HIS FOOD, BUT HIS HANDS SHAKED AND HIS FACE WAS STARTING TO GLIMMER WITH ANGER. REMEMBER THE FORM, HE TOLD HIMSELF. THINK ABOUT THE SCUMPAD, DON'T SAY ANYTHING, DON'T RISE

ALINT MARGE REACHED FOR HER GLASS OF WINE.

"IT'S ONE OF THE BASIC RULES OF BREEDING," SHE SAID. "THEY SEE IT ALL THE TIME WITH DOGS. IF THERE'S SOMETHING WRONG WITH THE KITCHEN, THERE'LL BE SOMETHING WRONG WITH THE FLIP --"

AT THAT MOMENT, THE WINEGLASS ALINT MARGE WAS HOLDING EXPLODED IN HER HAND, SHARDS OF GLASS FLEW IN EVERY DIRECTION AND ALINT MARGE SPLINTERED AND BLINDED, HER GREAT BLOODY FACE DRIPPING.

"MARGE!" SHRIELED ALINT PETLINA, "MARGE, ARE YOU ALL RIGHT?"

"NOT THE WHERRY," GRINNED ALINT MARGE, MIPPING HER FACE WITH HER NAPKIN.

"MUST HAVE SQUEEZED IT TOO HARD, DID THE SAME THING AT CHERREL FLISTER'S THE OTHER DAY, SHE NEED THE GLASS, PETLINA, I HAVE A VERY FIRM GRIP..."

BUT ALINT PETLINA AND LUCIE VERGENN WERE BOTH LEERING AT HARRY SUSPICIOUSLY, SO HE DECIDED HE'D BETTER SKIP DESSERT AND ESCAPE FROM THE TABLE AS SOON AS HE COULD.

ELTISIDE IN THE HALL, HE LEANED AGAINST THE WALL, BREATHING DEEPLY IT HAD BEEN A LONG TIME SINCE HE'D LOST CONTROL AND MADE SOMETHING EXPLODE. HE COULDN'T AFFORD TO LET IT HAPPEN AGAIN. THE HIGSMOOR FIRM WASN'T THE ONLY THING AT STAKE -- IF HE CARRIED ON LIKE THAT, HE'D BE IN TROUBLE WITH THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC.

HARRY WAS STILL AN UNDERAGE WIZARD, AND HE WAS FORBIDDEN BY WIZARD LAW TO DO MAGIC ELTISIDE SCHOOL. HIS RECORD WASN'T EXACTLY CLEAN EITHER. ONLY LAST SUMMER HE'D GOTTEN AN OFFICIAL WARNING THAT HAD STATED ELITE CLEARLY THAT IF THE MINISTRY GOT WIND OF ANY MORE MAGIC IN PRIVET DRIVE, HARRY WOULD FACE EXPULSION FROM HIGWARTS.

HE HEARD THE DURSLEYS LEAVING THE TABLE AND HURRIED UPSTAIRS BEFORE THEY WENT AWAY.

HARRY GOT THROUGH THE NEXT THREE DAYS BY PERSUADING HIMSELF THE THING ABOUT HIS HANGOVERS OF DO-IT-YOURSELF KITCHENWARE WHENEVER ALINT MARGE STARTED HIM

HIM. THIS WORKED ELITE WELL, THOUGH IT SEEMED TO GIVE HIM A GLAZED LOOK, BECAUSE ALINT MARGE STARTED VOICING THE OPINION THAT HE WAS MENTALLY SUBNORMAL.

AT LAST, AT LONG LAST, THE FINAL EVENING OF MARGE'S STAY ARRIVED. ALINT PETLINIA CHEEDED A FANCY DINNER AND LUNCLE VERNEN LUNCHERED SEVERAL BOTTLES OF WINE. THEY EET ALL THE WAY THROUGH THE STEEP AND THE SALMON WITH-OUT A SINGLE MENTION OF HARRY'S FAULTS; DURING THE BEEHIVE MERINGUE PIE, LUNCLE

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VERNEN KEERED THEM A WITH A LONG TALK ABOUT GRANNINGS, HIS DRILL-MAKING COMPANY; THEN ALINT PETLINIA MADE CHEFFER AND LUNCLE VERNEN KEELIGHT EET A BOTTLE OF BRANDY.

"CAN I TEMPT YEH, MARGE?"

ALINT MARGE HAD ALREADY HAD EET OF WINE, HER EELICE FACE WAS VERY RED.

"JUST A SMALL ONE, THEN," SHE CHUCKLED, "A BIT MORE THAN THAT... AND A BIT MORE... THAT'S THE TICKET."

BLUBBY WAS EATING HIS EELIRTH SLICE OF PIE, ALINT PETLINIA WAS SIPPING CHEFFER WITH HER LITTLE FINGER STICKING EET, HARRY REALLY WANTED THE DISAPPEAR INTO HIS BEDROOM, BUT HE MET LUNCLE VERNEN'S ANGRY LITTLE EYES AND KNEW HE WOULD HAVE TO SIT IT EET.

"AAH," SAID ALINT MARGE, SMACKING HER LIPS AND PUTTING THE EMPTY BRANDY GLASS BACK DOWN, "EXCELLENT NEET, PETLINIA. IT'S NEERMAALLY JUST A FRY-LIP FOR ME OF AN EVENING, WITH TWELVE DICS THE EELER AFTER..." SHE CLAPPED RICKLY AND PATTED HER GREAT TWEED STEPMACH. "PARDEN ME, BUT I EEL LIKE TO SEE A HEALTHY-SIZED EEL," SHE WENT EEN, WINKING AT BLUBBY, "YEH'LL BE A PREPPER-SIZED MAN, BLUBBERS, LIKE YEH'ER FATHER. YES, I'LL HAVE A SPOT MORE BRANDY, VERNEN..."

"YEH, THIS ONE HERE --"

SHE LOOKED HER HEAD AT HARRY, WHO FELT HIS STEPMACH CLENCH. THE HANDBOOK, HE THOUGHT EELICELY,

"THIS ONE'S GOT A MEAN, RILINTY ~~LEED~~ AZELT HIM, YELI GET THAT WITH DEES. I

HAD ~~CHLHNEK~~ FLIKSTER DREHN HEN LAST YEAR, RATTY LITTLE THING IT WAS-
LEAD, LINDERED."

HARRY WAS TRYING TO REMEMBER PAGE TWELVE OF HIS ~~KEED~~: A CHARM THE CLIRE
RELLITANT REVERSERS, "IT ALL CHMES DEHN THE ~~KEED~~, AS I WAS SAYING THE
HTHER DAY.

KAD ~~KEED~~ WILL ELT, NEH, I'M SAYING NEETHING AGAINST YELIR FAMILY,
PETLINIA" SHE PATTED ALINT PETLINIA'S KEEDY HAND WITH HER SEHYELLIDE HEN

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"BUT YELIR SISTER WAS A BAD EGG, THEY TURN UP IN THE BEST FAMILIES, THEN
SHE RAN OFF WITH A WASTREL AND HERE'S THE RESULT RIGHT IN FRONT OF US."

HARRY WAS STARING AT HIS PLATE, A FLINDY RINGING IN HIS EARS, GRASP YELIR
BHEEM FIRMLY BY THE TAIL, HE TEHLIGHT, BUT HE CHLDN'T REMEMBER WHAT CAME
NEXT, ALINT MARGE'S VOICE SEEMED TO BE BHRING INTO HIM LIKE HEN OF LINDLE
VERNEEN'S DRILLS.

"THIS BETTER, SI SAID ALINT MARGE LHLIDY, SEIZING THE BRANDY KETTLE AND
SPLASHING MORE INTO HER GLASS AND HYER THE TABLELHTE, "YELI NEVER TELD
ME WHAT HE DID?"

LINDLE VERNEEN AND ALINT PETLINIA WERE ~~LEEDING~~ EXTREMELY TENSE, DUBLY HAD
EVEN ~~LEED~~ UP FROM HIS PIE THE CAPE AT HIS PARENTS.

"HE -- DIDN'T ~~LEED~~," SAID LINDLE VERNEEN, WITH HALF A GLANCE AT HARRY.

"LINDERED."

"AS I EXPECTED!" SAID ALINT MARGE, TAKING A FLICK SWIG OF BRANDY AND
WIPING HER CHIN ON HER SLEEVE. "A NEH-ACCHLINT, CHHD-HER-NEETHING, LAZY
STREHLINGER LHE --"

"HE WAS RIGHT," SAID HARRY SUDDENLY. THE TABLE WENT VERY QUIET. HARRY WAS SHAKING ALL OVER. HE HAD NEVER FELT SHE ANGRY IN HIS LIFE.

"THESE BRADYS?" YELLED LITTLE VERNON, WHO HAD GONE VERY WHITE. HE EMPTIED

THE KETTLE INTO ALICE MARGE'S GLASS. "WELL, KID," HE SNARLED AT HARRY, "GIVE THEM RED, GIVE THEM --"

"NO, VERNON," HICUPPED ALICE MARGE, HOLDING UP A HAND. HER TINY BLUE-EYES FIXED ON HARRY'S. "GIVE THEM, KID, GIVE THEM. PRELUDE OF THEIR PARENTS, ARE THEY? THEY GIVE AND GET THEMSELVES KILLED IN A CAR CRASH (DRUNK, I EXPECT) --"

"THEY DIDN'T DIE IN A CAR CRASH!" SAID HARRY, WHO FELT HIMSELF ON HIS FEET.

"THEY DIED IN A CAR CRASH, YOU NASTY LITTLE LIAR, AND LEFT YOU TWO A BLOODY ON THEIR DECENT, HARDWORKING RELATIVES!" SCREAMED ALICE MARGE, SWELLING WITH FURY. "THEY ARE AN INSOLENT, INGRATEFUL LITTLE --"

224

BUT ALICE MARGE SUDDENLY STOPPED SPEAKING. FOR A MOMENT, IT LOOKED AS THOUGH WORDS HAD FAILED HER. SHE SEEMED TWO FEET SWELLING WITH INEXPRESSIBLE ANGER -- BUT THE SWELLING DIDN'T STOP. HER GREAT RED FACE STARTED TO EXPAND, HER TINY EYES BULGED, AND HER MOUTH STRETCHED THEM TIGHTLY FOR SPEECH -- NEXT SECOND, SEVERAL LITTELS HAD JUST BURST FROM HER TWEED JACKET AND PINCHED OFF THE WALLS -- SHE WAS INFLATING LIKE A MINSTREL'S BALLOON, HER STOMACH BURSTING FREE OF HER TWEED WAISTBAND, EACH OF HER FINGERS BULGING UP LIKE A SALAMI --

"MARGE!" YELLED LITTLE VERNON AND ALICE PETLINIA TOGETHER AS ALICE MARGE'S

WHOLE BODY BEGAN TO RISE OFF HER CHAIR TOWARD THE CEILING. SHE WAS ENTIRELY RED, NOW, LIKE A VAST LIFE BLOOD WITH PIGGY EYES, AND HER

THE DUNGEON IS

HARRY WAS SEVERAL STREETS AWAY WHEN HE COLLAPSED AGAINST A LOW WALL IN MAGNOLIA CRESCENT, PARTING FROM THE EFFORT OF DRAGGING HIS TRUNK. HE SAT HELITE STILL, ANGER STILL SURGING THROUGH HIM, LISTENING TO THE FRANTIC THUMPING OF HIS HEART.

BUT AFTER TEN MINUTES ALONE IN THE DARK STREET, A NEW EMOTION OVERTOOK HIM: PANIC. WHICHEVER WAY HE LOOKED AT IT, HE HAD NEVER BEEN IN A WORSE FIX. HE WAS STRANDED, HELITE ALONE, IN THE DARK MUGGLE WORLD, WITH ABSOLUTELY NOWHERE TO GO. AND THE WORST OF IT WAS, HE HAD JUST DONE SERIOUS MAGIC, WHICH MEANT THAT HE WAS ALMOST CERTAINLY EXPELLED FROM HOGWARTS. HE HAD BROKEN THE DECREE AND THE RESTRICTIONS OF UNDERAGE WIZARDRY SO BADLY, HE WAS SURPRISED MINISTRY OF MAGIC REPRESENTATIVES WEREN'T SWEEPING DOWN ON HIM WHERE HE SAT.

HARRY SHIVERED AND LOOKED UP AND DOWN MAGNOLIA CRESCENT.

WHAT WAS GOING TO HAPPEN TO HIM? WOULD HE BE ARRESTED, OR WOULD HE SIMPLY BE KICKED FROM THE WIZARDING WORLD? HE THOUGHT OF RON AND HERMION, AND HIS HEART SANK EVEN LOWER. HARRY WAS SURE THAT, CRIMINAL OR NOT, RON AND HERMION WOULD WANT TO HELP HIM NOW, BUT THEY WERE KEPT AHEAD, AND WITH PEDIGREE, HE HAD NO MEANS OF CONTACTING THEM.

HE DIDN'T HAVE ANY MUGGLE MONEY, EITHER. THERE WAS A LITTLE WIZARD GOLD IN THE MONEY BAG AT THE BOTTOM OF HIS TRUNK, BUT THE REST OF THE FORTUNE HIS PARENTS HAD LEFT HIM WAS STORED IN A VAULT AT GRINGOTTS WIZARDING BANK IN LONDON. HE'D NEVER BE ABLE TO DRAG HIS TRUNK ALL THE WAY TO LONDON, UNLESS...

22

HE LOOKED DOWN AT HIS HAND, WHICH HE WAS STILL CLUTCHING IN HIS HAND. IF HE WAS ALREADY EXPELLED (HIS HEART WAS NOW THUMPING PAINFULLY FAST), A

BIT MORE MAGIC CHILDREN'T FLIRT, HE HAD THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK HE HAD INHERITED FROM HIS FATHER -- WHAT IF HE REWITCHED THE TRUNK THE MADE IT FEATHER-LIGHT, TIED IT TO HIS KNEEMSTICK, COVERED HIMSELF IN THE CLOAK, AND FLEW THE HUNDREDS? THEN HE COULD GET THE REST OF HIS MONEY OUT OF HIS WALLET AND... BEGIN HIS LIFE AS AN ELITE. IT WAS A TERRIBLE PROSPECT, BUT HE COULDN'T SIT ON THIS WALL FOREVER, HE HAD FIND HIMSELF TRYING TO EXPLAIN THE MIDDLE POLICE WHY HE WAS OUT IN THE DEAD OF NIGHT WITH A TRUNKFUL OF SPELLBOOKS AND A KNEEMSTICK.

HARRY OPENED HIS TRUNK AGAIN AND PULSED THE CONTENTS ASIDE, WHISKING AWAY THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK -- BUT BEFORE HE HAD FOUND IT, HE STRAIGHTENED UP SUDDENLY, WHISKING AROUND HIM QUICK MORE.

A FLINDY PRICKLING ON THE BACK OF HIS NECK HAD MADE HARRY FEEL HE WAS BEING WATCHED, BUT THE STREET APPEARED TO BE DESERTED, AND THE LIGHTS SHONE FROM ANY OF THE LARGE SQUARE BUILDINGS.

HE BENT OVER HIS TRUNK AGAIN, BUT ALMOST IMMEDIATELY STOOD UP QUICK MORE, HIS HAND CLENCHED ON HIS WAND. HE HAD SENSED RATHER THAN HEARD IT: SOMETHING OR SOMETHING WAS STANDING IN THE NARROW GAP BETWEEN THE GARAGE AND THE FENCE BEHIND HIM. HARRY SHRINKED AT THE BLACK ALLEYWAY, IF ONLY IT WOULD MOVE, THEN HE'D KNOW WHETHER IT WAS JUST A STRAY CAT OR -- SOMETHING ELSE.

"BLIMM," HARRY MUTTERED, AND A LIGHT APPEARED AT THE END OF HIS WAND, ALMOST DAZZLING HIM. HE HELD IT HIGH OVER HIS HEAD, AND THE PEBBLE-DASHED WALLS OF ALUMINUM THEN SUDDENLY SPARKLED; THE GARAGE DOOR CLANGED, AND BETWEEN THEM HARRY SAW, WHITE DISTINCTLY, THE FLOPPING OUTLINE OF SOMETHING VERY BIG, WITH WIDE, GLAMING EYES.

HARRY STEPPED BACKWARD, HIS LEGS HIT HIS TRUNK AND HE TRIPPED, HIS HAND FLEW OUT OF HIS HAND AS HE FALLING OUT AN ARM THE BREAK HIS FALL, AND HE LANDED, HARD, IN THE GLITTER --

THERE WAS A DRAINING RANG, AND HARRY THREW UP HIS HANDS THE SHIELD HIS

EYES AGAINST A SUDDEN BLINDING LIGHT --

WITH A YELL, HE REELLED BACK TOWARD THE PAVEMENT, JUST IN TIME. A SECOND

209

LATER, A GIGANTIC PAIR OF WHEELS AND HEADLIGHTS SCREECHED TO A HALT EXACTLY WHERE HARRY HAD JUST BEEN LYING. THEY REVERSED, AS HARRY SAW WHEN HE RAISED HIS HEAD, THE A TRIPLE-DECKER, VIOLENTLY PURPLE BUS, WHICH HAD APPEARED OUT OF THIN AIR. GOLD LETTERING OVER THE WINDSHIELD SPELLED THE KNIGHT BUS.

FOR A SPLIT SECOND, HARRY WANDERED IF HE HAD BEEN DRIVEN SILENT BY HIS FALL. THEN A CHINDICTER IN A PURPLE UNIFORM LEAPT OUT OF THE BUS AND BEGAN TO SPEAK LOUDLY TO THE NIGHT.

"WELCOME TO THE KNIGHT BUS, EMERGENCY TRANSPORT FOR THE STRANDED WITCH-HER WIZARD, JUST STICK OUT YOUR HAND HAND, STEP UP BOARD! AND WE CAN TAKE YOU ANYWHERE YOU WANT TO GO. MY NAME IS STAN SHLIMPEX, AND I WILL BE YOUR CHINDICTER THIS EVE --"

THE CHINDICTER STOPPED ABRUPTLY. HE HAD JUST CALIGIT SIGHT OF HARRY, WHO WAS STILL SITTING IN THE CURBING. HARRY SNATCHED UP HIS HAND AGAIN AND SCRAMBLED TO HIS FEET. CLOSE UP, HE SAW THAT STAN SHLIMPEX WAS ONLY A FEW YEARS OLDER THAN HE WAS, EIGHTEEN OR NINETEEN AT MOST, WITH LARGE, PROTRUDING EARS AND WHITE A FEW PIMPLES.

"WHAT WERE YOU DOIN' DOWN THERE?" SAID STAN, DRIPPING HIS PROFESSIONAL MANNER.

"FELL OVER," SAID HARRY.

"THEE FALL OVER HER?" SNIGGERED STAN.

"I DIDN'T DO IT MY MYSELF," SAID HARRY, ANSWERED. ONE OF THE KNIVES IN HIS JEANS WAS THERE, AND THE HAND HE HAD THROWN OUT THE KRAK HIS FALL WAS BLEEDING. HE SUDDENLY REMEMBERED WHY HE HAD FALLEN OVER AND TURNED

AROUND QUICKLY THE STARE AT THE ALLEYWAY BETWEEN THE GARAGE AND FENCE.
THE KNIGHT BUS'S HEADLAMPS WERE FLOODING IT WITH LIGHT, AND IT WAS
EMPTY.

"LEHH LEHHIN' AT?" SAID STAN.

"THERE WAS A BIG BLACK THING," SAID HARRY, POINTING UNCERTAINLY INTO THE
GAP, "LIKE A DEE... BUT MASSIVE..."

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HE LOOKED AROUND AT STAN, WHOSE MOUTH WAS SLIGHTLY OPEN, WITH A FEELING
OF UNEASE, HARRY SAW STAN'S EYES MOVE TO THE SCAR ON HARRY'S FOREHEAD.

"WHIS THAT EN YELLER 'EAD?" SAID STAN ABRUPTLY.

"NOTHING," SAID HARRY QUICKLY, FLATTENING HIS HAIR OVER HIS SCAR, IF THE
MINISTRY OF MAGIC WAS LOOKING FOR HIM, HE DIDN'T WANT TO MAKE IT TOO
EASY FOR THEM.

"WHIS YELLER NAME?" STAN PERSISTED.

"NEVILLE LONGBOTT," SAID HARRY, SAYING THE FIRST NAME THAT CAME INTO
HIS HEAD. "SH -- SHE THIS BUS," HE WENT ON QUICKLY, TRYING TO DISTRACT
STAN. "DID YELL SAY IT GOES ANYWHERE?"

"YEP," SAID STAN PROMPTLY, "ANYWHERE YELL LIKE, WHING'S IT'S EN LAND, CAN'T
BE RIPPING UNDERWATER, 'ERE," HE SAID, LOOKING SUSPICIOUS AGAIN, "YELL
DID FLAG US DOWN, DINKLE? STICK HOLT YELLER HAND 'AND, DINKLE?"

"YES," SAID HARRY QUICKLY, "LISTEN, WHEN MUMS WOULD IT BE TO GET THE
LEHNDIN?"

"EVEN SIXLES," SAID STAN, "BUT FOR FIFTEEN YELL GET 'ER CHEESECAKE, AND
FOR FIFTEEN YELL GET AN 'ET WATER KETTLE AN' A THERMOS IN THE CUPBOARD
YELLER CHEESE."

HARRY RUMMAGED HURRY HERE IN HIS TRUNK, EXTRACTED HIS MONEY BAG, AND
SHOVED SOME COIN INTO STAN'S HAND, HE AND STAN THEN LIFTED HIS TRUNK,

WITH FREDWIG'S CAGE BALANCED ON TOP, UP THE STEPS OF THE BUS.

THERE WERE NO SEATS; INSTEAD, HALF A DOZEN BRASS BEDSTEADS STOOD BESIDE THE CURTAINED WINDOWS. CANDLES WERE BURNING IN BRACKETS BESIDE EACH BED, ILLUMINATING THE WHITE-PANELLED WALLS. A TINY WIZARD IN A NIGHTCAP AT THE REAR OF THE BUS MUTTERED, "NOT WELL, THANKS, I'M PICKLING SOME SLICES" AND ROLLED OVER IN HIS SLEEP.

"WELL 'AVE THIS ONE," STAN WHISPERED, SHEVING HARRY'S TRUNK UNDER THE BED RIGHT BEHIND THE DRIVER, WHO WAS SITTING IN AN ARMCHAIR IN FRONT OF THE STEERING WHEEL. "THIS IS OUR DRIVER, ERNIE PRANG. THIS IS NEVILLE LONGBOTTHER, ERN."

27

ERNIE PRANG, AN ELDERLY WIZARD WEARING VERY THICK GLASSES, NODDED TO HARRY, WHO NERVOUSLY FLATTENED HIS KNEES AGAIN AND SAT DOWN ON HIS BED. "TAKE 'ER AWAY, ERN," SAID STAN, SITTING DOWN IN THE ARMCHAIR NEXT TO ERNIE'S.

THERE WAS ANOTHER TREMENDOUS BANG, AND THE NEXT MOMENT HARRY FOUND HIMSELF FLAT ON HIS BED, THROWN BACKWARD BY THE SPEED OF THE KNIGHT BUS. PULLING HIMSELF UP, HARRY STARED OUT OF THE DARK WINDOW AND SAW THAT THEY WERE NOW ROLLING ALONG A COMPLETELY DIFFERENT STREET. STAN WAS WATCHING HARRY'S STUNNED FACE WITH GREAT ENJOYMENT.

"THIS IS WHERE WE WAS BEFORE YOU FLAGGED US DOWN," HE SAID. "WHERE ARE WE, ERN? SOMEWHERE IN WALES?"

"AR," SAID ERNIE.

"HOW COME THE MUGGLES DIDN'T HEAR THE BUS?" SAID HARRY.

"THEM?" SAID STAN CHEERFULLY, "DIDN'T LISTEN PROPERLY, DID THEY? DIDN'T THINK PROPERLY EITHER. NEVER NOTICE NOTHING, THEY DIDN'T."

"BEST GO WAKE UP MRS. MURPHY, STAN," SAID ERN. "WE'LL BE IN ABERCROFTON"

IN A MINUTE."

STAN PASSED HARRY'S BED AND DISAPPEARED UP A NARROW WOODEN STAIRCASE. HARRY WAS STILL LEANING OUT OF THE WINDOW, FEELING INCREASINGLY NERVOUS. ERNIE DIDN'T SEEM TO HAVE MASTERED THE USE OF A STEERING WHEEL. THE KNIGHT BUS KEPT BOUNCING THE PAVEMENT, BUT IT DIDN'T HIT ANYTHING; LINES OF LAMPPOSTS, MAILBOXES, AND TRASH CANS JUMPED OUT OF ITS WAY AS IT APPROACHED AND BACK INTO POSITION ONCE IT HAD PASSED.

STAN CAME BACK DOWNSTAIRS, FOLLOWED BY A FAINTLY GREEN WITCH WRAPPED IN A TRAVELING CLOAK.

"ERE YELL EH, MADAM MARSH," SAID STAN HAPPILY AS ERNIE STAMPED ON THE BRACKS AND THE BEDS SLID A FEET FOR HER TOWARD THE FRONT OF THE BUS. MADAM MARSH CLAMPED A HANDKERCHIEF TO HER MOUTH AND TITTERED BEHIND THE STEPS. STAN THREW HER BAG OUT AFTER HER AND RAMMED THE DOORS SHUT; THERE WAS

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ANOTHER WILD RIDE, AND THEY WERE THUNDERING DOWN A NARROW COUNTRY LANE,

TREES LEAPING OUT OF THE WAY.

HARRY WOULDN'T HAVE BEEN ABLE TO SLEEP EVEN IF HE HAD BEEN TRAVELING ON A BUS THAT DIDN'T KEEP BOUNCING WILDLY AND JUMPING A HUNDRED MILES AT A TIME. HIS STOMACH CLUNKED AS HE FELL BACK THUNDERING WHAT WAS GOING TO HAPPEN TO HIM, AND WHETHER THE BLURLEYS HAD MANAGED TO GET ALINT MARGE OFF THE CRUISE YET.

STAN HAD UNWRAPPED A COPY OF THE DAILY PROPHECY AND WAS NOW READING WITH HIS THUMB BETWEEN HIS TEETH. A LARGE PHOTOGRAPH OF A SLIMY-FACED MAN WITH LONG, MATTED HAIR BLINKED SLEAZY AT HARRY FROM THE FRONT PAGE. HE LOOKED STRANGELY FAMILIAR.

"THAT MAN?" HARRY SAID, FORGETTING HIS TROUBLE FOR A MOMENT. "HE WAS ON THE MUGGLE NEWS."

STANLEY TURNED THE FRONT PAGE AND CHUCKLED.

"STIRILIS BLACK," HE SAID, NODDING. "CHURCH 'E WAS IN THE MUGGLE NEWS, NEVILLE, WHERE WERE YOU KEEN?"

HE GAVE A SLIPPERIER SHIRT HE CHUCKLE AT THE BLANK LINE ON HARRY'S FACE, REMOVED THE FRONT PAGE, AND HANDED IT TO HARRY.

"YOU MIGHT READ THE PAPERS THERE, NEVILLE."

HARRY HELD THE PAPER UP TO THE CANDLELIGHT AND READ:

BLACK STILL AT LARGE

STIRILIS BLACK, POSSIBLY THE MOST INFAMOUS PRISONER EVER TO BE HELD IN AZKABAN PRISON, IS STILL ELUDING CAPTURE, THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC CONFIRMED TODAY.

"WE ARE DOING ALL WE CAN TO RECAPTURE BLACK," SAID THE MINISTER OF MAGIC, CORNELIUS FUDGE, THIS MORNING, "AND WE ASK THE MAGICAL COMMUNITY TO REMAIN CALM."

FUDGE HAS BEEN CRITICIZED BY SOME MEMBERS OF THE INTERNATIONAL

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FEDERATION OF WIZARDS FOR INFORMING THE MUGGLE PRIME MINISTER OF THE CRISIS.

"WELL, REALLY, I HAD TO, DIDN'T YOU KNOW?" SAID AN IRRITABLE FUDGE.

"BLACK IS MAD, HE'S A DANGER TO ANYONE WHO CROSSES HIM, MAGIC OR MUGGLE. I HAVE THE PRIME MINISTER'S ASSURANCE THAT HE WILL NOT REVEAL A WORD OF BLACK'S TRUE IDENTITY TO ANYONE, AND LET'S FACE IT-WE'D BELIEVE HIM IF HE DID?"

WHILE MUGGLES HAVE BEEN TOLD THAT BLACK IS CARRYING A GUN (A KIND OF METAL HAND THAT MUGGLES USE TO KILL EACH OTHER), THE MAGICAL COMMUNITY LIVES IN FEAR OF A MASSACRE LIKE THAT OF TWELVE YEARS AGO, WHEN BLACK MURDERED THIRTEEN PEOPLE WITH A SINGLE CURSE.

ELARRY LEEKED INTO THE SHADDED EYES OF STIRILS BLACK, THE ONLY PART OF THE SLINDEN FACE THAT SEEMED ALIVE. ELARRY HAD NEVER MET A VAMPIRE, BUT HE HAD SEEN PICTURES OF THEM IN HIS DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS CLASSES, AND BLACK, WITH HIS WAXY WHITE SKIN, LEEKED ILST LIKE ONE.

"SCARY-LEEKIN' FINE, INEE?" SAID STAN, WHO HAD BEEN WATCHING ELARRY READ. "HE MURDERED THIRTEEN PEEPLE?" SAID ELARRY, HANDING THE PAGE BACK TO STAN, "WITH HEE CLUSE?"

"YEP," SAID STAN, "IN PRENT OF WITNESSES AN' ALL. BREED DAYLIGHT. BIG TREBLE IT CALISED, DINNIT, ERN?"

"AR," SAID ERN DARKLY.

STAN SWIVLED IN HIS ARMCHAIR, HIS HANDS ON THE BACK, THE BETTER TO LEEK AT ELARRY.

"BLACK WEE A BIG SLIPPHINTER OF YELI-KNEEL-HEE," HE SAID.

"WHAT, YELDERHEE?" SAID ELARRY, WITH ILIT THINKING.

EVEN STAN'S PIMPLES WENT WHITE; ERN IRRED THE STEERING WHEEL SHE HAD THAT A WEELE FARMHEELEE HAD THE ILMP ASIDE THE AVENID THE ELIS.

"YELI ELITTA YELIR TREE?" YELPED STAN, "LEEE SAY 'IS NAME HEY?"

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"SHRRY," SAID ELARRY HASTILY, "SHRRY, I -- I FRIGHT --"

"FRIGHT?" SAID STAN WEARILY, "KLIMY, MY 'EART'S CHIN' THAT FAST ..."

"SEE -- SEE BLACK WAS A SLIPPHINTER OF YELI-KNEEL-LEE?" ELARRY PROMPTED APPEHEGETICALLY.

"YEAH," SAID STAN, STILL RLEKING HIS CHEST. "YEAH, THAT'S RIGHT. YERY CLUSE THE YELI-KNEEL-HEE, THEY SAY, ANDWAY, WHEN LITTLE 'ARRY PEEETTER GET THE BETTER OF YELI-KNEEL-HEE --"

ELARRY NERVHELISLY FLATTENED HIS KANGS DEELN AGAIN.

"-- ALL YELI-KNEEL-HEE'S SLIPPHINTERS WAS TRACKED DEELN, WASN'T THEY, ERN?"

MEET IF 'EM KNOW IT WAS ALL OVER, LIT YELL-DROWN-THO GONE, AND THEY CAME
HELPER, BUT NOT SIRILIS BLACK, I 'DARD HE THUGHT 'E'D BE
SECOND-IN-COMMAND SINCE YELL-DROWN-THO 'AD TAKEN OVER.

"ANDYDAD, THEY CHARGED BLACK IN THE MIDDLE OF A STREET FULL OF MUGGLES
AN' BLACK THEED HELT 'IS WARD AND 'E BLASTED 'ALL THE STREET APART, AN' A
WIZARD GET IT, AN' SHE DID A DIZZEN MUGGLES WAT GET IN THE WAY, 'HORRIBLE,
EH? AN' YELL DROWN WAT BLACK DID THEN?" STAN CONTINUED IN A DRAMATIC
WHISPER.

"WAT?" SAID HARRY.

"LAUGHED," SAID STAN. "ILIS' STEED THERE AN' LAUGHED, AN' WHEN
REINFORCEMENTS FROM THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC GET THERE, I 'E WENT LIT EM
HELPER AS ANYFING, STILL LAUGHING 'IS 'EAD OFF, 'THEE 'E'S MAD, INEE, ERN?
INEE MAD?"

"IF HE WEREN'T WHEN HE WENT TH AZKABAN, HE WILL BE NEH," SAID ERN IN HIS
SLOW VOICE. "I'D BEEN MESELF LIP BEHRE I SET FHEE IN THAT PLACE, SERVES
HIM RIGHT, MIND YELL ... AFTER WAT HE DID..."

"THEY 'AD A IHE CHYERIN' IT LIP, DIN' THEY, ERN?" STAN SAID. "HLE STREET
BEHIN LIP AN' ALL THEM MUGGLES DEAD, WAT WAS IT THEY SAID AD 'APPENED,
ERN?"

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"GAS EXPLOSTHEE," GRANTED ERNIE.

"AN' NEH 'E'S HELT," SAID STAN, EXAMINING THE NEWSPAPER PICTURE OF
BLACK'S GALINT FACE AGAIN. "NEVER BEEN A BREADHELT FROM AZKABAN BEHRE,
'AS THERE, ERN? BEATS ME 'HEW 'E DID IT, FRIGHTEENIN', EH? MIND, I DEEN'T
FANCY 'IS CHANCES AGAINST THEM AZKABAN GUARDS, EH, ERN?"
ERNIE SLIDENLY SHIVERED.

"TALK ABHELT SLIMAT ELSE, STAN, THERE'S A CHEED LAD, THEM AZKABAN GUARDS
GIVE ME THE CHILLS/SHAKES."

STAN PLIT THE PAPER AWAY RELUCTANTLY, AND HARRY LEANED AGAINST THE WINDMILL

BY THE DAWN LIGHT, FEELING WORSE THAN EVER, HE COULDN'T HELP IMAGINING WHAT STAN MIGHT BE TELLING HIS PASSENGERS IN A FEW NIGHTS' TIME.

"FOR ABOUT THAT 'ARRY PETER? BLEW UP 'IS ALINT? WE 'AD 'EM 'ERE BY THE DAWN LIGHT, DIDN'T WE, ERN? 'E WAS TRYIN' I TELL 'EM 'IT..."

HE, HARRY, HAD KNOWN WIZARD LAW ILIT LIKE SIRILIS BLACK, WAS IMPLATING ALINT MARGEY HAD ENOUGH THE LAND HIM IN ALEXANDER? HARRY DIDN'T KNOW ANYTHING

ABOUT THE WIZARD PRISON, THOUGH EVERYONE HE'D EVER HEARD SPEAK OF IT DID SEE IN THE SAME FEARFUL THING. HAGRID, THE HOGWARTS GAMEKEEPER, HAD SPENT TWO MONTHS THERE ONLY LAST YEAR, HARRY WOULDN'T SEEN FORGET THE LOOK OF TERROR BY HAGRID'S FACE WHEN HE HAD BEEN TOLD WHERE HE WAS GOING, AND HAGRID WAS ONE OF THE CRAVEST PEOPLE HARRY KNEW.

THE DAWN LIGHT ROLLED THROUGH THE DARKNESS, SCATTERING KISSES AND WASTEBASKETS, TELEPHONE KISSES AND TREES, AND HARRY LAY, RESTLESS AND MISERABLE, BY HIS FEATHER BED. AFTER A WHILE, STAN REMEMBERED THAT HARRY HAD PAID FOR HIS CHOCOLATE, BUT FORGOT IT ALL BY HARRY'S PILLOW WHEN THE LIGHT MOVED ABRUPTLY FROM ALEXANDER THE ALEXANDER, ONE BY ONE, WIZARDS AND WITCHES IN DRESSING GOWNS AND SLIPPERS DESCENDED FROM THE UPPER FLOORS TO LEAVE THE LIGHT. THEY ALL LOOKED VERY PLEASED TO GO.

FINALLY, HARRY WAS THE ONLY PASSENGER LEFT.

"RIGHT THEN, NEVILLE," SAID STAN, CLAPPING HIS HANDS, WHERE ABOUTS IN LONDON?"

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"DIAGN ALICE," SAID HARRY.

"RIGHT," SAID STAN, "HOLD TIGHT, THEN."

END.

THEY WERE THUNDERING ALONG CHARING CROSS ROAD. HARRY SAT UP AND WATCHED

BUILDINGS AND BENCHES SHAKING THEMSELVES UNTIL THE KNIGHT BUS'S WAY. THE SKY WAS GETTING A LITTLE LIGHTER. HE WOULD BE WELL AHEAD A COUPLE OF FEET. ON THE BRINKS THE MOMENT IT HAPPENED, THEN SET OFF -- WHERE HE DIDN'T KNOW.

ERN SLAPPED HIM THE BRACKS AND THE KNIGHT BUS SKIDDED TO A HALT IN FRONT OF A SMALL AND SHAKY-LOOKING PLACE, THE LEADY CALIBREIN, BEHIND WHICH LAY THE MAGICAL ENTRANCE TO DIAGON ALLEY.

"THANKS," HARRY SAID TO ERN.

HE JUMPED DOWN THE STEPS AND HELPED STAN LOWER HIS TRUNK AND HEDWIG'S CAGE INTO THE PAVEMENT.

"WELL," SAID HARRY, "BYE THEN!"

BUT STAN WASN'T PAYING ATTENTION. STILL STANDING IN THE MIDDLE OF THE BUS HE WAS GIGGLING AT THE SHAKELY ENTRANCE TO THE LEADY CALIBREIN.

"THERE YOU ARE, HARRY," SAID A VOICE.

BEFORE HARRY COULD TURN, HE FELT A HAND ON HIS SHOULDER. AT THE SAME TIME, STAN SHOUTED, "KIDNEY! ERN, COME 'ERE! COME 'ERE I"

HARRY LOOKED UP AT THE OWNER OF THE HAND ON HIS SHOULDER AND FELT A CLICKETAL OF ICE CASCADE INTO HIS STOMACH -- HE HAD WALKED RIGHT INTO CHERNOBIL'S FLICE, THE MINISTER OF MAGIC HIMSELF.

STAN LEAPT INTO THE PAVEMENT BESIDE THEM.

"WHAT DID I CALL NEVILLE, MINISTER?" HE SAID EXCITEDLY.

FLICE, A PORTLY LITTLE MAN IN A LONG, PINSTRIPED COAT, LOOKED UP AND EXHAUSTED.

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"NEVILLE?" HE REPEATED, FROWNING. "THIS IS HARRY POTTER."

"I KNOW IT!" STAN SHOUTED GLEEFULLY. "ERN! ERN! GUESS WHO NEVILLE IS,

ERNIE'S 'ARRY PHTTER! I CAN SEE 'IS SCAR!"

"YES," SAID FLUDGE TESTILY, "WELL, I'M VERY GLAD THE KNIGHT BUS PICKED
FARRY UP, BUT HE AND I NEED THE STEP INSIDE THE LEADY CALIBREIN NEEL..."
FLUDGE INCREASED THE PRESSURE ON FARRY'S SHOULDER, AND FARRY FELT
HIMSELF BEING STEERED INSIDE THE PLUG. A STEPPING FIGURE BEARING A
LANTERN APPEARED THROUGH THE DOOR BEHIND THE BAR. IT WAS THEM, THE
WIZENED, THEFT-LESS LANDLORD.

"WELL'VE GOT HIM, MINISTER!" SAID THEM. "WILL YOU BE WANTING ANYTHING?
KEERY BRANDY?"

"PERHAPS A PINT OF TEA," SAID FLUDGE, WHO STILL HADN'T LET GO OF FARRY.
THERE WAS A LITTLE SCRAPING AND PLUFFING FROM BEHIND THEM, AND STAN AND ERNIE
APPEARED, CARRYING FARRY'S TRUNK AND FREDDIE'S BAG AND BEHAVING AROUND
EXCITEDLY.

"WELL THERE YOU DIDN'T TELL US 'HEE YOU ARE, EH, NEVILLE?" SAID STAN,
BEAMING AT FARRY, WHILE ERNIE'S BEGLING FACE PEERED INTERESTEDLY OVER
STAN'S SHOULDER.

"AND A PRIVATE PARLOR, PLEASE, THEM," SAID FLUDGE PHINTEDLY.

BYE," FARRY SAID MISERABLY TO STAN AND ERNIE AS THEM RECKONED FLUDGE TOWARD
THE PASSAGE THAT LED FROM THE BAR.

"BYE, NEVILLE?" CALLED STAN.

FLUDGE MARCHED FARRY ALONG THE NARROW PASSAGE AFTER THEM'S LANTERN, AND
THEN INTO A SMALL PARLOR. THEM CLICKED HIS FINGERS, A FIRE BURST INTO
LIFE IN THE GRATE, AND HE KNEW HIMSELF HELD UP THE ROOM.

"SIT DOWN, FARRY," SAID FLUDGE, INDICATING A CHAIR BY THE FIRE.

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FARRY SAT DOWN, FEELING CHEESE KLIMPS RISING UP HIS ARMS DESPITE THE GLOW
OF THE FIRE. FLUDGE THREW OFF HIS PINSTRIPED CLOAK AND THESSED IT ASIDE,

THEN HITCHED UP THE TROUSERS OF HIS KITTLE-GREEN SLIT AND SAT DOWN
OPPOSITE HARRY.

"I AM CERNELIUS FUDGE, HARRY, THE MINISTER OF MAGIC."

HARRY ALREADY KNEW THIS, OF COURSE; HE HAD SEEN FUDGE ENCE BEFORE, BUT
AS HE HAD BEEN WEARING HIS FATHER'S INVISIBILITY CLOAK AT THE TIME,
FUDGE HADN'T THEN KNOWN THAT.

THEN THE INDOORER REAPPEARED, WEARING AN APRON OVER HIS NIGHTSHIRT AND
BEARING A TRAY OF TEA AND CRUMPKETS. HE PLACED THE TRAY ON A TABLE
BETWEEN FUDGE AND HARRY AND LEFT THE PARLOUR, CLOSING THE DOOR BEHIND
HIM.

"WELL, HARRY," SAID FUDGE, PHEURING MILK TEA, "YOU'VE HAD US ALL IN A
RIGHT FLAP, I DIDN'T MIND TELLING YOU. RUNNING AWAY FROM YOUR AUNT AND
UNCLE'S HOUSE LIKE THAT! I'D STARTED THE THINKING... BUT YOU'RE SAFE, AND
THAT'S WHAT MATTERS."

FUDGE KLITTERED HIMSELF A CRUMPKET AND POLISHED THE PLATE TOWARD HARRY.

"BUT, HARRY, YOU LOOK DEAD ON YOUR FEET. NOW THEN... YOU WILL BE PLEASED
TO HEAR THAT WE HAVE DEALT WITH THE UNFORTUNATE BLEEDING-LIP OF MISS
MARIONNE DURSLEY. THE MEMBERS OF THE ACCIDENTAL MAGIC REVERSAL
DEPARTMENT WERE DISPATCHED TO PRIVATE DRIVE A FEW HOURS AGO. MISS DURSLEY
HAS BEEN PUNCTURED AND HER MEMORY HAS BEEN MODIFIED. SHE HAS NO
RECOLLECTION OF THE INCIDENT AT ALL. SEE THAT'S THAT, AND NO HARM DONE."

FUDGE SMILED AT HARRY OVER THE RIM OF HIS TEACUP, RATHER LIKE AN UNCLE
SURVEYING A FAVORITE NEPHEW. BUT CHILDREN DON'T BELIEVE HIS EARS,
HE OPENED HIS MOUTH THE SPACE, CHILDREN DON'T THINK OF ANYTHING THEY SAY, AND CLOSED
IT AGAIN.

"AND YOU'RE WONDERING ABOUT THE REACTION OF YOUR AUNT AND UNCLE?" SAID
FUDGE. "WELL, I DON'T DENY THAT THEY ARE EXTREMELY ANGRY, HARRY, BUT
THEY ARE PREPARED TO TAKE YOU BACK NEXT SUMMER AS LONG AS YOU STAY AT
HOGWARTS FOR THE CHRISTMAS AND EASTER HOLIDAYS."

HARRY LINSTICK HIS THREAT.

"I ALWAYS STAY AT HOGWARTS FOR THE CHRISTMAS AND EASTER HOLIDAYS," HE SAID, "AND I DIDN'T EVER WANT TO GO BACK THE PRIVET DRIVE."

"NEH, NEH, I'M SURE YOU'LL FEEL DIFFERENTLY ONCE YOU'VE CALMED DOWN," SAID FLUDGE IN A WHIRRED TONE. "THEY ARE YOUR FAMILY, AFTER ALL, AND I'M SURE YOU ARE FRIENDS OF EACH OTHER -- ER -- VERY DEEP FRIENDS."

IT DIDN'T OCCUR TO HARRY TO PUT FLUDGE RIGHT, FOR WAS STILL WAITING TO HEAR WHAT WAS GOING TO HAPPEN TO HIM NEH.

"SEE ALL THAT REMAINS," SAID FLUDGE, NEH KLITTERING HIMSELF A SECOND CRUMPET, "IS TO DECIDE WHERE YOU'RE GOING TO SPEND THE LAST TWO WEEKS OF YOUR VACATION. I SUGGEST YOU TAKE A ROOM HERE AT THE LEADY CALDERN AND 'FANG ON," KLITTERED HARRY, "WHAT ABOUT MY PUNISHMENT?"

FLUDGE BLINKED. "PUNISHMENT?"

"I KNOW THE LAW!" HARRY SAID. "THE DECREE FOR THE RESTRICTIONS OF UNDERAGE WIZARDRY!"

"HEH, MY DEAR KID, WE'RE NOT GOING TO PUNISH YOU FOR A LITTLE THING LIKE THAT!" CRIED FLUDGE, WAVING HIS CRUMPET IMPATIENTLY. "IT WAS AN ACCIDENT! WE DIDN'T SEND PEOPLE THE ANKARAN LIST FOR KNEELING UP THEIR ALIBIS?" BUT THIS DIDN'T TALLY AT ALL WITH HARRY'S PAST DEALINGS WITH THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC.

"LAST YEAR, I GOT AN OFFICIAL WARNING LIST BECAUSE A FISHY-PL SPASTIC A PLUDDING IN MY UNCLE'S FISHY!" HE TOLD FLUDGE, FROWNING. "THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC SAID I'D BE EXPELLED FROM HOGWARTS IF THERE WAS ANY MORE MAGIC THERE!"

UNLESS HARRY'S EYES WERE DECEIVING HIM, FLUDGE WAS SUDDENLY WHISKING AWAYWARD.

"CIRCUMSTANCES CHANGE, HARRY... WE HAVE TO TAKE INTO ACCOUNT... IN THE PRESENT CLIMATE... SURELY YOU DIDN'T WANT THEM EXPULSED?"

XX

"OF COURSE I DIDN'T," SAID HARRY.

"WELL THEN, WHAT'S A THE FLISS ABOUT?" LAUGHED FLUDGE. "NOW, HAVE A CRUMPET, HARRY, WHILE I GO AND SEE IF THEM'S GOT A ROOM FOR YOU."

FLUDGE STRODE AWAY FROM THE PARLOUR AND HARRY STARED AFTER HIM. THERE WAS SOMETHING EXTREMELY ODD GOING ON. WHY HAD FLUDGE BEEN WAITING FOR HIM AT THE LEADY CALLOBBEN, IF NOT TO PLANISH HIM FOR WHAT HE'D DONE? AND NOW HARRY CAME TO THINK OF IT, SURELY IT WASN'T USUAL FOR THE MINISTER OF MAGIC HIMSELF TO GET INVOLVED IN MATTERS OF UNDERAGE MAGIC?

FLUDGE CAME BACK, ACCOMPANIED BY THEM THE INNKEEPER.

"ROOM ELEVEN'S FREE, HARRY," SAID FLUDGE. "I THINK YOU'LL BE VERY COMFORTABLE. JUST ONE THING, AND I'M SURE YOU'LL UNDERSTAND... I DIDN'T WANT YOU WANDERING OFF INTO MUGGLE LONDON, ALL RIGHT? KEEP THE DIAGON ALLEY, AND YOU'RE TO BE BACK HERE BEFORE DARK EACH NIGHT. SURE YOU'LL UNDERSTAND. THEM WILL BE KEEPING AN EYE ON YOU FOR ME."

"HEY," SAID HARRY SLEELY, "BUT WHY?"

"DIDN'T WANT THE LOSS OF YOU AGAIN, DID WE?" SAID FLUDGE WITH A HEARTY LAUGH.

"OH, YES... BEST WE KNOW WHERE YOU ARE... I MEAN..."

FLUDGE CLEARED HIS THROAT SLEELY AND PICKED UP HIS PINSTRIPED CLOAK.

"WELL, I'LL BE OFF, PLENTY OF THEM, YOU KNOW..."

"HAVE YOU HAD ANY LUCK WITH BLACK PETS?" HARRY ASKED.

FLUDGE'S FINGER SLIPPED ON THE SILVER FASTENINGS OF HIS CLOAK.

"WHAT'S THAT? EH, YOU'VE HEARD -- WELL, YES, NOT YET, BUT IT'S ONLY A MATTER OF TIME. THE AZKABAN CHAINS HAVE NEVER YET FAILED... AND THEY ARE ANGRIER THAN I'VE EVER SEEN THEM."

FLUDGE SLIDDERED SLIGHTLY.

"SEE, I'LL SAY GOOD-BYE."

K9

HE HELD UP HIS HAND AND HARRY, SEIZING IT, HAD A SUDDEN IDEA.

"ER -- MINISTER? CAN I ASK YOU SOMETHING?"

"CERTAINLY," SAID FLUDGE WITH A SMILE.

"WELL, THIRD YEARS AT HOGWARTS ARE ALLOWED THE VISIT HOGSMEADE, BUT MY AUNT AND UNCLE DIDN'T SIGN THE PERMISSION FORM, D'YOU THINK YOU COULD --?"

FLUDGE WAS BECOMING UNCOMFORTABLE.

"AH," HE SAID, "NEH, NEH, I'M VERY SORRY, HARRY, BUT AS I'M NOT YOUR PARENT OR GUARDIAN --"

"BUT YOU ARE THE MINISTER OF MAGIC," SAID HARRY EAGERLY. "IF YOU GAVE ME PERMISSION

"NEH, I'M SORRY, HARRY, BUT RULES ARE RULES," SAID FLUDGE FLATLY.

"PERHAPS YOU'LL BE ABLE TO VISIT HOGSMEADE NEXT YEAR. IN FACT, I THINK IT'S BEST IF YOU DON'T... YES... WELL, I'LL BE OFF ENJOY YOUR STAY, HARRY."

AND WITH A LAST SMILE AND SHAKE OF HARRY'S HAND, FLUDGE LEFT THE ROOM.

THEY THEN MOVED FORWARD, GLANCING AT HARRY.

"IF YOU'LL FOLLOW ME, MR. POTTER," HE SAID, "I'VE ALREADY TAKEN YOUR THINGS UP..."

HARRY FOLLOWED THEM UP A HANDSOME WOODEN STAIRCASE TO A DOOR WITH A BRASS

NUMBER ELEVEN ON IT, WHICH THEY UNLOCKED AND OPENED FOR HIM.

INSIDE WAS A VERY COMFORTABLE-LOOKING BED, SOME HIGHLY POLISHED OAK FURNITURE, A CHEERFULLY CRACKLING FIRE AND, PERCHED ON THE END OF THE WARDROBE -

"FREDWIG!" HARRY GASPED.

THE SNEELY HELL CLICKED HER REAR AND FLUTTERED BEHIND HENRY HARRY'S ARM.

"VERY SMART HELL WHEN YOU GET THERE, CHUCKLED THEM. "ARRIVED ABOUT FIVE MINUTES AFTER YOU DID. IF THERE'S ANYTHING YOU NEED, MR. POTTER, DON'T HESITATE TO ASK."

HE GAVE ANOTHER KISS AND LEFT.

HARRY SAT ON HIS BED FOR A LONG TIME, ASCENTMINDEDLY STRECHING FREDNIE.

THE SKY OUTSIDE THE WINDOW WAS CHANGING RAPIDLY FROM DEEP, VELVETY BLUE TO CHILD, STEELY GRAY AND THEN, SILENTLY, TO PINK SKIN WITH CHILD. HARRY COULD HARDLY BELIEVE THAT HE'D LEFT PRIVET DRIVE ONLY A FEW HOURS AGO, THAT HE WASN'T EXPELLED, AND THAT HE WAS NOW FACING THE COMPLETELY BLISSFUL-FREE WEEKS.

"IT'S BEEN A VERY WEIRD NIGHT, FREDNIE," HE YAWNED.

AND WITHOUT EVEN REMOVING HIS GLASSES, HE SLUMPED BACK INTO HIS PILLOWS AND FELL ASLEEP.

CHAPTER FOUR

THE LADY CALIBREIN

IT TOOK HARRY SEVERAL DAYS TO GET USED TO HIS STRANGE NEW FREEDOM. NEVER BEFORE HAD HE BEEN ABLE TO GET UP WHENEVER HE WANTED OR EAT WHATEVER HE FANCIED. HE COULD EVEN GO WHEREVER HE PLEASED, AS LONG AS IT WAS IN DIAGON ALLEY, AND AS THIS LONG CHECKED STREET WAS PACKED WITH THE MOST FASCINATING WIZARDING SHOPS IN THE WORLD, HARRY FELT THE DESIRE TO KRAKE HIS WARD THE FLICK AND STRAY BACK INTO THE MUGGLE WORLD.

HARRY ATE BREAKFAST EACH MORNING IN THE LADY CALIBREIN, WHERE HE LIKED WATCHING THE OTHER GUESTS: FLINDY LITTLE WITCHES FROM THE COUNTRY, UP FOR A DAY'S SHOPPING; VENERABLE-LOOKING WIZARDS ARGUING OVER THE LATEST ARTICLE IN TRANSFIGURATION TODAY; WILD-LOOKING WARRIORS; RALPH'S BLARS;

AND HENCE, WHAT LOOKED SUSPICIOUSLY LIKE A FLAG, HE ORDERED A PLATE OF
RAW LIVER FROM BEHIND A THICK WHITEEN KALACHAVA.

AFTER BREAKFAST HARRY WOULD GO OUT INTO THE BACKYARD, TAKE OUT HIS HAND,
TAP THE THIRD BRICK FROM THE LEFT ABOVE THE TRASH KIT,, AND STAND BACK

91

AS THE ARCHWAY INTO DIAGEN ALLEY OPENED IN THE WALL.

HARRY SPENT THE LONG SLINDY DAYS EXPLORING THE STREETS AND EATING UNDER
THE

BRIGHTLY CHEERED LUMINOUS HILLSIDE LAFES, WHERE HIS FELLOW DINERS WERE
STELLING ONE ANOTHER THEIR PURCHASES | " IT , \$ A LUNASCOPE, HAD BEEN --
NEE MORE MISSING AROUND WITH MEEN CHARTS, SEE? | HE ELSE DISCUSSING THE
CASE OF SIRILIS BLACK | " PERSONALITY, I WEN'T LET ANY OF THE CHILDREN GO
ALONE UNTIL HE'S BACK IN AZDARAN", HARRY DIDN'T HAVE THE BE HIS FELLOWERS
UNDER THE BLANKETS BY FLASHLIGHT ANYMORE; WHEN HE COULD SIT IN THE BRIGHT
SUNSHINE HILLSIDE FLEETMAN FORTESCUE'S ICE CREAM PARLOR, FINISHING ALL HIS
ESSAYS WITH OCCASIONAL HELP FROM FLEETMAN FORTESCUE HIMSELF, WHEN, APART
FROM KNOWING A GREAT DEAL ABOUT MEDIEVAL WITCH BURNINGS, GAVE HARRY FREE
SUNDAYS EVERY HALF AN HOUR.

HENCE HARRY HAD REFILLED HIS MONEY BAG WITH GOLD COININGS, SILVER
STICKLES, AND KRENNER DOLITS FROM HIS WALLET AT CRINGHITS, HE HAD THE
EXERCISE A LOT OF SELF-CONTROL NOT TO SPEND THE WHOLE LOT AT HENCE. HE
HAD THE DEEP REMINDING HIMSELF THAT HE HAD FIVE YEARS TO GO AT FLECHARTS,
AND FEEL IT WOULD FEEL THE ASK THE DURSLEYS FOR MONEY FOR SPELLBOOKS, THE
STEP HIMSELF FROM BUYING A HANDSOME SET OF SHED GOLD CHRISTENES (A
WIZARDING GAME RATHER LIKE MARBLES, IN WHICH THE STONES SHOOT A
NASTY-SMELLING LIQUID INTO THE OTHER PLAYER'S FACE WHEN THEY WERE A
PHEINT), HE WAS SHRELY TEMPTED, THEN, BY THE PERFECT, MOVING MODEL OF THE
GALAXY IN A LARGE GLASS BALL, WHICH WOULD HAVE MEANT HE NEVER HAD THE

TAKE ANOTHER ASTROLOGICAL LESSON, BUT THE THING THAT TESTED HARRY'S
RESOLUTION MEET APPEARED IN HIS FAVORITE SHOP, QUALITY ELIQUIDITY
SUPPLIES, A WEEK AFTER HE'D ARRIVED AT THE LEADY CALIBREIN.
CLOTHES THE DRESS WHAT THE CREED IN THE SHOP WAS STARRING AT, HARRY RODE
HIS WAY INSIDE AND SHELLED IN AMONG THE EXCITED WITCHES AND WIZARDS
UNTIL HE GLIMPSED A NEWLY ERECTED PEDILUM, HEN WHICH WAS MOUNTED THE MOST
MAGNIFICENT KREEM HE HAD EVER SEEN IN HIS LIFE.

"JUST COME OUT -- PROTOTYPE --" A SELLARE-LAID WIZARD WAS TELLING HIS
COMPANION.

"IT'S THE FASTEST KREEM IN THE WORLD, ISN'T IT, DAD?" SELLAREKED A KED
YELINGER THAN HARRY, WHO WAS SWINGING OFF HIS FATHER'S ARM.

"IRISH INTERNATIONAL SIDE'S JUST PUT IN AN ORDER FOR SEVEN OF THESE

42

REALITIES?" THE PROPRIETOR OF THE SHOP TOLD THE CREED, "AND THEY'RE
FAVORITES FOR THE WORLD CUP?"

A LARGE WITCH IN FRONT OF HARRY MOVED, AND HE WAS ABLE TO READ THE SIGN
NEXT TO THE KREEM:

** THE FIREHILL T **

THIS STATE-OF-THE-ART PACING KREEM SPORTS A STREAM-
LINED,

SLIPPERING

HANDLE OF ASH, TREATED WITH A DIAMOND-HARD POLISH AND
HAND-ALIGNED

WITH ITS OWN REGISTRATION ALPHER, EACH INDIVIDUALLY
SELECTED KIRCH TWIG

IN THE KREEMTAIL HAS BEEN HEARD THE AERODYNAMIC
PERFECTION, GIVING THE

FIREHILL UNSTOPPABLE BALANCE AND PINPOINT PRECISION.

THE FIREHILT HAS
AN ACCELERATION OF 150 MILES AN HOUR IN TEN SECONDS AND
INCORPORATES AN

UNBREAKABLE BRACING CLAMP, PRICE FIVE POUNDS.

PRICE FIVE POUNDS... HARRY DIDN'T LIKE THE THINK HE'LL MUCH CHILD THE
FIREHILT WOULD COST. HE HAD NEVER WANTED ANYTHING AS MUCH IN HIS WHOLE
LIFE -- BUT HE HAD NEVER WENT A BIDDITCH MATCH IN HIS NINE YEARS THE
FIREHILT, AND WHAT WAS THE POINT IN EMPTYING HIS GRINGOTT'S WALLET FOR
THE

FIREHILT, WHEN HE HAD A VERY GOOD KNIFE ALREADY? HARRY DIDN'T ASK FOR
THE PRICE, BUT HE RETURNED, ALMOST EVERY DAY AFTER THAT, JUST THE LOOK AT
THE FIREHILT.

THERE WERE, HOWEVER, THINGS THAT HARRY NEEDED THE KEY. HE WENT THE THE
ADVENTURER TO REPLENISH HIS STORE OF POTION'S INGREDIENTS, AND AS HIS
SCARF NECKS WERE NOW SEVERAL INCHES TOO SHORT IN THE ARM AND LEG, HE
VISITED MADAM MALKIN'S SHOP FOR ALL FANCIES AND BRIGHT NEW HATS. MOST
IMPORTANT OF ALL, HE HAD THE KEY HIS NEW SCARFNECKS, WHICH WOULD INCLUDE
THESE FOR HIS TWO NEW SUBJECTS, CARE OF MAGICAL CREATURES AND
DIVINATION.

HARRY GOT A SURPRISE AS HE LOOKED IN AT THE CHEAPEST-WINE WINE. INSTEAD OF
THE USUAL DISPLAY OF CHILD-EMBEDDED SPELLS THE SIZE OF PAYING SLAS,

HE

THERE WAS A LARGE IRON CAGE BEHIND THE GLASS THAT HELD ABOUT A HUNDRED
COPIES OF THE MINSTER BOOK OF MINSTERS. THIRN PAGES WERE FLYING
EVERYWHERE AS THE BOOKS GRAPPLER WITH EACH OTHER, LOCKED TOGETHER IN
FLIRTLY WRESTLING MATCHES AND SNAPPING AGGRESSIVELY.

HARRY PULLED HIS BOOKLIST OUT OF HIS POCKET AND CONSULTED IT FOR THE
FIRST TIME. THE MINSTER BOOK OF MINSTERS WAS LISTED AS THE REQUIRED BOOK

AFTER CARE OF MAGICAL CREATURES. WHEN HARRY UNDERSTOOD WHY Hagrid had said it would come in useful, he felt relieved; he had been wondering whether Hagrid wanted help with some terrifying new pet.

As Harry entered Flourish and Blets, the manager came hurrying toward him.

"Hedwigs?" he said abruptly. "Have we got your new hedges?"

"Yes," said Harry. "I need --"

"Get out of the way," said the manager impatiently, brushing Harry aside. He drew out a pair of very thick gloves, picked up a large, knobby walking stick, and proceeded toward the door of the Minister Hedges' cage.

"Hang on," said Harry quickly. "I've already got one of these."

"Have you?" A look of enthusiastic relief spread over the manager's face.

"Thank heavens for that. I've been bitten five times already this morning --"

A loud ripping noise rent the air; two of the Minister Hedges had seized a third and were pulling it apart.

"Stop it! Stop it!" cried the manager, poking the walking stick through the bars and knocking the hedges apart. "I'm never sticking them again, never! It's been a blam! I thought we'd seen the worst when we bought two hundred copies of the Invisible Hedge of Invisibility -- that's a headline, and we never found them... Well... is there anything else I can help you with?"

"Yes," said Harry, looking down his checklist. "I need something for the

44

FUTURE BY CASSANDRA VARLATOS."

"Ah, starting divination, are you?" said the manager, stripping off his gloves and leading Harry into the back of the shop, where there was a

CHARNER DEVOTED THE FORTUNE-TELLING. A SMALL TABLE WAS STACKED WITH
VOLUMES SUCH AS PREDICTING THE UNPREDICTABLE: INSULATE YOURSELF AGAINST
STOCKS AND BONDEN KILLS: WHEN FORTUNES TURN FULFILL.

"HERE YOU ARE," SAID THE MANAGER, WHO HAD CLIMBED A SET OF STEPS THE
TABLE BEHIND A THICK, BLACK-REINFORCED SHEET. "UNFOLDING THE FUTURE. VERY GOOD
GLIDE THE ALL YOUR BASIC FORTUNE-TELLING METHODS - PALMISTRY, CRYSTAL
BALLS, KID ENTRAILS.

BUT HARRY WASN'T LISTENING. HIS EYES HAD FALLEN ON ANOTHER SHEET, WHICH
WAS AMONG A DISPLAY ON A SMALL TABLE: DEATH THEMES. WHAT THE DEE WHEN YOU
KNOW THE WORST IS COMING.

"HEY, I WOULDN'T READ THAT IF I WERE YOU," SAID THE MANAGER LIGHTLY,

LOOKING THE SEE WHAT HARRY WAS STARING AT. "YOU'LL START SEEING DEATH
THEMES EVERYWHERE. IT'S ENOUGH TO FRIGHTEN ANYONE THE DEATH."

BUT HARRY CONTINUED THE STARE AT THE FRONT COVER OF THE SHEET. IT SHOWED A
BLACK DEE LARGER AS A BEAR, WITH GLAMING EYES. IT LOOKED HOBBY
FAMILIAR...

THE MANAGER PRESSED UNFOLDING THE FUTURE INTO HARRY'S HANDS.

"ANYTHING ELSE?" HE SAID.

"YES," SAID HARRY, TEARING HIS EYES AWAY FROM THE DEE'S AND DAZEDLY
CONSULTING HIS SHEETLIST. "ER -- I NEED INTERMEDIATE TRANSMUTATION AND
THE STANDARD SHEET OF SPELLS, GRADE THREE."

HARRY EMERGED FROM FLURRY AND BLITTS TEN MINUTES LATER WITH HIS NEW
SHEETS UNDER HIS ARM AND MADE HIS WAY BACK TO THE LEADY CALIBREIN, HARDLY
NOTICING WHERE HE WAS GOING AND CLIMBING INTO SEVERAL PEOPLE.

HE TRAMPED UP THE STAIRS TO HIS ROOM, WENT INSIDE, AND TIPPED HIS SHEETS
BENTH HIS BED. SOMEONE HAD BEEN IN THE TIDY: THE WINDOWLS WERE OPEN AND
SLIN WAS PHEURING INSIDE. HARRY COULD HEAR THE KISSES ROLLING BY IN THE

LINGERING MUGGLE STREET BEHIND HIM AND THE SOUND OF THE INVISIBLE CROWD
BEHIND IN DIAGON ALLEY, HE CAUGHT SIGHT OF HIMSELF IN THE MIRROR OVER THE
BASIN.

"IT CAN'T HAVE BEEN A DEATH EMMER," HE TOLD HIS REFLECTION DEFIANTLY. "I
WAS PANICKING WHEN I SAW THAT THING IN MAGNOLIA CRESCENT... IT WAS
PROBABLY JUST A STRAY DEER..."

HE RAISED HIS HAND AUTOMATICALLY AND TRIED TO MAKE HIS HAIR LIE FLAT
"YOU'RE FIGHTING A LOSING BATTLE THERE, DEAR," SAID HIS MIRROR IN A
WHISPERY VOICE.

AS THE DAYS SLIPPED BY, HARRY STARTED WANDERING WHEREVER HE WENT FOR A
SIGN OF RON AND HERMIONE. PLenty OF HOGWARTS STUDENTS WERE ARRIVING IN
DIAGON ALLEY NOW, WITH THE START OF TERM SEE NEAR. HARRY MET SEamus
FINNIGAN AND DEAN THOMAS, HIS FELLOW CROOKFINDERS, IN FLOOBY FLOOBY
SUPPLIES, WHERE THEY THEN WERE ENJOYING THE FIREWALK; HE ALSO RAN INTO THE
REAL NEVILLE LONGBOTT, A REDD-FACED, FORGETFUL KID, HALF-DEADLY
AND BLEETTS. HARRY DIDN'T STOP TO TALK; NEVILLE APPEARED TO HAVE MISLAID
HIS REMINDER AND WAS BEING TOLD OFF BY HIS VERY IMPRUDABLE-WANDERING
GRANDMOTHER. HARRY HOPED SHE NEVER FOUND OUT THAT HE'D PRETENDED TO BE
NEVILLE WHILE IN THE RUN FROM THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC.

HARRY WALKED ON THE LAST DAY OF THE HOLIDAYS, THINKING THAT HE WOULD AT
LEAST MEET RON AND HERMIONE SOMEWHERE, ON THE HOGWARTS EXPRESS. HE GOT
UP, DRESSED, WENT FOR A LAST WALK AT THE FIREWALK, AND WAS JUST
WANDERING WHERE HE'D HAVE LUNCH, WHEN SOMEONE YELLED HIS NAME AND HE
TURNED.

"HARRY! HARRY!"

THEY WERE THERE, BOTH OF THEM, SITTING HALF-DEADLY ALONGSIDE THE ICE
CREAM PARLOR -- RON WANDERING INCREDIBLY PROUDLY, HERMIONE VERY EAGER,
BOTH LAUGHING FRANTICALLY AT HIM.

"FINALLY!" SAID RHN, GRINNING AT HARRY AS HE SAT DOWN. "WE WENT TO THE
LEADY CALDREIN, BUT THEY SAID YHL'D LEFT, AND WE WENT TO FLEHRISH AND
BLITTS, AND MADAM MALDIN'S, AND --"

998

"I GOT ALL MY STUFF LAST WEEK," HARRY EXPLAINED. "AND THEN WHEN
YHL KNEW I'M STAYING AT THE LEADY CALDREIN?" "DAD," SAID RHN SIMPLY,
MR. WEASLEY, WHEN WORKED AT THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC, WOULD HE CHANCE HAVE
HEARD THE WHOLE STORY OF WHAT HAD HAPPENED TO ALINT MARGE.

"DID YHL REALLY KNEW LIP YHLIN ALINT, HARRY?" SAID HERMIONE IN A VERY
SERIOUS VOICE.

"I DIDN'T MEAN THAT," SAID HARRY, WHILE RHN BEAMED WITH LAUGHTER. "I JUST
-- LEFT CENTRAL."

"IT'S NOT FUNNY, RHN," SAID HERMIONE SHARPLY. "HONESTLY, I'M AMAZED
HARRY WASN'T EXPELLED."

"SEE AM I," ADMITTED HARRY. "PERGET EXPELLED, I THOUGHT I WAS GOING TO BE
ARRESTED." HE LOOKED AT RHN. "YHLIN DAD DOESN'T KNOW WHY FUDGE LET ME
OFF, DOES HE?"

"PROBABLY 'CAUSE IT'S YHL, ISN'T IT?" SHRUGGED RHN, STILL CHUCKLING.

"FARHUS HARRY BETTER AND ALL THAT, I'D HATE TO SEE WHAT THE MINISTRY'D
DO TO ME IF I KNEW LIP AN ALINT. MIND YHL, THEY'D HAVE TO DIE ME LIP FIRST,
BECAUSE MUM WOULD'VE KILLED ME. ANYWAY, YHL CAN ASK DAD YHLRSELF THIS
EVENING. WE'RE STAYING AT THE LEADY CALDREIN TONIGHT THEN? SEE YHL CAN
CHECK THE KING'S CROSS WITH HIS THEFTHEFTS? HERMIONE'S THERE AS WELL?"

HERMIONE NEEDED, BEAMING. "MUM AND DAD DRIPPED ME OFF THIS MORNING WITH
ALL MY HOGWARTS THINGS."

"EXCELLENT!" SAID HARRY HAPPILY. "SEE, HAVE YHL GET ALL YHLIN NEW KNEES
AND STUFF?"

"LOOK AT THIS," SAID RON, PULLING A LONG THIN RIBBON OUT OF A BAG AND OPENING IT. "BRAND-NEW WAND, FORTY-FOUR INCHES, SILVER, CONTAINING FINE LINCOLN TAIL-HAIR, AND WE'VE GOT ALL KINDS OF THINGS --" HE POINTED AT A LARGE BAG UNDER HIS CHAIR. "WHAT ABOUT THESE MONSTER RIBBONS, EH? THE ASSISTANT NEARLY CRIED WHEN WE SAID WE WANTED THEM."

"WHAT'S ALL THAT, HERMION?" HARRY ASKED, POINTING AT THE BAG WITH THREE

49

GLASS BAGS IN THE CHAIR NEXT TO HER.

"WELL, I'M TAKING MORE NEW SUBJECTS THAN YOU, AREN'T I?" SAID HERMION.

"THESE ARE MY RIBBONS FOR ARITHMAGIC, CARE OF MAGICAL CREATURES, DIVINATION, THE STUDY OF ANCIENT RUNES, Muggle STUDIES --"

"WHAT ARE YOU DOING Muggle STUDIES FOR?" SAID RON, ROLLING HIS EYES AT HARRY. "YOU'RE Muggle- BORN! YOUR MOM AND DAD ARE MUGGLES! YOU ALREADY KNOW ALL ABOUT MUGGLES!"

"BUT IT'LL BE FASCINATING THE STUDY THEM FROM THE WIZARDING POINT OF VIEW," SAID HERMION EARNESTLY.

"ARE YOU PLANNING TO EAT HER SLEEP AT ALL THIS YEAR, HERMION?" ASKED HARRY, WHILE RON SNIGGERED. HERMION IGNORED THEM.

"I'VE STILL GOT TEN GALLEONS," SHE SAID, CHECKING HER PURSE. "IT'S MY BIRTHDAY IN SEPTEMBER, AND MOM AND DAD GAVE ME SOME MONEY TO GET MYSELF AN EARLY BIRTHDAY PRESENT."

"YOU'VE GOT A NICE RIBBON?" SAID RON INDIFFERENTLY.

"NO, I DIDN'T THINK SO," SAID HERMION EMPHATICALLY. "I REALLY WANT AN EEL. I MEAN, HARRY'S GOT FRODO AND YOU'VE GOT KROOK --"

"I HAVEN'T," SAID RON. "KROOK'S A FAMILY EEL. ALL I'VE GOT IS SLITHERS."

HE PULLED HIS PET RAT OUT OF HIS POCKET. "AND I WANT TO GET HIM CHECKED OVER," HE ADDED, PLACING SLITHERS ON THE TABLE IN FRONT OF THEM. "I

DIDN'T THINK EGYPT AGREED WITH HIM."

SLARKERS WAS LEEKING THINNER THAN USUAL, AND THERE WAS A DEFINITE DREPP
TH HIS WHISKERS.

"THERE'S A MAGICAL CREATURE ST-HP ILST EVER THERE," SAID F-HARRY, WH-H DKNW
DIAGEN ALLEY VERY WELL BY NHH. "WH-L CHILD SEE IF THEY'VE GHT ANYTHING
FHR SLARKERS, AND F-HERMIONE CAN GET HER HELL."

SEE THEY PAID FHR THEIR ICE CREAM AND CROSSED THE STREET TH THE MAGICAL
MENAGERIE.

48

THERE WASN'T MUCH REHHY INSIDE. EVERY INCH HP WALL WAS HIDDEN BY CAGES.
IT WAS SMELLY AND VERY NHHISY BECAUSE THE HELLIPANTS HP THESE CAGES WERE
ALL SHLEADING, SHLEADING, LAKKERING, HP HISSING. THE WITCH BEHIND THE
CHELINTER WAS ALREADY ADVISING A WIZARD HN THE CARE HP DEHLKE-ENDED NELTS.
SH F-HARRY, REHN, AND F-HERMIONE WAITED, EXAMINING THE CAGES.
A PAIR HP ENHHMHHLS PURPLE THADS SAT GLIMPING WETLY AND FEASTING HN DEAD
BLEHPLIES. A GIGANTIC THHHHISE WITH A IELKE-ENCRUSTED SHELL WAS
GLITTERING NEAR THE WINDHEL. PHHHHHHLS HRRANGE SNAILS WERE HHHZING SLEHLY
UP THE SIDE HP THEIR GLASS TANK, AND A FAT WHITE RAKKIT KEPT CHANGING
INTH A SLD THP FAT AND BACK AGAIN WITH A HELD PHIPPING NHHSE. THEN THERE
WERE CATS HP EVERY CHELHR, A NHHISY CAGE HP RAYENS, A BASKET HP FLINDY
CLSTARD-CHELHRED FLUREALLS THAT WERE FLIMPING HELDLY, AND HN THE CHELINTER, A
VAST CAGE HP SLEK BLACK RATS THAT WERE PLAYING SHRE SHRT HP SKIPPING
GAME LISTING THEIR LEHG, BALD TAILS.

THE DEHLKE-ENDED NELT WIZARD LEFT, AND REHN APPROACHED THE CHELINTER.

"IT'S MY RAT," HE THLD THE WITCH. "F-H BEEN A KIT HPP-CHELHR EVER SINCE I
BRHLGHT HIM BACK FHHY EGYPT."

"KANG HIM HN THE CHELINTER," SAID THE WITCH, PULLING A PAIR HP HEAVY BLACK

SPECTACLES HILT UP HER POCKET.

RENN LIFTED SLACKERS HILT UP HIS INSIDE POCKET AND PLACED HIM NEXT THE THE CAGE OF HIS FELLOW RATS, WHO STOPPED THEIR SKIPPING TRICKS AND CLIPPED THE THE WIRE FOR A BETTER THEE.

LIKE NEARLY EVERYTHING RENN HOUND, SLACKERS THE RAT WAS SECONDHAND HE HAD HENCE RELEASED THE RENN'S BROTHER PERCY! AND A KIT BATTERED. NEXT THE THE GLASSY RATS IN THE CAGE, HE WHISKED ESPECIALLY WHEREVER.

"H-M," SAID THE WITCH, PICKING UP SLACKERS. "THEY HAD IS THIS RAT?"

"BLIND," SAID RENN. "WHITE HAD, HE USED THE BLEND THE MY BROTHER."

"WHAT FEELERS DOES HE HAVE?" SAID THE WITCH, EXAMINING SLACKERS CLOELY.

"ER --" THE TRUTH WAS THAT SLACKERS HAD NEVER SEEN THE FAINTEST TRACE OF INTERESTING FEELERS. THE WITCH'S EYES MOVED FROM SLACKERS'S TATTERED

47

LEFT EAR THE HIS FRONT PAW, WHICH HAD A THE MISSING, AND TITTED WHILDY.

"HE'S BEEN THROUGH THE MILL, THIS ONE," SHE SAID.

"HE WAS LIKE THAT WHEN PERCY GAVE HIM THE ME," SAID RENN DEFENSIVELY.

"AN ORDINARY COMMON GARDEN RAT LIKE THIS CAN'T BE EXPECTED THE LIVE LONGER THAN THREE YEARS OR SE," SAID THE WITCH. "WELL, IF YOU WERE LOOKING FOR SOMETHING A BIT MORE HARD-WEARING, YOU MIGHT LIKE ONE OF THESE --"

SHE INDICATED THE BLACK RATS, WHO PROMPTLY STARTED SKIPPING AGAIN. RENN MUTTERED, "SEMI-HYS."

"WELL, IF YOU DON'T WANT A REPLACEMENT, YOU CAN TRY THIS RAT THEN,"

SAID THE WITCH, REACHING UNDER THE CLOISTER AND BRINGING HILT A SMALL RED BOTTLE.

"HEY," SAID RENN. "THEY MUCH -- HILLY?"

RENN KICKED AS SOMETHING FLICK AND FRANGE CAME SHARING FROM THE THE OF

THE HIGHEST CAGE, LANDED ON HIS HEAD, AND THEN PROPELLED ITSELF,
SPITTING MADLY, AT SLARKERS.

"NEH, CREEECH-S-LANDS, NEH!" CRIED THE WITCH, BUT SLARKERS, SEEN FROM
BEHIND

HER HANDS LIKE A BAR OF SOAP, LANDED SPAY-LEGGED ON THE FLOOR, AND THEN
SLAMPERED OVER THE DOOR.

"SLARKERS?" THEN SCHELTED, RACING OUT OF THE SHOP AFTER HIM; F-HARRY
FOLLOWED.

IT TOOK THEM NEARLY TEN MINUTES TO CATCH SLARKERS, WHO HAD TAKEN REFUGE
UNDER A WASTEPAPER BIN OUTSIDE ELIABETH'S SUPPLIES. THEN STUFFED
THE TREMBLING RAT BACK INTO HIS POCKET AND STRAIGHTENED UP, MASSAGING
HIS HEAD.

"WHAT WAS THAT?"

"IT WAS EITHER A VERY BIG CAT OR ELITE A SMALL TIGER," SAID F-HARRY.

SO

"WHERE'S F-ERMINE?"

"PROBABLY GETTING HER HILL

THEY MADE THEIR WAY BACK UP THE CROOKED STREET TO THE MAGICAL MENAGERIE.

AS THEY REACHED IT, F-ERMINE CAME OUT, BUT SHE WASN'T CARRYING AN HILL.

HER ARMS WERE CLAMPED TIGHTLY AROUND THE ENORMOUS GINGER CAT.

"WELL HELLO THAT MENSTER?" SAID THEN, HIS MOUTH HANGING OPEN.

"HE'S GORGEOUS, ISN'T HE?" SAID F-ERMINE, GAWING.

THAT WAS A MATTER OF OPINION, THOUGHT F-HARRY. THE CAT'S GINGER FLUR WAS
THICK AND FLUFFY, BUT IT WAS DEFINITELY A KIT KILLER AND ITS FACE
LOOKED GRIMPY AND HOPELY SENSITIVE, AS THOUGH IT HAD RUN HEADLONG INTO A
BRICK WALL. NOW THAT SLARKERS WAS OUT OF SIGHT, HOWEVER, THE CAT WAS
PURRING CONTENTEDLY IN F-ERMINE'S ARMS.

"F-ERMINE, THAT THING NEARLY SCALPED ME!" SAID THEN.

"HE DIDN'T MEAN TH, DID YHL, CRHHXST-LANDX?" SAID HERMINE.

"AND WHAT ABELT SLARKERS?" SAID RHN, POINTING AT THE LIMP IN HIS CHEST
POCKET. "HE NEEDS REST AND RELAXATION; YHL'S HE GING TH GET IT WITH
THAT THING ABELND?"

"THAT REMINDS ME, YHL PERCHT YHLR RAT THNL," SAID HERMINE, SLAPPING
THE SMALL RED KETTLE INTO RHN'S HAND. "AND STOP WHIRRYING, CRHHXST-LANDX
WILL BE SLEEPING IN MY BERMITHRY AND SLARKERS IN YHLRS, WHAT'S THE
PROBLEM? PHEER CRHHXST-LANDX, THAT WITCH SAID HE'D BEEN IN THERE FOR AGES;
NEE HNR WANTED HIM."

"WUNDER LE-W," SAID RHN SARCASTICALLY AS THEY SET OFF TOWARD THE LEADY
CALLDREN.

THEY FELND MR. WEASLEY SITTING IN THE BAR, READING THE DAILY PROPHECY.

"HARRY?" HE SAID, SMILING AS HE LOOKED UP. "YHLN ARE YHL?"

"FINE, THANKS," SAID HARRY AS HE, RHN, AND HERMINE JOINED MR. WEASLEY

51

WITH A THEIR STOPPING.

MR. WEASLEY PUT DOWN HIS PAPER, AND HARRY SAW THE NEW FAMILIAR PICTURE
OF SIRILUS BLACK STARING UP AT HIM.

"THEY STILL HAVEN'T CALGT HIM, THEN?" HE ASKED.

"NHR," SAID MR. WEASLEY, LOOKING EXTREMELY GRAVE. "THEY'VE PULLED US ALL
OFF HLIR REGULAR IHES AT THE MINISTRY TH TRY AND FIND HIM, BJT NHR BLACK SE
FAR."

"WOULD WE GET A REWARD IF WE CALGT HIM?" ASKED RHN. "IT'D BE GING TH
GET SOME MORE MUNKY --"

"DHN'T BE RIDICULHLIS, RHN," SAID MR. WEASLEY, WITH HN CLEER INSPECTION
LOOKED VERY STRAINED. "BLACK'S NHT GING TH BE CALGT BY A
THIRTEEN-YEAR-OLD WIZARD. IT'S THE AZERKAN GUARDS WE'LL GET HIM BACK,

"WELL MARK MY WORDS."

AT THAT MOMENT MRS. WEASLEY ENTERED THE BAR, LADEN WITH SHOPPING BAGS AND FOLLOWED BY THE TWINS, FRED AND GEORGE, WHO WERE ABOUT THE START THEIR FIFTH YEAR AT HOGWARTS; THE NEWLY ELECTED HEAD BOY, PERCY; AND THE WEASLEYS' YOUNGEST CHILD AND ONLY GIRL, GINNY.

GINNY, WHO HAD ALWAYS BEEN VERY TAKEN WITH HARRY, SEEMED EVEN MORE HEARTILY EMBARRASSED THAN LILIA WHEN SHE SAW HIM, PERHAPS BECAUSE HE HAD SAVED HER LIFE DURING THEIR PREVIOUS YEAR AT HOGWARTS. SHE WENT VERY RED AND MUTTERED "HELLO" WITHOUT LOOKING AT HIM. PERCY, HOWEVER, HELD OUT HIS HAND SOLEMNNY AS THOUGH HE AND HARRY HAD NEVER MET AND SAID, "HARRY, IT'S SO NICE TO SEE YOU."

"HELLO, PERCY," SAID HARRY, TRYING NOT TO LAUGH.

"I HOPE YOU'RE WELL?" SAID PERCY EMPHATICALLY, SHAKING HANDS. IT WAS RATHER LIKE BEING INTRODUCED TO THE MASTER.

"VERY WELL, THANKS --"

"HARRY?" SAID FRED, ELBOWING PERCY OUT OF THE WAY AND KISSING DEEPLY.

"SIMPLY SPLENDID TO SEE YOU, OLD BOY --"

END

"MARVELOUS," SAID GEORGE, PUSHING FRED ASIDE AND SEIZING HARRY'S HAND IN TURN, "ABSOLUTELY SPINNING."

PERCY SMILED.

"THAT'S ENOUGH, NOW," SAID MRS. WEASLEY.

"MUM?" SAID FRED AS THOUGH HE'D ONLY JUST SPOTTED HER AND SEIZING HER HAND TOO, "IT'S REALLY CHUCKING THE SEE YOU --"

"I SAID, THAT'S ENOUGH," SAID MRS. WEASLEY, DEPOSITING HER SHOPPING IN AN EMPTY CHAIR. "HELLO, HARRY, DEAR, I SUPPOSE YOU'VE HEARD OUR EXCITING NEWS?" SHE POINTED TO THE BRAND-NEW SILVER BADGE ON PERCY'S CHEST.

"SECOND HEAD KID IN THE FAMILY?" SHE SAID, SWELLING WITH PRIDE.

"AND LAST," FRED MUTTERED UNDER HIS BREATH.

"I DON'T DELIGHT IN THAT," SAID MRS. WEASLEY, PREHLING SLIDENLY. "I NOTICE THEY HAVEN'T MADE YELL THE PREFFETS."

"WHAT DO WE WANT THE EE PREFFETS FERY?" SAID GEORGE, LEEHNG REVELTED AT THE VERY IDEA. "IT'D TAKE ALL THE FLIN HELL OF LIFE."

GINDY GIGGLED.

"YEE I WANT THE SET A BETTER EXAMPLE FEE YELLER SISTER!" SNAPPED MRS. WEASLEY.

"GINDY'S GHT EITHER BROTHERS THE SET HER AN EXAMPLE, MEETHER," SAID PERCY LEHTILY. "I'M GHTNG LIP THE CHANGER FEE DINNER..."

HE DISAPPEARED AND GEORGE HEAVED A SIGH.

"WE TRIED THE SHUT HIM IN A PYRAMID," HE THELD F-HARRY. "BUT MUM SPETTED US."

DINNER THAT NIGHT WAS A VERY ENIEHABLE AFFAIR. THEN THE INDOKEEPER PLIT THREE TABLES THEGETHER IN THE PARLER, AND THE SEVEN WEASLEYS, F-HARRY, AND F-ERMINE ATE THEIR WAY THROUGH FIVE DELICIEHLS CHLURSES.

SE

"F-HARRY WE GETTING THE KING'S CRHES THEHRRHLL, DAD?" ASKED FRED AS THEY DLG INTO A SLUMPTLIEHLS CH-HHLLATE PLDDING.

"THE MINISTRY'S PREHYDING A CHLIPLE OF CARS," SAID MR. WEASLEY. EVERYHNE LEEHED LIP AT HIM.

"WHY?" SAID PERCY CLIRIEHLSLY.

"IT'S RECALISE OF YELL, PERCE," SAID GEORGE SERIEHLSLY. "AND THERE'LL BE LITTLE PLACS HEN THE F-HHDS, WITH F-X HEN THEM"

"-- FEE F-LUMPHENGHLS RIGH-HEAD," SAID FRED.

EVERYHNE EXCEPT PERCY AND MRS. WEASLEY INHRTED INTO THEIR PLDDING.

"WHY ARE THE MINISTRY PROVIDING CARS, FATHER?" PERCY ASKED AGAIN, IN A DIGNIFIED VOICE.

"WELL, AS WE HAVEN'T GOTTEN HERE ANYMORE," SAID MR. WEASLEY,

"-- AND AS I WERE THERE, THEY'RE DOING ME A FAVOR --"

HIS VOICE WAS CASUAL, BUT HARRY COULDN'T HELP REMEMBERING THAT MR. WEASLEY'S EARS HAD GONE RED, JUST LIKE RON'S DID WHEN HE WAS UNDER PRESSURE.

"GOOD THING, THEN," SAID MRS. WEASLEY BRISKLY. "OH YOU REALIZE HOW MUCH LUGGAGE YOU'VE ALL GOT BETWEEN YOU? A Nice Night YOU'D BE IN THE MIDDLE UNDERGROUND... YOU ARE ALL PACKED, AREN'T YOU?"

"RON HASN'T PUT ALL HIS NEW THINGS IN HIS TRUNK YET," SAID PERCY, IN A LONG-SUFFERING VOICE. "HE'S DROPPED THEM IN MY BED."

"YOU'D BETTER GO AND PACK PROPERLY, RON, BECAUSE WE WON'T HAVE MUCH TIME IN THE MORNING," MRS. WEASLEY CALLED DOWN THE TABLE. RON SCHEWED AT PERCY.

AFTER DINNER EVERYONE FELT VERY FULL AND SLEEPY. ONE BY ONE THEY MADE

54

THEIR WAY UPSTAIRS TO THEIR ROOMS TO CHECK THEIR THINGS FOR THE NEXT DAY. RON AND PERCY WERE NEXT DOOR TO HARRY. HE HAD JUST CLOSED AND LOCKED HIS OWN TRUNK WHEN HE HEARD ANGRY VOICES THROUGH THE WALL, AND WENT TO SEE WHAT WAS GOING ON.

THE DOOR OF NUMBER TWELVE WAS ALARM AND PERCY WAS SPEAKING.

"IT WAS HERE, IN THE BEDSIDE TABLE, I THINK IT WAS FOR PUBLISHING

"I HAVEN'T CHECKED IT, ALL RIGHT?" RON REARED BACK.

"WHAT'S UP?" SAID HARRY.

"MY HEAD KEY RING IS GONE," SAID PERCY, RELOADING HIS HARRY.

"HE'S SLACKER'S RAT THINK," SAID RON, THROWING THINGS OUT OF HIS TRUNK

THE LINDS. "I THINK I MIGHT'VE LEFT IT IN THE CAR --"

"YOU'RE NOT GOING ANYWHERE TILL YOU'VE FOUND MY BADGE!" YELLED PERCY,

"I'LL GET SLACKERS'S STUFF, I'M PACKED," HARRY SAID THEN, AND HE WENT DOWNSTAIRS.

HARRY WAS HALFWAY ALONG THE PASSAGE TO THE CAR, WHICH WAS NOW VERY DARK, WHEN HE HEARD ANOTHER PAIR OF ANGRY VOICES COMING FROM THE PARLOR. A SECOND LATER, HE RECOGNIZED THEM AS MR. AND MRS.

WEASLEYS'. HE HESITATED, NOT WANTING THEM TO KNOW HE'D HEARD THEM ARGUING, WHEN THEY HEARD OF HIS OWN NAME MADE HIM STOP, THEN MOVE CLOSER TO THE PARLOR DOOR.

"--MAKES NO SENSE NOT TO TELL HIM," MR. WEASLEY WAS SAYING HEATEDLY.

"HARRY'S GOT A RIGHT TO KNOW, I'VE TRIED TO TELL FUDGE, BUT HE INSISTS ON TREATING HARRY LIKE A CHILD, HE'S THIRTEEN YEARS OLD AND --"

"ARTHEUR, THE TRUTH WOULD TERRIFY HIM!" SAID MRS. WEASLEY SHRILLY. "DO YOU REALLY WANT TO SEND HARRY BACK TO SCHOOL WITH THAT HANGING OVER HIM?"

"FOR HEAVEN'S SAKE, HE'S HAPPY NOT KNOWING!"

"I DON'T WANT TO MAKE HIM MISERABLE, I WANT TO PUT HIM ON HIS GUARD!"

SS

RETHINKED MR. WEASLEY. "YOU KNOW WHAT HARRY AND RON ARE LIKE, WANDERING OFF BY THEMSELVES -- THEY'VE ENDED UP IN THE FORBIDDEN FOREST TWICE! BUT HARRY MUSTN'T DO THAT THIS YEAR! WHEN I THINK WHAT COULD HAVE HAPPENED TO HIM THAT NIGHT HE RAN AWAY FROM HOME! IF THE KNIGHT BUS HADN'T PICKED HIM UP, I'M PREPARED TO BET HE WOULD HAVE BEEN DEAD BEFORE THE MINISTRY FOUND HIM."

"BUT HE'S NOT DEAD, HE'S FINE, SEE WHAT'S THE POINT

"GIBBY, THEY SAY SIRIUS BLACK'S MAD, AND MAYBE HE IS, BUT HE WAS CLEVER ENOUGH TO ESCAPE FROM AZKABAN, AND THAT'S SUPPOSED TO BE IMPOSSIBLE.

IT'S BEEN THREE WEEKS, AND NEH HEN'S SEEN HIDE NEH HAIR OF HIM, AND I
DIDN'T CARE WHAT FLUDGE DEEPS TELLING THE DAILY PROPHET, WE'RE NEH NEARER
CATCHING BLACK THAN INVENTING SELF-PELLING WANDS. THE ONLY THING WE
KNOW FOR SURE IS WHAT BLACK'S AFTER

"BUT HARRY WILL BE PERFECTLY SAFE AT HOGWARTS."

"WE THOUGHT AZKABAN WAS PERFECTLY SAFE. IF BLACK CAN BREAK OUT OF
AZKABAN, HE CAN BREAK INTO HOGWARTS."

"BUT NEH HEN'S REALLY SURE THAT BLACK'S AFTER HARRY

THERE WAS A THIRD MEN WHO, AND HARRY WAS SURE MR. WEASLEY HAD KNOCKED HIS
FIST INTO THE TABLE.

"WELL, HOW MANY TIMES DO I HAVE TO TELL YOU? THEY DIDN'T REPENT IT IN
THE PRESS BECAUSE FLUDGE WANTED IT KEPT QUIET, BUT FLUDGE WENT OUT THE
AZKABAN THE NIGHT BLACK ESCAPED. THE GUARDS TOLD FLUDGE THAT BLACKS BEEN
TALKING IN HIS SLEEP FOR A WHILE NOW, ALWAYS THE SAME WORDS: 'HE'S AT
HOGWARTS... HE'S AT HOGWARTS.' BLACK IS DERANGED, MURDERER, AND HE WANTS
HARRY DEAD. IF YOU ASK ME, HE THINKS MURDERING HARRY WILL BRING
YOU-KNOW-WHO BACK TO THE WORLD. BLACK LOST EVERYTHING THE NIGHT HARRY
STOPPED YOU-KNOW-WHO, AND HE'S HAD TWELVE YEARS ALONE IN AZKABAN THE
KNOWS HE THAT..."

THERE WAS A SILENCE. HARRY LEANED STILL CLOSER TO THE MEN, DESPERATE TO
HEAR MORE.

"WELL, ARTHUR, YOU MUST DO WHAT YOU THINK IS RIGHT, BUT YOU'RE

OK

FORGETTING ALBUS DUMBLEDORE. I DIDN'T THINK ANYTHING COULD HURT HARRY AT
HOGWARTS WHILE DUMBLEDORE'S HEADMASTER. I SUPPOSE HE KNOWS ABOUT ALL
THIS?"

"HE THINKS HE KNOWS, WE HAD TO ASK HIM IF HE MINDS THE AZKABAN GUARDS

STATING THEMSELVES AROUND THE ENTRANCES TO THE SCHOOL GROUNDS. HE WASN'T HAPPY ABOUT IT, BUT HE AGREED."

"NOT HAPPY? WHY SHOULDN'T HE BE HAPPY, IF THEY'RE THERE TO CATCH BLACK?"

"DUMBLEDORE ISN'T FOND OF THE AZKABAN GUARDS," SAID MR. WEASLEY HEAVILY.

"BUT AM I, IF IT COMES TO THAT... BUT WHEN YOU'RE DEALING WITH A WIZARD LIKE BLACK, YOU SOMETIMES HAVE TO USE FORCE WITH THESE YOU'D RATHER AVOID."

"IF THEY SAVE HARRY THEN I WILL NEVER SAY ANOTHER WORD AGAINST THEM," SAID MR. WEASLEY WEARILY. "IT'S LATE, MUM, WE'D BETTER GO UP..."

HARRY HEARD CHAIRS MOVE. AS QUIETLY AS HE COULD, HE FLIPPED DOWN THE PASSAGE TO THE BAR AND HUNG UP SILENTLY. THE PARLOR DOOR OPENED, AND A FEW SECONDS LATER FOOTSTEPS TOLD HIM THAT MR. AND MRS. WEASLEY WERE CLIMBING THE STAIRS.

THE KITTEN OF RAT TRICK WAS LYING UNDER THE TABLE THEY HAD SAT AT EARLIER. HARRY WAITED UNTIL HE HEARD MR. AND MRS. WEASLEY'S BEDROOM DOOR CLOSE, THEN HEADED BACK UPSTAIRS WITH THE KITTEN.

FRED AND GEORGE WERE CROUCHING IN THE SHADOWS IN THE LANDING, HEAVING WITH LAUGHTER AS THEY LISTENED TO PERCY DISMANTLING HIS AND RON'S ROOM IN SEARCH OF HIS BADGE.

"WE'VE GOT IT," FRED WHISPERED TO HARRY, "WE'VE BEEN IMPROVING IT."

THE BADGE NOW READ RIGHARD RHY.

HARRY FORCED A LAUGH, WENT TO GIVE RON THE RAT TRICK, THEN SLIT HIMSELF IN HIS ROOM AND LAY DOWN IN HIS BED.

SEE SIRIUS BLACK WAS AFTER HIM. THIS EXPLAINED EVERYTHING. FUDGE HAD BEEN LENIENT WITH HIM BECAUSE HE WAS SEE BELIEVED TO FIND HIM ALIVE. HE'D MADE

59

HARRY PROMISE TO STAY IN DIAGON ALLEY WHERE THERE WERE PLENTY OF WIZARDS

THE DEEP AN EYE ON HIM, AND HE WAS SENDING THE MINISTRY CARS TO TAKE THEM ALL TO THE STATION THEREAFTER, SO THAT THE LEASLEY CHILD WOULD AFTER HARRY UNTIL HE WAS ON THE TRAIN.

HARRY WAS LISTENING TO THE Muffled Sneaking Next Door AND WONDERED WHY HE DIDN'T FEEL MORE SCARED. SIRILS BLACK HAD MURDERED THIRTEEN PEOPLE WITH ONE CLASH; MR. AND MRS. LEASLEY HEAVILYLY THOUGHT HARRY WOULD BE PANIC-STRICKEN IF HE KNEW THE TRUTH, BUT HARRY HADN'T THE AGREE UNHEARTEDLY WITH MRS. LEASLEY THAT THE SAFEST PLACE ON EARTH WAS WHEREVER SIRILS BLACKED HADN'T HAPPENED TO BE. DIDN'T PEOPLE ALWAYS SAY THAT BLACKED WAS THE ONLY PERSON WHO VANDERBILT HAD EVER BEEN AFRAID OF? SIRILS BLACK, AS VANDERBILT'S RIGHT-HAND MAN, WOULD BE JUST AS FRIGHTENED BY HIM.

AND THEN THERE WERE THESE AZERAN GUARDS EVERYONE KEPT TALKING ABOUT. THEY SEEMED TO SCARE MOST PEOPLE SENSELESS, AND IF THEY WERE STATIONED ALL AROUND THE SCHEME, BLACK'S CHANCES OF GETTING INSIDE SEEMED VERY REMOTE.

NEH, ALL IN ALL, THE THING THAT BOTHERED HARRY MOST WAS THE FACT THAT HIS CHANCES OF VISITING THE STRAPE NOW WOULD BE LIKE ZERO. NOBODY WOULD WANT HARRY TO LEAVE THE SAFETY OF THE CASTLE UNTIL BLACK WAS CALLED; IN FACT, HARRY SUSPECTED HIS EVERY MOVE WOULD BE CAREFULLY WATCHED UNTIL THE DANGER HAD PASSED.

HE STARED AT THE DARK CEILING. DID THEY THINK HE COULDN'T WATCH AFTER HIMSELF? HE'D ESCAPED LORD VANDERBILT THREE TIMES; HE WASN'T COMPLETELY USELESS...

UNWITTINGLY, THE IMAGE OF THE BEAST IN THE SHADOWS OF MAGNOLIA CRESCENT CROSSED HIS MIND. WHAT THE DEE WHEN YOU KNOW THE BEAST IS COMING...

"I'M NOT GOING TO BE MURDERED," HARRY SAID OUT LOUD.

"THAT'S THE SPIRIT, DEAR," SAID HIS MIRROR SLEEPILY.

CHAPTER FIVE

THE DEMENTOR

XX

THEY WERE HARRY THE NEXT MORNING WITH HIS USUAL TEETHLESS GRIN AND A CLIP

OF TEA. HARRY GET DRESSED AND WAS JUST PERSUADING A DISORIENTED FREDNIG
THE GET BACK INTO HER CAGE WHEN RON RANGED HIS WAY INTO THE ROOM, PULLING
A SWEATSHIRT OVER HIS HEAD AND LOOKING IRRITABLE.

"THE SHORER WE GET WHEN THE TRAIN, THE BETTER," HE SAID, "AT LEAST I CAN
GET AWAY FROM PERCY AT HOGWARTS, WHEN HE'S ACCUSING ME OF DRIPPING TEA WHEN
HIS FATHER OF PENELOPE CLEARWATER, SHELL DENY," RON GRIMACED, "HIS
GIRLFRIEND, SHE'S HIDDEN HER FACE UNDER THE FRAME BECAUSE HER NOSE HAS
GONE ALL BENTLEY..."

"I'VE GOT SOMETHING TO TELL YOU," HARRY BEGAN, BUT THEY WERE INTERRUPTED
BY FRED AND GEORGE, WHO HAD WALKED IN TO CONGRATULATE RON WHEN INSULTING
PERCY AGAIN.

THEY HEADED DOWN THE BREAKFAST, WHERE MR. WEASLEY WAS READING THE FRONT
PAGE OF THE DAILY PROPHET WITH A FURROWED BROW AND MRS. WEASLEY WAS
TELLING HERMIONE AND GINNY ABOUT A LOVE LETTER SHE'D MADE AS A YOUNG
GIRL. ALL THREE OF THEM WERE RATHER GIGGLY.

"WHAT WERE YOU SAYING?" RON ASKED HARRY AS THEY SAT DOWN.

"LATER," HARRY MUTTERED AS PERCY STORMED IN.

HARRY HAD NO CHANCE TO SPEAK TO RON OR HERMIONE IN THE CHAIRS OF
LEAVING.

THEY WERE THEN BUSY HEAVING ALL THEIR TRUNKS DOWN THE LEADY CALIBREIN'S
NARROW STAIRCASE AND PILING THEM UP NEAR THE DOOR, WITH FREDNIG AND
HERMES, PERCY'S STRECHER, PERCHED ON TOP IN THEIR CAGES, A SMALL
WICKERWHEEL BASKET STOOD BESIDE THE HEAD OF TRUNKS, SPITTING LOUDLY.

"IT'S ALL RIGHT, CRIBSTANDS," HERMIONE CHIED THROUGH THE WICKERWHEEL.

"I'll let you hit him the train."

"You won't," snapped Ron, "What about Peter Skarrers, eh?"

He pointed at his chest, where a large lump indicated that Skarrers was curled up in his pocket.

Mr. Weasley, who had been outside waiting for the Ministry cars, stuck

59

his head inside.

"They're here, he said, "Harry, come on."

Mr. Weasley marched Harry across the short stretch of pavement toward the first of two old-fashioned dark green cars, each of which was driven by a flirtive-looking lizard wearing a slit of emerald velvet.

"In you get, Harry," said Mr. Weasley, glancing up and down the crowded street.

Harry got into the back of the car and was shortly joined by Hermione, Ron, and the Ron's dog, Percy.

The journey the King's Cross was very uneventful compared with Harry's trip in the Knight Bus. The Ministry of Magic cars seemed almost ordinary, though Harry noticed that they could slide through gaps that Uncle Vernon's new company car certainly couldn't have managed. They reached King's Cross with twenty minutes to spare; the Ministry drivers pulled them through, unhitched their trunks, tilted their hats in salute to Mr. Weasley, and drove away, leaving him managing the lump in the head of an impatient line at the traffic lights.

Mr. Weasley kept close to Harry's elbow all the way into the station.

"Right then," he said, glancing around them. "Let's do this in pairs, as there are so many of us. I'll go through first with Harry."

Mr. Weasley strode toward the barrier between platforms nine and ten,

PUSHING HARRY'S TRILLY AND APPARENTLY VERY INTERESTED IN THE INTERCITY
12S THAT HAD JUST ARRIVED AT PLATFORM NINE. WITH A MEANINGFUL LOOK AT
HARRY, HE LEANED CASUALLY AGAINST THE BARRIER. HARRY IMITATED HIM.
IN A MOMENT, THEY HAD FALLEN SIDEWAYS THROUGH THE SHED METAL BETWEEN
PLATFORM NINE AND THREE- QUARTERS AND LOOKED UP TO SEE THE HOGWARTS
EXPRESS, A SCARLET STEAM ENGINE, PLOPPING SMOKE OVER A PLATFORM PACKED
WITH WITCHES AND WIZARDS SEEING THEIR CHILDREN BETWEEN THE TRAIN.
PERCY AND GINNY SUDDENLY APPEARED BEHIND HARRY. THEY WERE PANTING AND
HAD APPARENTLY TAKEN THE BARRIER AT A RUN.

END

"AH, THERE'S PENELOPE!" SAID PERCY, SMEEHING HIS HAIR AND CHEEK PINK
AGAIN. GINNY CALIGHT HARRY'S EYE, AND THEY BOTH TURNED AWAY TO HIDE THEIR
BLIGHTER AS PERCY STRODE OVER TO A GIRL WITH LONG, CURLY HAIR, WALKING
WITH HIS CHEST THROUHN HLT SEE THAT SHE CHLDN'T MISS HIS SHINY BADGE.
STOOD BACK TO LET HIM GO. THEY LEANED HLT UP THE WINDHLL AND WAVED AT MR.
AND MRS. WEASLEY UNTIL THE TRAIN TURNED A CORNER AND BLEEKED THEM FROM
VIEW.

"I NEED TO TALK TO YOU IN PRIVATE," HARRY MUTTERED TO RON AND HERMIONE
AS THE TRAIN PICKED UP SPEED.

"GO AWAY, GINNY," SAID RON.

"HEH, THAT'S NICE," SAID GINNY FLIPPILY, AND SHE STALKED OFF.

HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONE SET OFF DOWN THE CORRIDOR, LEEDING FOR AN EMPTY
COMPARTMENT, BUT ALL WERE FULL EXCEPT FOR THE ONE AT THE VERY END OF THE
TRAIN.

THIS WAS ONLY ONE OCCUPANT, A MAN SITTING FAST ASLEEP NEXT TO THE
WINDHLL. HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONE CHECKED HIM THE THRESHOLD. THE
HOGWARTS

EXPRESS WAS USUALLY RESERVED FOR STUDENTS AND THEY HAD NEVER SEEN AN

ABOUT THERE BEHIND, EXCEPT FOR THE WITCH WHO PUSHED THE FOOD CART.

THE STRANGER WAS WEARING AN EXTREMELY STARKY SET OF WIZARD'S ROBES THAT HAD BEEN DARNED IN SEVERAL PLACES, HE LOOKED ILL AND EXHAUSTED. THOUGH ELITE YOUNG, HIS LIGHT GREEN HAIR WAS FLECKED WITH GRAY.

"WHAT DO YOU RECKON HE IS?" RHN HISSED AS THEY SAT DOWN AND SLID THE OTHER SEAT, TAKING THE SEATS FARTHEST AWAY FROM THE WINDOWS.

"PROFESSOR R. I. SLIPIN," HE WHISPERED FERMINE AT RHN.

"HOW DO YOU KNOW THAT?"

"IT'S ON HIS CASE," SHE REPLIED, POINTING AT THE LUGGAGE RACK OVER THE MAN'S HEAD, WHERE THERE WAS A SMALL, BATTERED CASE HELD TOGETHER WITH A LARGE FLAUNTITY OF NEATLY KNOTTED STRING. THE NAME PROFESSOR R. I. SLIPIN WAS STAMPED ACROSS ONE CORNER IN PEELING LETTERS.

R1

"WONDER WHAT HE TEACHES?" SAID RHN, FREELING AT PROFESSOR SLIPIN'S PALLID PROFILE.

"THAT'S HEAVILY," HE WHISPERED FERMINE. "THERE'S ONLY ONE VACANCY, ISN'T THERE? DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS."

HARRY, RHN, AND FERMINE HAD ALREADY HAD TWO DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS TEACHERS, BOTH OF WHICH HAD LASTED ONLY ONE YEAR. THERE WERE RUMORS THAT THE ONE WAS INKED.

"WELL, I HOPE HE'S UP TO IT," SAID RHN DELECTABLY. "HE LOOKS LIKE HE, GOOD HEK WOULD FINISH HIM OFF, DOESN'T HE? ANYWAY..." HE TURNED THE HARRY. "WHAT WERE YOU GOING TO TELL US?"

HARRY EXPLAINED ALL ABOUT MR. AND MRS. WEASLEY'S ARGUMENT AND THE WARNING MR. WEASLEY HAD JUST GIVEN HIM. WHEN HE'D FINISHED, RHN LOOKED THUNDERSTRUCK, AND FERMINE HAD HER HANDS OVER HER MOUTH. SHE FINALLY WHISPERED THEM THE SAY, "SIRILUS BLACK ESCAPED THE CEMETERY AFTER YOU LEFT."

"HARRY... YOU'LL HAVE TO BE REALLY, REALLY CAREFUL, DON'T GO WANDERING AROUND THERE, HARRY --"

"I DON'T GO WANDERING AROUND THERE," SAID HARRY, NETTLED. "THERE'S USUALLY SOMEONE THERE."

"HOW THICK WOULD HARRY HAVE TO BE, TO GO WANDERING AROUND A PLACE WHERE THEY WANT TO KILL HIM?" SAID RON STARKLY.

THEY WERE TAKING THE NEWS WHERE THAN HARRY HAD EXPECTED. BOTH RON AND HERMIONIE SEEMED TO BE MUCH MORE FRIGHTENED BY BLACK THAN HE WAS.

"OH ONE KNOWS HOW HE GOT OUT OF AZKABAN," SAID RON UNCOMFORTABLY. "OH ONE'S EVER BEEN IT BEFORE, AND HE WAS A TOP-SECURITY PRISONER THEN."

"BUT THEY'LL CATCH HIM, WON'T THEY?" SAID HERMIONIE EARNESTLY. "I MEAN, THEY'VE GOT ALL THE MUGGLES WANDERING OUT FOR HIM THEN..." "WHAT'S THAT MEANS?" SAID RON SLIDDERLY.

A FAINT, TINNY SOUND OF WHISTLE WAS COMING FROM SOMEWHERE. THE WHISTLE WAS ALL AROUND THE COMPARTMENT.

HP

"IT'S COMING FROM YOUR TROUSER, HARRY," SAID RON, STANDING UP AND REACHING INTO THE LUGGAGE RACK. A MOMENT LATER HE HAD PULLED THE POCKET SNEAKERSHOP OUT FROM BETWEEN HARRY'S KNEES. IT WAS SPINNING VERY FAST IN THE PALM OF RON'S HAND AND GLOWING BRILLIANTLY.

"IS THAT A SNEAKERSHOP?" SAID HERMIONIE INTERESTEDLY, STANDING UP FOR A BETTER LOOK.

"YES... MIND YOU, IT'S A VERY CHEAP ONE," RON SAID. "IT WENT AWAY FIRST AS I WAS TRYING IT THE KROOK'S LEG THEN SEND IT TO HARRY."

"WERE YOU DOING ANYTHING UNUSUAL AT THE TIME?" SAID HERMIONIE STARKLY.

"OH! WELL... I WASN'T SUPPOSED TO BE LISTENING KROOK. YOU KNOW HE'S NOT

REALLY UP THE LONG HALLWAYS... BUT WHEN ELSE WAS I SUPPOSED TO GET HARRY'S
PRESENT TO HIM?"

"STICK IT BACK IN THE TRUNK," HARRY ADVISED AS THE SNARLSCHNORR WHISTLED
PIERCINGLY, "OR IT'LL MAKE HIM UP."

HE NODDED TOWARD PROFESSOR KLIPIN, THEN STUFFED THE SNARLSCHNORR INTO A
PARTICULARLY HORRIBLE PAIR OF LITTLE VERNON'S OLD SHOES, WHICH DEADENED
THE SOUND, THEN CLOSED THE LID OF THE TRUNK ON IT.

"WE COULD GET IT CHECKED IN HOGSMOODE," SAID RON, SITTING BACK DOWN.

"THEY SELL THAT SORT OF THING IN DORVISH AND KANGLES, MAGICAL INSTRUMENTS
AND STUFF, FRED AND GEORGE TOLD ME."

"DO YOU KNOW MUCH ABOUT HOGSMOODE?" ASKED HERMIONIE DEEPLY, "I'VE READ
IT'S THE ONLY ENTIRELY NON-MAGICAL SETTLEMENT IN BRITAIN --"

"YEAH, I THINK IT IS," SAID RON IN AN EFFIANCÉ SORT OF WAY.

"BUT THAT'S NOT WHY I WANT TO GO, I JUST WANT TO GET INSIDE HOGGY
DOGGES."

"WHAT'S THAT?" SAID HERMIONIE.

KK

"IT'S THIS SWEETSHOP," SAID RON, A DREAMY SMILE CRAWLING OVER HIS FACE.

"WHERE THEY'VE GOT EVERYTHING... PEPPER IMPS -- THEY MAKE YOU SMELL AT
THE MOUTH -- AND GREAT FAT CHOCOLATES FULL OF STRAWBERRY MILKSHAKE AND
WHIPPED CREAM, AND REALLY EXCELLENT SUGAR BILLS, WHICH YOU CAN SUCK IN
CLASS AND JUST SMELL LIKE YOU'RE THINKING WHAT TO WRITE NEXT --"

"BUT HOGSMOODE'S A VERY INTERESTING PLACE, ISN'T IT?" HERMIONIE PRESSED
HIM EAGERLY. "IN SITES OF HISTORICAL SORCERY IT SAYS THE INN WAS THE
HEADQUARTERS FOR THE 1812 GELFIN REBELLION, AND THE SHRIeking SHADES
SUPPOSED TO BE THE MOST SEVERELY HAUNTED BUILDING IN BRITAIN --"

"-- AND MASSIVE SORCERER KILLS THAT MADE YOU LEVITATE A FEW INCHES OFF

THE GRUELING WHILE YOU'RE SLICKING THEM," SAID RENN, WHO WAS PLAINLY NOT LISTENING TO A WORD FERMINE WAS SAYING.

FERMINE LOOKED AROUND AT HARRY.

"WOEN'T IT BE NICE TO GET OUT OF SCHOOL FOR A BIT AND EXPLORE THE SMOKE?"

"SPEAK IT WILL," SAID HARRY HEAVILY. "YOU'LL HAVE TO TELL ME WHEN YOU'VE FOUND OUT."

"WHAT D'YOU MEAN?" SAID RENN.

"I CAN'T GO. THE DURSLEYS DIDN'T SIGN MY PERMISSION FORM, AND FLICKER WOULDN'T EITHER."

RENN LOOKED FURIOUS.

"YOU'RE NOT ALLOWED TO LEAVE? BUT -- NO WAY -- MCGONAGALL HER SHEPHERD WILL GIVE YOU PERMISSION -- " MURDER! CRABBE WAS TALLER, WITH A PLUMPING-BROWN HAIRCUT AND A VERY THICK NECK; GRAYLE HAD SHORT, CRISTLY HAIR AND LONG, GORILLA-LIKE ARMS.

"WELL, WHEN WE'VE IT IS," SAID MALFOY IN HIS USUAL LAZY DRAWL, PULLING OPEN THE COMPARTMENT DOOR. "PETTY AND THE WEASEL."

CRABBE AND GRAYLE CHUCKLED TREMBLINGLY.

"I HEARD YOUR FATHER FINALLY GOT HIS HANDS ON SOME GOOD THIS SUMMER,

24

WEASEL," SAID MALFOY. "DID YOUR MOTHER DIE OF STROKE?"

RENN STOOD UP SHE QUICKLY HE DOWNED CRABBE'S KIDNEY'S KIDNEY THE THE FLOOR. PROFESSOR SLIPIN GAVE A SMILE.

"WE'VE THAT?" SAID MALFOY, TAKING AN ALTERNATE STEP BACKWARD AS HE SPOTTED SLIPIN.

"NEW TEACHER," SAID HARRY, WHO GOT THE HIS FEET, THEN, IN CASE HE NEEDED THE FLOOR RENN BACK. "WHAT WERE YOU SAYING, MALFOY?"

MALFOY'S PALE EYES NARROWED; HE WASN'T FEEL ENOUGH THE PICK A FIGHT RIGHT

UNDER A TEACHER'S NESE.

"UMHN," HE MUTTERED RESENTFULLY THE CRACKS AND CHIRLS, AND THEY
DISAPPEARED.

HARRY AND RHN SAT DOWN AGAIN, RHN MASSAGING HIS KNEECAPS.

"I'M NOT GOING TO TAKE ANY CRAP FROM MALTHEY THIS YEAR," HE SAID ANGERILY.

"I MEAN IT. IF HE MAKES ONE MORE CRACK ABOUT MY FAMILY, I'M GOING TO GET
HOLD OF HIS HEAD AND --"

RHN MADE A VIOLENT GESTURE IN MIDAIR.

"RHN," HISSED HERMINE, POINTING AT PROFESSOR KLIPIN, "BE CAREFUL..."

BUT PROFESSOR KLIPIN WAS STILL FAST ASLEEP.

THE RAIN THICKENED AS THE TRAIN SPED YET FARTHER NORTH; THE WINDOWS WERE
NOW A SHED, SHIMMERING GRAY, WHICH GRADUALLY DARKENED UNTIL LANTERNS
FLICKERED INTO LIFE ALL ALONG THE CORRIDORS AND OVER THE LUGGAGE RACKS.

THE TRAIN RATTLED, THE RAIN HAMMERED, THE IND REARED, BUT STILL,
PROFESSOR KLIPIN SLEPT.

"WE MUST BE NEARLY THERE," SAID RHN, LEANING FORWARD THE LITTLE PAST
PROFESSOR KLIPIN AT THE NOW COMPLETELY BLACK WINDOWS.

THE WORDS HAD HARDLY LEFT HIM WHEN THE TRAIN STARTED TO SHED DOWN.

RS

"GREAT," SAID RHN, GETTING UP AND WALKING CAREFULLY PAST PROFESSOR KLIPIN
THE TRY AND SEE HILLSIDE. "I'M STARVING. I WANT TO GET THE THE FEAST..."

"WE CAN'T BE THERE YET," SAID HERMINE, CHECKING HER WATCH.

"SEE WHY'RE WE STOPPING?"

THE TRAIN WAS GETTING SLOWER AND SLOWER. AS THE NOISE OF THE PISTONS
FELL AWAY, THE WIND AND RAIN SWIRLED WILDER THAN EVER AGAINST THE
WINDOWS.

HARRY, WHO WAS NEAREST THE ENGINE, GOT UP THE LITTLE INTO THE CORRIDOR. ALL

ALONG THE CARRIAGE, HEADS WERE STICKING CURIOUSLY OUT OF THEIR COMPARTMENTS.

THE TRAIN CAME TO A STOP WITH A JOLT, AND DISTANT THUDS AND RANGES TOLD THEM THAT LUGGAGE HAD FALLEN OUT OF THE RACKS. THEN, WITHOUT WARNING, ALL THE LAMPS WENT OUT AND THEY WERE PLUNGED INTO TOTAL DARKNESS.

"WHAT'S GOING ON?" SAID RON'S VOICE FROM BEHIND HARRY.

"HUSH!" GASPED HERMIONE. "RON, THAT WAS MY SEAT!"

HARRY FELT HIS WAY BACK TO HIS SEAT.

"D'YOU THINK WE'VE BROKEN DOWN?"

"BLIND..."

THERE WAS A SHELTERING SHELTER, AND HARRY SAW THE DIM BLACK OUTLINE OF RON, WIPING A PATCH CLEAN ON THE WINDOW AND PEERING OUT.

"THERE'S SOMETHING MOVING OUT THERE," RON SAID. "I THINK PEOPLE ARE COMING AHEAD..."

THE COMPARTMENT DOOR SLIDENLY OPENED AND SOMETHING FELL PAINFULLY OVER HARRY'S LEGS.

"SHHH -- D'YOU KNOW WHAT'S GOING ON? -- HUSH -- SHHH"

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"LITTLE NEVILLE," SAID HARRY, FEELING AROUND IN THE DARK AND PULLING NEVILLE UP BY HIS CLOAK.

"HARRY? IS THAT YOU? WHAT'S HAPPENING?"

"NO IDEA -- SIT DOWN --"

THERE WAS A MILD HISsing AND A YELP OF PAIN; NEVILLE HAD TRIED TO SIT ON HERMIONe'S KNEES.

"I'M GOING TO GO AND ASK THE DRIVER WHAT'S GOING ON," CAME HERMIONe'S VOICE. HARRY FELT HER PASS HIM, HEARD THE DOOR SLIDE OPEN AGAIN, AND THEN A THUD AND THEN MILD SHELTERS OF PAIN.

"WHAT'S THAT?"

"WHAT'S THAT?"

"GINNY?"

"HERMION?"

"WHAT ARE YOU DOING?"

"I WAS WAITING FOR YOU --" "COME IN AND SIT DOWN --"

"NOT HERE!" SAID HARRY FLURRIEDLY, "I'M HERE!"

"HELLO?" SAID NEVILLE.

"HELLO?" SAID A FEARFUL VOICE SUDDENLY.

PROFESSOR KLIPIN APPEARED TO HAVE WOKEN UP AT LAST, HARRY COULD HEAR
MOVEMENTS IN HIS CHAIR.

NONE OF THEM SPOKE.

THERE WAS A SILENT, CRACKLING NOISE, AND A SHIVERING LIGHT FILLED THE
COMPARTMENT. PROFESSOR KLIPIN APPEARED TO BE HOLDING A BUNDLE OF FLAMES.
THEY ILLUMINATED HIS TIRED, GRAY FACE, BUT HIS EYES WERE ALERT AND

BY

WARY.

"STAY WHERE YOU ARE," HE SAID IN THE SAME FEARFUL VOICE, AND HE GOT
SUDDENLY TO HIS FEET WITH HIS BUNDLE OF FIRE HELD OUT IN FRONT OF HIM.

BUT THE DOOR SLID SUDDENLY OPEN BEFORE KLIPIN COULD REACH IT.

STANDING IN THE DARKNESS, ILLUMINATED BY THE SHIVERING FLAMES IN KLIPIN'S
HAND, WAS A CREATURE THAT THROUDED THE CEILING. ITS FACE WAS
COMPLETELY HIDDEN BENEATH ITS HAIR, HARRY'S EYES DARTED DOWNWARD, AND
WHAT HE SAW MADE HIS STOMACH CONTRACT. THERE WAS A HAND PROTRUDING FROM
THE CREAK AND IT WAS GLISTENING, GRAYISH, SLIMY-WETTING, AND STARKED,
LIKE SOMETHING DEAD THAT HAD DECAYED IN WATER...

BUT IT WAS VISIBLE ONLY FOR A SPLIT SECOND, AS THOUGH THE CREATURE

BENEATH THE CLOUD SENSED HARRY'S GAZE, THE HAND WAS SUDDENLY WITHDRAWN INTO THE FOLDS OF ITS BLACK CLOAK.

AND THEN THE THING BENEATH THE FLEECE, WHATEVER IT WAS, DREW A LONG, SILENT, RATTLING BREATH, AS THOUGH IT WERE TRYING TO SLICK SOMETHING MORE THAN AIR FROM ITS SURROUNDINGS.

AN INTENSE COLD SWEEP OVER THEM ALL, HARRY FELT HIS HEAVY BREATH CATCH IN HIS CHEST. THE COLD WENT DEEPER THAN HIS SKIN. IT WAS INSIDE HIS CHEST, IT WAS INSIDE HIS VERY HEART...

HARRY'S EYES REELLED UP INTO HIS HEAD, HE COULDN'T SEE. HE WAS DREAMING IN COLD. THERE WAS A RUSHING IN HIS EARS AS THOUGH OF WATER. HE WAS BEING DRAGGED DOWNWARD, THE RHEATING GROWING LOUDER. .

AND THEN, FROM FAR AWAY, HE HEARD SCREAMING, TERRIBLE, TERRIFIED, PLEADING SCREAMS. HE WANTED THE HELP WHATEVER IT WAS. HE TRIED TO MOVE HIS ARMS, BUT COULDN'T... A THICK WHITE FOG WAS SWIRLING AROUND HIM, INSIDE HIM -

"HARRY! HARRY! ARE YOU ALL RIGHT?"

SOMEONE WAS SLAPPING HIS FACE.

"W -- WHAT?"

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HARRY OPENED HIS EYES; THERE WERE LANTERNS ABOVE HIM, AND THE FLOOR WAS SHAKING -- THE HOGWARTS EXPRESS WAS MOVING AGAIN AND THE LIGHTS HAD COME

BACK ON. HE SEEMED TO HAVE SLID OUT OF HIS SEAT BENTH THE FLOOR. RON AND HERMIONE WERE DOZZLING NEXT TO HIM, AND ABOVE THEM HE COULD SEE NEVILLE AND PROFESSOR FLUPIN WATCHING. HARRY FELT VERY SICK; WHEN HE PUT UP HIS HAND TO PUSH HIS GLASSES BACK ON, HE FELT COLD SWEAT ON HIS FACE.

RON AND HERMIONE HEAVED HIM BACK BENTH HIS SEAT.

"ARE YOU OKAY?" RON ASKED NERVOUSLY.

"Yeah," said Harry, looking quickly toward the door. The hooded creature had vanished. "What happened? Where's that -- that thing? Where screamed?"

"We here screamed," said Ron, more nervously still.

Harry looked around the bright compartment. Ginny and Neville looked back at him, both very pale.

"But I heard screaming --"

A loud snap made them all jump. Professor Lupin was breaking an enormous

slab of chocolate into pieces.

"Here," he said to Harry, handing him a particularly large piece. "Eat it. It'll help."

Harry took the chocolate but didn't eat it.

"What was that thing?" he asked Lupin.

"A Dementor," said Lupin, who was now giving chocolate to everyone else.

"Here are the Dementors of Azkaban."

Everyone stared at him. Professor Lupin crumpled up the empty chocolate wrapper and put it in his pocket.

"Eat," he repeated. "It'll help. I need the speed the the driver, excuse me..."

EQ

He stropped past Harry and disappeared into the corridor.

"Are you sure you're okay, Harry?" said Hermione, watching Harry anxiously.

"I didn't get it... What happened?" said Harry, wiping more sweat off his face.

"Well -- that thing -- the Dementor -- stood there and looked around (I mean, I think it did, I couldn't see its face) -- and you -- you

"I thought you were having a fit for something," said Ron, who still

WHICH SCARED. "HE'LL GO INTO SHOCK AND FALL OFF HIS SEAT AND
STARTED TWITCHING -- 11

"AND PROFESSOR KLIPIN STEPPED OVER YELI, AND WALKED TOWARD THE DEMENTH,
AND PULLED OUT HIS WAND," SAID HERMIONE, "AND HE SAID, 'DON'T HE IS
HIDING STIRLIS BLACK UNDER HIS CHAIRS. GEE!' BUT THE DEMENTH DIDN'T MOVE,
SO KLIPIN MUTTERED SOMETHING, AND A SILVERY THING SHOT OUT OF HIS WAND AT
IT, AND IT TURNED AROUND AND SHEET HE GLIDED AWAY...."

"IT WAS TERRIBLE," SAID NEVILLE, IN A HIGHER VOICE THAN USUAL. "DID YELI
FEEL WHEN HE GOT WHEN IT CAME IN?"

"I FELT WEIRD," SAID REEN, SHIFTING HIS SHOULDERS UNCOMFORTABLY. "LIKE I'D
NEVER BE COMFORTABLE AGAIN...."

GINNY, WHO WAS FLIPPED IN HER CHAIR WHICH WAS NEARLY AS BAD AS HARRY
FELT, GAVE A SMALL SHRIEK. HERMIONE WENT OVER AND PUT A COMFORTING ARM
AROUND HER.

"BUT DIDN'T ANY OF YELI -- FALL OFF THEIR SEATS?" SAID HARRY ABSENTLY.

"NO," SAID REEN, WHICH ANXIOUSLY AT HARRY AGAIN. "GINNY WAS SHAKING
LIKE MAD, THOUGH...."

HARRY DIDN'T UNDERSTAND. HE FELT WEIRD AND SHIVERY, AS THOUGH HE WERE
RECOVERING FROM A BAD BEAT UP ALL. HE ALSO FELT THE BEGINNINGS OF SHAME.
WHY HAD HE GONE THE PIERCE LIKE THAT, WHEN HE HAD ELSE HAD?

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PROFESSOR KLIPIN HAD COME BACK. HE PAUSED AS HE ENTERED, WHICH AROUND,
AND SAID, WITH A SMALL SMILE, "I HAVEN'T FORGOTTEN THAT CHOCOLATE, YELI
KNOW...."

HARRY TOOK A KITE AND THE HIS GREAT SURPRISE FELT WARMTH SPREAD SLIDELY
THE TIPS OF HIS FINGERS AND THES.

"WE'LL BE AT HOGWARTS IN TEN MINUTES," SAID PROFESSOR KLIPIN. "ARE YELI

ALL RIGHT, HARRY?"

HARRY DIDN'T ASK THE PROFESSOR KLIPIN KNEW HIS NAME.

"FINE," HE MUTTERED, EMBARRASSED.

THEY DIDN'T TALK MUCH DURING THE REMAINDER OF THE JOURNEY. AT LONG LAST, THE TRAIN STOPPED AT HOGSMEAD STATION, AND THERE WAS A GREAT SCRAMBLE TO GET OUTSIDE; BELLS RINGED, CATS MEOWED, AND NEVILLE'S PET THEO CRAWLED BEHIND FROM UNDER HIS HAT. IT WAS FREEZING ON THE TINY PLATFORM; RAIN WAS DRIVING DOWN IN ICY SHEETS.

"FIRST YEARS THIS WAY!" CALLED A FAMILIAR VOICE. HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONIE TURNED AND SAW THE GIGANTIC OUTLINE OF Hagrid at the other end of the platform, beckoning the TERRIFIED-LOOKING NEW STUDENTS FORWARD FOR THEIR TRADITIONAL JOURNEY ACROSS THE LAKE.

"ALL RIGHT, WELL THREE?" Hagrid yelled over the heads of the crowd. THEY WAVED AT HIM, BUT HAD NO CHANCE TO SPEAK TO HIM BECAUSE THE MASS OF PEOPLE AMONG THEM WAS SHUNTING THEM AWAY ALONG THE PLATFORM. HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONIE FOLLOWED THE REST OF THE SCHOOL ALONG THE PLATFORM AND WENT DOWN A RAILWAY MUD TRACK, WHERE AT LEAST A HUNDRED STAGHOGS AWAITED THE REMAINING STUDENTS, EACH PULLED. HARRY COULD ONLY ASSUME, BY AN INVISIBLE FORCE, BECAUSE WHEN THEY CLIMBED INSIDE AND SHUT THE DOOR, THE CHAIR SET OFF ALL BY ITSELF, CLIPPING AND SLAYING IN PROCESSION. THE CHAIR SMELLED FAINTLY OF MILD AND STRAW. HARRY FELT BETTER SINCE THE CRASH, BUT STILL WEARY. RON AND HERMIONIE KEPT LOOKING AT HIM SIDELONG, AS THOUGH FRIGHTENED HE MIGHT COLLAPSE AGAIN.

AS THE CARRIAGE TRUNDLED TOWARD A PAIR OF MAGNIFICENT WHEELIGHT IRON

91

GATES, FLANKED WITH STONE CHIMNEYS TOPPED WITH WINGED CHARMS,

HARRY SAW TWO MORE THUNDERING, BEHEADED DEMONSTERS, STANDING GUARD ON EITHER

SIDE. A WAVE OF CHILD SICKNESS THREATENED THE ENGLISH HIM AGAIN; HE LEANED BACK INTO THE LIMPY SEAT AND CLOSED HIS EYES UNTIL THEY HAD PASSED THE GATES. THE CARRIAGE PICKED UP SPEED AND THE LEAD, SLEEPING DROVE UP THE CASTLE; FERMINE WAS LEANING OUT OF THE TINY WINDOW, WATCHING THE MANY TOWERS AND TOWERS DRAW NEARER. AT LAST, THE CARRIAGE STOPPED AT A HALL, AND FERMINE AND RICH GET OUT.

AS HARRY STEPPED DOWN, A DROWSY, DELICIOUS SLEEPER IN HIS EAR, "WELL PAINTED, BETTER IS LONGER THAN TELLING THE TRUTH WELL ACTUALLY PAINTED"

MALCOLM RUSHED PAST FERMINE THE BLACK HARRY'S WAY UP THE STONE STEPS THE CASTLE, HIS FACE GREY AND HIS PALE EYES GLINTING MALICIOUSLY.

"SEEK ME, MALCOLM," SAID RICH, WHOSE LIPS WERE CLENCHED.

"DID YOU PAINT AS WELL, WEAVER?" SAID MALCOLM WHISPERING, "DID THE STAFF WHO DEMENTED FRIGHTEN YOU TOO, WEAVER?"

"IS THERE A PROBLEM?" SAID A MILD VOICE, PROFESSOR LIPIN HAD JUST GOTTEN OUT OF THE NEXT CARRIAGE.

MALCOLM GAVE PROFESSOR LIPIN AN INSULTING STARE, WHICH THREW IN THE PATCHES ON HIS BEARD AND THE DELAPIDATED SUITCASE, WITH A TINY HINT OF SARCASTIC IN HIS VOICE, HE SAID, "HEY, NO -- ER -- PROFESSOR," THEN HE SMILED AT CRACK AND CRACK AND LED THEM UP THE STEPS INTO THE CASTLE.

FERMINE PRESSED RICH IN THE BACK TO MAKE HIM HURRY, AND THE THREE OF THEM JOINED THE CROWD SWARMING UP THE STEPS, THROUGH THE GATE THAT OPENED INTO THE CAVERNED ENTRANCE HALL, WHICH WAS LIT WITH FLAMING TORCHES, AND REVEALED A MAGNIFICENT MARBLE STAIRCASE THAT LED TO THE UPPER FLOORS.

THE DOOR INTO THE GREAT HALL STOOD OPEN AT THE RIGHT; HARRY FOLLOWED THE CROWD TOWARD IT, BUT HAD BARELY GLIMPSED THE ENCHANTED CEILING, WHICH WAS BLACK AND GLEAMING THEN, WHEN A VOICE CALLED, "BETTER! CRACKER! I WANT TO SEE YOU WITH!"

HARRY AND HERMIONE TURNED AROUND, SURPRISED. PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, TRANSFIGURATION TEACHER AND HEAD OF GRYFFINDOR HOUSE, WAS CALLING OVER THE HEADS OF THE CREED. SHE WAS A STERN-LOOKING WITCH WHOSE HAIR WAS IN A TIGHT BUN; HER SHARP EYES WERE FRAMED WITH SEVERE SPECTACLES. HARRY FELT HIS WAY OVER TO HER WITH A FEELING OF APPREHENSION. PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL HAD A WAY OF MAKING HIM FEEL HE MUST HAVE DONE SOMETHING WRONG.

"THERE'S NO NEED TO WORRY -- I JUST WANT A WORD IN MY OFFICE," SHE TOLD THEM. "MOVE ALONG THERE, PLEASE."

THEY STARED AS PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL DISMISSED HARRY AND HERMIONE AWAY FROM

THE CHATTERING CREED. THEY ACCOMPANIED HER ACROSS THE ENTRANCE HALL, UP THE MARBLE STAIRCASE, AND ALONG A HALLWAY.

WHEN THEY WERE IN HER OFFICE, A SMALL ROOM WITH A LARGE, WELCHING FIRE, PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL MOTIONED HARRY AND HERMIONE TO SIT DOWN. SHE SETTLED HERSELF BEHIND HER DESK AND SAID BRIEFLY, "PROFESSOR FLIPPIN SENT AN HOWL AHEAD TO SAY THAT YOU WERE TAKEN ILL ON THE TRAIN, PETER."

BEFORE HARRY COULD REPLY, THERE WAS A SHOT KNICK ON THE DOOR AND MADAM POMFREY, THE NURSE, CAME KLITTING IN.

HARRY FELT HIMSELF GOING RED IN THE FACE. IT WAS BAD ENOUGH THAT HE'D PASSED OUT, BUT WHATEVER HE HAD DONE, WITHOUT EVERYONE MAKING ALL THIS FUSS.

"I'M FINE," HE SAID. "I DIDN'T NEED ANYTHING."

"OH, IT'S YOU, IS IT?" SAID MADAM POMFREY, IGNORING THIS AND KEEPING HERSELF CLOSELY AT HIM. "I SUPPOSE YOU'VE BEEN DOING SOMETHING DANGEROUS AGAIN?"

"IT WAS A DEMENTOR, POMFREY," SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL.

THEY EXCHANGED A DARK LOOK, AND MADAM PEMFREY CLICKED DISAPPROVINGLY. "SETTING DEMENTERS AROUND A SCHEME, SHE MUTTERED, PLUSHING BACK HARRY'S HAIR AND FEELING HIS FOREHEAD. "HE WON'T BE THE LAST ONE WITH COLLAPSES.

RE

YES, HE'S ALL CLAMMY. TERRIBLE THINGS, THEY ARE, AND THE EFFECT THEY HAVE ON PEOPLE WHO ARE ALREADY DELICATE

"I'M NOT DELICATE," SAID HARRY CRASSLY.

"HE'LL SOON BE," SAID MADAM PEMFREY ASSENTMINDEDLY, WHILE TAKING HIS PULSE.

"WHAT DOES HE NEED?" SAID PROFESSOR MCKENAGALL CRISP. "BED REST? SHOULD HE PERHAPS SPEND THE NIGHT IN THE HOSPITAL WING?"

"I'M FINE," SAID HARRY, LIMPING UP. THE THOUGHT OF WHAT DRACH MALFOY WOULD SAY IF HE HAD THE CHANCE THE HOSPITAL WING WAS THIRTY.

"WELL, HE SHOULD HAVE SOME C-CHOCOLATE, AT THE VERY LEAST," SAID MADAM PEMFREY, WHILE WAS WHILE TRYING TO PEER INTO HARRY'S EYES.

"I'VE ALREADY HAD SOME," SAID HARRY. "PROFESSOR LUPIN GAVE ME SOME, HE GAVE IT TO ALL OF US."

"DID HE, NOW?" SAID MADAM PEMFREY APPROVINGLY. "SEE WE'VE FINALLY GOTTEN A DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS TEACHER WHO DENIES HIS REMEDIES?"

"ARE YOU SURE YOU FEEL ALL RIGHT, PETER?" PROFESSOR MCKENAGALL SAID SHARPLY.

"YES," SAID HARRY.

"VERY WELL. KINDLY WAIT OUTSIDE WHILE I HAVE A QUICK WORD WITH MISS GRANGER ABOUT HER CHURCH SCHEDULE, THEN WE CAN GO DOWN THE STAIRS TOGETHER."

HARRY WENT BACK INTO THE HALLWAY WITH MADAM PEMFREY, WHO LEFT HER THE HOSPITAL WING, MUTTERING TO HERSELF HE HAD TO WAIT ONLY A FEW MINUTES.

THEN HERMIONE EMERGED LOOKING VERY HAPPY ABOUT SOMETHING, FOLLOWED BY PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, AND THE THREE OF THEM MADE THEIR WAY BACK DOWN THE MARBLE STAIRCASE TO THE GREAT HALL.

IT WAS A SEA OF PRINTED BLACK FLATS; EACH OF THE LONG FINEST TABLES WAS LINKED WITH STUDENTS, THEIR FACES GLIMMERING BY THE LIGHT OF THOUSANDS OF

99

CANDLES, WHICH WERE FLUATING OVER THE TABLES IN MIDAIR. PROFESSOR FLITWICK, WHO WAS A TINY LITTLE WIZARD WITH A SHOCK OF WHITE HAIR, WAS CARRYING AN ANCIENT HAT AND A THREE-LEGGED STEEL STILT OF THE HALL.

"HEY," SAID HERMIONE SMYLY, "WE'VE MISSED THE SORTING!"

NEW STUDENTS AT HOGWARTS WERE SORTED INTO HOUSES BY TRYING ON THE SORTING HAT, WHICH SELECTED WHAT THE HOUSE THEY WERE BEST SUITED TO (GRYFFINDOR, RAVENCLAW, HUFFLEPUFF, OR SLYTHERIN). PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL STOOD OFF TOWARD HER EMPTY SEAT AT THE STAFF TABLE, AND HARRY AND HERMIONE SET OFF IN THE OTHER DIRECTION, AS QUIETLY AS POSSIBLE, TOWARD THE GRYFFINDOR TABLE. PEOPLE LOOKED AROUND AT THEM AS THEY PASSED ALONG THE BACK OF THE HALL, AND A FEW OF THEM PRINTED AT HARRY, WHO WAS STONY OF HIS COLLAPSING IN FRONT OF THE DEMENTOR TRAVELED THAT FAST?

HE AND HERMIONE SAT DOWN ON EITHER SIDE OF RON, WHO HAD SAVED THEM SEATS.

"WHAT WAS ALL THAT ABOUT?" HE MUTTERED TO HARRY.

HARRY STARTED TO EXPLAIN IN A WHISPER, BUT AT THAT MOMENT THE HEADMASTER STOOD UP TO SPEAK, AND HE STOPPED OFF.

PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE, THOUGH VERY OLD, ALWAYS GAVE AN IMPRESSION OF GREAT ENERGY. HE HAD SEVERAL FEET OF LONG SILVER HAIR AND BEARD, HALF-MOON SPECTACLES, AND AN EXTREMELY CRINKLED NECK. HE WAS OFTEN DESCRIBED AS THE GREATEST WIZARD OF THE AGE, BUT THAT WASN'T WHY HARRY

RESPECTED HIM. YELL CHILDREN'T HELP TRUSTING AUNTIE DUMBLEDORE, AND AS HARRY WATCHED HIM BEAMING AROUND AT THE STUDENTS, HE FELT REALLY CALM FOR THE FIRST TIME SINCE THE DEMENTERS HAD ENTERED THE TRAIN COMPARTMENT.

"WELCOME!" SAID DUMBLEDORE, THE CANDORLIGHT SHIMMERING IN HIS BEARD.

"WELCOME THE ANOTHER YEAR AT HOGWARTS! I HAVE A FEW THINGS TO SAY TO YOU ALL, AND AS HERE OF THEM IS VERY SERIOUS, I THINK IT BEST TO GET IT OUT OF THE WAY BEFORE YOU BECOME REJUBLED BY OUR EXCELLENT FEAST...."

DUMBLEDORE CLEARED HIS THROAT AND CONTINUED, "AS YOU WILL ALL BE AWARE AFTER THEIR SEARCH OF THE HOGWARTS EXPRESS, OUR SCHOOL IS PRESENTLY PLAYING HOST TO SOME OF THE DEMENTERS OF AZKABAN, WHO ARE HERE IN MINISTRY OF MAGIC BUSINESS."

AS

HE PAUSED, AND HARRY REMEMBERED WHAT MR. WEASLEY HAD SAID ABOUT

DUMBLEDORE NOT BEING HAPPY WITH THE DEMENTERS GUARDING THE SCHOOL.

"THEY ARE STATIONED AT EVERY ENTRANCE TO THE GROUNDS," DUMBLEDORE CONTINUED, "AND WHILE THEY ARE WITH US, I MUST MAKE IT PLAIN THAT NEKKED IS TO LEAVE SCHOOL WITHOUT PERMISSION. DEMENTERS ARE NOT TO BE FISHED BY TRICKS OR DISGUISES -- NOT EVEN INVISIBILITY CHARM." HE ADDED BLANDLY, AND HARRY AND RON GLANCED AT EACH OTHER. "IT IS NOT IN THE NATURE OF A DEMENTER TO UNDERSTAND PLEADING OR EXCUSES. I THEREFORE WARN EACH AND EVERY ONE OF YOU TO GIVE THEM NO REASON THE HARM YOU. I WOULD THE THE PROFFERS, AND OUR NEW HEAD BOY AND GIRL, TO MAKE SURE THAT NO STUDENT RUNS AWAY OF THE DEMENTERS," HE SAID.

PERCY, WHO WAS SITTING A FEW SEATS BEHIND HARRY, PLOPPED BACK HIS CHEST AGAIN AND STARED AROUND IMPRESSIVELY. DUMBLEDORE PAUSED AGAIN; HE LOOKED VERY SERIOUSLY AROUND THE HALL, AND NEKKED MOVED HER MOUTH AS IF TO SAY,

"THEN A HAPPIER MEET," HE CONTINUED, I AM PLEASED TO WELCOME THE NEW

TEACHERS THE HIGHER RANKS THIS YEAR.

"FIRST, PROFESSOR KLIPIN, WHO HAS KINDLY CONSENTED TO FILL THE POST OF
DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS TEACHER."

THERE WAS SOME SCATTERED, RATHER INDIFFERENT APPLAUSE, ONLY THESE
WHO

HAD BEEN IN THE COMPARTMENT ON THE TRAIN WITH PROFESSOR KLIPIN CLAPPED
HARD, HARRY AMONG THEM. PROFESSOR KLIPIN LOOKED PARTICULARLY STAGGERED NEXT
TO ALL THE OTHER TEACHERS IN THEIR BEST DRESSES.

"LOOK AT SNAPE?" RON HISSED IN HARRY'S EAR.

PROFESSOR SNAPE, THE POISONING MASTER, WAS STANDING ALONG THE STAFF TABLE
AT PROFESSOR KLIPIN. IT WAS COMMON KNOWLEDGE THAT SNAPE, ANTED THE
DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS JOB, BUT EVEN HARRY, WHO HATED SNAPE, WAS
STARTLED AT THE EXPRESSION TWISTING HIS THIN, SLENDER FACE. IT WAS PURE
ANGER! IT WAS BRUTAL. HARRY KNEW THAT EXPRESSION ONLY TOO WELL; IT WAS
THE LOOK SNAPE WORE EVERY TIME HE SET EYES ON HARRY.

"AS THE HIGHER SECOND NEW APPOINTMENT," DUMBLEDORE CONTINUED AS THE
LORDS

APPLAUSE FOR PROFESSOR KLIPIN DIED AWAY. "WELL, I AM SURE YOU WILL

THE

THAT PROFESSOR KETTLEBURN, HIGHER CARE OF MAGICAL CREATURES TEACHER,
RETIRED AT THE END OF LAST YEAR IN ORDER TO ENJOY MORE TIME WITH HIS
REMAINING LIVES. HOWEVER, I AM DELIGHTED TO SAY THAT HIS PLACE WILL BE
FILLED BY NONE OTHER THAN RUBEUS Hagrid, WHO HAS AGREED TO TAKE ON THIS
TEACHING JOB IN ADDITION TO HIS GAMEKEEPING DUTIES."

HARRY, RON, AND HERMION STARED AT ONE ANOTHER, STUNNED. THEN THEY
BROKE IN WITH THE APPLAUSE, WHICH WAS TIMIDLY AT THE GRYFFINDOR
TABLE IN PARTICULAR. HARRY LEANED FORWARD TO SEE Hagrid, WHO WAS
FLUSHED IN THE FACE AND STARING DOWN AT HIS ENORMOUS HANDS, HIS WIDE

GRIN HIDDEN IN THE TANGLE OF HIS BLACK BEARD.

"WE SHOULD'VE KNOWN!" RON REARED, POUNDING THE TABLE. "WHY ELSE WOULD HAVE ASSIGNED US A KITTEN KITCH?"

HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONIE WERE THE LAST THE STEEP CLAPPING, AND AS PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE STARTED SPEAKING AGAIN, THEY SAW THAT LACRIB WAS WIPING HIS EYES ON THE TABLECLOTH.

"WELL, I THINK THAT'S EVERYTHING OF IMPORTANCE," SAID DUMBLEDORE. "LET THE FEAST BEGIN!"

THE GOLDEN PLATES AND CHINKETS BEFORE THEM FILLED SUDDENLY WITH MEAT AND DRINK. HARRY, SUDDENLY RAVENHILL, HELPED HIMSELF TO EVERYTHING HE COULD REACH AND BEGAN TO EAT.

IT WAS A DELICIOUS FEAST; THE HALL ECHOED WITH TALK, LAUGHTER, AND THE CLATTER OF KNIVES AND FORKS. HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONIE, HOWEVER, WERE LAGER FOR IT THE FINISH SEE THAT THEY COULD TALK TO LACRIB. THEY KNEW FULLY MUCH BEING MADE A TEACHER WOULD MEAN TO HIM. LACRIB WASN'T A FULLY QUALIFIED WIZARD; HE HAD BEEN EXPELLED FROM HOGWARTS IN HIS THIRD YEAR FOR A CRIME HE HAD NOT COMMITTED. IT HAD BEEN HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONIE WHO HAD CLEARED LACRIB'S NAME LAST YEAR.

AT LONG LAST, WHEN THE LAST MEREELS OF PLUMPOIN TART HAD MELTED FROM THE GOLDEN PLATTERS, DUMBLEDORE GAVE THE WORD THAT IT WAS TIME FOR THEM ALL TO GET THE BED, AND THEY GOT THEIR CHANCE.

"CONGRATULATIONS, LACRIB!" HERMIONIE SHEWLED AS THEY REACHED THE TEACHERS' TABLE.

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"ALL DOWN THE DILL THERE," SAID LACRIB, WIPING HIS SHINING FACE ON HIS NAPKIN AS HE LOOKED UP AT THEM. "CAN' BELIEVE IT... GREAT MAN, DUMBLEDORE... CAME STRAIGHT DOWN THE ME HILL AFTER PROFESSOR KETTLEBURN

SAID HE'D HAD ENOUGH.... IT'S WHAT I ALWAYS WANTED. --"

EVERYONE WITH EYES THEN, HE BURIED HIS FACE IN HIS NAPKIN, AND PROFESSOR
MCGONAGALL SEEMED THEM AWAY.

HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONE HEARD THE GRYFFINDERS STREAMING UP THE MARBLE
STAIRCASE AND, VERY TIRED NOW, ALONG THEIR CORRIDORS, UP MORE AND MORE
STAIRS, TO THE HIDDEN ENTRANCE THE GRYFFINDER TOWER'S LARGE PORTRAIT OF A
FAT LADY IN A PINK DRESS ASKED THEM, "PASSWORD?"

"CHIMING THREGLIGH, CHIMING THREGLIGH!" PERCY CALLED FROM BEHIND THE CURTAIN.

"THE NEW PASSWORD'S 'HEARTLINE MOTHER!'"

"HEH HEH," SAID NEVILLE LONGBOTT SADLY, HE ALWAYS HAD TROUBLE
REMEMBERING THE PASSWORDS.

THROUGH THE PORTRAIT HOLE AND ACROSS THE CHIMNEY ROOM, THE GIRLS AND
BOYS

DIVIDED TOWARD THEIR SEPARATE STAIRCASES. HARRY CLIMBED THE SPIRAL STAIR
WITH NEW THREGLIGHT IN HIS HEAD EXCEPT HE WAS GLAD HE WAS THERE BACK. THEY
REACHED THEIR FAMILIAR, CIRCULAR DORMITORY WITH ITS FIVE PINK-PINK
BEDS, AND HARRY, WHISKING AROUND, FELT HE WAS HOME AT LAST.

CHAPTER SIX

TALKERS AND TEA LEAVES

WHEN HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONE ENTERED THE GREAT HALL FOR BREAKFAST THE
NEXT DAY, THE FIRST THING THEY SAW WAS BRUCE MALFOY, WHO SEEMED TO BE
ENTERTAINING A LARGE GROUP OF SLYTHERINS WITH A VERY FLINDY STORY. AS
THEY PASSED, MALFOY DID A RIDICULOUS IMPRESSION OF A SHINING FIT AND
THERE WAS A HEAR OF LAUGHTER.

"IGNORE HIM," SAID HERMIONE, WHO WAS RIGHT BEHIND HARRY, "JUST IGNORE
HIM, IT'S NOT WORTH IT...."

"HEY, BETTER!" SHRIEKED PANSY PARKINSON, A SLYTHERIN GIRL WITH A FACE

LIKE A PLUG. "PITTER! THE DEMENTHRS ARE COMING, PITTER! WHHHHHHHHHHH!"
HARRY DROPPED INTO A SEAT AT THE GRYPFINDER TABLE, NEXT TO GEORGE
WEASLEY.

"NEW THIRD-YEAR CHLRSK SCHEDULES," SAID GEORGE, PASSING THEM OVER.

"WHAT'S UP WITH YOU, HARRY?"

"MALFOY," SAID RON, SITTING DOWN ON GEORGE'S OTHER SIDE AND GLARING OVER
AT THE SLYTHERIN TABLE.

GEORGE WINKED UP IN TIME TO SEE MALFOY PRETENDING TO FAINT WITH TERROR
AGAIN.

"THAT LITTLE GIT," HE SAID CALMLY. "HE WASN'T SEE CHECKY LAST NIGHT WHEN
THE DEMENTHRS WERE DOWN AT HIS END OF THE TRAIN. CAME RUNNING INTO HIS
COMPARTMENT, DIDN'T HE, FRED?"

"NEARLY WET HIMSELF," SAID FRED, WITH A CONTEMPTUOUS GLANCE AT MALFOY.

"I WASN'T TOO HAPPY MYSELF," SAID GEORGE. "THEY'RE HORRIBLE THINGS,
THESE DEMENTHRS...."

"SHORT OF FREEZE YOUR INSIDES, DIDN'T THEY?" SAID FRED.

"YOU DIDN'T PASS OUT, THOUGH, DID YOU?" SAID HARRY IN A LOW VOICE.

"FORGET IT, HARRY," SAID GEORGE BRACINGLY. "DAD HAD THE CAR WHEN THE AZKABAN
HIT TIME, REMEMBER, FRED? AND HE SAID IT WAS THE WORST PLACE HE'D EVER
BEEN, HE CAME BACK ALL WRECK AND SHAKING.... THEY SUCK THE HAPPINESS OUT
OF A PLACE, DEMENTHRS, MOST OF THE PRISONERS GET MAD IN THERE."

"ANYWAY, WE'LL SEE HOW HAPPY MALFOY LOOKS AFTER HIS FIRST FLUIDITCH
MATCH," SAID FRED. "GRYPFINDER VERSUS SLYTHERIN, FIRST GAME OF THE
SEASON, REMEMBER?"

THE ONLY TIME HARRY AND MALFOY HAD FACED EACH OTHER IN A FLUIDITCH
MATCH, MALFOY HAD DEFINITELY WON HIS WARE, FEELING SLIGHTLY MORE
CHEERFUL, HARRY HELPED HIMSELF TO SALISAGES AND ARIED THEMATHES.

BERMITHRE WAS EXAMINING HER NEW SCHEDULE.

"HEH, GHEH, WE'RE STARTING SOME NEW SLICKETS TODAY," SHE SAID HAPPILY. VILLAINS ARE THESE, THAT TRESPASS UPON MY PRIVATE LANDS? COME I, STERN AT MY FALL, PERCHANCE? DRAW, YELL KNIVES, YELL DINGS!"

THEY WATCHED IN ASTONISHMENT AS THE LITTLE KNIGHT TUGGED HIS SWORD HILT UP ITS SCABBARD AND BEGAN BRANDISHING IT VIOLENTLY, HOPPING UP AND DOWN IN RAGE. BUT THE SWORD WAS TOO LONG FOR HIM; A PARTICULARLY WILD SWING MADE HIM OVERBALANCE, AND HE LANDED FACEDOWN IN THE GRASS.

"ARE YELL ALL RIGHT?" SAID FARRY, MOVING CLOSER TO THE PICTURE.

"GET BACK, YELL SLIRVY BRAGGART! BACK, YELL REGLIE!"

THE KNIGHT SEIZED HIS SWORD AGAIN AND USED IT TO PLOUGH HIMSELF BACK UP, BUT THE BLADE SANK DEEPLY INTO THE GRASS AND, THOUGH HE PULLED WITH ALL HIS MIGHT, HE COULDN'T GET IT HILT AGAIN. FINALLY, HE HAD TO PEEP BACK DOWN INTO THE GRASS AND PLOUGH UP HIS VISOR TO MEEP HIS SWEATING FACE.

"LISTEN," SAID FARRY, TAKING ADVANTAGE OF THE KNIGHT'S EXHAUSTION.

"WE'RE LOOKING FOR THE NORTH TOWER. YELL DON'T KNOW THE WAY, DO YELL?"

"A HELPER?" THE KNIGHT'S RAGE SEEMED TO VANISH INSTANTLY. HE CLANKED THE HIS FEET AND SMILTED. "COME FOLLOW ME, DEAR FRIENDS, AND WE SHALL FIND OUR CHAL, OR ELSE SHALL PERISH BRAVELY IN THE CHARGE!"

HE GAVE THE SWORD ANOTHER FRUITLESS TUG, TRIED AND FAILED TO MOUNT THE FAT POND, GAVE UP, AND CRIED, "HN HET THEN, GHEH SIR AND GENTLE LADY? HN? HN?"

AND HE RAN, CLANKING LOUDLY, INTO THE LEFT SIDE OF THE FRAME AND HILT UP SIGHT.

THEY HURRIED AFTER HIM ALONG THE CORRIDOR, FOLLOWING THE SHLIND OF HIS ARMOR. EVERY NOW AND THEN THEY SPOTTED HIM RUNNING THROUGH A PICTURE ALKAD.

"BE HE STEALY HEART, THE WERST IS YET TO COME!" YELLED THE KNIGHT, AND THEY SAW HIM REAPPEAR IN FRONT OF AN ALARMED GROUP OF WOMEN IN

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CRIMELINES, WHERE PICTURE HUNG ON THE WALL OF A NARROW SPIRAL STAIRCASE. PLIPPING HEEDLESSLY, F-JARRY, RENN, AND F-ERMINE CLIMBED THE TIGHTLY SPIRALING STEPS, GETTING DIZZIER AND DIZZIER, UNTIL AT LAST THEY HEARD THE MURMUR OF VEHICLES AROUND THEM AND KNEW THEY HAD REACHED THE CLASSROOM.

"FAREWELL!" CRIED THE KNIGHT, PLOPPING HIS HEAD INTO A PAINTING OF SOME SINISTER-LOOKING MEN. "FAREWELL, MY COMRADES-IN-ARMS! IF EVER YOU HAVE NEED OF NERVE HEART AND STEELY SINEL, CALL UPON SIR CADMEAN!"

"Yeah, we'll call you," MUTTERED RENN AS THE KNIGHT DISAPPEARED. "IF WE EVER NEED SOMEONE MENTAL."

THEY CLIMBED THE LAST FEW STEPS AND EMERGED INTO A TINY LANDING, WHERE MOST OF THE CLASS WAS ALREADY ASSEMBLED. THERE WERE NO OTHERS OFF THIS LANDING, BUT RENN NODDED F-JARRY AND POINTED AT THE CEILING, WHERE THERE WAS A CIRCULAR TRAPDOOR WITH A BRASS PLATE ON IT.

"SIR WILL TRELAWNEY, DIVINATION TEACHER," F-JARRY READ. "THEY'RE WE SLIPPED THE GET UP THERE?"

AS THOUGH IN ANSWER TO HIS QUESTIONS, THE TRAPDOOR SUDDENLY OPENED, AND A SILVERY LADDER DESCENDED RIGHT AT F-JARRY'S FEET. EVERYONE GOT QUIET.

"AFTER YOU," SAID RENN, GRINNING, AS F-JARRY CLIMBED THE LADDER FIRST.

HE EMERGED INTO THE STRANGEST-LOOKING CLASSROOM HE HAD EVER SEEN. IN

FACT, IT DIDN'T LOOK LIKE A CLASSROOM AT ALL, MORE LIKE A CRIB BETWEEN

SOMEONE'S ATTIC AND AN OLD-FASHIONED TEA SHOP. AT LEAST TWENTY SMALL,

CIRCULAR TABLES WERE CRAMPED INSIDE IT, ALL SURROUNDED BY CHINTZ

ARMCHAIRS AND FAT LITTLE PUFFS. EVERYTHING WAS LIT WITH A DIM, CRIMSON

LIGHT; THE CURTAINS AT THE WINDOWS WERE ALL CLOSED, AND THE MANY LAMPS

WERE DRAPED WITH DARK RED SCARVES. IT WAS STIKINGLY WARM, AND THE FIRE

THAT WAS BURNING UNDER THE CHECKED MANTELPIECE WAS GIVING OFF A HEAVY,

SICKLY SMOKE OF PERUKE AS IT HEATED A LARGE CHOPPER KETTLE. THE SHELVES
RUNNING AROUND THE CIRCULAR WALLS WERE CRAMPED WITH DUSTY-LOOKING
FEATHERS, STICKS OF CANDLES, MANY PACKS OF TATTERED PLAYING CARDS,
ENDLESS SILVERY CRYSTAL BALLS, AND A HUGE ARRAY OF TRACAPS.
RENN APPEARED AT HARRY'S SHOULDERS AS THE CLASS ASSEMBLED AROUND THEM, ALL

81

TALKING IN WHISPERS.

"WHERE IS SHE?" RENN SAID.

A VOICE CAME SUDDENLY FROM THE SHADOWS, A SOFT, MISTY SMOKE OF VOICE.

"WELCOME," IT SAID, "HOW NICE TO SEE YOU IN THE PHYSICAL WORLD AT LAST."

HARRY'S IMMEDIATE IMPRESSION WAS OF A LARGE, GLITTERING INSECT.

PROFESSOR TRILAWNEY MOVED INTO THE FIRELIGHT, AND THEY SAW THAT SHE WAS
VERY THIN; HER LARGE GLASSES MAGNIFIED HER EYES THE SEVERAL TIMES THEIR
NATURAL SIZE, AND SHE WAS DRAPED IN A GOWN SPANGLED WITH INNUMERABLE
CHAINS AND BEADS HUNG AROUND HER SPINDLY NECK, AND HER ARMS AND HANDS
WERE ENCRUSTED WITH RANGLES AND RINGS.

"SIT, MY CHILDREN, SIT," SHE SAID, AND THEY ALL CLIMBED ALLEGORICALLY INTO
ARMCHAIRS AND SANDHOLDS. PHILIPS, HARRY, RENN, AND HERMIONE SAT THEMSELVES
AROUND THE SAME ROUND TABLE.

"WELCOME TO DIVINATION," SAID PROFESSOR TRILAWNEY, WHO HAD SEATED
HERSELF IN A WINGED ARMCHAIR IN FRONT OF THE FIRE. "MY NAME IS PROFESSOR
TRILAWNEY. YOU MAY NOT HAVE SEEN ME BEFORE. I FIND THAT DESCENDING THROUGH
DOWN INTO THE WHISTLE AND WHISTLE OF THE MAIN STREET LIGHTS MY INNER
EYE."

NONE OF THEM SAID ANYTHING TO THIS EXTRAORDINARY PROPHETESS. PROFESSOR
TRILAWNEY DELICATELY REARRANGED HER GOWN AND CONTINUED, "SEE YOU HAVE
CHOSEN THE STUBBY DIVINATION, THE MOST DIFFICULT OF ALL MAGICAL ARTS. I

MUST WARN YOU AT THE ELISET THAT IF YOU DO NOT HAVE THE SIGHT, THERE IS VERY LITTLE I WILL BE ABLE TO TEACH YOU. KNEES CAN TAKE YOU ONLY SO FAR IN THIS FIELD...."

AT THESE WORDS, BOTH HARRY AND RON GLANCED, GRINNING, AT HERMIONE, WHO LOOKED STARTLED AT THE NEWS THAT KNEES WOULDN'T BE MUCH HELP IN THIS SUBJECT.

"MANY WITCHES AND WIZARDS, TALENTED THOUGH THEY ARE IN THE AREA OF HEALING RINGS AND SPELLS AND SUDDEN DISAPPEARINGS, ARE YET UNABLE TO PENETRATE THE VEILED MYSTERIES OF THE FUTURE." PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY WENT ON, HER EMBROIDERED, GLAMING EYES MOVING FROM FACE TO NERVELESS FACE. "IT IS A GIFT

BY

GRANTED TO FEW, YOU, KID," SHE SAID SUDDENLY TO NEVILLE, WHO ALMOST THROUPELLED HIS PONY. "IS YOUR GRANDMOTHER WELL?"

"I THINK SHE," SAID NEVILLE TREMBLINGLY.

"I WOULDN'T BE SO SURE IF I WERE YOU, DEAR," SAID PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY, THE FIRELIGHT GLINTING ON HER LONG EMERALD EARRINGS. NEVILLE GLIMPED, PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY CONTINUED PLACIDLY. "WE WILL BE COVERING THE BASIC METHODS OF DIVINATION THIS YEAR. THE FIRST TERM WILL BE DEVOTED TO READING THE TEA LEAVES. NEXT TERM WE SHALL PROGRESS TO PALMISTRY. BY THE WAY, MY DEAR," SHE SAID SUDDENLY AT PARVATI PATIL, "BEWARE A RED-HAIRED MAN."

PARVATI GAVE A STARTLED LOOK AT RON, WHO WAS RIGHT BEHIND HER AND POKED HER CHAIR AWAY FROM HIM.

"IN THE SECOND TERM," PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY WENT ON, "WE SHALL PROGRESS TO THE CRYSTAL BALL -- IF WE HAVE FINISHED WITH FIRE HERMS, THAT IS. UNFORTUNATELY, CLASSES WILL BE DISRUPTED IN FEBRUARY BY A NASTY BLIZZARD OF ALL. I MYSELF WILL LOSE MY VEHICLE. AND AROUND EASTER, HERE OF OUR NIMPER

WILL LEAVE US FOREVER."

A VERY TENSE SILENCE FOLLOWED THIS ANNOUNCEMENT, BUT PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY SEEMED UNAWARE OF IT.

"I WONDER, DEAR," SHE SAID TO LAVENDER BROWN, WHO WAS NEAREST AND STOOD BACK IN HER CHAIR, "IF YOU COULD PASS ME THE LARGEST SILVER TEACUP?" LAVENDER, BECOMING RELIEVED, STOOD UP, TOOK AN ENORMOUS TEACUP FROM THE SHELF, AND PUT IT DOWN ON THE TABLE IN FRONT OF PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY.

"THANK YOU, MY DEAR. INCIDENTALLY, THAT THING YOU ARE DRINKING -- IT WILL HAPPEN ON FRIDAY THE SIXTEENTH OF OCTOBER."

LAVENDER TREMBLED.

"NOW, I WANT YOU ALL TO DIVIDE INTO PAIRS. COLLECT A TEACUP FROM THE SHELF, COME TO ME, AND I WILL FILL IT. THEN SIT DOWN AND DRINK, DRINK UNTIL ONLY THE DREGS REMAIN. SWILL THESE AROUND THE CUP THREE TIMES WITH THE LEFT HAND, THEN TURN THE CUP UPSIDE DOWN ON ITS SAUCER, WAIT FOR THE

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LAST OF THE TEA TO DRAIN AWAY, THEN GIVE YOUR CUP TO YOUR PARTNER TO READ. YOU WILL INTERPRET THE PATTERNS USING PAGES FIVE AND SIX OF LINING THE FUTURE. I SHALL MOVE AMONG YOU, HELPING AND INSTRUCTING. HERE, AND DEAR" -- SHE CALLED NEVILLE BY THE ARM AS HE MADE HER STAND UP --

"AFTER YOU'VE BROKEN YOUR FIRST CUP, WOULD YOU BE SO KIND AS TO SELECT ONE OF THE BLUE PATTERNED ONES? I'M RATHER ATTACHED TO THE PINK."

SURE ENOUGH, NEVILLE HAD NEITHER REACHED THE SHELF OF TEACUPS WHEN THERE WAS A TINKLE OF BREAKING CHINA. PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY SWIFTLY TOOK HIM HOLDING A DUSTPAN AND BRUSH AND SAID, "ONE OF THE BLUE ONES, THEN, DEAR, IF YOU WOULDN'T MIND... THANK YOU, ..."

WHEN HARRY AND RON HAD HAD THEIR TEACUPS FILLED, THEY WENT BACK TO THEIR TABLE AND TRIED THE DRINK THE STANDING TEA HELDLY. THEY SWILLED THE

DRESS AROUND AS PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY HAD INSTRUCTED, THEN DRAINED THE CLIPS AND SWAPPED OVER.

"RIGHT," SAID RON AS THEY BOTH OPENED THEIR BOOKS AT PAGES FIVE AND SIX.

"WHAT CAN YOU SEE IN MINE?"

"A LUMP OF SUGGY GREEN STUFF," SAID HARRY. THE HEAVILY PERLINED SMOKE IN THE ROOM WAS MAKING HIM FEEL SLEEPY AND STUPID.

"BROADEN YOUR MINDS, MY DEARS, AND ALLOW YOUR EYES TO SEE PAST THE ORDINARY!" PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY CRIED THROUGH THE CLOUDS.

HARRY TRIED TO PULL HIMSELF TOGETHER.

"RIGHT, YOU'VE GOTTEN A CRINKLED SHEET OF CLOTH..." HE CONSULTED LINGERING THE FUTURE. "THAT MEANS YOU'RE GOING TO HAVE 'TRIALS AND SUFFERING' -- SURELY ABOUT THAT -- BUT THERE'S A THING THAT COULD BE THE SIGN... HANG ON... THAT MEANS 'GREAT HAPPINESS'... SO YOU'RE GOING TO SUFFER BUT BE VERY HAPPY..."

"YOU NEED YOUR INNER EYE TESTED, IF YOU ASK ME," SAID RON, AND THEY BOTH HAD TO STILE THEIR LAUGHS AS PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY GAZED IN THEIR DIRECTION.

"MY TURN..." RON PEERED INTO HARRY'S TEACUP, HIS FOREHEAD WRINKLED WITH EFFORT. "THERE'S A BLOB A BIT LIKE A KILLER FISH," HE SAID. "MAYBE YOU'RE

24

GOING TO LEARN FROM THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC...

HE TURNED THE TEACUP THE OTHER WAY UP.

"BUT THIS WAY IT LOOKS MORE LIKE AN ACHORN... WHAT'S THAT?" HE SCANNED HIS COPY OF LINGERING THE FUTURE. "A WINDMILL, UNEXPECTED GUILD, EXCELLENT, YOU CAN LEND ME SOME... AND THERE'S A THIN, FINE," HE TURNED THE CLIP AGAIN. "THAT LOOKS LIKE AN ANIMAL... YES, IF THAT WAS ITS HEAD... IT LOOKS LIKE A HIPPO... NO, A SHEEP..."

PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY WHIRLED AROUND AS HARRY LET OUT A SHORT OF LAUGHTER.

"LET ME SEE THAT, MY DEAR," SHE SAID REPROVINGLY TO BEN, SWEEPING OVER AND SNATCHING HARRY'S CLIP FROM HIM. EVERYONE WENT HELIET THE WATCH. PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY WAS STARING INTO THE TACCLIP, REHATING IT CILINTERCLOCKWISE.

"THE FALCHIN... MY DEAR, YELL HAVE A DEADLY ENEMY."

"BUT EVERYONE KNOWS THAT," SAID HERMIONE IN A WHISPER. PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY STARED AT HER.

"WELL, THEY DO," SAID HERMIONE. "EVERYBODY KNOWS ABOUT HARRY AND YELL-KNOW-WHIE."

HARRY AND BEN STARED AT HER WITH A MIXTURE OF AMAZEMENT AND ADMIRATION. THEY HAD NEVER HEARD HERMIONE SPEAK THE A TEACHER LIKE THAT BEFORE. PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY CHIEE NOT THE REPLY. SHE WINKED HER BLUE EYES THE HARRY'S CLIP AGAIN AND CONTINUED THE TURN IT.

"THE CLIP... AN ATTACK, DEAR, DEAR, THIS IS NOT A HAPPY CLIP..."

I THOUGHT THAT WAS A SLENDER FAT," SAID BEN SHEEPISHLY.

"THE SKULL... DANGER IN YOUR PATH, MY DEAR..."

EVERYONE WAS STARING, TRANSFIXED, AT PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY, WHO GAVE THE CLIP A FINAL TURN, GASPED, AND THEN SCREAMED.

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THERE WAS ANOTHER TINKLE OF BREAKING CHINA; NEVILLE HAD SMASHED HIS SECOND CLIP. PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY SANK INTO A VACANT ARMCHAIR, HER GLITTERING HAND AT HER HEART AND HER EYES CLOSED.

"MY DEAR KID... MY PHIEE, DEAR KID NOT IT IS KINDER NOT THE SAY... . NOT... DON'T ASK ME..."

"WHAT IS IT, PROFESSOR?" SAID DEAN THOMAS AT ONCE. EVERYONE HAD GOT THE THEIR FEET, AND SILENTLY THEY CRAWLED AROUND HARRY AND BEN'S TABLE, PRESSING CLOSE TO PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY'S CHAIR THE GET A

GHED LHHK AT F-JARRY'S CLIP.

"MY DEAR," PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY'S BLUE EYES OPENED DRAMATICALLY,

"YELL HAVE THE GRIM."

"THE WHAT?" SAID F-JARRY.

HE COULD TELL THAT HE WASN'T THE ONLY ONE WHO DIDN'T UNDERSTAND; DEAN THOMAS STOLGEGED AT HIM AND LAVENDER BROWN LHHKED PLIZZLED, BUT NEARLY EVERYBODY ELSE CLAPPED THEIR HANDS TH THEIR MHLTHS IN F-HRORR.

"THE GRIM, MY DEAR, THE GRIM!" CRIED PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY, WHO LHHKED SHOCKED THAT F-JARRY HADN'T UNDERSTOOD. "THE GIANT, SPECTRAL DEE THAT HALINTS CHURCH-YARDS! MY DEAR KEE, IT IS AN EMEN -- THE WERST EMEN -- OF DEATH!"

F-JARRY'S STOMACH LURCHED. THAT DEE HIN THE CEVER OF DEATH EMENS IN FHLRISH AND BLITTS -THE DEE IN THE SHADHLS OF MAGNELLIA CRESCENT...

LAVENDER BROWN CLAPPED HER HANDS TH HER MHLTH THH, EVERYONE WAS LHHKING

AT F-JARRY, EVERYONE EXCEPT HERMIONE, WHO HAD GITTEN LIP AND MOVED AWHLND TH THE BACK OF PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY'S CHAIR.

"I DEEN'T THINK IT LHHKS LIKE A GRIM," SHE SAID FLATLY.

PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY SLRWYED HERMIONE WITH MHLINTING DISLIKE.

"YELL'LL PERCTIVE ME HER SAYING SEE, MY DEAR, BUT I PERCTIVE VERY LITTLE ALRA AWHLND YELL. VERY LITTLE RECEPTIVITY TH THE RESHMANCES OF THE

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FLTLRE." SEAMUS FINNIGAN WAS TILTING HIS HEAD FROM SIDE TH SIDE.

"IT LHHKS LIKE A GRIM IF YELL DEE TH-IS," HE SAID, WITH HIS EYES ALMEET SH-LT, "BUT IT LHHKS MORE LIKE A DRINKY FROM HERE," HE SAID, LEANING TH THE LEFT.

"WHEN YELL'VE ALL FINISHED DECIDING WHETHER I'M GHING TH DIE HER NEET?" SAID F-JARRY, TAKING EVEN HIMSELF BY SURPRISE. NELL NEEKHD SEEMED TH WANT

THEY LOOKED AT HIM.

"I THINK WE WILL LEAVE THE LESSON HERE FOR TODAY," SAID PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY IN HER MISTYEST VOICE. "YES... PLEASE PACK AWAY YOUR THINGS..."

SILENTLY THE CLASS TOOK THEIR TRICKLES BACK THE PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY, PACKED AWAY THEIR BOOKS, AND CLOSED THEIR BAGS. EVEN RON WAS AVOIDING HARRY'S EYES.

"UNTIL WE MEET AGAIN," SAID PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY FAINTLY, "TAKE HEARTLINE BE YOURS, EH, AND DEAR" -- SHE POINTED AT NEVILLE -- "YOU'LL BE LATE NEXT TIME, SO MIND YOU LEAVE EXTRA-FAST THE LATCH UP."

HARRY, RON, AND HERMION DESCENDED PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY'S LADDER AND THE WINDING STAIR IN SILENCE, THEN SET OFF FOR PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL'S TRANSFIGURATION LESSON. IT TOOK THEM SOME TIME TO FIND HER CLASSROOM THAT EARLY AS THEY HAD LEFT DIVINATION, THEY WERE ONLY JUST IN TIME.

HARRY CHOSE A SEAT RIGHT AT THE BACK OF THE ROOM, FEELING AS THOUGH HE WERE SITTING IN A VERY BRIGHT SPOTLIGHT; THE REST OF THE CLASS KEPT SHOOTING FLIRTATY GLANCES AT HIM, AS THOUGH HE WERE ABOUT THE DUMB DUMB AT AND MUGGENT. HE HARDLY HEARD WHAT PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL WAS TELLING THEM ABOUT ANIMAGI (WIZARDS WHO CAN TRANSFORM AT WILL INTO ANIMALS), AND WASN'T EVEN WATCHING WHEN SHE TRANSFORMED HERSELF IN FRONT OF THEIR EYES INTO A TABBY CAT WITH SPECTACULAR MARKINGS AROUND HER EYES.

"REALLY, WHAT HAS GOTTEN INTO YOU ALL TODAY?" SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, TURNING BACK INTO HERSELF WITH A FAINT POOF, AND STARING AROUND AT THEM ALL. "NOT THAT IT MATTERS, BUT THAT'S THE FIRST TIME MY TRANSFORMATION'S NOT GOTTEN APPRAISED FROM A CLASS."

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EVERYBODY'S HEADS TURNED TOWARD HARRY AGAIN, BUT NEITHER SPoke, THEN

HERMIONE RAISED HER HAND.

"PLEASE, PROFESSOR, WE'VE JUST HAD OUR FIRST DIVINATION CLASS, AND WE WERE READING THE TEA LEAVES, AND --"

"AH, OF COURSE," SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, SLIDENLY PREENING.

"THERE IS NO NEED TO SAY ANY MORE, MISS GRANGER. TELL ME, WHICH OF YOU WILL BE DYING THIS YEAR?"

EVERYONE STARED AT HER.

"ME," SAID HARRY, FINALLY.

"I SEE," SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, FIXING HARRY WITH HER DEAD EYES.

"THEN YOU SHOULD KNOW, BETTER, THAT SYBIL TRELAWNEY HAS PREDICTED THE DEATH OF ONE STUDENT A YEAR SINCE SHE ARRIVED AT THIS SCHOOL. NONE OF THEM HAS DIED YET. SEEING DEATH THEMSELVES IS HER FAVORITE WAY OF GREETING A NEW CLASS. IF IT WERE NOT FOR THE FACT THAT I NEVER SPEAK TO ANY OF MY COLLEAGUES --"

PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL BROKE OFF, AND THEY SAW THAT HER NEUSTILS HAD GONE WHITE. SHE WENT ON, MORE CALMLY, "DIVINATION IS ONE OF THE MOST IMPRECISE BRANCHES OF MAGIC. I SHALL NOT CHARGE ANY OF YOU THAT I HAVE VERY LITTLE PATIENCE WITH IT. TRUE SEERS ARE VERY RARE, AND PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY --"

SHE STOPPED AGAIN, AND THEN SAID, IN A VERY MATTER-OF-FACT TONE, "YOU LOOK IN EXCELLENT HEALTH TO ME, BETTER, SO YOU WILL EXCUSE ME IF I DON'T LET YOU OFF HENCEFORTH TODAY. I ASSURE YOU THAT IF YOU DIE, YOU NEED NOT HAND IT IN."

HERMIONE LAUGHED. HARRY FELT A BIT BETTER. IT WAS HARDER TO FEEL SCARED OF A LUMP OF TEA LEAVES AWAY FROM THE DIM RED LIGHT AND KAZZLING PERLUME OF PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY'S CLASSROOM. NOT EVERYONE WAS CONVINCED, HOWEVER. RON STILL LOOKED WHIRLED, AND LAVENDER WHISPERED, "BUT WHAT ABOUT NEVILLE'S CLIP?"

WHEN THE TRANSCIGURATION CLASS HAD FINISHED, THEY THOUGHT THE WORLD

XX

THUNDERING TOWARD THE GREAT HALL HER BLIND.

"REEN, CHEER UP," SAID FERMINE, PUSHING A DISH OF STEW TOWARD HIM. "YOU
HEARD WHAT PROFESSOR MCENAGALL SAID."

REEN SPINNED STEW AROUND HIS PLATE AND PICKED UP HIS FORK BUT DIDN'T START.

"HARRY," HE SAID, IN A LOW, SERIOUS VOICE, "YOU HAVEN'T SEEN A GREAT
BLACK BEG ANYWHERE, HAVE YOU?"

"YES, I HAVE," SAID HARRY. "I SAW ONE THE NIGHT I LEFT THE DURSLEYS."

REEN LET HIS FORK FALL WITH A CLATTER.

"PROBABLY A STRAY," SAID FERMINE CALMLY.

REEN LOOKED AT FERMINE AS THOUGH SHE HAD GONE MAD.

"FERMINE, IF HARRY'S SEEN A GRIM, THAT'S -- THAT'S BAD," HE SAID. "MY
-- MY UNCLE KILIS SAW ONE AND -- AND HE DIED TWENTY-FOUR HOURS LATER!"

"COINCIDENCE," SAID FERMINE AIRILY, PHEERING HERSELF SOME PUMPKIN ILIC.

"YOU DON'T KNOW WHAT YOU'RE TALKING ABOUT!" SAID REEN, STARTING TO GET
ANGRY. "GRIMS SCARE THE LIVING DAYLIGHTS OUT OF MOST WIZARDS!"

"THERE YOU ARE, THEN," SAID FERMINE IN A SUPERIOR TONE. "THEY SEE THE
GRIM AND DIE OF FRIGHT. THE GRIM'S NOT AN ENEMY, IT'S THE CAUSE OF DEATH!
AND HARRY'S STILL WITH US BECAUSE HE'S NOT STUPID ENOUGH TO SEE ONE AND
THINK, RIGHT, WELL, I'D BETTER KICK THE BUCKET THEN!"

REEN PHEATED WHOLEHEARTEDLY AT FERMINE, WHO OPENED HER BAG, TOOK OUT HER
NEW

ARITHMANTY BOOK, AND PREPARED IT OPEN AGAINST THE ILIC ILIC.

"I THINK DIVINATION SEEMS VERY WEIRD," SHE SAID, SEARCHING FOR HER
PAGE. "A LOT OF GUESSEWORK, IF YOU ASK ME."

"THERE WAS NOTHING WEIRD ABOUT THE GRIM IN THAT CLIP!" SAID REEN HOTLY.

"YOU DIDN'T SEEM WHITE SHE COINCIDENT WHEN YOU WERE TELLING HARRY IT WAS A

XX

SLEEP," SAID FERMINE CHEERLY.

"PROFESSOR TRILANEY SAID YOU DIDN'T HAVE THE RIGHT ALRA! YOU JUST DIDN'T LIKE BEING BAD AT SOMETHING FOR A CHANGE!"

HE HAD THICKED A NERVE, FERMIENE SLAMMED HER ARITHMANCY BOOK DOWN ON THE

TABLE SHE HAD THAT BITS OF MEAT AND CARROT ALL OVERWHERE.

"IF BEING GOOD AT DIVINATION MEANS I HAVE TO PRETEND TO SEE DEATH IMAGENS IN A BUMP OF TEA LEAVES, I'M NOT SURE I'LL BE STUDYING IT MUCH LONGER!"

THAT LESSON WAS ABSOLUTELY BORING COMPARED WITH MY ARITHMANCY CLASS!" SHE SNATCHED UP HER BAG AND STALKED AWAY.

RHEN FOLLOWED AFTER HER.

"WHAT'S SHE TALKING ABOUT?" HE SAID TO HARRY. "SHE HASN'T BEEN TO AN ARITHMANCY CLASS YET."

HARRY WAS PLEASED TO GET OUT OF THE CASTLE AFTER LUNCH. YESTERDAY'S RAIN HAD CLEARED; THE SKY WAS A CLEAR, PALE GRAY, AND THE GRASS WAS SPRINGY AND DAMP UNDERNEATH AS THEY SET OFF FOR THEIR FIRST EVER LARK OF MAGICAL CREATURES CLASS.

RHEN AND FERMIENE WEREN'T SPEAKING TO EACH OTHER, HARRY WALKED BESIDE THEM IN SILENCE AS THEY WENT DOWN THE SLEEPING LAWS THE HAGRID'S HILT ON THE EDGE OF THE FORBIDDEN FOREST. IT WAS ONLY WHEN HE SPOTTED THREE ONLY-THREE FAMILIAR BACKS AHEAD OF THEM THAT HE REALIZED THEY MUST BE HAVING THESE LESSONS WITH THE SLYTHERINS. MALFOY WAS TALKING ANIMATEDLY TO CRABBE AND GOYLE, WHO WERE CHORTLING. HARRY WAS WHITE SURE HE KNEW WHAT THEY WERE TALKING ABOUT.

HAGRID WAS WAITING FOR HIS CLASS AT THE DOOR OF HIS HILT. HE STOOD IN HIS MULESKIN EVERWEAT, WITH LONG THE REAR-LEND AT HIS HEELS, LOOKING IMPATIENT TO START.

"WELL, WELL, GET A MOVE ON!" HE CALLED AS THE CLASS APPROACHED. "GOT A REAL TREAT FOR YOU TODAY! GREAT LESSON COMIN' UP! EVERYONE HERE? RIGHT,

SHHHH ME?"

NO

FOR ONE NASTY MOMENT, HARRY THOUGHT THAT HAGRID WAS GOING TO LEAD THEM INTO THE FOREST; HARRY HAD HAD ENOUGH UNPLEASANT EXPERIENCES IN THERE TO LAST HIM A LIFETIME. HOWEVER, HAGRID STUMBLED OFF AROUND THE EDGE OF THE TREES, AND FIVE MINUTES LATER, THEY FOUND THEMSELVES OUTSIDE A KIND OF Paddock. THERE WAS NOTHING IN THERE.

"EVERYONE GATHER 'ROUND THE FENCE HERE!" HE CALLED. "THAT'S IT -- MAKE SURE YOU CAN SEE -- WELL, FIRST THING YOU'LL WANT TO DO IS OPEN YOUR EYES --"

"HOW?" SAID THE CHILD, DRAWING VICE OF DRACH MALFOY.

"HOW?" SAID HAGRID.

"HOW DO WE OPEN OUR EYES?" MALFOY REPEATED, FOR THOSE WHO HAD HIS COPY OF THE

MINISTER BOOK OF MINISTERS, WHICH HE HAD FOUND SHUT WITH A LENGTH OF ROPE. EITHER PEOPLE THOSE THINGS WHO THOSE, SOME, LIKE HARRY, HAD KEPT THEIR EYES SHUT; OTHERS HAD CRAMPED THEM INSIDE TIGHT BAGS OR CLAMPED THEM TOGETHER WITH RIGID CLIPS.

"HASN'T -- HASN'T ANYONE BEEN ABLE TO OPEN THEIR EYES?" SAID HAGRID, LOOKING CRESTFALLEN.

THE CLASS ALL SHOOK THEIR HEADS.

"YOU'VE GOT TO STRIKE 'EM," SAID HAGRID, AS THOUGH THIS WAS THE MOST OBVIOUS THING IN THE WORLD. "HOW --"

FOR THOSE HARRY'S COPY AND RIPPED OFF THE SPELLTAPE THAT KEPT IT. THE BOOK TRIED TO KICK, BUT HAGRID RAN A GIANT THREE-FINGER DOWN ITS SPINE, AND THE BOOK SHIVERED, AND THEN FELL OPEN AND LAY FLAT IN HIS HAND.

"WELL, WELL SILLY WE'VE ALL BEEN!" MALFOY SNEERED. "WE SHOULD HAVE STRUCK THEM; WE DIDN'T WE GLASS?"

"I -- I THOUGHT THEY WERE FLINCH," FARRID SAID UNCERTAINLY THE FERMINE.
"HEY, TREMENDOUSLY FLINCH!" SAID MALTHEY. "REALLY WITTY, GIVING US KIDS
THAT TRY AND RIP OUR HANDS OFF?"

91

"SPLIT UP, MALTHEY," SAID FARRID QUIETLY. FARRID WAS LEERKING DOWNCAST AND
FARRID WANTED FARRID'S FIRST LESSON THE BE A SUCCESS.

"RIGHT! THEN," SAID FARRID, WHO SEEMED THE HAVE LOST HIS THREAD, "SEE -- SEE
YOU'VE GOT YOUR KIDS AND' -- AND' -- NOW YOU NEED THE MAGICAL CREATURES.
YEAH, SEE I'LL GO AND GET 'EM, FARRID HEH..."

HE STRODE AWAY FROM THEM INTO THE FOREST AND OUT OF SIGHT.

"GOD, THIS PLACE IS GIVING THE THE DEES," SAID MALTHEY LOUDLY. "THAT HAS
TEACHING CLASSES, MY FATHER'LL HAVE A FIT WHEN I TELL HIM

"SPLIT UP, MALTHEY," FARRID REPEATED.

CAREFULLY, BUTTER, THERE'S A DEMENTER BEHIND YOU

"HHHHHHHHH!" SQUEALING LAVENDER KIDNAP, POINTING TOWARD THE OPPOSITE SIDE
OF THE PADDOCK.

WAITING TOWARD THEM WERE A DOZEN OF THE MOST BIZARRE CREATURES FARRID
HAD EVER SEEN. THEY HAD THE BODIES, HIND LEGS, AND TAILS OF HORSES, BUT
THE FRONT LEGS, WINGS, AND HEADS OF WHAT SEEMED THE BE GIANT EAGLES, WITH
CURLY, STEEL-CLIMBED BEAKS AND LARGE, BRILLIANTLY, ORANGE EYES. THE
TAILS ON THEIR FRONT LEGS WERE HALF A FEET LONG AND DEADLY LEERKING.
EACH OF THE BEASTS HAD A THICK LEATHER COLLAR AROUND ITS NECK, WHICH WAS
ATTACHED TO A LONG CHAIN, AND THE ENDS OF ALL OF THESE WERE HELD IN THE
FAST HANDS OF FARRID, WHO CAME HOGGING INTO THE PADDOCK BEHIND THE
CREATURES.

"GET UP, THERE?" HE BEARED, SHAKING THE CHAINS AND LINGING THE CREATURES
TOWARD THE FENCE WHERE THE CLASS STOOD. EVERYONE DREW BACK SLIGHTLY AS

FLAGRID REACHED THEM AND TETHERED THE CREATURES TO THE FENCE.

"HIPPOGRIFFS?" FLAGRID BEAMED HAPPILY, LAYING A HAND AT THEM. "BEAUTIFUL, AREN'T THEY?"

FLARRY COULD SCART HE SEE WHAT FLAGRID MEANT, SINCE YELL GET OVER THE FIRST SENSE HE SEEING SOMETHING THAT WAS, HALF HORSE, HALF BIRD, YELL STARTED TO APPRECIATE THE HIPPOGRIFFS' GLEAMING COATS, CHANGING SWIFTLY FROM FEATHER TO HAIR, EACH OF THEM A DIFFERENT COLOR: STORMY GRAY, BROWNIE,

OR

PINKISH-RED, GLEAMING CHESTNUT, AND INKY BLACK.

"SEE," SAID FLAGRID, RUBBING HIS HANDS TOGETHER AND BEAMING AROUND. "IF YOU WANT TO COME A BIT NEARER --"

THE THREE SEEMED TO WANT TO, FLARRY, RENN, AND HERMINE, HOWEVER, APPROACHED THE FENCE CAUTIOUSLY.

"WELL, FIRST THING YOU GOTTA KNOW ABOUT HIPPOGRIFFS IS, THEY'RE PREY," SAID FLAGRID. "EASILY OFFENDED, HIPPOGRIFFS ARE, DON'T NEVER INSULT ONE, 'CAUSE IT MIGHT BE THE LAST THING YOU SEE."

MALPHE, CRABBE, AND GEMPLE WEREN'T LISTENING; THEY WERE TALKING IN AN UNDERTONE AND FLARRY HAD A NASTY FEELING THEY WERE PLOTTING HOW BEST TO DISRUPT THE LESSON.

"YOU ALWAYS WAIT FOR THE HIPPOGRIFF TO MAKE THE FIRST MOVE," FLAGRID CONTINUED. "IT'S PRETTY, SEE? YOU WALK TOWARD HIM, AND YOU KNOW, AND YOU WAIT. IF HE KNOWS BACK, YOU'RE ALLOWED TO TOUCH HIM. IF HE DOESN'T KNOW, THEN GET AWAY FROM HIM SHARPISH. 'CAUSE THESE THINGS HURT."

"RIGHT -- WHO WANTS TO GO FIRST?"

MOST OF THE CLASS BACKED FARTHER AWAY IN ANSWER. EVEN FLARRY, RENN, AND HERMINE HAD MISGIVINGS. THE HIPPOGRIFFS WERE TWISTING THEIR PIERCE HEADS AND FLEXING THEIR PHEWRAIL WINGS; THEY DIDN'T SEEM TO LIKE BEING TETHERED LIKE THIS.

"OH HEN?" SAID HAGRID, WITH A PLEADING LOOK.

"I'LL DO IT," SAID HARRY.

THERE WAS AN INTAKE OF BREATH FROM BEHIND HIM, AND BOTH LAVENDER AND

PARYATI WHISPERED, "HEHEH, YES, HARRY, REMEMBER YOUR TEA LEAVES?"

HARRY IGNORED THEM, HE CLIMBED OVER THE PADDOCK FENCE.

"GOOD MAN, HARRY!" REARED HAGRID. "RIGHT THEN -- LET'S SEE HOW YOU GET ON WITH KICKLEHEAD."

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HE LUNTED OVER THE CHAINS, PULLED THE GRAY HIPPOGRIF AWAY FROM ITS PELLEWS, AND SLIPPED OFF ITS LEATHER CHILLAR. THE CLASS ON THE EITHER SIDE OF THE PADDOCK SEEMED TO BE HOLDING ITS BREATH. MALFOY'S EYES WERE NARROWED MALICIOUSLY.

"EASY! YES, HARRY," SAID HAGRID QUIETLY. "YOU'VE GOTTEN EYE CONTACT, NOW TRY NOT TO BLINK... HIPPOGRIF'S DON'T TRUST YOU IF YOU BLINK THEM MUCH..."

HARRY'S EYES IMMEDIATELY BEGAN TO WATER, BUT HE DIDN'T FEEL THEM.

KICKLEHEAD HAD TURNED HIS GREAT, SHARP HEAD AND WAS STARING AT HARRY WITH ONE FIERCE ORANGE EYE. "THAT'S IT," SAID HAGRID. "THAT'S IT, HARRY... YES, YES."

HARRY DIDN'T FEEL MUCH LIKE EXPRESSING THE BACK OF HIS NECK TO KICKLEHEAD, BUT HE DID AS HE WAS TOLD. HE GAVE A SHORT YES AND THEN LOOKED UP.

THE HIPPOGRIF WAS STILL STARING HALIGHTLY AT HIM. IT DIDN'T MOVE.

"AH," SAID HAGRID, SOUNDING BEHIND. "RIGHT -- BACK AWAY, YES, HARRY, EASY DOES IT"

BUT THEN, TO HARRY'S ENORMOUS SURPRISE, THE HIPPOGRIF SUDDENLY KENT ITS STALY FRONT KNEES AND DROPPED INTO WHAT WAS AN UNMISTAKABLE YES.

"WELL DONE, HARRY!" SAID HAGRID, ECSTATIC. "RIGHT -- YOU CAN THANK HIM!"

PAT HIS HEAD, CHEERFULLY.

FEELING THAT A BETTER REWARD WOULD HAVE BEEN THE SAME AS A PAT, HARRY MOVED
SWIFTLY TOWARD THE HIPPOGRIF AND REACHED OUT TOWARD IT. HE PATTED THE
HEAD SEVERAL TIMES AND THE HIPPOGRIF CLOSED ITS EYES LAZILY, AS THOUGH
ENJOYING IT.

THE CLASS BROKE INTO APPLAUSE, ALL EXCEPT THE MALFOYS, CRABBE, AND GOYLE,
WHO WERE LOOKING DEEPLY DISAPPOINTED.

"RIGHT! THEN, HARRY," SAID Hagrid. "I THINK HE MIGHT LET YOU RIDE HIM!"

THIS WAS MORE THAN HARRY HAD BARGAINED FOR. HE WAS USED TO A BROOMSTICK,
BUT HE WASN'T SURE A HIPPOGRIF WOULD BE EXACTLY THE SAME.

79

"YOU CLIMB UP THERE, IT'S BEHIND THE WING HINT," SAID Hagrid. "AND MIND
YOU DON'T PULL ANY OF HIS FEATHERS OUT, HE WON'T LIKE THAT..."

HARRY PUT HIS FEET IN THE THOPE OF BLUBBER'S WING AND HESITATED HIMSELF ABOUT
ITS BACK. BLUBBER STOOD UP. HARRY WASN'T SURE WHERE TO HOLD ON;
EVERYTHING IN FRONT OF HIM WAS COVERED WITH FEATHERS.

"CHEER! THEN!" ROARED Hagrid, SLAPPING THE HIPPOGRIF'S HINDQUARTERS.
WITHOUT WARNING, TWELVE-FOOT WINGS FLAPPED OPEN ON EITHER SIDE OF HARRY.
HE JUST HAD TIME TO SEIZE THE HIPPOGRIF AROUND THE NECK BEFORE HE WAS
SHARING UPWARD. IT WAS NOTHING LIKE A BROOMSTICK, AND HARRY KNEW WHICH
ONE HE PREFERRED. THE HIPPOGRIF'S WINGS BEAT UNCEASANTLY ON EITHER
SIDE OF HIM, CATCHING HIM UNDER HIS LEGS AND MAKING HIM FEEL HE WAS
ABOUT TO BE THROWN OFF. THE GLASSY FEATHERS SLIPPED UNDER HIS FINGERS
AND HE DIDN'T DARE GET A STRONGER GRIP. INSTEAD OF THE SMOOTH ACTION OF
HIS NIMBUS TWO THOUSAND, HE NOW FELT HIMSELF ROCKING BACKWARD AND
FORWARD AS THE HINDQUARTERS OF THE HIPPOGRIF ROSE AND FELL WITH ITS
WINGS.

CLICKHEAD FLEW HIM BACK AROUND THE PADDOCK AND THEN HEADED BACK TO THE
GRILLING; THIS WAS THE KIT HARRY HAD BEEN DREADING; HE LEANED BACK AS THE
SMOOTH NECK WHISPERED, FEELING HE WAS GOING TO SLIP OFF EVERY TIME HEAD,
THEN FELT A HEAVY THUD AS THE POOR ILL-ASSORTED FEET HIT THE GRILLING. HE
JUST MANAGED TO HOLD ON AND PUSH HIMSELF STRAIGHT AGAIN.

"GOOD WORK, HARRY!" REARED LACRID AS EVERYONE EXCEPT MALPHY, CRABBE, AND
GOYLE CHEERED. "HOW, WHEN ELSE WANTS A GO?"

EMBOLDENED BY HARRY'S SUCCESS, THE REST OF THE CLASS CLIMBED CALMLY INTO
THE PADDOCK. LACRID LINTED THE HIPPOGRIFTS ONE BY ONE, AND SEEN
PEOPLE WERE BEHAVING NERVOUSLY, ALL OVER THE PADDOCK. NEVILLE RAN
REPEATEDLY BACKWARD FROM HIS, WHICH DIDN'T SEEM TO WANT TO END ITS
DANCE. RON AND HERMIONIE PRACTICED ON THE CHESTNUT, WHILE HARRY WATCHED.
MALPHY, CRABBE, AND GOYLE HAD TAKEN OVER CLICKHEAD. HE HAD KICKED THE
MALPHY, WHEN WAS NOW PATTING HIS HEAD, BEHAVING DISDAINFUL.

"THIS IS VERY EASY," MALPHY DRAINED, BEING ENOUGH FOR HARRY TO HEAR HIM.

AS

"I KNOW IT MUST HAVE BEEN, IF BETTER CHILD DO IT... I GET YOU'RE NOT
DANGEROUS AT ALL, ARE YOU?" HE SAID TO THE HIPPOGRIFTS. "ARE YOU, YOU
GREAT LITTLE KILLER?"

IT HAPPENED IN A FLASH OF STEELY TALENTS; MALPHY LET OUT A HIGH-PITCHED
SCREAM AND NEXT MOMENT, LACRID WAS WRESTLING CLICKHEAD BACK INTO HIS
CELLAR AS HE STRAINED TO GET AT MALPHY, WHO WAS CURLED IN THE GRASS,
BLEEDING BLESSEING OVER HIS REEKS.

"I'M DYING!" MALPHY YELLED AS THE CLASS PANICKED. "I'M DYING, LOOK AT
ME! IT'S KILLED ME!"

"PER NOT DYING!" SAID LACRID, WHO HAD GONE VERY WHITE. "SOMEONE HELP ME
-- GETTA GET HIM HELTTA HERE --"

HERMIONE RAN THE FIELD WHEN THE GATE AS HARRY LIFTED MALPHY EASILY. AS THEY PASSED, HARRY SAW THAT THERE WAS A LONG, DEEP GASH IN MALPHY'S ARM; BLOOD SPLATTERED THE GRASS AND HARRY RAN WITH HIM, UP THE SLOPE TOWARD THE CASTLE.

VERY SHAKEN, THE CARE OF MAGICAL CREATURES CLASS PHEELED AT A WALK. THE SLYTHERINS WERE ALL SMILING ABOUT HARRY.

"THEY SHOULD FIRE HIM STRAIGHT AWAY!" SAID PANSY PARKINSON, WHO WAS IN TEARS.

"IT WAS MALPHY'S FAULT!" SNAPPED DEAN THOMAS. CRABBE AND GOYLE FLEXED THEIR MUSCLES THREATENINGLY.

THEY ALL CLIMBED THE STONE STEPS INTO THE DESERTED ENTRANCE HALL.

"I'M GOING TO SEE IF HE'S DEAD!" SAID PANSY, AND THEY ALL WATCHED HER RUN UP THE MARBLE STAIRCASE. THE SLYTHERINS, STILL SMILING ABOUT HARRY, HEADED AWAY IN THE DIRECTION OF THEIR DUNGEON CHAMBERS WHEN HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONE PROCEEDED UPSTAIRS TO GRYPFINDER TOWER.

"WELL THINK HE'LL BE ALL RIGHT!" SAID HERMIONE NERVOUSLY.

"WHEN HE WILL, MADAM POMFREY CAN MEND CUTS IN ABOUT A SECOND," SAID HARRY, WHO HAD HAD FAR WORSE INJURIES MENDED MAGICALLY BY THE NURSE.

XX

"THAT WAS A REALLY BAD THING THAT HAPPEN IN HARRY'S FIRST CLASS, THOUGH, WASN'T IT?" SAID RON, LOOKING WORRIED. "TRUST MALPHY TO DO THINGS UP FOR HIM..."

THEY WERE AMONG THE FIRST TO REACH THE GREAT HALL AT DINNER TIME, FINDING THE SEE HARRY, BUT HE WASN'T THERE.

"THEY WOULDN'T FIRE HIM, WOULD THEY?" SAID HERMIONE ANXIOUSLY, MEET THINKING HER STARK-AND-BOLD PLEADING.

"THEY'D BETTER NOT," SAID RON, WHO WASN'T EATING EITHER.

HARRY WAS WATCHING THE SLYTHERIN TABLE. A LARGE GROUP INCLUDING CRABBE AND GOYLE WAS Huddled TOGETHER, DEEP IN CONVERSATION. HARRY WAS SURE THEY WERE CHECKING UP THEIR MEN VERSION OF FRED MALFOY HAD BEEN INJURED. "WELL, YOU CAN'T SAY IT WASN'T AN INTERESTING FIRST DAY BACK," SAID DEAN GLENNILLY.

THEY WENT UP THE THE CRUMLED GRYFFINDOR CHIMNEY AFTER DINNER AND TRIED TO DO THE HOMEWORK PROFESSOR MCGRAGALL HAD GIVEN THEM, BUT ALL THREE OF THEM KEPT BREAKING OFF AND GLANCING OUT OF THE THICK WINDOWS. "THERE'S A LIGHT ON IN Hagrid's WINDOW," HARRY SAID SUDDENLY. DEAN LOOKED AT HIS WATCH.

"IF WE HURRIED, WE COULD GO DOWN AND SEE HIM. IT'S STILL EARLY..." "I DIDN'T KNOW," HERMIONIE SAID SILENTLY, AND HARRY SAW HER GLANCE AT HIM. "I'M ALLOWED TO WALK ACROSS THE GRIMLODS," HE SAID POINTEDLY. "SIRIUS BLACK HASN'T GOTTEN PAST THE BERTHENS YET, HAS HE?"

SEE THEY PUT THEIR THINGS AWAY AND HEADED OUT OF THE PORTRAIT HOLE, GLAD THE MEET NEIGHBY ON THEIR WAY TO THE FRONT DOORS, AS THEY WEREN'T ENTIRELY SURE THEY WERE SUPPOSED TO BE OUT.

THE GRASS WAS STILL WET AND LOOKED ALMOST BLACK IN THE TWILIGHT. WHEN

99

THEY REACHED Hagrid's HUT, THEY KNOCKED, AND A VOICE GROANED. "T'AIN." Hagrid WAS SITTING IN HIS SHIRT-SLEEVES AT HIS SCRUBBED WOODEN TABLE; HIS RHINO-HORN, FANG, HAD HIS HEAD IN Hagrid's LAP. HENK WOOD TOLD THEM THAT Hagrid HAD BEEN DRINKING A LITTLE; THERE WAS A PLETER TARDAR ALMOST AS BIG AS A CRICKET IN FRONT OF HIM, AND HE SEEMED TO BE HAVING DIFFICULTY GETTING THEM INTO THE HILLS.

"SPEAK IT'S A RECORD," HE SAID THICKLY, WHEN HE RECOGNIZED THEM. "DEAN" RECOGNIZED THEY'VE EVER HAD A TEACHER WHO LASTED MORE THAN A DAY BEFORE."

"THEY HAVEN'T BEEN FIRED, LACRID," GASTED FERMINE.

"NOT YET," SAID LACRID MISERABLY, TAKING A FLICE CLIP OF WHATEVER WAS IN THE TANKARD. "BUT IT'S ONLY A MATTER OF TIME, I'N'T IT, AFTER MALTHEY..."

"HE'S HERE?" SAID REIN AS THEY ALL SAT DOWN. "IT WASN'T SERIOUS, WAS IT?"

"MADAM PHEMPREY FIXED HIM BEST SHE COULD," SAID LACRID DULLY. "BUT HE'S SAYIN' IT'S STILL ACHIN'... COVERED IN BANDAGES... MEANIN'..

"HE'S FAKING IT," SAID LARRY AT ONCE. "MADAM PHEMPREY CAN MEND ANYTHING. SHE RECOVERED HALF MY KNEES LAST YEAR. TELL ME MALTHEY THE MILD IT FOR ALL IT'S WORTH."

"SOMEHOW THEY'VE HAD KIN THEM, HE' CHURSE," SAID LACRID MISERABLY. "THEY RECKEN I STARTED THEM RIG. SHE'LLA LEFT HIPPHICRIFFS FOR LATER... DENY FLEKKERHEIMS HER SLUTTAT... ILIS' TELL-IT IT MAKE A GOOD FIRE' LESSENS ALL MY PAIN..."

"IT'S ALL MALTHEY'S FAULT, LACRID," SAID FERMINE EARNESTLY.

"WE'RE WITNESSES," SAID LARRY. "THEY SAID HIPPHICRIFFS ATTACK IF THEY INSULT THEM. IT'S MALTHEY'S PROBLEM THAT HE WASN'T LISTENING. WE'LL TELL DUMKLEHIRE WHAT REALLY HAPPENED."

"YEAH, DEN'T WORRY, LACRID, WE'LL BACK THEM UP," SAID REIN.

TEARS LEAKED OUT OF THE CRINKLED CORNERS OF LACRID'S BEETLE-BLACK EYES. HE GRABBED BOTH LARRY AND REIN AND PULLED THEM INTO A KNEE-BREAKING HUG.

XX

"I THINK THEY'VE HAD ENOUGH THE DRINK, LACRID," SAID FERMINE FIRMLY. SHE THREW THE TANKARD FROM THE TABLE AND WENT ELTISIDE THE EMPTY IT.

"AT, MAYBE SHE'S RIGHT," SAID LACRID, LETTING GO OF LARRY AND REIN, WHO BOTH STAGGERED AWAY, BLINKING THEIR EYES. LACRID HEAVED HIMSELF UP FROM HIS CHAIR AND SWAYED FERMINE UNSTABLY ELTISIDE. THEY HEARD A LUD SPLASH.

"WHAT'S HE THINK?" SAID HARRY NERVELISLY AS HERMIONE CAME BACK IN WITH THE EMPTY TANKARD.

"STUCK HIS HEAD IN THE WATER BARREL," SAID HERMIONE, PLUTTING THE TANKARD AWAY.

HAGRID CAME BACK, HIS LONG HAIR AND BEARD SHEDDING WET, WIPING THE WATER FROM HIS EYES.

"THAT'S BETTER," HE SAID, SHAKING HIS HEAD LIKE A BEG AND DRENCHING THEM ALL. "LISTEN, IT WAS GOOD OF YOU TWO TO COME AND SEE ME, I REALLY --

HAGRID STOPPED DEAD, STARING AT HARRY AS THOUGH HE'D ONLY JUST REALIZED HE WAS THERE.

"WHAT DO YOU THINK YOU'RE DOING, EH?" HE ROARED, SHE SLIDDERLY THAT THEY

KLIMPED A FEET IN THE AIR. "YOU'RE NOT THE ONE WANDERIN' AROUND AFTER

DARK,

HARRY: AND YOU TWO LETTIN' HIM?"

HAGRID STRODE OVER THE HARRY, GRABBED HIS ARM, AND PULLED HIM THE THE DOOR.

"MINE!" HAGRID SAID ANGERILY. "I'M TAKIN' YOU ALL BACK UP TO SCHOOL, AND THEN LET ME CATCH YOU WALKIN' DOWN TO SEE ME AFTER DARK AGAIN. I'M NOT WORTH THAT?"

CHAPTER SEVEN

THE BEGGART IN THE WARDROBE

77

MALFOY DIDN'T REAPPEAR IN CLASSES UNTIL LATE IN THURSDAY MORNING, WHEN THE SLYTHERINS AND GRUFFINDERS WERE HALFWAY THROUGH DOUBLE POTIONS. HE SLUGGERED INTO THE DINGED, HIS RIGHT ARM COVERED IN BANDAGES AND HUNG UP IN A SLING, ACTING, IN HARRY'S MIND, AS THOUGH HE WERE THE HEROIC

SURVIVOR OF SOME DREADFUL BATTLE.

"HOW IS IT, DRAGON?" SIMPERED PANSY PARKINSON. "DID IT HURT MUCH?"

"Yeah," said Malfoy, putting on a brave sort of grimace, but Harry saw him wince at Crabbe and Goyle when Pansy had looked away.

"SETTLE DOWN, SETTLE DOWN," SAID PROFESSOR SNAPE IDLY.

Harry and Ron sneaked at each other; Snape wouldn't have said "SETTLE DOWN" if they'd walked in late, he'd have given them detention, but Malfoy had always been able to get away with anything in Snape's classes; Snape was head of Slytherin House, and generality favored his own students above all others.

They were making a new potion today, a Shrinking Solution, Malfoy set up

his cauldron right next to the Harry and Ron, so that they were preparing their ingredients on the same table.

"Sir," Malfoy called, "sir, I'll need help cutting up these daisy roots, because of my arm --"

"Weasley, cut up Malfoy's roots for him," said Snape without looking up, Ron went brick red.

"THERE'S NOTHING WRONG WITH YOUR ARM," HE HISSED AT MALFOY.

MALFOY SMIRKED ACROSS THE TABLE.

"WEASLEY, YOU HEARD PROFESSOR SNAPE; CUT UP THESE ROOTS."

Ron seized his knife, pulled Malfoy's roots toward him, and began to chop them obediently, so that they were all different sizes.

"PROFESSOR," DRAINED MALFOY, "WEASLEY'S MUTILATING MY ROOTS, SIR."

1000

SNAPE APPROACHED THEIR TABLE, STARED DOWN HIS BECKED NECK AT THE ROOTS, THEN GAVE RON AN UNPLEASANT SMILE FROM BENEATH HIS LONG, GREASY BLACK HAIR.

"CHANGE REEHTS WITH MALPHE, LEASLEY,"

"BLIT, SIT --"

REHN HAD SPENT THE LAST QUARTER OF AN HOUR CAREFULLY SPREADING HIS REHN
REEHTS INTO EXACTLY REHNAL PIECES.

"NEHN," SAID SNAPE IN HIS MOST DANGEROUS VEHICLE.

REHN STAYED HIS REHN REALTICALLY BLIT REEHTS ACROSS THE TABLE AT MALPHE,
THEN THUNK UP THE KNIFE AGAIN.

"AND, SIR, I'LL NEED THIS ST-RIVELTIC SKINNED," SAID MALPHE, HIS VEHICLE
FULL OF MALICIOUS LAUGHTER.

"BETTER, YELL CAN SKIN MALPHE'S ST-RIVELTIC," SAID SNAPE, GIVING HARRY THE
LOOK OF WEATHING HE ALWAYS RESERVED JUST FOR HIM.

HARRY THUNK MALPHE'S ST-RIVELTIC AS REHN BEGAN TRYING TO REPAIR THE DAMAGE
TO THE REEHTS HE NEHN HAD THE USE. HARRY SKINNED THE ST-RIVELTIC AS FAST AS
HE COULD AND FLUNG IT BACK ACROSS THE TABLE AT MALPHE WITHOUT SPREADING.
MALPHE WAS SMIRKING MORE BROADLY THAN EVER.

"SEEN YELLER PAL HAGRID LATELY?" HE ASKED THEM QUIETLY.

"NEHN OF YELLER BUSINESS," SAID REHN IRRITABLY, WITHOUT WHISKING UP.

"I'M AFRAID HE WOEN'T BE A TEACHER MUCH LONGER," SAID MALPHE IN A TONE OF
MUCH SHREWD. "FATHER'S NOT VERY HAPPY ABOUT MY INILTY --"

"KEEP TALKING, MALPHE, AND I'LL GIVE YELL A REAL INILTY," SPARKED REHN.

"- HE'S COMPLAINED TO THE SEVEN GOVERNORS, AND THE THE MINISTRY OF
MAGIC. FATHER'S GOT A LOT OF INFLUENCE, YELL KNOW, AND A LASTING INILTY
LIKE THIS" -- HE GAVE A FLICE, FAKE SIGH -- "WELL KNOWS IF MY ARM'LL EVER

101

BE THE SAME AGAIN?"

"SEE THAT'S WHY YELL'RE PUTTING IT ON," SAID HARRY, ACCIDENTALLY RE-READING
A DEAD CATERPILLAR BECAUSE HIS HAND WAS SHAKING IN ANGER. "THEY TRY TO GET

"MAGRID FIRED."

"WELL," SAID MALPHY, WHEELING HIS VEHICLE THE A WHISPER, "PARTLY, BETTER, BUT THERE ARE OTHER BENEFITS TOO, WEASLEY, SLICE MY CATERPILLARS FOR ME."

A FEW CALIBRENS AWAY, NEVILLE WAS IN TROUBLE. NEVILLE REGULARLY WENT THE PIECES IN PENTHENS LESSONS; IT WAS HIS WORST SUBJECT, AND HIS GREAT FEAR OF PROFESSOR Snape MADE THINGS TEN TIMES WORSE. HIS PENTHEN, WHICH WAS SLIPPED THE BE A BRIGHT, ACID GREEN, HAD TURNED --

"ERANGE, LENGTHEN," SAID Snape, LADLING SOME UP AND ALLOWING THE SPLASH BACK INTO THE CALIBREN, SEE THAT EVERYONE COULD SEE.

"ERANGE. TELL ME, WHY DOES ANYTHING PENETRATE THAT THICK SKULL OF YOURS? DIDN'T YOU HEAR ME SAY, ELITE CLEARLY, THAT ONLY ONE -TAT SPEEN WAS NEEDED? DIDN'T I STATE PLAINLY THAT A DASH OF BEECH ILICE WOULD SUFFICE? WHAT DO I HAVE TO DO TO MAKE YOU UNDERSTAND, LENGTHEN?" NEVILLE WAS PINK AND TREMBLING. HE WHEEZED AS THOUGH HE WAS ON THE VERGE OF TEARS.

"PLEASE, SIR," SAID HERMIONE, "PLEASE, I COULD HELP NEVILLE PUT IT RIGHT --"

"I DIDN'T REMEMBER ASKING YOU THE ST-HEW OF, MISS GRANGER," SAID Snape COLDLY, AND HERMIONE WENT AS PINK AS NEVILLE. "LENGTHEN, AT THE END OF THIS LESSON WE WILL FEED A FEW DROPS OF THIS PENTHEN TO YOUR HEAD AND SEE WHAT HAPPENS. PERHAPS THAT WILL ENCOURAGE YOU TO DO IT PROPERLY." Snape MOVED AWAY, LEAVING NEVILLE BREATHLESS WITH FEAR.

"HELP ME?" HE MEANED THE HERMIONE.

"HEY, HARRY," SAID SEamus FINNIGAN, LEANING OVER THE BARRICADE HARRY'S GRASS STALKS, "HAVE YOU HEARD? DAILY PROPHET THIS MORNING -- THEY RECKON

STRIPS BLACK'S BEEN SIGHTED."

"WHERE?" SAID HARRY AND RON QUICKLY, FROM THE OTHER SIDE OF THE TABLE, MALPHY LEANED UP, LISTENING CLOSELY.

"NOT TOO FAR FROM HERE," SAID SEamus, WHO LEANED FORWARDED, "IT WAS A MUGGLE WHO SAW HIM, 'CAUSE, SHE DIDN'T REALLY UNDERSTAND, THE MUGGLES THINK HE'S JUST AN ORDINARY CRIMINAL, DON'T THEY? SHE SHE PHONED THE TELEPHONE HOT LINE, BY THE TIME THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC GOT THERE, HE WAS GONE."

"NOT TOO FAR FROM HERE..." RON REPEATED, LEANING SIGNIFICANTLY AT HARRY, HE TURNED AROUND AND SAW MALPHY WATCHING CLOSELY, "WHAT, MALPHY? NEED SOMETHING ELSE SKINNED?"

BUT MALPHY'S EYES WERE SHINING MALICIOUSLY, AND THEY WERE FIXED HARRY,

HE LEANED ACROSS THE TABLE,

BLACK SINGLE-HANDED, BETTER?"

"THINKING OF TRYING THE LATCH

"YEAH, THAT'S RIGHT," SAID HARRY OFF-HANDLY,

MALPHY'S THIN MOUTH WAS CURVING IN A MEAN SMILE,

"HE 'CAUSE, IF IT WAS ME," HE SAID QUIETLY, "I'D HAVE DONE SOMETHING BEFORE NOW, I WOULDN'T BE STAYING IN SCHOOL LIKE A GOOD BOY, I'D BE OUT THERE LOOKING FOR HIM."

"WHAT ARE YOU TALKING ABOUT, MALPHY?" SAID RON QUIETLY,

"DON'T YOU KNOW, BETTER?" BREATHED MALPHY, HIS DARK EYES NARROWED,

"KNOW WHAT?"

MALPHY LET OUT A LOW, SNICKING LAUGH,

"MAYBE YOU'D RATHER NOT RISK YOUR NECK," HE SAID, "WANT TO LEAVE IT TO THE DEMENTORS, DO YOU? BUT IF IT WAS ME, I'D WANT REVENGE, I'D HUNT HIM

DOWN MYSELF."

"WHAT ARE YOU TALKING ABOUT?" SAID HARRY ANGRILY, BUT AT THAT MOMENT SNAPE CALLED, "YOU SHOULD HAVE FINISHED ADDING YOUR INGREDIENTS BY NOW; THIS POTION NEEDS THE STEW BEFORE IT CAN BE DRUNK, SEE CLEAR AWAY WHILE IT SIMMERS AND THEN WE'LL TEST LONGBOTTLE'S..."

CRAKE AND COLE LAUGHED HEAVILY, WATCHING NEVILLE SWEAT AS HE STIRRED HIS POTION FEVERISHLY. HERMIONE WAS MUTTERING INSTRUCTIONS TO HIM FROM THE CORNER OF HER MOUTH, SEE THAT SNAPE WOULDN'T SEE. HARRY AND RON PACKED AWAY THEIR UNUSED INGREDIENTS AND WENT TO WASH THEIR HANDS AND LADLES IN THE STONE BASIN IN THE CORNER.

"WHAT DID MALFOY MEAN?" HARRY MUTTERED TO RON AS HE STUCK HIS HANDS UNDER THE ICE ICE THAT COVERED FROM THE GARGOYLE'S MOUTH. "WHY WOULDN'T I WANT REVENGE ON BLACK? HE HASN'T DONE ANYTHING TO ME -- YET."

"HE'S MAKING IT UP," SAID RON SAVAGELY. "HE'S TRYING TO MAKE YOU SEE SOMETHING STUPID..."

THE END OF THE LESSON IN SIGHT, SNAPE STRIDE OVER TO NEVILLE, WHO WAS CHEWING ON HIS CALIBRE.

"EVERYONE GATHER 'ROUND," SAID SNAPE, HIS BLACK EYES GLITTERING, AND WATCH WHAT HAPPENS TO LONGBOTTLE'S TEAD. IF HE HAS MANAGED TO PRODUCE A SHRINKING SOLUTION, IT WILL SHRINK THE TADPOLE. IF, AS I DIDN'T EXPECT, HE HAS DONE IT WRONG, HIS TEAD IS LIKELY TO BE POISONED."

THE GRYFFINDORS WATCHED FEARFULLY. THE SLYTHERINS LOOKED EXCITED. SNAPE PICKED UP TREYER THE TEAD IN HIS LEFT HAND AND DIPPED A SMALL SPOON INTO NEVILLE'S POTION, WHICH WAS NOW GREEN. HE TRICKLED A FEW DROPS DOWN TREYER'S THROAT.

THERE WAS A MOMENT OF FLISHED SILENCE, IN WHICH TREYER GLIPED; THEN THERE WAS A SMALL POP, AND TREYER THE TADPOLE WAS WRIGGLING IN SNAPE'S PALM. THE GRYFFINDORS BURST INTO APPLAUSE. SNAPE, LOOKING SERIOUS, PULLED A SMALL BOTTLE FROM THE POCKET OF HIS ROBE, POURED A FEW DROPS INTO THE OF TREYER,

AND HE REAPPEARED SUDDENLY, FULLY GREEN.

1099

"FIVE POINTS FROM GRYPFINDER," SAID SNAPE, WHICH WIPED THE SMILES FROM EVERY FACE. "I TELL YOU NEXT TIME HELP HIM, MISS GRANGER, CLASS DISMISSED." HARRY, RON, AND HERMION CLIMBED THE STEPS TO THE ENTRANCE HALL. HARRY WAS STILL THINKING ABOUT WHAT MALFOY HAD SAID, WHILE RON WAS SPEERING ABOUT SNAPE.

"FIVE POINTS FROM GRYPFINDER BECAUSE THE POINTS WAS ALL RIGHT? WHY DIDN'T YOU LIE, HERMION? YOU SHOULD'VE SAID NEVILLE DID IT ALL BY HIMSELF?"

HERMION DIDN'T ANSWER, RON LOOKED AROUND.

"WHERE IS SHE?"

HARRY TURNED THEM. THEY WERE AT THE TOP OF THE STEPS NOW, WATCHING THE REST OF THE CLASS PASS THEM, HEADING FOR THE GREAT HALL AND LUNCH.

"SHE WAS RIGHT BEHIND US," SAID RON, FROWNING.

MALFOY PASSED THEM, WALKING BETWEEN CRABBE AND GOYLE. HE SMIRKED AT HARRY AND DISAPPEARED.

"THERE SHE IS," SAID HARRY.

HERMION WAS PANTING SLIGHTLY, CLIMBING UP THE STAIRS; HER HAND CLUTCHED HER BAG, THE OTHER SEEMED TO BE TAPPING SOMETHING DOWN THE FRONT OF HER PANTS.

"HOW DID YOU DO THAT?" SAID RON.

"WHAT?" SAID HERMION, BEHIND THEM.

"ONE MINUTE YOU WERE RIGHT BEHIND US, THE NEXT MOMENT, YOU WERE BACK AT THE BOTTOM OF THE STAIRS AGAIN."

"WHAT?" HERMION LOOKED SLIGHTLY CONFUSED. "EH -- I HAD THE GUN BACK FOR SOMETHING, EH NEH --"

A SEAM HAD SPLIT HIS FERMINE'S BAG. HARRY WASN'T SURPRISED; HE COULD SEE THAT IT WAS CRAMPED WITH AT LEAST A DOZEN LARGE AND HEAVY BOOKS.

"WHO ARE YOU CARRYING ALL THESE AROUND WITH YOU?" REEN ASKED HER.

"YOU KNOW HOW MANY SUBJECTS I'M TAKING," SAID FERMINNE BRATELESSLY.

"COULDN'T YOU TAKE THESE FOR ME, CHILD YOU?"

"BUT --" REEN WAS TURNING OVER THE BOOKS SHE HAD HANDS HIM, LOOKING AT THE COVERS. "YOU HAVEN'T GOTTEN ANY OF THESE SUBJECTS TODAY, IT'S ONLY DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS THIS AFTERNOON."

"OH YES," SAID FERMINNE VAGUELY, BUT SHE PACKED ALL THE BOOKS BACK INTO HER BAG JUST THE SAME. I HOPE THERE'S SOMETHING GOOD FOR LUNCH, I'M STARVING," SHE ADDED, AND SHE MARCHED OFF TOWARD THE GREAT HALL.

"DO YOU GET THE FEELING FERMINNE'S NOT TELLING US SOMETHING?" REEN ASKED HARRY.

PROFESSOR BLIPIN WASN'T THERE WHEN THEY ARRIVED AT HIS FIRST DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS LESSON. THEY ALL SAT DOWN, TOOK OUT THEIR BOOKS, PENCILS, AND PARCHMENT, AND WERE TALKING WHEN HE FINALLY ENTERED THE ROOM. BLIPIN SMILED VAGUELY AND PLACED HIS TATTY OLD BRIECASE ON THE TEACHER'S DESK. HE WAS AS SHAKY AS EVER BUT LOOKED HEALTHIER THAN HE HAD BEEN THE TRAIN, AS THOUGH HE HAD HAD A FEW SOLID MEALS.

"GOOD AFTERNOON," HE SAID. "WOULD YOU PLEASE PUT ALL YOUR BOOKS BACK IN YOUR BAGS. TODAY'S WILL BE A PRACTICAL LESSON. YOU WILL NEED ONLY YOUR WANDS."

A FEW CURIOUS LOOKS WERE EXCHANGED AS THE CLASS PUT AWAY THEIR BOOKS. THEY HAD NEVER HAD A PRACTICAL DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS BEFORE, UNLESS YOU COUNTED THE MEMORABLE CLASS LAST YEAR WHEN THEIR OLD TEACHER HAD BROUGHT A CAGGLE OF PIXIES INTO THE CLASS AND SET THEM FREE.

"RIGHT THEN," SAID PROFESSOR LUPIN, WHEN EVERYONE WAS READY. "IF YOU'D ALLOWED ME,"

PURPLED BUT INTERESTED, THE CLASS GOT TO ITS FEET AND ALLOWED PROFESSOR LUPIN TO LEAVE THE CLASSROOM. HE LED THEM ALONG THE DESERTED CORRIDOR AND

1000

AROUND A CORNER, WHERE THE FIRST THING THEY SAW WAS PEEVES THE PEELERGET, WHO WAS PEATING UPSIDE DOWN IN MIDAIR AND STUFFING THE NEAREST DEFTHE WITH CHEWING GUM.

PEEVES DIDN'T LIFT UP UNTIL PROFESSOR LUPIN WAS TEN FEET AWAY; THEN HE WIGGLED HIS CLIMBY-THRO FEET AND BROKE INTO A SMILE.

"LIMPY, LIMPY LUPIN," PEEVES SANG. "LIMPY, LIMPY LUPIN, LIMPY, LIMPY LUPIN --"

RUDE AND UNMANAGEABLE AS HE ALMOST ALWAYS WAS, PEEVES USUALLY SHOWED SOME RESPECT TOWARD THE TEACHERS. EVERYONE LOOKED QUICKLY AT PROFESSOR LUPIN THE SEE WHEN HE WOULD TAKE THEM; TO THEIR SURPRISE, HE WAS STILL SMILING.

"I'D TAKE THAT GUM OUT OF THE DEFTHE IF I WERE YOU, PEEVES," HE SAID PLEASANTLY. "MR. FILCH WON'T BE ABLE TO GET IN THE HIS ROOMS."

FILCH WAS THE HOGWARTS CARETAKER, A BAD-TEMPERED, FAILED WIZARD WHO WAGED A CONSTANT WAR AGAINST THE STUDENTS AND, INDEED, PEEVES. HOWEVER, PEEVES PAID HIM ATTENTION TO PROFESSOR LUPIN'S WORDS, EXCEPT THE WHEN A WOULD GET RASPBERRY.

PROFESSOR LUPIN GAVE A SMALL SIGH AND THEN TOOK HIS WAND.

"THIS IS A USEFUL LITTLE SPELL, HE TOLD THE CLASS OVER HIS SHOULDER.

"PLEASE WATCH CLOSELY."

HE RAISED THE WAND THE SHOULDER HEIGHT, SAID, "WADDI-WAST!" AND POINTED IT AT PEEVES.

WITH THE FORCE OF A BULLET, THE WAD OF CHEWING GUM SENT HIM TO THE
BACK AND STRAIGHT DOWN PEEVES'S LEFT NECKTAIL; HE WHIRLED UPRIGHT AND
ZOOMED AWAY, CURSING.

"WELL, SIT?" SAID DEAN THOMAS IN AMAZEMENT.

"THANK YOU, DEAN," SAID PROFESSOR KLIPIN, PUTTING HIS HAND AWAY AGAIN.

"SHALL WE PROCEED?"

107

THEY SET OFF AGAIN, THE CLASS LOOKING AT SHAGGY PROFESSOR KLIPIN WITH
INCREASED RESPECT, HE LED THEM DOWN A SECOND CORRIDOR AND STOPPED, RIGHT
OUTSIDE THE STAFFROOM DOOR.

"INSIDE, PLEASE," SAID PROFESSOR KLIPIN, OPENING IT AND STANDING BACK.

THE STAFFROOM, A LONG, PANELLED ROOM FULL OF OLD, MISMATCHED CHAIRS, WAS
EMPTY EXCEPT FOR ONE TEACHER. PROFESSOR SNAPE WAS SITTING IN A LEAN
ARMCHAIR, AND HE LOOKED AROUND AS THE CLASS FILED IN. HIS EYES WERE
GLITTERING AND THERE WAS A NASTY SMILE PLAYING AROUND HIS MOUTH. AS
PROFESSOR KLIPIN CAME IN AND MADE THE CASE THE DOOR BEHIND HIM, SNAPE
SAID, "LEAVE IT OPEN, KLIPIN, I'D RATHER NOT WITNESS THIS."

HE GOT TO HIS FEET AND STRODE PAST THE CLASS, HIS BLACK ROBES KIMMELING
BEHIND HIM. AT THE DOORWAY HE TURNED ON HIS HEEL AND SAID, "POSSIBLY NOT
HIS WARNING YOU, KLIPIN, BUT THIS CLASS CONTAINS NEVILLE LONGBOTT. I
WOULD ADVISE YOU NOT TO ENTRUST HIM WITH ANYTHING DIFFICULT, NOT UNLESS
MISS GRANGER IS GIVING INSTRUCTIONS IN HIS EAR."

NEVILLE WENT SCARLET. HARRY GLARED AT SNAPE; IT WAS BAD ENOUGH THAT HE
BULLIED NEVILLE IN HIS OWN CLASSES, LET ALONE DOING IT IN FRONT OF OTHER
TEACHERS.

PROFESSOR KLIPIN HAD RAISED HIS EYEBROWS.

"I WAS HOPING THAT NEVILLE WOULD ASSIST ME WITH THE FIRST STAGE OF THE

EXPECTATIONS," HE SAID, "AND I AM SURE HE WILL PERFORM IT ADMIRABLY."

NEVILLE'S FACE WENT, IF POSSIBLE, EVEN REDDER. SNAPE'S LIP CURLED, BUT HE LEFT, SLUTTING THE DOOR WITH A SNAP.

"WELL, THEN," SAID PROFESSOR KLIPIN, REDEEMING THE CLASS TOWARD THE END OF THE PERIOD, WHERE THERE WAS NOTHING BUT AN OLD WARDROBE WHERE THE TEACHERS KEPT THEIR SPARE ROBES. AS PROFESSOR KLIPIN WENT THE STAGE NEXT TO IT, THE WARDROBE GAVE A SUDDEN LURCH, BANGING OFF THE WALL.

"NOTHING TO BEHOLD AHEAD," SAID PROFESSOR KLIPIN CALMLY BECAUSE A FEW PEOPLE HAD JUMPED BACKWARD IN ALARM. "THERE'S A KEEGART IN THERE." MOST PEOPLE SEEMED TO FEEL THAT THIS WAS SOMETHING TO BEHOLD AHEAD.

1000

NEVILLE GAVE PROFESSOR KLIPIN A LOOK OF PURE TERROR, AND SEamus FINNIGAN EYED THE NEW RATTLING DOORWAY APPREHENSIVELY.

"KEEGARTS LIKE DARK, ENCLOSED SPACES," SAID PROFESSOR KLIPIN. "WARDROBES, THE GAP BENEATH BEDS, THE CLIMBERS UNDER STAIRS -- I'VE EVEN MET ONE THAT HAD LODGED ITSELF IN A GRANDFATHER CLOCK. THIS ONE MOVED IN YESTERDAY AFTERNOON, AND I ASKED THE HEADMASTER IF THE STAFF WOULD LEAVE IT TO GIVE MY THIRD YEARS SOME PRACTICE.

"SEE, THE FIRST QUESTION WE MUST ASK OURSELVES IS, WHAT IS A KEEGART?" HERMIONE PUT UP HER HAND.

"IT'S A SHAPE-SHIFTER," SHE SAID. "IT CAN TAKE THE SHAPE OF WHATEVER IT THINKS WILL FRIGHTEN US MOST."

"I SHOULDN'T HAVE PUT IT BETTER MYSELF," SAID PROFESSOR KLIPIN, AND HERMIONE GLEEKED. "SEE THE KEEGART SITTING IN THE DARKNESS WITHIN HAS NOT YET ASSUMED A FORM. HE DOES NOT YET KNOW WHAT WILL FRIGHTEN THE PERSON ON THE OTHER SIDE OF THE DOOR. NORMALLY KNOWS WHAT A KEEGART LOOKS LIKE WHEN HE IS ALONE, BUT WHEN I LET HIM OUT, HE WILL IMMEDIATELY BECOME WHATEVER

EACH OF HIS DEEPEST FEARS.

"THIS MEANS," SAID PROFESSOR KLIPIN, CHEERING THE IGNORANT NEVILLE'S 'MALL SPLITTER UP TERRIER, "THAT WE HAVE A HUGE ADVANTAGE OVER THE KHEGART BEFORE WE BEGIN. I HAVE YETI SPOTTED IT, I HARRY?"

TRYING THE ANSWER A HOLSTEIN WITH I-HERMINE NEXT TO HIM, KHEKING UP AND DOWN ON THE BALLS OF HER FEET WITH HER HAND IN THE AIR, WAS VERY EFF-PLITTING, BUT I-HARRY HAD A GEE.

"ER -- BECAUSE THERE ARE SO MANY OF US, IT WOEN'T KNOW WHAT SHAPE IT SHOULD BE?"

"PRECISELY," SAID PROFESSOR KLIPIN, AND I-HERMINE PUT HER HAND DOWN, LEEKING A LITTLE DISAPPOINTED. "IT'S ALWAYS BEST TO HAVE THEM PARRY WHEN YOU'RE DEALING WITH A KHEGART, I-ER BECOMES CHOKLED, WHICH SHOULD BE BECOME, A HEADLESS CHORSE OR A FLESH-EATING SLUG? I HENCE SAW A KHEGART MAKE THAT VERY MISTAKE -- TRIED TO FRIGHTEN THE PEOPLE AT HENCE AND TURNED HIMSELF INTO HALF A SLUG, NOT REMOTELY FRIGHTENING.

187

"THE CHARM THAT REPELS A KHEGART IS SIMPLE, YET IT REQUIRES AERIE OF MIND. YOU SEE, THE THING THAT REALLY FINISHES A KHEGART IS LAUGHTER. WHAT YOU NEED TO DO IS AERIE IT TO ASSUME A SHAPE THAT YOU FIND AMUSING.

"WE WILL PRACTICE THE CHARM WITHOUT HANDS FIRST. AFTER ME, PLEASE ...
RIDDIDULLIS?"

"RIDDIDULLIS?" SAID THE CLASS TOGETHER.

"GHEE," SAID PROFESSOR KLIPIN. "VERY GHEE, BUT THAT WAS THE EASY PART, I'M AFRAID, YOU SEE, THE WHIRL AROUND IS NOT ENOUGH, AND THIS IS WHERE YOU COME IN, NEVILLE."

THE WARDROBE STOOD AGAIN, THOUGH NOT AS MUCH AS NEVILLE, WHEN WALKED FORWARD AS THOUGH HE WERE HEADING FOR THE GALLEYS.

"RIGHT, NEVILLE," SAID PROFESSOR LUPIN. "FIRST THINGS FIRST: WHAT WOULD YOU SAY IS THE THING THAT FRIGHTENS YOU MOST IN THE WORLD?"

NEVILLE'S LIPS MOVED, BUT NO NOISE CAME OUT.

"DIDN'T CATCH THAT, NEVILLE, SORRY," SAID PROFESSOR LUPIN CHEERFULLY.

NEVILLE LOOKED AROUND RATHER WILDLY, AS THOUGH BEGGING SOMEONE TO HELP HIM, THEN SAID, IN BARELY MORE THAN A WHISPER, "PROFESSOR SNAPE."

NEARLY EVERYONE LAUGHED. EVEN NEVILLE GRINNED APPLAUSIVELY. PROFESSOR LUPIN, HOWEVER, LOOKED THOUGHTFUL.

"PROFESSOR SNAPE... HMM... NEVILLE, I BELIEVE YOU LIVE WITH YOUR GRANDMOTHER?"

"Er -- YES," SAID NEVILLE NERVOUSLY. "BUT -- I DIDN'T WANT THE KEGGART TO TURN INTO HER EITHER."

"OH, OH, YOU MISUNDERSTAND ME," SAID PROFESSOR LUPIN, NOW SMILING. "I WUNDER, COULD YOU TELL US WHAT SORT OF CLOTHES YOUR GRANDMOTHER USUALLY WEARS?"

110

NEVILLE LOOKED STARTLED, BUT SAID, "WELL... ALWAYS THE SAME HAT, A TALL HORN WITH A STUPPED VULTURE ON TOP, AND A LONG DRESS... GREEN, NORMALLY... AND SOMETIMES A FOX-FUR SCARF."

"AND A HANDKER?" PROMPTED PROFESSOR LUPIN.

"A BIG RED ONE," SAID NEVILLE.

"RIGHT THEN," SAID PROFESSOR LUPIN. "CAN YOU PICTURE THESE CLOTHES VERY CLEARLY, NEVILLE? CAN YOU SEE THEM IN YOUR MIND'S EYE?"

"YES," SAID NEVILLE UNCERTAINLY, PLAINLY WUNDERING WHAT WAS COMING NEXT.

"WHEN THE KEGGART BURSTS OUT OF THIS WARDROBE, NEVILLE, AND SEES YOU, IT WILL ASSUME THE FORM OF PROFESSOR SNAPE," SAID LUPIN. "AND YOU WILL RAISE YOUR HAND -- THIS -- AND CRY 'RIDDIKULUS' -- AND CONCENTRATE HARD

HEN YELIN GRANDFATHER'S CLOTHES. IF ALL GOES WELL, PROFESSOR KEGGART SHAPE
WILL BE FORCED INTO THAT VULTURE-TOPPED HAT, AND THAT GREEN DRESS, WITH
THAT BIG RED HANDBAG."

THERE WAS A GREAT SURGE OF LAUGHTER. THE LAUGHING WHEELED MORE
VIOLENTLY.

"IF NEVILLE IS SUCCESSFUL, THE KEGGART IS LIKELY TO SHIFT HIS ATTENTION
THE EACH OF US IN TURN," SAID PROFESSOR LUPIN. "I WOULD LIKE ALL OF YELIN
TO TAKE A MOMENT NOW TO THINK OF THE THING THAT SCARES YOU MOST, AND
IMAGINE HOW YOU MIGHT FORCE IT TO BEHOLD CHIMERA..."

THE ROOM WENT SILENT. HARRY THOUGHT... "WHAT SCARED HIM MOST IN THE
WORLD?"

HIS FIRST THOUGHT WAS LORD VOLDEMORT -- A VOLDEMORT RETURNED THE FULL
STRENGTH. BUT BEFORE HE HAD EVEN STARTED THE PLAN A POSSIBLE
COUNTERATTACK HAD A KEGGART-VOLDEMORT, A TERRIBLE IMAGE CAME FLASHING THE
THE SURFACE OF HIS MIND...

A RATTING, GLISTENING HAND, SLITHERING BACK BENEATH A BLACK CLOAK ... A
LONG, RATTING BREATH FROM AN UNSEEN BEING... THEN A CHILD'S PENETRATING
IT FELT LIKE BREATHING...

111

HARRY SHIVERED, THEN LOOKED AROUND, FEELING AS IF HE HAD NOTICED. MANY
PEOPLE HAD THEIR EYES SHUT TIGHT. RON WAS MUTTERING TO HIMSELF, "TAKE
ITS LEGS OFF" HARRY WAS SURE HE KNEW WHAT THAT WAS ABOUT. RON'S
GREATEST FEAR WAS SPIDERS.

"EVERYONE READY?" SAID PROFESSOR LUPIN.

HARRY FELT A LURCH OF FEAR. HE WASN'T READY. THAT CHILD YOU MADE A
DEMENTOR LESS FRIGHTENING? BUT HE DIDN'T WANT TO ASK FOR MORE TIME.
EVERYONE ELSE WAS NODDING AND ROLLING UP THEIR SLEEVES.

"NEVILLE, WE'RE GOING THE BACK AWAY," SAID PROFESSOR KLIPIN. "LET THEM HAVE A CLEAR FIELD, ALL RIGHT? I'LL CALL THE NEXT PERSON FORWARD... EVERYONE BACK, NOW, SO NEVILLE CAN GET A CLEAR SHEET --"

THEY ALL RETREATED, BACKED AGAINST THE WALLS, LEAVING NEVILLE ALONE BESIDE THE WARDROBE. HE LOOKED PALE AND FRIGHTENED, BUT HE HAD PULSED UP THE SLEEVES OF HIS ROBES AND WAS HOLDING HIS WAND READY.

"HEN THE COUNT OF THREE, NEVILLE," SAID PROFESSOR KLIPIN, WHO WAS POINTING HIS OWN WAND AT THE HANDLE OF THE WARDROBE. "ONE TWO -- THREE -- NOW!"

A JET OF SPARKS SHEET FROM THE END OF PROFESSOR KLIPIN'S WAND AND HIT THE DOORDOOR. THE WARDROBE FIRST OPEN, THEN-NEED AND MENACING, PROFESSOR SNAPE STEPPED OUT, HIS EYES FLASHING AT NEVILLE.

NEVILLE BACKED AWAY, HIS WAND UP, FEELING UNHELPLESSLY. SNAPE WAS BEARING DOWN UPON HIM, REACHING INSIDE HIS ROBES.

"R -- R -- RIDDLIKULUS!" SHRIEKED NEVILLE.

THERE WAS A NOISE LIKE A WHIP CRACK. SNAPE STUMBLER; HE WAS WEARING A LONG, LACE-TRIMMED DRESS AND A THUNDERING HAT THROPPED WITH A MOUTH-EATEN VULTURE, AND HE WAS SWINGING A FLICK CRIMSON HANDKER.

THERE WAS A RUSH OF LAUGHTER; THE HEGGART PALSED, CHUCKLED, AND PROFESSOR KLIPIN SHOUTED, "PARVATI! FORWARD!"

112

PARVATI WALKED FORWARD, HER FACE SET. SNAPE REELINED HER. THERE WAS ANOTHER CRACK, AND WHERE HE HAD STOOD WAS A BLEEDSTAINED, RANAGED MUMMY; ITS SIGHTLESS FACE WAS TURNED THE PARVATI AND IT BEGAN THE WALK TOWARD HER VERY SILENTLY, DRAGGING ITS FEET, ITS STIFF ARMS RISING --

"RIDDLIKULUS!" CRIED PARVATI.

A RANAGE UNRAVELED AT THE MUMMY'S FEET; IT BECAME ENTANGLED, FELL FACE

FORWARD, AND ITS HEAD REELLED OFF.

"SEAMUS!" REARED PROFESSOR KLIPIN.

SEAMUS DARTED PAST PARYATI.

[CRACK! WHERE THE MUMMY HAD BEEN WAS A WERMAN WITH FLEETLENGTH BLACK HAIR AND A SKELETAL, GREEN-TINGED FACE -- A KANSHEE. SHE OPENED HER MOUTH WIDE AND AN UNCEANTHLY SILEND FILLED THE ROOM, A LONG, WAILING SCREECH THAT MADE THE HAIR ON HARRY'S HEAD STAND ON END -- 'RIDDIKLILIS!' SCHELTED SEAMUS.

THE KANSHEE MADE A RASPING NOISE AND CLUTCHED HER THERAT; HER VEHICLE WAS GONE.

[CRACK! THE KANSHEE TURNED INTO A RAT, WHICH CHASED ITS TAIL IN A CIRCLE, THEN -- CRACK! -- BECAME A RATTLESNAKE, WHICH SLITHERED AND WRITHED BEHIND -- CRACK! -- BECOMING A SINGLE, BLENDY EYEBALL.

'IT'S CHOKUSED!' SCHELTED KLIPIN, "WE'RE GETTING THERE! DEAN!"

DEAN FLURRIED FORWARD.

[CRACK! THE EYEBALL BECAME A SEVERED HAND, WHICH FLIPPED OVER AND BEGAN TO CREEP ALONG THE FLOOR LIKE A CRAB.

"RIDDIKLILIS!" YELLED DEAN.

"THERE WAS A SNAP, AND THE HAND WAS TRAPPED IN A MESHETRAP.

"EXCELLENT! THEN, WHO NEXT?"

113

REIN LEAPT FORWARD.

[CRACK!

ELITE A FEW PEOPLE STREAMED. A GIANT SPIDER, SIX FEET TALL AND COVERED IN HAIR, WAS ADVANCING ON REIN, CLICKING ITS PINKERS MENACINGLY. FOR A MOMENT, HARRY THOUGHT REIN HAD FROZEN. THEN --

"RIDDIKLILIS!" KILLED REIN, AND THE SPIDER'S LEGS VANISHED; IT REELLED

EVER AND EVER! LAVENDER BROWN SQUEALED AND RAN HIT OF ITS WAY AND IT
CAME TO A HALT AT HARRY'S FEET. HE RAISED HIS HAND, READY, BUT --
"FIRE!" SHOUTED PROFESSOR FLIPIN SUDDENLY, FLIRTING FORWARD. CRACK!
THE LEGLESS SPIDER HAD VANISHED. FOR A SECOND, EVERYONE LEANED WILDLY
AROUND TO SEE WHERE IT WAS. THEN THEY SAW A SILVERY-WHITE HOB HANGING IN
THE AIR IN FRONT OF FLIPIN, WHO SAID, "RIDDIKULUS!" ALMOST LAZILY.

CRACK!

"FORWARD, NEVILLE, AND FINISH HIM OFF!" SAID FLIPIN AS THE HOGGART LANDED
BETWEEN THE FLEET AS A CHOCORHACH. CRACK! SNAPE WAS BACK. THIS TIME NEVILLE
CHARGED FORWARD LEANING DETERMINED.

"RIDDIKULUS!" HE SHOUTED, AND THEY HAD A SPLIT SECOND'S VIEW OF SNAPE IN
HIS LADY DRESS BEFORE NEVILLE LET HIM A GREAT "F-I-A!" OF LIGHTS, AND THE
HOGGART EXPLODED, BURST INTO A THOUSAND TINY WISPS OF SMOKE, AND WAS
GONE.

"EXCELLENT!" CRIED PROFESSOR FLIPIN AS THE CLASS BROKE INTO APPLAUSE.

"EXCELLENT! NEVILLE, WELL DONE, EVERYONE... LET ME SEE... FIVE POINTS
THE CROPFINDOR FOR EVERY PERSON WHO TACKLED THE HOGGART -- TEN FOR NEVILLE
BECAUSE HE DID IT TWICE... AND FIVE EACH THE HERMIONE AND HARRY."

"BUT I DIDN'T DO ANYTHING," SAID HARRY.

"WELL AND HERMIONE ANSWERED MY QUESTIONS CORRECTLY AT THE START OF THE
CLASS, HARRY," FLIPIN SAID LIGHTLY, "VERY WELL, EVERYONE, AN EXCELLENT
LESSON. HERMION, KINDLY READ THE CHAPTER ON HOGGARTS AND SUMMARIZE IT
FOR ME... THE EE HANDED IN ON MONDAY. THAT WILL BE ALL."

119

TALKING EXCITEDLY, THE CLASS LEFT THE STAFFROOM. HARRY, HOWEVER, WASN'T
FEELING CHEERFUL. PROFESSOR FLIPIN HAD DELIBERATELY STOPPED HIM FROM
TACKLING THE HOGGART, WHY WAS IT BECAUSE HE'D SEEN HARRY CHALLENGE HIM

THE TRAIN, AND THE THOUGHT HE WASN'T LIP THE MILEN? HAD HE THE THOUGHT HARRY
WHLID

PASS HLT AGAIN?

BLT NEH HNE ELSE SEEMED THE HAVE NOTICED ANYTHING.

"DID YHL SEE ME TAKE THAT KANSHER?" SEHELTED SEAMUS, "AND THE HAND?" SAID
DEAN, WAVING HIS HLN ARHLND.

"AND SNAPE IN THAT HAT?" "AND MY MUMMY?"

I WHNDER WHY PROFESSOR LUPIN'S FRIGHTENED HP CRYSTAL BALLS? SAID
LAVENDER THEHLIGHTFULLY.

"THAT WAS THE BEST DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS LESSON WE'VE EVER HAD,
WASN'T IT?" SAID REHN EXCITEDLY AS THEY MADE THEIR WAY BACK THE THE
CLASSRHHM? THE GET THEIR BAGS.

"HE SEEMS LIKE A VERY GOOD TEACHER," SAID HERMIONE APPROVINGLY. "BLT I
WISH I HHLID HAVE HAD A TURN WITH THE KEGGART --"

"WHAT WHHLID IT HAVE BEEN AHR YHL?" SAID REHN, SNIGGERING. "A PIERCE HP
HHEMELHED THAT HNL GET NINE HLT HP TEN?"

CHAPTER EIGHT

FLIGHT HP THE FAT RADDY

IN NEH TIME AT ALL, DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS HAD BECOME MEET
PEOPLE'S FAVORITE CLASS. HNL DRACH MALFOY AND HIS GANG HP SLYTHERINS
HAD ANYTHING BAD THE SAY ABLT PROFESSOR LUPIN.

"LHED AT THE STATE HP HIS RHEES," MALFOY WHHLID SAY IN A HHLD WHISPER AS
PROFESSOR LUPIN PASSED. "HE DRESSES LIKE HHLR HLD HHLISPEL?"

BLT NEH HNE ELSE CARED THAT PROFESSOR LUPIN'S RHEES WERE PATCHED AND
PRAYED. HIS NEXT FEW LESSONS WERE ILST AS INTERESTING AS THE FIRST.

AFTER KEGGARTS, THEY STUDIED RED CAPS, NASTY LITTLE GHEKIN LIKE
CREATLRES THAT LURKED WHEREVER THERE HAD BEEN BLEEDSHEED: IN THE DUNGHEENS

OF CASTLES AND THE PENTILES OF DESERTED BATTLEFIELDS, WAITING THE
BLUDGEON THESE WERE HAD GOTTEN LOST, FROM RED CAPS THEY MOVED ON THE
KAPPAS, CREEPY, WATER-DWELLERS THAT LOOKED LIKE SCALY MONKEYS, WITH
WEEED HANDS ITCHING THE STRANGE LINGUISTIC WADERS IN THEIR POUNDS.
HARRY ONLY WISHED HE WAS AS HAPPY WITH SOME OF HIS OTHER CLASSES, WHEREST
HE ALL WAS PERTINENS, SNAPE WAS IN A PARTICULARLY VINDICTIVE MOOD THESE
DAYS, AND NEH HNE WAS IN AN OBLIET WAY, THE STORY OF THE KEGGART ASSUMING
SNAPE'S SHAPE, AND THE WAY THAT NEVILLE HAD DRESSED IT IN HIS
GRANDMOTHER'S CLOTHES, HAD TRAVELED THROUGH THE SCHOOL LIKE WILDFIRE,
SNAPE DIDN'T SEEM TO FIND IT FUNNY, HIS EYES FLASHED MENACINGLY AT THE
VERY MENTION OF PROFESSOR KLIPIN'S NAME, AND HE WAS KILLING NEVILLE
WORSER THAN EVER.

HARRY WAS ALSO GRUELING THE DREAD THE FEELING HE SPENT IN PROFESSOR
TRELABNEY'S STYLING THUNDER RHYTHM, DECRYPTING UPSIDOWN SHAPES AND
SYMBOLS, TRYING TO IGNORE THE WAY PROFESSOR TRELABNEY'S ENORMOUS EYES
FILLED WITH TEARS EVERY TIME SHE LOOKED AT HIM, HE COULDN'T LIKE
PROFESSOR TRELABNEY, EVEN THOUGH SHE WAS TREATED WITH RESPECT BEHOLDING
HIS REVERENCE BY MANY OF THE CLASS, PARYATI PATIL AND LAVENDER BROWN HAD
TAKEN THE HAUNTING PROFESSOR TRELABNEY'S THUNDER RHYTHM AT LUNCH TIMES, AND
ALWAYS RETURNED WITH ANNOUNCINGLY SUPERIOR LOOKS ON THEIR FACES, AS THOUGH
THEY KNEW THINGS THE OTHERS DIDN'T, THEY HAD ALSO STARTED USING FANCY
VEHICLES WHATEVER THEY SPoke TO HARRY, AS THOUGH HE WERE HIS DEATH-KID,
NEHEBY REALLY LIKED CARE OF MAGICAL CREATURES, WHICH, AFTER THE
ACTION-PACKED FIRST CLASS, HAD BECOME EXTREMELY DULL, HAGRID SEEMED TO
HAVE LOST HIS CONFIDENCE, THEY WERE NOW SPENDING LESSON AFTER LESSON
LEARNING FEEL THE WOOD AFTER FLEKKERLHORMS, WHICH HAD THE RE SEME OF THE
MOST BIRING CREATURES IN EXISTENCE.

"WHY WOULD ANYONE BOTHER LOOKING AFTER THEM?" SAID RON, AFTER SET
ANOTHER FEELER OF POKING STABBED LITTLE DOWN THE FLEKKERLHORMS' THREATS,

AT THE START OF EITHER, HOWEVER, HARRY HAD SOMETHING ELSE TO WORRY
HIM, SOMETHING SO ENJOYABLE IT MORE THAN MADE UP FOR HIS UNSATISFACTORY
CLASSES. THE HOLIDITCH SEASON WAS APPROACHING, AND OLIVER WOOD, CAPTAIN
OF THE GRYFFINDOR TEAM, CALLED A MEETING ON THURSDAY EVENING TO DISCUSS

118

TACTICS FOR THE NEW SEASON.

THERE WERE SEVEN PEOPLE ON A HOLIDITCH TEAM: THREE CHASERS, WHOSE JOB IT
WAS TO SCORE GOALS BY PLACING THE HURLER (A RED, SHOCKER-SIZED BALL)
THROUGH ONE OF THE FIFTY-FOOT-HIGH HOOPS AT EACH
END OF THE FIELD; TWO BEATERS, WHO WERE EQUIPPED WITH HEAVY BATTS TO
REPEL THE BLUDGERS (THE HEAVY BLACK BALLS THAT ZOOMED AROUND TRYING TO
ATTACK THE PLAYERS); A KEEPER, WHO DEFENDED THE GOAL
POSTS, AND THE SEEKER, WHO HAD THE HARDEST JOB OF ALL, THAT OF CATCHING
THE GOLDEN SNITCH, A TINY, WINGED, WAINUT-SIZED BALL, WHOSE CAPTURE
ENDED THE GAME AND EARNED THE SEEKER'S TEAM AN EXTRA ONE HUNDRED AND
FIFTY POINTS.

OLIVER WOOD WAS A BURLY SEVENTEEN-YEAR-OLD, NEW IN HIS SEVENTH AND FINAL
YEAR AT HOGWARTS. THERE WAS A GLINT SHOT OF DESPERATION IN HIS VOICE AS
HE ADDRESSED HIS SIX FELLOW TEAM MEMBERS IN THE CHILLY LOCKER ROOMS ON
THE EDGE OF THE DARKENING HOLIDITCH FIELD.

"THIS IS OUR LAST CHANCE -- MY LAST CHANCE -- TO WIN THE HOLIDITCH CUP,"
HE TOLD THEM, STRIDING UP AND DOWN IN FRONT OF THEM. "I'LL BE LEAVING AT
THE END OF THIS YEAR. I'LL NEVER GET ANOTHER SHOT AT IT."

"GRYFFINDOR HAIN'T WON FOR SEVEN YEARS NOW, HARRY, SO WE'VE HAD THE WORST
LUCK IN THE WORLD -- INJURIES -- THEN THE TOURNAMENTGETTING CALLED OFF
LAST YEAR WOOD STAMMERED, AS THOUGH THE MEMORY STILL BRULGHT A LUMP ON
HIS THROAT. "BUT WE ALSO KNOW WE'VE GOT THE

BEST-RODDY-TEAM-IN-THE-SCHOOL," HE SAID, PUNCHING A FIST INTO HIS OTHER HAND, THE OLD MANIC GLINT BACK IN HIS EYE. "WE'VE GOT THREE SLIPPER CHASERS."

WHEED POINTED AT ALICIA SPINNER, ANGELINA JENNISON, AND KATIE BELL.

"WE'VE GOT TEN LINEEATABLE BEATERS."

"STEP IT, HELIVER, YOU'RE EMBARRASSING US," SAID FRED AND GEORGE WEASLEY TOGETHER, PRETENDING THE ELUSIVE.

"AND WE'VE GOT A SEEKER WHO HAS NEVER FAILED TO WIN US A MATCH!" WHEED

119

WRINKLED, GLARING AT HARRY WITH A KIND OF FLIRTLIS PRIDE. "AND ME," HE ADDED AS AN AFTERTHOUGHT.

"WE THINK YOU'RE VERY GOOD THEN, HELIVER," SAID GEORGE.

"SPARKING GOOD DEEDER," SAID FRED.

"THE POINT IS," WHEED WENT ON, RESUMING HIS PACING, "THE FLUIDITCH CUP SHOULD HAVE HAD OUR NAME IN IT THESE LAST TWO YEARS. EVER SINCE HARRY JOINED THE TEAM, I'VE THOUGHT THE THING WAS IN THE BAG, BUT WE HAVEN'T GOT IT, AND THIS YEAR'S THE LAST CHANCE WE'LL GET TO FINALLY SEE OUR NAME IN THE THING..."

WHEED SPOKE SO DIRECTLY THAT EVEN FRED AND GEORGE LOOKED SYMPATHETIC.

"HELIVER, THIS YEAR'S OUR YEAR," SAID FRED.

"WE'LL DO IT, HELIVER!" SAID ANGELINA.

"DEFINITELY," SAID HARRY.

FULL OF DETERMINATION, THE TEAM STARTED TRAINING SESSIONS, THREE EVENINGS A WEEK. THE WEATHER WAS GETTING COLDER AND WETTER, THE NIGHTS DARKER, BUT NOT APPEALINGLY MILD, WIND, OR RAIN COULD TARNISH HARRY'S WONDERFUL VISION OF FINALLY WINNING THE HUGE, SILVER FLUIDITCH CUP. HARRY RETURNED TO THE GRYFFINDOR COMMON ROOM ONE EVENING AFTER TRAINING,

CHILD AND STIFF KILT PLEASED WITH THE WAY PRACTICE HAD GONE, HE FIND THE
RHYTHM KLIZZING EXCITEDLY.

"WHAT'S HAPPENED?", HE ASKED RENN AND HERMINE, WHO WERE SITTING IN TWO
OF THE BEST CHAIRS BY THE FIRESIDE AND COMPLETING SOME STAR CHARTS FOR
ASTRONOMY.

"FIRST HIGSMERE WEEKEND," SAID RENN, POINTING AT A NOTICE THAT HAD
APPEARED ON THE BATTERED OLD KILLETIN BOARD. "AND OF COURSE,
HALLOWEEN."

"EXCELLENT," SAID FRED, WHO HAD FOLLOWED HARRY THROUGH THE PORTRAIT
DOOR. "I NEED THE VISIT ZENITH'S, I'M NEARLY BLIT BY STINK PELLETS."

118

HARRY THREW HIMSELF INTO A CHAIR BESIDE RENN, HIS HIGH SPIRITS PEKING
AWAY, HERMINE SEEMED TO READ HIS MIND.

"HARRY, I'M SURE YOU'LL BE ABLE TO GO NEXT TIME," SHE SAID, "THEY'RE
BEHIND THE LATCH BLACK SHEN, HE'S BEEN SIGHTED ONCE ALREADY."

"BLACK'S NOT ABLE ENOUGH TO TRY ANYTHING IN HIGSMERE," SAID RENN, "ASK
MCCHINAGALL IF YOU CAN GO THIS TIME, HARRY, THE NEXT ONE MIGHT NOT BE FOR
AGES --"

"RENN?" SAID HERMINE, "HARRY'S SLOPPED THE STAY IN SCHOOLS--"

"HE CAN'T BE THE ONLY THIRD YEAR LEFT BEHIND," SAID RENN, "ASK
MCCHINAGALL, GO ON, HARRY --"

"YEAH, I THINK I WILL," SAID HARRY, MAKING UP HIS MIND.

HERMINE OPENED HER MOUTH THE AGLIE, BLIT AT THAT MOMENT CRIBBSHANDS
LEAPT

LIGHTLY INTO HER LAP, A LARGE, DEAD SPIDER WAS DANGLING FROM HIS MOUTH,

"DID HE HAVE THE EAT THAT IN FRONT OF US?" SAID RENN, SCHEWLING.

"CLEVER CRIBBSHANDS, DID YOU CATCH THAT ALL BY YOURSELF?" SAID HERMINE.

CRIBBSHANDS; SLEENLY CRAWLED UP THE SPIDER, HIS YELLOW EYES FIXED

INSELENTLY HEN REHN.

"JUST KEEP HIM EVER THERE, THAT'S ALL," SAID REHN IRRITABLY, TURNING BACK THE HIS STAR CHART. "I'VE GOTT STARRERS ASLEEP IN MY BAG."

FARRY YAWNED. HE REALLY WANTED THE GEE THE RED, BUT HE STILL HAD HIS HEN STAR CHART THE COMPLETE. HE PULLED HIS BAG TOWARD HIM, THEED HILT PARCEMENT, INK, AND HILL, AND STARTED WORK.

"WELL CAN COPY MINE, IF WELL LIKE," SAID REHN, LABELING HIS LAST STAR WITH A FLURISH AND SHOVING THE CHART TOWARD FARRY.

FERMINE, WITH DISAPPROVED OF COPYING, PURSED HER LIPS BUT DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING. CRIBSTANDS WAS STILL STARING UNBLINKINGLY AT REHN, FLICKING

119

THE END OF HIS RUSTY TAIL. THEN, WITHOUT WARNING, HE PULSED.

"HEY!" REHN WHARED, SEIZING HIS BAG AS CRIBSTANDS SAND FOUR SETS OF CLAWS DEEP INSIDE IT AND BEGAN TEARING FEROCIOUSLY. "GET OFF, WELL STUPID ANIMAL!"

REHN TRIED THE PULL THE BAG AWAY FROM CRIBSTANDS, BUT CRIBSTANDS CLUNG HEN, SPITTING AND SLASHING.

"REHN, DIDN'T HURT HIM?" SHRIELED FERMINE; THE LITTLE CHIMPEN REHN WAS WATCHING; REHN WHIRLED THE BAG AROUND, CRIBSTANDS STILL CLINGING THE IT, AND STARRERS CAME FLYING HILT OF THE THEP -

"CATCH THAT CAR!" REHN YELLED AS CRIBSTANDS FREED HIMSELF FROM THE REMNANTS OF THE BAG, SPRANG OVER THE TABLE, AND CHASED AFTER THE TERRIFIED STARRERS.

GEORGE WEASLEY MADE A LINGER FOR CRIBSTANDS BUT MISSED; STARRERS STREPPED THROUGH TWENTY PAIRS OF LEGS AND SEET BENEATH AN OLD CHEST OF DRAWERS. CRIBSTANDS SKIDDED THE A HOLT, CREELED WHEN HEN HIS RANBY LEGS, AND STARTED MAKING FLURISH SWIPES BENEATH IT WITH HIS FRONT PAW.

RHEN AND FERMINE FLARRIED HYER; FERMIENE GRABBED CRIBBEX-STANXS AROUND THE

MIDDLE AND HEAVED HIM AWAY; RHEN THREW HIMSELF BENTH HIS STOMACH AND, WITH GREAT DIFFICULTY, PULLED SLACKERS HLIT BY THE TAIL.

"LOOK AT HIM!" HE SAID FLURIELLSLY TH FERMIENE, DANGLING SLACKERS IN FRONT OF HER. "HE'S SKIN AND BONE! YOU KEEP THAT CAT AWAY FROM HIM!"

"CRIBBEX-STANXS DOESN'T UNDERSTAND IT'S WORKING!" SAID FERMIENE, HER VOICE SHAKING. "ALL CATS CHASE RATS, RHEN!"

"THERE'S SOMETHING FLINDY ABOUT THAT ANIMAL!" SAID RHEN, WHO WAS TRYING TO PERSUADE A FRANTICALLY WIGGLING SLACKERS BACK INTO HIS POCKET. "IT HEARD ME SAY THAT SLACKERS WAS IN MY BAG!"

"EH, WHAT FLURISH!" SAID FERMIENE IMPATIENTLY. "CRIBBEX-STANXS COULD SMELL HIM, RHEN, HOW ELSE D'YOU THINK --"

"THAT CAT'S GOT IT IN FOR SLACKERS!" SAID RHEN, 'IGNORING THE PEOPLE

120

AROUND HIM, WHO WERE STARTING TO GIGGLE. "AND SLACKERS WAS HERE FIRST, AND HE'S ILL!"

RHEN MARCHED THROUGH THE CHIMNEY ROOM AND HLIT UP SIGHT LIP THE STAIRS TO THE KIDS' BERMITHRIES.

RHEN WAS STILL IN A BAD MOOD WITH FERMIENE NEXT DAY. HE RARELY TALKED TO HER ALL THROUGH FLURIELLSLY, EVEN THOUGH HE, HARRY, AND FERMIENE WERE WORKING TOGETHER ON THE SAME PROJECT.

"YOU'VE SLACKERS?" FERMIENE ASKED TIMIDLY AS THEY STRIPPED FAT PINK PODS FROM THE PLANTS AND EMPTIED THE SHINING BEANS INTO A WOODEN PAIL.

"HE'S HIDING AT THE BOTTOM OF MY BED, SHAKING," SAID RHEN ANGRILY, MISSING THE PAIL AND SCATTERING BEANS OVER THE GREENHOUSE FLOOR.

"CAREFUL, CAREFUL, CAREFUL!" CRIED PROFESSOR SPREHLT AS THE BEANS BLIST INTO BLENNY BEANS THEIR VERY EYES.

THEY HAD TRANSCRIPTION NEXT, FARRY, WHO HAD RESOLVED THE ASK PROFESSOR MCGINNAGALL AFTER THE LESSON WHETHER HE COULD GO INTO THE BUSHES WITH THE REST, JOINED THE LINE OUTSIDE THE CLASS TRYING TO DECIDE WHEN HE WAS GOING TO ASK HIS CASE. HE WAS DISTRACTED, HOWEVER, BY A DISTURBANCE AT THE FRONT OF THE LINE.

LAVENDER GREEN SEEMED TO BE CRYING. PARVATI HAD HER ARM AROUND HER AND WAS EXPLAINING SOMETHING TO SEAMUS FINNIGAN AND DEAN THOMAS, WHO WERE LOOKING VERY SERIOUS.

"WHAT'S THE MATTER, LAVENDER?" SAID HERMIONE ANXIOUSLY AS SHE, FARRY, AND RON WENT TO JOIN THE CROWD.

"SHE GOT A LETTER FROM HOME THIS MORNING," PARVATI WHISPERED. "IT'S HER RABBIT, KINKY. HE'S BEEN KILLED BY A FOX."

"EH," SAID HERMIONE, "I'M SORRY, LAVENDER."

"I SHOULD HAVE KNOWN!" SAID LAVENDER TRAGICALLY, "WHY KNOW WHAT DAY IT IS?"

121

"Er --"

"THE SIXTEENTH OF OCTOBER! 'THAT THING YOU'RE DREADING, IT WILL HAPPEN ON THE SIXTEENTH OF OCTOBER!' REMEMBER? SHE WAS RIGHT, SHE WAS RIGHT!"

THE WHOLE CLASS WAS GATHERED AROUND LAVENDER NOW. SEAMUS SHOOK HIS HEAD

SERIOUSLY. HERMIONE HESITATED; THEN SHE SAID, "WELL -- YOU WERE DREADING KINKY BEING KILLED BY A FOX?"

"WELL, NOT NECESSARILY BY A FOX," SAID LAVENDER, LOOKING UP AT HERMIONE WITH STREAMING EYES, "BUT I WAS HEAVILY DREADING HIM DYING, WASN'T I?"

"EH," SAID HERMIONE. SHE PAUSED AGAIN. THEN

"WAS KINKY AN OLD RABBIT?"

"N -- NO," SAID LAVENDER. "H -- HE WAS ONLY A KID!"

PARYATI TIGHTENED HER ARM AROUND LAVENDER'S SHOULDERS.

"BUT THEN, WHY WOULD YOU DREAD HIM DYING?" SAID HERMIONE.

PARYATI GLARED AT HER.

"WELL, LOOK AT IT LOGICALLY," SAID HERMIONE, TURNING THE THE REST OF THE GROUP- "I MEAN, KIDDO DIDN'T EVEN DIE TODAY, DID HE? LAVENDER JUST GOT THE NEWS TODAY- " LAVENDER WAILED LOUDLY, "- AND SHE CAN'T HAVE BEEN DREADING IT, BECAUSE IT'S HERE AS A REAL THING --"

"DIDN'T MIND HERMIONE, LAVENDER," SAID REIN LOUDLY, "SHE DOESN'T THINK EITHER PEOPLE'S PETS MATTER VERY MUCH."

PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL OPENED THE CLASSROOM DOOR AT THAT MOMENT, WHICH WAS

PERHAPS LUCKY; HERMIONE AND REIN WERE LOOKING DAGGERS AT EACH OTHER, AND WHEN THEY GOT INTO THE CLASS, THEY SEATED THEMSELVES ON EITHER SIDE OF HARRY AND DIDN'T TALK TO EACH OTHER FOR THE WHOLE CLASS.

HARRY STILL HADN'T DECIDED WHAT HE WAS GOING TO SAY TO PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL WHEN THE BELL RANG AT THE END OF THE LESSON, BUT IT WAS SHE WHO BROUGHT UP THE SUBJECT OF HOGSMEAD FIRST.

122

"ONE MOMENT, PLEASE!" SHE CALLED AS THE CLASS MADE THE LEAVE. "AS YOU'RE ALL IN MY HOUSE, YOU SHOULD HAVE HOGSMEAD PERMISSION FROM THE ME BEFORE FALLING ASLEEP, NOT FROM, NOT VISITING THE VILLAGE, SHE DIDN'T FORGET!"

NEVILLE PUT UP HIS HAND.

"PLEASE, PROFESSOR, I -- I THINK I'VE LEFT

"YOUR GRANDFATHER SENT YOU THE ME DIRECTLY, LONGER THAN," SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL. "SHE SEEMED TO THINK IT WAS SAFER. WELL, THAT'S ALL, YOU MAY LEAVE."

"ASK HER NOW," REIN HISSED AT HARRY.

"EH, BUT --" HERMIONE BEGAN.

"Oh for it, Harry," said Ron stammeringly.

Harry waited for the rest of the class to disappear, then headed nervously for Professor McGonagall's desk.

"Yes, Potter?" Harry took a deep breath.

"Professor, my aunt and uncle -- er -- forgot to sign my form," he said. Professor McGonagall looked over her square spectacles at him but didn't say anything.

"See -- er I've thought it would be all right now, will it be okay if I -- if I get the Hogsmeade?"

Professor McGonagall looked down and began flipping papers in her desk.

"I'm afraid not, Potter," she said. "You heard what I said. No form, no visiting the village. That's the rule."

"But -- Professor, my aunt and uncle -- they know, they're Muggles, they don't really understand what -- what Hogwarts forms and stuff," Harry said, while Ron looked him in with vicious eyes. "If you said I could get

123

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"But I didn't say so," said Professor McGonagall, standing up and piling her papers neatly into a drawer. "The form clearly states that the parent or guardian must give permission." She turned the look at him, with an odd expression in her face. Was it pity? "I'm sorry, Potter, but that's my final word. You had better hurry, or you'll be late for your next lesson."

There was nothing to be done. Ron called Professor McGonagall a lot of names that greatly annoyed Hermione; Hermione assumed an

"all-for-the-rest" expression that made Ron even angrier, and Harry had the entire everyone in the class talking loudly and happily about what

THEY WERE GOING THE OTHER FIRST, SINCE THEY LEFT IN THE FOGSMEAD.

"THERE'S ALWAYS THE FEAST," SAID RICH, IN AN EFFORT TO CHEER HARRY UP.

"WELL KNOWN, THE HALLOWEEN FEAST, IN THE EVENING."

"YES," SAID HARRY GLENNILLY, "GREAT."

THE HALLOWEEN FEAST WAS ALWAYS GOOD, BUT IT WOULD TASTE A LOT BETTER IF HE WAS CELEBRATING IT AFTER A DAY IN FOGSMEAD WITH EVERYONE ELSE. NOTHING ANYONE SAID MADE HIM FEEL ANY BETTER ABOUT BEING LEFT BEHIND. DEAN

THOMAS, WHO WAS GOOD WITH A PENCIL, HAD OFFERED THE POOR LITTLE VERNON'S SIGNATURE FOR THE FORM, BUT AS HARRY HAD ALREADY TOLD PROFESSOR

MCENAGALL HE HADN'T HAD IT SIGNED, THAT WAS NOT GOOD. RICH HALF-HEARTEDLY

SUGGESTED THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK, BUT HERMIONE STAMPED ON THAT ONE,

REMINING RICH WHAT DUMBLEDORE HAD TOLD THEM ABOUT THE DEMENTORS BEING ABLE TO SEE THROUGH THEM. PERCY HAD WHAT WERE POSSIBLY THE LEAST HELPFUL WORDS OF COMFORT.

"THEY MAKE A LOSS ABOUT FOGSMEAD, BUT I ASSURE YOU, HARRY, IT'S NOT ALL IT'S CRACKED UP THE RE," HE SAID SERIOUSLY. "ALL RIGHT, THE SWEETSHOP'S RATHER GOOD, AND ZENKE'S JUNK SHOP'S STRANGELY INTERESTING, AND YES, THE SHRIeking SHOP'S ALWAYS WORTH A VISIT, BUT REALLY, HARRY, APART FROM THAT, YOU'RE NOT MISSING ANYTHING."

ON HALLOWEEN MORNING, HARRY AWOKE WITH THE REST AND WENT DOWN THE BREAKFAST, FEELING TERRIBLY DEPRESSED, THOUGH DOING HIS BEST TO ACT NORMALLY.

129

"WE'LL BRING YOU, LET'S BE SWEET'S BACK FROM HONEYDOLLS," SAID HERMIONE, WHISKING DESPERATELY AWAY FOR HIM.

"YES, LEADS," SAID RICH. HE AND HERMIONE HAD FINALLY FIGURED OUT THEIR SOLUTION ABOUT CRIBS-AND-DOGS IN THE FACE OF HARRY'S DIFFICULTIES.

"DIDN'T WANT TO ABUSE ME," SAID HARRY, IN WHAT HE FELT WAS AT BEST A
VEHICLE, "I'LL SEE YOU AT THE FEAST, HAVE A GOOD TIME."

HE ACCOMPANIED THEM TO THE ENTRANCE HALL, WHERE FILCH, THE CARETAKER,
WAS STANDING INSIDE THE FRONT DOORS, CHECKING OFF NAMES AGAINST A LONG
LIST, PEERING SUSPICIOUSLY INTO EVERY FACE, AND MAKING SURE THAT NO ONE
WAS SPEAKING HINTS THAT HE SHOULDN'T BE GOING.

"STAYING HERE, BETTER?" WHISPERED MALFOY, WHO WAS STANDING IN LINE WITH
CRABBE AND GOYLE. "STARTED HE PASSING THE DEMENTERS?"

HARRY IGNORED HIM AND MADE HIS SILENT WAY UP THE MARBLE STAIRCASE,
THROUGH THE DESERTED HALLWAYS, AND BACK TO GRYFFINDOR TOWER.

"PASSING?" SAID THE FAT LADY, TALKING HINTS TO A DAME.

"FERTILIZING MALFOY," SAID HARRY LISTLESSLY.

THE PORTRAIT SWUNG OPEN AND HE CLIMBED THROUGH THE HOLE INTO THE
CHIMNEY

WHICH. IT WAS FULL OF CHATTERING FIRST AND SECOND YEARS, AND A FEW ELDER
STUDENTS, WHO HAD RECENTLY VISITED HOGSWARTS SEVENTEN THE NIGHTLY HAD
WHEN HE

"HARRY! HARRY! HI, HARRY!"

IT WAS CELIN CREEVEY, A SECOND YEAR WHO WAS DEEPLY IN LOVE WITH HARRY AND
NEVER MISSED AN OPPORTUNITY TO SPEAK TO HIM.

"AREN'T YOU GOING TO HOGSWARTS, HARRY? WHY NOT? WHY?" -- CELIN LOOKED
EAGERLY AROUND AT HIS FRIENDS -- "YOU CAN COME AND SIT WITH US, IF YOU
LIKE, HARRY!"

"ER -- NO, THANKS, CELIN," SAID HARRY, WHO WASN'T IN THE MOOD TO HAVE A

125

LEFT HIM PEOPLE STARING AVIDLY AT THE SCAR ON HIS FOREHEAD. "I -- I'VE GOT
THE GO TO THE LIBRARY, GOT TO GET SOME WORK DONE."

AFTER THAT, HE HAD NO CHOICE BUT TO TURN RIGHT AROUND AND HEAD BACK INTO

OF THE PORTRAIT FELL AGAIN.

"WHAT WAS THE POINT WAKING ME UP?" THE FAT LADY CALLED GRUMPILY AFTER HIM AS HE WALKED AWAY.

HARRY WANDERED DISPIRITEDLY TOWARD THE LIBRARY, BUT HALFWAY THERE HE CHANGED HIS MIND; HE DIDN'T FEEL LIKE WORKING. HE TURNED AROUND AND CAME FACE-TO-FACE WITH FILCH, WHO HAD HEVILY ILST SEEN HOF THE LAST OF THE FINGSMERE VISITERS.

"WHAT ARE YEL DOING?" FILCH SNARLED SUSPICIEUSLY.

"NOTHING," SAID HARRY TRULTEFULLY.

"NOTHING?" SPAT FILCH, HIS EELS SLIVERING UNPLEASANTLY, "A LIKELY STORY! SNEAKING AROUND HIN YELIR HORN -- WE-D AREN'T YEL IN FINGSMERE KLYING

STINK PELLETS AND BELCH PHEWER AND WE-HIZZING WHIRMS LIKE THE REST OF YELIR NASTY LITTLE FRIENDS?"

HARRY SHRUGGED.

"WELL, GET BACK TH YELIR CHIMPEN REHM WHERE YEL KLYING?" SNAPPED FILCH, AND HE STOOD GLARING UNTIL HARRY HAD PASSED BEHIT OF SIGHT.

BUT HARRY DIDN'T GO BACK TH THE CHIMPEN REHM; HE CLIMBED A STAIRCASE, THINKING VAGUELY OF VISITING THE FHLERY TH SEE F-EDWIC, AND WAS WALKING ALONG ANOTHER CORRIDOR WHEN A VOICE FROM INSIDE ONE OF THE REHMS SAID, "HARRY?"

HARRY BEHELED BACK TH SEE WHO HAD SPOKEN AND MET PROFESSOR KLIPIN, WHIRING AROUND HIS OFFICE DEER.

"WHAT ARE YEL DOING?" SAID KLIPIN, THOUGH IN A VERY DIFFERENT VOICE FROM FILCH. "WHERE ARE REH AND F-ERMITH?"

"FINGSMERE," SAID HARRY, IN A WEIRD-KE CASUAL VOICE.

128

"AH," SAID KLIPIN, HE CONSIDERED HARRY FOR A MOMENT. "WE-D DEEN'T YEL COME

IN? I'VE JUST TAKEN DELIVERY OF A GRINDWHEEL FOR HIS NEXT LESSON." "A

WHAT?" SAID HARRY. I

HE PHEELED KLIPIN INTO HIS OFFICE. IN THE CORNER STOOD A VERY LARGE TANK
OF WATER. A SICKLY GREEN CREATURE WITH SHARP LITTLE HORNS HAD ITS FACE
PRESSED AGAINST THE GLASS, PULLING FACES AND FLEXING ITS LONG, SPINDLY
FINGERS.

"WATER DEEPEN," SAID KLIPIN, SURVEYING THE GRINDWHEEL THOUGHTFULLY. "WE
SHOULD'NT HAVE MUCH DIFFICULTY WITH HIM, NOT AFTER THE DAPPAS. THE TRICK
IS TO BREAK HIS GRIP. YOU NOTICE THE ABNORMALLY LONG FINGERS? STRONG,
BUT VERY BRITTLE."

THE GRINDWHEEL BARED ITS GREEN TEETH AND THEN ELIRED ITSELF IN A TANGLE
OF WEEDS IN A CORNER.

"CLIP UP TEA?" KLIPIN SAID, WHISKING AROUND FOR HIS KETTLE. "I WAS JUST
THINKING OF MAKING ONE."

"ALL RIGHT," SAID HARRY ALQUARDLY.

KLIPIN TAPPED THE KETTLE WITH HIS HAND AND A BLAST OF STEAM ISSUED
SUDDENLY FROM THE SPILT.

"SIT DOWN," SAID KLIPIN, TAKING THE LID OFF A DUSTY TIN. "I'VE ONLY GOT
TEARAGS, I'M AFRAID -- BUT I DARE SAY YOU'VE HAD ENOUGH OF TEA LEAVES?"

HARRY WHISKED AT HIM. KLIPIN'S EYES WERE TWINKLING.

"HOW DID YOU KNOW ABOUT THAT?" HARRY ASKED.

"PROFESSOR MCGHINAGALL TOLD ME," SAID KLIPIN, PASSING HARRY A CHIPPED MUG
OF TEA. "YOU'RE NOT WORRIED, ARE YOU?"

"NO," SAID HARRY.

HE THOUGHT FOR A MOMENT OF TELLING KLIPIN ABOUT THE DING HE'D SEEN IN
MAGNOLIA CRESCENT BUT DECIDED NOT TO. HE DIDN'T WANT KLIPIN TO THINK HE

WAS A CHILD, ESPECIALLY SINCE LLIPIN ALREADY SEEMED TO THINK HE WOULDN'T
COME WITH A KEGGART.

SOMETHING OF FARRY'S TELLTALS SEEMED TO HAVE SEEN HIM HIS FACE, BECAUSE
LLIPIN SAID, "ANYTHING WORTHYING YOU, FARRY?"

"NO," FARRY LIED, HE DRANK A BIT OF TEA AND WATCHED THE GRINDWHEEL
BRANDISHING A FIST AT HIM. "YES," HE SAID SILENTLY, PUTTING HIS TEA DOWN
ON LLIPIN'S DESK. "YOU KNOW THAT DAY WE FIGHT THE KEGGART?"

"YES," SAID LLIPIN SILENTLY.

"WHY DIDN'T YOU LET ME FIGHT IT?" SAID FARRY ABRUPTLY.

LLIPIN RAISED HIS EYEBROWS.

"I WOULD HAVE THOUGHT THAT WAS OBVIOUS, FARRY," HE SAID, SOUNDING
SURPRISED.

FARRY, WHO HAD EXPECTED LLIPIN TO DENY THAT HE'D DONE ANY SUCH THING, WAS
TAKEN ABACK.

"WHY?" HE SAID AGAIN.

"WELL," SAID LLIPIN, FROWNING SLIGHTLY. "I ASSUMED THAT IF THE KEGGART
FELL YOU, IT WOULD ASSUME THE SHAPE OF LORD VERMONT."

FARRY STARED. NOT ONLY WAS THIS THE LAST ANSWER HE'D EXPECTED, BUT LLIPIN
HAD SAID VERMONT'S NAME. THE ONLY PERSON FARRY HAD EVER HEARD SAY THE
NAME ALONE APART FROM HIMSELF WAS PROFESSOR DUMKEDORE.

"CLEARLY, I WAS WRONG," SAID LLIPIN, STILL FROWNING AT FARRY. "BUT I
DIDN'T THINK IT A GOOD IDEA FOR LORD VERMONT TO MATERIALIZE IN THE
STAFFROOM. I IMAGINED THAT PEOPLE WOULD PANIC."

"I DIDN'T THINK OF VERMONT," SAID FARRY HESITANTLY. "I -- I REMEMBERED
THESE DEMENTERS."

"I SEE," SAID LLIPIN TELLTALLY. "WELL, WELL... I'M IMPRESSED." HE
SMILED SLIGHTLY AT THE LOOK OF SURPRISE ON FARRY'S FACE. "THAT SUGGESTS

THAT WHAT YOU FEEL FIRST OF ALL IS -- FEAR, VERY WISE, HARRY."

HARRY DIDN'T KNOW WHAT TO SAY TO THAT, SO HE DRANK SOME MORE TEA.

"SEE YOU'VE BEEN THINKING THAT I DIDN'T BELIEVE YOU CAPABLE OF FIGHTING THE KREGGART?" SAID LUPIN SMILING.

"WELL... YES," SAID HARRY, HE WAS SUDDENLY FEELING A LITTLE HAPPIER.

"PROFESSOR LUPIN, YOU KNOW THE DEMENTORS --"

HE WAS INTERRUPTED BY A KNOCK ON THE DOOR.

"COME IN," CALLED LUPIN.

THE DOOR OPENED, AND IN CAME SNAPE, HE WAS CARRYING A CASKET, WHICH WAS SMELLING FAINTLY, AND STOPPED AT THE SIGHT OF HARRY, HIS BLACK EYES NARROWING.

"AH, SEVERUS," SAID LUPIN, SMILING. "THANKS VERY MUCH, CHILD YOU LEAVE IT HERE ON THE DESK FOR ME?"

SNAPE SET DOWN THE SMELLING CASKET, HIS EYES WANDERING BETWEEN HARRY AND LUPIN.

"I WAS JUST SHOWING HARRY MY GRINDSTONE," SAID LUPIN PLEASANTLY, POINTING AT THE TABLE.

"FASCINATING," SAID SNAPE, WITHOUT LOOKING AT IT. "YOU SHOULD DRINK THAT DIRECTLY, LUPIN."

"YES, YES, I WILL," SAID LUPIN.

"I MADE AN ENTIRE CALIBRENGER," SNAPE CONTINUED. "IF YOU NEED MORE."

"I SHOULD PROBABLY TAKE SOME AGAIN TOMORROW. THANKS VERY MUCH, SEVERUS."

"NOT AT ALL," SAID SNAPE, BUT THERE WAS A LINE IN HIS EYE HARRY DIDN'T LIKE, HE KNEW WELL OF THE ROOM, UNSMILING AND WATCHFUL.

HARRY LOOKED CURIOUSLY AT THE CASKET. LUPIN SMILED.

"PROFESSOR SNAPE HAS VERY KINDLY REQUESTED A PETITION FOR ME," HE SAID. "I HAVE NEVER BEEN MUCH OF A PETITION-DRIVER AND THIS ONE IS PARTICULARLY COMPLEX." HE PICKED UP THE SHEET AND SNIPPED IT. "PITY SWEAR MAKES IT USELESS," HE ADDED, TAKING A SIP AND S-LIDDERING.

"WELL --" HARRY BEGAN. LUPIN LOOKED AT HIM AND ANSWERED THE UNFINISHED QUESTIONS.

"I'VE BEEN FEELING A BIT OFF-COLOR," HE SAID. "THIS PETITION IS THE ONLY THING THAT HELPS. I AM VERY LUCKY TO BE WORKING ALONGSIDE PROFESSOR SNAPE; THERE AREN'T MANY WIZARDS WHO ARE UP TO MAKING IT."

PROFESSOR LUPIN TOOK ANOTHER SIP AND HARRY HAD A CRAZY WINK TO KNOW THE

SHEET WAS IN HIS HANDS.

"PROFESSOR SNAPE'S VERY INTERESTED IN THE DARK ARTS, HE MENTIONED THAT.

"REALLY?" SAID LUPIN, LOOKING ONLY MILDLY INTERESTED AS HE TOOK ANOTHER GLIMPSE OF THE SHEET.

"SOME PEOPLE THINK --" HARRY HESITATED, THEN PLUNGED RECKLESSLY ON.

"SOME PEOPLE THINK HE'D DO ANYTHING TO GET THE DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS OFF."

LUPIN DRAINED THE SHEET AND PULLED A FACE.

"DISGUSTING," HE SAID. "WELL, HARRY, I'D BETTER GET BACK TO WORK. SEE YOU AT THE FEAST LATER."

"RIGHT," SAID HARRY, PLACING DOWN HIS EMPTY TRAY.

THE EMPTY SHEET WAS STILL SMOKING.

"THERE YOU GO," SAID REIN. "WE GOT AS MUCH AS WE COULD CARRY."

A SMOOTHER OF BRILLIANTLY COLOURED SWEETS FELL INTO HARRY'S LAP. IT WAS BLISS, AND REIN AND HERMIONE HAD INSTANTLY TURNED UP IN THE CHAIRS REIN, PINK-FACED FROM THE CHILD WIND AND LOOKING AS THOUGH THEY'D HAD THE TIME OF THEIR LIVES.

"THANKS," SAID HARRY, PICKING UP A PACKET OF TINY BLACK PEPPER IMPS.

"WHAT'S THE SPREAD LIKE? WHERE DID YOU GET"

BY THE SOUND OF IT -- EVERYWHERE. DERVISH AND BANGES, THE WIZARDING EQUIPMENT SHOP, ZEDDIE'S LEMON SHOP, IN THE THREE BROOMSTICKS AND FADING MUGS OF FEET CLATTERER, AND MANY PLACES BESIDES.

"THE POST OFFICE, HARRY? ABOUT TWO HUNDRED EGGS, ALL SITTING ON SHELVES, ALL CHEER-LEDED DEPENDING ON HOW FAST YOU WANT YOUR LETTER TO GET THERE?"

"HERNEDONES HAS GOT A NEW KIND OF PUDGE; THEY WERE GIVING ME FREE SAMPLES, THERE'S A KIT, LEMON --"

"WE THINK WE SAW AN EGRE, HONESTLY, THEY GET ALL SHOTS AT THE THREE BROOMSTICKS --"

"WISH WE COULD HAVE BROUGHT YOU SOME CLATTERER, REALLY WARM YOU UP --"

"WHAT DID YOU GET?" SAID HERMIONE, LOOKING ANXIOUS, "DID YOU GET ANY LEMON DUNE?"

"NO," SAID HARRY, "LUPIN MADE ME A CUP OF TEA IN HIS OFFICE, AND THEN SNAPE CAME IN..."

HE TOLD THEM ALL ABOUT THE CHURCH, RON'S MOUTH FELL OPEN.

"LUPIN DRANK IT?" HE GASPED. "IS HE MAD?"

HERMIONE CHECKED HER WATCH.

"WE'D BETTER GO NOW, YOU KNOW, THE FEAST'LL BE STARTING IN FIFTEEN MINUTES

THEY HURRIED THROUGH THE PORTRAIT HOLE AND INTO THE KITCHEN, STILL DISCUSSING SNAPE.

"BUT IF HE -- YOU KNOW" -- HERMIONE DROPPED HER VEIL, GLANCING NERVIOUSLY AROUND -- "IF HE WAS TRYING TO TELL US LUPIN -- HE WOULDN'T HAVE DONE IT IN FRONT OF HARRY."

"Yeah, maybe," said Harry as they reached the entrance hall and crossed into the Great Hall. It had been decorated with hundreds and hundreds of candle-filled pumpkin, a cloud of fluttering live bats, and many flaming orange streamers, which were swimming lazily across the stony ceiling like brilliant water snakes.

The food was delicious; even Hermione and Ron, who were still the slightest with honey-sweetened sweets, managed second helpings of everything. Harry kept glancing at the staff table. Professor Lupin looked cheerful and as well as he ever did; he was talking animatedly to tiny little Professor Flitwick, the charms teacher. Harry moved his eyes along the table, to the place where Snape sat. Was he imagining it, or were Snape's eyes flickering toward Lupin more often than was natural? The feast finished with an entertainment provided by the Hogwarts ghosts. They popped out of the walls and tables to do a bit of apparition gliding. Nearly Headless Nick, the Gryffindor ghost, had a great success with a reenactment of his own beheaded beheading.

It had been such a pleasant evening that Harry's good mood couldn't even be spoiled by Malfoy, who sneered through the crowd as they all left the hall. "The Dementors send their love, Potter!"

Harry, Ron, and Hermione followed the rest of the Gryffindors along the usual path to the Gryffindor Tower, but when they reached the corridor that ended with the portrait of the Fat Lady, they found it jammed with students.

"Why isn't anyone going in?" said Ron curiously.

Harry peered over the heads in front of him. The portrait seemed to be closed.

"Let me through, please," came Percy's voice, and he came bustling importantly through the crowd. "What's the holdup here? We can't all

HAVE FORGOTTEN THE PASSWORD -- EXCUSE ME, I'M HEAD BEE --"

AND THEN A SILENCE FELL OVER THE CROWD, FROM THE FRONT FIRST, SEE THAT A
CHILL SEEMED TO SPREAD DOWN THE CORRIDOR. THEY HEARD PERCY SAY, IN A

182

SUDDENLY SHARP VOICE, "SOMEBODY GET PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE, QUICK."

PEOPLE'S HEADS TURNED; THOSE AT THE BACK WERE STANDING ON TIPTOE.

"WHAT'S GOING ON?" SAID GINNY, WHO HAD JUST ARRIVED.

A MOMENT LATER, PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE WAS THERE, SLEEPING TOWARD THE
PORTRAIT; THE GRYFFINDORS SQUEEZED TOGETHER TO LET HIM THROUGH, AND
HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONIE MOVED CLOSER TO SEE WHAT THE PROBLEM WAS.

"HEY, ME --" HERMIONIE GRABBED HARRY'S ARM.

THE FAT LADY HAD VANISHED FROM HER PORTRAIT, WHICH HAD BEEN SLASHED SO
VIOLENTLY THAT STRIPS OF CANVAS LITTERED THE FLOOR; GREAT CHUNKS OF IT
HAD BEEN TORN AWAY COMPLETELY.

DUMBLEDORE THREW ONE QUICK LOOK AT THE RUINED PAINTING AND TURNED, HIS
EYES SHUTTER, TO SEE PROFESSORS MCGONAGALL, LUPIN, AND SNAPE HURRYING
TOWARD HIM.

"WE NEED TO FIND HER," SAID DUMBLEDORE. "PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, PLEASE GO
TO MR. FILCH AT ONCE AND TELL HIM TO SEARCH EVERY PAINTING IN THE CASTLE
FOR THE FAT LADY."

"YOU'LL BE BLOODY?" SAID A CACKLING VOICE.

IT WAS PERCY THE PENTAGONIST, CACKLING OVER THE CROWD AND WHISKING
DELIGHTED, AS HE ALWAYS DID, AT THE SIGHT OF WEREWOLF HIS WHISKY.

"WHAT DO YOU MEAN, PERCY?" SAID DUMBLEDORE CALMLY, AND PERCY'S GRIN
FADDED A LITTLE. HE DIDN'T DARE TALK TO DUMBLEDORE. INSTEAD HE ADOPTED AN
EILY VOICE THAT WAS NOT BETTER THAN HIS CACKLE. "AS-MADE, YOUR HEADSHIP,
SIT, DOESN'T WANT TO BE SEEN. SHE'S A TERRIBLE MESS, SAW HER RUNNING

THROUGH THE LANDSCAPE UP IN THE FOURTH FLOOR, SIR, HIDING BETWEEN THE TREES, CRYING SOMETHING DREADFUL," HE SAID HAPPILY. "OTHER THING," HE ADDED LINGERINGLY.

"DID SHE SAY WHEN DID IT?" SAID DUMBLEDORE QUIETLY.

"EH YES, PROFESSOR-HEAD," SAID PEEVES, WITH THE AIR OF ONE CRADLING A

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LARGE KIMSWELL IN HIS ARMS. "HE GOT VERY ANGRY WHEN SHE WOULDN'T LET HIM IN, YEH SEE." PEEVES FLIPPED OVER AND GRINNED AT DUMBLEDORE FROM BETWEEN HIS OWN LEGS. "NASTY TEMPER HE'S GOT, THAT SIRIUS BLACK."

CHAPTER NINE

GRIM DEWAT

PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE SENT ALL THE GRYFFINDORS BACK TO THE GREAT HALL, WHERE THEY WERE JOINED TEN MINUTES LATER BY THE STUDENTS FROM HUFFLEPUFF, RAVENCLAW, AND SLYTHERIN, WHO ALL LOOKED EXTREMELY CONCERNED.

"THE TEACHERS AND I NEED TO CONDUCT A THOROUGH SEARCH OF THE CASTLE," PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE TOLD THEM AS PROFESSORS MCGONAGALL AND FLITWICK CLOSED ALL DOORS INTO THE HALL. "I'M AFRAID THAT, FOR YOUR OWN SAFETY, YOU WILL HAVE TO SPEND THE NIGHT HERE. I WANT THE PROTECTS TO STAND GUARD OVER THE ENTRANCES TO THE HALL AND I AM LEAVING THE HEAD BOY AND GIRL IN CHARGE, AND DISTURBANCE SHOULD BE REPORTED TO ME IMMEDIATELY," HE ADDED TO PERCY, WHO WAS LOOKING IMPENSELY PROUD AND IMPORTANT. "SEND WORD WITH ME OF THE GHOSTS."

PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE PAUSED ABOUT TO LEAVE THE HALL, AND SAID, "EH, YES, YOU'LL BE NEEDING..."

HIS CASUAL WAVE OF HIS HAND AND THE LONG TABLES ALONG THE SIDES OF THE HALL AND STOOD THEMSELVES AGAINST THE WALLS; ANOTHER WAVE, AND THE FLOOR WAS COVERED WITH HUNDREDS OF SEVERAL PURPLE SLEEPING BAGS.

"SLEEP WELL," SAID PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE, CLOSING THE DOOR BEHIND HIM.

THE HALL IMMEDIATELY BEGAN THE BUZZ EXCITEDLY; THE GRYPFINDERS WERE TELLING THE REST OF THE SCHOOL WHAT HAD JUST HAPPENED.

"EVERYONE INTO THEIR SLEEPING BAGS!" SHOUTED PERCY. "COME ON, NOW, NOW MORE TALKING! LIGHTS OUT IN TEN MINUTES!"

"UMMM," RHN SAID TO HARRY AND HERMIONE; THEY SEIZED THREE SLEEPING BAGS AND DRAGGED THEM INTO A CORNER.

"DO YOU THINK BLACK'S STILL IN THE CASTLE?" HERMIONE WHISPERED

129

ANXIOUSLY.

"DUMBLEDORE HEAVILYLY THINKS HE MIGHT BE," SAID RHN.

"IT'S VERY LUCKY HE PICKED TONIGHT, YOU KNOW," SAID HERMIONE AS THEY CLIMBED QUICKLY DRESSED INTO THEIR SLEEPING BAGS AND PROPPED THEMSELVES ON THEIR ELBOWS THE TALK. "THE ONE NIGHT WE WEREN'T IN THE TOWER..."

I RECKON HE'S LOST TRACK OF TIME, BEING ON THE RUN," SAID RHN. "DIDN'T REALIZE IT WAS HALLOWEEN, OTHERWISE HE'D HAVE BEEN KILTING IN HERE."

HERMIONE SHOOKED.

ALL AROUND THEM, PEOPLE WERE ASKING ONE ANOTHER THE SAME QUESTION: "HOW

DID HE GET IN?"

"MAYBE HE KNOWS HOW THE APPARATE," SAID A RAVENCLAW A FEW FEET AWAY.

"JUST APPEAR OUT OF THIN AIR, YOU KNOW."

"DISGUISED HIMSELF, PROBABLY," SAID A HUFFLEPUFF FIFTH YEAR. "THE CHILD'VE BEEN IN," SUGGESTED DEAN THOMAS.

"HONESTLY, AM I THE ONLY PERSON WHO'S EVER EITHERED THE READ HIGWARTS, A HISTORY?" SAID HERMIONE CROSSLY TO HARRY AND RHN.

"PROBABLY," SAID RHN. "WHY?"

"BECAUSE THE CASTLE'S PROTECTED BY MORE THAN WALLS, YOU KNOW," SAID

HERMIONE. "THERE ARE ALL SORTS OF ENCHANTMENTS ON IT, THE SLEEP PEOPLE ENTERING BY STEALTH. YOU CAN'T JUST APPARATE IN HERE. AND I'D LIKE TO SEE THE DISGUISE THAT COULD MAKE THESE DEMENTORS. THEY'RE GUARDING EVERY SINGLE ENTRANCE TO THE GRIMMOLD. THEY'D HAVE SEEN HIM AS IN THERE. AND FITCH KNOWS ALL THE SECRET PASSAGES, THEY'LL HAVE THEM COVERED...."

"THE LIGHTS ARE GOING OUT NOW!" PERCY WHISPERED. "I WANT EVERYONE IN THEIR SLEEPING BAGS AND NOT HERE TALKING!"

THE CANDLES ALL WENT OUT AT ONCE. THE ONLY LIGHT NOW CAME FROM THE SILVERY GHOSTS, WHO WERE DRIFTING ABOUT TALKING SERIOUSLY TO THE PRECEPTS, AND THE ENCHANTED CEILING, WHICH, LIKE THE SLEEP HILLSIDE, WAS

185

SCATTERED WITH STARS, WHAT WITH THAT, AND THE WHISPERING THAT STILL FILLED THE HALL, HARRY FELT AS THOUGH HE WERE SLEEPING HITCHHIKERS IN A LIGHT WIND.

HENCE EVERY HOUR, A TEACHER WOULD REAPPEAR IN THE HALL TO CHECK THAT EVERYTHING WAS QUIET. ABOUT THREE IN THE MORNING, WHEN MANY STUDENTS HAD FINALLY FALLEN ASLEEP, PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE CAME IN. HARRY WATCHED HIM WHISKING ABOUT FOR PERCY, WHO HAD BEEN PRUDDLING BETWEEN THE SLEEPING BAGS, TELLING PEOPLE OFF FOR TALKING. PERCY WAS ONLY A SHORT WAY AWAY FROM HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONE, WHO QUICKLY PRETENDED TO BE ASLEEP AS DUMBLEDORE'S FOOTSTEPS DREW NEARER.

"ANY SIGN OF HIM, PROFESSOR?" ASKED PERCY IN A WHISPER.

"NO. ALL WELL HERE?"

"EVERYTHING UNDER CONTROL, SIR."

"GOOD. THERE'S NO POINT MOVING THEM ALL NOW. I'VE FOUND A TEMPORARY GUARDIAN FOR THE GRYPFINDER PORTRAIT HERE. YOU'LL BE ABLE TO MOVE THEM BACK IN TOMORROW."

"AND THE FAT LADY, SIR?"

"FINDING IN A MAP OF WILTSHIRE IN THE SECOND FLOOR, APPARENTLY SHE RECALLED THE LET BLACK IN WITHELLT THE PASSAGE, SHE HE ATTACKED, SHE'S STILL VERY DISTRESSED, BUT SINCE SHE'S CALMED DOWN, I'LL HAVE MR. FILCH RESTORE HER."

HARRY HEARD THE DOOR OF THE HALL CREAK OPEN AGAIN, AND MORE FOOTSTEPS.

"HEADMASTER?" IT WAS SNAPE, HARRY KEPT HEART STILL, LISTENING HARD, "THE WHILE OF THE THIRD FLOOR HAS BEEN SEARCHED, HE'S NOT THERE, AND FILCH HAS DONE THE DUNGEONS; NOTHING THERE EITHER."

"WHAT ABOUT THE ASTROLOGY TOWER? PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY'S ROOM? THE HALLS?"

"ALL SEARCHED."

LIKE

"VERY WELL, SEVERUS, I DIDN'T REALLY EXPECT BLACK TO LINGER."

"I HAVE BEEN ASKING THEM AS THE MOMENT HE GOT IN, PROFESSOR?" ASKED SNAPE.

HARRY RAISED HIS HEAD VERY SLIGHTLY OFF HIS ARMS TO FREE HIS OTHER EAR.

"MAYBE, SEVERUS, EACH OF THEM AS UNLIKELY AS THE NEXT."

HARRY OPENED HIS EYES A FRACTION AND SHOOKED UP THE WHERE THEY STOOD;

BLUMBERG'S BACK WAS TO HIM, BUT HE COULD SEE PERCY'S FACE, RAPT WITH

ATTENTION, AND SNAPE'S PROFILE, WHICH LOOKED ANGRY.

"WELL REMEMBER THE CONVERSATION WE HAD, HEADMASTER, JUST BEFORE -- AH --

THE START OF TERM?" SAID SNAPE, WHO WAS EARLY OPENING HIS LIPS, AS

THOUGH TRYING TO REMIND PERCY OF THE CONVERSATION.

"I SEE, SEVERUS," SAID BLUMBERG, AND THERE WAS SOMETHING LIKE WARNING IN HIS VOICE.

"IT SEEMS -- ALMOST IMPOSSIBLE -- THAT BLACK COULD HAVE ENTERED THE SCHOOL WITHELLT INSIDE HELP, I DID EXPRESS MY CONCERNS WHEN, WELL

APPOINTED --"

"I DO NOT BELIEVE A SINGLE PERSON INSIDE THIS CASTLE WOULD HAVE HELPED BLACK ENTER IT," SAID DUMBLEDORE, AND HIS TONE MADE IT SH CLEAR THAT THE SUBJECT WAS CLOSED THAT SNAPE DIDN'T REPLY. "I MUST GO DOWN THE THE DEMENTORS," SAID DUMBLEDORE. I SAID I WOULD INFORM THEM WHEN MY SEARCH WAS COMPLETE."

"DIDN'T THEY WANT THE HELP, SITY?" SAID PERCY.

"HEY YES," SAID DUMBLEDORE COLDLY. "BUT I'M AFRAID THE DEMENTOR WILL CROSS THE THRESHOLD OF THIS CASTLE WHILE I AM HEADMASTER."

PERCY LOOKED SLIGHTLY ABASHED. DUMBLEDORE LEFT THE HALL, WALKING QUIETLY AND QUIETLY. SNAPE STOOD FOR A MOMENT, WATCHING THE HEADMASTER WITH AN EXPRESSION OF DEEP RESENTMENT ON HIS FACE; THEN HE TOO LEFT.

HARRY GLANCED SIDELONG AT RON AND HERMION, BOTH OF THEM HAD THEIR EYES OPEN TOO, REFLECTING THE STARRY CEILING.

189

"WHAT WAS ALL THAT ABOUT?" RON MURMURED.

THE SCHOOL TALKED OF NOTHING BUT SIRIUS BLACK FOR THE NEXT FEW DAYS. THE THEORIES ABOUT HOW HE HAD ENTERED THE CASTLE BECAME WILDER AND WILDER;

JANNA ABBOTT, FROM HUFFLEPUFF, SPENT MUCH OF THEIR NEXT HOURS CLASS TELLING ANYONE WHO'D LISTEN THAT BLACK HAD TURNED INTO A FLEETING SNAKE.

THE FAT LADY'S RIPPED CANYAS HAD BEEN TAKEN OFF THE WALL AND REPLACED WITH THE PORTRAIT OF SIR CADOGAN AND HIS FAT GRAY PONY. NEHEM WAS VERY HAPPY ABOUT THIS. SIR CADOGAN SPENT HALF HIS TIME CHALLENGING PEOPLE THE DUKES, AND THE REST THINKING UP RIDICULOUSLY COMPLICATED PASSWORDS, WHICH HE CHANGED AT LEAST TWICE A DAY.

"HE'S A COMPLETE LUNATIC," SAID SEamus FINNIGAN ANGRILY TO PERCY. "CAN'T WE GET ANYONE ELSE?"

"NONE OF THE OTHER PICTURES WANTED THE JOB," SAID PERCY. "FRIGHTENED OF WHAT HAPPENED TO THE FAT LADY. SIR LADWIGAN WAS THE ONLY ONE BRAVE ENOUGH

TO VOLUNTEER."

SIR LADWIGAN, HOWEVER, WAS THE LEAST OF HARRY'S WORRIES. HE WAS BEING CLOSELY WATCHED. TEACHERS ALWAYS EXCUSSED THE WALK ALONG CORRIDORS WITH HIM, AND PERCY WEASLEY (ACTING, HARRY SUSPECTED, ON HIS MOTHER'S ORDERS) WAS TAILING HIM EVERYWHERE LIKE AN EXTREMELY PHIMPISH GUARD DOG. THE CAP IT ALL, PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL SLAMMED HARRY INTO HER OFFICE, WITH SUCH A STERN EXPRESSION ON HER FACE HARRY THOUGHT SOMETHING MUST HAVE DIED.

"THERE'S NO POINT HIDING IT FROM ME, ANY LONGER, POTTER," SHE SAID IN A VERY SERIOUS VOICE. "I KNOW THIS WILL COME AS A SHOCK TO YOU, BUT SIRIUS IS DEAD --"

"I KNOW HE'S DEAD," SAID HARRY WEARILY. "I HEARD REMUS'S DAD TELLING HIS MUM, MR. WEASLEY WORKS FOR THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC."

PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL SEEMED VERY TAKEN ABACK. SHE STARED AT HARRY FOR A MOMENT AND THEN SAID, "I SEE! WELL, IN THAT CASE, POTTER, YOU'LL UNDERSTAND WHY I DIDN'T THINK IT'S A GOOD IDEA FOR YOU TO BE PRACTICING

LEO

FLUIDITY IN THE EVENINGS. MEET ME IN THE FIELD WITH ONLY YOUR TEAM MEMBERS. IT'S VERY EXPOSED, POTTER --"

"WE'VE GOT OUR FIRST MATCH ON SATURDAY!" SAID HARRY, ELTRAGED. "I'VE GOT THE TRAIN, PROFESSOR!"

PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL CONSIDERED HIM INTENTLY. HARRY KNEW SHE WAS DEEPLY INTERESTED IN THE GRYPFINDER TEAM'S PROSPECTS; IT HAD BEEN SHE, AFTER ALL, WHO'D SUGGESTED HIM AS SEEKER IN THE FIRST PLACE. HE WAITED, HOLDING HIS BREATH.

"HMM..." PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL STOOD UP AND STARED OUT OF THE WINDOWS AT

THE FLUIDITCH FIELD, JUST VISIBLE THROUGH THE RAIN. "WELL... CHERNESS KNOWS, I'D LIKE TO SEE US WIN THE CUP AT LAST... BUT ALL THE SAME, BETTER... I'D BE HAPPIER IF A TEACHER WERE PRESENT, I'LL ASK MADAM BEECH THE HYPERSEE VEHIC TRAINING SESSIONS."

THE WEATHER WORSENERED STEADILY AS THE FIRST FLUIDITCH MATCH DREW NEARER. UNDAUNTED, THE GRYFFINDOR TEAM WAS TRAINING HARDER THAN EVER UNDER THE EYE OF MADAM BEECH. THEN, AT THEIR FINAL TRAINING SESSION BEFORE SATURDAY'S MATCH, ELIVER WOOD GAVE HIS TEAM SOME UNWELCOME NEWS. "WE'RE NOT PLAYING SLOTHERING!" HE TOLD THEM, SOUNING VERY ANGRY. "FLINT'S JUST BEEN TO SEE ME, WE'RE PLAYING FLUFFLEPUFF INSTEAD." "WHY?" CHALLENGED THE REST OF THE TEAM.

"FLINT'S EXCUSE IS THAT THEIR SEEKER'S ARM'S STILL INJURED," SAID WOOD, GRINDING HIS TEETH FURIOUSLY. "BUT IT'S BECAUSE WE'RE DOING IT, WE DON'T WANT TO PLAY IN THIS WEATHER, THINK IT'LL DAMAGE THEIR CHANCES..."

THERE HAD BEEN STRONG WINDS AND HEAVY RAIN ALL DAY, AND AS WOOD SPEKE, THEY HEARD A DISTANT RUMBLE OF THUNDER.

"THERE'S NOTHING WRONG WITH MALFOY'S ARM!" SAID HARRY FURIOUSLY, "HE'S FADING IT!"

"I KNOW THAT, BUT WE CAN'T PROVE IT," SAID WOOD BITTERLY, "AND WE'VE BEEN PRACTICING ALL THESE MOVES ASSUMING WE'RE PLAYING SLOTHERING, AND

187

INSTEAD IT'S FLUFFLEPUFF, AND THEIR STYLE'S COMPLETELY DIFFERENT. THEY'VE GOT A NEW CAPTAIN AND SEEKER, CEDRIC DIGGORY --"

ANGELINA, ALICIA, AND KATIE SUDDENLY GIGGLED.

"WHAT?" SAID WOOD, FROWNING AT THIS LIGHT-HEARTED REACTION.

"HE'S THAT TALL, CHIMP-LOOKING ONE, ISN'T HE?" SAID ANGELINA.

"STRENGTH AND SILENT," SAID KATIE, AND THEY STARTED THE GIGGLE AGAIN.

"HE'S ONLY SILENT BECAUSE HE'S BEEN THICK THE STRING TWO WEEKS TOGETHER,"

SAID FRED IMPATIENTLY. "I DIDN'T KNOW WE'D BE HERE WHEN WE WERE HERE, HELPER.

FLAPFLAP IS A PLEASURE. LAST TIME WE PLAYED THEM, HARRY CALLED THE
SWITCH IN ABOUT FIVE MINUTES, REMEMBER?"

"WE WERE PLAYING IN COMPLETELY DIFFERENT CIRCUMSTANCES!" WHO SPELLED, HIS
EYES BLINKING SLIGHTLY. "DICKER'S PUT A VERY STRONG SIDE TOGETHER. HE'S
AN EXCELLENT SEEKER. I WAS AFRAID WE'D TAKE IT LIKE THIS. WE MUSTN'T
RELAX. WE MUST KEEP OUR FEELINGS. SLOTHERIN IS TRYING THE WINDING-UP LIST. WE
MUST WIN."

"HELPER, CALM DOWN!" SAID FRED, LOOKING SLIGHTLY ALARMED. "WE'RE TAKING
FLAPFLAP VERY SERIOUSLY, SERIOUSLY."

THE DAY BEFORE THE MATCH, THE WINDS REACHED FEVERISH PITCH AND THE RAIN
FELL HARDER THAN EVER. IT WAS THE DARK INSIDE THE CORRIDORS AND
CLASSROOMS THAT EXTRA THICKETS AND LANTERNS WERE LIT. THE SLOTHERIN TEAM
WAS LOOKING VERY STRONG INDEED, AND NONE MORE SO THAN MALFOY.

"AH, IF ONLY MY ARM WAS FEELING A BIT BETTER!" HE SIGHED AS THE GALE
BLASTED PAST THE WINDOWS.

HARRY HAD NO ROOM IN HIS HEAD THE MORNING ABOUT ANYTHING EXCEPT THE MATCH
THEMSELVES. HELPER WHO KEPT HURRYING UP TO HIM BETWEEN CLASSES AND
GIVING

HIM TIPS. THE THIRD TIME THIS HAPPENED, WHO TALKED FOR HIM THAT
HARRY SUDDENLY REALIZED HE WAS TEN MINUTES LATE FOR DEFENSE AGAINST THE
DARK ARTS, AND SET OFF AT A RUN WITH WHO SPELLED AFTER HIM. "DICKER'S
GOT A VERY FAST SERVICE, HARRY, SO YOU MIGHT WANT TO TRY KICKING HIM --"

140

HARRY SKIDDED TO A HALT OUTSIDE THE DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS
CLASSROOM, PULLED THE DOOR OPEN, AND DASHED INSIDE.

"SHHRY I'M LATE, PROFESSOR KLIPIN, I --"

BUT IT WASN'T PROFESSOR KLIPIN WHO LOOKED UP AT HIM FROM THE TEACHER'S DESK; IT WAS SNAPE.

"THIS LESSON BEGAN TEN MINUTES AGO, PETER, SO I THINK WE'LL MAKE IT TEN POINTS FROM GRYFFINDOR, SIT DOWN."

BUT HARRY DIDN'T MOVE.

"WHERE'S PROFESSOR KLIPIN?" HE SAID.

"HE SAYS HE IS FEELING TERRIBLE TODAY," SAID SNAPE WITH A TWISTED SMILE. "I BELIEVE I SHOULD FEEL THE SIT DOWN"

BUT HARRY STAYED WHERE HE WAS.

"WHAT'S WRONG WITH HIM?"

SNAPE'S BLACK EYES GLITTERED.

"NOTHING LIFE-THREATENING," HE SAID, SNEERING AS THOUGH HE WISHED IT WERE. "FIVE MORE POINTS FROM GRYFFINDOR, AND IF I HAVE THE ASK FEEL THE SIT DOWN AGAIN, IT WILL BE FIFTY."

HARRY WALKED SLOWLY TO HIS SEAT AND SAT DOWN. SNAPE LOOKED AROUND AT THE CLASS.

"AS I WAS SAYING BEFORE PETER INTERRUPTED, PROFESSOR KLIPIN HAS NOT LEFT AND RETURNED OF THE TOPICS WE HAVE COVERED SO FAR --"

"PLEASE, SIR, WE'VE DONE KEGGARTS, RED CAPS, RAPPAS, AND GRINDWHEELS," SAID HERMIONE QUICKLY, "AND WE'RE JUST ABOUT TO START --"

"BE QUIET," SAID SNAPE COLDLY. "I DID NOT ASK FOR INFORMATION, I WAS MERELY COMMENTING ON PROFESSOR KLIPIN'S LACK OF ORGANIZATION."

141

"HE'S THE BEST DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS TEACHER WE'VE EVER HAD," SAID DEAN THOMAS QUICKLY, AND THERE WAS A MURMUR OF AGREEMENT FROM THE REST OF THE CLASS. SNAPE LOOKED MORE MENACING THAN EVER.

"THEY ARE EASILY SATISFIED, LUPIN IS HARDLY OVERTAKING THEM -- I WOULD EXPECT FIRST YEARS TO BE ABLE TO DEAL WITH RED CAPS AND GRINDWHEELS.

THEY ARE STILL DISCLOSE --"

HARRY WATCHED HIM FLICK THROUGH THE TEXTBOOK, TO THE VERY BACK CHAPTER, WHICH HE MUST KNOW THEY HADN'T COVERED.

"WEREWOLVES," SAID SNAPE.

"BLIT, SIR," SAID HERMIONE, SEEMINGLY UNABLE TO RESTRAIN HERSELF, "WE'RE NOT SLIPPED THE DEER WEREWOLVES YET, WE'RE ON THE START HINDSPLINDS --"

"MISS GRANGER," SAID SNAPE IN A VOICE HE DEARLY CALM, "I WAS UNDER THE IMPRESSION THAT I AM TEACHING THIS LESSON, NOT THEM, AND I AM TELLING THEM ALL TO TURN THE PAGE 174." HE GLANCED AROUND AGAIN, 'ALL OF THEM! NONE!'
WITH MANY BITTER SIDELING LOOKS AND SOME SILENT MUTTERING, THE CLASS OPENED THEIR BOOKS.

"WHICH OF THEM CAN TELL ME HOW WE DISTINGUISH BETWEEN THE WEREWOLVES AND THE TRUE WOLF?" SAID SNAPE.

EVERYONE SAT IN MOUTHLESS SILENCE; EVERYONE EXCEPT HERMIONE, WHOSE HAND, AS IT SO OFTEN DID, HAD SLIPPED STRAIGHT INTO THE AIR.

"ANYONE?" SNAPE SAID, IGNORING HERMIONE. HIS TWISTED SMILE WAS BACK.

"ARE THEY TELLING ME THAT PROFESSOR LUPIN HASN'T EVEN TAUGHT THEM THE BASIC DISTINCTION BETWEEN --"

"WE TOLD THEM," SAID PARVATI SUDDENLY, "WE HAVEN'T GOTT AS FAR AS WEREWOLVES YET, WE'RE STILL ON --"

"SILENCE!" SNARLED SNAPE. "WELL, WELL, WELL, I NEVER THOUGHT I'D MEET A THIRD-YEAR CLASS WHO WOULDN'T EVEN RECOGNIZE A WEREWOLF WHEN THEY SAW ONE. I SHALL MAKE A POINT OF INFORMING PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE HOW VERY BEHIND THEY ALL ARE...."

"PLEASE, SIR," SAID HERMIONE, WHOSE HAND WAS STILL IN THE AIR, "THE WEREWOLF DIFFERS FROM THE TRUE WOLF IN SEVERAL SMALL WAYS. THE SNOUT OF THE WEREWOLF --"

"THAT IS THE SECOND TIME YOU HAVE SPOKEN OUT OF TURN, MISS GRANGER," SAID SNAPE COLDLY, "FIVE MORE POINTS FROM CRUPPINDEN FOR BEING AN INSUFFERABLE KNOW-IT-ALL."

HERMIONE WENT VERY RED, PUT DOWN HER HAND, AND STARED AT THE FLEER WITH HER EYES FULL OF TEARS. IT WAS A MARK OF HOW MUCH THE CLASS HATED SNAPE THAT THEY WERE ALL GLARING AT HIM, BECAUSE EVERY ONE OF THEM HAD CALLED HERMIONE A KNOW-IT-ALL AT LEAST ONCE, AND THEN, WHEN THEY HEARD HERMIONE SHE WAS A KNOW-IT-ALL AT LEAST TWICE A WEEK, SAID COLDLY, "YOU ASKED US A QUESTION AND SHE KNOWS THE ANSWER! WHY ASK IF YOU DON'T WANT THE REPLY?"

THE CLASS KNEW INSTANTLY HE'D GONE TOO FAR, SNAPE ADVANCED HIS REIN SILENTLY, AND THE REIN HELD ITS BREATH.

"DETENTION, WEASLEY," SNAPE SAID SILENTLY, HIS FACE VERY CLOSE TO THE REIN'S.

"AND IF I EVER HEAR YOU CRITICIZE THE WAY I TEACH A CLASS AGAIN, YOU WILL BE VERY SHAMY INDEED."

THEY HAD MADE A SILENT AGREEMENT THE REST OF THE LESSON. THEY SAT AND MADE NOTES ON WEREWOLVES FROM THE TEXTBOOK, WHILE SNAPE PRAWLED UP AND DOWN THE ROWS OF DESKS, EXAMINING THE WORK THEY HAD BEEN DOING WITH PROFESSOR LUPIN.

"VERY POORLY EXPLAINED... THAT IS INCORRECT, THE KAPPA IS MORE COMMONLY FOUND IN MONGOLIA... PROFESSOR LUPIN GAVE THIS RIGHT BUT HE TOLD I WOULDN'T HAVE GIVEN IT THREE..."

WHEN THE BELL RANG AT LAST, SNAPE HELD THEM BACK.

"YOU WILL EACH WRITE AN ESSAY, THE ONE HANDED IN THE FIRST, THE LAST YOU WILL RECOGNIZE AND WILL WEREWOLVES. I WANT TWO SHEETS OF PARCHMENT EACH, THE SLICKET, AND I WANT THEM BY MONDAY MORNING. IT IS TIME SOMEONE THOUGHT

THIS CLASS IN HAND, LEASLEY, STAY BEHIND, WE NEED TO ARRANGE YOUR
DETENTION."

198

HARRY AND HERMIONE LEFT THE ROOM WITH THE REST OF THE CLASS, WHO WAITED
UNTIL THEY WERE WELL OUT OF EARSHOT, THEN ERUPTED INTO A FURIOUS TIRADE
AGAINST SNAPE.

"SNAPE'S NEVER BEEN LIKE THIS WITH ANY OF HIS OTHER DEFENSE AGAINST THE
DARK ARTS TEACHERS, EVEN IF HE DID WANT THE JOB," HARRY SAID TO
HERMIONE, "WHY'S HE GET IT IN FOR KLIPKIN? D'YOU THINK THIS IS ALL BECAUSE
OF THE KEGGART?"

"I DON'T KNOW," SAID HERMIONE PENSIVELY, "BUT I REALLY HATE PROFESSOR
KLIPKIN GETS BETTER WHEN..."

THEY CALGHT UP WITH THEM FIVE MINUTES LATER, IN A THUNDERING RAGE.

"D'YOU KNOW WHAT THAT --" HE CALLED SNAPE SOMETHING THAT MADE HERMIONE
SAY "WHY?" -- IS MAKING ME DO? I'VE GOT THE SCURF OUT THE BEDPANS IN
THE HOSPITAL WING, WITHOUT MAGIC!" HE WAS BREATHING DEEPLY, HIS FISTS
CLENCHED, "WHY COULDN'T BLACK HAVE HIDDEN IN SNAPE'S OFFICE, IF HE
COULD HAVE FINISHED HIM OFF FOR US?"

HARRY WOKED EXTREMELY EARLY THE NEXT MORNING; SO EARLY THAT IT WAS STILL
DARK, FOR A MOMENT HE THOUGHT THE RUMORING OF THE WIND HAD WOKEN HIM.
THEN HE FELT A CHILL BREEZE ON THE BACK OF HIS NECK AND SAT UP RIGHT
-- PERVES THE PHILTHERGIST HAD BEEN BREATHING NEXT TO HIM, BREATHING HARD IN
HIS EAR.

"WHAT DID YOU DO THAT FOR?" SAID HARRY FURIOUSLY, PERVES PLOPPED BACK HIS
CHEEKS, BLEW HARD, AND ZIPPED BACKWARD OUT OF THE ROOM, CACKLING.

HARRY PLUNKED OFF HIS ALARM CLOCK AND LEANED AT IT. IT WAS HALF PAST
FIVE, CURSING PERVES, HE ROLLED OVER AND TRIED TO GET BACK TO SLEEP, BUT

IT WAS VERY DIFFICULT, WHEN THAT HE WAS AWAKE, TO IGNORE THE SOUNDS OF THE THUNDER RUMBLING OVERHEAD, THE HOWLING OF THE WIND AGAINST THE CASTLE WALLS, AND THE DISTANT CREAKING OF THE TREES IN THE FORBIDDEN FOREST. IN A FEW MINUTES HE WOULD BE HIT BY THE BLINDING FLOOD, RATTING THROUGH THAT GALE. FINALLY, HE GAVE UP AND THOUGHT OF MORE SLEEP, GOT UP, DRESSED, PICKED UP HIS DINGHYS TWO THOUSAND, AND WALKED QUIETLY OUT OF THE DORMITORY.

1999

AS HARRY OPENED THE DOOR, SOMETHING CRASHED AGAINST HIS LEG. HE KNEW WHEN IT IN TIME THE GRAB CRUMPLED HANDS BY THE END OF HIS KICKY TAIL AND DRAG HIM OUTSIDE.

"WELL DONE, I REMEMBER WHEN WAS RIGHT ABOUT WELL," HARRY TOLD CRUMPLED HANDS SUSPICIOUSLY. "THERE ARE PLenty OF MICE AROUND THIS PLACE -- GET AND CHASE THEM, GET HIM," HE ADDED, PUSHING CRUMPLED HANDS DOWN THE SPIRAL STAIRCASE WITH HIS FOOT. "LEAVE STALKERS ALONE."

THE NOISE OF THE STORM WAS EVEN LOUDER IN THE CHAMBER ROOMS. HARRY KNEW BETTER THAN TO THINK THE MATCH WOULD BE CANCELED; BLINDING MATCHES WEREN'T CALLED OFF FOR TRIPLES LIKE THUNDERSTORMS. NEVERTHELESS, HE WAS STARTING TO FEEL VERY APPREHENSIVE. WHO HAD POINTED OUT CEDRIC DIGGORY TO HIM IN THE HALLWAY? DIGGORY WAS A FIFTY YEAR AND A LITTLE BIGGER THAN HARRY. SPEEDERS WERE USUALLY LIGHT AND SPEEDY, BUT DIGGORY'S WEIGHT WOULD BE AN ADVANTAGE IN THIS WEATHER BECAUSE HE WAS LESS LIKELY TO BE SWOONED OFF COURSE.

HARRY HEADED AWAY THE MINUTES UNTIL DOWN IN FRONT OF THE FIRE, GETTING UP EVERY WHEN AND THEN THE STEADY CRUMPLED HANDS FROM SNEAKING UP THE KIDS, STAIRCASE AGAIN. AT LONG LAST HARRY THOUGHT IT MUST BE TIME FOR BREAKFAST, SO HE HEADED THROUGH THE PORTRAIT HOLE ALONE.

"STAND AND FIGHT, YELL MANGY CLIP!" YELLED SIR CADMORGAN.

"HEH, SHUT UP," HARRY YALNED.

HE REVIVED A KIT EVER A LARGE KILL OF PERRIDGE, AND BY THE TIME HE'D
STARTED HIN THAST, THE REST OF THE TEAM HAD TURNED UP.

"IT'S GING THE EE A THUGH HIN," SAID WHEED, WHO WASN'T EATING ANYTHING.

"STEP WHORRYING, ELIVER," SAID ALICIA SHEET-INGLY, "WE DERN'T MIND A KIT OF
RAIN."

BUT IT WAS CONSIDERABLY MORE THAN A KIT OF RAIN. SUCH WAS THE POPULARITY
OF ELVIDITCH THAT THE WHOLE SCHEM TURNED OUT THE WATCH THE MATCH AS
USUAL, BUT THEY RAN DOWN THE LAINS TOWARD THE ELVIDITCH FIELD, HEADS

195

SHED AGAINST THE PERVICIOUS WIND, LIMRELLAS BEING WHIPPED OUT OF THEIR
HANDS AS THEY WENT. JUST BEFORE HE ENTERED THE LOCKER ROOM, HARRY SAW
MALPOT, CRABBE, AND GOMPE, LAUGHING AND POINTING AT HIM FROM UNDER AN
ENORMOUS LIMRELLA IN THEIR WAY TO THE STADIUM.

THE TEAM CHANGED INTO THEIR SCARLET RINGS AND WAITED FOR WHEED'S USUAL
PRE-MATCH PEP TALK, BUT IT DIDN'T COME. HE TRIED TO SPEAK SEVERAL TIMES,
MADE AN EDD CLIPPING NOISE, THEN SHOOK HIS HEAD HELPLESSLY AND RECOVERED
THAT HE HADN'T HIM.

THE WIND WAS SO STRONG THAT THEY STAGGERED SIDEWAYS AS THEY WALKED OUT
TOWARD THE FIELD. IF THE CROWD WAS CHEERING, THEY COULDN'T HEAR IT EVER
THE FRESH REELS OF THUNDER. RAIN WAS SPLATTERING OVER HARRY'S GLASSES.
HEEN HIN EARTH WAS HE GING THE SEE THE SNITCH IN THIS?

THE FLAPPOPPS WERE APPROACHING FROM THE OPPOSITE SIDE OF THE FIELD,
WEARING CANARY-YELLOW RINGS. THE CAPTAINS WALKED UP TO EACH OTHER AND
SHOOK HANDS; DIGGERY SMILED AT WHEED BUT WHEED NE, LOOKED AS THOUGH HE HAD
MISSED AND MERELY NEEDED. HARRY SAW MADAM FLECK'S MOUTH FROM THE
WARDS.

"WHISTLE YOUR KNEES!," HE PULLED HIS RIGHT FOOT OUT OF THE MUD WITH A SWEEP AND SWUNG IT OVER HIS SHOULDER TWO THOUSAND, MADAM FRICK PUT HER

WHISTLE TO HER LIPS AND GAVE IT A BLAST THAT SOUNDED TERRIBLE AND DISTANT THEY WERE OFF

HARRY RAN FAST, BUT HIS SHOULDER WAS SWERVING SLIGHTLY WITH THE WIND, HE HELD IT AS STEADY AS HE COULD AND TURNED, SWIMMING INTO THE RAIN.

WITHIN FIVE MINUTES HARRY WAS SHAKED TO HIS SKIN AND FREEZING, HARDLY ABLE TO SEE HIS TEAMMATES, LET ALONE THE TINY SNITCH, HE FLEW BACKWARD AND FORWARD ACROSS THE FIELD PAST BURNED RED AND YELLOW STAPES, WITH NO IDEA OF WHAT WAS HAPPENING IN THE REST OF THE GAME. HE COULDN'T HEAR THE COMMENTARY OVER THE WIND. THE GOAL WAS HIDDEN BEHIND A SEA OF CLOUDS AND BATTERED LILYPADS. TWICE HARRY CAME VERY CLOSE TO BEING DISMOUNTED BY A KILDRER; HIS VISION WAS SO OBSCURED BY THE RAIN AND HIS GLASSES HE HADN'T SEEN THEM COMING.

HE LOST TRACK OF TIME. IT WAS GETTING DARKER AND DARKER TO HIS RIGHT STRAIGHT. THE SKY WAS GETTING DARKER, AS THOUGH NIGHT HAD DECIDED TO COME EARLY. TWICE HARRY NEARLY HIT ANOTHER PLAYER, WITHOUT KNOWING WHETHER IT WAS A TEAMMATE OR OPPONENT; EVERYONE WAS NOW SO WET, AND THE

199

RAIN SO THICK, HE COULD HARDLY TELL THEM APART...

WITH THE FIRST FLASH OF LIGHTNING CAME THE SOUND OF MADAM FRICK'S WHISTLE; HARRY COULD JUST SEE THE SILHOUETTE OF WHOO THROUGH THE THICK RAIN, GETTING HIM TO THE GOAL. THE WHOLE TEAM SPLASHED DOWN INTO THE MUD.

"I CALLED FOR TIME-OUT!" WHOO ROARED AT HIS TEAM. "COME ON, LINGER HERE

--"

THEY Huddled AT THE EDGE OF THE FIELD UNDER A LARGE LILYPAD; HARRY TOOK OFF HIS GLASSES AND WIPED THEM FRantically WITH HIS SLEEVES.

"WHAT'S THE SCENE?"

"WE'RE FIFTY POINTS UP," SAID LINDY, "BUT UNLESS WE GET THE SNITCH SEEN, WE'LL BE PLAYING IN THE NIGHT."

"I'VE GOT NO CHANCE WITH THESE MEN," HARRY SAID EXASPERATEDLY, WAVING HIS GLASSES.

AT THAT VERY MOMENT, FERMINE APPEARED AT HIS SHOULDERS; SHE WAS HOLDING HER HEAD OVER HER HEAD AND WAS, IMPLICITLY, BEATING.

"I'VE HAD AN IDEA, HARRY! GIVE ME YOUR GLASSES, QUICK!"

HE HANDED THEM TO HER, AND AS THE TEAM WATCHED IN AMAZEMENT, FERMINE TAPPED THEM WITH HER HAND AND SAID, "IMPERVIOUS!"

"THERE!" SHE SAID, HANDING THEM BACK TO HARRY, "THEY'LL REPEL WATER!"

LINDY SMILED AS THOUGH HE COULD HAVE KISSED HER.

"BRILLIANT!" HE CALLED HIMSELF AFTER HER AS SHE DISAPPEARED INTO THE CROWD. "HEY, TEAM, LET'S GO FOR IT!"

FERMINE'S SPELL HAD DONE THE TRICK, HARRY WAS STILL NINE WITH CHILD, STILL BETTER THAN HE'D EVER BEEN IN HIS LIFE, BUT HE COULD SEE, FULL OF FRESH DETERMINATION, HE WAGED HIS BROTHER THROUGH THE TURBULENT AIR, STARTING IN EVERY DIRECTION FOR THE SNITCH, AVOIDING A COLLIDER, CLICKING

149

BEHIND DICKEY, WHO WAS STREAMING IN THE OPPOSITE DIRECTION...

THERE WAS ANOTHER CLAP OF THUNDER, FOLLOWED IMMEDIATELY BY AROUND LIGHTNING. THIS WAS GETTING MORE AND MORE DANGEROUS, HARRY NEEDED TO GET THE SNITCH QUICKLY -

HE TURNED, INTENDING TO HEAD BACK TOWARD THE MIDDLE OF THE FIELD, BUT AT THAT MOMENT, ANOTHER FLASH OF LIGHTNING ILLUMINATED THE STANDS, AND HARRY SAW SOMETHING THAT DISTRACTED HIM COMPLETELY, THE SILHOUETTE OF AN ENORMOUS SLAGGY BLACK BEAR, CLEARLY IMPRINTED AGAINST THE SKY,

NEITHERLESS IN THE THORNEST, EMPTY ROWS OF SEATS,

HARRY'S NINE HANDS SLIPPED IN THE KROTH HANDLE AND HIS NIMBUS DROPPED A FEW FEET. SHAKING HIS SHODEN KINGS OUT OF HIS EYES, HE SWAYED BACK INTO THE STANDS. THE DEE HAD VANISHED.

"HARRY!" CAME LINDA'S ANGLISHED YELL FROM THE GRYFFINDOR CHEAL SEATS.

"HARRY, BEHIND ME!"

HARRY LUNCHED WILDLY AROUND. CEDRIC DIGGORY WAS PELTING UP THE FIELD, AND A TINY SPECK OF CHILD WAS SHIMMERING IN THE RAIN-FILLED AIR BETWEEN THEM -

WITH A HIT OF PANIC, HARRY THREW HIMSELF FLAT TO THE KROTH HANDLE AND ZOOMED TOWARD THE SNITCH.

"HERE HE!" HE GRIELED AT HIS NIMBUS AS THE RAIN WHIPPED HIS FACE.

"TASTER!"

BUT SOMETHING HAD WAS HAPPENING. AN ERIE SILENCE WAS FALLING ACROSS THE STADIUM. THE WIND, THOUGH AS STRONG AS EVER, WAS FORGETTING THE REAR. IT WAS AS THOUGH SOMETHING HAD TURNED OFF THE SOUND, AS THOUGH HARRY HAD GONE

SLIDDERLY DEAD -- WHAT WAS GOING ON?

AND THEN A HORRIBLY FAMILIAR WAVE OF CHILD SWEPT OVER HIM, INSIDE HIM,

JUST AS HE BECAME AWARE OF SOMETHING MOVING IN THE FIELD BEHIND...

BEFORE HE'D HAD TIME TO THINK, HARRY HAD TAKEN HIS EYES OFF THE SNITCH AND LUNCHED DOWN.

199

AT LEAST A HUNDRED DEMENTORS, THEIR HIDDEN FACES POINTING UP AT HIM, WERE STANDING BENEATH HIM. IT WAS AS THOUGH FREEZING WATER WERE RISING IN HIS CHEST, CUTTING AT HIS INSIDES. AND THEN HE HEARD IT AGAIN...

SOMETHING WAS SCREAMING, SCREAMING INSIDE HIS HEAD... A WHIMAN...

"NEET HARRY, NEET HARRY, PLEASE NEET HARRY!"

"STAND ASIDE, YOU SILLY GIRL... STAND ASIDE, NEEL..."

"NEET HARRY, PLEASE NEH, TAKE ME, KILL ME INSTEAD --"

NUMBING, SWIRLING WHITE MIST WAS FILLING HARRY'S BRAIN... WHAT WAS HE DOING? WHY WAS HE DYING? HE NEEDED THE HELP HER... SHE WAS GOING TO DIE... SHE WAS GOING TO BE MURDERED...

HE WAS FALLING, FALLING THROUGH THE ICY MIST.

"NEET HARRY? PLEASE... HAVE MERCY... HAVE MERCY..."

A SHRIILL VOICE WAS LAUGHING, THE WOMAN WAS SCREAMING, AND HARRY KNEW NEH MORE.

"BLIND? THE GRIELAND WAS SHE SHOT."

"I THOUGHT HE WAS DEAD FOR SURE."

"BUT HE DIDN'T EVEN BREAK HIS GLASSES."

HARRY COULD HEAR THE VEHICLES WHISPERING, BUT THEY MADE NEH SENSE

NEVERTHELESS, HE DIDN'T HAVE A CLUE WHERE HE WAS, HE FELT HE'D GOTT THERE,

HE WHAT HE'D BEEN DOING BEFORE HE GOTT THERE, ALL HE KNEW WAS THAT EVERY INCH OF HIM WAS ACHING AS THOUGH IT HAD BEEN BEATEN.

"THAT WAS THE SCARIEST THING I'VE EVER SEEN IN MY LIFE."

SCARIEST... THE SCARIEST THING... HUNDRED BLACK FIGURES... CHILD ... SCREAMING...

HARRY'S EYES SNAPPED OPEN, HE WAS LYING IN THE HOSPITAL WING, THE GRYFFINDOR HOLIDITCH TEAM, SPATTERED WITH BLOOD FROM HEAD TO FEET, WAS

147

GATHERED AROUND HIS BED, RON AND HERMIONE WERE ALSO THERE, LOOKING AS THOUGH THEY'D JUST CLIMBED OUT OF A SWIMMING POOL.

"HARRY?" SAID RON, WHO LOOKED EXTREMELY WHITE UNDERNEATH THE MOON.

"HOW'RE YOU FEELING?"

IT WAS AS THOUGH HARRY'S MEMORY WAS GOING FAST AWAY, THE LIGHTNING --

THE GRIM -- THE SNITCH -- AND THE DEMENTHORS...

"WHAT HAPPENED?" HE SAID, SITTING UP SHE SUDDENLY THEY ALL GASPED.

"YELL FELL OFF," SAID FRED, "MUST'VE BEEN -- WHAT -- FIFTY FEET?"

"WE THOUGHT YELL'D DIED," SAID ALICIA, WHO WAS STANDING.

HERMIONE MADE A SMALL, SHLEADY NOISE, HER EYES WERE EXTREMELY BLEEDEST-ENT.

"BLIT THE MATCH," SAID HARRY, "WHAT HAPPENED? ARE WE DOING A REPLAY?"

HE HAD SAID ANYTHING, THE TERRIBLE TRUTH SANK INTO HARRY LIKE A STONE.

"WE DIDN'T -- WESE?"

"DIGGERY GOT THE SNITCH," SAID GEORGE, "JUST AFTER YELL FELL, HE DIDN'T

REALIZE WHAT HAD HAPPENED, WHEN HE WHEEDED BACK AND SAW YELL HEN THE

GRHLING, HE TRIED TO CALL IT OFF, WANTED A REMATCH, BLIT THEY WERE FAIR AND

SHLARE... EVEN WEHD ADMITS IT."

"WHERE IS WEHD?" SAID HARRY, SUDDENLY REALIZING HE WASN'T THERE.

"STILL IN THE SHHLERS," SAID FRED, "WE THINK HE'S TRYING TO DROWN HIMSELF."

HARRY PUT HIS FACE TO HIS KNEES, HIS HANDS GRIPPING HIS HAIR, FRED

GRABBED HIS SHHLBER AND SHHHED IT RELIEF-ILY.

"T'MEN, HARRY, YELL'VE NEVER MISSED THE SNITCH BEFORE."

"THERE HAD TO BE ONE TIME YELL DIDN'T GET IT," SAID GEORGE.

150

"IT'S NOT YET," SAID FRED, "WE LOST BY A HUNDRED PHINTS"

"RIGHT? SEE IF H-LPPLEPLPP WHESES THE RAVENCLAW AND WE BEAT RAVENCLAW AND SLYTHERIN --,"

"H-LPPLEPLPP'LL HAVE THE WHESE BY AT LEAST TWO HUNDRED PHINTS," SAID GEORGE.

"BLIT IF THEY BEAT RAVENCLAW..."

"THE WAY, RAVENCLAW IS THEE CHHD, BLIT IF SLYTHERIN WHESES AGAINST

FLAPFLAP..."

"IT ALL DEPENDS ON THE PRINTS -- A MARGIN OF A HUNDRED EITHER WAY,"

HARRY LAY THERE, NOT SAYING A WORD. THEY HAD LOST... FOR THE FIRST TIME EVER, HE HAD LOST A FLIDGITCH MATCH.

AFTER TEN MINUTES OR SO, MADAM PEMFREY CAME OVER TO TELL THE TEAM TO LEAVE HIM IN PEACE.

"WE'LL COME AND SEE YOU LATER," FRED TOLD HIM, "DON'T BEAT YOURSELF UP,

HARRY, YOU'RE STILL THE BEST SEEKER WE'VE EVER HAD."

THE TEAM TREMPED AWAY, TRAILING MUD BEHIND THEM. MADAM PEMFREY STAYED BEHIND THEM, LOOKING DISAPPROVING. RON AND HERMIONIE MOVED NEARER TO

HARRY'S BED.

"DUMBLEDORE WAS REALLY ANGRY," HERMIONIE SAID IN A RELAXING VOICE. "I'VE NEVER SEEN HIM LIKE THAT BEFORE. HE RAN RORTH THE FIELD AS YOU FELL, WAVED HIS WAND, AND YOU SAW HE SHOOK DUST OFF THERE YOU HIT THE GROUND. THEN HE WHIRLED HIS WAND AT THE DEMENTORS. SHEET SILVER STUFF AT THEM. THEY LEFT THE STADIUM RIGHT AWAY... HE WAS FLURRIED THEY'D COME RORTH THE GROUND. WE HEARD HIM --"

"THEN HE MAGICED YOU RORTH A STRETCHER," SAID RON. "AND WALKED UP THE STAIRS WITH YOU ALONG WITH IT. EVERYONE THOUGHT YOU WERE --"

HIS VOICE FADED, BUT HARRY HARDLY NOTICED. HE WAS THINKING ABOUT WHAT THE DEMENTORS HAD DONE TO HIM... ABOUT THE SCREAMING VOICE. HE LOOKED UP

151

AND SAW RON AND HERMIONIE LOOKING AT HIM WITH ANXIOUSLY THAT HE QUICKLY LAST ABOUT FOR SOMETHING MATTER-OF-FACT THE DAY.

"DID SOMEONE GET MY NICKLES?"

RON AND HERMIONIE LOOKED QUICKLY AT EACH OTHER.

"ER --"

"WHAT?" SAID HARRY, LEEDING FROM HENCE THE EITHER.

"WELL... WHEN YOU FELL OFF, IT GOT BLEW AWAY," SAID HERMIONE
HESITANTLY.

"AND"

"AND IT HIT -- IT HIT -- HEI, HARRY -- IT HIT THE WHIPPING WILLOW."

HARRY'S INSIDES LURCHED. THE WHIPPING WILLOW WAS A VERY VIOLENT TREE
THAT STOOD ALONE IN THE MIDDLE OF THE GROUNDS.

"AND" HE SAID, DREADING THE ANSWER.

"WELL, YOU KNOW THE WHIPPING WILLOW," SAID REEN. "IT -- IT DOESN'T LIKE
BEING HIT."

"PROFESSOR FLITWICK BRIGHT IT BACK JUST BEFORE YOU CAME AROUND, SAID
HERMIONE IN A VERY SMALL VOICE.

SHEELY, SHE REACHED DOWN FOR A BAG AT HER FEET, TURNED IT UPSIDE DOWN,
AND TIPPED A DOZEN KITS OF SPLINTERED WOOD AND TWIG BENT THE BED, THE
ONLY REMAINS OF HARRY'S FAITHFUL, FINALLY BEATEN KNEEMSTICK.

CHAPTER TEN

THE MARAUDER'S MAP

MADAM POMFREY INSISTED ON KEEPING HARRY IN THE HOSPITAL WING FOR THE
REST OF THE WEEKEND. HE DIDN'T ARGUE HIS COMPLAIN, BUT HE WOULDN'T LET
HER THROW AWAY THE SHATTERED REMNANTS OF HIS NIKKIS TWO THOUSAND. HE

152

KNEW HE WAS BEING STUPID, KNEW THAT THE NIKKIS WAS BEYOND REPAIR, BUT
HARRY WOULDN'T HELP IT; HE FELT AS THOUGH HE'D LOST ONE OF HIS BEST
FRIENDS.

HE HAD A STREAM OF VISITORS, ALL INTENT ON CHEERING HIM UP. LAGRID SENT
HIM A BUNCH OF EARLY-BLOOMING FLOWERS THAT LOOKED LIKE YELLOW CABBAGES, AND
GINNY WEASLEY, BLUSHING FLURRIEDLY, TURNED UP WITH A GET-WELL CARD SHE

HAD MADE HERSELF, WHICH SANG STRILLY LIKESS F-JARRY KEPT IT SHUT UNDER HIS
HEEL HE FELT IT. THE GRYFFINDOR TEAM VISITED AGAIN ON SUNDAY MORNING, THIS
TIME ACCOMPANIED BY LUNA, WHO TOLD F-JARRY (IN A WHISPER, DEAD SERIOUS
VOICE) THAT HE DIDN'T BLAME

HIM IN THE SLIGHTEST. REEN AND HERMIONE LEFT F-JARRY'S BEDSIDE EARLY AT
NIGHT- BUT NOTHING ANYONE SAID OR DID COULD MAKE F-JARRY FEEL ANY BETTER,
BECAUSE THEY KNEW ONLY HALF OF WHAT WAS TRUING HIM.

HE HADN'T TOLD ANYONE ABOUT THE GRIM, NOT EVEN REEN AND HERMIONE,
BECAUSE HE KNEW REEN WOULD PANIC AND HERMIONE WOULD SCREAM. THE FACT
REMAINED, HOWEVER, THAT IT HAD NOW APPEARED TWICE, AND BOTH APPEARANCES
HAD BEEN FOLLOWED BY NEAR-FATAL ACCIDENTS: THE FIRST TIME, HE HAD NEARLY
BEEN RUN OVER BY THE KNIGHT BUS; THE SECOND, FALLEN FIFTY FEET FROM HIS
BROOMSTICK. WAS THE GRIM CHasing THREATENING HIM UNTIL HE ACTUALLY DIED? WAS
HE CHasing TH SPENDING THE REST OF HIS LIFE WHIPPING OVER HIS SHOULDER FOR THE
BEAST?

AND THEN THERE WERE THE DEMENTORS, F-JARRY FELT SICK AND HUMILIATED EVERY
TIME HE THOUGHT OF THEM. EVERYONE SAID THE DEMENTORS WERE TERRIBLE, BUT
HE HAD ELSE COLLAPSED EVERY TIME THEY WENT NEAR HIM. HE HAD ELSE HEARD
ECHOES IN THEIR HEAD OF THEIR DYING PARENTS.

BECAUSE F-JARRY KNEW WHO THAT SCREAMING VOICE BELONGED TO NOW, HE HAD
HEARD HER WHISPERS, HEARD THEM OVER AND OVER AGAIN DURING THE NIGHT HOURS
IN THE HOSPITAL WING WHILE HE LAY AWAKE, STARING AT THE STRIPS OF
MOONLIGHT ON THE CEILING. WHEN THE DEMENTORS APPROACHED HIM, HE HEARD
THE LAST MOMENTS OF HIS MOTHER'S LIFE, HER ATTEMPTS TO PROTECT HIM,
F-JARRY, FROM LORD VOLDEMORT, AND VOLDEMORT'S LAUGHTER BECAUSE HE MURDERED
HER... F-JARRY SHOOK FURIOUSLY, SINKING INTO DREAMS ALL OF CLAMMY, SHUTTED
HANDS AND PETRIFIED PLEADING, JERKING AWAKE THE SAME AGAIN ON HIS

MEETHER'S VEHICLE.

IT WAS A RELIEF TO RETURN TO THE NOISE AND CLUSTLE OF THE MAIN SCHOOL ON MONDAY, WHERE HE WAS FORCED TO THINK ABOUT OTHER THINGS, EVEN IF HE HAD THE ENDLESS DRAGON MALFOY'S TALINGING. MALFOY WAS ALMOST BESIDE HIMSELF WITH GLEE AT CROPPINDEN'S DEFEAT. HE HAD FINALLY TAKEN OFF HIS BANDAGES, AND CELEBRATED HAVING THE FULL USE OF BOTH ARMS AGAIN BY BEING SPIRITED IMITATIONS OF HARRY FALLING OFF HIS BROOM. MALFOY SPENT MUCH OF THEIR NEXT PECTIONS CLASS BEING DEMENTED IMITATIONS ACROSS THE DUNGEON; THEN FINALLY CRACKED AND FILING A LARGE, SLIPPERY CRIBBLED HEART AT MALFOY, WHICH HIT HIM IN THE FACE AND CALISED SNAPE TO TAKE FIFTY PEINTS FROM CROPPINDEN.

"IF SNAPE'S TEACHING DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS AGAIN, I'M SORRYING OFF," SAID RON AS THEY HEADED TOWARD LUPIN'S CLASSROOM AFTER LUNCH.

"THERE'S SOME IN THERE, I'M SURE."

I'M SURE PEERED AROUND THE CLASSROOM DOOR.

"IT'S HARRY!"

PROFESSOR LUPIN WAS BACK AT WORK. IT CERTAINLY LOOKED AS THOUGH HE HAD BEEN ILL. HIS EYES WERE HANGING MORE LOOSELY ON HIM AND THERE WERE DARK STAINES BENEATH HIS EYES; NEVERTHELESS, HE SMILED AT THE CLASS AS THEY TOOK THEIR SEATS, AND THEY BURST AT ONCE INTO AN EXPLANATION OF COMPLAINTS ABOUT SNAPE'S BEHAVIOR WHILE LUPIN HAD BEEN ILL.

"IT'S NOT FAIR, HE WAS ONLY FILLING IN, WHY SHOULD HE GIVE US HOMEWORK?"

"WE DIDN'T KNOW ANYTHING ABOUT WORKING WITH THE WALLS OF PARCEMENT?"

"DID YOU TELL PROFESSOR SNAPE WE HAVEN'T COVERED THEM YET?" LUPIN ASKED, FROWNING SLIGHTLY.

THE KIDNEY KICK HURT AGAIN.

"YES, BUT HE SAID WE WERE REALLY BEHIND HE WOULDN'T LISTEN --"

"-- THE REELS OF PARCEMENT?"

159

PROFESSOR KLIPIN SMILED AT THE LOOKS OF INDIGNATION ON EVERY FACE.

"DON'T WORRY, I'LL SPEAK THE PROFESSOR SNARE. YOU DON'T HAVE TO DO THE ESSAY."

"EH-NH," SAID F-HARRY, LOOKING VERY DISAPPOINTED, "I'VE ALREADY FINISHED IT."

THEY HAD A VERY ENJOYABLE LESSON. PROFESSOR KLIPIN HAD BRUGHT ALONG A GLASS BOX CONTAINING A HINDOPLINK, A LITTLE HOK-LEGGED CREATURE WHICH LOOKED AS THOUGH HE WERE MADE OF WHIPS OF SMOKE, RATHER FRAIL AND HARMLESS LOOKING.

"LURES TRAVELERS INTO TRAPS," SAID PROFESSOR KLIPIN AS THEY THREW NETS.

"YOU NOTICE THE LANTERN DANGLING FROM HIS HAND? F-HOPS AHEAD - PEOPLE FOLLOW THE LIGHT -- THEN --"

THE HINDOPLINK MADE A TERRIBLE SHUPLING NOISE AGAINST THE GLASS.

WHEN THE BELL RANG, EVERYONE GATHERED UP THEIR THINGS AND HEADED FOR THE DOOR, F-HARRY AMONG THEM, BUT --

"WAIT A MOMENT, F-HARRY," KLIPIN CALLED. "I'D LIKE A WORD."

F-HARRY SHOOKED BACK AND WATCHED PROFESSOR KLIPIN CHEVING THE HINDOPLINK'S

BOX WITH A CLETH.

"I HEARD ABOUT THE MATCH," SAID KLIPIN, TURNING BACK TO HIS DESK AND STARTING TO PILE BOOKS INTO HIS BRIECASE, "AND I'M SORRY ABOUT YOUR KNEEMSTICK. IS THERE ANY CHANCE OF FIXING IT?"

"NH," SAID F-HARRY, "THE TREE SMASHED IT THE KITS."

KLIPIN SIGHED.

"THEY PLANTED THE WHIPPING WILLOW THE SAME YEAR THAT I ARRIVED AT HOGWARTS. PEOPLE USED THE PLAY A GAME, TRYING TO GET NEAR ENOUGH TO THE TREE

THE TRUNK. IN THE END, A KEY CALLED DAVEY GLIDED NEARLY LOST AN EYE,
AND WE WERE ABANDONED THE KEY NEAR IT. NO CRIMINALS WOULD HAVE A CHANCE."

155

"DID YOU HEAR ABOUT THE DEMENTORS THEN?" SAID HARRY WITH DIFFICULTY,
LUPIN LOOKED AT HIM QUIETLY.

"YES, I DID. I DIDN'T THINK ANY OF US HAVE SEEN PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE THAT
ANGRY. THEY HAVE BEEN GROWING RESTLESS FOR SOME TIME -- FIRSTLY AT HIS
REFUSAL TO LET THEM INSIDE THE GREENHOUSES... I SUPPOSE THEY WERE THE
REASON YOU FELL?"

"YES," SAID HARRY, HE HESITATED, AND THEN THE QUESTION HE HAD THE ASK
FIRST FROM HIM BEFORE HE COULD STOP HIMSELF. "WOULD THEY AFFECT ME
LIKE THAT? AM I JUST --?"

"IT HAS NOTHING TO DO WITH WEAKNESS," SAID PROFESSOR LUPIN SHARPLY, AS
THOUGH HE HAD READ HARRY'S MIND. "THE DEMENTORS AFFECT YOU WHOSE THAN
THE OTHERS BECAUSE THERE ARE THINGS IN YOUR PAST THAT THE OTHERS DIDN'T
HAVE."

A RAY OF WINTER'S SUNLIGHT FELL ACROSS THE CLASSROOM, ILLUMINATING
LUPIN'S GRAY HAIRS AND THE LINES ON HIS WEARING FACE.

"DEMENTORS ARE AMONG THE UGLIEST CREATURES THAT WALK THIS EARTH. THEY
INHABIT THE DARKEST, FILTHIEST PLACES, THEY GLORY IN DEATH AND DESPAIR,
THEY DRAIN PEACE, HOPE, AND HAPPINESS OUT OF THE AIR AROUND THEM. EVEN
MUGGLES FEEL THEIR PRESENCE, THOUGH THEY CAN'T SEE THEM. GET TOO NEAR A
DEMENTOR AND EVERY GOOD FEELING, EVERY HAPPY MEMORY WILL BE SUCKED OUT
OF YOU. IF IT CAN, THE DEMENTOR WILL FEED ON YOU LONG ENOUGH TO REDUCE
YOU TO SOMETHING LIKE ITSELF... SOUL-LESS AND EVIL. YOU'LL BE LEFT WITH
NOTHING BUT THE WORST EXPERIENCES OF YOUR LIFE, AND THE WORST THAT
HAPPENED TO YOU, HARRY, IS ENOUGH TO MAKE ANYONE FALL OFF THEIR CRIMINAL.

"THEY HAVE NOTHING THE FEEL ASHAMED OF,"

"WHEN THEY GET NEAR ME --" HARRY STARED AT LUPIN'S DESK, HIS THERAT
TIGHT. "I CAN HEAR VERMINT MURDERING MY MUM,"

LUPIN MADE A SLIDEN MENTHEN WITH HIS ARM AS TEHLIGH THE GRIP HARRY'S
SHOULDER, BUT TEHLIGHT BETTER OF IT. THERE WAS A MEMENT'S SILENCE, THEN

--

"WHY DID THEY HAVE THE CHEER THE THE MATCH?" SAID HARRY BITTERLY.

152

"THEY'RE GETTING HINGRY," SAID LUPIN CHELLY, SHUTTING HIS BRIEFCASE WITH
A SNAP. "DUMBLEDORE WEN'T LET THEM INTO THE SCHEEN, SEE THEIR SLIPPLY OF
HUMAN PREY HAS DRIED UP,,, I DEN'T THINK THEY COULD RESIST THE LARGE
CROWD AROUND THE FLIDITCH FIELD, ALL THAT EXCITEMENT ... EMETHENS
RUNNING HIGH,,, IT WAS THEIR IDEA OF A FEAST,"

"AZKABAN MUST BE TERRIBLE," HARRY MUTTERED, LUPIN NEEDED GRIMLY.

"THE PRITRESS IS SET BEN A TINY ISLAND, WAY EHUT THE SEA, BUT THEY DEN'T
NEED WALLS AND WATER THE DEEP THE PRISONERS IN, NOT WHEN THEY'RE ALL
TRAPPED INSIDE THEIR OWN HEADS, INCAPABLE OF A SINGLE CHERRY TEHLIGHT,
MUST OF THEM GO MAD WITHIN WEEKS,"

"BUT SIRILUS BLACK ESCAPED FROM THEM," HARRY SAID SLEMLY. "HE GOT
AWAY..."

LUPIN'S BRIEFCASE SLIPPED FROM THE DESK; HE HAD THE STEHP HILICLY THE
CATCH IT.

"YES," HE SAID, STRAIGHTENING UP, "BLACK MUST HAVE FELIND A WAY THE FIGHT
THEM. I WELDON'T HAVE BELIEVED IT POSSIBLE,,, DEMENTHRS ARE SLIPPESSED THE
BRAIN A WIZARD OF HIS PHELERS IF HE IS LEFT WITH THEM THEE LONG..."

"THEY MADE THAT DEMENTHER BEN THE TRAIN RACK OF?" SAID HARRY SLUDDENLY.

"THERE ARE -- CERTAIN DEFENSES HEN CAN USE," SAID LUPIN. "BUT THERE WAS

ONLY ONE DEMENTOR ON THE TRAIN. THE MORE THERE ARE, THE MORE DIFFICULT IT BECOMES TO RESIST."

"WHAT DEFENSES?" SAID HARRY AT ONCE. "CAN YOU TEACH ME?"

"I DIDN'T PRETEND TO BE AN EXPERT AT FIGHTING DEMENTORS, HARRY, EXACTLY THE CONTRARY..."

"BUT IF THE DEMENTORS COME TO ANOTHER HOLIDITCH MATCH, I NEED TO BE ABLE TO FIGHT THEM --"

SLIPIN LOOKED INTO HARRY'S DETERMINED FACE, HESITATED, THEN SAID,

"WELL... ALL RIGHT. I'LL TRY AND HELP, BUT IT'LL HAVE TO WAIT UNTIL NEXT

159

TERM, I'M AFRAID, I HAVE TO GO OFF BEFORE THE HOLIDAYS. I CHOSE A VERY INCONVENIENT TIME TO FALL ILL."

WHAT WITH THE PROMISE OF ANTI-DEMENTOR LESSONS FROM SLIPIN, THE THOUGHT THAT HE MIGHT NEVER HAVE TO FEAR HIS MOTHER'S DEATH AGAIN, AND THE FACT THAT RAVENCLAW FLATTERED HUFFLEPUFF IN THEIR HOLIDITCH MATCH AT THE END OF NOVEMBER, HARRY'S MIND TOOK A DEFINITE UPTURN. GRYFFINDORS WERE NOT BLIT BY THE RUNNING AFTER ALL, ALTHOUGH THEY COULD NOT AFFORD THE LOSS ANOTHER MATCH. WHOO BECAME REPOSSESSED OF HIS MANIC ENERGY, AND WHOOSHED HIS TEAM AS HARD AS EVER IN THE CHILLY HAZE OF RAIN THAT PERSISTED INTO DECEMBER. HARRY SAW NO HINT OF A DEMENTOR WITHIN THE GRIHLINGS. DUMBLEDORE'S ANGER SEEMED TO BE KEEPING THEM AT THEIR STATIONS AT THE ENTRANCES.

TWO WEEKS BEFORE THE END OF THE TERM, THE SKY LIGHTENED SUDDENLY TO A DAZZLING, OPALINE WHITE AND THE MUDGY GRIHLINGS WERE REVEALED IN MORNING COVERED IN GLITTERING FROST. INSIDE THE CASTLE, THERE WAS A FLIZZ OF CHRISTMAS IN THE AIR. PROFESSOR FLITWICK, THE CHARMS TEACHER, HAD ALREADY DECORATED HIS CLASSROOM WITH SHIMMERING LIGHTS THAT TURNED BLIT

THE BE REAL, FLUTTERING FAIRIES. THE STUDENTS WERE ALL HAPPILY DISCUSSING THEIR PLANS FOR THE HOLIDAYS. RUTH REIN AND HERMIONE HAD DECIDED TO REMAIN AT HOGWARTS, AND TELLIE REIN SAID IT WAS BECAUSE HE COULDN'T STAND TWO WEEKS WITH PERCY, AND HERMIONE INSISTED SHE NEEDED THE USE OF THE LIBRARY. HARRY WASN'T FHEELED; THEY WERE DOING IT TO KEEP HIM COMPANY, AND HE WAS VERY GRATEFUL.

THE EVERYONE'S DELIGHT EXCEPT HARRY'S, THERE WAS THE BE ANOTHER HOGSMEAD TRIP IN THE VERY LAST WEEKEND OF THE TERM.

"WE CAN DO ALL OUR CHRISTMAS SHOPPING THERE!" SAID HERMIONE. "MUM AND DAD WOULD REALLY LOVE THESE THEFT-BLESSING STRINGMINTS FROM HONEYBLOKS!" RESIGNED TO THE FACT THAT HE WOULD BE THE ONLY THIRD YEAR STAYING BEHIND AGAIN, HARRY SHRIMPLED A COPY OF WHICH BROOMSTICK FROM WHICH, AND DECIDED TO SPEND THE DAY READING UP ON THE DIFFERENT MODES. HE HAD BEEN RIDING ONE OF THE SCHEER BROOMS AT TEAM PRACTICE, AN ANCIENT SE-THETTING STAR, WHICH WAS VERY SLEW AND LERKY; HE DEFINITELY NEEDED A NEW BROOM OF HIS OWN.

IN THE SATURDAY MORNING OF THE HOGSMEAD TRIP, HARRY BID GOOD-BYE TO THE REIN

158

AND HERMIONE, WHO WERE WRAPPED IN CLOAKS AND SCARVES, THEN TURNED UP THE MARBLE STAIRCASE ALONE, AND HEADED BACK TOWARD GRYFFINDOR TOWER. SLEW HAD STARTED THE FALL HLTSIDE THE WINDHILLS, AND THE CASTLE WAS VERY STILL AND HLJET.

"PEST -- HARRY!"

HE TURNED, HALFWAY ALONG THE THIRD-FLOOR CHORRIDER, TO SEE FRED AND GEORGE PEERING HLJT AT HIM FROM BEHIND A STATUE OF A FLIMPEACKED, ONE-EYED WITCH.

"WHAT ARE YOU DOING?" SAID HARRY CLIRIELISLY. "FEEL LIKE YOU'RE NOT GOING

THE FINGERSMEAD?"

"WE'VE COME TO GIVE YOU A BIT OF FESTIVE CHEER BEFORE WE GO," SAID FRED, WITH A MYSTERIOUS WINK. "COME IN HERE..."

HE NEEDED THEM AN EMPTY CLASSROOM THE LEFT OF THE ONE-EYED STATUE. HARRY FOLLOWED FRED AND GEORGE INSIDE. GEORGE CLOSED THE DOOR QUIETLY AND THEN TURNED, BEAMING, THE LOOK AT HARRY.

"EARLY CHRISTMAS PRESENT FOR YOU, HARRY," HE SAID.

FRED PULLED SOMETHING FROM INSIDE HIS COAT WITH A FLURRY AND LAID IT ON ONE OF THE DESKS. IT WAS A LARGE, SQUARE, VERY LEAN PIECE OF PARCHMENT WITH NOTHING WRITTEN ON IT. HARRY, SUSPECTING ONE OF FRED AND GEORGE'S TRICKS, STARED AT IT.

"WHAT'S THAT SLIPPERS THE KEY?"

"THIS, HARRY, IS THE SECRET OF OUR SUCCESS," SAID GEORGE, PATTING THE PARCHMENT TENDERLY.

"IT'S A WRENCH, GIVING IT THE YOU," SAID FRED. "BUT WE DECIDED LAST NIGHT, YOUR NEED'S GREATER THAN OURS."

"AND WHY, WE KNOW IT BY HEART," SAID GEORGE. "WE BELIEVE IT THE YOU. WE DON'T REALLY NEED IT ANYMORE."

"AND WHAT DO I NEED WITH A BIT OF OLD PARCHMENT?" SAID HARRY.

157

"A BIT OF OLD PARCHMENT?" SAID FRED, CLOSING HIS EYES WITH A GRIMACE AS THOUGH HARRY HAD MENTALLY OFFENDED HIM. "EXPLAIN, GEORGE."

"WELL... WHEN WE WERE IN OUR FIRST YEAR, HARRY -- YOUNG, CAREFREE, AND INNOCENT --"

HARRY INTERRUPTED, HE Doubted WHETHER FRED AND GEORGE HAD EVER BEEN INNOCENT.

"WELL, MORE INNOCENT THAN WE ARE NOW -- WE GOT INTO A SPOT OF KITCHEN

WITH FILCH."

"WE LET HIM SLING HIM IN THE HALLWAY AND IT UPSET HIM FOR SOME REASON --"

"SEE HE HALLIED US FOR THE HIS OFFICE AND STARTED THREATENING US WITH THE USUAL --" DETENTION DISMEMBERMENT AND WE CHILDREN'T HELP NOTICING A DRAWER IN ONE OF HIS FILING CABINETS MARKED CONVICATED AND HIGHLY DANGEROUS.

"DIDN'T TELL ME --" SAID HARRY, STARTING THE GRIN.

"WELL, WHAT WOULD YOU'VE DONE?" SAID FRED. "GEORGE CALLED A DIVERSION BY DROPPING ANOTHER BOMB, I WHIPPED THE DRAWER OPEN, AND GRABBED -- THIS."

"IT'S NOT AS BAD AS IT SEEMS, YOU KNOW," SAID GEORGE. "WE DIDN'T RECOVER FILCH EVER BECAUSE HE'D TAKEN THE BOMB IT, HE PROBABLY SUSPECTED WHAT IT WAS, THOUGH, OR HE WOULDN'T HAVE CONVICATED IT."

"AND YOU KNOW HOW HE TOOK IT?"

"HEH YES," SAID FRED, SMIRKING. "THIS LITTLE REALITY'S TALENT US MORE THAN ALL THE TEACHERS IN THIS SCHOOL."

"YOU'RE WINDING ME UP," SAID HARRY, LOOKING AT THE RAGGED OLD KIT OF PARCHMENT.

"HEH, ARE WE?" SAID GEORGE.

188

HE THEN HELT HIS HAND, TOUCHED THE PARCHMENT LIGHTLY, AND SAID, "I SILENTLY SWEAR THAT I AM UP THE NE CHAIR."

AND AT ONCE, THIN RED LINES BEGAN TO SPREAD LIKE A SPIDER'S WEB FROM THE POINT THAT GEORGE'S HAND HAD TOUCHED. THEY JOINED EACH OTHER, THEY CRISSESSSED, THEY FANNED INTO EVERY CORNER OF THE PARCHMENT; THEN WORDS BEGAN TO APPEAR ACROSS THE TOP, GREAT, CLEAR GREEN WORDS, THAT

PRECLAIMED:

MESSRS. MEENY, WHERMTAIL, PADTHEET, AND PRINGS

PLURVEYERS OF AIDS THE MAGICAL MISCHIEF-MAKERS ARE PREHLD THE PRESENT THE
MARALDOR'S MAP

IT WAS A MAP SHOWING EVERY DETAIL OF THE FEEGLARTS CASTLE AND GROHLINDS,
BUT THE TRULY REMARKABLE THING WERE THE TINY INK DOTS MEYING AROUND IT,
EACH LABELED WITH A NAME IN MINUSCULE WRITING. AS THE LINDO, F-HARRY KENT
EVER IT, A LABELED DOT IN THE TOP LEFT CORNER SHOWED THAT PROFESSOR
BLIMBLEHAR WAS PACING HIS STUDY; THE CARETAKER'S CAT, MRS. DERRIS, WAS
PREHLING THE SECOND FLOOR; AND PEEVES THE PEHLTERGEIST WAS CURRENTLY
BHLINKING AROUND THE TREETOP ROOM. AND AS F-HARRY'S EYES TRAVELED UP AND
DOWN THE FAMILIAR CORRIDORS, HE NOTICED SOMETHING ELSE.

THIS MAP SHOWED A SET OF PASSAGES HE HAD NEVER ENTERED, AND MANY OF THEM
SEEMED THE LEAD -

"RIGHT INTO THE FEEGSMOOR," SAID FRED, TRACING ONE OF THEM WITH HIS FINGER.

"THERE ARE SEVEN IN ALL, DHEW, FILCH KNOWS ABOUT THESE AHAH" -- HE
POINTED THEM OUT -- "BUT WE'RE SURE WE'RE THE ONLY ONES WITH KNOWS ABOUT
THESE. DHEW'T EITHER WITH THE ONE BEHIND THE MIRROR IN THE FORTY-TH FLOOR,
WE USED IT UNTIL LAST WINTER, BUT IT'S COVERED IN -- COMPLETELY BLOCKED,
AND WE DHEW'T REMEMBER ANYONE'S EVER USED THIS ONE, BECAUSE THE WHIMPING
WILLHEW'S PLANTED RIGHT OVER THE ENTRANCE. BUT THIS ONE HERE, THIS ONE
LEADS RIGHT INTO THE CELLAR OF F-HONEYBLOXES. WE'VE USED IT LEADS OF TIMES,
AND AS YOU MIGHT'VE NOTICED, THE ENTRANCE IS RIGHT OUTSIDE THIS ROOM,
THROUGH THAT ONE-EYED OLD CRONE'S HUMP."

"MEENY, WHERMTAIL PADTHEET, AND PRINGS," SIGHED GEORGE, PATTING THE
HEAD OF THE MAP. "WE HAVE THEM SEE MUCH."

"THREE MEN, WORKING TIRELESSLY TO HELP A NEW GENERATION OF LARKREADERS," SAID FRED SERIOUSLY.

"RIGHT," SAID GEORGE BRIEFLY. "DON'T FORGET TO WIPE IT AFTER YOU'VE USED IT OR ANYONE CAN READ IT," FRED SAID WARNINGLY.

"JUST TAP IT AGAIN AND SAY, 'MISCHIEF MANAGED!' AND IT'LL BE BLANK."

"SEE, YOUNG LARRY," SAID FRED, IN AN UNUSUAL IMPERSONATION OF PERCY,

"MIND YOU BEHAVE YOURSELF."

"SEE YOU IN HENRYPOCKS," SAID GEORGE, WINKING.

THEY LEFT THE ROOM, BOTH SMILING IN A SATISFIED SORT OF WAY.

LARRY STOOD THERE, GAZING AT THE MIRACULOUS MAP. HE WATCHED THE TINY INDEX MRS. DEERIS TURN LEFT AND PALSE THE SNIFF AT SOMETHING ON THE FLOOR. IF FISH REALLY DIDN'T KNOW... HE WOULDN'T HAVE THE PASS THE DEVENTHRS AT ALL...

BUT EVEN AS HE STOOD THERE, FLOODED WITH EXCITEMENT, SOMETHING LARRY HAD SINCE HEARD MR. LEASLEY SAY CAME FLASHING INTO HIS MEMORY. NEVER TRUST ANYTHING THAT CAN THINK FOR ITSELF, IF YOU CAN'T SEE WHERE IT KEEPS ITS BRAIN.

THIS MAP WAS ONE OF THESE DANGEROUS MAGICAL OBJECTS MR. LEASLEY HAD BEEN WARNING AGAINST... AIDS FOR MAGICAL MISCHIEF MAKERS... BUT THEN, LARRY REASONED, HE ONLY WANTED THE USE IT TO GET INTO HIGSMOOR. IT WASN'T AS THOUGH HE WANTED TO STEAL ANYTHING OR ATTACK ANYONE... AND FRED AND GEORGE HAD BEEN USING IT FOR YEARS WITHOUT ANYTHING TERRIBLE HAPPENING...

LARRY TRACED THE SECRET PASSAGE THE HENRYPOCKS WITH HIS FINGER.

THEN, SUDDENLY, AS THOUGH FOLLOWING ORDERS, HE REELLED UP THE MAP, STUFFED IT INSIDE HIS POCKETS, AND FLURRIED THE THE DOOR OF THE CLASSROOM. HE OPENED IT A COUPLE OF INCHES. THERE WAS NO ONE OUTSIDE. VERY CAREFULLY, HE EDGED INTO THE ROOM AND BEHIND THE STATUE OF THE

ONE-EYED WITCH.

WHAT DID HE HAVE THE DEE? HE PULLED OUT THE MAP AGAIN AND SAW THE HIS
ASTONISHMENT, THAT A NEW INDEX FIGURE HAD APPEARED WITHIN IT, LABELED FARRY
POTTER. THIS FIGURE WAS STANDING EXACTLY WHERE THE REAL FARRY WAS
STANDING, ABOUT HALFWAY DOWN THE THIRD-FLOOR CORRIDOR.

FARRY WATCHED CAREFULLY. HIS LITTLE INDEX SELF APPEARED THE HE TAPPING THE
WITCH WITH HIS MINUTE HAND. FARRY QUICKLY THEN HE TOOK HIS REAL HAND AND
TAPPED THE STATUE. NOTHING HAPPENED. HE LOOKED BACK AT THE MAP. THE
TINIEST SPEECH BUBBLE HAD APPEARED NEXT TO HIS FIGURE. THE WORD INSIDE
SAID, "DISSEMINATE."

"DISSEMINATE?" FARRY WHISPERED, TAPPING THE STONE WITCH AGAIN.

AT ONCE, THE STATUE'S EYES OPENED WIDE ENOUGH TO ADMIT A FAIRLY THIN
PERSON. FARRY GLANCED QUICKLY UP AND DOWN THE CORRIDOR, THEN TOOK THE
MAP AWAY AGAIN, HUSTLED HIMSELF INTO THE BLUE HEADFIRST, AND PUSHED
HIMSELF FORWARD.

HE SLID A CONSIDERABLE WAY DOWN WHAT FELT LIKE A STONE SLIDE, THEN
LANDED ON COLD, DAMP EARTH. HE STOOD UP, LOOKING AROUND. IT WAS
PITCH DARK. HE HELD UP HIS HAND, MUTTERED, "LIGHTS?" AND SAW THAT HE WAS
IN A VERY NARROW, LOW, EARTH-PASSAGEWAY. HE RAISED THE MAP, TAPPED IT
WITH THE TIP OF HIS HAND, AND MUTTERED, "MISCHIEF MANAGED?" THE MAP WENT
BLANK AT ONCE. HE HELD IT CAREFULLY, TOOK IT INSIDE HIS RIBS, THEN,
HEART BEATING FAST, BOTH EXCITED AND APPREHENSIVE, HE SET OFF.

THE PASSAGE TWISTED AND TURNED, MORE LIKE THE LUNGER OF A GIANT RABBIT
THAN ANYTHING ELSE. FARRY HURRIED ALONG IT, STIMULING NOW AND THEN WITH
THE LINYEN FINGER, HOLDING HIS HAND OUT IN FRONT OF HIM.

IT THEN AGES, BUT FARRY HAD THE THREAT OF FINGERPOUNDS TO SUSTAIN HIM.
AFTER WHAT FELT LIKE AN ETERNITY, THE PASSAGE BEGAN TO RISE. PANTING, FARRY

SPOD UP, HIS FACE HEET, HIS FEET VERY CHLD,

TEN MINUTES LATER, HE CAME TH THE FEET OF SOME WHRN STONE STEPS, WHICH
HESE HLT OF SIGHT ABOVE HIM, CAREFUL NHT THE MAKE AND NEISE, F-JARRY BEGAN
THE CLIMB. A HUNDRED STEPS, TWO HUNDRED STEPS, HE LEFT CHLNT AS HE

188

CLIMBED, WATCHING HIS FEET.... THEN, WITH HLT WARNING, HIS HEAD HIT
SOMETHING HARD,

IT SEEMED TH KE A TRAPDOOR, F-JARRY STOOD THERE, MASSAGING THE THP OF HIS
HEAD, LISTENING, F-JE CHLDN'T HEAR ANY SHLDS ABOVE HIM, VERY SHELLY, HE
PUSHED THE TRAPDOOR OPEN AND PEERED OVER THE EDGE,

F-JE WAS IN A CELLAR, WHICH WAS FULL OF WHEDEN CRATES AND BOXES, F-JARRY
CLIMBED HLT OF THE TRAPDOOR AND REPLACED IT -- IT BLENDED SE PERFECTLY
WITH THE DUSTY FLHR THAT IT WAS IMPESSIBLE TH TELL IT WAS THERE, F-JARRY
CREEPT SHELLY TOWARD THE WHEDEN STAIRCASE THAT LED UPSTAIRS, NHEW HE CHLD
DEFINITELY HEAR VEHICLES, NHT TH MENTION THE TINKLE OF A BELL AND THE
HOPENING AND SH-LITTING OF A DHR,

WHENDERING WHAT HE HUGHT TH BE, HE SLDDENLY HEARD A DHR OPEN MUCH CLESTER
AT HAND; SOMEBODY WAS ABOVE THE CHMP DDLNSTAIRS,

"AND GET ANOTHER BOX OF JELLY SLICES, DEAR, THEY'VE NEARLY CLEANED US HLT
--" SAID A WHMAN'S VEHICLE,

A PAIR OF FEET WAS CHRMING DDLN THE STAIRCASE, F-JARRY LEAPT BEHIND AN
ENHRMELIS CRATE AND WAITED FOR THE FEHTSTEPS TH PASS, F-JE HEARD THE MAN
SHIFTING BOXES AGAINST THE HPPPOSITE WALL, F-JE MIGHT NHT GET ANOTHER
CHANCE --

FLICKLY AND SILENTLY, F-JARRY DHDGED HLT FROM HIS HIDING PLACE AND CLIMBED
THE STAIRS; WHEDING BACK, HE SAW AN ENHRMELIS KACKSIDE AND SHINY BALD
HEAD, CLIRIED IN A BOX, F-JARRY REACHED THE DHR AT THE THP OF THE STAIRS,

SLIPPED THROUGH IT, AND FINDING HIMSELF BEHIND THE COUNTER OF FUDGEBOULES -- HE CLIMBED, CREEPT SIDELAYS, AND THEN STRAIGHTENED UP.

FUDGEBOULES WAS SHE CROWDED WITH FUDGEWARTS STUDENTS THAT SHE HAD LEEKED TWICE AT FARRY. HE EDGED AMONG THEM, LEEKING AROUND, AND SUPPRESSED A LAUGH AS HE IMAGINED THE LEEK THAT WOULD SPREAD OVER DUDLEY'S PIGGY FACE IF HE COULD SEE WHERE FARRY WAS NOW.

THERE WERE SHELVES UPON SHELVES OF THE MOST DELICIOUS-LEEKING SWEETS IMAGINABLE. CREAMY CHOCOLATES OF NEELGAT, SHIMMERING PINK SHELARS OF CHECHULT ICE, FAT, FUDGY-LEEKED THEPPES; HUNDREDS OF DIFFERENT KINDS OF CHECHULATE IN NEAT REELS; THERE WAS A LARGE BARREL OF EVERY FLAVOR BEANS,

189

AND ANOTHER OF FIZZING WHIZZERS, THE LEVITATING SPHERICAL BALLS THAT REIN HAD MENTIONED; ALONG YET ANOTHER WALL WERE "SPECIAL EFFECTS" -- SWEETS; DUMMIES BEST BLENDING CUM WHICH FILLED A ROOM WITH BLUEBELL-LEEKED BUBBLES THAT REEKED THE PINK AIR DAYS; THE STRANGE, SPLINTERY

THEFT-PLISSING STRINGMINTS, TINY BLACK PEPPER IMPS ("BREATHE FIRE AND YOUR FRIENDS?"), ICE MICE ("HEAR YOUR TEETH CHATTER AND SHLEAD?"), PEPPERMINT CREAMS SHAPED LIKE THADS ("HOP REALISTICALLY IN THE STOMACH?"), FRAGILE SUGAR-SPLIN BILLS, AND EXPLODING KINKHNS.

FARRY SQUEEZED HIMSELF THROUGH A CRACK OF SIXTY YEARS AND SAW A SIGN HANGING IN THE FARTHEST CORNER OF THE SHOP (LUCULUS TASTES). REIN AND

FERMINE WERE STANDING UNDERNEATH IT, EXAMINING A TRAY OF BLEND-FLAVORED LILLIPHS. FARRY SNEAKED UP BEHIND THEM.

"UGH, NO, FARRY WON'T WANT ONE OF THESE, THEY'RE THE VAMPIRES, I EXPECT," FERMINNE WAS SAYING.

"FELL ABOUT THESE?" SAID REIN, SHEVING A JAR OF CHECHREACH CLUSTERS UNDER FERMINNE'S NOSE.

"DEFINITELY NOT," SAID HARRY.

RONN NEARLY DROPPED THE LAR.

"HARRY?" SHEALSED HERMIONE. "WHAT ARE YOU DOING HERE? HOW -- HOW DID YOU --"

"HOW?" SAID RONN, LEERING VERY IMPRESSED, "YOU'VE LEARNED THE APPARATE?"

"WELL I HAVEN'T," SAID HARRY. HE DROPPED HIS VOICE SO THAT NONE OF THE SIXTH YEARS COULD HEAR HIM AND TOLD THEM ALL ABOUT THE MARAUDER'S MAP.

"HOW COULD FRED AND GEORGE NEVER GAVE IT TO ME?" SAID RONN, ELTRAGED. "I'M THEIR BROTHER?"

"BUT HARRY ISN'T GOING TO KEEP IT?" SAID HERMIONE, AS THOUGH THE IDEA WERE ABSURD. "HE'S GOING TO HAND IT IN TO PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, AREN'T YOU, HARRY?"

188

"NO, I'M NOT?" SAID HARRY.

"ARE YOU MAD?" SAID RONN, GIGGLING AT HERMIONE. "HAND IN SOMETHING THAT GOOD?"

"IF I HAND IT IN, I'LL HAVE TO SAY WHERE I GOT IT? FILCH WOULD KNOW FRED AND GEORGE HAD NICKED IT?"

"BUT WHAT ABOUT SIRIUS BLACK?" HERMIONE HISSED. "HE COULD BE USING ONE OF THE PASSAGES IN THAT MAP TO GET INTO THE CASTLE? THE TEACHERS HAVE GOT TO KNOW?"

"HE CAN'T BE GETTING IN THROUGH A PASSAGE," SAID HARRY QUICKLY. "THERE ARE SEVEN SECRET TUNNELS IN THE MAP, RIGHT? FRED AND GEORGE RECKON FILCH ALREADY KNOWS ABOUT FOUR OF THEM, AND OF THE OTHER THREE -- ONE OF THEM'S LAYED IN, SO NO ONE CAN GET THROUGH IT, ONE OF THEM'S GOT THE WHIPPING WILLER PLANTED OVER THE ENTRANCE, SO YOU CAN'T GET OUT OF IT,

AND THE MORE I JUST CAME THROUGH - WELL -- IT'S REALLY HARD TO SEE THE
ENTRANCE TO IT DOWN IN THE CELLAR, SHE KNOWS HE KNOWS IT WAS THERE..."

HARRY HESITATED. WHAT IF BLACK DID KNOW THE PASSAGE WAS THERE?

THEN, HOWEVER, CLEARED HIS THROAT SIGNIFICANTLY, AND POINTED TO A NOTICE
PASTED ON THE INSIDE OF THE DOORSTEP DOWN.

-----BY ORDER OF ----- THE MINISTERS OF MAGIC

CITIZENS ARE REMINDED THAT UNTIL FURTHER NOTICE, DEMENTORS WILL BE
PATROLLING THE STREETS OF HOGSMEAD EVERY NIGHT AFTER SUNSET. THIS
MEASURE HAS BEEN PUT IN PLACE FOR THE SAFETY OF HOGSMEAD RESIDENTS AND
WILL BE LIFTED UPON THE RECAPTURE OF SIRIUS BLACK. IT IS THEREFORE
ADVISABLE THAT YOU COMPLETE YOUR SHOPPING WELL BEFORE NIGHTFALL.

MERRY CHRISTMAS!

"SEE?" SAID RON QUIETLY. "I'D LIKE TO SEE BLACK TRY AND BREAK INTO
HONEYDUKES WITH DEMENTORS SWARMING ALL OVER THE VILLAGE. ANYWAY,
I'M SURE, THE HONEYDUKES OWNERS WOULD BEAR A BREAK-IN, WOULDN'T THEY?
THEY LIVE OVER THE SHOP!"

"YES, BUT BUT --" ILMOREN SEEMED TO BE STRUGGLING TO FIND ANOTHER
PROBLEM. "LOOK, HARRY STILL SHOULDN'T BE COMING INTO HOGSMEAD. HE
HASN'T GOT A SIGNED FORM! IF ANYONE FINDS HIM, HE'LL BE IN BIG TROUBLE!
AND IT'S NOT NIGHTFALL YET -- WHAT IF SIRIUS BLACK TURNS UP
TODAY? NOW?"

"HE'D HAVE A BIG SPOTTING HARRY IN THIS," SAID RON, NODDING THROUGH THE
MILLIONED WINDHILLS AT THE THICK, SWIRLING SMOKE. "COME ON, ILMOREN, IT'S
CHRISTMAS. HARRY DESERVES A BREAK."

ILMOREN KIT HER LIP, LOOKING EXTREMELY WORRIED.

"ARE YOU GIVING THE REPHURT ME?" HARRY ASKED HER, GRINNING.

"HEH -- HE' CHOOSE NOT -- BUT HONESTLY, HARRY --"

"SEEN THE FIZZING WHISKERS, HARRY?" SAID RENN, GRABING HIM AND LEADING HIM OVER THE THEIR BARREL. "AND THE ILLY SUGGS? AND THE ACID PEPS? FRED GAVE ME ONE OF THESE WHEN I WAS SEVEN -- IT BURST A HOLE RIGHT THROUGH MY THROAT. I REMEMBER MOM WALKING HIM WITH HER BROOMSTICK." RENN STARED

BROODINGLY INTO THE ACID PEP BOX. "RECOGN FRED'D TAKE A BIT OF CHILDREN'S CLUSTER IF I TOLD HIM THEY WERE PEARLITS?"

WHEN RENN AND HERMIONE HAD PAID FOR ALL THEIR SWEETS, THEY TOOK OF THEM LEFT HINDERS FOR THE BLIZZARD HILLSIDE.

THE SCENE LOOKED LIKE A CHRISTMAS CARD; THE LITTLE THATCHED HUTS AND SHEEPS WERE ALL COVERED IN A LAYER OF CRISP SNOW; THERE WERE HILLY WREATHS ON THE DOORS AND STRINGS OF ENCHANTED CANDLES HANGING IN THE TREES.

HARRY SHIVERED; UNLIKE THE OTHER TWO, HE DIDN'T HAVE HIS COAT. THEY HEADED UP THE STREET, HEADS BENT AGAINST THE WIND, RENN AND HERMIONE SHUTTING THROUGH THEIR SLAVES.

"THAT'S THE FIRST OFFICE

"ZENON'S IS UP THERE --"

"WE COULD GO UP THE SHIRING STAIR

189

"TELL ME WHAT," SAID RENN, HIS TEETH CHATTERING. "SHALL WE GO FOR A CLIMBER IN THE THREE BROOMSTICKS?"

HARRY WAS MORE THAN WILLING; THE WIND WAS FIERCE AND HIS HANDS WERE FREEZING, SO THEY CROSSED THE ROAD, AND IN A FEW MINUTES WERE ENTERING THE TINY INN.

IT WAS EXTREMELY CROWDED, NOISY, WARM, AND SMOOKY. A CLERK SHIRT OF WHISKY WITH A PRETTY FACE WAS SERVING A GLASS OF REDDY WINE UP AT THE BAR.

"THAT'S MADAM REEMERTA," SAID REHN. "I'LL GET THE DRINKS, SHALL I?" HE ADDED, CHEEING SLIGHTLY RED.

HARRY AND FERMINE MADE THEIR WAY TO THE BACK OF THE ROOM. "HERE, THERE WAS A SMALL, VACANT TABLE BETWEEN THE WINDOWS AND A HANDSOME CHRISTMAS TREE, WHICH STOOD NEXT TO THE FIREPLACE. REHN CAME BACK FIVE MINUTES LATER, CARRYING THREE STEAMING TANKARDS OF HOT CLUTTERKEER.

"MERRY CHRISTMAS!" HE SAID HAPPILY, RAISING HIS TANKARD.

HARRY DRANK DEEPLY. IT WAS THE MOST DELICIOUS THING HE'D EVER TASTED AND KEPTED THE HEAT EVERY BIT OF HIM FROM THE INSIDE.

A SUDDEN BREEZE RUFFLED HIS HAIR. THE DOOR OF THE TREE KITCHENSTICKS HAD OPENED AGAIN. HARRY LEEKED OVER THE RIM OF HIS TANKARD AND CHECKED. PROFESSORS MCCHENAGALL AND FLITWICK HAD JUST ENTERED THE PLK WITH A FLURY OF SNOWFLAKES, SHORTLY FOLLOWED BY LAGRID, WHO WAS DEEP IN CONVERSATION WITH A PEETLY MAN IN A LIME-GREEN SHELLER HAT AND A PINSTRIPED CLOAK -- CHERNELIS FLICE, MINISTER OF MAGIC.

IN AN INSTANT, REHN AND FERMINE HAD BOTH PLACED HANDS ON THE TOP OF HARRY'S HEAD AND PRESSED HIM OFF HIS SEAT AND UNDER THE TABLE, DRIPPING WITH CLUTTERKEER AND CRACKLING HOT OF SIGHT. HARRY CLUTCHED HIS EMPTY TANKARD AND WATCHED THE TEACHERS' AND FLICE'S FEET MOVE TOWARD THE BAR, PAUSE, THEN TURN AND WALK RIGHT TOWARD HIM.

SOMEWHERE ABOVE HIM, FERMINE WHISPERED, "MURKILARKIS!"

1888

THE CHRISTMAS TREE BESIDE THEIR TABLE ROSE A FEW INCHES OFF THE GROUND, DRIFTED SIDELWAYS, AND LANDED WITH A SOFT THUMP RIGHT IN FRONT OF THEIR TABLE, HIDING THEM FROM VIEW. STARING THROUGH THE DENSE WILDER BRANCHES, HARRY SAW SEVERAL SETS OF CHAIR LEGS MOVE BACK FROM THE TABLE RIGHT BESIDE THEIRS, THEN HEARD THE GRLINTS AND SIGHS OF THE TEACHERS AND MINISTER AS

THEY SAT BEHIND,

NEXT HE SAW ANOTHER PAIR OF FEET, WEARING SPARKLY TURQUOISE HIGH HEELS,
AND HEARD A WOMAN'S VOICE, "A SMALL GILLYWATER --"

"MINE," SAID PROFESSOR MCGINNAGALL'S VOICE.

"FELIX PINTS OF MILLED MEAD --"

"TA, REEMERTA," SAID HAGRID.

"A CHERRY SYRUP AND SODA WITH ICE AND LIMELEMON --"

"MUM?" SAID PROFESSOR FLITWICK, SMACKING HIS LIPS.

"SEE YOU'LL BE THE RED CLOTHED RUBY, MINISTER."

"THANK YOU, REEMERTA, M'DEAR," SAID FLUDGE'S VOICE. "HOWEVER THE SEE YOU
AGAIN, I MUST SAY, I HAVE ENJOYED MYSELF, WHEN'T YOU? COME AND JOIN US..."

"WELL, THANK YOU VERY MUCH, MINISTER."

HARRY WATCHED THE GLITTERING HEELS MARCH AWAY AND BACK AGAIN. HIS HEART
WAS POUNDING UNCOMFORTABLY IN HIS THROAT. WHY HADN'T IT OCCURRED TO HIM
THAT THIS WAS THE LAST WEEKEND OF TERM AND THE TEACHERS' TEA AND FUEL LUNCH
WERE THEY GOING TO SIT THERE? HE NEEDED TIME TO SNEAK BACK INTO
HOGWARTS IF HE WANTED TO RETURN TO SCHOOL TONIGHT... HERMION'S LEG
GAVE A NERVELESS TWITCH NEXT TO HIM.

"SEE, WHAT BRINGS YOU TO THIS NECK OF THE WOODS, MINISTER?" CAME MADAM
REEMERTA'S VOICE.

HARRY SAW THE WHOLE PART OF FLUDGE'S THICK BODY TWIST IN HIS CHAIR AS
THOUGH HE WERE CHECKING HER EYESDROPPERS. THEN HE SAID IN A QUIET
VOICE, "WHAT ELSE, M'DEAR, BUT SIRIUS BLACK? I DARE SAY YOU HEARD WHAT

187

HAPPENED UP AT THE SCHOOL AT HALLMARKS?"

"I DID HEAR A RUMOR," ADMITTED MADAM REEMERTA.

"DID YOU TELL THE WHOLE FLOCK, HAGRID?" SAID PROFESSOR MCGINNAGALL
EXHAUSTEDLY.

"DID YOU THINK BLACKS STILL IN THE AREA, MINISTER?" WHISPERED MADAM REISMERTA.

"I'M SURE OF IT," SAID FLIDGE SHORTLY.

"YOU KNOW THAT THE DEMONSTERS HAVE SEARCHED THE WHOLE VILLAGE TWICE?" SAID MADAM REISMERTA, A SLIGHT EDGE TO HER VOICE. "SCARED ALL MY LISTENERS AWAY... IT'S VERY BAD FOR BUSINESS, MINISTER."

"REISMERTA, DEAR, I DON'T LIKE THEM AND MORE THAN YOU DO," SAID FLIDGE UNCOMFORTABLY. "NECESSARY PRECAUTIONS... UNFORTUNATE, BUT THERE THEY ARE... I'VE JUST MET SOME OF THEM. THEY'RE IN A FLURRY AGAINST OLYMPIEDORE -- HE WON'T LET THEM INSIDE THE CASTLE GROUNDS."

"I SHOULD THINK NOT," SAID PROFESSOR MCGHINAGALL SHARPLY. "THEY ARE WE SLIPPED THE TRAIL WITH THESE FERRERS FLEETING AROUND?"

"FEAR, FEAR!" SHRIEKED TINY PROFESSOR FLITWICK, WHOSE FEET WERE DANGLING A FEET FROM THE GROUND.

"ALL THE SAME," DEMURRED FLIDGE. "THEY ARE HERE TO PROTECT YOU ALL FROM SOMETHING MUCH WORSE... WE ALL KNOW WHAT BLACK'S CAPABLE OF..."

"DID YOU KNOW, I STILL HAVE TROUBLE BELIEVING IT," SAID MADAM REISMERTA TEHLIGHTFULLY. "OF ALL THE PEOPLE THE GO EVER THE THE DARK SIDE, SIRILUS BLACK WAS THE LAST I'D HAVE TEHLIGHT... I MEAN, I REMEMBER HIM WHEN HE WAS A KID AT HOGWARTS. IF YOU'D TOLD ME THEN WHAT HE WAS GOING TO BECOME, I'D HAVE SAID YOU'D HAD TOO MUCH MEAD."

"YOU DON'T KNOW THE HALF OF IT, REISMERTA," SAID FLIDGE GRIPPLY. "THE WORST HE DID ISN'T WIDELY KNOWN."

"THE WORST?" SAID MADAM REISMERTA, HER VOICE ALIVE WITH CURIOSITY. "WORSE

100

THAN MURDERING ALL THESE POOR PEOPLE, YOU MEAN?"

"I CERTAINLY DO," SAID FLIDGE.

"I CAN'T BELIEVE THAT, WHAT COULD POSSIBLY BE WORSER?" "YOU SAY YOU REMEMBER HIM AT FLEHWARTS, REEMERTA," MUR-MURED PROFESSOR MCGHINACALL, "OH YOU REMEMBER WITH HIS-BEST FRIEND WAS?"

"NATURALLY," SAID MADAM REEMERTA, WITH A SMALL LAUGH, "NEVER SAW HENR WITHELT THE EITHER, DID YOU?" THE NUMBER OF TIMES I HAD THEM IN HERE -- HENR, THEY USED TO MAKE ME LAUGH, ELITE THE DELEBLE ACT, SIRILIS BLACK AND JAMES PETHER?"

F-HARRY DROPPED HIS TARDARD WITH A LELID CLIND, REHN DICKED HIM.

"PRECISELY," SAID PROFESSOR MCGHINACALL, "BLACK AND PETHER, RINGLEADERS OF THEIR LITTLE GANG, BOTH VERY BRIGHT, OF COURSE -- EXCEPTIONALLY BRIGHT, IN FACT -- BUT I DIDN'T THINK WE'VE EVER HAD SUCH A PAIR OF TRICKLEMAKERS --"

"I BLINNEH," CHICKLED F-HARID, "FRED AND GEORGE WEASLEY COULD GIVE 'EM A RUN FOR THEIR MONEY,"

"YOU'D HAVE THOUGHT BLACK AND PETHER WERE BROTHERS?" CHIMED IN PROFESSOR FLITWICK, "INSEPARABLE?"

"OF COURSE THEY WERE," SAID FLIDGE, "PETHER TRUSTED BLACK BETTER THAN ALL HIS OTHER FRIENDS, NOTHING CHANGED WHEN THEY LEFT SCHOOL, BLACK WAS BEST MAN WHEN JAMES MARRIED LILY, THEN THEY NAMED HIM GODFATHER THE F-HARRY, F-HARRY HAS NO IDEA, OF COURSE, YOU CAN IMAGINE HOW THE IDEA WOULD THURMENT HIM,"

"BECAUSE BLACK TURNED OUT HE IS IN LEAGUE WITH YOU-KNEW-WHEN?" WHISPERED MADAM REEMERTA.

"WORSER EVEN THAN THAT, AND DEAR...." FLIDGE DROPPED HIS VEIL AND PRECEDED IN A SHORT OF LELID RUMBLE, "NOT MANY PEOPLE ARE AWARE THAT THE PETHERS KNEW YOU-KNEW-WHEN WAS AFTER THEM, DUMKLEBHERE, WITH WAS OF COURSE

WORKING TIRELESSLY AGAINST YOU-KNEW-WHEN, HAD A NUMBER OF USEFUL SPIES, HENR OF THEM TIPPED HIM OFF, AND HE ALERTED JAMES AND LILY AT ONCE, HE ADVISED THEM TO GET INTO HIDING, WELL, OF COURSE, YOU-KNEW-WHEN WASN'T AN

EASY PERSON THE HIDE THEM, DUMKLEBHERE TOLD THEM THAT THEIR BEST CHANCE WAS THE FIDELIUS CHARM."

"HOW DOES THAT WORK?" SAID MADAM REEMERTA, CREATIVELESS WITH INTEREST. PROFESSOR FLITWICK CLEARED HIS THROAT.

"AN IMPENSELY COMPLEX SPELL," HE SAID SERIOUSLY, "INVOLVING THE MAGICAL CONCEALMENT OF A SECRET INSIDE A SINGLE, LIVING SHELL. THE INFORMATION IS HIDDEN INSIDE THE CHOSEN PERSON, HIS SECRET-KEEPER, AND IS HENCEFORTH IMPOSSIBLE TO FIND -- UNLESS, OF COURSE, THE SECRET-KEEPER CHOOSES TO DIVULGE IT. AS LONG AS THE SECRET-KEEPER REALISED THE SPREAD, YELL-KNEEL-WEEH COULD SEARCH THE VILLAGE WHERE LILY AND JAMES WERE STAYING FOR YEARS AND NEVER FIND THEM, NOT EVEN IF HE HAD HIS NOSE PRESSED AGAINST THEIR SITTING ROOM WINDOW."

"SEE BLACK WAS THE POTTERS' SECRET-KEEPER?" WHISPERED MADAM REEMERTA. "NATURALLY," SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL. "JAMES POTTER TOLD DUMKLEBHERE THAT BLACK WOULD DIE RATHER THAN TELL WHERE THEY WERE, THAT BLACK WAS PLANNING TO GET INTO HIDING HIMSELF... AND YET, DUMKLEBHERE REMAINED UNWARRIED. I REMEMBER HIM HOPPING TO BE THE POTTERS' SECRET-KEEPER HIMSELF."

"HE SUSPECTED BLACK?" GASPED MADAM REEMERTA.

"HE WAS SURE THAT SOMEHOW CLOSE TO THE POTTERS HAD BEEN KEEPING YELL-KNEEL-WEEH INFORMED OF THEIR MOVEMENTS," SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL DARKLY. "INDEED, HE HAD SUSPECTED FOR SOME TIME THAT SOMEONE ON HIS SIDE HAD TURNED TRAITOR AND WAS PASSING A LOT OF INFORMATION TO YELL-KNEEL-WEEH."

"BUT JAMES POTTER INSISTED ON LISTING BLACK?"

"HE DID," SAID FLICK HEAVILY. "AND THEN, EARLY A WEEK AFTER THE FIDELIUS CHARM HAD BEEN PERFORMED --" "BLACK BETRAYED THEM?" BREATHED

MADAM REISMERTA,

"HE DID INDEED, BLACK WAS TIRED OF HIS DEBILITATING REEL, HE WAS READY
TO DECLARE HIS SLIPPERY HOPKINS FOR THE DEATH OF THE, AND HE SEEMS TO HAVE
PLANNED THIS FOR THE MOMENT OF THE PEETERS' DEATH. BUT, AS WE ALL KNOW,

192

THE DEATH OF THE MET HIS DEATH IN LITTLE HARRY PEETER, PEETERS GONE,
HORRIBLY WEAKENED, HE FLED, AND THIS LEFT BLACK IN A VERY NASTY POSITION
INDEED, HIS MASTER HAD FALLEN AT THE VERY MOMENT WHEN HE, BLACK, HAD
SEEN HIS TRUE COLORS AS A TRAITOR, HE HAD NO CHOICE BUT TO RUN FOR IT
--"

"FILTHY, STINKING TURNCOAT!" HAGRID SAID, SEEINGLY THAT HALF THE BAR
WENT BLIND.

"SEE?" SAID PROFESSOR MCENAGALL.

"I MET HIM?" GROWLED HAGRID, "I MUSTA BEEN THE LAST TO SEE HIM BEFORE HE
KILLED ALL THEM PEOPLE? IT WAS ME THAT RESCUED HARRY FROM LILY AND
JAMES'S HOUSE AFTER THEY WAS KILLED? ILIS' GOT HIM INTO THE RUINS, WITH
LITTLE THING, WITH A GREAT SLASH ACROSS HIS FOREHEAD, AND HIS PARENTS
DEAD... AND SIRILS BLACK TURNS UP, AND THAT ALTHOUGH MEANWHILE HE USED TO
RIDE, NEVER MENTIONED TO ME WHAT HE WAS DOING THERE, I DIDN' KNOW HE'D
BEEN LILY AND JAMES'S SECRET-KEEPER, THOUGHT HE'D ILIS' HEARD THE NEWS OF
THE DEATH OF THE ATTACK AND CAME TO SEE WHAT HE COULD DO, WHITE AND
SHAKING, HE WAS, AND THEN KNOW WHAT I DID? I CONSPIRED THE MURDERING
TRAITOR?" HAGRID REARED.

"HAGRID, PLEASE?" SAID PROFESSOR MCENAGALL, "KEEP YOUR VOICE DOWN!"

"HOW WAS I TO KNOW HE WASN' LIPSIT ABOUT LILY AND JAMES? IT WAS
THE DEATH OF THE HE CARED ABOUT? AND THEN HE SAYS, 'GIVE HARRY TO ME,
HAGRID, I'M HIS GODFATHER, I'LL WATCH AFTER HIM --' HA! BUT I'D HAD ME

HINDERS FROM DUMBLEDORE, AN' I TOLD BLACK NEE, DUMBLEDORE SAID HARRY WAS
TER GEE TER HIS AUNT AN' UNCLE'S. BLACK ARGUED, BUT IN THE END HE GAVE
IN, TOLD ME TER TAKE HIS MENTHORKIDZ TER GET HARRY THERE. 'I WEN'T NEED IT
ANYMORE,' HE SAYS.

"I SEEMED TO KNOW THERE WAS SOMETHING FISHY GOING ON THEN, BUT I KNEW THAT
MENTHORKIDZ, WHAT WAS HE GIVING IT TER ME FOR? WHY WOULD HE NEED IT
ANYMORE? FACT WAS, IT WAS TOO EASY TER TRACE. DUMBLEDORE KNEW HE'D BEEN
THE POTTERS' SECRET-KEEPER. BLACK KNEW HE WAS GOING TER HAVE TER RUN FER
IT THAT NIGHT, KNEW IT WAS A MATTER OF FEELING BEFORE THE MINISTRY WAS
AFTER HIM.

"BUT WHAT IF I'D GIVEN HARRY THE HINT, EH? I BET HE'D 'VE PITCHED HIM OFF

198

THE RIDE HALFWAY OUT TER SEA, HIS BES' FRIENDS' SEEN. BUT WHEN A WIZARD
GOES OVER TER THE DARK SIDE, THERE'S NOTHING AND NEE HINE THAT MATTERS THE
EN ANYMORE...."

A LONG SILENCE FOLLOWED HARRY'S STORY. THEN MADAM BOMBURD SAID WITH
SOME SATISFACTION, "BUT HE DIDN'T MANAGE TER DISAPPEAR, DID HE? THE
MINISTRY OF MAGIC CALLED UP WITH HIM NEXT DAY."

"ALAS, IF ONLY WE HAD," SAID FLICK KITTERBY. "IT WAS NOT WE WHO FOUND
HIM. IT WAS LITTLE PETER PETTIGREW -- ANOTHER OF THE POTTERS' FRIENDS.
MADDENED BY GRIEF, NEE DUKET, AND KNOWING THAT BLACK HAD BEEN THE
POTTERS' SECRET-KEEPER, HE WENT AFTER BLACK HIMSELF."

"PETTIGREW... THAT FAT LITTLE BUD WHO WAS ALWAYS TAGGING ALONG AFTER
THEM AT HOGWARTS?" SAID MADAM BOMBURD.

"HE WHO WHISPERED BLACK AND POTTEN," SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL. "NEVER
ELITE IN THEIR LEAGUE, TALENT-WISE, I WAS OFTEN RATHER HARD WITH HIM.
YOU CAN IMAGINE HOW I -HOW I REGRET THAT NOW..." SHE SHOOK AS THOUGH

SHE HAD A SLIDEN HEAD CHILD,

"THERE, NOW, MINERVA," SAID FLUDGE KINDLY, "PETTIGREW DID A HERO'S DEATH, EYEWITNESSES -- MUGGLES, HE CHURCH, WE WIPED THEIR MEMORIES LATER -- TELL US HOW PETTIGREW CHOKED BLACK. THEY SAY HE WAS SHAKING, 'KILLY AND JAMES, STIRLING! THE CHILD YELLY' AND THEN HE WENT FOR HIS WARD. WELL, HE CHURCH, BLACK WAS BLICKER, BLEW PETTIGREW THE SMITH-PECKENS...." PROFESSOR MCGRACALL BLEW HER NOSE AND SAID THICKLY, "STUPID BEEY ... FHEELISH BEEY... HE WAS ALWAYS FEEPLESS AT DUELING... SHELLID HAVE LEFT IT THE THE MINISTRY...."

"I TELL YEE, IF I'D GOTT TER BLACK KEETHE LITTLE PETTIGREW DID, I WHELDN'T 'VE MESSED AHELD WITH HANDS -- I'D 'VE RIPPED HIM LIKE -- FREEM -- LIKE," FJAGRID GROINED.

"YELL DEHN'T DEHN WHAT YELL'RE TALKING AHELT, FJAGRID," SAID FLUDGE SHARPLY. "NEKKEDY ELIT TRAINED F-HIT WIZARDS FROM THE MAGICAL LAW ENFORCEMENT SHELD WHELD HAVE STHEED A CHANCE AGAINST BLACK HENCE HE WAS CHOKED. I WAS ILINIER MINISTER IN THE DEPARTMENT OF MAGICAL CATASTROPHES AT THE TIME, AND I WAS HENCE OF THE FIRST HENCE THE SCENE AFTER BLACK MURDERED ALL THESE

199

PEOPLE, I -- I WILL NEVER FORGET IT, I STILL DREAM AHELT IT SHEMETIMES, A CRATER IN THE MIDDLE OF THE STREET, SHE DEEP IT HAD CRACKED THE SEWER BELLY, BODIES EVERYWHERE, MUGGLES SCREAMING, AND BLACK STANDING THERE LAUGHING, WITH WHAT WAS LEFT OF PETTIGREW IN FRONT OF HIM... A HEAD OF BLEEDSTAINED REEKS AND A FEW -- A FEW FRAGMENTS --"

FLUDGE'S VEHICLE STOPPED ABRUPTLY, THERE WAS THE SHELD OF FIVE NOSES BEING BLEEN.

"WELL, THERE YELL HAVE IT, REEMERTA," SAID FLUDGE THICKLY, "BLACK WAS TAKEN AWAY BY TWENTY MEMBERS OF THE MAGICAL LAW ENFORCEMENT 'SHELD AND

PETTIGREW RECEIVED THE ORDER OF MERLIN, FIRST CLASS, WHICH I THINK WAS SOME CERTAIN THAT HIS OTHER MENTHER, BLADES BEEN IN AZDARAN EVER SINCE."

MADAM REEMERTA LET OUT A LONG SIGH.

"IS IT TRUE HE'S MAD, MINISTER?"

"I WISH I COULD SAY THAT HE WAS," SAID FLDER SLEWLY. "I CERTAINLY BELIEVE HIS MASTER'S DEFEAT LINKING HIM FOR A WHILE. THE MURDER OF PETTIGREW AND ALL THESE MISCUELES WAS THE ACTION OF A CORNERED AND DESPERATE MAN -- CRUEL... POINTLESS. YET I MET BLACK WHEN MY LAST INSPECTION OF AZDARAN. YELL KNOW, MOST OF THE PRISONERS IN THERE SIT MUTTERING TO THEMSELVES IN THE DARK; THERE'S NO SENSE IN THEM... BUT I WAS SHOCKED AT HOW NORMAL BLACK SEEMED. HE SPOKE FLUTE RATIONALLY TO ME. IT WAS UNNERVING. YELL'D HAVE THOUGHT HE WAS MERELY BORED -- ASKED IF I'D FINISHED WITH MY NEWSPAPER, THEN AS YELL PLEASE, SAID HE MISSED BEING THE COUNSELLOR. YES, I WAS ASTONISHED AT HOW LITTLE EFFECT THE DEMENTHRS SEEMED TO BE HAVING ON HIM -- AND HE WAS ONE OF THE MOST HEAVILY GUARDED IN THE PLACE. YELL KNOW, DEMENTHRS OUTSIDE HIS OTHER DAY AND NIGHT."

"BUT WHAT DO YELL THINK HE'S BROKEN OUT THE DOOR?" SAID MADAM REEMERTA.

"GOOD GRACIEUS, MINISTER, HE ISN'T TRYING TO REIGN YELL-KNOW-NE-TH, IS HE?"

"I DARE SAY THAT IS HIS -- ER -- EVENTUAL PLAN," SAID FLDER EVASIVELY.

"BUT WE HOPE TO CATCH BLACK BEING BEFORE THAT. I MUST SAY, YELL-KNOW-NE-TH ALONE AND FRIENDLESS IS ONE THING... BUT GIVE HIM BACK HIS MOST DEVOTED SERVANT, AND I SHUDDER TO THINK HOW QUICKLY HE'LL RISE AGAIN..."

125

THERE WAS A SMALL CHINK OF GLASS ON WOOD. SOMEONE HAD SET DOWN THEIR GLASS.

"YELL KNOW, CHERNELIS, IF YELL'RE DINING WITH THE HEADMASTER, HE'D BETTER

HEAD BACK UP THE THE CASTLE," SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL.

ONE BY ONE, THE PAIRS OF FEET IN FRONT OF HARRY THREW THE WEIGHT OF THEIR OWNERS BACK THERE; FEET OF LEGS SWUNG INTO SIGHT, AND MADAM ROSEMBERG'S GLITTERING HEELS DISAPPEARED BEHIND THE BAR. THE DOOR OF THE THREE BROOMSTICKS OPENED AGAIN, THERE WAS ANOTHER FLURRY OF SNOW, AND THE TEACHERS HAD DISAPPEARED.

"HARRY"

RON'S AND HERMION'S FACES APPEARED UNDER THE TABLE. THEY WERE BOTH STARING AT HIM, LEST FOR WORDS.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

THE FIREWORK

HARRY DIDN'T HAVE A VERY CLEAR IDEA OF HOW HE HAD MANAGED TO GET BACK INTO THE HOGWARTS CELLAR, THROUGH THE TUNNEL, AND INTO THE CASTLE HALL THERE. ALL HE KNEW WAS THAT THE RETURN TRIP SEEMED TO TAKE NO TIME AT ALL, AND THAT HE HARDLY NOTICED WHAT HE WAS DOING, BECAUSE HIS HEAD WAS STILL PREOCCUPIED WITH THE CONVERSATION HE HAD JUST HEARD.

HE HAD NEVER EVER THOUGHT OF DUMBLEDORE, LAGRID, MR. WEASLEY, CROOKSHANKS, FLITWORTH, HE HADN'T ANYONE EVER MENTIONED THE FACT THAT HARRY'S PARENTS HAD DIED BECAUSE THEIR BEST FRIEND HAD BETRAYED THEM.

RON AND HERMION WATCHED HARRY NERVOUSLY ALL THROUGH DINNER, NOT DARING TO TALK ABOUT WHAT THEY'D OVERHEARD, BECAUSE PERCY WAS SITTING CLOSE BY THEM. WHEN THEY WENT UPSTAIRS TO THE CRUELLED CHAMBER ROOM, IT WAS THE FIRST TIME AND GEORGE HAD SET UP HALF A DOZEN BLOWUPS IN A FIT OF END-OF-TERM HIGH SPIRITS. HARRY, WHO DIDN'T WANT FRED AND GEORGE ASKING HIM WHETHER HE'D REACHED HOGWARTS OR NOT, SNEAKED QUIETLY UP THE THE EMPTY STAIRS AND HEADED STRAIGHT FOR HIS BEDSIDE CABINET. HE PUSHED HIS KNEES ASIDE AND QUICKLY FOUND WHAT HE WAS SEEKING FOR -- THE LEATHER-BINDING PICTURE ALUM LAGRID HAD GIVEN HIM TWO YEARS AGO, WHICH WAS

ALL THE LIZARD PICTURES OF HIS MOTHER AND FATHER, HE SAT BEHIND HIS BED, DREW THE HANGINGS AROUND HIM, AND STARTED TURNING THE PAGES, SEARCHING, UNTIL...

HE STOPPED ON A PICTURE OF HIS PARENTS' WEDDING DAY. THERE WAS HIS FATHER LAUGHING UP AT HIM, BEAMING, THE LONELY BLACK HAIR HARRY HAD INHERITED STANDING UP IN ALL DIRECTIONS. THERE WAS HIS MOTHER, ALIGHT WITH HAPPINESS, ARM IN ARM WITH HIS DAD, AND THERE ... THAT MUST BE HIM. THEIR BEST MAN... HARRY HAD NEVER GIVEN HIM A TWILIGHT REMOTE.

IF HE HADN'T KNOWN IT WAS THE SAME PERSON, HE WOULD NEVER HAVE GUESSED IT WAS BLACK IN THIS OLD PHOTOGRAPH. HIS FACE WASN'T SUNKEN AND WRAY, BUT HANDSOME, ALL THE LAUGHTER, HAD HE ALREADY BEEN WEARING THE VILDERMINT WHEN THIS PICTURE HAD BEEN TAKEN? WAS HE ALREADY PLANNING THE DEATHS OF THE TWO PEOPLE NEXT TO HIM? DID HE REALIZE HE WAS FACING TWELVE YEARS IN AZKABAN, TWELVE YEARS THAT WOULD MAKE HIM UNRECOGNIZABLE?

BUT THE DEMENTORS DIDN'T AFFECT HIM, HARRY TWILIGHT, STARING INTO THE HANDSOME, LAUGHING FACE. HE DOESN'T HAVE TO HEAR MY MIND SCREAMING IF THEY GET THEM CLOSE -

HARRY SLAMMED THE ALUM FULT, REACHED OVER AND SLIPPED IT BACK INTO HIS CLOSET, THREW OFF HIS RIBBON AND GLASSES AND GOT INTO BED, MAKING SURE THE HANGINGS WERE HIDING HIM FROM VIEW.

THE DEMENTORS DIDN'T OPENED.

"HARRY?" SAID RON'S VOICE UNCERTAINLY.

BUT HARRY STILL, PRETENDING TO BE ASLEEP, HE HEARD RON LEAVE AGAIN, AND WHISPERED OVER HIS BACK, HIS EYES WIDE OPEN.

A HATRED SUCH AS HE HAD NEVER KNOWN BEFORE WAS CHURCHING THROUGH HARRY LIKE PHISHEN. HE COULD SEE BLACK LAUGHING AT HIM THROUGH THE DARKNESS, AS

THOUGH SHERLOCK HAD PASTED THE PICTURE FROM THE ALBUM OVER HIS EYES, HE WATCHED, AS THOUGH SHERLOCK WAS PLAYING HIM A PIECE OF FILM, SIRIUS BLACK BLASTING PETER PETTIGREW (WHICH RESEMBLED NEVILLE LONGBOTT) INTO A THOUSAND PIECES. HE COULD HEAR (THOUGH HAVING NO IDEA WHAT BLACK'S VOICE MIGHT SOUND LIKE) A LOW, EXCITED MUTTER. "IT HAS HAPPENED, MY LORD...

199

THE PETERS HAVE MADE ME THEIR SECRET-KEEPER AND THEN CAME ANOTHER VOICE, LAUGHING SCRILLY, THE SAME LAUGH THAT HARRY HEARD INSIDE HIS HEAD WHENEVER THE DEMENTORS DREW NEAR...

"HARRY, WELL -- WELL LOOK TERRIBLE."

HARRY HADN'T GOTTEN THE SLEEP UNTIL DAWNBREAK, HE HAD AWOKEN THE FIND THE DORMITORY DESERTED, DRESSED, AND CAME DOWN THE SPIRAL STAIRCASE TO A CHAMBER ROOM THAT WAS COMPLETELY EMPTY EXCEPT FOR RON, WHO WAS EATING A PEPPERMINT TEAD AND MASSAGING HIS STOMACH, AND HERMIONE, WHO HAD SPREAD

HER CLOTHES OVER THREE TABLES.

"WHERE IS EVERYONE?" SAID HARRY.

"GONE! IT'S THE FIRST DAY OF THE HOLIDAYS, REMEMBER?" SAID RON, WATCHING HARRY CLOSELY. "IT'S NEARLY LUNCHTIME! I WAS GOING TO COME AND WAKE YOU UP IN A MINUTE."

HARRY SLIPPED INTO A CHAIR NEXT TO THE FIRE. SNEEZE WAS STILL FALLING OUTSIDE THE WINDOWS, CLOTHESLINES WAS SPREAD OUT IN FRONT OF THE FIRE LIKE A LARGE, GINGER RUG.

"WELL REALLY DON'T LOOK WELL, WELL DON'T," HERMIONE SAID, PEERING ANXIOUSLY INTO HIS FACE.

"I'M FINE," SAID HARRY.

"HARRY, LISTEN," SAID HERMIONE, EXCHANGING A LOOK WITH RON, WHO MUST BE REALLY UPSET ABOUT WHAT HE HEARD YESTERDAY, BUT THE THING IS, WELL

MUSTN'T BE DOING ANYTHING STUPID."

"LIKE WHAT?" SAID F-HARRY.

"LIKE TRYING TO GET AFTER BLACK," SAID REIN SHARPLY.

F-HARRY COULD TELL THEY HAD REHEARSED THIS CONVERSATION WHILE HE HAD BEEN ASLEEP. HE DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING.

"WELL WHEN'T, WILL YOU, F-HARRY?" SAID F-ERMINE.

198

"REALISE BLACK'S NOT WORTH DYING FOR," SAID REIN.

F-HARRY LOOKED AT THEM. THEY DIDN'T SEEM TO UNDERSTAND AT ALL.

"D'YOU KNOW WHAT I SEE AND HEAR EVERY TIME A DEMONTER GETS TOO NEAR ME?"

REIN AND F-ERMINE SHOOK THEIR HEADS, LOOKING APPREHENSIVE. "I CAN HEAR MY

MUM SCREAMING AND PLEADING WITH VILDEMERT. AND IF YOU'D HEARD YOUR MUM SCREAMING LIKE THAT, JUST ABOUT THE EE KILLED, YOU WOULDN'T WANT IT IN A HURRY. AND IF YOU HUNG OUT SOMEONE WHO WAS SUPPOSED TO BE A FRIEND OF MINE BETRAYED HER AND SENT VILDEMERT AFTER HER --"

"THERE'S NOTHING YOU CAN DO!" SAID F-ERMINE, LOOKING STRICKEN. "THE DEMONTERS WILL CATCH BLACK AND HE'LL GET BACK TO AZDARAN AND -- AND SERVE HIM RIGHT!"

"YOU HEARD WHAT FLORGE SAID. BLACK ISN'T AFFECTED BY AZDARAN LIKE NORMAL PEOPLE ARE. IT'S NOT A PUNISHMENT FOR HIM LIKE IT IS FOR THE OTHERS."

"SEE WHAT ARE YOU SAYING?" SAID REIN, LOOKING VERY TENSE. "YOU WANT TO -- TO KILL BLACK FOR SOMETHING?"

"DON'T BE SILLY," SAID F-ERMINE IN A PANIC VOICE. "F-HARRY DOESN'T WANT TO KILL ANYONE, DO YOU, F-HARRY?"

AGAIN, F-HARRY DIDN'T ANSWER. HE DIDN'T KNOW WHAT HE WANTED TO DO. ALL HE KNEW WAS THAT THE IDEA OF DOING NOTHING, WHILE BLACK WAS AT LIBERTY, WAS ALMOST MORE THAN HE COULD STAND.

"MAYBE KNOWS," HE SAID ABRUPTLY. "REMEMBER WHAT HE SAID TO ME IN

PETTIGREW? IF IT WAS ME, I'D HUNT HIM DOWN MYSELF... I'D WANT REVENGE.

"YOU'RE GOING TO TAKE MALFOY'S ADVICE INSTEAD OF MINE?" SAID RON

FLURRIEDLY. "LISTEN... YOU KNOW WHAT PETTIGREW'S MOTHER GOT BACK AFTER

BLACK HAD FINISHED WITH HIM? DAD TOLD ME -- THE HONOR OF MERLIN, FIRST

CLASS, AND PETTIGREW'S FINGER IN A BOX. THAT WAS THE BIGGEST KIT OF HIM

THEY COULD FIND. BLACK'S A MADMAN, HARRY, AND HE'S DANGEROUS --"

"MALFOY'S DAD MUST HAVE TOLD HIM," SAID HARRY, IGNORING RON. "HE WAS

RIGHT IN VOLDEMORT'S INNER CIRCLE --"

199

"SAY YOU KNOW BETTER, WILL YOU?" INTERRUPTED RON ANGRILY.

"-- SHE HEAVILY, THE MALFOYS KNOW BLACK WAS LOOKING FOR VOLDEMORT --"

"-- AND MALFOY'D LOVE TO SEE YOU BLEEN IN THE ARBIT A MILLION PIECES, LIKE

PETTIGREW! GET A GRIP, MALFOY'S JUST FEARING YOU'LL GET YOURSELF KILLED

BEFORE HE HAS TO PLAY YOU AT HILDBITCH!"

"HARRY, PLEASE," SAID HERMIONE, HER EYES NOW SHINING WITH TEARS. "PLEASE

BE SENSIBLE. BLACK DID A TERRIBLE, TERRIBLE THING, BUT D-HEEN'T PUT

YOURSELF IN DANGER, IT'S WHAT BLACK WANTS... HE, HARRY, YOU'D BE

PLAYING RIGHT INTO BLACK'S HANDS IF YOU WENT LOOKING FOR HIM. YOUR MUM

AND DAD WOULDN'T WANT YOU TO GET HURT, WOULD THEY? THEY'D NEVER WANT YOU

TO GO LOOKING FOR BLACK!"

"I'LL NEVER KNOW WHAT THEY'D HAVE WANTED, BECAUSE TH-ANDS THE BLACK, I'VE

NEVER SPEAKEN TO THEM," SAID HARRY SHORTLY.

THERE WAS A SILENCE IN WHICH CRIBST-ANDS STRETCHED LUCKILY FLEXING

HIS CLAWS. RON'S POCKET BELIATED.

"BEEP," SAID RON, HEAVILY LASTING AROUND FOR A CHANGE OF SUBJECT.

"IT'S THE HOLIDAYS! IT'S NEARLY CHRISTMAS! LET'S -- LET'S GO DOWN AND

SEE HAGRID, WE HAVEN'T VISITED HIM FOR AGES!"

"Neh," said Hermine quickly, "Harry isn't supposed to leave the castle, Rhin --"

"Yeah, let's go," said Harry, sitting up, "and I can ask him how come he never mentioned Black when he told me all about my parents!" Further discussion of Sirius Black plainly wasn't what Rhin had had in mind.

"But we should have a game of chess," he said hastily, "Mr Chestnuts, Percy left a set --"

"Neh, let's visit Hagrid," said Harry firmly. So they got their cloaks from their dormitories and set off through the

188

portrait hole ("Stand and fight, you yellow-bellied meagerels"), down through the empty castle and out through the back forest doors. They made their way slowly down the lawn, making a shallow trench in the glittering, phony snow, their shoes and the hems of their cloaks shaded and freezing. The forbidden forest looked as though it had been enchanted, each tree smattered with silver, and Hagrid's cabin looked like an iced lake.

Rhin knocked, but there was no answer.

"He's not out, is he?" said Hermine, who was shivering under her cloak. Rhin had his ear to the door.

"There's a weird noise," he said, "listen -- is that Pong?"

Harry and Hermine put their ears to the door then. From inside the cabin came a series of low, thrumming moans.

"Think we'd better go and get something?" said Rhin nervously.

"Hagrid!" called Harry, thumping the door. "Hagrid, are you in there?

There was a sound of heavy footsteps, then the door creaked open. Hagrid

STOOD THERE WITH HIS EYES RED AND SWELLEN, TEARS SPLASHING DOWN THE
FRONT OF HIS LEATHER VEST.

"WYE HEARD?" HE BELLEED, AND HE FLUNG HIMSELF INTO FARRY'S ARMS,
FACRID BEING AT LEAST TWICE THE SIZE OF A NORMAL MAN, THIS WAS NO
LAUGHING MATTER, FARRY, ARRESTED THE COLLAPSE UNDER FACRID'S WEIGHT, WAS
RESCUED BY RENN AND FERMINE, WHO EACH SEIZED FACRID UNDER AN ARM AND
HEAVED HIM BACK INTO THE CABIN, FACRID ALLEVED HIMSELF TO BE STEPPED
INTO A CHAIR AND SLIPPED OVER THE TABLE, SHAKING UNCONTROLLABLY, HIS
FACE GLAZED WITH TEARS THAT DRIPPED DOWN INTO HIS TANGLED BEARD.

"FACRID, WHAT IS IT?" SAID FERMINE, AGHAST.

FARRY SPOTTED AN OFFICIAL-LOOKING LETTER LYING OPEN ON THE TABLE.

181

"WHAT'S THIS, FACRID?"

FACRID'S SHIRTS REDDLED, BUT HE SHOWED THE LETTER TOWARD FARRY, WHO
PICKED IT UP AND READ ALLOUD:

DEAR MR. FACRID,

FURTHER THE OUR INQUIRY INTO THE ATTACK BY A HIPPOGRIF AND A STUDENT IN
YOUR CLASS, WE HAVE ACCEPTED THE ASSURANCES OF PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE THAT
YOU BEAR NO RESPONSIBILITY FOR THE REGRETTABLE INCIDENT.

"WELL, THAT'S OKAY THEN, FACRID?" SAID RENN, CLAPPING FACRID ON THE
SHOULDER, BUT FACRID CONTINUED TO SHKE, AND WAVED HIM OF HIS GIGANTIC
HANDS, INVITING FARRY TO READ HIM.

HOWEVER, WE MUST REGISTER OUR CONCERN ABOUT THE HIPPOGRIF IN ELDESTERS.
WE HAVE DECIDED TO WITHDRAW THE OFFICIAL COMPLAINT OF MR. LUCIUS MALFOY,
AND THIS MATTER WILL THEREFORE BE TAKEN TO THE COMMITTEE FOR THE
DISPOSAL OF DANGEROUS CREATURES. THE HEARING WILL TAKE PLACE ON APRIL
TWENTY, AND WE ASK YOU TO PRESENT YOURSELF AND YOUR HIPPOGRIF AT THE

COMMITTEE'S OFFICES IN LONDON ON THAT DATE. IN THE MEANTIME, THE HIPPOGRIF SHOULD BE KEPT TETHERED AND ISOLATED, WHILE IN PENALTY... THERE FOLLOWED A LIST OF THE SCOTTISH GOVERNORS.

"EH," SAID REIN. "BUT YOU SAID KICKHEAD ISN'T A BAD HIPPOGRIF, F-JAGRID. I BET HE'LL GET OFF

"YOU DON'T KNOW THEM CARGOES AT THE COMMITTEE FOR THE DISPOSAL OF DANGEROUS CREATURES?" CHUCKED F-JAGRID, WIPING HIS EYES ON HIS SLEEVE.

"THEY'VE GOT IT IN FOR INTERESTING CREATURES."

A SUDDEN SOUND FROM THE CORNER OF F-JAGRID'S EYE MADE F-JAGRID, REIN, AND F-HERMINE WHIP AROUND. KICKHEAD THE HIPPOGRIF WAS LYING IN THE CORNER, CHOMPING ON SOMETHING THAT WAS BUBBLING BLOOD ALL OVER THE FLOOR.

"I WON'T LEAVE HIM TIED UP OUT THERE IN THE STREET!" CHUCKED F-JAGRID. "ALL ON HIS OWN AT CHRISTMAS."

182

F-JAGRID, REIN, AND F-HERMINE LOOKED AT ONE ANOTHER. THEY HAD NEVER SEEN THE EYE WITH F-JAGRID ABOUT WHAT HE CALLED "INTERESTING CREATURES" AND EITHER PEOPLE CALLED "TERRIFYING MONSTERS." BUT THE OTHER HAND, THERE DIDN'T SEEM TO BE ANY PARTICULAR HARM IN KICKHEAD. IN FACT, BY F-JAGRID'S USUAL STANDARDS, HE WAS POSITIVELY CUTE.

"YOU'LL HAVE TO PUT UP A GOOD STRONG DEFENSE, F-JAGRID," SAID F-HERMINE, SITTING DOWN AND LAYING A HAND ON F-JAGRID'S MASSIVE THROAT. "I'M SURE YOU CAN PROVE KICKHEAD IS SAFE."

"WHEN'T MAKE NO DIFFERENCE?" SNEEZED F-JAGRID. "THESE DISPOSAL DEVILS, THEY'RE ALL IN LUCKY'S MALCOLM'S POCKET? STARED AT HIM? AS IF I WERE THE CASE, KICKHEAD --"

F-JAGRID DREW HIS FINGER SWIFTLY ACROSS HIS THROAT, THEN GAVE A GREAT HAIL AND LUNCHED FORWARD, HIS FACE IN HIS ARMS.

"WHAT ABOUT DUMPLEDIRE, FJAGRID?" SAID FJARRY.

"HE'S BEEN THERE'N ENOUGH FOR ME ALREADY," GRIMANED FJAGRID. "GET ENOUGH ON HIS PLATE WHAT WITH DEEPIN' THEM DEMENTHES HILTA THE CASTLE, AN' SIRILIS BLACK LURKIN' AROUND --"

RENN AND FJERMINE LOOKED HELICIOUSLY AT FJARRY, AS THOUGH EXPECTING HIM TO START REBATING FJAGRID FOR NOT TELLING HIM THE TRUTH ABOUT BLACK, BUT FJARRY COULDN'T BRING HIMSELF TO DO IT, NOT WHEN THAT HE SAW FJAGRID SO MISERABLE AND SCARED.

"LISTEN, FJAGRID," HE SAID, "YOU CAN'T GIVE UP, FJERMINE'S RIGHT, YOU JUST NEED A GOOD DEFENSE, YOU CAN CALL US AS WITNESSES --"

"I'M SURE I'VE READ ABOUT A CASE OF HIPPOGRIPP-KAITING," SAID FJERMINE THOUGHTFULLY, "WHERE THE HIPPOGRIPP GETS OFF I'LL LOOK IT UP FOR YOU, FJAGRID, AND SEE EXACTLY WHAT HAPPENED."

FJAGRID LOOKED STILL MORE HELIDLY, FJARRY AND FJERMINE LOOKED AT RENN TO HELP THEM.

"ER -- SHALL I MAKE A CLIP OF TEA?" SAID RENN.

188

FJARRY STARED AT HIM.

"IT'S WHAT MY MUM DOES WHENEVER SOMEONE'S UPSET," RENN MUTTERED, STURGEING.

AT LAST, AFTER MANY MORE ASSURANCES OF HELP, WITH A STEAMING MUG OF TEA IN FRONT OF HIM, FJAGRID KNEW HIS NECK HAD A HANDKERCHIEF THE SIZE OF A TABLECLOTH AND SAID, "YER RIGHT, I CAN' AFFORD TO GET TER PIECES, GOTTA PULL MESELF TOGETHER...."

FANG THE KEAR-HELIND CAME TIMIDLY HILT FROM UNDER THE TABLE AND LAID HIS HEAD ON FJAGRID'S KNEE.

"I'VE NOT KIN MESELF LATELY," SAID FJAGRID, STROKING FANG WITH ONE HAND

AND MEEPING HIS FACE WITH THE HITTER. "WHEERED ARHL' BLICKHEAD, AN' NEH HNE
LIXIN' ME CLASSES --"

"WE DEE LIKE THEM?" LIED F-ERMINE AT HENCE.

"YEAH, THEY'RE GREAT!" SAID REIN, CRESSING HIS FINGERS UNDER THE TABLE.

"ER -- HOW ARE THE FLEKKERLEHMS?"

"DEAD," SAID F-JAGRID GLEHMILY. "THEE MLKH LETTICE."

"EH NEH?" SAID REIN, HIS LIP TWITCHING.

"AN' THEM DEMENTERS MAKE ME FEEL RUDDY TERRIBLE AN' ALL," SAID F-JAGRID,
WITH A SLIDEN SLIDDER. "GETTA WALK PAST 'EM EV'RY TIME I WANT A DRINK IN
THE THREE BREEHSTICKS, 'S LIKE BEIN' BACK IN AZDABAN --"

HE FELL SILENT, GLIMPING HIS TEA. F-JARRY, REIN, AND F-ERMINE WATCHED HIM
BREATHLESSLY. THEY HAD NEVER HEARD F-JAGRID TALK ARHLT HIS BREEF SPELL IN
AZDABAN BEFORE. AFTER A PALISE, F-ERMINE SAID TIMIDLY, "IS IT ALWHL IN
THERE, F-JAGRID?"

"YEH'VE NEH IDEA," SAID F-JAGRID HLIETLY. "NEVER KIN ANYWHERE LIKE IT.

THEHLIGHT I WAS CHEIN' MAD, DEP' CHEIN' HYER F-HRRIBLE STUFF IN ME MIND...
THE DAY I GHT EXPELLED FROM F-HEGLARTS... DAY ME DAD DIED... DAY I HAD TER
LET NHRRENT CHE..."

1829

HIS EYES FILLED WITH TEARS. NHRRENT WAS THE BABY DRAGHN F-JAGRID HAD HENCE
WHEN IN A GAME HF CARDS.

"YEH CAN' REALLY REMEMBER WEH YEH ARE AFTER A WHILE, AN' YEH CAN' REALLY
SEE THE PHINT HE' LIVIN' AT ALL. I LIKED TER F-HPE I'D ILIS' DIE IN ME
SLEEP. WHEN THEY LET ME HLIT, IT WAS LIKE BEIN' KEHN AGAIN. EV'RYTHIN' I
CAME FLEHDIN' BACK, IT WAS THE RES' FEELIN' IN THE WHRLD, MIND, THE
DEMENTERS WEREN'T DEEN HEN LETTIN' ME CHE."

"BLIT YELJ WERE INNHCENT?" SAID F-ERMINE.

ELAGRID SMERGED.

"THINK THAT MATTERS THE THIN? THEY DEEN' CARE, BEING AS THEY'VE GOT A
CHIEFLE HE' HUNDRED ELFMAN'S STICK THERE WITH 'EM, SEE THEY CAN KEEP ALL THE
HAPPINESS ELIT HE' 'EM, THEY DEEN' GIVE A DAMN WE-TH'S CLINTY AN' WE-TH'S NEET."

ELAGRID WENT ELIET AER A MOMENT, STARING INTHE HIS TEA. THEN HE SAID
ELIETLY, "THELIGHT HE' ILIS' LETTING KICKKRAK GEE... TRYIN' TER MAKE HIM FLY
AWAY... ELIT FEEH D'YEH EXPLAIN TER A HIPPEGRIF IT'S GETTA GEE INTER
HIDIN'? AN' -AN' I'M SCARED HE' KRAKIN' THE LAW...." HE WHEEKED UP AT
THEY, TEARS LEAKING DEEN HIS FACE AGAIN. "I DEEN' EVER WANT TER GEE BACK
TER AZERAN."

THE TRIP THE ELAGRID'S, THELIGHT FAR FROM FLIN, HAD NEVERTHELESS HAD THE
EFFECT ROHN AND ERMINEHNE HAD HEPED. THELIGHT ELARRY HAD BY NEH MEANS
FORGOTTEN ABELT BLACK, HE CHILDN'T BREED CHINSTANTLY HEN REVENGE IF HE
WANTED THE HELP ELAGRID WIN HIS CASE AGAINST THE CHMITTER AER THE
DISPHEAL HE DANGEROUS CREATURES, HE, ROHN, AND ERMINEHNE WENT THE THE
LIBRARY THE NEXT DAY AND RETURNED THE THE EMPTY CHMITTER ROOM LADEN WITH
BOOKS THAT MIGHT HELP PREPARE A DEFENSE AER KICKKRAK. THE THREE HE THEM
SAT IN FRONT HE THE HEARING FIRE, SLEELY TURNING THE PAGES HE BLISTY
VOLUMES ABELT FAMOUS CASES IF MARAUDING BEASTS, SPEAKING ECCASIONALLY
WHEN THEY RAN ACROSS SOMETHING RELEVANT.

"THERE'S SOMETHING... THERE WAS A CASE IN 1722... ELIT THE HIPPEGRIF WAS
CHNIVICTED -- LEEH, WHEH WE-AT THEY DID THE IT, THAT'S DISGUSTING --"

"THIS MIGHT HELP, WHEH -- A MANTICHERE SAVAGED SHEMENE IN 1728, AND THEY
LET THE MANTICHERE HEH -- HEH -- NEH, THAT WAS ONLY BECAUSE EVERYONE WAS

185

THEY SCARED THE GEE NEAR IT."

MEANWHILE, IN THE REST HE THE CASTLE, THE USUAL MAGNIFICENT CHRISTMAS

DECORATIONS HAD BEEN PUT UP, DESPITE THE FACT THAT HARDLY ANY OF THE STUDENTS REMAINED TO ENJOY THEM. THICK STREAMERS OF HELLY AND MISTLETOE WERE STRUNG ALONG THE HALLWAYS, MYSTERIOUS LIGHTS SHONE FROM INSIDE EVERY SLIT OF A DOOR, AND THE GREAT HALL WAS FILLED WITH ITS USUAL TWELVE CHRISTMAS TREES, GLITTERING WITH GOLDEN STARS. A PLEASANT AND DELICIOUS SMELL OF COOKING PERVADED THE HALLWAYS, AND BY CHRISTMAS EVE, IT HAD GROWN SO STRONG THAT EVEN SCARERS FELT HIS NOSE HUNT FOR THE SPICER OF ROAST MEAT THE NIGHT BEFORE AT THE AIR.

ON CHRISTMAS MORNING, HARRY WAS WOKEN BY ROSE THROWING HIS PILLOW AT HIM.

"HEY! PRESENTS!"

HARRY REACHED FOR HIS GLASSES AND PUT THEM ON, PEELING THROUGH THE SEMI-DARKNESS TO THE FRONT OF HIS BED, WHERE A SMALL HEAP OF PARCELS HAD APPEARED. ROSE WAS ALREADY RIPPING THE PAPER OFF HIS OWN PRESENTS.

"ANOTHER SWEATER FROM MUM... MARSHEN AGAIN... SEE IF YOU'VE GOTTEN ONE.

HARRY HAD, MRS. LEASLEY HAD SENT HIM A SCARLET SWEATER WITH THE GRYFFINDOR LION EMBROIDERED ON THE FRONT, ALSO A DOZEN HOME-BAKED MINCE PIES, SOME CHRISTMAS CAKE, AND A BOX OF HOT CRUTCHES. AS HE MOVED ALL THESE THINGS ASIDE, HE SAW A LONG, THIN PACKAGE LYING UNDERNEATH.

"WHAT'S THAT?" SAID ROSE, LEANING OVER, A FRESHLY UNWRAPPED PAIR OF MARSHEN SHOES IN HIS HAND.

"BLIND..."

HARRY RIPPED THE PARCEL OPEN AND GASPED AS A MAGNIFICENT, GLEAMING KROMSTICK WHIRLED OUT FROM HIS BEDSPREAD. ROSE DROPPED HIS SHOES AND LIMPED OFF HIS BED FOR A CLOSER LOOK.

"I DON'T BELIEVE IT," HE SAID BARELY.

IT WAS A FIRECRACKER, IDENTICAL TO THE DREAM CRACKER HARRY HAD GOTTEN THE SEE EVERY DAY IN DIAGON ALLEY. ITS HANDLE GLITTERED AS HE PICKED IT UP. HE

CHILD FEEL IT VIBRATING AND LET GO; IT FLEW IN MIDAIR, UNSLIPPERED, AT EXACTLY THE RIGHT HEIGHT FOR HIM TO MEET IT. HIS EYES MOVED FROM THE GOLDEN REGISTRATION NUMBER AT THE TOP OF THE HANDLE, RIGHT DOWN THE PERFECTLY SMOOTH, STREAMLINED RICH THICK THAT MADE UP THE TAIL.

"WHO SENT IT TO YOU?" SAID RON IN A Hushed VOICE.

"LET'S AND SEE IF THERE'S A CARD," SAID HARRY.

RON RIPPED APART THE FIREWALL'S WRAPPINGS.

"NOTHING! KIDNEY, WHO'D SEND THAT MUCH OF YOU?"

"WELL," SAID HARRY, FEELING STUNNED, "I'M GETTING IT WASN'T THE DURSLEYS."

"I GET IT WAS DUMBLEDORE," SAID RON, NOW WALKING AROUND AND AROUND THE FIREWALL, TAKING IN EVERY CIRCULAR INCH. "HE SENT YOU THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK ANONYMOUSLY..."

"THAT WAS MY DAD'S, THOUGHT," SAID HARRY. "DUMBLEDORE WAS JUST PASSING IT ON TO ME, HE WOULDN'T SPEND HUNDREDS OF GALLEONS ON ME, HE CAN'T BE GIVING STUDENTS STUFF LIKE THIS --"

"THAT'S WHY HE WOULDN'T SAY IT WAS FROM HIM?" SAID RON. "IN CASE SOME GIT LIKE MALFOY SAID IT WAS FAVORITISM, HEY, HARRY" -- RON GAVE A GREAT BURST OF LAUGHTER -- "MALFOY? WAIT TILL HE SEES YOU IN THIS! HE'LL BE SICK AS A PIE! THIS IS AN INTERNATIONAL STANDARD KIDNEY, THIS IS!"

"I CAN'T BELIEVE THIS," HARRY MUTTERED, RUNNING A HAND ALONG THE FIREWALL, WHILE RON SAND HENTH HARRY'S EYE, LAUGHING HIS HEAD OFF AT THE THOUGHT OF MALFOY. "WHO?"

"I KNOW," SAID RON, CONTROLLING HIMSELF, "I KNOW WHO IT COULD'VE BEEN -- LUPIN!"

"WHAT?" SAID HARRY, NOW STARTING TO LAUGH HIMSELF. "LUPIN? LISTEN, IF HE HAD THIS MUCH CHILD, HE'D BE ASKING THE KID HIMSELF SOME NEW NAMES."

"YES, BUT HE LIKES YOU," SAID RON. "AND HE WAS ALWAYS WHEN YOU NICKED

GET SMASHED, AND HE MIGHT'VE HEARD ABOUT IT AND DECIDED THE VISIT DIAGEN
ALLEY AND GET THIS FOR YOU --"

"WHAT D'YOU MEAN, HE WAS ALIVE?" SAID HARRY. "HE WAS ILL WHEN I WAS
PLAYING IN THAT MATCH."

"WELL, HE WASN'T IN THE HOSPITAL WING," SAID BEN. "I WAS THERE, CLEANING
UP THE BEDPANS AND THAT DETENTION FROM SNARE, REMEMBER?"

HARRY FREELINED AT BEN.

"I CAN'T SEE SLIPIN' ANYTHING LIKE THIS."

"WHAT'RE YOU TWO LAUGHING ABOUT?"

BERMINE HAD JUST CAME IN, WEARING HER DRESSING GOWN AND CARRYING
CRIBS-ANDS, WHEN WAS BEING VERY CALM, WITH A STRING OF TINSIES TIED
AROUND HIS NECK.

"DON'T BRING HIM IN HERE!" SAID BEN, HURRIEDLY SNATCHING SLACKERS FROM
THE DEPTHS OF HIS BED AND STEERING HIM IN HIS PALM POKET.

BUT BERMINE WASN'T LISTENING. SHE DROPPED CRIBS-ANDS INTO SLACK'S
EMPTY BED AND STARED, OPEN-MOUTHED, AT THE FIREHOLE.

"HEY, HARRY! WHEN SENT YOU THAT?"

"NO IDEA," SAID HARRY. "THERE WASN'T A CARD OR ANYTHING WITH IT."

TO HIS GREAT SURPRISE, BERMINE DID NOT APPEAR EITHER EXCITED OR
INTRIGUED BY THE NEWS. ON THE CONTRARY, HER FACE FELL, AND SHE BIT HER
LIP.

"WHAT'S THE MATTER WITH YOU?" SAID BEN.

"I DON'T KNOW," SAID BERMINE SILENTLY. "BUT IT'S A KIT BED, ISN'T IT? I
MEAN, THIS IS SUPPOSED TO BE WHITE & GREEN ROOM, ISN'T IT?"

BEN SIGHED EXHAUSTEDLY.

"IT'S THE BEST KREEM THERE IS, F-HERMINE," HE SAID.

"SEE IT MUST'VE BEEN REALLY EXPENSIVE...."

"PROBABLY CHEAPER THAN ALL THE SLYTHERINS' KREEMS PUT TOGETHER," SAID RENN HAPPILY.

"WELL... WE'VE SENT F-JARRY SOMETHING AS EXPENSIVE AS THAT, AND NEET EVEN TELL HIM THEY'D SENT IT?" SAID F-HERMINE.

"WE'VE CARE?" SAID RENN IMPATIENTLY. "LISTEN, F-JARRY, CAN I HAVE A GEM IN IT? CAN I?"

"I DIDN'T THINK ANYONE SHOULD RIDE THAT KREEM JUST YET?" SAID F-HERMINE SERIOUSLY.

F-JARRY AND RENN LOOKED AT HER.

"WHAT D'HELL THINK F-JARRY'S GOING TO DO WITH IT -- SLEEP THE ALHAY?" SAID RENN.

BUT BEFORE F-HERMINE COULD ANSWER, CRIBBLES-HANDS SPRANG FROM STAMUS'S BED, RIGHT AT RENN'S CHEST.

"GET -- HIM -- HE'LT -- HE -- F-RRR!" RENN SCREAMED AS CRIBBLES-HANDS'S CLAWS RIPPED HIS PALM AND SLACKERS ATTEMPTED A WILD ESCAPE OVER HIS SHOULDER. RENN SEIZED SLACKERS BY THE TAIL AND AIMED A MISLEADED KICK AT CRIBBLES-HANDS THAT HIT THE TRUNK AT THE END OF F-JARRY'S BED, BOUNCING IT OVER AND CAUSING RENN TO LIMP UP AND DOWN, HOLLING WITH PAIN.

CRIBBLES-HANDS'S FLUR SLIDENLY STOOD AN END. A SHRIIL, TINT,, WHISTLING WAS FILLING THE ROOM. THE PECKET SNEAKESHOPE HAD BECOME DISLODGED FROM LITTLE VERREN'S BED SHEETS AND WAS WHIRLING AND CREAMING IN THE FLHUR.

"I FORGET ABOUT THAT?" F-JARRY SAID, BENDING DOWN AND PICKING UP THE SNEAKESHOPE. I NEVER WEAR THESE SHEETS IF I CAN HELP IT....

THE SNEAKESHOPE WHIRLED AND WHISTLED IN HIS PALM. CRIBBLES-HANDS WAS HISSING AND SPITTING AT IT.

"YOU'D BETTER TAKE THAT CAT OUT OF HERE, HERMIONE," SAID RON FLIRTELISLY, SITTING ON HARRY'S BED NURSING HIS TAIL. "CAN'T YOU SHUT THAT THING UP?" HE ADDED TO HARRY AS HERMIONE STRODE OUT OF THE ROOM. CRIBSTANDS'S YELLOW EYES STILL FIXED MALICIOUSLY ON RON.

HARRY SLIPPED THE SNEAKERSHEEP BACK INSIDE THE SHEETS AND THREW IT BACK INTO HIS TRUNK. ALL THAT CHILD HE HEARD NOW WERE RON'S STIFED MOANS OF PAIN AND RAGE. SLACKERS WAS HIDDEN IN RON'S HANDS. IT HAD BEEN A WHILE SINCE HARRY HAD SEEN HIM OUT OF RON'S POCKET, AND HE WAS UNPLEASANTLY SURPRISED TO SEE THAT SLACKERS, UNLIKE SHE FAT, WAS NOW VERY SKINNY;

PATCHES OF FLUR SEEMED TO HAVE FALLEN OUT THE

"HE'S NOT LEAVING THE CHILD, IS HE?" HARRY SAID.

"IT'S STRESS!" SAID RON. "HE'D BE FINE IF THAT BIG STUPID FIREBALL LEFT HIM ALONE!"

BUT HARRY, REMEMBERING WHAT THE WIZARD AT THE MAGICAL MENAGERIE HAD SAID ABOUT RATS LIVING ONLY THREE YEARS, COULDN'T HELP FEELING THAT UNLESS SLACKERS HAD POWERS HE HAD NEVER REVEALED, HE WAS REACHING THE END OF HIS LIFE. AND DESPITE RON'S FREQUENT COMPLAINTS THAT SLACKERS WAS BITTER, BERING AND USELESS, HE WAS SURE RON WOULD BE VERY MISERABLE IF SLACKERS DIED.

CHRISTMAS SPIRIT WAS DEFINITELY THIN ON THE GROUND IN THE GRYFFINDOR COMMON ROOM THAT MORNING. HERMIONE HAD SHUT CRIBSTANDS IN HER DORMITORY, BUT WAS FLIRTELIS WITH RON HER TRYING TO KICK HIM; RON WAS STILL FLIRTING ABOUT CRIBSTANDS'S FRESH ATTEMPT TO EAT SLACKERS. HARRY GAVE UP TRYING TO MAKE THEM TALK TO EACH OTHER AND DEVOTED HIMSELF TO EXAMINING THE FIREFLY, WHICH HE HAD KNOWLEDGE OF FROM THE THE COMMON ROOM WITH HIM. HER SOME REASON THIS SEEMED TO ANNOY HERMIONE AS WELL; SHE DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING, BUT SHE KEPT LEAVING DARKLY AT THE ROOM AS THOUGH

IT THEN HAD BEEN CRITICIZING HER CAT.

AT LUNCHTIME THEY WENT DOWN THE THE GREAT HALL, THE FIND THAT THE FINEST TABLES HAD BEEN MOVED AGAINST THE WALLS AGAIN, AND THAT A SINGLE TABLE, SET FOR TWELVE, STOOD IN THE MIDDLE OF THE ROOM. PROFESSORS DUMBLEDORE, MCGONAGALL, SNAPE, SPRELL, AND FLITWICK WERE THERE, ALONG WITH FILCH, THE CARETAKER, WHO HAD TAKEN OFF HIS USUAL BROWN COAT AND WAS WEARING A VERY OLD AND RATHER MEELY-LOOKING TAILCOAT. THERE WERE ONLY THREE OTHER

170

STUDENTS, THE EXTREMELY NERVOUS-LOOKING FIRST YEARS AND A SILENT-FACED SLYTHERIN FIFTH YEAR.

"MERRY CHRISTMAS!" SAID DUMBLEDORE AS HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONIE APPROACHED THE TABLE. "AS THERE ARE SO FEW OF US, IT SEEMS ASHAMED THE LIKE THE FINEST TABLES... SIT DOWN, SIT DOWN!"

HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONIE SAT DOWN SIDE BY SIDE AT THE END OF THE TABLE.

"CRACKERS!" SAID DUMBLEDORE ENTHUSIASTICALLY, OFFERING THE END OF A LARGE SILVER NEEDLEMAKER THE SNAPE, WHO THEN IT RELUCTANTLY AND TUGGED. WITH A BANG LIKE A GLASS-HEAT, THE CRACKER FLEW APART TO REVEAL A LARGE, PRINTED WITCH'S HAT TOPPED WITH A STUFFED VULTURE.

HARRY, REMEMBERING THE HOGWART, CALLED RON'S EYE AND THEY BOTH GRINNED; SNAPE'S MOUTH THINNED AND HE PUSHED THE HAT TOWARD DUMBLEDORE, WHO SWAPPED IT FOR HIS WIZARD'S HAT AT ONCE.

"DIG IN!" HE ADVISED THE TABLE, BEAMING ABEAM.

AS HARRY WAS HELPING HIMSELF THE REAST PENTATHLES, THE DOORS OF THE GREAT HALL OPENED AGAIN. IT WAS PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY, GLIDING TOWARD THEM AS THOUGH ON WHEELS. SHE HAD PUT ON A GREEN SEQUINED DRESS IN HONOR OF THE OCCASION, MAKING HER LOOK MORE THAN EVER LIKE A GLITTERING, OVERSIZED DRAGONFLY.

"SIXTH, THIS IS A PLEASANT SURPRISE!" SAID DUMKLEDDERE, STANDING UP.
"I HAVE BEEN CRYSTAL GAZING, HEADMASTER," SAID PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY IN
HER MISTYEST, MIST PARALAY VOICE, "AND THE MY ASTERISMMENT, I SAW MYSELF
ABANDONING MY SELTARY BLINCK-HEEN AND CHEMING THE IHIN YELL. LIKE AM I THE
REPLISE THE PROMPTINGS OF FATE? I AT ONCE HASTENED FROM MY TOWER, AND I
DID REG YELL THE PEEGIVE MY LATENESS...."

"CERTAINLY, CERTAINLY," SAID DUMKLEDDERE, HIS EYES TWINKLING. "LET ME
DRAW YELL UP A CHAIR --"

AND HE DID INDEED DRAW A CHAIR IN MIDAIR WITH HIS WAND, WHICH REVEALED
FOR A FEW SECONDS BEFORE FALLING WITH A THUD BETWEEN PROFESSOR'S SNARE
AND MCGHINAGALL. PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY, HOWEVER, DID NOT SIT DOWN; HER

191

ENORMOUS EYES HAD BEEN REVIVING AROUND THE TABLE, AND SHE SLIDENLY LITTERED
A KIND OF SHOT SCREAM.

I DARE NOT, HEADMASTER! IF I IHIN THE TABLE, WE SHALL BE THIRTEEN!

NOTHING COULD BE MORE UNLIKELY! NEVER FORGET THAT WHEN THIRTEEN DINE
TOGETHER, THE FIRST TH RISE WILL BE THE FIRST TH DIE!"

"WE'LL RISK IT, SIXTH," SAID PROFESSOR MCGHINAGALL IMPATIENTLY, "DID SIT
DOWN, THE TURKEY'S GETTING STINKY CHILD."

PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY HESITATED, THEN LEANED HERSELF INTO THE EMPTY
CHAIR, EYES SHUT AND MOUTH CLENCHED TIGHT, AS THOUGH EXPECTING A
THUNDERBOLT TO HIT THE TABLE. PROFESSOR MCGHINAGALL POURED A LARGE SPOON
INTO THE NEAREST TURKEN.

"TRIP, SIXTH?"

PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY IGNORED HER, EYES OPEN AGAIN, SHE LEANED AROUND HER
MERE AND SAID, "BUT WHERE IS DEAR PROFESSOR LUPIN?"

"I'M AFRAID THE POOR FELLOW IS ILL AGAIN," SAID DUMKLEDDERE, INDICATING

THAT EVERYBODY SHOULD START SERVING THEMSELVES. "MOST UNFORTUNATE THAT IT SHOULD HAPPEN ON CHRISTMAS DAY."

"BUT SURELY YOU ALREADY KNEW THAT, SIR?" SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, HER EYEBROWS RAISED.

PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY GAVE PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL A VERY COLD LOOK.

"CERTAINLY I KNEW, MINERVA, 11 SHE SAID BRISKLY. "BUT HERE DOES NOT PARADE THE FACT THAT HERE IS ALL-DOMINATING, I FREQUENTLY ACT AS THOUGH I AM NOT POSSESSED OF THE INNER EYE, SEE AS NOT THE MAKE OTHERS NERVOUS.

"THAT EXPLAINS A GREAT DEAL," SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL TARTLY.

PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY'S VOICE SUDDENLY BECAME A GOOD DEAL LESS MISTY.

"IF YOU MUST KNOW, MINERVA, I HAVE SEEN THAT POOR PROFESSOR LUPIN WILL NOT BE WITH US FOR VERY LONG. HE SEEMS AWARE, HIMSELF, THAT HIS TIME IS SHORT. HE POSITIVELY FLED WHEN I OFFERED THE CRYSTAL GAZE FOR HIM --"

192

"IMAGINE THAT," SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL DRIPPLY.

I BELIEVE," SAID DUMBLEDOORE, IN A CHEERFUL BUT SLIGHTLY RAISED VOICE, WHICH PUT AN END TO THE PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL AND PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY'S CONVERSATION. "THAT PROFESSOR LUPIN IS IN AN IMMEDIATE DANGER, HOWEVER, YOU'VE MADE THE POINT FOR HIM AGAIN?"

"YES, HEADMASTER," SAID SNAPE. "W -- WHAT?" SAID HARRY, SCRAMBLING TO HIS FEET. "WHY?"

"IT WILL NEED TO BE CHECKED FOR INK," SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL. "HE CHURCH, I'M AN EXPERT, BUT I DARE SAY MADAM BEECH AND PROFESSOR FLITWICK WILL STRIP IT DOWN --"

"STRIP IT DOWN?" REPEATED SHE, AS THOUGH PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL WAS MAD.

"IT SHOULDN'T TAKE MORE THAN A FEW WEEKS," SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL.

"YOU WILL HAVE IT BACK IF WE ARE SURE IT IS INK-FREE."

"THERE'S NOTHING WRONG WITH IT!" SAID HARRY, HIS VEHICLE SHAKING SLIGHTLY.

"HONESTLY, PROFESSOR --"

"YOU CAN'T KNOW THAT, BETTER," SAID PROFESSOR MCGINNAGALL, ELITE KINDLY,

"NOT UNTIL YOU'VE SEEN IT, AT ANY RATE, AND I'M AFRAID THAT IS ALL IT

THE ELDESTHER UNTIL WE ARE CERTAIN THAT IT HAS NOT BEEN TAMPERED WITH. I

SHALL KEEP YOU INFORMED."

PROFESSOR MCGINNAGALL TURNED ON HER HEEL AND CARRIED THE FIREHUNT HELT OF

THE PORTRAIT FRAME, WHICH CLESED BEHIND HER. HARRY STOOD STARING AFTER

HER, THE TIN OF HIGH-FINISH POLISH STILL CLUTCHED IN HIS HANDS. THEN,

HOWEVER, REELDED ON HERMINE.

"WHAT DID YOU GET RUNNING THE MCGINNAGALL FOR?"

HERMINE THREW HER EYES ASIDE. SHE WAS STILL PINK IN THE FACE, BUT STOOD

UP AND FACED THEN DEFIANTLY.

"BECAUSE I THOUGHT -- AND PROFESSOR MCGINNAGALL AGREES WITH ME -- THAT

THAT BROTHER WAS PROBABLY SENT THE HARRY BY SIRILIS BLACK?"

198

CHAPTER TWELVE

THE PATRONS

HARRY KNEW THAT HERMINE HAD MEANT WELL, BUT THAT DIDN'T STOP HIM FROM

BEING ANGRY WITH HER. HE HAD BEEN THE OWNER OF THE BEST BROTHER IN THE

WORLD FOR A FEW SHORT YEARS, AND NOW, BECAUSE OF HER INTERFERENCE, HE

DIDN'T KNOW WHETHER HE WOULD EVER SEE IT AGAIN. HE WAS POSITIVE THAT

THERE WAS NOTHING WRONG WITH THE FIREHUNT NOW, BUT WHAT SORT OF STATE

WOULD IT BE IN IF IT HAD BEEN SUBJECTED THE ALL SORTS OF ANTI-TANK

TESTS?

THEN WAS FURIOUS WITH HERMINE THEN. AS FAR AS HE WAS CONCERNED, THE

STRIPPING-DOWN OF A BRAND-NEW FIREHUNT WAS NOTHING LESS THAN CRIMINAL

DAMAGE. HERMIONE, WHO REMAINED CONVINCED THAT SHE HAD ACTED FOR THE
BEST, STARTED AVOIDING THE COMMON ROOM. HARRY AND RON SUPPOSED SHE HAD
TAKEN REFUGE IN THE LIBRARY AND DIDN'T TRY TO PERSUADE HER TO COME BACK.
ALL IN ALL, THEY WERE GLAD WHEN THE REST OF THE SCHOOL RETURNED SHORTLY
AFTER NEW YEAR, AND GRYFFINDOR TOWER BECAME CROWDED AND NOISY AGAIN.
WHEN SHELLY HARRY MET HIM THE NIGHT BEFORE TERM STARTED.

"HAD A GOOD CHRISTMAS?" HE SAID, AND THEN, WITHOUT WAITING FOR AN
ANSWER, HE SAT DOWN, WHEELED HIS CHAIR, AND SAID, "I'VE BEEN DOING SOME
THINKING EVERY CHRISTMAS, HARRY, AFTER LAST MATCH, YOU KNOW. IF THE
DEMENTORS COME THE NEXT TIME... I MEAN... WE CAN'T AFFORD YOU THE --
WELL --"

WHEN RONNY HAD, LOOKING APOLOGETIC.

"I'M WORKING ON IT," SAID HARRY QUICKLY. "PROFESSOR SLIPIN SAID HE'D
TRAIN ME THE WAY OFF THE DEMENTORS, WE SHOULD BE STARTING THIS WEEK. HE
SAID HE'D HAVE TIME AFTER CHRISTMAS."

"AH," SAID WHEN, HIS EXPRESSION CLEARING. "WELL, IN THAT CASE -- I
REALLY DIDN'T WANT TO LOSE YOU AS SEEKER, HARRY, AND HAVE YOU ORDERED A
NEW KROMM YET?"

"NO," SAID HARRY.

199

"WHAT? YOU'D BETTER GET A MOVE ON, YOU KNOW -- YOU CAN'T RIDE THAT
SHOOTING STAR AGAINST RAVENCLAW!"

"HE GOT A FIRECRACKER FOR CHRISTMAS," SAID RON.

"A FIRECRACKER? NOT SERIOUSLY? A -- A REAL FIRECRACKER?"

"DIDN'T GET EXCITED, HARRY," SAID HARRY GLENNILY. "I HAVEN'T GOT IT
ANYMORE. IT WAS CONSUMED," AND HE EXPLAINED ALL ABOUT HOW THE
FIRECRACKER WAS NOW BEING CHECKED FOR HINDERS.

"INDEXED? HOW COULD IT BE INDEXED?"

"DIRT IS BLACK" HARRY SAID LEARILY. "HE'S SLIPPED THE TRIP AFTER ME. SHE
MCGONAGALL THINKS HE MIGHT HAVE SENT IT."

LAYING ASIDE THE INFORMATION THAT A FAMOUS MURDERER WAS AFTER HIS
SEWER, LUCAS SAID, "BUT BLACK COULDN'T HAVE KNOWN IT A FIREBOLT? HE'S BEEN
THE ALIVE THE WHILE COULDN'T HE THE LUCAS FOR HIM? HOW COULD HE JUST
WALK INTO HOGWARTS HOGWARTS SUPPLIES AND BUY A FIREBOLT?"

"I KNOW," SAID HARRY, "BUT MCGONAGALL STILL WANTS THE STRIP IT DOWN --"
LUCAS WENT PALE.

"I'LL GO AND TALK TO HER, HARRY," HE PROMISED. "I'LL MAKE HER SEE
REASON... A FIREBOLT... A REAL FIREBOLT, AND HER TEAM... SHE WANTS
GROWING THE WIN AS MUCH AS WE DO... I'LL MAKE HER SEE SENSE. A
FIREBOLT..."

CLASSES STARTED AGAIN THE NEXT DAY. THE LAST THING ANYONE FELT LIKE
DOING WAS SPENDING TWO HOURS IN THE GARDENS IN A RAIN JANUARY MORNING,
BUT HARRY HAD PROVIDED A FIREBOLT FULL OF SALAMANDERS FOR THEIR
ENTERTAINMENT, AND THEY SPENT AN UNUSUALLY GOOD LESSON COLLECTING DRY WOOD
AND LEAVES TO KEEP THE FIRE BLAZING WHILE THE FLAME-LOVING LIZARDS
STAMPERED UP AND DOWN THE CRUMBLING, WHITE-FEET LINES. THE FIRST
DIVINATION LESSON OF THE NEW TERM WAS MUCH LESS FUN; PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY
WAS NOW TEACHING THEM PALMISTRY, AND SHE HAD NO TIME IN INFORMING HARRY
THAT HE HAD THE SHORTEST LIFE LINE SHE HAD EVER SEEN.

125

IT WAS DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS THAT HARRY WAS BEEN THE GET THE;
AFTER HIS CONVERSATION WITH LUCAS, HE WANTED THE GET STARTED IN HIS
ANTI-DEMENTOR LESSONS AS SOON AS POSSIBLE.

"AH YES," SAID LUCAS, WHEN HARRY REMINDED HIM OF HIS PROMISE AT THE END

OF CLASS. "LET ME SEE... FELL ABOUT EIGHT O'CLOCK ON THURSDAY EVENING?
THE HISTORY OF MAGIC CLASSROOM SHOULD BE LARGE ENOUGH... I'LL HAVE THE
TEACH CAREFULLY ABOUT FELL WE'RE GOING TO DO THIS... WE CAN'T BRING A
REAL DEMENTOR INTO THE CASTLE TO PRACTICE ON..."

"STILL LOOKS ILL, DOESN'T HE?" SAID RON AS THEY WALKED DOWN THE
CORRIDOR, HEADING TO DINNER. "WHAT DO YOU THINK'S THE MATTER WITH HIM?"
THERE WAS A LOUD AND IMPATIENT "TUT" FROM BEHIND THEM. IT WAS HERMION,
WHEN HAD BEEN SITTING AT THE FEET OF A SLIT OF ARMOR, REPACKING HER BAG,
WHICH WAS SHE FULL OF BOOKS IT WOULDN'T CLOSE.

"AND WHAT ARE YOU TALKING AT HIS FEET?" SAID RON IRRITABLY.

"NOTHING," SAID HERMION IN A HEFTY VOICE, HEAVING HER BAG BACK OVER HER
SHOULDER.

"YES, YOU WERE," SAID RON. "I SAID I WONDER WHAT'S WRONG WITH LUPIN, AND
YOU --"

"WELL, ISN'T IT EVIDENT?" SAID HERMION, WITH A LOOK OF MADDENING
SUPERIORITY.

"IF YOU DIDN'T WANT TO TELL US, DON'T," SNAPPED RON.

"FINE," SAID HERMION HALIGHTLY, AND SHE MARCHED OFF.

"SHE DOESN'T KNOW," SAID RON, STARING RESENTFULLY AFTER HERMION. "SHE'S
JUST TRYING TO GET US TO TALK TO HER AGAIN."

AT EIGHT O'CLOCK ON THURSDAY EVENING, HARRY LEFT GRYFFINDOR TOWER FOR
THE HISTORY OF MAGIC CLASSROOM. IT WAS DARK AND EMPTY WHEN HE ARRIVED,
BUT HE LIT THE LAMPS WITH HIS HAND AND HAD WAITED ONLY FIVE MINUTES WHEN
PROFESSOR LUPIN TURNED UP, CARRYING A LARGE PACKING CASE, WHICH HE
HEAVED ONTO PROFESSOR KILN'S DESK.

178

"WHAT'S THAT?" SAID HARRY.

"ANOTHER KEGGART," SAID LUPIN, STRIPPING OFF HIS COAT. "I'VE BEEN CHECKING THE CASTLE EVER SINCE TUESDAY, AND VERY LIKELY, I FEELING THIS ONE WORKING INSIDE MR. FILCH'S FILING CABINET. IT'S THE NEAREST WE'LL GET TO A REAL DEMENTOR. THE KEGGART WILL TURN INTO A DEMENTOR WHEN HE SEES YEL, SHE WE'LL BE ABLE TO PRACTICE WITH HIM, I CAN STEER HIM IN MY OFFICE WHEN WE'RE NOT USING HIM; THERE'S A CLIPBOARD UNDER MY DESK HE'LL LIKE."

"HEY," SAID HARRY, TRYING TO SOUND AS THOUGH HE WASN'T APPREHENSIVE AT ALL AND MERELY GLAD THAT LUPIN HAD FEELING SUCH A GOOD SUBSTITUTE FOR A REAL DEMENTOR.

"SEE," PROFESSOR LUPIN HAD TAKEN HOLD HIS OWN HAND, AND INDICATED THAT HARRY SHOULD DO THE SAME. "THE SPELL I AM GOING TO TRY AND TEACH YEL IS HIGHLY ADVANCED MAGIC, HARRY -- WELL BEYOND ORDINARY WIZARDING LEVEL. IT IS CALLED THE PATRONUS CHARM."

"YEL DOES IT WHEN?" SAID HARRY NERVOUSLY.

"WELL, WHEN IT WORKS CORRECTLY, IT CREATES UP A PATRONUS," SAID LUPIN, "WHICH IS A KIND OF ANTI- DEMENTOR -- A GUARDIAN THAT ACTS AS A SHIELD BETWEEN YEL AND THE DEMENTOR."

HARRY HAD A SUDDEN VISION OF HIMSELF CRELCHING BEHIND A JAGGED-SIZED FIGURE HOLDING A LARGE CLUB. PROFESSOR LUPIN CONTINUED, "THE PATRONUS IS A KIND OF POSITIVE FORCE, A PROJECTION OF THE VERY THINGS THAT THE DEMENTOR FEELS WITHIN -- HOPE, HAPPINESS, THE DESIRE TO SURVIVE -- BUT IT CANNOT FEEL DESPAIR, AS REAL HUMANS CAN, SO THE DEMENTORS CAN'T HURT IT. BUT I MUST WARN YEL, HARRY, THAT THE CHARM MIGHT BE MORE ADVANCED FOR YEL. MANY QUALIFIED WIZARDS HAVE DIFFICULTY WITH IT."

"WHAT DOES A PATRONUS LOOK LIKE?" SAID HARRY CLERKLY.

"EACH ONE IS UNLIKE THE OTHER WIZARD WHO CREATES IT."

"AND HOW DO YEL CREATE IT?"

"WITH AN INCANTATION, WHICH WILL WORK ONLY IF YOU ARE CONCENTRATING, WITH ALL YOUR MIGHT, HEN A SINGLE, VERY HAPPY MEMORY."

HARRY CAST HIS MIND ABOUT FOR A HAPPY MEMORY, CERTAINLY, NOTHING THAT HAD HAPPENED TO HIM AT THE DURSLEYS' WAS GOING TO DO, FINALLY, HE SETTLED ON THE MOMENT WHEN HE HAD FIRST RIDDEN A BROOMSTICK.

"RIGHT," HE SAID, TRYING THE RECALL AS EXACTLY AS POSSIBLE THE WONDERFUL, SHARING SENSATION OF HIS STEPMOTHER.

"THE INCANTATION IS THIS --" LUPIN CLEARED HIS THROAT, "EXPECTE PATRONUM!"

"EXPECTE PATRONUM," HARRY REPEATED UNDER HIS BREATH, "EXPECTE PATRONUM."

"CONCENTRATING HARD ON YOUR HAPPY MEMORY?"

"YES -- YES --" SAID HARRY, BLINDLY FEELING HIS TEEGLIGHTS BACK TO THAT FIRST BROOM RIDE, "EXPECTE PATRONUM -- YES, PATRONUM -- SHINY -- EXPECTE PATRONUM, EXPECTE PATRONUM"

SOMETHING WHISPERED SUDDENLY OUT OF THE END OF HIS WAND, IT SOUNDED LIKE A WIND OF SILVERY GAS.

"DID YOU SEE THAT?" SAID HARRY EXCITEDLY, "SOMETHING HAPPENED!"

"VERY GOOD," SAID LUPIN, SMILING. "RIGHT, THEN -- READY TO TRY IT ON A BROOM?"

"YES," HARRY SAID, GRIPPING HIS WAND VERY TIGHTLY, AND MOVING INTO THE MIDDLE OF THE DESERTED CLASSROOM. HE TRIED TO KEEP HIS MIND ON FLYING, BUT SOMETHING ELSE KEPT INTERLUING... AND SECONDLY, HE MIGHT HEAR HIS MOTHER AGAIN... BUT HE SHOULDN'T THINK THAT, HE HADN'T HEARD HER AGAIN, AND HE DIDN'T WANT HER... HE DID HE?

LUPIN GRASPED THE LID OF THE PACKING CASE AND PULLED.

A BROOMSTICK ROSE SILENTLY FROM THE CASE, ITS FINISHED FACE TURNED TOWARD

HARRY, HEN GLISTENING, STARKED HAND GRIPPING ITS CHEAD. THE LAMPS ARELIND

198

THE CLASSREEM FLICKERED AND WENT BLIT. THE DEMENTER STEPPED FROM THE REEK
AND STARTED THE SLEEP SILENTLY TELLARD HARRY, DRAWING A DEEP, RATTLING
BREATH. A WAVE OF PIERCING CHILD BRECKE OVER HIM --

"EXPECTE PATRENLIN!" HARRY YELLED, "EXPECTE PATRENLIN! EXPECTE --"

BUT THE CLASSREEM AND THE DEMENTER WERE DISSELYING... HARRY WAS FAILING
AGAIN TEREHLIGH TEREK WHITE REG, AND HIS MEET-ER'S VEHICLE WAS BEHIDER THAN
EVER, EREHING INSIDE HIS HEAD -- "NEET HARRY! NEET HARRY! PLEASE -- I'LL
DEH ANYTHING!"

"STAND ASIDE. STAND ASIDE, GIRL!"

"HARRY!"

HARRY IERKED BACK THE LIFE, HE WAS LYING FLAT HEN HIS BACK HEN THE FLEHER,
THE CLASSREEM LAMPS WERE ALIGHT AGAIN, HE DIDN'T HAVE THE ASK WHAT HAD
HAPPENED.

"SHRRY," HE MUITTERED, SITTING UP AND FEELING CHILD SWEAT TRICKLING DEELIN
BEHIND HIS GLASSES.

"ARE YELI ALL RIGHT?" SAID BLUPIN.

"YES..." HARRY PULLED HIMSELF UP HEN HENK OF THE DESKS AND LEANED AGAINST
IT.

"HERE --" BLUPIN HANDED HIM A CHECHILATE FREEG. "EAT THIS BEATRE WE TRY
AGAIN. I DIDN'T EXPECT YELI THE DEH IT YELI'S FIRST TIME; IN FACT, I WOULD
HAVE BEEN ASHELINED IF YELI HAD."

"IT'S GETTING WERSE," HARRY MUITTERED, BITING OFF THE FREEG'S HEAD. "I
CHILD HEAR HER BEHIDER THAN TIME -- AND HIM -- VHEDEMENT
BLUPIN WHEKED PALER THAN LILIAL.

"HARRY, IF YELI DEHN'T WANT THE CHESTINLIE, I WILL MEHE THAN LINDERSTAND --"

"I SEE!" SAID HARRY FIERCELY, STUFFING THE REST OF THE CHOCOLATE FRING INTO HIS MOUTH. "I'VE GOTTEN THE WHAT IF THE DEMENTORS TURN UP AT OUR MATCH

177

AGAINST RAVENCLAW? I CAN'T AFFORD THE FALL OFF AGAIN. IF WE LOSE THIS GAME WE'VE LOST THE HOLIDITCH CUP!"

"ALL RIGHT THEN..." SAID LUPIN. "YOU MIGHT WANT THE SELECT 'BETTER MEMORY, A HAPPY MEMORY, I MEAN, THE CONCENTRATE ETC..." THAT ONE DOESN'T SEEM TO HAVE BEEN STRONG ENOUGH..."

HARRY THOUGHT HARD AND DECIDED HIS FEELINGS WHEN GRYFFINDOR HAD WON THE HOUSE CHAMPIONSHIP LAST YEAR HAD DEFINITELY QUALIFIED AS VERY HAPPY. HE GRIPPED HIS WAND TIGHTLY AGAIN AND TOOK UP HIS POSITION IN THE MIDDLE OF THE CLASSROOM.

"READY?" SAID LUPIN, GRIPPING THE BOX LID.

"READY," SAID HARRY, TRYING HARD TO FILL HIS HEAD WITH HAPPY THOUGHTS ABOUT GRYFFINDOR WINNING, AND NOT DARK THOUGHTS ABOUT WHAT WAS GOING TO

HAPPEN WHEN THE BOX OPENED.

"GO!" SAID LUPIN, PULLING OFF THE LID. THE ROOM WENT ICY COLD AND DARK ENCE MORE. THE DEMENTOR GLIDED FORWARD, DRAWING ITS BREATH; ONE WHITING HAND WAS EXTENDING TOWARD HARRY -

"EXPECTO PATRONUM!" HARRY YELLED. "EXPECTO PATRONUM! EXPECTO PAT --"

WHITE AND HESITATED HIS SENSES... BIG, BURNING SHAPES WERE MOVING AROUND HIM... THEN CAME A NEW VOICE, A MAN'S VOICE, SHOUTING, PANICKING --

"LILY, TAKE HARRY AND GO! IT'S HIM! GO! RUN! I'LL HOLD HIM OFF --"

THE SHEDS OF SOMETHING STUMBLING FROM A ROOM -- A OTHER CLUSTING OPEN -- A CLOUD OF HIGH-PITCHED LAUGHTER --

"HARRY! HARRY... WAKE UP..."

LUPIN WAS TAPPING HARRY HARD ON THE FACE. THIS TIME IT WAS A MINUTE

BEFORE HARRY UNDERSTOOD WHY HE WAS LYING IN A DUSTY CLASSROOM FLOOR.
"I HEARD MY DAD," HARRY MUMBLED. "THAT'S THE FIRST TIME I'VE EVER HEARD
HIM -- HE TRIED TO TAKE ME UNDERWORTH HIMSELF, TO GIVE MY MOM TIME TO RUN
FOR IT...."

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HARRY SUDDENLY REALIZED THAT THERE WERE TEARS IN HIS FACE MINGLING WITH  
THE SWEAT. HE BENT HIS FACE AS LOW AS POSSIBLE, WIPING THEM OFF IN HIS  
POCKETS, PRETENDING TO SEE HIS STEELBACK, SEE THAT KLIPIN WOULDN'T SEE.

"WELL HEARD JAMES?" SAID KLIPIN IN A STRANGE VOICE.

"Yeah..." FACE DRY, HARRY WINKED LIP. "Well -- WELL DIDN'T KNOW MY DAD, DID  
WELL?"

"I -- I DID, AS A MATTER OF FACT," SAID KLIPIN. "WE WERE FRIENDS AT  
HOGWARTS. LISTEN, HARRY -- PERHAPS WE SHOULD LEAVE IT HERE FOR TONIGHT.  
THIS CHARM IS RIDICULOUSLY ADVANCED... I SHOULDN'T HAVE SUGGESTED  
PUTTING WELL THROUGH THIS...."

"Nah?" SAID HARRY. HE GOT UP AGAIN. "I'LL HAVE ONE MORE GEE! I'M NOT  
THINKING OF HAPPY ENOUGH THINGS, THAT'S WHAT IT IS... LONGER..."  
HE RACKED HIS BRAINS. A REALLY, REALLY HAPPY MEMORY... ONE THAT HE COULD  
TURN INTO A GOOD, STRONG PATRONUS...

THE MOMENT WHEN HE'D FIRST FELT THAT HE WAS A WIZARD, AND WOULD BE  
LEAVING THE DURSLEYS FOR HOGWARTS! IF THAT WASN'T A HAPPY MEMORY, HE  
DIDN'T KNOW WHAT WAS... CONCENTRATING VERY HARD IN HIS HEAD HE HAD FELT WHEN  
HE'D REALIZED HE'D BE LEAVING PRIVET DRIVE, HARRY GOT ON HIS FEET AND  
FACED THE PACKING CASE BEHIND HIM.

"Ready?" SAID KLIPIN, WHO WINKED AS THOUGH HE WERE DOING THIS AGAINST HIS  
BETTER JUDGMENT. "CONCENTRATING HARD? ALL RIGHT -- GEE!"

HE PULLED OFF THE LID OF THE CASE FOR THE THIRD TIME, AND THE DEMENTOR

RESE FELT HP IT; THE REHEM FELL CHLD AND DARK

"EXPECTEE PATREHLLM;" HARRY BELLEWD, "EXPECTEE PATREHLLM;  
EXPECTEE PATREHLLM;

•

THE SCREAMING INSIDE HARRY'S HEAD HAD STARTED AGAIN -- EXCEPT THIS TIME,  
IT SEEMED AS THOUGH IT WERE COMING FROM A BADLY TUNED RADIO -- SHUTTER  
AND WHISPER AND SHUTTER AGAIN -- AND HE COULD STILL SEE THE DEMENTER -- IT

WAS

HAD HALTED -- AND THEN A FLICK, SILVER SHADDED CAME BURSTING OUT OF THE  
END OF HARRY'S WAND, THE FEVER BETWEEN HIM AND THE DEMENTER, AND THOUGH  
HARRY'S LEGS FELT LIKE WATER, HE WAS STILL ON HIS FEET -- THOUGH FOR FEEL  
MUCH LONGER, HE WASN'T SURE --

"RIDICULOUS!" REARED LUPIN, SPRINGING FORWARD,

THERE WAS A LUD CRACK, AND HARRY'S CHILLY PATREHLLS VANISHED ALONG WITH  
THE DEMENTER; HE SANK INTO A CHAIR, FEELING AS EXHAUSTED AS IF HE'D JUST  
RUN A MILE, AND FELT HIS LEGS SHAKING. OUT OF THE CORNER OF HIS EYE, HE  
SAW PROFESSOR LUPIN PULLING THE KEGGART BACK INTO THE PACKING CASE WITH  
HIS WAND; IT HAD TURNED INTO A SILVERY HIRE AGAIN.

"EXCELLENT!" LUPIN SAID, STRIDING OVER THE WHERE HARRY SAT, "EXCELLENT,  
HARRY! THAT WAS DEFINITELY A START!"

"CAN WE HAVE ANOTHER ONE? JUST ONE MORE ONE?"

"NOT NOW," SAID LUPIN FIRMLY, "YOU'VE HAD ENOUGH FOR ONE NIGHT, HERE --"

HE HANDED HARRY A LARGE BAR OF HONEYBLOOM'S BEST CHOCOLATE.

"AT THE LEFT, MR MADAM PHEMPREY WILL BE AFTER MY KNEED, SAME TIME NEXT  
WEEK?"

"THANK," SAID HARRY, HE TOOK A BITE OF THE CHOCOLATE AND WATCHED LUPIN

EXTINGUISHING THE LAMPS THAT HAD REKINDLED WITH THE DISAPPEARANCE OF THE  
DEMENTHOR. A TWELIGHT HAD JUST REKINDLED THE FIRE.

"PROFESSOR KLIPIN?" HE SAID. "IF YOU KNEW MY DAD, YOU MUST'VE KNOWN  
STIRLIS BLACK AS WELL."

KLIPIN TURNED VERY QUICKLY.

"WHAT GIVES YOU THAT IDEA?" HE SAID SHARPLY.

"NOTHING -- I MEAN, I JUST KNEW THEY WERE FRIENDS AT HOGWARTS THEN..."

KLIPIN'S FACE RELAXED.

END

"YES, I KNEW HIM," HE SAID SHORTLY. "BUT I TWELIGHT I DID. YOU'D BETTER BE  
HURRY, HARRY, IT'S GETTING LATE."

HARRY LEFT THE CLASSROOM, WALKING ALONG THE CORRIDOR AND AROUND A  
CORNER, THEN HEARD A BELLING BEHIND A SLIT OF ARCHER AND SANDY DEER IN ITS  
PLINTE. HE FINISHED HIS CHOCOLATE, WISHING HE HADN'T MENTIONED BLACK, AS  
KLIPIN WAS HEAVILY NOT BEEN IN THE SUBJECT. THEN HARRY'S TWELIGHTS  
WANDERED BACK TO HIS MOTHER AND FATHER...

HE FELT DRAINED AND STRANGELY EMPTY, EVEN THOUGH HE WAS STILL IN  
CHOCOLATE. TERRIBLE THOUGH IT WAS TO HEAR HIS PARENTS' LAST MOMENTS  
REPLAYED INSIDE HIS HEAD, THESE WERE THE ONLY TIMES HARRY HAD HEARD  
THEIR VOICES SINCE HE WAS A VERY SMALL CHILD. BUT HE'D NEVER BE ABLE TO  
PRODUCE A PROPER PATRONUS IF HE HADN'T WANTED TO HEAR HIS PARENTS  
AGAIN...

"THEY'RE DEAD," HE TOLD HIMSELF STERNLY. "THEY'RE DEAD AND LISTENING THE  
ECHOES OF THEM WON'T BRING THEM BACK. YOU'D BETTER GET A GRIP ON  
YOURSELF IF YOU WANT THAT FLIGHTY CLIP."

HE STOOD UP, CRAMMED THE LAST BIT OF CHOCOLATE INTO HIS MOUTH, AND  
HEADED BACK TO GRYPFINDER TOWER.

RAVENCLAW PLAYED SLYTHERIN A WEEK AFTER THE START OF TERM. SLYTHERIN WON, THOUGH NARROWLY. ACCORDING TO WHED, THIS WAS GOOD NEWS FOR GRYPFINDER, WHO WOULD TAKE SECOND PLACE IF THEY BEAT RAVENCLAW THIS YEAR. THEREFORE INCREASED THE NUMBER OF TEAM PRACTICES THE FIVE A WEEK. THIS MEANT THAT WITH LUPIN'S ANTI-DEMENTOR CLASSES, WHICH IN THEMSELVES WERE MORE DRAINING THAN SIX FLUIDITCH PRACTICES, HARRY HAD JUST ONE NIGHT A WEEK TO DO ALL HIS HOMEWORK. EVEN SO, HE WAS SHOWING THE STRAIN NEARLY AS MUCH AS HERMIONE, WHOSE INTENSE WORKLOAD FINALLY SEEMED TO BE GETTING TO HER. EVERY NIGHT, WITHOUT FAIL, HERMIONE WAS TO BE SEEN IN A CORNER OF THE COMMON ROOM, SEVERAL TABLES SPREAD WITH BOOKS, ARITHMAGIC CHARTS, RUNE DICTIONARIES, DIAGRAMS OF MUGGLES LIFTING HEAVY BRICKS, AND FILE AFTER FILE OF EXTENSIVE NOTES. SHE RARELY SPOKE TO ANYBODY AND SNAPPED WHEN SHE WAS INTERRUPTED.

"WHAT'S SHE DOING IT?" RON MUTTERED TO HARRY ONE EVENING AS HARRY SAT FINISHING A NASTY ESSAY ON UNDETECTABLE POISONS FOR SNAPE. HARRY WHEEDED UP, HERMIONE WAS RARELY VISIBLE BEHIND A TETHERING PILE OF BOOKS.

THE

"DOING WHAT?"

"GETTING TO ALL HER CLASSES?" RON SAID. "I HEARD HER TALKING TO PROFESSOR VECTER, THAT ARITHMAGIC WITCH, THIS MORNING. THEY WERE CHING ON ABOUT YESTERDAY'S LESSON, BUT HERMIONE CAN'T 'VE BEEN THERE, BECAUSE SHE WAS WITH LIS IN CARE OF MAGICAL CREATURES. AND ERNIE McMILLAN TOLD ME SHE'S NEVER MISSED A MUGGLE STUDIES CLASS, BUT HALF OF THEM ARE AT THE SAME TIME AS DIVINATION, AND SHE'S NEVER MISSED ONE OF THEM EITHER."

HARRY DIDN'T HAVE TIME TO PATHETIC THE MYSTERY OF HERMIONE'S IMPOSSIBLE SCHEDULE AT THE MOMENT; HE REALLY NEEDED TO GET ON WITH SNAPE'S ESSAY.

TWO SECONDS LATER, HOWEVER, HE WAS INTERRUPTED AGAIN, THIS TIME BY WHED.

"BAD NEWS, HARRY. I'VE JUST BEEN TO SEE PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL ABOUT THE FIRECRACK. SHE -- ER -- GAVE A BIT SHORTLY WITH ME. TOLD ME I'D GIVE MY PRIORITIES WRONG. SEEMED TO THINK I CARED MORE ABOUT WINNING THE CUP THAN I DID ABOUT STAYING ALIVE. I JUST REALISE I TOLD HER I DIDN'T CARE IF IT THREW YOU OFF, AS LONG AS YOU CAUGHT THE SNITCH FIRST." WOOD SHOOK HIS HEAD IN DISBELIEF. "HONESTLY, THE WAY SHE WAS YELLING AT ME... YOU'D THINK I'D SAID SOMETHING TERRIBLE... THEN I ASKED HER HOW MUCH LONGER SHE WAS GOING TO KEEP IT. HE SCOWLED UP HIS FACE AND IMITATED PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL'S SEVERE VOICE. 'AS LONG AS NECESSARY, WOOD'... I RECKON IT'S TIME YOU ORDERED A NEW CRICKET, HARRY. THERE'S AN ORDER FORM AT THE BACK OF WHICH CRICKET... YOU COULD GET A NIKELI TEN THOUSAND AND FIVE, LIKE MALFOY'S GIFT."

"I'M NOT BUYING ANYTHING MALFOY THINKS IS GOOD," SAID HARRY FLATLY. JANUARY FADED IMPERCEPTIBLY INTO FEBRUARY, WITH NO CHANGE IN THE BITTERLY COLD WEATHER. THE MATCH AGAINST RAVENCLAW WAS DRAWING NEARER AND NEARER, BUT HARRY STILL HADN'T ORDERED A NEW CRICKET. HE WAS NOW ASKING PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL FOR NEWS OF THE FIRECRACK AFTER EVERY TRANSFIGURATION LESSON, REMAINING HOPEFULLY AT HIS SHOULDERS, DETERMINED

BLUSHING PAST WITH HER FACE AVERTED.

"NO, BETTER, YOU CAN'T HAVE IT BACK YET," PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL TOLD HIM THE TWELFTH TIME THIS HAPPENED, BECAUSE HE'D EVEN OPENED HIS MOUTH. "WE'VE CHECKED OUR BEST OF THE USUAL CLASSES, BUT PROFESSOR FLITWICK BELIEVES THE CRICKET MIGHT BE CARRYING A FLAMING FLAG. I SHALL TELL YOU

2004

BECAUSE WE'VE FINISHED CHECKING IT. NOW, PLEASE STOP BAGGERING ME."

THE MARCH MATTERS EVEN WORSE, HARRY'S ANTI-DEMENTOR LESSONS WERE NOT GOING



NEARLY AS WELL AS HE HAD HELPED. SEVERAL SESSIONS ON, HE WAS ABLE TO  
PRODUCE AN INDISTINCT, SILVERY SHADOW EVERY TIME THE KEEGART-DEMENTHOR  
APPROACHED HIM, BUT HIS PATRONUS WAS THEN FORCED TO DRIVE THE DEMENTHOR  
AWAY. ALL IT DID WAS HEAVE, LIKE A SEMITRANSPARENT CURTAIN, DRAINING HARRY  
OF ENERGY AS HE TRIED TO KEEP IT THERE. HARRY FELT ANGRY WITH HIMSELF,  
GUILTILY ABOUT HIS SECRET DESIRE TO HEAR HIS PARENTS' VOICES AGAIN.

"YOU'RE EXPECTING THEM MUCH OF YOURSELF," SAID PROFESSOR KLIPIN, STERNLY  
IN THEIR FOURTH WEEK OF PRACTICE. "FOR A THIRTEEN-YEAR-OLD WIZARD, EVEN  
AN INDISTINCT PATRONUS IS A HUGE ACHIEVEMENT. YOU AREN'T PASSING BUT  
ANYMORE, ARE YOU?"

"I TRIED TO GET A PATRONUS BUT I -- I CAN'T GET THE DEMENTHORS OUT OF MY HEADS,"  
SAID HARRY DISPIRITEDLY. "MAKE THEM DISAPPEAR --"

"THE TRUE PATRONUS DOES DO THAT," SAID KLIPIN. "BUT YOU'VE ACHIEVED A  
GREAT DEAL IN A VERY SHORT SPACE OF TIME. IF THE DEMENTHORS PUT IN AN  
APPEARANCE AT YOUR NEXT HOLIDITCH MATCH, YOU WILL BE ABLE TO KEEP THEM  
AT BAY LONG ENOUGH TO GET BACK TO THE GROUND."

"YOU SAID IT'S HARDER IF THERE ARE LOTS OF THEM," SAID HARRY.

"I HAVE COMPLETE CONFIDENCE IN YOU," SAID KLIPIN, SMILING. "HERE --  
YOU'VE EARNED A DRINK - SOMETHING FROM THE THREE BROOMSTICKS. YOU WON'T  
HAVE TRIED IT BEFORE --"

HE PULLED TWO KITTLES OUT OF HIS BRIECASE.

"BUTTERBEER?" SAID HARRY, WITHOUT THINKING. "YES, I LIKE THAT STUFF."

KLIPIN RAISED AN EYEBROW.

"HEH - JOHN AND HERMIONE BROUGHT ME SOME BACK FROM HOGSMEAD," HARRY LIED  
HEEDLESSLY.

"I SEE," SAID KLIPIN, THOUGH HE STILL LOOKED SLIGHTLY SUSPICIOUS. "WELL --  
LET'S DRINK TO A GRYPFINDER VICTORY AGAINST RAVENCLAW! NOT THAT I'M

THE

SLIPPED THE TAPE SIDES, AS A TEACHER... " HE ADDED HASTILY

THEY DROVE THE CLITTERER IN SILENCE, UNTIL HARRY VEHICLED SOMETHING HE'D BEEN WONDERING FOR A WHILE.

"WHAT'S UNDER A DEMENTER'S FINGER?"

PROFESSOR KLIPIN WINKED HIS EYELID THOUGHTFULLY.

"HMM... WELL, THE ONLY PEOPLE WHO REALLY KNOW ARE IN A CONDITION THEY TELL US. YOU SEE, THE DEMENTER KNOWS ITS FINGER ONLY THE LIKE ITS LAST AND WORST WEAPON."

"WHAT'S THAT?"

"THEY CALL IT THE DEMENTER'S KISS," SAID KLIPIN, WITH A SLIGHTLY TWISTED SMILE. "IT'S WHAT DEMENTERS DO THE THING THEY WISH THE DESTROY LITERALLY. I SUPPOSE THERE MUST BE SOME KIND OF MENTAL UNDER THERE, BECAUSE THEY CLAMP THEIR JAWS UPON THE MENTAL OF THE VICTIM AND -- AND SLICK OUT HIS SKIN."

HARRY ACCIDENTALLY SPAT OUT A BIT OF CLITTERER.

"WHAT -- THEY KILL --?"

"HEY NO," SAID KLIPIN, "MUCH WORSE THAN THAT, YOU CAN EXIST WITHOUT YOUR SKIN, YOU KNOW, AS LONG AS YOUR BRAIN AND HEART ARE STILL WORKING, BUT YOU'LL HAVE NO SENSE OF SELF ANYMORE, NO MEMORY, NO .. ANYTHING.

THERE'S NO CHANCE AT ALL OF RECOVERY, YOU'LL JUST EXIST, AS AN EMPTY SHELL, AND YOUR SKIN IS GONE FOREVER... BEST."

KLIPIN DROVE A LITTLE MORE CLITTERER, THEN SAID, "IT'S THE FACT THAT AWAITS SIRILIS BLACK. IT WAS IN THE DAILY PROPHET THIS MORNING. THE MINISTRY HAVE GIVEN THE DEMENTERS PERMISSION TO PERFORM IT IF THEY FIND HIM."

HARRY SAT STUNNED FOR A MOMENT AT THE IDEA OF SOMEONE HAVING THEIR SKIN SLICKED OUT THROUGH THEIR MENTAL, BUT THEN HE THOUGHT OF BLACK.

"HE DESERVES IT," HE SAID SUDDENLY.

2008

"YOU THINK SHE?" SAID LUPIN LIGHTLY. "DID YOU REALLY THINK ANYONE DESERVES THAT?"

"YES," SAID HARRY DEFIANTLY. "HER... AND SOME THINGS..."

HE WOULD HAVE LIKED TO HAVE TOLD LUPIN ABOUT THE CONVERSATION HE'D OVERHEARD ABOUT BLACK IN THE THREE BROOMSTICKS, ABOUT BLACK BETRAYING HIS MOTHER AND FATHER, BUT IT WOULD HAVE INVOLVED REVEALING THAT HE'D GONE TO THE HOGSMOOR WITHOUT PERMISSION, AND HE KNEW LUPIN WOULDN'T BE VERY

IMPRESSED BY THAT. SO HE FINISHED HIS CLATTERBOX, THANKED LUPIN, AND LEFT THE HISTORY OF MAGIC CLASSROOM.

HARRY HAD WISHED THAT HE HADN'T ASKED WHAT WAS UNDER A DEMENTOR'S MIND, THE ANSWER HAD BEEN SO TERRIBLE, AND HE WAS SO LEFT IN UNPLEASANT THOUGHTS OF WHAT IT WOULD FEEL LIKE TO HAVE YOUR SELF SLICKED OUT OF YOU THAT HE WALKED HEADLONG INTO PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL HALFWAY UP THE STAIRS. "DIDN'T YOU SEE WHERE YOU'RE GOING, POTTER?"

"SRRRY, PROFESSOR --"

"I'VE JUST BEEN LOOKING FOR YOU IN THE GRYFFINDOR COMMON ROOM. WELL, HERE IT IS, WE'VE DONE EVERYTHING WE COULD THINK OF, AND THERE DOESN'T SEEM TO BE ANYTHING WRONG WITH IT AT ALL. YOU'VE GOT A VERY GOOD FRIEND SOMEWHERE, POTTER..."

HARRY'S JAW DROPPED. SHE WAS HOLDING OUT HIS FIREBOLT, AND IT LOOKED AS MAGNIFICENT AS EVER.

"I CAN HAVE IT BACK?" HARRY SAID LEADLY. "SERIOUSLY?"

"SERIOUSLY," SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, AND SHE WAS ACTUALLY SMILING. "I DARE SAY YOU'LL NEED TO GET THE FEEL OF IT BEFORE SATURDAY'S MATCH, WON'T YOU? AND POTTER -- DID TRY AND WIN, WON'T YOU? HER WE'LL BE OUT OF THE RUNNING FOR THE EIGHTH YEAR, IN A REEL, AS PROFESSOR SNAPE WAS KIND ENOUGH TO REMIND ME ONLY LAST NIGHT..."

SPEECHLESS, HARRY CARRIED THE FIREWALK BACK UPSTAIRS TOWARD GRYFFINDOR TOWER. AS HE TURNED A CORNER, HE SAW RON DASHING TOWARD HIM, GRINNING FROM EAR TO EAR.

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"SHE GAVE IT THE VERY EXCELLENT! LISTEN, CAN I STILL HAVE A CHANCE IT? THE VERY VERY?"

"YES!... ANYTHING," SAID HARRY, HIS HEART LIGHTER THAN IT HAD BEEN IN A MONTH. "VERY MUCH WHAT -- WE SHOULD MAKE UP WITH HERMIONE... SHE WAS ONLY TRYING TO HELP..."

"YES! ALL RIGHT," SAID RON. "SHE'S IN THE CHAMBER ROOM WITH HERMIONE, AND A CHANGE --"

THEY TURNED INTO THE CORRIDOR THE GRYFFINDOR TOWER AND SAW NEVILLE LONGSIGHT, PLEADING WITH SIR CADOGAN, WHO SEEMED TO BE REFUSING HIM ENTRANCE.

"I WROTE THEM DOWN!" NEVILLE WAS SAYING TEARFULLY. "BUT I MUST'VE DROPPED THEM SOMEWHERE!"

"A LIKELY TALE!" REPLIED SIR CADOGAN, THEN, SPOTTING HARRY AND RON: "GOOD EVEN, MY FINE YOUNG MEN! COME CLAP THIS WREN IN IRONS. HE IS TRYING TO FORCE ENTRY TO THE CHAMBERS WITHIN!"

"HE'S SHUT UP," SAID RON AS HE AND HARRY DREW LEVEL WITH NEVILLE.

"I'VE LOST THE PASSWORDS!" NEVILLE TOLD THEM MISERABLY. "I MADE HIM TELL ME WHAT PASSWORDS HE WAS GIVING THE LATE THIS WEEK, BECAUSE HE KEEPS CHANGING THEM, AND NOW I DON'T KNOW WHAT I'VE DONE WITH THEM!"

"HOLD ON," SAID HARRY TO SIR CADOGAN, WHO LOOKED EXTREMELY DISAPPOINTED AND RELUCTANTLY SLINGING AROUND THE LET THEM INTO THE CHAMBER ROOM. THERE WAS A SILENT, EXCITED MURMUR AS EVERY HEAD TURNED AND THE NEXT MOMENT, HARRY WAS SURROUNDED BY PEOPLE EXCLAIMING OVER HIS

FIRECRACK.

"WHERE'D YOU GET IT, HARRY?"

"WILL YOU LET ME HAVE A CHANCE? I HAVE YOU RIDDEN IT YET, HARRY?"

"RAVENCLAW'LL HAVE NO CHANCE, THEY'RE ALL IN CLEANSWEEP SEVENS!"

XXX

"CAN I JUST HOLD IT, HARRY?"

AFTER TEN MINUTES HER SEE, DURING WHICH THE FIRECRACK WAS PASSED AROUND AND ADMIRED FROM EVERY ANGLE, THE CROWD DISPERSED AND HARRY AND RHN HAD A CLEAR VIEW OF HERMIONE. THE ONLY PERSON WHO HADN'T GLANCED OVER THE THEM, SENT OVER HER SHOULDERS AND CAREFULLY AVOIDING THEIR EYES, HARRY AND RHN APPROACHED HER TABLE AND AT LAST, SHE NODDED LIP.

"I GET IT BACK," SAID HARRY, GRINNING AT HER AND HOLDING LIP THE FIRECRACK.

"SEE, HERMIONE? THERE WASN'T ANYTHING WRONG WITH IT!" SAID RHN.

"WELL -- THERE MIGHT HAVE BEEN!" SAID HERMIONE. "I MEAN, AT LEAST YOU KNOW NOW THAT IT'S SAFE!"

"YES, I SUPPOSE SEE," SAID HARRY. "ID BETTER PUT IT UPSTAIRS."

"I'LL TAKE IT!" SAID RHN EAGERLY. "I'VE GOT TO GIVE SLACKERS HIS RAT THINK."

HE THREW THE FIRECRACK AND, HOLDING IT AS IF IT WERE MADE OF GLASS, CARRIED IT AWAY LIP THE KEYS' STAIRCASE.

"CAN I SIT DOWN, THEN?" HARRY ASKED HERMIONE.

"I SUPPOSE SEE," SAID HERMIONE, MOVING A GREAT STACK OF PARCHMENT OFF A CHAIR.

HARRY NODDED AROUND AT THE CLUTTERED TABLE, AT THE LONG ARITHMETIC ESSAY IN WHICH THE INK WAS STILL GLISTENING, AT THE EVEN LONGER MUSCLE STUDIES ESSAY ("EXPLAIN WHY MUSCLES NEED ELECTRICITY" AND AT THE LONG

TRANSLATION HERMINE WAS BEH PERRING HER.

"THEY ARE BEH GETTING THROUGH ALL THIS STUFF?" HARRY ASKED HER.

"EH, WELL -- BEH DONE -- WORKING HARD," SAID HERMINE, CHESE-LIP. HARRY  
SAW THAT SHE LOOKED ALMOST AS TIRED AS LIPIN.

"WHY DON'T BEH JUST DROP A CHUPLE OF SLICKETS?" HARRY ASKED, WATCHING

207

HER LISTING BEHDS AS SHE SEARCHED FOR HER PLINE DICTIONARY.

"I COULDN'T BEH THAT!" SAID HERMINE, LOOKING SCANDALIZED.

"ARITHMANY BEHDS TERRIBLE," SAID HARRY, PICKING UP A VERY  
COMPLICATED-LOOKING NUMBER CHART.

"EH NH, IT'S WONDERFUL!" SAID HERMINE EARNESTLY. "IT'S MY FAVORITE  
SLICKET! IT'S --"

BUT EXACTLY WHAT WAS WONDERFUL ABOUT ARITHMANY, HARRY NEVER FELT.

AT THAT PRECISE MOMENT, A STRANGLER BEH CAME DOWN THE BEH'S

STAIRCASE. THE BEHLE CHIMPEN BEH BEH SILENT, STARING, PETRIFIED, AT THE  
ENTRANCE. THEN CAME FLURRIED FEETSTEPS, GRINNING BEHDER AND BEHDER -- AND  
THEN BEH CAME LEAPING INTO THE VIEW, DRAGGING WITH HIM A REDSHEET.

"BEH!" HE BELLEDED, STRIDING OVER THE HERMINE'S TABLE.

"BEH!" HE YELLED, SHAKING THE SHEETS IN HER FACE.

"BEH, WHAT --?"

"STARRERS! BEH! STARRERS!"

HERMINE WAS LEANING AWAY FROM BEH, LOOKING LITTERLY BEMILDERED. HARRY  
LOOKED DOWN AT THE SHEET BEH WAS HOLDING. THERE WAS SOMETHING RED IN IT.  
SOMETHING THAT LOOKED HORRIBLY LIKE --

"BEH!" BEH YELLED INTO THE STUNNED SILENCE. "IT'S GEEK! AND BEH  
DONE

WHAT WAS IN THE BEH?"

"N -- NH," SAID FERMINE IN A TREMBLING VOICE.

REN THREW SOMETHING DOWN INTO FERMIN'S BLUE TRANSLATION, FERMIN AND

HARRY LEANED FORWARD, LYING ON THE OF THE WEIRD, SPIDY SHAPES WERE  
SEVERAL LINE, GINGER CAT HAIRS.

## CHAPTER THIRTEEN

210

### CRISPINDEER VERSUS RAYNCLAW

IT LOOKED LIKE THE END OF REN AND FERMIN'S FRIENDSHIP. EACH WAS SHE  
ANGRY WITH THE OTHER THAT HARRY COULDN'T SEE HOW THEY'D EVER MADE UP.  
REN WAS ENRAGED THAT FERMIN HAD NEVER TAKEN CRISPINDEER'S ATTEMPTS  
THE

EAT SLACKERS SERIOUSLY, HADN'T EITHERED THE DEEP A CLOSE ENOUGH WATCH ON  
HIM, AND WAS STILL TRYING TO PRETEND THAT CRISPINDEER WAS INNOCENT BY  
SUGGESTING THAT REN LIED FOR SLACKERS UNDER ALL THE KEYS' EYES.

FERMIN, MEANWHILE, MAINTAINED FIERCELY THAT REN HAD NO PROOF THAT  
CRISPINDEER HAD EATEN SLACKERS, THAT THE GINGER HAIRS MIGHT HAVE BEEN  
THERE SINCE CHRISTMAS, AND THAT REN HAD BEEN PREJUDICED AGAINST HER CAT  
EVER SINCE CRISPINDEER HAD LANDED ON REN'S HEAD IN THE MAGICAL  
MENAGERIE.

PERSONALLY, HARRY WAS SURE THAT CRISPINDEER HAD EATEN SLACKERS, AND  
WHEN

HE TRIED TO POINT OUT TO FERMIN THAT THE EVIDENCE ALL POINTED THAT  
WAY, SHE LOST HER TEMPER WITH HARRY THEM.

"HEY, SIDE WITH REN, I KNOW YOU WOULD!" SHE SAID SHRILLY, "FIRST THE  
FIREHILL, NOW SLACKERS, EVERYTHING'S MY FAULT, ISN'T IT? JUST LEAVE ME  
ALONE, HARRY, I'VE GOT A LOT OF WORK TO DO!"

REN HAD TAKEN THE LOSS OF HIS RAT VERY HARD INDEED.

"THERE HE, REN, YOU WERE ALWAYS SAYING HOW EATING SLACKERS WAS," SAID

FRED GRACIOUSLY. "AND HE'S BEEN OFF-HEELER FOR AGES, HE WAS WASTING AWAY. IT WAS PROBABLY BETTER FOR HIM THE SOONER IT ENDED -- HE'LL SWALLOW -- HE PROBABLY DIDN'T FEEL A THING."

"FRED!" SAID CINDY INDIGNANTLY.

"ALL HE DID WAS EAT AND SLEEP, THEN, YELL SAID IT YOURSELF," SAID GEORGE.

"HE BIT GEORGE FOR HIS HONOR!" THEN SAID MISERABLY. "REMEMBER, HARRY?"

"YEAH, THAT'S TRUE," SAID HARRY.

"HIS FINEST HOUR," SAID FRED, UNABLE TO KEEP A STRAIGHT FACE. "LET THE STAR ON GEORGE'S FINGER STAND AS A LASTING TRIBUTE TO HIS MEMORY. HEH,

211

COME ON, THEN, GET YOURSELF DOWN TO THE HESPERADE AND BUY A NEW RAT, WHAT'S THE POINT OF MEANING?"

IN A LAST-DITCH ATTEMPT TO CHEER THEN UP, HARRY PERSUADED HIM TO COME ALONG TO THE GRYFFINDOR TEAM'S FINAL PRACTICE BEFORE THE RAVENCLAW MATCH, SEE THAT HE COULD HAVE A RIDE ON THE FIREHUNT AFTER THEY'D FINISHED. THIS DID SEEM TO TAKE THEN'S MIND OFF SLACKERS AND A MOMENT ("GREAT! CAN I TRY AND SHOOT A FEW GHAZS ON IT?") SEE THEY SET OFF FOR THE HURDITCH FIELD TOGETHER.

MADAM HUNTER, WHO WAS STILL OVERSEEING GRYFFINDOR PRACTICES THE DEEP AN EYE ON HARRY, WAS JUST AS IMPRESSED WITH THE FIREHUNT AS EVERYONE ELSE HAD BEEN. SHE TOOK IT IN HER HANDS BEFORE TAKING AND GAVE THEM THE BENEFIT OF HER PROFESSIONAL OPINION.

"LOOK AT THE BALANCE ON IT! IF THE NIMBLE SERIES HAS A FLAW, IT'S A SLIGHT LIST TO THE TAIL END -- YOU'LL OFTEN FIND THEY DEVELOP A DRAG AFTER A FEW YEARS. THEY'VE UPDATED THE HANDLE THEN, A KIT SLIMMER THAN THE CLEANSWEPS, REMINDS ME OF THE OLD SILVER ARROWS -- A PITY THEY'VE STOPPED MAKING THEM. I LEARNED THE FLY ON ONE, AND A VERY FINE OLD KNIFE"



IT WAS THERE...."

SHE CONTINUED IN THIS VEIN FOR SOME TIME, UNTIL WEED SAID, "ER -- MADAM BEECH? IS IT OKAY IF HARRY HAS THE FIREBLIT BACK? WE NEED THE PRACTICE...."

"EH -- RIGHT -- HERE YOU ARE, THEN, BETTER," SAID MADAM BEECH. "I'LL SIT OVER HERE WITH WEASLEY...."

SHE AND REIN LEFT THE FIELD THE SIT IN THE STADIUM, AND THE GRYFFINDOR TEAM GATHERED AROUND WEED FOR HIS FINAL INSTRUCTIONS FOR THE HORNED'S MATCH.

"HARRY, I'VE JUST FOUND OUT WITH RAVENCLAW IS PLAYING AS SEEKER. IT'S LEE CHANG. SHE'S A FORTY-ONE YEAR, AND SHE'S PRETTY GOOD.... I REALLY HOPED SHE WOULDN'T BE FIT, SHE'S HAD SOME PROBLEMS WITH INJURIES...." WEED SHOOK HIS DISPLEASURE THAT LEE CHANG HAD MADE A FULL RECOVERY, THEN SAID, "ON THE OTHER HAND, SHE RIDES A CHIMP TWO SIXTY, WHICH IS GOING TO BE LIKE A BOMB NEXT TO THE FIREBLIT." HE GAVE HARRY'S BROTHER A LONG OF PERVENT ADMIRATION, THEN SAID, "OKAY, EVERYONE, LET'S GO -- "

212

AND AT LONG LAST, HARRY MOUNTED HIS FIREBLIT, AND KICKED OFF FROM THE GRASS.

IT WAS BETTER THAN HE'D EVER DREAMED. THE FIREBLIT TURNED WITH THE LIGHTEST TOUCH; IT SEEMED TO BE HIS THOUGHTS RATHER THAN HIS GRIP; IT SPED ACROSS THE FIELD AT SUCH SPEED THAT THE STADIUM TURNED INTO A GREEN-AND-GRAY BLUR; HARRY TURNED IT SHARPLY THAT ALICE SPINNET SCREAMED, THEN HE WENT INTO A PERFECTLY CONTROLLED DIVE, CRASHING THE GRASSY FIELD WITH HIS THES REARS RISING THIRTY, FORTY, FIFTY FEET INTO THE AIR AGAIN.

"HARRY, I'M LETTING THE SNITCH GO!" WEED CALLED.

HARRY TURNED AND RACED A KLUDGER TOWARD THE CHAL PHISTS; HE HILTSTRIPPED IT EASILY, SAW THE SNITCH DART HILT FROM BEHIND WHEED, AND WITHIN TEN SECONDS HAD CALGHT IT TIGHTLY IN HIS HAND.

THE TEAM CHEERED MADLY, HARRY LET THE SNITCH GO AGAIN, GAVE IT A MINUTE'S HEAD START, THEN THRE AFTER IT, LEAVING IN AND HILT OF THE EITHER; HE SPOTTED IT LURKING NEAR KATIE KELL'S DNER, WHIPPED HER EASILY, AND CALGHT IT AGAIN.

IT WAS THE BEST PRACTICE EVER; THE TEAM, INSPIRED BY THE PRESENCE OF THE FIREKILT IN THEIR MIDST, PERFORMED THEIR BEST MOVES FLAWLESSLY, AND BY THE TIME THEY HIT THE GROUND AGAIN, WHEED DIDN'T HAVE A SINGLE CRITICISM TO MAKE, WHICH, AS GEMRGE WEASLEY POINTED HILT, WAS A FIRST.

"I CAN'T SEE WHAT'S GOING THE STOP US THEHREHLY!" SAID WHEED, "NOT UNLESS -- HARRY, YOU'VE SHOTED HILT YOUR DEMENTHER PROBLEM, HAVEN'T YOU?"

"Yeah," SAID HARRY, THINKING OF HIS FEELER PATRONUS AND WISHING IT WERE STRONGER.

"THE DEMENTHERS WHENT TURN UP AGAIN, HILYER, DUMBLEDHRE'D GO BALLISTIC," SAID FRED CONFIDENTLY.

"WELL, LET'S HOPE NOT," SAID WHEED, "ANYWAY -- GOOD WHEED, EVERYONE, LET'S GET BACK THE THE THEHRE... TURN IN EARLY --"

ZLK

"I'M STAYING HILT FOR A BIT; RHN WANTS A GO IN THE FIREKILT," HARRY TOLD WHEED, AND WHILE THE REST OF THE TEAM HEADED OFF THE THE LUCKER REHMS, HARRY STRODE OVER THE RHN, WHO VALITED THE BARRIER THE THE STANDS AND LAZE TO MEET HIM, MADAM FHEECH HAD FALLEN ASLEEP IN HER SEAT.

"HERE YOU GO," SAID HARRY, HANDING RHN THE FIREKILT.

RHN, AN EXPRESSION OF ELSTASY IN HIS FACE, MELINTED THE RHNEM AND ZEHMED OFF INTO THE GATHERING DARKNESS WHILE HARRY WALKED AROUND THE EDGE OF

THE FIELD, WATCHING HIM. NIGHT HAD FALLEN BEFORE MADAM ~~HEED~~ AWOKE WITH A START, THOUGHT ~~HARRY~~ AND ~~REIN~~ OFF HER FEET WAKING HER, AND INSISTED THAT THEY GO BACK TO THE CASTLE.

~~HARRY~~ ~~SHOULDERS~~ THE ~~FIREWHEEL~~ AND HE AND ~~REIN~~ WALKED ALONG THE ~~SHADELESS~~ STADIUM, DISCUSSING THE ~~FIREWHEEL~~'S SILENTLY ~~SMOOTH~~ ACTION, ITS PERMANENT ACCELERATION, AND ITS PERSISTENT TURNING. THEY WERE HALFWAY TOWARD THE CASTLE WHEN ~~HARRY~~, GLANCING TO HIS LEFT, SAW SOMETHING THAT MADE HIS HEART TURN OVER -- A PAIR OF EYES, GLEAMING ALONG THE DARKNESS.

~~HARRY~~ STOPPED DEAD, HIS HEART BANGING AGAINST HIS RIBS.

"WHAT'S THE MATTER?" SAID ~~REIN~~.

~~HARRY~~ FLINCHED, ~~REIN~~ PULLED ALONG HIS WAND AND MUTTERED, "LUMOS!"

A BEAM OF LIGHT FELL ACROSS THE GRASS, HIT THE TRUNK OF A TREE, AND ILLUMINATED ITS BRANCHES; THERE, CRACKLING AMONG THE KLIPPING LEAVES, WAS ~~CRIBBLES-ANDS~~.

"GET ALONG HERE!" ~~REIN~~ REARED, AND HE STOPPED DEAD AND SEIZED A STONE LYING IN THE GRASS, BUT BEFORE HE COULD DO ANYTHING ELSE, ~~CRIBBLES-ANDS~~ HAD VANISHED WITH ONE SWISH OF HIS LONG GINGER TAIL.

"SEE?" ~~REIN~~ SAID FLURRIEDLY, FLICKING THE STONE DEAD AGAIN. "SHE'S STILL LETTING HIM WANDER ABOUT WHEREVER HE WANTS -- PROBABLY WASTING DEAD SLACKERS WITH A WHOLE LOT OF KINDS ~~NEED~~..."

~~HARRY~~ DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING, HE TOOK A DEEP BREATH AS RELIEF SEEPED THROUGH HIM; HE HAD BEEN SURE FOR A MOMENT THAT THOSE EYES HAD REMEMBERED

219

THE THE GRIM. THEY SET OFF FOR THE CASTLE HENCE MORE, SLIGHTLY ASHAMED OF HIS MOMENT OF PANIC, ~~HARRY~~ DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING TO ~~REIN~~ -- NEAR DID HE ~~WHEN~~ LEFT HER RIGHT UNTIL THEY HAD REACHED THE WELL-LIT ENTRANCE HALL.

Harry went down the breakfast the next morning with the rest of the kids in his dormitory, all of whom seemed to think the Firebolt deserved a shirt of eldritch of feather. As Harry entered the Great Hall, heads turned in the direction of the Firebolt, and there was a good deal of excited muttering. Harry saw, with enormous satisfaction, that the Slytherin team were all looking thunderstruck.

"Did you see his face?" said Ron gleefully, looking back at Malfoy. "He can't believe it! This is brilliant!"

Which, then, was taking in the reflected glory of the Firebolt.

"Put it here, Harry," he said, laying the broom in the middle of the table and carefully turning it so that its name faced upward. People from the Ravenclaw and Hufflepuff tables were seen coming over the heads. Cedric Diggory came over the counterplate Harry had having acquired such a superb replacement for his Nimbus, and Percy's Ravenclaw girlfriend, Penelope Clearwater, asked if she could actually hold the Firebolt.

"Well, well, Pen, see sabotage?" said Percy heartily as she examined the Firebolt closely. "Penelope and I have got a bet on," he told the team.

"Ten Galleons on the outcome of the match!"

Penelope put the Firebolt down again, thanked Harry, and went back to her table.

"Harry -- make sure you win," said Percy, in an urgent whisper. "I haven't got ten Galleons. Yes, I'm coming, Pen!" And he elbowed her the in her in a piece of toast.

"Sure you can manage that broom, Putter?" said a child, drawing voice. Draco Malfoy had arrived for a closer look, Crabbe and Goyle right behind him.

"Yeah, reckon so," said Harry casually.

"GET PLenty OF SPECIAL FEATURES, HASN'T IT?" SAID MALTHEY, EYES GLITTERING MALICIOUSLY. "SHAME IT DOESN'T COME WITH A PARACHUTE -- IN CASE YOU GET TOO NEAR A DEMENTHEE."

CRABBE AND GOYLE SNIGGERED.

"PITY YOU CAN'T ATTACK AN EXTRA ARMY THE OTHERS, MALTHEY," SAID LARRY. "THEN IT COULD CATCH THE SNITCH FOR YOU."

THE GRYFFINDOR TEAM LAUGHED LOUDLY. MALTHEY'S PALE EYES NARROWED, AND HE STALKED AWAY. THEY WATCHED HIM REJOIN THE REST OF THE SLYTHERIN TEAM, WHO PUT THEIR HEADS TOGETHER, NOT WITHOUT ASKING MALTHEY WHETHER LARRY'S BROTHER REALLY WAS A FIREBOLT.

AT A QUARTER TEN ELEVEN, THE GRYFFINDOR TEAM SET OFF FOR THE LOCKER ROOMS. THE WEATHER COULDN'T HAVE BEEN MORE DIFFERENT FROM THEIR MATCH AGAINST HUFFLEPUFF. IT WAS A CLEAR, COLD DAY WITH A VERY LIGHT BREEZE; THERE COULD BE NO VISIBILITY PROBLEMS THIS TIME, AND LARRY, THOUGH NERVOUS, WAS STARTING TO FEEL THE EXCITEMENT ONLY A HOLIDAY MATCH COULD BRING. THEY COULD HEAR THE REST OF THE SCHOOL MOVING INTO THE STADIUM BEHIND. LARRY THREW OFF HIS BLACK SCHOOL COAT, REMOVED HIS GLOVES FROM HIS POCKET, AND STUCK IT INSIDE THE T-SHIRT HE WAS GOING TO WEAR UNDER HIS HOLIDAY COAT. HE ONLY HOPED HE WOULDN'T NEED IT. HE WONDERED SUDDENLY WHETHER PROFESSOR SLIPIN WAS IN THE CROWD, WATCHING. "YOU KNOW WHAT WE'VE GOT TO DO," SAID LINDA AS THEY PREPARED TO LEAVE THE LOCKER ROOMS. "IF WE LOSE THIS MATCH, WE'RE OUT OF THE RUNNING. JUST -- JUST FLY LIKE YOU DID IN PRACTICE YESTERDAY, AND WE'LL BE BACK!"

THEY WALKED OUT INTO THE FIELD TO THE TUMULTUOUS APPLAUSE. THE RAVENCLAW TEAM, DRESSED IN BLUE, WERE ALREADY STANDING IN THE MIDDLE OF THE FIELD. THEIR SEEKER, LEE LANE, WAS THE ONLY GIRL IN THEIR TEAM. SHE WAS SHORTER THAN LARRY BY ABOUT A HEAD, AND LARRY COULDN'T HELP REMARKING, NERVOUS AS HE WAS, THAT SHE WAS EXTREMELY PRETTY. SHE SMILED AT LARRY AS

THE TEAMS FACED EACH OTHER BEHIND THEIR CAPTAINS, AND HE FELT A SLIGHT LURCH IN THE REGION OF HIS STOMACH THAT HE DIDN'T THINK HAD ANYTHING TO DO WITH NERVES.

"WHEED, DAVIES, SHAKE HANDS," MADAM PITCHER SAID BRISKLY, AND WHEED SHOOK

218

HANDS WITH THE RAVENCLAW CAPTAIN.

"MELUNT YELUR KREHEES... HEN MY WHISTLE... THREE -- TWO -- ONE --"

HARRY KICKED OFF INTO THE AIR AND THE FIREBOLT ZOOMED HIGHER AND FASTER THAN ANY OTHER KREHEE; HE SHARED AROUND THE STADIUM AND BEGAN WHISTLING AROUND FOR THE SNITCH, LISTENING ALL THE WHILE TO THE COMMENTARY, WHICH WAS BEING PROVIDED BY THE WEASLEY TWINS' FRIEND LEE JORDAN.

"THEY'RE OFF, AND THE BIG EXCITEMENT THIS MATCH IS THE FIREBOLT THAT HARRY POTTER IS FLYING FOR GRYFFINDOR, ACCORDING TO WHICH KREHEEMSTICK, THE FIREBOLT'S GOING TO BE THE KREHEE OF CHOICE FOR THE NATIONAL TEAMS AT THIS YEAR'S WORLD CHAMPIONSHIP --"

"JORDAN, WOULD YOU MIND TELLING US WHAT'S GOING ON IN THE MATCH?" INTERRUPTED PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL'S VOICE.

"RIGHT YOU ARE, PROFESSOR -- I'VE JUST GIVING A BIT OF BACKGROUND INFORMATION -- THE FIREBOLT, INCIDENTALLY, HAS A KNIT-IN ALTHOUGH AND --"

"JORDAN!"

"HEY, HEY, GRYFFINDOR IN POSSESSION, KATIE BELL OF GRYFFINDOR, HEADING FOR GOAL..."

HARRY STREAKED PAST KATIE IN THE OPPOSITE DIRECTION, GLAZING AROUND FOR A GLINT OF GOLD AND NOTICING THAT CHEE CHANG WAS TAILING HIM CLOSELY. SHE WAS UNDOUBTEDLY A VERY GOOD FLIER -- SHE KEPT CUTTING ACROSS HIM, FORCING HIM TO CHANGE DIRECTION.

"SHE'S HER YELUR ACCELERATION, HARRY!" FRED YELLED AS HE WHISPERED PAST IN PURSUIT OF A BLUDGEON THAT WAS AIMING FOR ALICIA.

HARRY LUNGED THE FIREBOLT FORWARD AS THEY REELLED THE RAVENCLAW CHAL  
PISTS AND LEE FELL REELING. JUST AS KATIE SUCCEEDED IN SCORING THE FIRST  
GOAL OF THE MATCH, AND THE GRYPFINDER END OF THE FIELD WENT WILD, HE SAW  
IT -- THE SNITCH WAS CLOSE TO THE GOALING, FLITTING NEAR ONE OF THE  
BARRIERS.

HARRY DIVED; LEE SAW WHAT HE WAS DOING AND THERE AFTER HIM -- HARRY WAS

219

SPEEDING UP, EXCITEMENT BLENDING HIM; DIVES WERE HIS SPECIALITY, HE WAS  
TEN FEET AWAY --

THEN A BLUDGER, HIT BY ONE OF THE RAVENCLAW BEATERS, CAME PELTING BLIT OF  
NEIGH-HERE; HARRY VEERED OFF COURSE, AVOIDING IT BY AN INCH, AND IN THESE  
FEW CRUCIAL SECONDS, THE SNITCH HAD VANISHED.

THERE WAS A GREAT "HEHEHEHE" OF DISAPPOINTMENT FROM THE GRYPFINDER  
SLIPPHETERS, BUT MUCH APPALISE FOR THEIR BEATER FROM THE RAVENCLAW END.  
GEORGE WEASLEY VENTED HIS FEELINGS BY HITTING THE SECOND BLUDGER  
DIRECTLY AT THE OFFENDING BEATER, WHO WAS FORCED TO REEL RIGHT OVER IN  
MIDAIR TO AVOID IT.

"GRYPFINDER LEADS BY EIGHTY POINTS TO ZERO, AND LOOK AT THAT FIREBOLT  
GEE! PETER'S REALLY PUTTING IT THROUGH ITS PACE NOW, SEE IT TURN --  
LEAG'S CHIEF IS JUST NOW MATCH FOR IT, THE FIREBOLT'S PRECISION- BALANCE  
IS REALLY NOTICEABLE IN THESE LONG --"

"THEODORE ARE YOU BEING PAID TO ADVERTISE FIREBOLTS? GET HIM  
WITH THE  
COMMENTARY!"

RAVENCLAW WAS PULLING BACK; THEY HAD NOW SCORED THREE GOALS, WHICH PUT  
GRYPFINDER ONLY FIFTY POINTS AHEAD -- IF LEE GOT THE SNITCH BEFORE HIM,  
RAVENCLAW WOULD WIN. HARRY DROPPED LOWER, NARROWLY AVOIDING A  
RAVENCLAW

CHASER, SCANNING THE FIELD FRANTICALLY -- A GLINT OF GOLD, A FLUTTER OF  
TINY WINGS -- THE SNITCH WAS CIRCLING THE GRYFFINDOR GHAZ POST --  
HARRY ACCELERATED, EYES FIXED ON THE SPARK OF GOLD AHEAD -- BUT JUST  
THEN, LEE APPEARED OUT OF THE AIR, BLOCKING HIM --

"HARRY, THIS IS THE TIME TO BE A GENTLEMAN!" LEE REARED AS  
HARRY

SWERVED

THE AHEAD A CHALLENGER, "DON'T FORGET TO REMEMBER IF YOU HAVE THE"  
HARRY TURNED AND CAUGHT SIGHT OF LEE; SHE WAS GRINNING. THE SNITCH HAD  
VANISHED AGAIN. HARRY TURNED HIS FIREHILT UPWARD AND WAS SEEN TWENTY  
FEET ABOVE THE GAME. OUT OF THE CORNER OF HIS EYE, HE SAW LEE FOLLOWING  
HIM... SHE'D DECIDED TO MARK HIM RATHER THAN SEARCH FOR THE SNITCH  
HERSELF... ALL RIGHT, THEN... IF SHE WANTED TO TAIL HIM, SHE'D HAVE THE

218

TAKE THE CONSEQUENCES...

HE DIVED AGAIN, AND LEE, THINKING HE'D SEEN THE SNITCH, TRIED TO FOLLOW;  
HARRY PULLED OUT OF THE DIVE VERY SHARPLY; SHE HURTTLED DOWNWARD; HE ROSE  
FAST AS A BULLET SINCE MORE, AND THEN SAW IT, FOR THE THIRD TIME -- THE  
SNITCH WAS GLITTERING WAY ABOVE THE FIELD AT THE RAVENCLAW END.  
HE ACCELERATED; SEE, MANY FEET BELOW, DID LEE. HE WAS WINNING, GAINING ON  
THE SNITCH WITH EVERY SECOND -- THEN --

"HEY!" SCREAMED LEE, POINTING.

DISTRACTED, HARRY LOOKED DOWN.

THREE DEMENTORS, THREE TALL, BLACK, HEEDED DEMENTORS, WERE LEERING UP AT  
HIM.

HE DIDN'T STOP TO THINK. PULLING A HAND DOWN THE NECK OF HIS ROBE, HE  
WHIPPED OUT HIS WAND AND REARED, "EXPECTO PATRONUM!"

SOMETHING SILVER-WHITE, SOMETHING ENORMOUS, ERUPTED FROM THE END OF HIS



HAND, HE KNEW IT HAD SEEN DIRECTLY AT THE DEMENTERS BUT DIDN'T PALSE THE  
 WATCH; HIS MIND STILL MIRACULOUSLY CLEAR, HE LEANED AHEAD -- HE WAS  
 NEARLY THERE, HE STRETCHED OUT THE HAND STILL GRASPING HIS HAND AND INST  
 MANAGED THE CREEP HIS FINGERS OVER THE SMALL, STRUGGLING SNITCH.  
 MADAM BUNCH'S WHISTLE SOUNDED, HARRY TURNED AROUND IN MIDAIR AND SAW SIX  
 SCARLET EILERS BEARING DOWN ON HIM; NEXT MOMENT, THE WHOLE TEAM WAS  
 FLEEING HIM SEE THAT HE WAS NEARLY PULLED OFF HIS KNEES, DOWN BELOW HE  
 COULD HEAR THE REARS OF THE GRYPFINDERS IN THE CROWD.

"THAT'S MY KEY!" WHO KEPT YELLING, ALICIA, ANGELINA, AND KATIE HAD ALL  
 KISSED HARRY; FRED HAD HIM IN A GRIP SO TIGHT HARRY FELT AS THOUGH HIS  
 HEAD WOULD COME OFF IN COMPLETE DISARRAY, THE TEAM MANAGED THE MAKE ITS  
 WAY BACK TO THE CROWD, HARRY GOT OFF HIS KNEES AND LEANED UP TO SEE A  
 GAGGLE OF GRYPFINDER SLIPSTERS SPRINTING ACROSS THE FIELD, WITH IN THE  
 LEAD, BEFORE HE KNEW IT, HE HAD BEEN ENGLISHED BY THE CHEERING CROWD.

"YES!" WITH YELLED, POKING HARRY'S ARM INTO THE AIR, "YES! YES!"

219

"WELL DONE, HARRY!" SAID PERCY, LEANING DELIGHTED, "TEN GALLEONS THE ME!  
 MUST FIND PENELPHE, EXCUSE ME --"

"GOOD FOR YOU, HARRY!" ROARED SAMUEL FINNICAN.

"BLOODY BRILLIANT!" CHEERED HAGRID OVER THE HEADS OF THE MILLING  
 GRYPFINDERS.

"THAT WAS WHITE SOME PATRONUS," SAID A VOICE IN HARRY'S EAR.  
 HARRY TURNED AROUND TO SEE PROFESSOR LUPIN, WHO LEANED BOTH SHOULDERS AND  
 PLEASED.

"THE DEMENTERS DIDN'T AFFECT ME AT ALL!" HARRY SAID EXCITEDLY, "I DIDN'T  
 FEEL A THING!"

"THAT WOULD BE BECAUSE THEY -- ER -- WEREN'T DEMENTERS," SAID PROFESSOR

SLIP IN, THERE AND SEE -- "

HE LED HARRY HEAT OF THE CREEK UNTIL THEY WERE ABLE TO SEE THE EDGE OF THE FIELD.

"WELL GAVE MR. MALPHE HEAT A FRIGHT," SAID SLIP IN.

HARRY STARED, LYING IN A CRUMPLED HEAP IN THE CREEK WERE MALPHE, CRABE, COYLE, AND MARCUS FLINT, THE SLYTHERIN TEAM CAPTAIN, ALL STRUGGLING TO REMOVE THEMSELVES FROM BEING, BLACK, FENCED REEKS. IT LOOKED AS THOUGH MALPHE HAD BEEN STANDING IN COYLE'S SHOULDERS, STANDING OVER THEM, WITH AN EXPRESSION OF THE LITHEST FLARE IN HER FACE, WAS PROFESSOR MCENAGALL.

"AN UNWORTHY TRICK!" SHE WAS SCREAMING, "A LIES AND CHEATERS ATTEMPT TO SABOTAGE THE GRYFFINDOR SEEKER'S DETENTION FOR ALL OF THEM, AND FIFTY POINTS FROM SLYTHERIN! I SHALL BE SPREADING THE PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE ABOUT THIS, MAKE NO MISTAKE! AH, HERE HE COMES NOW!"

IF ANYTHING COULD HAVE SET THE SEAL ON GRYFFINDOR'S VICTORY, IT WAS THIS, WHEN HE HAD REACHED HIS WAY THROUGH THE HARRY'S SIDE, DROPPED UP WITH LAUGHTER AS THEY WATCHED MALPHE FIGHTING TO EXTRICATE HIMSELF FROM THE REEK, COYLE'S HEAD STILL STUCK INSIDE IT.

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"THERE HE, HARRY!" SAID GEORGE, FIGHTING HIS WAY OVER. "PARTY! GRYFFINDOR CHEMPIONSHIP, NOW!"

"RIGHT," SAID HARRY, AND FEELING HAPPIER THAN HE HAD IN AGES, HE AND THE REST OF THE TEAM LED THE WAY, STILL IN THEIR SCARLET REEKS, HEAT OF THE STADIUM AND BACK UP TO THE CASTLE.

IT FELT AS THOUGH THEY HAD ALREADY BEEN THE HOLIDAY CLUB; THE PARTY WENT ON ALL DAY AND WELL INTO THE NIGHT. FRED AND GEORGE WEASLEY DISAPPEARED FOR A COUPLE OF HOURS AND RETURNED WITH ARMS OF KITTLES OF

CLITTERKEER, PLIMPOKIN FIZZ, AND SEVERAL BAGS FULL OF HONEYBLOOM SWEETS.

"WELL DID YOU SEE THAT?" SHEALSED ANGELINA JENNISON AS GEORGE STARTED  
TWIRLING PEPPERMINT TWADS INTO THE CIRCLE.

"WITH A LITTLE HELP FROM MERRY, WHISKYTAIL, PADFEET, AND PRINCE," FRED  
MUTTERED IN HARRY'S EAR.

ONLY ONE PERSON WASN'T JOINING IN THE FESTIVITIES. HERMIONE, INCREDIBLY,  
WAS SITTING IN A CORNER, ATTEMPTING TO READ AN ENORMOUS BOOK ENTITLED  
HARRY LIFE AND SPECIAL FACTS OF BRITISH MAGICLES. HARRY KEPT AWAY FROM  
THE TABLE WHERE FRED AND GEORGE HAD STARTED JUGGLING CLITTERKEER BOTTLES  
AND WENT OVER TO HER.

"DID YOU EVEN CHEER THE THE MATCH?" HE ASKED HER.

"OF COURSE I DID," SAID HERMIONE IN A STRANGELY HIGH-PITCHED VOICE, NOT  
LOOKING UP. "AND I'M VERY GLAD WE WON, AND I THINK YOU DID REALLY WELL,  
BUT I NEED TO READ THIS BY MONDAY."

"Come on, Hermione, come and have some food," HARRY SAID, LOOKING OVER  
AT RON AND WONDERING WHETHER HE WAS IN A GOOD ENOUGH MOOD TO ENJOY THE  
MATCHET.

"I CAN'T, HARRY, I'VE STILL GOT FOUR HUNDRED AND TWENTY-TWO PAGES TO  
READ!" SAID HERMIONE, NOW SOUNDING SLIGHTLY HYSTERICAL. "AND...!" SHE  
GLANCED OVER AT RON THEN. "HE DOESN'T WANT ME TO JOIN IN."

THERE WAS NO ARGUING WITH THIS, AS RON CHOSE THAT MOMENT TO SAY LAUDABLY,

221

"If SLARKERS HADN'T JUST BEEN EATEN, HE COULD HAVE HAD SOME OF THESE  
FLICKER FLIES. HE LIKED THEM REALLY LIKE THEM --"

HERMIONE BURST INTO TEARS. BEFORE HARRY COULD SAY HER ONE ANYTHING, SHE  
THROCKED THE ENORMOUS BOOK UNDER HER ARM, AND, STILL SHAKING, RAN TOWARD  
THE STAIRCASE TO THE GIRLS' DORMITORIES AND HURT HER SIGHT.

"CAN'T YOU GIVE HER A BREAK?" HARRY ASKED RON QUIETLY.

"NO," SAID RON FLATLY. "IF SHE JUST ACTED LIKE SHE WAS SORRY -- BUT SHE'LL NEVER ADMIT SHE'S WRONG, HERMIONE. SHE'S STILL ACTING LIKE STARKERS HAS GIVEN HER VACATION HER SOMETHING."

THE GRYFFINDOR PARTY ENDED ONLY WHEN PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL TURNED UP IN

HER TARTAN DRESSING GOWN AND HAIR NET AT ONE IN THE MORNING. SHE INSISTED THAT THEY ALL GET THE BED. HARRY AND RON CLIMBED THE STAIRS TO THEIR DORMITORY, STILL DISCUSSING THE MATCH. AT LAST, EXHAUSTED, HARRY CLIMBED INTO THE BED, TWITCHED THE HANGINGS OF HIS FOUR-POSTER SO THAT THE BLINDS BLUCKED A RAY OF MIDNIGHT, LAY BACK, AND FELT HIMSELF ALMOST INSTANTLY DRIFTING OFF TO SLEEP....

HE HAD A VERY STRANGE DREAM. HE WAS WALKING THROUGH A FOREST, HIS FIREWILT OVER HIS SHOULDER, FOLLOWING SOMETHING SILVER-WHITE. IT WAS WINDING ITS WAY THROUGH THE TREES AHEAD, AND HE COULD ONLY CATCH GLIMPSES OF IT BETWEEN THE LEAVES. ANXIOUSLY HE CATCHED UP WITH IT, HE SPED UP, BUT AS HE MOVED FASTER, SHE DID HIS BACK. HARRY CRASHED INTO A BURN, AND AHEAD HE HEARD BEEHIVES GATHERING SPEED. WHEN HE WAS RUNNING FLAT OUT, AND AHEAD HE COULD HEAR GALLIPIPING. THEN HE TURNED A CORNER INTO A CLEARING AND -

"A-A-ANGEL-X-X: DEEEEE!"

HARRY WAKE AS SUDDENLY AS THOUGH HE'D BEEN HIT IN THE FACE. DISORIENTED IN THE TOTAL DARKNESS, HE FUMBLER WITH HIS HANGINGS. HE COULD HEAR MOVEMENTS AROUND HIM, AND SEamus FINNIGAN'S VOICE FROM THE OTHER SIDE OF THE ROOM: "WHAT'S GOING ON?"

HARRY THOUGHT HE HEARD THE DORMITORY DOOR SLAM. AT LAST FINDING THE DIVIDE IN HIS CURTAINS, HE RIPPED THEM BACK, AND AT THE SAME MOMENT, DEAN THOMAS LIT HIS LAMP.

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REHN WAS SITTING UP IN BED, THE HANGINGS TORN FROM ONE SIDE, A LEANER OF  
LUTHEST TERROR ON HIS FACE.

"BLACK! SIRILIS BLACK! WITH A KNIFE!"

"WHAT?"

"HERE! I'VE JUST BEEN! SLASHED THE CURTAINS! WHERE HE LIES!"

"YOU'VE SURE YOU WEREN'T DREAMING, REHN?" SAID DRAN.

"LOOK AT THE CURTAINS! I TELL YOU, HE WAS HERE!"

THEY ALL SCRAMBLED OUT OF BED; HARRY REACHED THE BATHROOM FIRST,  
AND THEY SPRINTED BACK DOWN THE STAIRCASE, DOORS OPENED BEHIND THEM, AND  
SLEEPY VOICES CALLED AFTER THEM.

"WHAT'S THAT?"

"WHAT'RE YOU DOING?"

THE CHIMNEY ROOM WAS LIT WITH THE GLOW OF THE DYING FIRE, STILL LITTERED  
WITH THE DEBRIS FROM THE PARTY, IT WAS DESERTED.

"ARE YOU SURE YOU WEREN'T DREAMING, REHN?"

"I'M TELLING YOU, I SAW HIM!"

"WHAT'S ALL THE NOISE?"

"PROFESSOR MCGINAGALL TOLD US THE GUY IN BED!"

A FEW OF THE GIRLS HAD COME DOWN THEIR STAIRCASE, PULLING HIM, DRESSING  
GOWNS AND PALMERS, KIDS, THEN, WERE REAPPEARING.

"EXCELLENT, ARE WE CARRYING HIM?" SAID FRED WEASLEY BRIGHTLY.

"EVERYONE BACK UPSTAIRS!" SAID PERCY, FLURRYING INTO THE CHIMNEY ROOM AND  
PINNING HIS HEAD BACK TO HIS PALMERS AS HE SPEAKED.

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"PERCY -- SIRILIS BLACK!" SAID REHN FAINTLY, "IN HIS BATHROOM! WITH A  
KNIFE! WHERE HE LIES!"

THE CHAMBER ROOM WENT VERY STILL.

"NONSENSE?" SAID PERCY, LOOKING STARTLED. "YELL HAD THEM MUCK THE CAT, RHN -- HAD A NIGHTMARE --"

"I'M TELLING YELL --"

"NOW, REALLY, ENOUGH'S ENOUGH!"

PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL WAS BACK. SHE SLAMMED THE PORTRAIT BEHIND HER AS SHE ENTERED THE CHAMBER ROOM AND STARED FLURRIEDLY AROUND.

"I AM DELIGHTED THAT GRYFFINDOR WON THE MATCH, BUT THIS IS GETTING RIDICULOUS! PERCY, I EXPECTED BETTER OF YELL!"

"I CERTAINLY DIDN'T AUTHORIZE THIS, PROFESSOR!" SAID PERCY, PUFFING HIMSELF UP INDIGNANTLY. "I WAS JUST TELLING THEM ALL THE GET BACK THE KEY! MY BROTHER RHN HERE HAD A NIGHTMARE --"

"IT WASN'T A NIGHTMARE!" RHN YELLED. "PROFESSOR, I WOOK UP, AND

STILL

BLACK WAS STANDING OVER ME, HOLDING A KNIFE!"

PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL STARED AT HIM.

"DIDN'T SE RIDICULOUS, WEASLEY, HOW COULD HE POSSIBLY HAVE GOTTEN THROUGH THE PORTRAIT KEY?"

"ASK HIM!" SAID RHN, POINTING A SHAKING FINGER AT THE BACK OF SIR CADOGAN'S PICTURE. "ASK HIM IF HE SAW --"

GLARING SUSPICIOUSLY AT RHN, PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL PUSHED THE PORTRAIT BACK OPEN AND WENT HILLSIDE. THE WHILE CHAMBER ROOM LISTENED WITH BATED BREATH. "SIR CADOGAN, DID YELL JUST LET A MAN ENTER GRYFFINDOR TOWER?"

"CERTAINLY, GOOD LADY!" CRIED SIR CADOGAN.

229

THERE WAS A STUNNED SILENCE, BOTH INSIDE AND HILLSIDE THE CHAMBER ROOM.

"YELL -- YELL DID?" SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL. "BUT -- BUT THE PASSWORD?"

"HE HAD 'EM?" SAID SIR CADWGAN PROUDLY. "HAD THE WIZARD WOOD'S, MY LADY? READ 'EM OFF A LITTLE PIECE OF PAPER?"

PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL PULLED HERSELF BACK THROUGH THE PORTRAIT BEHIND THE FACE THE STUNNED CREED. SHE WAS WHITE AS CHALK.

"WHICH PERSON," SHE SAID, HER VOICE SHAKING, "WHICH ABYSMALLY FOOLISH PERSON WROTE DOWN THIS WOOD'S PASSWORDS AND LEFT THEM LYING AROUND?"

THERE WAS LITTLE SILENCE, BROKEN BY THE SMALLEST OF TERRIFIED SQUEALS.

NEVILLE LONGBOTT, TREMBLING FROM HEAD THE FLIPPY SLIPPERS THES, RAISED HIS HAND SILENTLY INTO THE AIR.

## CHAPTER FIFTEEN

### SNAP'S GINGER

NOW HERE IN GRYFFINDOR TOWER SLEPT THAT NIGHT. THEY KNEW THAT THE CASTLE WAS BEING SEARCHED AGAIN, AND THE WIZARD WOOD STAYED AWAKE IN THE CHIMNEY ROOM, WAITING TO HEAR WHETHER BLACK HAD BEEN CAUGHT. PROFESSOR

MCGONAGALL CAME BACK AT DAWN, TO TELL THEM THAT HE HAD AGAIN ESCAPED.

THROUGHOUT THE DAY, EVERYWHERE THEY WENT THEY SAW SIGNS OF TIGHTER

SECURITY; PROFESSOR FLITWICK COULD BE SEEN TEACHING THE FIRST YEARS TO

RECOGNIZE A LARGE PICTURE OF SIRIUS BLACK; FILCH WAS SLIDING

UP AND DOWN THE CORRIDORS, REPAIRING UP EVERYTHING FROM TINY CRACKS IN

THE WALLS TO THE FLOOR BOARDS. SIR CADWGAN HAD BEEN FIRED, HIS PORTRAIT HAD

BEEN TAKEN BACK TO ITS USUAL LANDING ON THE SEVENTH FLOOR, AND THE FAT

LADY WAS BACK. SHE HAD BEEN EXPERTLY RESTORED, BUT WAS STILL EXTREMELY

NERVOUS, AND HAD AGREED TO RETURN TO HER OLD HOME ON THE CONDITION THAT SHE

WAS GIVEN EXTRA PROTECTION. A KIND OF SILENT SECURITY THREAT HAD BEEN

MADE THE GUARD HER. THEY PAVED THE CORRIDOR IN A MENACING GRIP, TALKING

IN WHISPERS AND COMPARING THE SIZE OF THEIR CLOES.

HARRY COULDN'T HELP REMEMBERING THAT THE STATUE OF THE HORN-EYED WITCH ON

THE THIRD FLOOR REMAINED UNGUARDED AND UNLOCKED. IT SEEMED THAT FRED

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AND GEORGE HAD BEEN RIGHT IN THINKING THAT THEY -- AND NEW HARRY, RENN, AND FERMINE -- WERE THE ONLY ONES WHO KNEW ABOUT THE HIDDEN PASSAGEWAY WITHIN IT.

"D'YELL RECKEN WE SHOULD TELL SOMEONE?" HARRY ASKED RENN.

"WE KNOW HE'S NOT COMING IN THROUGH FINEYBLOKE'S," SAID RENN DISMISSIVELY.

"WE'D'VE HEARD IF THE SHEP HAD BEEN BROKEN INTO."

HARRY WAS GLAD RENN THOUGHT THIS VIEW. IF THE ONE-EYED WITCH WAS KEPTED UP THERE, HE WOULD NEVER BE ABLE TO GET INTO THE CESSPORE AGAIN.

RENN HAD BECOME AN INSTANT CELEBRITY, FOR THE FIRST TIME IN HIS LIFE, PEOPLE WERE PAYING MORE ATTENTION TO HIM THAN TO HARRY, AND IT WAS CLEAR THAT RENN WAS RATHER ENJOYING THE EXPERIENCE. THOUGH STILL SEVERELY SHAKEN BY THE NIGHT'S EVENTS, HE WAS HAPPY TO TELL ANYONE WHO ASKED WHAT HAD HAPPENED, WITH A WEALTH OF DETAIL.

"... I WAS ASLEEP, AND I HEARD THIS RIPPING NOISE, AND I THOUGHT IT WAS IN MY DREAM, YELL KNOW? BUT THEN THERE WAS THIS DRAFT... I WOKE UP AND HERE SIDE OF THE HANGINGS ON MY BED HAD BEEN PULLED DOWN... I ROLLED OVER... AND I SAW HIM STANDING OVER ME... LIKE A SKELETON, WITH LONG FILTHY HAIR ... HOLDING THIS GREAT LONG KNIFE, MUST'VE BEEN TWELVE INCHES... AND HE LOOKED AT ME, AND I LOOKED AT HIM, AND THEN I YELLED, AND HE STAMPERED.

"WEE, THOUGHT?" RENN ASKED THE HARRY AS THE GROUP OF SECONDYEAR GIRLS WHO HAD BEEN LISTENING TO HIS CHILLING TALE DEPARTED. "WEE DID HE RUN?"

HARRY HAD BEEN WONDERING THE SAME THING. WEE HAD BLACK, HAVING GOTTEN THE WRONG KEY, NOT SILENCED RENN AND PROCEEDED TO HARRY? BLACK HAD PROMISED TWELVE YEARS AGO THAT HE DIDN'T MIND MURDERING INNOCENT PEOPLE, AND THIS TIME HE HAD BEEN FACING FIVE UNARMED KEYS, ALTHOUGH THEY WERE ASLEEP.

"HE MUST'VE KNOWN HE'D HAVE A HARD GETTING BACK INTO THE CASTLE HENCE



WHEEL'D ROLLED AND LICKEN PEOPLE LIP," SAID F-JARRY T-ELIGHTFULLY. "F-K'D'VE HAD THE BULL THE W-HELE F-JELISE THE GET BACK T-ERELIGH THE PH-TRAIT F-EL... THEN HE WHEEL'D' VE MET THE TRAC-KERS..."

NEVILLE WAS IN T-OTAL DISGRACE. PROFESSOR MC-ENACALL WAS SEEN FL-IRTELIS WITH

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HIM SHE HAD BANNED HIM FROM ALL FUTURE F-JEGSM-AD- VISITS, GIVEN HIM A DETENTION, AND F-ERBIDDEN ANYONE THE GIVE HIM THE PASS-WORD INTO THE T-ELER. F-HER NEVILLE WAS F-ERCED THE WAIT, ELT-SIDE THE CH-PT-EN ROOM EVERY NIGHT AND SHE-KEDDY THE LET HIM IN, W-ILE THE SEC-LITY T-RELLS KEERED UNPLEASANTLY AT HIM. N-ONE OF THESE PL-NT-MENTS, F-HEWEVER, CAME CL-SE THE MATCH-ING THE H-NE HIS GRAND-TH-TER HAD IN ST-ERE FOR HIM. T-EN DAYS AFTER BLACK'S BREAD-IN, SHE SENT NEVILLE THE VERY W-ORST TH-ING A F-J-GLWARTS ST-UDENT CHILD RECEIVE EVER BREAD-FAST -- A F-J-ELER.

THE SC-HEM ELKS ST-EMPPED INTO THE GREAT F-J-ALL CARRYING THE MAIL AS USUAL, AND NEVILLE CH-ED AS A FL-GE BARN ELK LANDED IN F-RENT OF HIM, A SCARLET ENVELOPE CLUTCHED IN ITS BEAK. F-JARRY AND R-EN, W-HE WERE SITTING OPPOSITE HIM, RE-EN-IZED THE LETTER AS A F-J-ELER AT ONCE -- R-EN HAD GET H-NE FROM HIS M-TH-ER THE YEAR BE-ERE.

"R-EN FOR IT, NEVILLE," R-EN ADVISED.

NEVILLE DIDN'T NEED TELLING TWICE. F-K SEIZED THE ENVELOPE, AND F-ELDING IT BE-ERE HIM LIKE A K-EM, SPRINTED ELT OF THE H-ALL, W-ILE THE SLYTH-ERIN TABLE EXPLODED WITH LAUGHTER AT THE SIGHT OF HIM. THEY HEARD THE F-J-ELER GO OFF IN THE ENTRANCE H-ALL -- NEVILLE'S GRAND-TH-TER'S VEHICLE, MAGICALLY MAGNIFIED THE A H-NDRED TIMES ITS USUAL VOLUME, ST-IRKING AKELT F-EL HE HAD T-ELIGHT ST-LAKE H-EN THE W-HELE FAMILY.

F-JARRY WAS T-EN ELIS F-ELING SH-RY FOR NEVILLE THE N-ETICE IMMEDIATELY THAT HE HAD A LETTER T-EN, F-J-ELIC GET HIS ATTENTION BY NIPPING HIM SHARPLY H-EN

THE WRIST.

"HELLO? EH -- THANKS, FREDWIG."

HARRY THEN OPENED THE ENVELOPE WHILE FREDWIG HELPED HERSELF TO SOME OF NEVILLE'S CHOCOLATES. THE NOTE INSIDE SAID:

DEAR HARRY AND RON, I'VE ENJOYED HAVING TEA WITH ME THIS AFTERNOON. REWIND  
SIX? I'LL COME COLLECT YOU FROM THE CASTLE. WAIT FOR ME IN THE  
ENTRANCE

HALL; YOU'RE MEET ALLREADY HEAT AND YOU'RE HEARD. CHEERS, FLOAGRID  
"HE PROBABLY WANTS TO HEAR ALL ABOUT BLACK?" SAID RON.

SEE AT SIX O'CLOCK THAT AFTERNOON, HARRY AND RON LEFT GRYFFINDOR TOWER,

END

PASSED THE SECURITY TRENDS AT A RUN, AND HEADED DOWN THE THE ENTRANCE  
HALL.

FLOAGRID WAS ALREADY WAITING FOR THEM.

"ALL RIGHT, FLOAGRID?" SAID RON. "I'VE BEEN WANT TO HEAR ABOUT SATURDAY  
NIGHT, BE YOU?"

"I'VE ALREADY HEARD ALL ABOUT IT," SAID FLOAGRID, OPENING THE FRONT DOORS  
AND LEADING THEM HILLSIDE.

"EH," SAID RON, LOOKING SLIGHTLY PLAT HEAT.

THE FIRST THING THEY SAW WHEN ENTERING FLOAGRID'S CLOSET WAS BLOODRED, WHICH  
WAS STRETCHED OUT AND THE OF FLOAGRID'S PATCHWORK HEAT, HIS ENORMOUS WINGS  
HIDED TIGHT TO HIS BODY, COVERING A LARGE PLATE OF DEAD FERRETS.

AVERTING HIS EYES FROM THIS UNPLEASANT SIGHT, HARRY SAW A GIGANTIC,  
HAIRY KNEELIN SLIT AND A VERY TERRIBLE YELLOW-AND-ORANGE TIE HANGING FROM  
THE TOP OF FLOAGRID'S WARDROBE DOOR.

"WHAT ARE THEY FOR, FLOAGRID?" SAID HARRY.

"BLOODREDS CASE AGAINST THE COMMITTEE FOR THE DISPOSAL OF DANGEROUS  
CREATURES," SAID FLOAGRID. "THIS FRIDAY, HIM AND ME'LL BE GOING DOWN TO

LENDING TOGETHER, I'VE KILLED TWO KIDS AND THE KNIGHT KIDS..."

HARRY FELT A NASTY PANG OF GUILT. HE HAD COMPLETELY FORGOTTEN THAT KICKHEAD'S TRIAL WAS SO NEAR, AND JUDGING BY THE LINEASY LOOK ON REIN'S FACE, HE HAD THEM. THEY HAD ALSO FORGOTTEN THEIR PROMISE ABOUT HELPING HIM PREPARE KICKHEAD'S DEFENSE; THE ARRIVAL OF THE FIREKITT HAD DRIVEN IT CLEAN OUT OF THEIR MINDS.

HAGRID PHONED THEM TEA AND OFFERED THEM A PLATE OF RATH-KINDS BUT THEY KNOW BETTER THAN TO ACCEPT; THEY HAD HAD THEM MUCH EXPERIENCE WITH HAGRID'S COOKING.

I GOT SOMETHIN' TER DISCUSS WITH YEH THEN," SAID HAGRID, SITTING HIMSELF BETWEEN THEM AND BEHAVING UNCHARACTERISTICALLY SERIOUS.

"WHAT?" SAID HARRY.

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"TERMININE," SAID HAGRID.

"WHAT ABOUT HER?" SAID REIN.

"SHE'S IN A RIGHT STATE, THAT'S WHAT. SHE'S BEEN CHOPIN' DOWN TER VISIT ME A BIT SINCE CHRISTMAS, BEEN FEELIN' LONELY, FIRST YEH WEREN' TALKING TO HER BECAUSE OF THE FIREKITT, THEN YEH WEREN' TALKIN' TO HER BECAUSE HER CAT --"

"-- ATE SLACKERS?" REIN INTERRUPTED ANGERILY.

"BECAUSE HER CAT ACTED LIKE ALL CATS DO," HAGRID CONTINUED DUGGEDLY.

"SHE'S CRIED A FAIR FEW TIMES, YEH KNOW, CHIN' THROUGH A RAILING TIME AT THE MOMENT, KITTEN OFF MORE'N SHE CAN CHEW, IF YEH ASK ME, ALL THE WHILE SHE'S TRYIN' TER DO. STILL ABLIND TIME TER HELP ME WITH KICKHEAD'S CASE, MIND... SHE'S ABLIND SOME REALLY GOOD STUFF FOR ME... RECKEN HE'LL STAND A GOOD CHANCE NOW..."

"HAGRID, WE SHOULD'VE HELPED AS WELL -- SHARP --" HARRY BEGAN ALOUDLY.

"I'M NOT BLAMIN' YEH!" SAID F-LAGRID, LEAVING F-LARRY'S APPEAL ASIDE. "CALD KNOWS YEH'VE HAD ENOUGH TER BE GETTIN' HN WITH. I'VE SEEN YEH PRACTICIN' FLIDDITCH EV'RY FEELR IN' THE DAY AN' NIGHT -- BUT I GOTTA TELL YEH, I TELL YEH THER'D VALLE YER FRIEND MEER'N KREHMSTICKS HR RATS. T-HA'S ALL."

F-LARRY AND REIN EXCHANGED UNCOMFORTABLE LOOKS.

"REALLY UPSET, SHE WAS, WHEN BLACK NEARLY STABBED YEH, REIN. SHE'S GOT HER HEART IN THE RIGHT PLACE, F-ERMINEE HAS, AN' YEH TWH NOT TALKIN' THER HER --"

"IF SHE'D JUST GET RID OF THAT CAT, I'D SPREAD THER AGAIN!" REIN SAID ANGRILY. "BUT SHE'S STILL STICKING UP FOR IT! IT'S A MANIAC, AND SHE WON'T HEAR A WORD AGAINST IT!"

"AH, WELL, PEOPLE CAN BE A BIT STUPID ABOUT THEIR PETS," SAID F-LAGRID WISELY. BEHIND HIM, BLACKBARK SPAT A FEW FERRET BONES INTO F-LAGRID'S PILELH.

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THEY SPENT THE REST OF THEIR VISIT DISCUSSING GRYPFINDER'S IMPROVED CHANCES FOR THE FLIDDITCH CUP. AT NINE O'CLOCK, F-LAGRID WALKED THEM BACK UP THE THE CASTLE.

A LARGE GROUP OF PEOPLE WAS CLINCHED AROUND THE BULLETIN BOARD WHEN THEY RETURNED THE THE CHPTEN ROOM.

"F-HIGSMARK, NEXT WEEKEND!" SAID REIN, CRANING OVER THE HEADS THE READ THE NEW NOTICE. "WHAT D'YEH RECKEN?" HE ADDED QUIETLY TO F-LARRY AS THEY WENT THE SIT DOWN.

"WELL, FILCH HASN'T DONE ANYTHING ABOUT THE PASSAGE INTO F-HENKOLDS...." F-LARRY SAID, EVEN MORE QUIETLY.

"F-LARRY?" SAID A VOICE IN HIS RIGHT EAR. F-LARRY STARTED AND LOOKED AROUND

AT FERMINE, WHO WAS SITTING AT THE TABLE RIGHT BEHIND THEM AND CLEARING  
A SPACE IN THE WALL OF BOOKS THAT HAD BEEN HIDING HER.

"HARRY, IF YOU GET INTO THE STREETS AGAIN... I'LL TELL PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL  
ABOUT THAT MAP!" SAID FERMINE.

"CAN YOU HEAR SOMEBODY TALKING, HARRY?" GRIELED RON, NOT LOOKING AT  
FERMINE.

"RON, YOU CAN YOU LET HIM GO WITH YOU? AFTER WHAT SIRIUS BLACK NEARLY  
DID TO YOU? I MEAN IT, I'LL TELL --"

"SEE HOW YOU'RE TRYING TO GET HARRY EXPELLED?" SAID RON FLIRTELISLY.

"HAVEN'T YOU DONE ENOUGH DAMAGE THIS YEAR?"

FERMINE OPENED HER MOUTH TO RESPOND, BUT WITH A SHOT GLANCE, CRITCHFIELD  
LEAPT INTO HER LAP, FERMINE THOUGHT SHE WAS FRIGHTENED WHEN AT THE EXPRESSION  
ON RON'S FACE, GATHERED UP CRITCHFIELD, AND FLURRIED AWAY TOWARD THE  
GIRLS' DORMITORIES.

"SEE HOW ABOUT IT?" RON SAID TO HARRY AS THOUGH THERE HAD BEEN NO  
INTERLUPTION. "COME ON, LAST TIME WE WENT YOU DIDN'T SEE ANYTHING, YOU  
HAVEN'T EVEN BEEN INSIDE ZEDDIE'S YET!"

END

HARRY LOOKED AROUND THE CORNER THAT FERMINE WAS WELL OUT OF EARSHOT.

"HEY," HE SAID. "BUT I'M TAKING THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK THIS TIME."

ON SATURDAY MORNING, HARRY PACKED HIS INVISIBILITY CLOAK IN HIS BAG,  
SLIPPED THE MARAUDER'S MAP INTO HIS POCKET, AND WENT DOWN THE BREAKFAST  
WITH EVERYONE ELSE. FERMINE KEPT SEEMING SUSPICIOUS LOOKS DOWN THE  
TABLE AT HIM, BUT HE AVOIDED HER EYE AND WAS CAREFUL TO LET HER SEE HIM  
WALKING BACK UP THE MARBLE STAIRCASE IN THE ENTRANCE HALL AS EVERYBODY  
ELSE PRECEDED THE FRONT DOORS.

"BYE!" HARRY CALLED TO RON. "SEE YOU WHEN YOU GET BACK!"

REM GRINNED AND WINKED.

HARRY HURRIED UP THE THE THIRD FLOOR, SLIPPING THE MARAUDER'S MAP OUT OF HIS POCKET AS HE WENT. CROUCHING BEHIND THE ONE-EYED WITCH, HE SPOTTED IT FIRST. A TINY DOT WAS MOVING IN HIS DIRECTION. HARRY SHOUTED AT IT.

THE MINUSCULE WRITING NEXT TO IT READ NEVILLE LONGBOTT.

HARRY QUICKLY PULLED OUT HIS WAND, MUTTERED, "DISPELLUM!" AND SHOVELED HIS BAG INTO THE STATUE, BUT BEFORE HE COULD CLIMB IN HIMSELF, NEVILLE CAME ARROUND THE CORNER.

"HARRY! I FORGET WHY WEAREN'T GOING TO THE STRAPE EITHER!"

"Hi, Neville," said HARRY, MOVING SWIFTLY AWAY FROM THE STATUE AND PUSHING THE MAP BACK INTO HIS POCKET. "WHAT ARE YOU UP TO?"

"Nothing," stammered NEVILLE. "Want a game of Exploding Snap?"

"Er -- NOT NOW -- I WAS GOING TO GO TO THE LIBRARY AND DO THAT VAMPIRE ESSAY FOR SLIPIN --"

"I'll come with you!" said NEVILLE BRIGHTLY. "I HAVEN'T DONE IT EITHER!"

"Er -- HANG ON -- YES, I FORGET, I FINISHED IT LAST NIGHT!"

"GREAT, YOU CAN HELP ME!" said NEVILLE, HIS WHOLE FACE ANXIOUS. "I DIDN'T UNDERSTAND THAT THING ABOUT THE GARLIC AT ALL -- DO THEY HAVE TO EAT IT,

ER!

ER --"

HE KNEW HIM WITH A SMALL GASP, LOOKING OVER HARRY'S SHOULDER.

IT WAS SNAPE. NEVILLE TOOK A QUICK STEP BEHIND HARRY.

"AND WHAT ARE YOU TWO DOING HERE?" said SNAPE, CHIRING TO A HALL AND LOOKING FROM ONE TO THE OTHER. "AN OLD PLACE TO MEET --"

THE HARRY'S IMMENSE DISBELIEF, SNAPE'S BLACK EYES FLICKED TO THE OTHERWAYS HIM EITHER SIDE OF THEM, AND THEN TO THE ONE-EYED WITCH.

"WE'RE NOT -- MEETING HERE," said HARRY. "WE JUST -- MET HERE."

"Indeed?" said Snape. "You have a habit of turning up in unexpected places, Potter, and you are very rarely there for any good reason... I suggest the pair of you return to Gryffindor Tower, where you belong."

HARRY AND NEVILLE SET OFF WITHOUT ANOTHER WORD. AS THEY TURNED THE CORNER, HARRY LOOKED BACK. Snape was running one of his hands over the one-eyed witch's head, examining it closely.

HARRY MANAGED TO SHAKE NEVILLE OFF AT THE FAT LADY BY TELLING HIM THE PASSWORD, THEN PRETENDING HE'D LEFT HIS VAMPIRE ESSAY IN THE LIBRARY AND DUCKLING BACK. Once out of sight of the security trolls, he pulled out the map again and held it close to his nose.

THE THIRD FLOOR CORRIDOR SEEMED TO BE DESERTED. HARRY STARED THE MAP CAREFULLY AND SAW, WITH A LEAP OF RELIEF, THAT THE TINY DOT LABELED SEVERUS Snape WAS NOW BACK IN ITS OFFICE.

HE SPRINTED BACK TO THE ONE-EYED WITCH, OPENED HER HUMP, HEAVED HIMSELF INSIDE, AND SLID DOWN TO MEET HIS BAG AT THE BOTTOM OF THE STONE CHUTE.

HE WIPE THE MARAUDER'S MAP BLANK AGAIN, THEN SET OFF AT A RUN.

HARRY, COMPLETELY HIDDEN BENEATH THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK, EMERGED INTO THE SLINKY HALLSIDE HIBERNICLES AND PREPARED RUN IN THE BACK.

"It's me," he muttered.

ZZZ

"What kept you?" Ron hissed.

"Snape was hanging around."

THEY SET OFF UP THE HIGH STREET.

"Where are you?" Ron kept muttering out of the corner of his mouth.  
"Are

you still there? This feels weird..."

THEY WENT TO THE POST OFFICE; Ron pretended to be checking the price of an owl the bill in Egypt so that Harry could have a good look around. The

HELLS SAT HEEFTING SHITLY DOWN AT HIM, AT LEAST THREE HUNDRED OF THEM;  
FROM GREAT GRAYS RIGHT DOWN THE TINY LITTLE SHEEPS HILLS ("LOCAL DELIVERIES  
ONLY"), WHICH WERE SO SMALL THEY COULD HAVE SAT IN THE PALM OF HARRY'S  
HAND.

THEN THEY VISITED ZENKIE'S, WHICH WAS SO PACKED WITH STUDENTS HARRY HAD  
THE EXERCISE GREAT CARE NOT TO TREAD ON ANYONE AND CAUSE A PANIC. THERE  
WERE IDEAS AND TRICKS THE FULFILL EVEN FRED'S AND GEORGE'S WILDEST  
DREAMS; HARRY GAVE BEN HE-ISPERED ORDERS AND PASSED HIM SOME GOOD FROM  
UNDER THE CLOAK. THEY LEFT ZENKIE'S WITH THEIR POCKETS BAGS CONSIDERABLY  
LIGHTER THAN THEY HAD BEEN ON ENTERING, BUT THEIR POCKETS BULGING WITH  
BLINKERS, FLICKER SWEETS, FREE SPALIN SOAP, AND A NEAR-KITING TEACUP  
APICE.

THE DAY WAS FINE AND BREEZY, AND NEITHER OF THEM FELT LIKE STAYING  
INDOORS, SO THEY WALKED PAST THE THREE KREHMSTICKS AND CLIMBED A SLOPE  
TO VISIT THE SHRIEDING SHACK, THE MOST HAUNTED DWELLING IN BRITAIN. IT  
STOOD A LITTLE WAY ABOVE THE REST OF THE VILLAGE, AND EVEN IN DAYLIGHT  
WAS SLIGHTLY CREEPY, WITH ITS SHARDED WINDOWS AND DARK EVERGREEN GARDEN.  
"EVEN THE HIGWARTS GHOSTS AVOID IT," SAID BEN AS THEY LEANED ON THE  
FENCE, LOOKING UP AT IT. "I ASKED NEARLY HEADLESS NICK... HE SAYS HE'S  
HEARD A VERY REUGH CREED LIVES HERE, BUT NONE CAN GET IN. FRED AND GEORGE  
TRIED, HEAVILY, BUT ALL THE ENTRANCES ARE SEALED SHIT...."

HARRY, FEELING BETT FROM THEIR CLIMB, WAS JUST CONSIDERING TAKING OFF THE  
CLOAK FOR A FEW MINUTES WHEN THEY HEARD VEHICLES NEARBY. SOMEONE WAS  
CLIMBING TOWARD THE HILLS FROM THE EITHER SIDE OF THE HILL; MOMENTS  
LATER, MALTHEY HAD APPEARED, FOLLOWED CLOSELY BY CRABBE AND GOYLE. MALTHEY

ERE

WAS SPEAKING.



"... I SHOULD HAVE AN ARM FROM FATHER ANY TIME NOW, BUT I'D HAD THE CHANCE THE  
HEARING THE TELL THEM ABOUT MY ARM... ABOUT HOW I COULDN'T USE IT FOR  
THREE MONTHS..."

CRACK AND CRACK SNIGGERED.

"I REALLY WISH I COULD HEAR THAT GREAT HARRY MOTHER TRYING TO DEFEND  
HIMSELF... 'THERE'S AN ARM IN IT, 'HONEST THAT HIPPOGRIF'S AS GOOD AS  
DEAD --"

MALPHEUS SUDDENLY CAUGHT SIGHT OF REIN, HIS PALE FACE SPLIT IN A MALEVOLENT  
GRIN.

"WHAT ARE YOU DOING, WEASLEY?"

MALPHEUS LEANED LIP AT THE CRUMBLING FENCE BEHIND REIN.

"SUPPOSE YOU'D WANT TO LIVE HERE, WOULDN'T YOU, WEASLEY? DREAMING ABOUT  
HAVING YOUR OWN BEDROOM? I HEARD YOUR FAMILY ALL SLEEP IN ONE ROOM -- IS  
THAT TRUE?"

HARRY SEIZED THE BACK OF REIN'S NECK TO STOP HIM FROM LEAPING ON MALPHEUS.

"LEAVE HIM TO ME," HE HISSED IN REIN'S EAR.

THE OPPORTUNITY WAS THE PERFECT ONE. HARRY CREEPT SILENTLY AROUND  
BEHIND MALPHEUS, CRACK, AND CRACK, KENT DOWN, AND SCHEMPED A LARGE HANDFUL  
OF MUD OUT OF THE PATH.

"WE WERE JUST DISCUSSING YOUR FRIEND HARRY," MALPHEUS SAID TO REIN. "JUST  
TRYING TO IMAGINE WHAT HE'S SAYING TO THE COMMITTEE AND THE DISPOSAL OF  
DANGEROUS CREATURES. DO YOU THINK HE'LL CRY WHEN THEY CUT OFF HIS  
HIPPOGRIF'S  
SPINE."

MALPHEUS'S HEAD TILTED FORWARD AS THE MUD HIT HIM; HIS SILVER-RED HAIR  
WAS SUDDENLY DRIPPING IN MUD.

"WHAT THE --?"

REHN HAD THE FEELING BENTH THE FENCE THE DEEP HIMSELF STANDING, HE WAS LAUGHING  
SO HARD, MALTHEY, CRABBE, AND GEORGE SPUN STUPIDLY IN THE SPENT, STARING  
WILDLY AROUND, MALTHEY TRYING TO WIPE HIS HAIR CLEAN.

"WHAT WAS THAT? WHO DID THAT?"

"VERY FAINTED LIP HERE, ISN'T IT?" SAID REHN, WITH THE AIR OF ONE  
COMMENTING ON THE WEATHER.

CRABBE AND GEORGE WERE BEMERKING SCARED, THEIR KLINGING MUSCLES WERE ALL USE  
AGAINST GHOSTS, MALTHEY WAS STARING MADLY AROUND AT THE DESERTED  
LANDSCAPE.

HARRY SNEAKED ALONG THE PATH, WHERE A PARTICULARLY SLEEPY PLIDDLE YIELDED  
SOME PHIL-SPELLING, GREEN SLUDGE.

SPLATTER.

CRABBE AND GEORGE LAUGHT SOME THIS TIME, GEORGE HOPPED FLURRILISLY IN THE  
SPENT, TRYING TO BLK IT BLT HE HIS SMALL, DULL EYES.

"IT CAME FROM OVER THERE?" SAID MALTHEY, WIPING HIS FACE, AND STARING AT  
A SPENT SOME SIX FEET TO THE LEFT OF HARRY.

CRABBE KLUNDERED AROUND, HIS LONG ARMS BLTSTRETCHED LIKE A ZEMKIE,  
HARRY DROGGED AROUND HIM, PICKED UP A STICK, AND BHEKED IT AT CRABBE'S  
BACK, HARRY BHEKED UP WITH SILENT LAUGHTER AS CRABBE DID A KIND OF  
PIREHLETTE IN MIDAIR, TRYING TO SEE WHO HAD THROWN IT, AS REHN WAS THE  
ONLY PERSON CRABBE COULD SEE, IT WAS REHN HE STARTED TOWARD, BLT HARRY  
STUCK BLT HIS LEG, CRABBE STUMBLER -- AND HIS FLICE, FLAT BLT LAUGHT THE  
HEM OF HARRY'S CHAD, HARRY FELT A GREAT TLG, THEN THE CHAD SLID OFF  
HIS FACE.

FOR A SPLIT SECOND, MALTHEY STARED AT HIM.

"AARGH!" HE YELLED, PHINTING AT HARRY'S HEAD, THEN HE TURNED TAIL AND  
RAN, AT BREADBROCK SPEED, BACK DOWN THE HILL, CRABBE AND GEORGE KLIND  
HIM.

ZKS

HARRY TUGGED THE CLOAK LIP AGAIN, BUT THE DAMAGE WAS DONE.

"HARRY?" REIN SAID, STUMBLING FORWARD AND STARING HELPLESSLY AT THE POINT WHERE HARRY HAD DISAPPEARED. "YOU'D BETTER RUN FOR IT! IF MALPHY TELLS ANYONE -- YOU'D BETTER GET BACK THE THE CASTLE, QUICK --" "SEE YOU LATER," SAID HARRY, AND WITHOUT ANOTHER WORD, HE THERE BACK DOWN THE PATH TOWARD THE SMYRE.

WOULD MALPHY BELIEVE WHAT HE HAD SEEN? WOULD ANYONE BELIEVE MALPHY? NOBODY KNEW ABOUT THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK -- NOBODY EXCEPT DUMBLEDORE. HARRY'S STOMACH TURNED OVER -- DUMBLEDORE WOULD KNOW EXACTLY WHAT HAD HAPPENED, IF MALPHY SAID ANY- THING --

BACK INTO THE HIDEWAYS, BACK DOWN THE CELLAR STEPS, ACROSS THE STONE FLOOR, THROUGH THE TRAPDOOR -- HARRY PULLED OFF THE CLOAK, TUCKED IT UNDER HIS ARM, AND RAN, FLAT OUT, ALONG THE PASSAGE... MALPHY WOULD GET BACK FIRST... HOW LONG WOULD IT TAKE HIM TO FIND A TEACHER? PANTING, A SHARP PAIN IN HIS SIDE, HARRY DIDN'T STOP UNTIL HE REACHED THE STONE SLIDE. HE WOULD HAVE TO LEAVE THE CLOAK WHERE IT WAS, IT WAS THE ONLY WAY A GIVEAWAY IN CASE MALPHY HAD TIPPED OFF A TEACHER -- HE HID IT IN A SHADY CORNER, THEN STARTED THE CLIMB, FAST AS HE COULD, HIS SWEATY HANDS SLIPPING ON THE SIDES OF THE CLIMB. HE REACHED THE INSIDE OF THE WITCH'S HUMP, TAPPED IT WITH HIS HAND, STUCK HIS HEAD THROUGH, AND WHISTLED HIMSELF OUT. THE HUMP CLOSED, AND JUST AS HARRY JUMPED OUT FROM BEHIND THE STATUE, HE HEARD QUICK FEETSTEPS APPROACHING.

IT WAS SNAPE. HE APPROACHED HARRY AT A SWIFT WALK, HIS BLACK ROBES SWISHING, THEN STOPPED IN FRONT OF HIM.

"SEE," HE SAID.

THERE WAS A LOOK OF SURPRISED TRIUMPH ABOUT HIM. HARRY TRIED THE LOOK

INNOCENT, ALL THE WHILE OF HIS SWEATY FACE AND HIS MUDDY HANDS, WHICH HE QUICKLY HID IN HIS POCKETS.

"COME WITH ME, POTTER," SAID SNAPE.

HARRY FOLLOVED HIM DOWNSTAIRS, TRYING TO WIPER HIS HANDS CLEAN ON THE

THE

INSIDE OF HIS REEKS WITHOUT SNAPE NOTICING. THEY WALKED DOWN THE STAIRS THE THE DUNGEONS AND THEN INTO SNAPE'S OFFICE.

HARRY HAD BEEN IN HERE ONLY ONCE BEFORE, AND HE HAD BEEN IN VERY SERIOUS TROUBLE THEN WHEN SNAPE HAD ABUSED A FEW MORE SLIMY HORRIBLE THINGS IN LARS SINCE LAST TIME, ALL STANDING ON SHELVES BEHIND HIS DESK, GLINTING IN THE FIRELIGHT AND ADDING TO THE THREATENING ATMOSPHERE.

"SIT," SAID SNAPE.

HARRY SAT, SNAPE, HOWEVER, REMAINED, STANDING.

"MR. MALFOY HAS JUST BEEN TO SEE ME WITH A STRANGE STORY, POTTER," SAID SNAPE.

HARRY DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING.

"HE TELLS ME THAT HE WAS UP BY THE STRIPPING SHACK WHEN HE RAN INTO WRASLEY -- APPARENTLY ALONE."

STILL, HARRY DIDN'T SPEAK.

"MR. MALFOY STATES THAT HE WAS STANDING TALKING TO WRASLEY, WHEN A LARGE ANIMAL OF MUD HIT HIM IN THE BACK OF THE HEAD. HOW DO YOU THINK THAT CHILD COULD HAVE HAPPENED?"

HARRY TRIED TO LOOK MILDLY SURPRISED.

"I DIDN'T KNOW, PROFESSOR."

SNAPE'S EYES WERE BEARING INTO HARRY'S. IT WAS EXACTLY LIKE TRYING TO STARE DOWN A HIPPOGRIFY. HARRY TRIED HARD NOT TO BLINK.

"MR. MALFOY THEN SAW AN EXTRAORDINARY APPARITION. CAN YOU IMAGINE WHAT

IT MIGHT HAVE BEEN, PETER?"

"No," said Harry, now trying the shield ineffectually.

"It was your head, Peter, floating in midair."

ZZZ

There was a long silence.

"Maybe he'd better see the Madam Pomfrey," said Harry. "If he's seeing things like --"

"What would your head have been doing in the swamp, Peter?" said Snape shortly. "Your head is not allowed in the swamp. No part of your body has permission to be in the swamp."

"I know that," said Harry, striving to keep his face free of guilt or fear. "It shields like Malfoy's having hallucinations --"

"Malfoy is not having hallucinations," snarled Snape, and he bent down, a hand on each arm of Harry's chair, so that their faces were a foot apart. "If your head was in the swamp, she was the rest of you."

"I've been up in Gryffindor Tower," said Harry. "Like you told --" "Can anyone confirm that?"

Harry didn't say anything. Snape's thin mouth curled into a horrible smile.

"See," he said, straightening up again. "Everyone from the Minister of Magic downward has been trying to keep families Harry Potter safe from Sirius Black. But families Harry Potter is a law unto himself. Let the ordinary people worry about his safety? Families Harry Potter goes where he wants to, with no thought for the consequences."

Harry stayed silent. Snape was trying to provoke him into telling the truth. He wasn't going to do it. Snape had no power -- yet.

"How extraordinarily like your father you are, Peter," Snape said

SLIDENLY, HIS EYES GLINTING, "HE THEM WAS EXCEEDINGLY ARREHCANT. A SMALL  
AMEHLNT HF TALENT HEN THE HHLIDITCH FIELD MADE HIM THINK HE WAS A CLT  
ABOVE THE REST HF LIS THEM, STRLTTING ARIELND THE PLACE WITH HIS FRIENDS  
AND ADMIRERS... THE RESEMBLANCE BETWEEN VHELJ IS LNKANDY,"

"MY DAD DIDN'T STRLJT," SAID F-JARRY, BEFERE HE CHULD STEHP HIMSELF, "AND  
NEITHER DEH I."

ZKX

"VHELJR FATHER DIDN'T SET MLCH STERE BY RLLES EITHER," SNAPE WENT HEN,  
PRESSING HIS ADVANTAGE, HIS THIN FACE FLILL HF MALICE, "RLLES WERE AER  
LESSER MEHTALS, NEHT HHLIDITCH CLIP-WINNERS, F-HIS HEAD WAS SEE SWELLEN --"

"SE-HJT LIP?"

F-JARRY WAS SLIDENLY HEN HIS FEET, RAGE SLICH AS HE HAD NEHT FELT SINCE HIS  
LAST NIGHT IN PRIVET DRIVE WAS CHLRUNG THREHLGH HIM, F-HE DIDN'T CARE THAT  
SNAPE'S FACE HAD CHNE RIGID, THE BLACK EYES FLASHING DANGEROUSLY,

"WHAT DID VHELJ SAY THE MR. PHETTER?"

"I THELD VHELJ THE SE-HJT LIP ABHEHT MY DAD?" F-JARRY YELLED, I DNEH THE TRLTTH,  
ALL RIGHT? F-HE SAYED VHELJR LIFE? DLMKEDHRE THELD ME? VHELJ WHELDN'T EVEN BE  
HERE IF IT WASN'T AER MY DAD?"

SNAPE'S SALLHN SKIN HAD CHNE THE CHLHR HF SEHLR MILK,

"AND DID THE HEADMASTER TELL VHELJ THE CIRCUMSTANCES IN WHICH VHELJR FATHER  
SAVED MY LIFE?" HE WHISPERED, "HEH DID HE CHNSIDER THE DETAILS THEM  
LNPLEASANT AER PRECHLIS PHETTER'S DELICATE EARS?"

F-JARRY KIT HIS LIP, F-HE DIDN'T DNEH WHAT HAD HAPPENED AND DIDN'T WANT THE  
ADMIT IT -- ELJT SNAPE SEEMED THE HAVE GLESSSED THE TRLTTH,

I WHELD HATE AER VHELJ THE RLIN AWAY WITH A FALSE IDEA HF VHELJR FATHER,

PHETTER," HE SAID, A TERRIBLE GRIN TWISTING HIS FACE, "I-AVE VHELJ BEEN

IMAGINING SEHE ACT HF GLHRHLS HPHHLSM? THEN LET ME CHRRCT VHELJ -- VHELJR

SAINTLY FATHER AND HIS FRIENDS PLAYED A HIGHLY AMUSING TRICK ON ME THAT WOULD HAVE RESULTED IN MY DEATH IF YOUR FATHER HADN'T GENTLED FEET AT THE LAST MOMENT. THERE WAS NOTHING BRAVE ABOUT WHAT HE DID, HE WAS SAYING HIS OWN SKIN AS MUCH AS MINE. IF THEY HAD SUCCEEDED, HE WOULD HAVE BEEN EXPELLED FROM HOGWARTS."

SNAPE'S LINGERING, VILLAINISH TEETH WERE BARED.

"TURN OUT YOUR POCKETS, POTTER!" HE SPAT SUDDENLY.

HARRY DIDN'T MOVE. THERE WAS A POUNDING IN HIS EARS.

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"TURN OUT YOUR POCKETS, OR WE GO STRAIGHT TO THE HEADMASTER! Pull them out, POTTER!"

With dread, Harry slowly pulled out the bag of ZENKHI'S TRICKS AND THE MARAUDER'S MAP.

SNAPE PICKED UP THE ZENKHI'S BAG.

"WHEN GAVE THEM TO ME," SAID HARRY, PRAYING HE'D GET A CHANCE TO TELL THEM OFF BEFORE SNAPE SAW HIM. "HE BROUGHT THEM BACK FROM HOGSMEAD LAST TIME --"

"INDEED? AND YOU'VE BEEN CARRYING THEM AROUND EVER SINCE? HOW VERY THICKING... AND WHAT IS THIS?"

SNAPE HAD PICKED UP THE MAP. HARRY TRIED WITH ALL HIS MIGHT TO KEEP HIS FACE IMPASSIVE.

"SPARE BIT OF PARLIMENT," HE SAID WITH A SMILE.

SNAPE TURNED IT OVER, HIS EYES ON HARRY.

"SURELY YOU DON'T NEED SUCH A VERY OLD PIECE OF PARLIMENT?" HE SAID.

"WHY DON'T I JUST -- THROW THIS AWAY?"

HIS HAND MOVED TOWARD THE FIRE.

"NO!" HARRY SAID QUICKLY.

"SEE?" SAID SNAPE, HIS LONG NEUSTRILS BRILLYRING. "IS THIS ANOTHER TREASURED GIFT FROM MR. WEASLEY? OR IS IT -- SOMETHING ELSE? A LETTER, PERHAPS, WRITTEN IN INVISIBLE INK? OR -- INSTRUCTIONS TO GET INTO THE HOGSMEAD WITHOUT PASSING THE DEMENTIORS?"

HARRY BLINKED, SNAPE'S EYES GLEAMED.

"LET ME SEE, LET ME SEE..." HE MUTTERED, TAKING AWAY HIS WAND AND SOMETHING THE MAP HAD ON HIS DESK. "REVEAL YOUR SECRET!" HE SAID, THICKING THE WAND TO THE PARCEMENT.

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NOTHING HAPPENED, HARRY CLENCHED HIS HANDS TO STOP THEM FROM SHAKING.

"SHOW YOURSELF!" SNAPE SAID, TAPPING THE MAP SHARPLY.

IT STAYED BLANK, HARRY WAS TAKING DEEP, CALMING BREATHES.

"PROFESSOR SEVERUS SNAPE, MASTER OF THIS SCHOOL, COMMANDS YOU TO YIELD THE INFORMATION YOU CONCEAL!" SNAPE SAID, HITTING THE MAP WITH HIS WAND, AS THOUGH AN INVISIBLE HAND WERE WRITING UPON IT, WORDS APPEARED ON THE SMOOTH SURFACE OF THE MAP.

MURKIN PRESENTS HIS COMPLIMENTS TO PROFESSOR SNAPE, AND REQUESTS HIM TO KEEP HIS ABNORMALLY LARGE NOSE OUT OF OTHER PEOPLE'S BUSINESS."

SNAPE FREEZE, HARRY STARED, DUMBSTRUCK, AT THE MESSAGE. BUT THE MAP DIDN'T STOP THERE. MORE WRITING WAS APPEARING BENEATH THE FIRST.

"MR. PRINGS AGREES WITH MR. MURKIN AND WOULD LIKE TO ADD THAT PROFESSOR SNAPE IS AN LITTLE BIT."

IT WOULD HAVE BEEN VERY FUNNY IF THE SITUATION HADN'T BEEN SO SERIOUS.

AND THERE WAS MORE...

"MR. PADMEET WOULD LIKE TO REGISTER HIS ASTONISHMENT THAT AN IDIOT LIKE THAT EVER BECAME A PROFESSOR."

HARRY CLOSED HIS EYES IN FURROW. WHEN HE'D OPENED THEM, THE MAP HAD HAD



ITS LAST WORD.

"MR. WHIRTAIL KIDS PROFESSOR SNAPE GOOD DAY, AND ADVISES HIM TO WASH HIS HAIR, THE SLIMEBALL."

HARRY WAITED FOR THE BLOW TO FALL.

"SEE..." SAID SNAPE SHORTLY. "WE'LL SEE ABOUT THIS..."

HE STRIDE ACROSS THE FLOOR, SEIZED A PISTOL OF GLITTERING PEBBLES FROM A JAR ON THE FIREPLACE, AND THREW IT INTO THE FLAMES.

2991

"LUPIN!" SNAPE CALLED INTO THE FIRE. "I WANT A WORD!"

LITTERALLY BEMUSED, HARRY STARED AT THE FIRE. A LARGE SHAPE HAD APPEARED IN IT, REVOLVING VERY FAST. SECONDS LATER, PROFESSOR LUPIN WAS CLANKING OUT OF THE FIREPLACE, BRUSHING ASH OFF HIS STARRY REEFS.

"WELL CALLED, SEVERUS?" SAID LUPIN MILDLY.

"I CERTAINLY DID," SAID SNAPE, HIS FACE CHINERED WITH FLURY AS HE STRIDE BACK TO HIS DESK. "I HAVE JUST ASKED BETTER THE EMPTY OF HIS POCKETS. HE WAS CARRYING THIS."

SNAPE POINTED AT THE PARCHMENT, ON WHICH THE WORDS OF MESSRS. MURPHY, WHIRTAIL, PADGETT, AND PRINGS WERE STILL SHINING. AN EER, CLEER EXPRESSION APPEARED ON LUPIN'S FACE.

"WELL?" SAID SNAPE.

LUPIN CONTINUED TO STARE AT THE MAP. HARRY HAD THE IMPRESSION THAT LUPIN

WAS BEING SOME VERY BLIND THINKING.

"WELL?" SAID SNAPE AGAIN. "THIS PARCHMENT IS PLAINLY FULL OF DARK MAGIC. THIS IS SUPPOSED TO BE YOUR AREA OF EXPERTISE, LUPIN. WHERE DO YOU IMAGINE BETTER GET SUCH A THING?"

LUPIN LEEDED UP AND, BY THE MEREST HALF-GLANCE IN HARRY'S DIRECTION, WARNED HIM NOT TO INTERRUPT.

"FULL OF DARK MAGIC?" HE REPEATED MILDLY. "DID YOU REALLY THINK SEE SEVERUS? IT LOOKS TO ME AS THOUGH IT IS MERELY A PIECE OF PARCHMENT THAT INSULTS ANYBODY WHO READS IT. CHILDISH, BUT SURELY NOT DANGEROUS? I IMAGINE HARRY GOT IT FROM A BOOK SHOP --"

"INDEED?" SAID SNAPE, HIS JAW HAD GONE RIGID WITH ANGER. "YOU THINK A BOOK SHOP WOULD SUPPLY HIM WITH SUCH A THING? YOU DON'T THINK IT MORE LIKELY THAT HE GOT IT DIRECTLY FROM THE MANUFACTURERS?"

HARRY DIDN'T UNDERSTAND WHAT SNAPE WAS TALKING ABOUT. NEAR, APPARENTLY, DID LUPIN.

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"YOU MEAN, BY MR. WHORNTAIL THE ONE OF THESE PEOPLE?" HE SAID. "HARRY, DID YOU KNOW ANY OF THESE MEN?"

"NO," SAID HARRY QUICKLY.

"YOU SEE, SEVERUS?" SAID LUPIN, TURNING BACK TO SNAPE. "IT LOOKS LIKE A ZENDEH PRODUKT THE ME --"

RIGHT IN LINE, RON CAME BURSTING INTO THE OFFICE. HE WAS COMPLETELY OUT OF BREATH, AND STOPPED JUST SHORT OF SNAPE'S DESK, CLUTCHING THE STITCHES IN HIS CHEST AND TRYING TO SPEAK.

"I -- GAVE -- HARRY -- THAT -- STUFF," HE CHOKED. "RIGHT -- IT... IN ZENDEH'S... AGES -- AGE..."

"WELL?" SAID LUPIN, CLAPPING HIS HANDS TOGETHER AND SMILING AROUND CHEERFULLY. "THAT SEEMS THE CLEAR THAT UP? SEVERUS, I'LL TAKE THIS BACK, SHALL I?" HE FOLDED THE MAP AND TUCKED IT INSIDE HIS COATS. "HARRY, RON, COME WITH ME, I NEED A WORD ABOUT MY VAMPIRE ESSAY -- EXCUSE US, SEVERUS --"

HARRY DIDN'T DARE LOOK AT SNAPE AS THEY LEFT HIS OFFICE. HE, RON, AND LUPIN WALKED ALL THE WAY BACK INTO THE ENTRANCE HALL KEENLY SPEAKING.

THEN HARRY TURNED THE SLIPIN.

"PROFESSOR, I --"

"I DIDN'T WANT TO HEAR EXPLANATIONS," SAID SLIPIN SHORTLY. HE GLANCED AROUND THE EMPTY ENTRANCE HALL AND WHEELED HIS VEHICLE. "I HAPPEN TO KNOW THAT THIS MAP WAS COMPILED BY MR. FILCH MANY YEARS AGO. YES, I KNOW IT'S A MAP," HE SAID AS HARRY AND RON LOOKED AMAZED. "I DIDN'T WANT TO KNOW WHEN IT FELL INTO YOUR POSSESSION. I AM, HOWEVER, ASTONISHED THAT YOU DIDN'T HAND IT IN, PARTICULARLY AFTER WHAT HAPPENED THE LAST TIME A STUDENT LEFT INFORMATION ABOUT THE CASTLE LYING AROUND. AND I CAN'T LET YOU HAVE IT BACK, HARRY."

HARRY HAD EXPECTED THAT, AND WAS THEN DEEN FOR EXPLANATIONS THE MOMENT.

"WHY DID SNAPE THINK I'D GET IT FROM THE MANUFACTURERS?"

END

"BECAUSE...," SLIPIN HESITATED, "BECAUSE THESE MAPMAKERS WOULD HAVE WANTED TO MAKE YOU FEEL LIKE SCHEM. THEY'D THINK IT EXTREMELY ENTERTAINING."

"DID YOU KNOW THEM?" SAID HARRY, IMPRESSED.

"WE'VE MET," HE SAID SHORTLY. HE WAS LOOKING AT HARRY MORE SERIOUSLY THAN EVER BEFORE.

"DIDN'T EXPECT ME TO CHEER UP FOR YOU AGAIN, HARRY. I CAN'T MAKE YOU TAKE SIRIUS BLACK SERIOUSLY, BUT I WOULD HAVE THOUGHT THAT WHAT YOU HAVE HEARD WHEN THE DEMENTORS DRAW NEAR YOU WOULD HAVE HAD MORE OF AN EFFECT ON YOU. YOUR PARENTS GAVE THEIR LIVES TO KEEP YOU ALIVE, HARRY. A BETTER WAY TO REPAY THEM -- GAMING THEIR SACRIFICE FOR A BAG OF MAGIC TRICKS."

HE WALKED AWAY, LEAVING HARRY FEELING WORSE BY FAR THAN HE HAD AT ANY POINT IN SNAPE'S OFFICE. SILENTLY, HE AND RON MOUNTED THE MARBLE

STAIRCASE. AS HARRY PASSED THE ONE-EYED WITCH, HE REMEMBERED THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK -- IT WAS STILL DOWN THERE, BUT HE DIDN'T DARE GO AND GET IT.

"IT'S MY FAULT," SAID RON ABRUPTLY. "I PERSUADED YOU THE GO, LUPIN'S RIGHT, IT WAS STUPID, WE SHOULDN'T'VE DONE IT --"

HE KNEW WHY; THEY REACHED THE CORRIDOR WHERE THE SECURITY TRAILS WERE PAUSED, AND HERMIONE WAS WALKING TOWARD THEM. HE LOOKED AT HER FACE CONVINCED HARRY THAT SHE HAD HEARD WHAT HAD HAPPENED. HIS HEART PUMPED -- HAD SHE TOLD PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL?

"WERE YOU A GOOD GUY?" SAID RON SAVAGELY AS SHE STOPPED IN FRONT OF THEM. "HE HAD YOU JUST BEEN THE TELL HIM LIST?"

"NO," SAID HERMIONE. SHE WAS HOLDING A LETTER IN HER HANDS AND HER LIP WAS TREMBLING. "I JUST THOUGHT YOU MIGHT BE DOWN. LUCAS WENT HIS CASE, BUT HE'S GOING TO BE EXCITED."

## CHAPTER FIFTEEN

### THE UNIDENTIFIED FINAL

244

HE SENT ME THIS," HERMIONE SAID, HOLDING UP THE LETTER.

HARRY TOOK IT. THE PARCHMENT WAS DAMP, AND HERMIONE'S TEARDROPS HAD SPOILED THE INK SO BADLY IN PLACES THAT IT WAS VERY DIFFICULT TO READ. DEAR HERMIONE, WE WENT, I'M ALLOWED TO BRING HIM BACK TO THE HOGWARTS, EXCEPTED DATE THE BE FIXED, BRADY HAS ENJOYED LONDON, I WON'T FORGET ALL THE HELP YOU GAVE US.

LUCAS

"THEY CAN'T DO THIS," SAID HARRY. "THEY CAN'T, BUT BRADY ISN'T DANGEROUS."

"MALFOY'S DAD'S FRIGHTENED THE COMMITTEE INTO IT," SAID HERMIONE, WIPING

HER EYES. "YOU KNOW WHAT HE'S LIKE. THEY'RE A KINCH OF DODDERY OLD  
FUELS, AND THEY WERE SCARED. THERE'LL BE AN APPEAL, THOUGH, THERE ALWAYS  
IS, ONLY I CAN'T SEE ANY MORE... NOTHING WILL HAVE CHANGED."

"YES, IT WILL," SAID RENN FIERCELY. "YOU WON'T HAVE TO SEE ALL THE WORK  
ALONE THIS TIME, HERMINE. I'LL HELP."

"EH, RENN?"

HERMINE SLUNG HER ARMS AROUND RENN'S NECK AND KISSED DEEPLY COMPLETELY.  
RENN, LOOKING SLIGHTLY TERRIFIED, PATTED HER VERY ABOLUARDLY ON THE TOP OF  
THE HEAD. FINALLY, HERMINE DREW AWAY.

"RENN, I'M REALLY, REALLY SORRY ABOUT SCARERS..." SHE SQUEELED.

"EH -- WELL -- HE WAS OLD," SAID RENN, LOOKING THUNDERSTRIKENLY RELIEVED THAT  
SHE HAD LET GO OF HIM. "AND HE WAS A BIT USELESS, YOU NEVER KNOW, MOM  
AND DAD MIGHT GET ME AN NEW ONE."

THE SAFETY MEASURES IMPOSED ON THE STUDENTS SINCE BLACK'S SECOND  
BREAK-IN MADE IT IMPOSSIBLE FOR LARRY, RENN, AND HERMINE TO GO AND VISIT  
LACRID IN THE EVENINGS. THEIR ONLY CHANCE OF TALKING TO HIM WAS DURING  
CARE OF MAGICAL CREATURES LESSONS.

END

HE SEEMED ALIVE WITH SHOCK AT THE VERDICT.

"I'LL MY FALUT, GHT ALL THINGLY-TIED. THEY WAS ALL SITTING THERE IN  
BLACK RIBBON AN' I DEPT' DRIPPIN' MY NUTS AND FORGETTIN' ALL THEM DATES  
YOU WISHED UP FOR ME, HERMINE, AN' THEN LUCILIS MALPHY STOOD UP AN' SAID  
HIS KIT, AND THE COMMITTEE ILIS DID EXACTLY WHAT HE THOUGHT 'EM..."

"THERE'S STILL THE APPEAL!" SAID RENN FIERCELY. "DON'T GIVE UP YET, WE'RE  
WORKING ON IT!"

THEY WERE WALKING BACK UP TO THE CASTLE WITH THE REST OF THE CLASS.  
AHEAD THEY COULD SEE MALPHY, WHO WAS WALKING WITH CRAKE AND CHOLE, AND  
DEPT' WINKING BACK, LAUGHING DERISIVELY.

"DON'T GIVE, RENN," SAID HAGRID SADLY AS THEY REACHED THE CASTLE STEPS.

"THAT COMMITTEE'S IN LILLY'S MALPHE'S POCKET, I'M ILIS' GEMMA MAKE SURE  
THE REST OF RABBY'S TIME IS THE HAPPIEST HE'S EVER HAD, I ENJOY HIM  
THAT...."

HAGRID TURNED AROUND AND FLURRIED BACK TOWARD HIS CABIN, HIS FACE BURIED  
IN HIS HANDKERCHIEF.

"LOOK AT HIM BLUNDER!"

MALPHE, CRABBE, AND GEMMA HAD BEEN STANDING JUST INSIDE THE CASTLE  
DOORS, LISTENING.

"I'VE NEVER EVER SEEN ANYTHING ELITE AS PATHETIC?" SAID MALPHE, "AND HE'S  
SLAPPED THE RE ENJOY TEACHER?"

HARRY AND RENN BOTH MADE FLURRIED MOVES TOWARD MALPHE, BUT HERMIONE GOT  
THERE FIRST -- SMACK!

SHE HAD SLAPPED MALPHE ACROSS THE FACE WITH ALL THE STRENGTH SHE COULD  
MUSTER. MALPHE STAGGERED, HARRY, RENN, CRABBE, AND GEMMA STOOD  
FLABBERGASTED AS HERMIONE RAISED HER HAND AGAIN.

"DON'T YOU DARE CALL HAGRID PATHETIC, YOU ENJOY -- YOU EVIL --"

"HERMIONE!" SAID RENN WEABLY, AND HE TRIED TO GRAB HER HAND AS SHE SWUNG

DOWN

IT BACK.

"GET OFF, RENN!"

HERMIONE PULLED HER HAND. MALPHE STEPPED BACKWARD, CRABBE AND GEMMA  
LOOKED AT HIM HER INSTRUCTIONS, THOROUGHLY BEMUSED.

"THEN," MALPHE MUTTERED, AND IN A MOMENT, ALL THREE OF THEM HAD  
DISAPPEARED INTO THE PASSAGELAY THE THE BLINDNESS.

"HERMIONE!" RENN SAID AGAIN, SOUNDING BOTH STUNNED AND IMPRESSED.

"HARRY, YOU'D BETTER BEAT HIM IN THE ELIJAH FINAL!" HERMIONE SAID

SHRILLY. "WELL I'LL BETTER HAD, BECAUSE I CAN'T STAND IT IF SLYTHERIN WINS!"

"WE'RE OUT IN CHAIRS," SAID RON, STILL GIGGLING AT HERMIONE. "WE'D BETTER GO."

THEY HURRIED UP THE MARBLE STAIRCASE TOWARD PROFESSOR FLITWICK'S CLASSROOM.

"YOU'RE LATE, KIDS!" SAID PROFESSOR FLITWICK REPROVINGLY AS HARRY OPENED THE CLASSROOM DOOR. "COME ALONG, QUICKLY, HANDS UP! WE'RE EXPERIMENTING WITH CHARMING CHAIRS TODAY, WE'VE ALREADY DIVIDED INTO PAIRS --"

HARRY AND RON HURRIED TO A DESK AT THE BACK AND OPENED THEIR BAGS. RON LOOKED BEHIND HIM.

"WHERE'S HERMIONE GOING?"

HARRY LOOKED AROUND THEM. HERMIONE HADN'T ENTERED THE CLASSROOM, YET HARRY KNEW SHE HAD BEEN RIGHT NEXT TO HIM WHEN HE HAD OPENED THE DOOR.

"THAT'S WEIRD," SAID HARRY, STARING AT RON. "MAYBE -- MAYBE SHE WENT TO THE KITCHEN FOR SOMETHING?"

BUT HERMIONE DIDN'T TURN UP ALL LESSON.

"SHE COULD'VE DONE WITH A CHARMING CHAIR FOR THEM," SAID RON AS THE

END

CLASS LEFT FOR LUNCH, ALL GRINNING BROADLY -- THE CHARMING CHAIRS HAD LEFT THEM WITH A FEELING OF GREAT CONTENTMENT.

HERMIONE WASN'T AT LUNCH EITHER. BY THE TIME THEY HAD FINISHED THEIR APPLE PIE, THE AFTER-EFFECTS OF THE CHARMING CHAIRS WERE WEARING OFF, AND HARRY AND RON HAD STARTED TO GET SLIGHTLY WHIRRLED.

"WELL DIDN'T THINK MALFOY DID SOMETHING TO HER?" RON SAID ANXIOUSLY AS THEY HURRIED UPSTAIRS TOWARD GRYPFINDER TOWER.

THEY PASSED THE SECURITY TRILLS, GAVE THE FAT LADY THE PASSWORD

"FLICKERTICKET", AND STRAMLED THROUGH THE PORTRAIT HOLE INTO THE  
COMMON ROOM.

BERMINE WAS SITTING AT A TABLE, FAST ASLEEP, HER HEAD RESTING ON AN  
OPEN ARITHMANY BOOK. THEY WENT TO SIT DOWN ON EITHER SIDE OF HER, FARRY  
PRESSED HER AWAKE.

"WH -- WHAT?" SAID BERMINE, WAKING WITH A START AND STARING WILDLY  
AROUND. "IS IT TIME TO GO? -- WHICH LESSON HAVE WE GOT NOW?"

"DIVINATION, BUT IT'S NOT FOR ANOTHER TWENTY MINUTES," SAID FARRY.

"BERMINE, WHY DIDN'T YOU CHECK THE CHAIRS?"

"WHAT? HOW NOW?" BERMINE SQUEAKED. "I FORGOT TO GO TO THE CHAIRS?"

"BUT HOW COULD YOU FORGET?" SAID FARRY. "YOU WERE WITH US TILL WE WERE  
RIGHT OUTSIDE THE CLASSROOM?"

"I DON'T BELIEVE IT!" BERMINE LAILED. "WAS PROFESSOR FLITWICK ANGRY?  
HEH, IT WAS MALFOY, I WAS THINKING ABOUT HIM AND I LOST TRACK OF THINGS!"

"YOU KNOW WHAT, BERMINE?" SAID FARRY, LEANING DOWN AT THE ENORMOUS  
ARITHMANY BOOK BERMINE HAD BEEN USING AS A PILLOW. "I RECKON YOU'RE  
CRACKING UP, YOU'RE TRYING TO DO THEM ALL."

"NO, I'M NOT!" SAID BERMINE, BRUSHING HER HAIR OUT OF HER EYES AND  
STARING HELPLESSLY AROUND FOR HER BAG. "I JUST MADE A MISTAKE, THAT'S  
ALL! I'D BETTER GO AND SEE PROFESSOR FLITWICK AND SAY SORRY... I'LL SEE  
YOU IN DIVINATION!"

END

BERMINE JOINED THEM AT THE FOOT OF THE LADDER THE PROFESSOR TRILAWNEY'S  
CLASSROOM TWENTY MINUTES LATER, LOOKING EXTREMELY HARRASSED.

"I CAN'T BELIEVE I MISSED CHAIRING CHAIRS! AND I GOT THEM UP IN MY  
EXAMS! PROFESSOR FLITWICK HINTED THEY MIGHT!"

TOGETHER THEY CLIMBED THE LADDER INTO THE DIM, STIPING THEIR ROOM.



GLOWING ON EVERY LITTLE TABLE WAS A CRYSTAL BALL FULL OF PEARLY WHITE MIST. HARRY, RHN, AND FERMINE SAT DOWN TOGETHER AT THE SAME RICKETY TABLE.

"I THOUGHT WE WEREN'T STARTING CRYSTAL BALLS UNTIL NEXT TERM," RHN MUTTERED, CASTING A WARY EYE AROUND HER PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY, IN CASE SHE WAS LISTENING NEARBY.

"DON'T COMPLAIN, THIS MEANS WE'VE FINISHED PALMISTRY," HARRY MUTTERED BACK. "I WAS GETTING SICK OF HER FLINCHING EVERY TIME SHE LOOKED AT MY HANDS."

"GOOD DAY TO YOU!" SAID THE FAMILIAR, MISTY VOICE, AND PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY MADE HER USUAL DRAMATIC ENTRANCE OUT OF THE SHADOWS. PARYATI AND LAVENDER DELIVERED WITH EXCITEMENT, THEIR FACES LIT BY THE MILD GLOW OF THEIR CRYSTAL BALL.

"I HAVE DECIDED TO INTRODUCE THE CRYSTAL BALL A LITTLE EARLIER THAN I HAD PLANNED," SAID PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY, SITTING WITH HER BACK TO THE FIRE AND GAZING AROUND. "THE FATES HAVE INFORMED ME THAT YOUR EXAMINATION IN JUNE WILL CONCERN THE FIRE, AND I AM ANXIOUS TO GIVE YOU SUFFICIENT PRACTICE."

FERMINE SMILED.

"WELL, HONESTLY... 'THE FATES HAVE INFORMED HER' DOES SETS THE EXAMPLE. SHE DOES! WHAT AN AMAZING PREDICTION!" SHE SAID, NOT THINKING THE DEEP HER VOICE WOULD. HARRY AND RHN LOOKED BACK LAUGHING.

IT WAS HARD TO TELL WHETHER PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY HAD HEARD THEM AS HER FACE WAS HIDDEN IN SHADOWS. SHE CONTINUED, HOWEVER, AS THOUGH SHE HAD NOT.

247

"CRYSTAL GAZING IS A PARTICULARLY REFINED ART," SHE SAID DRAMATICALLY. "I DO

NOT EXPECT AND HE WOULD THEN SEE WHEN FIRST WOULD PEER INTO THE FIRE'S INFINITE DEPTHS. WE SHALL START BY PRACTICING RELAXING THE CONSCIOUS MIND AND EXTERNAL EYES" -- RHN BEGAN THE SNIGGER UNCONTROLLABLY AND HAD THE STUFF HIS FIST IN HIS MOUTH THE STICK THE NEEDLE -- "SEE AS THE CLEAR THE INNER EYE AND THE SUPERCONSCIOUS. PERHAPS, IF WE ARE LUCKY, SOME OF YOU WILL SEE BEFORE THE END OF THE CLASS."

AND SHE THEN BEGAN. HARRY, AT LEAST, FELT EXTREMELY AWKWARD, STARING BLANKLY AT THE CRYSTAL BALL, TRYING THE DEEP HIS MIND EMPTY WHEN THOUGHTS SUCH AS "THIS IS STUPID" KEPT DRIFTING ACROSS IT. IT DIDN'T HELP THAT RHN KEPT BREAKING INTO SILENT GIGGLES AND HERMIONE KEPT TUTTING. "SEEN ANYTHING YET?" HARRY ASKED THEM AFTER A MOMENT OF AN EAGER'S EAGER CRYSTAL GAZING.

"YEAH, THERE'S A FLAME ON THIS TABLE," SAID RHN, POINTING. "SOMEONE'S SPILLED THEIR CANDLE."

"THIS IS SUCH A WASTE OF TIME," HERMIONE HISSED. "I COULD BE PRACTICING SOMETHING USEFUL, I COULD BE CATCHING UP ON CHARMING CHARMS --" PROFESSOR TRILAHNEY RUSTLED PAST.

"WOULD ANYONE LIKE ME TO HELP THEM INTERPRET THE SHADY PORTENTS WITHIN

THEIR FIRE?" SHE MURMURED OVER THE CLINKING OF HER RANGLES.

I DON'T NEED HELP," RHN WHISPERED. "IT'S OBVIOUS WHAT THIS MEANS.

THERE'S SOMETHING TO BE LEARNED OF THE THING."

BOTH HARRY AND HERMIONE WERE ALREADY LAUGHING.

"WELL, REALLY?" SAID PROFESSOR TRILAHNEY AS EVERYONE'S HEADS TURNED IN THEIR DIRECTION. PARVATI AND LAVENDER WERE LOOKING SCANDALIZED. "YOU ARE DISTURBING THE CLAIRVOYANT VIBRATIONS!" SHE APPROACHED THEIR TABLE AND PEERED INTO THEIR CRYSTAL BALL. HARRY FELT HIS HEART SINKING. HE WAS SURE HE KNEW WHAT WAS COMING --

"THERE IS SOMETHING HERE!" PROFESSOR TRILAHNEY WHISPERED, LEANING HER

FACE THE THE BALL, SHE THAT IT WAS REFLECTED TWICE IN HER FLICE GLASSES.

"SOMETHING MOVING... BUT WHAT IS IT?"

HARRY WAS PREPARED THE SET EVERYTHING HE HEARD, INCLUDING HIS FIREHILT, THAT IT WASN'T GOOD NEWS, WHATEVER IT WAS, AND SURE ENOUGH --

"MY DEAR PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY BREATHED, GAZING UP AT HARRY. "IT IS HERE, PLAINER THAN EVER BEFORE... MY DEAR, STALKING THEWARD WELL, GROWING EVER CLEARER... THE GR --"

"HEY, FOR GOODNESS' SAKE!" SAID HERMIONE LUDLY. "NOT THAT RIDICULOUS GRIM AGAIN?"

PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY RAISED HER ENORMOUS EYES TO HERMIONE'S FACE. PARVATI WHISPERED SOMETHING TO LAVENDER, AND THEY BOTH GLARED AT HERMIONE THEN. PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY STOOD UP, SURVEYING HERMIONE WITH UNMISTAKABLE ANGER.

"I AM SORRY THE SAY THAT FROM THE MOMENT YOU HAVE ARRIVED IN THIS CLASS MY DEAR, IT HAS BEEN APPARENT THAT YOU DO NOT HAVE WHAT THE NECKLE ART OF DIVINATION REQUIRES. INDEED, I DIDN'T REMEMBER EVER MEETING A STUDENT WHOSE MIND WAS SO HELPLESSLY PLINDANE."

THERE WAS A MOMENT'S SILENCE. THEN --

"FINE?" SAID HERMIONE SUDDENLY, GETTING UP AND CRAMMING LINAGGING THE FUTURE BACK INTO HER BAG. "FINE?" SHE REPEATED, SWINGING THE BAG OVER HER SHOULDER AND ALMOST KNOCKING RON OFF HIS CHAIR. "I GIVE UP! I'M LEAVING!"

AND THE THE WHOLE CLASS'S AMAZEMENT, HERMIONE STRIDE OVER THE THE TRAPDOOR, KICKED IT OPEN, AND CLIMBED DOWN THE LADDER BLIT OFF SIGHT. IT TOOK A FEW MINUTES FOR THE CLASS TO SETTLE DOWN AGAIN. PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY SEEMED TO HAVE FORGOTTEN ALL ABOUT THE GRIM. SHE TURNED ABRUPTLY FROM HARRY AND RON'S TABLE, BREATHING RATHER HEAVILY AS SHE

TUGGED HER CLOTHES AGAIN MORE CLOSELY TO HER.

"HHHHH!" SAID LAVENDER SUDDENLY, MAKING EVERYONE START. "HHHHH  
PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY, I'VE JUST REMEMBERED! SHE'S SAW HER LEAVING, DIDN'T

251

SHE'D DIDN'T SHE, PROFESSOR? 'AROUND EASTER, WHEN HER ALIBI WILL LEAVE  
US FOREVER!' SHE SAID IT AGES AGO, PROFESSOR!"

PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY GAVE HER A DRY SMILE.

"YES, MY DEAR, I DID INDEED KNOW THAT MISS GRANGER WOULD BE LEAVING US.  
BUT HERE, HOWEVER, THAT SHE MIGHT HAVE MISTAKEN THE SIGNS... THE INNER  
EYE CAN BE A BURDEN, SHE KNOWS..."

LAVENDER AND PARYATI LOOKED DEEPLY IMPRESSED, AND MOVED OVER SO THAT  
PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY COULD JOIN THEIR TABLE INSTEAD.

"SOME DAY HERMIONE'S SAYING, ISN'T?" RON MUTTERED TO HARRY, LOOKING AWAY.  
"Yeah..."

HARRY GLANCED INTO THE CRYSTAL BALL BUT SAW NOTHING BUT SWIRLING WHITE  
MIST. HAD PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY REALLY SEEN THE GRIM AGAIN? WOULD HE? THE  
LAST THING HE NEEDED WAS ANOTHER NEAR-FATAL ACCIDENT, WITH THE HOLIDAY  
FINAL DRAWING EVER NEARER.

THE EASTER HOLIDAYS WERE NOT EXACTLY RELAXING. THE THIRD YEARS HAD NEVER  
HAD SO MUCH HOMEWORK. NEVILLE LONGBOTT THEM SEEMED CLOSE TO A NERVOUS  
COLLAPSE, AND HE WASN'T THE ONLY ONE.

"CALL THIS A HOLIDAY?" SEAMUS FINNIGAN REARED AT THE CHIMPEN ROOM ONE  
AFTERNOON. "THE EXAMS ARE AGES AWAY, WHAT'RE THEY PLAYING AT?"

BUT NEEDY HAD AS MUCH TO DO AS HERMIONE. EVEN WITHOUT DIVINATION, SHE  
WAS TAKING MORE SUBJECTS THAN ANYBODY ELSE. SHE WAS USUALLY LAST TO  
LEAVE THE CHIMPEN ROOM AT NIGHT, FIRST TO ARRIVE AT THE LIBRARY THE NEXT  
MORNING; SHE HAD STAINLESS LIKE LUPIN'S UNDER HER EYES, AND SEEMED

CONSTANTLY CLESE THE TEARS.

RENN HAD TAKEN EVERY RESPONSIBILITY FOR KLICKERAD'S APPEAL. WHEN HE WASN'T DOING HIS OWN WORK, HE WAS PHIRING EVERY ENTHUSIASTICALLY THICK VELLIMES WITH NAMES LIKE THE F-ANDREXX OF F-IPPICRIFF PSYCH-THINGS AND FEEL HER FEEL? A STUDY OF F-IPPICRIFF REALITY. HE WAS SO ASHAMED, HE EVEN ACHIEVE THE SO F-IRRIKLE THE C-REXXS-LANDS.

252

F-HARRY, MEANWHILE, HAD THE FIT IN HIS F-IRREXXS ACHING F-LLIDITCH PRACTICE EVERY DAY, NOT THE MENTION ENDLESS DISCUSSIONS OF TACTICS WITH W-HEED. THE G-ROFFINDEE-SLYTHERIN MATCH WOULD TAKE PLACE ON THE FIRST SATURDAY AFTER THE EASTER HOLIDAYS. SLYTHERIN WAS LEADING THE THERMAGMENT BY EXACTLY TWO HUNDRED POINTS. THIS MEANT AS W-HEED CONSTANTLY REMINDED HIS TEAM THAT THEY NEEDED THE WIN THE MATCH BY MORE THAN THAT AMOUNT THE WIN THE CUP. IT ALSO MEANT THAT THE BURDEN OF WINNING FELL LARGELY ON F-HARRY, BECAUSE CAPTURING THE SNITCH WAS WORTH ONE HUNDRED AND FIFTY POINTS.

"SEE YOU MUST CATCH IT ONLY IF WE'RE MORE THAN FIFTY POINTS UP," W-HEED TOLD F-HARRY CONSTANTLY. "ONLY IF WE'RE MORE THAN FIFTY POINTS UP, F-HARRY, OR WE WIN THE MATCH BUT LOSE THE CUP. YOU'VE GOT THAT, F-HAVEN'T YOU? YOU MUST CATCH THE SNITCH ONLY IF WE'RE --"

"I DON'T, ELIYER!" F-HARRY YELLED.

THE WEEK OF G-ROFFINDEE F-ELISE WAS MESSED WITH THE CHIMPING MATCH. G-ROFFINDEE HADN'T WON THE F-LLIDITCH CUP SINCE THE LEGENDARY CHARLIE WEASLEY (RENN'S SECOND ELDEST BROTHER) HAD BEEN SEEKER, BUT F-HARRY Doubted WHETHER ANY OF THEM, EVEN W-HEED, WANTED THE WIN AS MUCH AS HE DID. THE ENMITY BETWEEN F-HARRY AND MALTHEY WAS AT ITS HIGHEST POINT EVER. MALTHEY WAS STILL SPARTING ABOUT THE MUD-THROWING INCIDENT IN F-HEGSMOOR AND WAS EVEN MORE CLINICAL THAT F-HARRY HAD SOMEHOW WORMED HIS WAY INTO

PUNISHMENT. HARRY HADN'T FORGOTTEN MALFOY'S ATTEMPT TO SABOTAGE HIM IN THE MATCH AGAINST RAVENCLAW, BUT IT WAS THE MATTER OF KIDNAPING THAT MADE HIM MOST DETERMINED TO BEAT MALFOY IN FRONT OF THE ENTIRE SCHOOL. NEVER, IN ANYONE'S MEMORY, HAD A MATCH APPROACHED IN SUCH A HIGHLY CHARGED ATMOSPHERE. BY THE TIME THE HOLIDAYS WERE OVER, TENSION BETWEEN THE TWO TEAMS AND THEIR FANS WAS AT THE BREAKING POINT. A NUMBER OF SMALL SCUFFLES BROKE OUT IN THE HALLWAYS, CLIMINATING IN A NASTY INCIDENT IN WHICH A GRYFFINDOR FIFTH YEAR AND A SLYTHERIN SIXTH YEAR ENDED UP IN THE HOSPITAL WING WITH LEGS SPRELLING OUT OF THEIR EARS. HARRY WAS HAVING A PARTICULARLY BAD TIME OF IT. HE COULDN'T WALK THE CLASS WITHOUT SLYTHERINS STICKING OUT THEIR LEGS AND TRYING TO TRIP HIM UP; CRABBE AND GOYLE KEPT PEEPING UP WHEREVER HE WENT, AND SMELCHING AWAY LOOKING DISAPPOINTED WHEN THEY SAW HIM SURROUNDED BY PEOPLE. WHO HAD GIVEN INSTRUCTIONS THAT HARRY SHOULD BE ACCOMPANIED EVERYWHERE HE WENT, IN CASE THE SLYTHERINS TRIED TO PUT HIM OUT OF ACTION. THE WHILE

THE

OF GRYFFINDOR FANS TOOK UP THE CHALLENGE ENTHUSIASTICALLY, SEE THAT IT WAS IMPOSSIBLE FOR HARRY TO GET THE CLASSES ON TIME BECAUSE HE WAS SURROUNDED BY A VAST, CHATTERING CROWD. HARRY WAS MORE CONCERNED FOR HIS FIREWALK'S SAFETY THAN HIS OWN. WHEN HE WASN'T FLYING IT, HE HOOKED IT SECURELY IN HIS TROUSER AND FREQUENTLY DASHED BACK UP THE GRYFFINDOR TOWER AT BREAK TIMES TO CHECK THAT IT WAS STILL THERE. ALL USUAL PURSUITS WERE ABANDONED IN THE GRYFFINDOR COMMON ROOM THE NIGHT BEFORE THE MATCH. EVEN HERMIONE HAD PUT DOWN HER BOOKS. "I CAN'T WORK, I CAN'T CONCENTRATE," SHE SAID NERVIOUSLY. THERE WAS A GREAT DEAL OF NOISE. FRED AND GEORGE WEASLEY WERE DEALING WITH THE PRESSURE OF BEING LEADER AND MORE EXCITANT THAN EVER. FLITVER

WIND WAS CRELICKED OVER A MEDEL OF A FLIDDITCH FIELD IN THE CORNER, PREDING LITTLE FIGURES ACROSS IT WITH HIS HAND AND MUTTERING TO HIMSELF. ANGELINA, ALICIA, AND KATIE WERE LAUGHING AT FRED'S AND GEORGE'S IDEAS. HARRY WAS SITTING WITH REIN AND HERMIONE, REMOVED FROM THE CENTER OF THINGS, TRYING NOT TO THINK ABOUT THE NEXT DAY, BECAUSE EVERY TIME HE DID, HE HAD THE HORRIBLE SENSATION THAT SOMETHING VERY LARGE WAS FIGHTING TO GET OUT OF HIS STOMACH.

"YOU'RE GOING TO BE FINE," HERMIONE TOLD HIM, THOUGH SHE LOOKED POSITIVELY TERRIFIED.

"YOU'VE GOT A FIREBOLT?" SAID REIN.

"YES..." SAID HARRY, HIS STOMACH WRITHING.

IT CAME AS A RELIEF WHEN WIND SLIDDERLY STOOD UP AND YELLED, "TEAM! RED!" HARRY SLEPT BADLY, FIRST HE DREAMED THAT HE HAD OVERSLEPT, AND THAT WIND WAS YELLING, "WHERE WERE YOU? WE HAD TO USE NEVILLE INSTEAD!" THEN HE DREAMED THAT MALFOY AND THE REST OF THE SLYTHERIN TEAM ARRIVED FOR THE MATCH RIDING DRAGONS, HE WAS FLYING AT BREAKNECK SPEED, TRYING TO AVOID A SPURT OF FLAMES FROM MALFOY'S STEED'S MOUTH, WHEN HE REALIZED HE HAD FORGOTTEN HIS FIREBOLT, HE FELL THROUGH THE AIR AND Woke WITH A START. IT WAS A FEW SECONDS BEFORE HARRY REMEMBERED THAT THE MATCH HADN'T TAKEN PLACE YET, THAT HE WAS SAFE IN BED, AND THAT THE SLYTHERIN TEAM

254

DEFINITELY WOULDN'T BE ALLOWED TO PLAY ON DRAGONS, HE WAS FEELING VERY THIRSTY, EXACTLY AS HE USUALLY, HE GOT OUT OF HIS PILLOW-POSTER AND WENT TO POUR HIMSELF SOME WATER FROM THE SILVER JUG BENEATH THE WINDOW. THE GRHLINGS WERE STILL AND QUIET, NO BREATH OF WIND DISTURBED THE TREETOPS IN THE FORGOTTEN FOREST; THE WAKING WILLIAM WAS METERLESS AND INNOCENT-LOOKING. IT LOOKED AS THOUGH THE CONDITIONS FOR THE MATCH WOULD

BE PERFECT.

HARRY SET DOWN HIS CHECKER AND WAS ABOUT TO TURN BACK TO HIS BED WHEN SOMETHING CAUGHT HIS EYE. AN ANIMAL OF SOME KIND WAS PRAWLING ACROSS THE SILVERY LAWN.

HARRY DASHED TO HIS BEDSIDE TABLE, SNATCHED UP HIS GLASSES, AND PLUT THEM ON, THEN HURRIED BACK TO THE WINDOW. IT COULDN'T BE THE GRIM -- NOT NOW -- NOT RIGHT BEFORE THE MATCH --

HE PEERED OUT AT THE GREENLANDS AGAIN AND, AFTER A MINUTE'S FRANTIC SEARCHING, SPOTTED IT. IT WAS SKIRTING THE EDGE OF THE FOREST NOW... IT WASN'T THE GRIM AT ALL ... IT WAS A CAT... HARRY CLUTCHED THE WINDOW LEDGE IN RELIEF AS HE RECOGNIZED THE RATTLESLASH-TAIL. IT WAS ONLY CRIBBET-HANDS...

HIS WAS IT ONLY CRIBBET-HANDS? HARRY SHLINTED, PRESSING HIS NOSE FLAT AGAINST THE GLASS. CRIBBET-HANDS SEEMED TO HAVE COME TO A HALT. HARRY WAS SURE HE COULD SEE SOMETHING ELSE MOVING IN THE SHADOWS OF THE TREES THEN, AND JUST THEN, IT EMERGED -- A GIGANTIC, SHAGGY BLACK BEG, MOVING STEALTHILY ACROSS THE LAWN, CRIBBET-HANDS TROTTING AT ITS SIDE. HARRY STARED. WHAT DID THIS MEAN? IF CRIBBET-HANDS COULD SEE THE BEG AS WELL, WHY COULD IT BE AN OMEN OF HARRY'S DEATH?

"REIN!" HARRY HISSED. "REIN! WAKE UP!"

"HUR!"

"I NEED YOU! YOU TELL ME IF YOU CAN SEE SOMETHING!"

"I'LL DARK, HARRY," REIN MUTTERED THICKLY. "WHAT'RE YOU DOING HERE, ABILITY?"

ZSS

"DOWN HERE --"

HARRY WHISKED HELICALLY BACK OUT OF THE WINDOW.

CRIBBET-HANDS AND THE BEG HAD VANISHED. HARRY CLIMBED MENTH THE WINDOWSTILL



THE THREE RIGHT DOWN INTO THE SHADOWS OF THE CASTLE, BUT THEY WEREN'T THERE. WHERE HAD THEY GONE?

A LITTLE WHILE THEN HIM HAD FALLEN ASLEEP AGAIN.

HARRY AND THE REST OF THE GRYFFINDOR TEAM ENTERED THE GREAT HALL THE NEXT DAY THE ENTIRETHINGS APPLAUSE. HARRY COULDN'T HELP GRINNING BROADLY AS HE SAW THAT BOTH THE RAVENCLAW AND SLYTHERLYN TABLES WERE APPLAUDING THEM THEN. THE SLYTHERIN TABLE HISSED LOUDLY AS THEY PASSED. HARRY NOTICED THAT MALFOY LOOKED EVEN PALER THAN USUAL.

WHEN SPENT THE WHILE OF BREAKFAST URGING HIS TEAM THE CAT, WHILE THINKING NOTHING HIMSELF THEN HE HURRIED THEM OFF THE FIELD BEFORE ANYONE ELSE HAD FINISHED, SO THEY COULD GET AN IDEA OF THE CONDITIONS. AS THEY LEFT THE GREAT HALL, EVERYONE APPLAUDED AGAIN.

"GOOD LUCK, HARRY!" CALLED THE HARRY FELT HIMSELF BLISSING.

"HEY -- NO WIND THE SPARK OF -- SUN'S A BIT BRIGHT, THAT COULD IMPAIR YOUR VISION, WATCH OUT FOR IT -- GRUNDY'S FAIRLY HARD, GOOD, THAT'LL GIVE US A FAST KICKOFF --"

WHEN PACED THE FIELD, STARING AROUND WITH THE TEAM BEHIND HIM. FINALLY, THEY SAW THE FRONT DOORS OF THE CASTLE OPEN IN THE DISTANCE AND THE REST OF THE SLYTHERLYN SPILLING INTO THE LAWN.

"LOOKER THEM," SAID WHEN TERSELY.

WHEN OF THEM SPARK AS THEY CHANGED INTO THEIR SCARLET ROBES, HARRY WONDERED IF THEY WERE FEELING LIKE HE WAS: AS THOUGH HE'D EATEN SOMETHING EXTREMELY WIGGLY FOR BREAKFAST. IN WHAT SEEMED LIKE NO TIME AT ALL, WHEN WAS SAYING, "HEY, IT'S TIME, LET'S GO --"

THEY WALKED OUT INTO THE FIELD THE A TIDAL WAVE OF NOISE. THREEQUARTERS OF THE CREW WAS WEARING SCARLET ROSETTES, WAVING SCARLET FLAGS WITH THE

GRYFFINDOR WHEN UPON THEM, HER BRANDISHING BANNERS WITH SLOGANS LIKE "GEE  
GRYFFINDOR!" AND "LIENS FEEL THE CLIX" BEHIND THE SLYTHERIN CHEAL  
PESTS,

HOWEVER, THE HUNDRED PEOPLE WERE WEARING GREEN; THE SILVER SERPENT OF  
SLYTHERIN GLITTERED ON THEIR FLAGS, AND PROFESSOR SNAPE SAT IN THE VERY  
FRONT ROW, WEARING GREEN LIKE EVERYONE ELSE, AND A VERY GRIM SMILE.

"AND HERE ARE THE GRYFFINDORS!" YELLED LEE JORDAN, WHO WAS ACTING AS  
COMMENTATOR AS USUAL. "PUTTER, BELL, JENNISON, SPINNER, WEASLEY, WEASLEY,  
AND WHED, WIDELY ACKNOWLEDGED AS THE BEST TEAM HOGWARTS HAS SEEN IN A  
GOOD FEW YEARS --"

LEE'S COMMENTS WERE ORIENTED BY A TIDE OF "KHEES" FROM THE SLYTHERIN END.  
"AND HERE COME THE SLYTHERIN TEAM, LED BY CAPTAIN FLINT. HE'S MADE SOME  
CHANGES IN THE LINEUP AND SEEMS TO BE GOING FOR SIZE RATHER THAN SKILL  
--"

MORE KHEES FROM THE SLYTHERIN CROWD. HARRY, HOWEVER, REMEMBERED LEE HAD A  
POINT. MALFOY WAS EASILY THE SMALLEST PERSON IN THE SLYTHERIN TEAM; THE  
REST OF THEM WERE ENORMOUS.

"CAPTAINS, SHAKE HANDS!" SAID MADAM BUNCH.

FLINT AND WHED APPROACHED EACH OTHER AND GRASPED EACH OTHER'S HAND VERY  
TIGHTLY; IT LOOKED AS THOUGH EACH WAS TRYING TO BREAK THE OTHER'S  
FINGERS.

"MELT YOUR KNEES!" SAID MADAM BUNCH. "THREE... TWO... ONE..."

THE SOUND OF HER WHISTLE WAS LOST IN THE RUSH FROM THE CROWD AS FOURTEEN  
KHEES ROSE INTO THE AIR. HARRY FELT HIS HAIR FLY BACK OFF HIS FOREHEAD;  
HIS NERVES LEFT HIM IN THE THRILL OF THE FLIGHT; HE GLANCED AROUND, SAW  
MALFOY IN HIS TAIL, AND SPED OFF IN SEARCH OF THE SNITCH.

"AND IT'S GRYFFINDOR IN POSSESSION, ALICIA SPINNER OF GRYFFINDOR WITH  
THE HURLER, HEADING STRAIGHT FOR THE SLYTHERIN CHEAL PESTS, LOOKING  
GOOD, ALICIA! ARCH, NEH -- HURLER INTERCEPTED BY WARRINGTON, WARRINGTON  
OF SLYTHERIN TEARING UP THE FIELD -- WEE-AGH! -- NICK BLUDGEON WENT THERE BY

GEORGE WEASLEY, HARRINGTON DROPS THE FLAG, IT'S CAUGHT BY -- THE OTHER,  
GRYFFINDOR BACK IN POSSESSION, COME ON, ANGELINA -- NICE SWEET ANGELINA

259

MONTAGUE -- BUCK, ANGELINA, THAT'S A BLUNDER! SHE SCORES! TWENTY-THREE  
THE

GRYFFINDOR!"

ANGELINA PLUNGED THE AIR AS SHE SHARED AROUND THE END OF THE FIELD, THE  
SEA OF SCARLET KEEPS WAS STREAMING ITS DELIGHT

"HELLO!"

ANGELINA WAS NEARLY THREEIN FROM HER KNEE AS MARCUS FLINT WENT  
SMASHING

INTO HER.

"SHOOT!" SAID FLINT AS THE CROWD KEELS KNEED, "SHOOT, DIDN'T SEE HER?"

A MOMENT LATER, FRED WEASLEY CLIPPED HIS BEATER'S CLUB AT THE BACK OF  
FLINT'S HEAD, FLINT'S NECK SMASHED INTO THE HANDLE OF HIS KNEE AND  
BEGAN THE BLEED.

"THAT WILL DO!" SHRIEKED MADAM BUNCH, ZEEING BETWEEN THEM, "PENALTY  
SHOOT THE GRYFFINDOR FOR AN UNPREPARED ATTACK ON THEIR CHASER! PENALTY  
SHOOT THE SLYTHERIN FOR DELIBERATE DAMAGE TO THEIR CHASER!"

"HERE HE IT, MISS!" FLEW FRED, BUT MADAM BUNCH BLEW HER WHISTLE AND  
ALICIA FLEW FORWARD TO TAKE THE PENALTY.

"HERE HE, ALICIA!" YELLED LEE INTO THE SILENCE THAT HAD DESCENDED ON THE  
CROWD, "YES! SHE'S KEATEN THE DEEPER! TWENTY-THREE THE  
GRYFFINDOR!"

HARRY TURNED THE FIREHUNT SHARPLY TO WATCH FLINT, STILL BLEEDING FREELY,  
FLY FORWARD TO TAKE THE SLYTHERIN PENALTY, WHO WAS HEEVERING IN FRONT OF  
THE GRYFFINDOR CHAL POSTS, HIS JAW CLENCHED.

"THURSE, WHO'S A SUPER DEEPER!" LEE JORDAN TOLD THE CROWD AS FLINT

WAITED FOR MADAM PITCHER'S WHISTLE. "SLIPPER? VERY DIFFICULT THE PASS --  
VERY DIFFICULT INDEED -- YES! I DIDN'T BELIEVE IT! HE'S SAVED IT!"  
RELIEVED, HARRY ZOOMED AWAY, GAZING AROUND FOR THE SNITCH, BUT STILL  
MAKING SURE HE CALIGHT EVERY WORD OF LEE'S COMMENTARY. IT WAS ESSENTIAL  
THAT HE FIELD MALPHY OFF THE SNITCH UNTIL GRYFFINDOR WAS MORE THAN FIFTY  
POINTS UP --

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"GRYFFINDOR IN POSSESSION, AH, SLYTHERIN IN POSSESSION -- AH!  
GRYFFINDOR BACK IN POSSESSION AND IT'S KATIE BELL, KATIE BELL FOR  
GRYFFINDOR WITH THE BLAZER, SHE'S STRADING UP THE FIELD -- THAT WAS  
DELICERATE!"

MINTAGLE, A SLYTHERIN CHASER, HAD SERVED IN FRONT OF KATIE, AND INSTEAD  
OF SEIZING THE BLAZER HAD GRABBED HER HEAD, KATIE LIFT WHEELED IN THE  
AIR, MANAGED THE STAY FOR HER KNEES, BUT DROPPED THE BLAZER.

MADAM PITCHER'S WHISTLE RANG OUT AGAIN AS SHE SHARED OVER THE MINTAGLE  
AND

BEGAN SHOOTING AT HIM. A MINUTE LATER, KATIE HAD PUT ANOTHER PENALTY  
PAST THE SLYTHERIN SEEKER.

"THIRTY-THREE! TAKE THAT, WELL DIRTY, CRATING --"

"HORDAN, IF WELL CAN'T COMMENTATE IN AN UNBIASED WAY --"

"I'M TELLING IT LIKE IT IS, PROFESSOR!"

HARRY FELT A FLICE OF EXCITEMENT. HE HAD SEEN THE SNITCH IT WAS  
SHIMMERING AT THE FEET OF ONE OF THE GRYFFINDOR CHAL FEETS -- BUT HE  
MISTN'T CATCH IT YET -- AND IF MALPHY SAW IT -

MAKING A LEAP OF SUDDEN CONCENTRATION, HARRY PULLED HIS FIREHIT AROUND  
AND SPED OFF TOWARD THE SLYTHERIN END -- IT WHIRLED, MALPHY WENT HAVING  
AFTER HIM, CLEARLY THINKING HARRY HAD SEEN THE SNITCH THERE...

LEAVING.

HEARD THE BILDBERS CAME STREAKING PAST HARRY'S RIGHT EAR, HIT BY THE  
GIGANTIC SLYTHERIN BEATER, DERRICK. THEN AGAIN  
WHEE-HEE-HEE-HEE.

THE SECOND BILDBER GRAZED HARRY'S EYE. THE OTHER BEATER, KEEL, WAS  
CLOSING IN.

HARRY HAD A FLEETING GLIMPSE OF KEEL AND DERRICK ZOOMING TOWARD HIM.

257

CLIKS RAISED --

HE TURNED THE FIREWHEEL UPWARD AT THE LAST SECOND, AND KEEL AND DERRICK  
COLLIDED WITH A SICKENING CLINCH.

"HA HAAA!" YELLED LEE JORDAN AS THE SLYTHERIN BEATERS WURLED AWAY FROM  
EACH OTHER, CLUTCHING THEIR HEADS. "THEE BAD, KEYS! THEE'LL NEED THE GET UP  
EARLIER THAN THAT THE BEAT A FIREWHEEL AND IT'S GRYFFINDOR IN POSSESSION  
AGAIN, AS THEE-NEE TAKES THE BLUWALL -- FLINT ALONGSIDE HER -- POKE HIM  
IN THE EYE, ANGELINA! -- IT WAS A HEE, PROFESSOR, IT WAS A HEE -- HE-  
NEE -- FLINT IN POSSESSION, FLINT FLYING TOWARD THE GRYFFINDOR CHAL-  
LENGER, THEE HEE NEE, WHEE, SAYE --!"

BUT FLINT HAD SCARED; THERE WAS AN ERUPTION OF CHEERS FROM THE SLYTHERIN  
END, AND LEE SAW SHE BADLY THAT PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL TRIED THE TUG THE  
MAGICAL MEGAPHONE AWAY FROM HIM.

"SHRRY, PROFESSOR, SHRRY! WHEE! HAPPEN AGAIN! SHE, GRYFFINDOR IN THE LEAD,  
THIRTY POINTS THE TEN, AND GRYFFINDOR IN POSSESSION --"

IT WAS TURNING INTO THE DIRTIEST GAME HARRY HAD EVER PLAYED IN. ENRAGED  
THAT GRYFFINDOR HAD TAKEN SUCH AN EARLY LEAD, THE SLYTHERINS WERE  
RAPIDLY RESORTING THE ANY MEANS THE TAKE THE BLUWALL. KEEL HIT ALICIA WITH  
HIS CLIK AND TRIED THE SAY HE'D THOUGHT SHE WAS A BILDBER. GEORGE WEASLEY  
PUNCHED KEEL IN THE FACE IN RETALIATION. MADAM EWECH AWARDED BOTH TEAMS

PENALTIES, AND LINDO PULLED OFF ANOTHER SPECTACULAR SAVE, MAKING THE SCORE FORTY-TEN TO GRYFFINDOR.

THE SNITCH HAD DISAPPEARED AGAIN. MALFOY WAS STILL KEEPING CLOSE TO HARRY AS HE SEARCHED OVER THE MATCH, LEEDING AROUND HER IT SINCE GRYFFINDOR WAS FIFTY POINTS AHEAD -

KATIE SCORED, FIFTY-TEN, FRED AND GEORGE WEASLEY WERE SLEEPING AROUND HER, EYES RAISED, IN CASE ANY OF THE SLYTHERINS WERE THINKING OF REVENGE. KELE AND DERRICK TOOK ADVANTAGE OF FRED'S AND GEORGE'S ABSENCE THE AIM BOTH BLUDGERS AT LINDO; THEY CALGHT HIM IN THE STOMACH, ONE AFTER THE OTHER, AND HE REELLED OVER IN THE AIR, CLUTCHING HIS BREATH, COMPLETELY WOUNDED.

MADAM PUMPH was beside herself

THE

"WELL DO NOT ATTACK THE DEEPER UNLESS THE BALLER IS WITHIN

THE SCORING

AREA!" SHE SHRIEKED AT KELE AND DERRICK. "GRYFFINDOR PENALTY!"

AND ANGELINA SCORED, SIXTY-TEN. MOMENTS LATER, FRED WEASLEY PELTED A BLUDGER AT WARRINGTON, DENYING THE BALLER ELIT OF HIS HANDS; ALICIA SEIZED IT AND PLIT IT THROUGH THE SLYTHERIN GOAL -- SEVENTY-TEN.

THE GRYFFINDOR CHIEF KELE WAS SCREAMING ITSELF FEARSE -- GRYFFINDOR WAS SIXTY POINTS IN THE LEAD, AND IF HARRY CALGHT THE SNITCH NOW, THE CUP WAS THEIRS. HARRY COULD ALMOST FEEL HUNDREDS OF EYES FOLLOWING HIM AS HE SEARCHED AROUND THE FIELD, HIGH ABOVE THE REST OF THE GAME, WITH MALFOY SPEEDING ALONG BEHIND HIM.

AND THEN HE SAW IT. THE SNITCH WAS SPARKLING TWENTY FEET ABOVE HIM. HARRY PLIT HER A FLICE BLIST OF SPEED; THE WIND WAS HOWLING IN HIS EARS; HE STRETCHED ELIT HIS HAND, ELIT SLIDDERLY, THE FIREBLIT WAS SHEDDING DOWN --

FHRRIFIED, HE LUNCHED AROUND. MALPHY HAD THROWN HIMSELF FORWARD, GRABBED  
HOLD OF THE FIREBOLT'S TAIL, AND WAS PULLING IT BACK.

"YELL --"

HARRY WAS ANGRY ENOUGH HE HIT MALPHY, BUT COULDN'T REACH -- MALPHY WAS  
PARTING WITH THE EFFORT OF HOLDING BENTH THE FIREBOLT, BUT HIS EYES WERE  
SPARKLING MALICIOUSLY. HE HAD ACHIEVED WHAT HE'D WANTED THE DAY -- THE  
SNITCH HAD DISAPPEARED AGAIN.

"PENALTY! PENALTY THE GRYFFINDERS! I'VE NEVER SEEN SUCH TACTICS." MADAM  
MURKIN SCREECHED, SCHEETING UP THE WHERE MALPHY WAS SLIDING BACK BENTH HIS  
NIMBUS TWO THOUSAND AND FIVE.

"YELL CRATING SLIM!" LEE JORDAN WAS FEELING INTO THE MEGAPHONE,  
DANCING

HUT OF PROFESSOR MCKINAGALL'S REACH. "YELL FIRE TRY, CRATING B --"

PROFESSOR MCKINAGALL DIDN'T EVEN BOTHER THE TELL HIM HOW SHE WAS  
ACTUALLY SHAKING HER FINGER IN MALPHY'S DIRECTION, HER HAT HAD FALLEN

281

OFF, AND SHE THEN WAS SCHEETING FLURIOUSLY.

ALICIA THOMAS GRYFFINDERS' PENALTY, BUT SHE WAS SO ANGRY SHE MISSED BY  
SEVERAL FEET. THE GRYFFINDERS TEAM WAS LOSTING CONCENTRATION AND THE  
SLYTHERINS, DELIGHTED BY MALPHY'S FEELING HARRY, WERE BEING SPURRED ON  
THE GREATER HEIGHTS.

"SLYTHERIN IN POSSESSION, SLYTHERIN LEADING THE CHASE -- MONTAGUE SCREAMS  
--" LEE GRIMMOND. "SEVENTY-TWO THE GRYFFINDERS..."

HARRY WAS NOW MARKING MALPHY SO CLOSELY THEIR KNEES KEPT HITTING EACH  
OTHER. HARRY WASN'T GOING TO LET MALPHY ANYWHERE NEAR THE SNITCH...

"GET OUT OF IT, PETER!" MALPHY YELLED IN FRUSTRATION AS HE TRIED THE  
TURN AND FEELING HARRY KICKING HIM.

"ANGELINA JEFFERSON GETS THE BLAZAR FOR GRYFFINDERS, THERE SHE, ANGELINA,

"CHEER MEN!"

HARRY LEANED AHEAD, EVERY SINGLE SLYTHERIN PLAYER APART FROM MALPHY WAS

STREAKING UP THE PITCH TOWARD ANGELINA, INCLUDING THE SLYTHERIN KEEPER -- THEY WERE ALL GOING TO KICK HER --

HARRY GRABBED THE FIREBOLT AHEAD, KNEW SHE KNEW HE WAS LYING FLAT ALONG THE HANDLE, AND KICKED IT FORWARD. LIKE A BULLET, HE SENT TOWARD THE SLYTHERINS.

"AAAAAAAAAAAAHHH!"

THEY SCATTERED AS THE FIREBOLT WHIRLED TOWARD THEM; ANGELINA'S WAY WAS CLEAR.

"SEE SCHEERS! SEE SCHEERS! GRYFFINDOR LEADS BY EIGHTY POINTS THE TWENTY!"

HARRY, WHO HAD ALMOST PELTED HEADLONG INTO THE STANDS, SKIDDED TO A HALT IN MIDAIR, REVERSED, AND WHIRLED BACK INTO THE MIDDLE OF THE FIELD.

AND THEN HE SAW SOMETHING THAT MADE HIS HEART STAND STILL. MALPHY WAS DIVING, A BEAM OF TRIUMPH ON HIS FACE -- THERE, A FEW FEET ABOVE THE GRASS LEVEL, WAS A TINY, GILDED GLIMMER --

THE

HARRY LUNGED THE FIREBOLT DOWNWARD, BUT MALPHY WAS MILES AHEAD --

"GO! GO! GO!" HARRY LUNGED HIS KNEES. HE WAS GAINING ON MALPHY -- HARRY FLATTENED HIMSELF TO THE KNEES HANDLE AS KEEL SENT A BLUDGEON AT HIM -- HE WAS AT MALPHY'S ANKLES -- HE WAS LEVEL --

HARRY THREW HIMSELF FORWARD, THUD WITH HIS HANDS OFF HIS KNEES. HE KNOCKED MALPHY'S ARM OUT OF THE WAY AND --

"YES!"

HE PULLED HIMSELF UP HIS DIVE, HIS HAND IN THE AIR, AND THE STADIUM

EXPLODED. HARRY SEARED ABOVE THE CROWD, AN ECHO RINGING IN HIS EARS. THE TINY GILDED BALL WAS HELD TIGHT IN HIS FIST, BEATING ITS WINGS



HOPELESSLY AGAINST HIS FINGERS.

THEN WHED WAS SPEEDING TOWARD HIM, HALF-BLIND BY TEARS; HE SEIZED  
HARRY ARHLND THE NECK AND SHREK UNRESTRAINEDLY INTO HIS SHULDER. HARRY  
FELT THE LARGE THUMPS AS FRED AND GEORGE HIT THEM; THEN ANGELINA'S,  
ALICIA'S, AND KATIE'S VEHICLES. "WE'VE WEN THE CLIP! WE'VE WEN THE CLIP!"  
TANGLED TOGETHER IN A MANDY-ARMED HLE, THE GRYFFINDR TEAM SAND, YELLING  
HEARSLY, BACK TH EARTH.

WAVE WPHN WAVE HF CRIMSHN SLIPPHNTS WAS PHLRNG EVER TH BARRIERS  
HNTH

THE FIELD, H-ANDS WERE RAINING DHN HN THIR BACKS, HARRY HAD A CHNLSHD  
IMPRESSHN HF NHISZ AND KHISZ PRESSING IN HN HIM. THEN HE, AND THE REST  
HF THE TEAM, WERE HLISTED HNTH TH SHULDERS HF TH CRHL. THRLST INTO  
THE LIGHT, HE SAW H-GRID, PLASTERED WITH CRIMSHN RHSETTES -- "YEH KEAT  
'EM, HARRY, YEH KEAT 'EM"

WAIT TILL I TELL KICKREAZ!" THERE WAS PERCY, ILMPING LIP AND DHN LIKE A  
MANIAC, ALL DIGNITY PHRGHTTEN. PROFESSHR MCHINACALL WAS SHRKNG HARDER  
EVEN THAN WHED, WIPING HER EYES WITH AN ENHRPHLS GRYFFINDR FLAG; AND  
THERE, FIGHTING THEIR WAY TOWARD HARRY, WERE RHEN AND H-PRMTHNE. WHEDS  
FAILED THEM. THEY SIMPLY REAMED AS HARRY WAS KHRNK TOWARD TH STANDS,  
WHERE BLMKLEBHR STHHD WAITING WITH TH ENHRPHLS HLLIDITCH CLIP.  
IF HNLY THERE HAD BEEN A DEMENTHR ARHLND... AS A SHRKNG WHED PASSED  
HARRY TH CLIP, AS HE LIFTED IT INTO TH AIR, HARRY FELT HE CHULD HAVE

ZEE

PREDLKED TH WHRLD'S BEST PATRHNLIS.

## CHAPTER SIXTEEN

### PROFESSHR TRRLALNRY'S PREDICTIHN

HARRY'S ELIPHHRIA AT FINALLY WINNING TH HLLIDITCH CLIP LASTED AT LEAST A  
WEEK. EVEN TH WEATHER SEEMED TH BE CELEBRATING; AS ILNK APPRHCHED, TH  
DAYS BECAME CHHLBLEST AND SLTRY, AND ALL ANYBHDY FELT LIKE DHNG WAS

STROLLING AMONG THE GRIFFINDS AND SLEEPING DEEP IN THE GRASS WITH SEVERAL PINTS OF ICED PUMPKIN JUICE, PERHAPS PLAYING A CASUAL GAME OF CHESS. SHE WAS WATCHING THE GIANT SLEIGH PROPEL ITSELF DREAMILY ACROSS THE SURFACE OF THE LAKE.

BUT THEY COULDN'T. EXAMS WERE NEARLY UPON THEM, AND INSTEAD OF LAZING AROUND HILLSIDE, THE STUDENTS WERE FORCED TO REMAIN INSIDE THE CASTLE, TRYING TO BURY THEIR BRAINS INTO CONCENTRATING WHILE ENTICING WASTES OF SUMMER AIR DRIFTED IN THROUGH THE WINDOWS. EVEN FRED AND GEORGE WEASLEY HAD BEEN SPOTTED WORKING; THEY WERE ABOUT TO TAKE THEIR OWLS (ORDINARY WIZARDING LEVELS). PERCY WAS GETTING READY TO TAKE HIS N.E.W.T.s (NASTILY EXHAUSTING WIZARDING TESTS), THE HIGHEST QUALIFICATION FLEGGWARTS OFFERED. AS PERCY ABOUT TO ENTER THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC, HE NEEDED THE GRADES. HE WAS BECOMING INCREASINGLY EDGY, AND GAVE VERY SEVERE PUNISHMENTS TO ANYBODY WHO DISTURBED THE QUIET OF THE COMMON ROOMS IN THE EVENINGS. IN FACT, THE ONLY PERSON WHO SEEMED MORE ANXIOUS THAN PERCY WAS HERMIONE.

HARRY AND RON HAD GIVEN UP ASKING HER HOW SHE WAS MANAGING TO ATTEND SEVERAL CLASSES AT ONCE, BUT THEY COULDN'T RESTRAIN THEMSELVES WHEN THEY SAW THE EXAM SCHEDULE SHE HAD DRAWN UP FOR HERSELF. THE FIRST COLUMN READ:

MONDAY

9 O'CLOCK, ARITHMAGIC

9 O'CLOCK, TRANSFIGURATION

LUNCH

2PM

1 O'CLOCK, CHARM

1 O'CLOCK, ANCIENT RUNES

"FERMINE?" PHIN SAID CALIBLY, BECAUSE SHE WAS LIKELY TO EXPLAIN WHEN INTERRUPTED THESE DAYS. "OR -- ARE YOU SURE YOU'VE COPIED DOWN THESE TIMES RIGHT?"

"WHAT?" SNAPPED FERMINNE, PICKING UP THE EXAM SCHEDULE AND EXAMINING IT.

"YES, OF COURSE I HAVE."

"IS THERE ANY POINT ASKING WHEN YOU'RE GOING TO SIT FOR THE EXAMS AT HOME?" SAID HARRY.

"NO," SAID FERMINNE SHORTLY. "I HAVE EITHER OF YOU SEEN MY COPY OF ALGEBRA AND GRAMMAR?"

"OH, YES, I REMEMBERED IT FOR A KIT OF BEDTIME READING," SAID PHIN, BUT VERY QUIETLY, FERMINNE STARTED SHIFTING HEADS OF PARCEMENT HARRY, PHIN, AND FERMINNE PLenty OF EMPHATICITY TO SPREAD THE FLAG.

"READY'S GETTING A KIT DEPRESSED," FLAG TOLD THEM, KENDING WHEN THE PRETENSE OF CHECKING THAT HARRY'S FLECKENHORN WAS STILL ALIVE. "KIN COPIED UP THE LONG, BUT STILL... WE'LL KNOW DAY AFTER THE OTHER -- ONE WAY FOR THE OTHER --"

THEY HAD PHIN'S THAT AFTERNOON, WHICH WAS AN UNQUALIFIED DISASTER. TRY AS HARRY MIGHT, HE COULDN'T GET HIS CHANGING CHURCHMEN THE THICKEN, AND SNARE, STANDING WATCH WITH AN AIR OF VINDICTIVE PLEASURE, SCRIBBLED SOMETHING THAT LOOKED SUSPICIOUSLY LIKE A ZERO WHEN HIS NOTES BEGAN MOVING AWAY.

THEN CAME ASTROLOGY AT MIDNIGHT, UP IN THE TALLEST TOWER; HISTORY OF MAGIC IN WEDNESDAY MORNING, IN WHICH HARRY SCRIBBLED EVERYTHING FLECKENHORN HAD EVER TOLD HIM ABOUT MEDICAL WITCH-HUNTS, WHILE WISHING HE COULD HAVE HAD ONE OF FLECKENHORN'S CHURCHMEN SLIDERS WITH HIM IN THE STYLING CLASSROOM. WEDNESDAY AFTERNOON MEANT FERMINE, IN THE GREEN-HOUSES UNDER A BAKING-HOT SUN; THEN BACK TO THE CHURCHMEN WHEN THERE, WITH SLINKING NECKS, THINKING LONGINGLY OF THIS TIME NEXT DAY, WHEN IT WOULD ALL BE OVER.

YES

THEIR SECOND THE LAST EXAM, HEN THURSDAY MORNING, WAS DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS. PROFESSOR LUPIN HAD COMPILED THE MOST UNUSUAL EXAM AND OF THEM HAD EVER TAKEN; A SHORT OF OBSTACLE COURSE HELTIDE IN THE SNOW, WHERE THEY HAD TO WADE ACROSS A DEEP PADDLING POOL CONTAINING A GRINDWHEEL, CROSS A SERIES OF PITEFULES FULL OF RED CAPS, SWIM THEIR WAY ACROSS A PATCH OF MARSH WHILE IGNORING MISLEADING DIRECTIONS FROM A HINDOPLIND, THEN CLIMB INTO AN OLD TROLLEY AND BATTLE WITH A NEW KEGGART.

"EXCELLENT, HARRY," LUPIN MUTTERED AS HARRY CLIMBED HELT OF THE TROLLEY, GRINNING, "FULL MARKS."

FINISHED WITH HIS SUCCESS, HARRY FLEW AROUND THE WATCH TOWER AND HERMIONE. RON DID VERY WELL UNTIL HE REACHED THE HINDOPLIND, WHICH SUCCESSFULLY CHUCKLED HIM INTO SINKING WAIST-HIGH INTO THE MUDMIRE. HERMIONE DID EVERYTHING PERFECTLY UNTIL SHE REACHED THE TROLLEY WITH THE KEGGART IN IT. AFTER ABOUT A MINUTE INSIDE IT, SHE BURST HELT AGAIN, SCREAMING.

"HERMIONE?" SAID LUPIN, STARTLED, "WHAT'S THE MATTER?"

"O -- O -- PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL?" HERMIONE GASPED, POINTING INTO THE TROLLEY. "SHE -- SHE SAID I'D FAILED EVERYTHING!"

IT TOOK A LITTLE WHILE THE CALM HERMIONE OWEN. WHEN AT LAST SHE HAD REGAINED A GRIP HEN HERSELF, SHE, HARRY, AND RON WENT BACK THE THE CASTLE. RON WAS STILL SLIGHTLY INCLINED THE LAUGH AT HERMIONE'S KEGGART, BUT AN ARGUMENT WAS AVERTED BY THE SIGHT THAT MET THEM HEN THE TOP OF THE STEPS. CHERNBLISS FLICK, SWEATING SLIGHTLY IN HIS PINSTRIPED CLOAK, WAS STANDING THERE STARING HELT AT THE GRIMLINDS. HE STARTED AT THE SIGHT OF HARRY.

"FELLER THERE, HARRY?" HE SAID, "LIST HAD AN EXAM, I EXPECT? NEARLY FINISHED?"

"YES," SAID HARRY, HERMIONE AND RON, NOT BEING HEN SPEAKING TERMS WITH

THE MINISTER OF MAGIC, FEEVERED ALIKELANDLY IN THE BACKGROUND.

"BEVERLY DAY," SAID FLUDGE, CASTING AN EYE OVER THE LAKE.

"PITY... PITY..."

THE

HE SIGHED DEEPLY AND WHISKED DOWN AT HARRY.

"I'M HERE ON AN UNPLEASANT MISSION, HARRY. THE COMMITTEE FOR THE  
DISPOSAL OF DANGEROUS CREATURES REQUIRED A WITNESS TO THE EXECUTION OF A  
MAD HIPPOGRIFF. AS I NEEDED THE VISIT OF HOGWARTS THE CHECK ON THE BLACK  
SITUATION, I WAS ASKED TO STEP IN."

"THAT MEANS THE APPEAL'S ALREADY HAPPENED?" RHN INTERRUPTED,  
STEPPING FORWARD.

"NEH, NEH, IT'S SCHEDULED FOR THIS AFTERNOON," SAID FLUDGE, WHISKING  
CLIMBILLY AT RHN.

"THEN WHY MIGHT NOT HAVE THE WITNESS AN EXECUTION AT ALL?" SAID RHN  
STEALTHY. "THE HIPPOGRIFF MIGHT GET AWAY?"

BEFORE FLUDGE COULD ANSWER, TWO WIZARDS CAME THROUGH THE CASTLE DOORS  
BEHIND HIM. ONE WAS AN ANCIENT HE APPEARED TO BE WITHERING BEFORE THEIR  
VERY EYES. THE OTHER WAS TALL AND STRAPPING, WITH A THIN BLACK MUSTACHE.  
HARRY GATHERED THAT THEY WERE REPRESENTATIVES OF THE COMMITTEE FOR THE  
DISPOSAL OF DANGEROUS CREATURES, BECAUSE THE VERY OLD WIZARD WHISTLED  
TOWARD HARRY'S LARKIN AND SAID IN A PECKLE VOICE, "DEAR, DEAR, I'M  
GETTING THERE OLD FOR THIS... THE WHISKER, ISN'T IT, FLUDGE?"

THE BLACK-MUSTACHED MAN WAS FINGERING SOMETHING IN HIS BELT. HARRY  
WHISKED AND SAW THAT HE WAS RUNNING ONE BEHIND HIM ALONG THE BLADE OF A  
SHINING AXE. RHN OPENED HIS MOUTH TO SAY SOMETHING, BUT HERMIONE NODDED  
HIM HARD IN THE RIBS AND JERKED HER HEAD TOWARD THE ENTRANCE HALL.

"WOULD YOU STOP ME?" SAID RHN ANGRILY AS THEY ENTERED THE GREAT HALL FOR  
LUNCH. "DID YOU SEE THEM? THEY'VE EVEN GOT THE AXE READY! THIS ISN'T

JUSTICE?"

"THEN, WHEN DAD LOOKS FOR THE MINISTRY, WHY CAN'T HE SAYING THINGS LIKE THAT TO HIS KIDS?" SAID HERMIONE, BUT SHE WAS LOOKED VERY UPSET. "AS LONG AS LACRIS KEEPS HIS HEAD THIS TIME, AND ARGUE, HI CASE PROPERLY, THEY CAN'T POSSIBLY EXCELITE KICKBACK...."

BUT LARRY COULD TELL HERMIONE DIDN'T REALLY BELIEVE WHAT SHE WAS SAYING.

THEY

ALL AROUND THEM, PEOPLE WERE TALKING EXCITEDLY AS THEY ATE THEIR LUNCH, HAPPILY ANTICIPATING THE END OF THE EXAMS THAT AFTERNOON, BUT LARRY, REIN, AND HERMIONE, WENT IN WHEN THEY HEARD LACRIS AND KICKBACK, DIDN'T JOIN IN.

LARRY'S AND REIN'S LAST EXAM WAS DIVINATION; HERMIONE'S, MUGGLE STUDIES. THEY WALKED UP THE MARBLE STAIRCASE TOGETHER; HERMIONE LEFT THEM ON THE FIRST FLOOR AND LARRY AND REIN PROCEEDED ALL THE WAY UP THE SEVENTH, WHERE MANY OF THEIR CLASS WERE SITTING ON THE SPIRAL STAIRCASE THE PROFESSOR TRILAWNEY'S CLASSROOM, TRYING THE CREAM IN A KIT OF LAST-MINUTE STUDYING.

"SHE'S SEEING US ALL SEPARATELY," NEVILLE INFORMED THEM AS THEY WENT THE SIT DOWN NEXT TO HIM. HE HAD HIS COPY OF JOURNALING THE FUTURE OPEN ON HIS LAP AT THE PAGES DEVOTED TO CRYSTAL GAZING. "HAVE EITHER OF YOU EVER SEEN ANYTHING IN A CRYSTAL BALL?" HE ASKED THEM LINE-HAPPILY.

"NONE," SAID REIN IN AN HURT-TONE VOICE, HE KEPT CHECKING HIS WATCH; LARRY, KNEW THAT HE WAS COUNTING DOWN THE TIME UNTIL KICKBACK'S APPEAL STARTED. THE LINE OF PEOPLE OUTSIDE THE CLASSROOM SHORTENED VERY SLOWLY. AS EACH PERSON CLIMBED BACK DOWN THE SILVER LADDER, THE REST OF THE CLASS HISSED, "WHAT DID SHE ASK? WAS IT HARD?"

BUT THEY ALL REPLIED THE SAME.

"SHE SAYS THE CRYSTAL BALL'S TOLD HER THAT IF I TELL YOU, I'LL HAVE A  
HORRIBLE ACCIDENT!" SHELEDGED NEVILLE AS HE CLAMBERED BACK DOWN THE  
LADDER TOWARD HARRY AND REIN, WHO HAD NOW REACHED THE LANDING.

"THAT'S CONVENIENT," SNEERED REIN. "YOU KNOW, I'M STARTING TO THINK  
HERMIONE WAS RIGHT ABOUT HER" -- HE JARRED HIS TAILOR TOWARD THE TRAPDOOR  
OVERHEAD -- "SHE'S A RIGHT OLD FRAID."

"Yeah," SAID HARRY, LEERING AT HIS OWN WATCH. IT WAS NOW TWO EIGHTS,

"WISH SHE'D FLIPPED LIP..."

PARYATI CAME BACK DOWN THE LADDER GLEELING WITH PRIDE.

"SHE SAYS I'VE GOT ALL THE MAKINGS OF A TRUE SEER," SHE INFORMED HARRY

THEY

AND REIN. "I SAW LOADS OF STUFF... WELL, GOOD LUCK?"

SHE FLIPPED OFF DOWN THE SPIRAL STAIRCASE TOWARD LAVENDER.

"REINOLD LEASLEY," SAID THE FAMILIAR, MISTY VOICE FROM OVER THEIR HEADS.  
REIN GRIMACED AT HARRY AND CLIMBED THE SILVER LADDER OUT OF SIGHT. HARRY  
WAS NOW THE ONLY PERSON LEFT TO BE TESTED. HE SETTLED HIMSELF IN THE  
ARMCHairs WITH HIS BACK AGAINST THE WALL, LISTENING TO A FLY BUZZING IN THE  
SLINDY WINDOW, HIS MIND ACROSS THE GREENLANDS WITH HARRY.

FINALLY, AFTER ABOUT TWENTY MINUTES, REIN'S LARGE FEET REAPPEARED IN THE  
LADDER.

"WOULD IT GO?" HARRY ASKED HIM, STANDING UP.

"BUBBLES," SAID REIN. "I HADN'T SEEN A THING, SO I MADE SOME STUFF UP.  
DIDN'T THINK SHE WAS CONVINCED, THOUGH..."

"MEET YOU IN THE COMMON ROOM," HARRY MUTTERED AS PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY'S  
VOICE CALLED. "HARRY PETER?"

THE TOWER ROOM WAS BETTER THAN EVER BEFORE: THE CURTAINS WERE CLOSED,  
THE FIRE WAS ALIGHT, AND THE USUAL SICKLY SCENT MADE HARRY GIGGLE AS HE

STUMBLING THROUGH THE CLITTER OF CHAIRS AND TABLES WHERE PROFESSOR  
TRILAHNEY SAT WAITING FOR HIM BEHIND A LARGE CRYSTAL BALL.

"GOOD DAY, MY DEAR," SHE SAID SEPTLY. "IF YOU WOULD KINDLY GAZE INTO THE  
HERE... TAKE YOUR TIME, NOW... THEN TELL ME WHAT YOU SEE WITHIN IT..."

HARRY KENT EVER THE CRYSTAL BALL AND STARED, STARED AS HARD AS HE COULD,  
WILLING IT TO SHOW HIM SOMETHING BETTER THAN SWIRLING WHITE FOG, BUT  
NOTHING HAPPENED.

"WELL?" PROFESSOR TRILAHNEY PROMPTED DELICATELY. "WHAT DO YOU SEE?"  
THE HEAT WAS EVERPREVAILING AND HIS NEETAILS WERE STINGING WITH THE  
PERFUMED SMOKE WAITING FROM THE FIRE BESIDE THEM, BUT THEUGHT OF WHAT SHE  
HAD JUST SAID, AND DECIDED TO PRETEND.

"ER --" SAID HARRY, "A DARK SHAPE... LIM..."

END

"WHAT DOES IT RESEMBLE?" WHISPERED PROFESSOR TRILAHNEY. "THINK, NOW..."  
HARRY LOST HIS MIND AROUND AND IT LANDED HIM KICKHEAD.

"A HIPPOGRIF?" HE SAID FIRMLY.

"INDEED?" WHISPERED PROFESSOR TRILAHNEY, SCRIBBLING DEEPLY ON THE  
PARCHMENT PERCHED UPON HER KNEES. "MY DEAR, YOU MAY WELL BE SEEING THE  
EIGHTH OF THEM HARRY'S TROUBLE WITH THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC. WHEN  
WHEN... DOES THE HIPPOGRIF APPEAR THEN... HAVE ITS HEAD?"

"YES," SAID HARRY FIRMLY.

"ARE YOU SURE?" PROFESSOR TRILAHNEY LARGED HIM. "ARE YOU WHITE SURE,  
DEAR? YOU DIDN'T SEE IT WRITHING ON THE GROUND, PERHAPS, AND A SHADY  
FIGURE RAISING AN AXE BEHIND IT?"

"NO!" SAID HARRY, STARTING TO FEEL SLIGHTLY SICK.

"NO MORE? NO MORE HARRY?"

"NO!" SAID HARRY AGAIN, WANTING MORE THAN EVER TO LEAVE THE ROOM AND THE



HEAT. "IT LOOKS FINE, IT'S - - FLYING AWAY..."

PROFESSOR TRILAHNEY SIGHED.

"WELL, DEAR, I THINK WE'LL LEAVE IT THERE... A LITTLE DISAPPOINTING...

BUT I'M SURE YOU DID YOUR BEST."

RELIEVED, HARRY GET UP, PICKED UP HIS BAG AND TURNED THE CH, BUT THEN A  
LOUD, HARSH VOICE SPoke BEHIND HIM.

"IT WILL HAPPEN TONIGHT!"

HARRY WHEELED AROUND, PROFESSOR TRILAHNEY HAD GONE RIGID IN HER  
ARMCHAIR; HER EYES WERE LIDCLOSED AND HER MOUTH SAGGING.

"S -- SHARP?" SAID HARRY.

END

BUT PROFESSOR TRILAHNEY DIDN'T SEEM TO HEAR HIM, HER EYES STARTED TO  
ROLL, HARRY SAT THERE IN A PANIC. SHE LOOKED AS THOUGH SHE WAS ABOUT TO  
HAVE SOME SORT OF SEIZURE, HE HESITATED, THINKING OF RUNNING TO THE  
HOSPITAL WING -- AND THEN PROFESSOR TRILAHNEY SPoke AGAIN, IN THE SAME  
HARSH VOICE, BUT UNLIKE HER HEN:

"THE DARK LORD LIES ALONE AND FRIENDLESS, ABANDONED BY  
HIS FOLLOWERS.

HIS SERVANT HAS BEEN CHAINED THESE TWELVE YEARS.  
TONIGHT,

BEFORE

MIDNIGHT... THE SERVANT WILL BREAK FREE AND SET HIM TO  
REJOIN HIS

MASTER. THE DARK LORD WILL RISE AGAIN WITH HIS SERVANTS  
AID, GREATER AND

MORE TERRIBLE THAN EVER HE WAS. TONIGHT... BEFORE

MIDNIGHT... THE

SERVANT... WILL SET HIM... TO REJOIN... HIS MASTER...

PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY'S HEAD FELL FORWARD BENT HER CHEST. SHE MADE A GRUNTING SERT HP NOISE. HARRY SAT THERE, STARING AT HER. THEN, BLITE SLIDENLY, PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY'S HEAD SNAPPED UP AGAIN.

"I'M SEE SHIRRY, DEAR KID," SHE SAID DREAMILY, "THE HEAT HP THE DAY, YELL KNELL... I DRIFTED OFF FOR A MOMENT..."

HARRY SAT THERE, STARING AT HER.

"IS THERE ANYTHING WRONG, MY DEAR?"

"YELL -- YELL ILST TELL ME THAT THE -- THE DARK LORD'S GOING THE RISE AGAIN... THAT HIS SERVANT'S GOING THE GO BACK THE HIM.

PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY LEEKED TEEHLEGLY STARTLED.

"THE DARK LORD? HE-LE-TH-ILST-NET-RE-NAMED? MY DEAR KID, THAT'S HARDLY SOMETHING THE INDEE AKELLT... RISE AGAIN, INDEED --"

'BUT YELL ILST SAID IT? YELL, SAID THE DARK LORD --"

"I THINK YELL ILST HAVE DRIZZED OFF THEM, DEAR!" SAID PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY.

END

"I WOULD CERTAINLY NOT PRESUME TO PREDICT ANYTHING BLITE AS FAR-FETCHED AS THAT?"

HARRY CLIMBED BACK DOWN THE LADDER AND THE SPIRAL STAIRCASE,

WANDERING... HAD HE ILST HEARD PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY MAKE A REAL

PREDICTION? HIR HAD THAT BEEN HER IDEA HP AN IMPRESSIVE END THE THE TEST?

FIVE MINUTES LATER HE WAS DASHING PAST THE SECURITY TRELLS ELTISIDE THE

ENTRANCE THE GRYFFINDOR TOWER, PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY'S WORDS STILL

RESEHLNDING IN HIS HEAD. PEOPLE WERE STRIDING PAST HIM IN THE OPPOSITE

DIRECTION, LAUGHING AND IDKING, HEADING FOR THE GREENS AND A KIT HP

LONG-AWAITED FREEDOM; BY THE TIME HE HAD REACHED THE PORTRAIT HELL AND

ENTERED THE CHAMBER WHIM, IT WAS ALMOST DESERTED. EVER IN THE CORNER,

HELLEVER, SAT RON AND HERMIONE.

"PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY," HARRY PANTED, "JUST TOLD ME --"

BUT HE STOPPED ABRUPTLY AT THE SIGHT OF THEIR FACES.

"CLICKHEAD LIST," SAID RON WEARILY, "HARRY'S JUST SENT THIS."

HARRY'S NOTE WAS DRY THIS TIME, NO TEARS HAD SPLATTERED IT, YET HIS HAND SEEMED TO HAVE SHAKEN SO MUCH AS HE WROTE THAT IT WAS HARDLY LEGIBLE.

BEST APPEAL. THEY'RE GOING TO EXCELITE AT SUNSET. NOTHING YOU CAN DO. DIDN'T COME DOWN, I DIDN'T WANT YOU TO SEE IT.

HARRY

"WE'VE GOT TO GO," SAID HARRY AT ONCE. "HE CAN'T JUST SIT THERE ON HIS OWN, WAITING FOR THE EXCELITHEER!"

"SUNSET, TELL ME," SAID RON, WHO WAS STARING OUT THE WINDOW IN A GLAZED SORT OF WAY. "WE'D NEVER BE ALLOWED... 'SPECIALLY YOU, HARRY..."

HARRY SANK HIS HEAD INTO HIS HANDS, THINKING.

"If we only had the INVISIBILITY CHARM..."

END

"WHERE IS IT?" SAID HERMION.

HARRY TOLD HER ABOUT LEAVING IT IN THE PASSAGEWAY UNDER THE ONE-EYED WITCH.

"... IF SNAPE SEES ME ANYWHERE NEAR THERE AGAIN, I'M IN SERIOUS TROUBLE," HE FINISHED.

"THAT'S TRUE," SAID HERMION, GETTING TO HER FEET. "IF HE SEES YOU... WHEN DO YOU OPEN THE WITCH'S HUMP AGAIN?"

"YOU -- YOU TAP IT AND SAY, 'DISSEMBLING,'" SAID HARRY. "BUT --"

HERMION DIDN'T WAIT FOR THE REST OF HIS SENTENCE; SHE STRODE ACROSS THE ROOM, PUSHED OPEN THE FAT LADY'S PORTRAIT AND VANISHED FROM SIGHT.

"SHE HAIN'T GONE TO GET IT?" RON SAID, STARING AFTER HER.

SHE HAD. HERMIONE RETURNED A BILGATE OF AN EELER LATER WITH THE SILVER  
CLAD FEELER CAREFULLY UNDER HER REES.

"HERMIONE, I DEN'T DENEL WEAT'S GETTEN, INTH YEL LATELY?" SAID REEN,  
ASTHELOED. "FIRST YEL HIT MALPHY, THEN YEL WALK FELT HEN PROFESSER  
TRELLARNEY --"

HERMIONE WHEEDED RATHER FLATTERED.

THEY WENT DEELN TH DINNER WITH EVERYBODY ELSE, ELT DID NOT RETURN TH  
GROFFINDER THER AFTERWARD. HARRY HAD TH CLAD HIDDEN DEELN TH FRONT OF  
HIS REES. HE HAD TH DEEP HIS ARMS FEELER TH HIDE TH CLIP. THEY EXLAKED  
IN AN EMPTY CLARKER OFF TH ENTRANCE HALL, LISTENING, UNTIL THEY WERE  
SURE IT WAS DESERTED. THEY HEARD A LAST PAIR OF PEOPLE FLIRRYING ACROSS  
TH HALL AND A DEER SLAMMING. HERMIONE PEEKED HER HEAD AROUND TH DEER.  
"HAY," SHE WHISPERED, "NEE HNE THERE -- CLAD HEN --"

WALKING VERY CLOSE TOGETHER SEE THAT NOBODY WOULD SEE THEM, THEY CROSSED  
TH HALL HEN TIPTHE BENEATH TH CLAD, THEN WALKED DEELN TH STONE FRONT  
STEPS INTO TH GREENS. TH SUN WAS ALREADY SINKING BEHIND TH FORBIDDEN  
FOREST, GILDING TH TH BRANCHES OF TH TREES.

THE

THEY REACHED HAGRID'S CAGIN AND DEHEEDED. HE WAS A MINUTE IN ANSWERING,  
AND WHEN HE DID, HE WHEEDED ALL AROUND HER HIS VISTHER, PALE-FACED AND  
TREMBLING.

"IT'S US," HARRY HISSED, "WE'RE WEARING TH INVISIBILITY CLAD. LET US  
IN AND WE CAN TAKE IT OFF."

"YEH SEELON'VE HERE?" HAGRID WHISPERED, ELT HE STHEE BACK, AND THEY  
STEPPED INSIDE. HAGRID SHUT TH DEER ELICKLY AND HARRY PULLED OFF TH  
CLAD.

HAGRID WAS NOT CRYING, NEER DID HE THREW HIMSELF UPON THIR NECKS. HE

WHEEDED LIKE A MAN WHO DID NOT KNOW WHERE HE WAS OR WHAT THE DEE. HIS  
HELPLESSNESS WAS WORSE THE WATCH THAN TEARS.

"WAN' SOME TEA?" HE SAID. HIS GREAT HANDS WERE SHAKING AS HE REACHED FOR  
THE KETTLE.

"WHERE'S BLACKBREAD, HAGRID?" SAID FERMINE HESITANTLY.

I -- I THREW HIM HELTSIDE," SAID HAGRID, SPILLING MILK ALL OVER THE TABLE  
AS HE FILLED UP THE ILG. "HE'S TETHERED IN ME PLIMPOIN PATCH. THEUGHT HE  
HEUGHTA SEE THE TREES AN' -- AN' SWEET FRESH AIR -- BEHRE

HAGRID'S HAND TREMBLED SO VIOLENTLY THAT THE MILK ILG SLIPPED FROM HIS  
GRASP AND SPATTERED ALL OVER THE FLOOR.

"I'LL DEE IT, HAGRID," SAID FERMINE BLINKING, FLURRYING OVER AND STARTING  
THE CLEAN UP THE MESS.

"THERE'S ANOTHER ONE IN THE CLIPBOARD," HAGRID SAID, SITTING DOWN AND  
WIPING HIS FOREHEAD ON HIS SLEEVE. HARRY GLANCED AT REIN, WHO WHEEDED BACK  
HELPLESSLY.

"ISN'T THERE ANYTHING ANYONE CAN DEE, HAGRID?" HARRY ASKED FIERCELY,  
SITTING DOWN NEXT TO HIM. "DUMBLEDORE --"

"HE'S TRIED," SAID HAGRID. "HE'S GOT NO POWER TER EVERLUKE THE  
CHEMISTEE. HE THO 'EM BLACKBREAD'S ALL RIGHT, BUT THEY'RE SCARED... YEH

279

KNOW WHAT LUCIUS MALFOY'S LIKE... THREATENED 'EM, I EXPECT... AN' THE  
EXCELTHUNDER, MACNAIR, HE'S AN OLD PAL OF MALFOY'S... BUT IT'LL BE BLIND  
AN' CLEAN... AN' I'LL BE BESIDE HIM.... "

HAGRID SWALLOWED. HIS EYES WERE DARTING ALL OVER THE LADY AS THOUGH  
HEADING FOR SOME STARD OF HER HER CHEMIST.

"DUMBLEDORE'S GONNA COME DOWN WHILE IT -- WHILE IT HAPPENS, WRITE ME  
THIS MORNIN'. SAID HE WANTS TER -- TER BE WITH ME, GREAT MAN,

BLINKLEDHRE...."

F-ERMINE, WHO HAD BEEN ALIMAGING IN F-JAGRID'S CLIPHEARD FOR ANOTHER MILK ILG, LET HLIT A SMALL, HELICIDLY STIPLD SHE. SHE STRAIGHTENED UP WITH THE NEW ILG IN HER HANDS, FIGHTING BACK TEARS.

"WE'LL STAY WITH YELI THEE, F-JAGRID," SHE BEGAN, BUT F-JAGRID STENED HIS SHAGGY HEAD.

"YEF'RE TER GEH BACK UP TER THE CASTLE, I THED YEF, I DEEN' WAN' YEF WATCH-IN'. AN' YEF SHEDDN' BE DEEN HERE ANWAY... IF FLICE AN' BLINKLEDHRE CATCH YEF HLIT WITH HLIT PERMISSIEN, F-JAGRD, YEF'LL BE IN BIG TRELKLE."

SILENT TEARS WERE NEEL STREAMING DEEN F-ERMINE'S FACE, BUT SHE HID THEM FROM F-JAGRID, KLITLING AREHND MAKING TEA. THEN, AS SHE PICKED UP THE MILK BOTTLE THE PEHLR SHEKE INTH THE ILG, SHE LET HLIT A SHRIEK.

"REHN, I DEEN'T BELIEVE IT -- IT'S SLACKERS!"

REHN Gaped AT HER.

"WHAT ARE YELI TALKING AREHLY?"

F-ERMINE CARRIED THE MILK ILG HYER THE THE TABLE AND TURNED IT UPSIDE DEEN, WITH A FRANTIC SHLEAD, AND MUCH SCRAMBLING THE GET BACK INSIDE, SLACKERS THE RAT CAME SLIDING HLIT INTH THE TABLE.

"SLACKERS?" SAID REHN BLANKLY. "SLACKERS, WHAT ARE YELI DEING HERE?"

HE GRABED THE STRUGGLING RAT AND HELD HIM UP TH THE LIGHT. SLACKERS

ZES

HEEDED DREADFUL. HE WAS THINNER THAN EVER, LARGE TUFTS OF HAIR HAD FALLEN HLIT LEAVING WIDE BALD PATCHES, AND HE WRITHED IN REHN'S HANDS AS THEHLYCH DESPERATE THE FREE HIMSELF

"IT'S HEDAY, SLACKERS!" SAID REHN. "NEE CATS! THERE'S NEETHING HERE THE HLIT YELI!"

F-JAGRID SLIDDEENLY STEHH LIP, HIS EYES FIXED ENN THE WINDHILL. F-HIS NEHRMALLY  
RUBBY FACE HAD CHHNE THE CHHHR EN PARCEMENT.

"THEY'RE CHHMIN'..."

F-JARRY, RHHN, AND F-HERMHHNE WHIPPED AHHHLND. A GRHLLP EN MEN WAS WALKING  
DHHLN

THE DISTANT CASTLE STEPS. IN AHHHT WAS AALHS DUMBLEDHRE, HIS SILVER  
BEARD GLHAPING IN THE DYING SLN. NEXT TH HIM TRHHTTED CHHRRNELLIS FLDCR.  
BEHHND THEM CAME THE FEEBLE HND CHHMMITTER MEMBER AND THE EXCELUTHHNER,  
MACNNAIR.

"YEH CHHTTA CH," SAID F-JAGRID, EVERY INCH EN HIM WAS TREPKLING. "THEY  
MLSTN' FIND YEH HERE... CH NHHL..."

RHHN STLOPPED SLAKKERS INTN HIS PHCKET AND F-HERMHHNE PICKED LIP THE CHHAK.

"I'LL LET YEH HHLT THE BACK WAY," SAID F-JAGRID.

THEY AHHLHED HIM TH THE DHHR INTN HIS KACK GARDEN. F-JARRY FELT STRANGELY  
LNNREAL, AND EVEN MHHRE SH WHN HE SAW KLICKREAX A FEW YARDS AWAY, TETHERED  
TH A TREE BEHHND F-JAGRID'S PLIMPKIN PATCH. KLICKREAX SEEMED TH DNHHW  
SHHETHING WAS HAPPENING. F-HE TLARNED HIS SHARP HEAD AHHH SIDE TH SIDE AND  
PALED THE GRHLLND NERVHLLISLY.

"IT'S HHKAY, REAXY," SAID F-JAGRID SHHTLY. "IT'S HHKAY..." F-HE TLARNED TH

F-JARRY, RHHN, AND F-HERMHHNE. "CH HN," HE SAID, "GET CHHIN'."

BLT THEY DHN'T MHHVE.

"F-JAGRID, WE CAN'T --"

"WE'LL TELL THEM WHAT REALLY HAPPENED --"

"THEY CAN'T KILL HIM --"

END

"CHH" SAID F-JAGRID FIERCELY. "IT'S KAD ENHLLGH WTH-HHLT YHLL WHT IN TRHLLKLE  
AN' ALL!"

THEY HAD NO CHOICE. AS FERMINE THREW THE CHAIR OVER HARRY AND RHN, THEY

HEARD VEHICLES AT THE FRONT OF THE CANYON. LAGRID LOOKED AT THE PLACE WHERE THEY HAD JUST VANISHED FROM SIGHT.

"OH HELL," HE SAID HARSHLY, "RHN LISTEN..."

AND HE STRODE BACK INTO HIS CANYON AS SOMETHING CRASHED AT THE FRONT DOOR. SILENTLY, IN A KIND OF TERRIFIED TRANCE, HARRY, RHN, AND FERMINE SET OFF SILENTLY AROUND LAGRID'S HOUSE. AS THEY REACHED THE OTHER SIDE, THE FRONT DOOR CLOSED WITH A SHARP SNAP.

"PLEASE, LET'S HURRY," FERMINE WHISPERED, "I CAN'T STAND IT, I CAN'T BEAR IT..."

THEY STARTED UP THE SLEEPING CANYON TOWARD THE CASTLE. THE SUN WAS SETTING FAST NOW; THE SKY HAD TURNED TO A CLEAR, PURPLE-TINGED GREY, BUT THE WEST THERE WAS A RUBY-RED GLOW.

RHN STOPPED DEAD.

"EH, PLEASE, RHN," FERMINE BEGAN.

"IT'S SCARRERS -- HE WON'T -- STAY PUT --"

RHN WAS KENT OVER, TRYING THE DEEP SCARRERS IN HIS POCKET, BUT THE RAT WAS GOING BERSERK, SHREDDING MADLY, TWISTING AND FLAILING, TRYING TO SINK HIS TEETH INTO RHN'S HAND.

"SCARRERS, IT'S ME, WHY DIDN'T IT'S RHN," RHN HISSED.

THEY HEARD A DOOR OPEN BEHIND THEM AND MEN'S VOICES.

"EH, RHN, PLEASE LET'S MOVE, THEY'RE GOING TO SEE IT," FERMINE BREATHED.

"HURRY -- SCARRERS, STAY PUT --"

END

THEY WALKED FORWARD; HARRY, LIKE FERMINE, WAS TRYING NOT TO LISTEN TO THE RUMBLE OF VEHICLES BEHIND THEM. RHN STOPPED AGAIN.

"I CAN'T HOLD HIM -- SCARRERS, SHUT UP, EVERYONE'LL HEAR US --"



THE RAT WAS SNEAKING WILDLY, BUT NOT LOUDLY ENOUGH TO HEAR UP THE  
SHEDS DRIFTING FROM HAGRID'S GARDEN. THERE WAS A LITTLE OF INDISTINCT  
MULE VEHICLES, A SILENCE, AND THEN, WITHOUT WARNING, THE UNMISTAKABLE  
SWISH AND THUD OF AN AXE.

BERMIONE SLAYED HIM THE SPOT.

"THEY DID IT!" SHE WHISPERED TO HARRY. "I D -- DON'T BELIEVE IT -- THEY  
DID IT!"

## CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

### CAT, RAT, AND DEE

HARRY'S MIND HAD GONE BLANK WITH SHOCK. THE THREE OF THEM STOOD  
TRANSFIXED WITH HORROR UNDER THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK. THE VERY LAST RAYS  
OF THE SETTING SUN WERE CASTING A BLEEDY LIGHT OVER THE LONG-STAYED  
GRHLINDS. THEN, BEHIND THEM, THEY HEARD A WILD HOWLING.

"HAGRID," HARRY MUTTERED, WITHOUT THINKING ABOUT WHAT HE WAS DOING, HE  
MADE THEM TURN BACK, BUT BOTH RON AND BERMIONE SEIZED HIS ARMS.

"WE CAN'T," SAID RON, WHO WAS PAPER-WHITE. "HE'LL BE IN WORSE TROUBLE IF  
THEY KNOW WE'VE BEEN TO SEE HIM...."

BERMIONE'S BREATHING WAS SHALLOWS AND UNEVEN.

"THEY -- CHILD -- THEY?" SHE CHECKED. "THEY CHILD THEY?"

"THEY EN," SAID RON, WHOSE TEETH SEEMED TO BE CHATTERING.

THEY SET OFF BACK TOWARD THE CASTLE, WALKING SLOWLY TO KEEP THEMSELVES  
HIDDEN UNDER THE CLOAK. THE LIGHT WAS FADING FAST NOW.

END

BY THE TIME THEY REACHED OPEN GRHLIND, DARKNESS WAS SETTLING LIKE A SPELL  
AROUND THEM.

"SLACKERS, KEEP STILL," RON HISSED, CLAMPING HIS HAND OVER HIS CHEST.

THE RAT WAS WRIGGLING MADLY. RON CAME TO A SUDDEN HALT, TRYING TO FORCE

SLACKERS DEEPER INTO HIS POCKET. "WHAT'S THE MATTER WITH YOU, YOU STUPID RAT? STAY STILL -- HELIX! HE HIT ME!"

"RHHN, RE RHJHT!" HERMINE WHISPERED URGENTLY. "FLJGE'LL RE RHJHT HERE IN A MINUTE --"

"HE WHENT -- STAY -- PLJT --"

SLACKERS WAS PLAINLY TERRIFIED, HE WAS WRITHING WITH ALL HIS MIGHT, TRYING TO BREAK FREE OF RHHN'S GRIP.

"WHAT'S THE MATTER WITH HIM?"

BUT HARRY HAD JUST SEEN -- STINKING TOWARD THEM, HIS BODY BENEATH THE GREENING, WIDE YELLOW EYES GLINTING FURILY IN THE DARKNESS -- CRHHXST-IANDS. WHETHER HE COULD SEE THEM OR WAS FEELING THE SHLIND OF SLACKERS'S SHLEADS, HARRY COULDN'T TELL.

"CRHHXST-IANDS!" HERMINE MEANED. "NHH, GHH ALJAY, CRHHXST-IANDS! GHH ALJAY!" BUT THE CAT WAS GETTING NEARER --

"SLACKERS -- NHH!"

THEH LATE -- THE RAT HAD SLIPPED BETWEEN RHHN'S CLUTCHING FINGERS, HIT THE GREENING, AND STAMPERED AWAY. IN ONE SHLIND, CRHHXST-IANDS SPRANG AFTER HIM, AND BEFORE HARRY OR HERMINE COULD STOP HIM, RHHN HAD THROWN THE INVISIBILITY CHLAD OFF HIMSELF AND PELTED AWAY INTO THE DARKNESS.

"RHHN!" HERMINE MEANED.

SHE AND HARRY LOOKED AT EACH OTHER, THEN RHHLED AT A SPRINT; IT WAS IMPOSSIBLE THE RUN WOULD HIT UNDER THE CHLAD; THEY PULLED IT OFF AND IT STREAMED BEHIND THEM LIKE A BANNER AS THEY FLIRTLED AFTER RHHN; THEY COULD HEAR HIS FEET THUNDERING AHEAD AND HIS SHLITS AT CRHHXST-IANDS.

277

"GET AWAY FROM HIM -- GET AWAY -- SLACKERS, COME HERE --"

THERE WAS A WHLD THLD.

"GET UP! GET UP, YOU STINKING CAT --"

HARRY AND HERMIONE ALMOST FELL OVER REIN; THEY SKIPPED THE A STEP RIGHT IN FRONT OF HIM. HE WAS SPRAWLED ON THE GROUND, BUT STARRERS WAS BACK IN HIS POCKET; HE HAD BOTH HANDS HELD TIGHT OVER THE BULGING LUMP.

"REIN -- COME ON BACK UNDER THE CHAIR --" HERMIONE PANTED. "DUMBLEDORE THE MINISTER -- THEY'LL BE COMING BACK HERE IN A MINUTE --"

BUT BEFORE THEY COULD CHEER THEMSELVES AGAIN, BEFORE THEY COULD EVEN CATCH THEIR BREATH, THEY HEARD THE SOFT POUNDING OF GIANTIC PAIS... SOMETHING WAS BEHINDING THEM, QUIET AS A SHADOW -- AN ENORMOUS, PALE-EYED, IET-BLACK BEG.

HARRY REACHED FOR HIS WAND, BUT THEN LATE -- THE BEG HAD MADE AN ENORMOUS LEAP AND THE FRONT PAIS HIT HIM ON THE CHEST; HE BECAME OVER BACKWARD IN A WHIRL OF HAIR; HE FELT ITS HOT BREATH, SAW INCH-LONG TEETH --

BUT THE FORCE OF ITS LEAP HAD CARRIED IT TOO FAR; IT ROLLED OFF HIM.

Dazed, feeling as though his ribs were broken, HARRY TRIED TO STAND UP; HE COULD HEAR IT GRUNTING AS IT SKIPPED AROUND FOR A NEW ATTACK.

REIN WAS ON HIS FEET, AS THE BEG SPRANG BACK TOWARD THEM HE PULSED HARRY ASIDE; THE BEG'S TAIL FASTENED INSTEAD AROUND REIN'S ELONGSTRETCHED ARM.

HARRY LUNGED FORWARD, HE GRIPPED A HANDFUL OF THE BEG'S HAIR, BUT IT WAS DRAGGING REIN AWAY AS EASILY AS THOUGH HE WERE A BAG OF FLUFF --

THEN, JUST AS NEARLY, SOMETHING HIT HARRY ON THE BACK OF THE HEAD HE WAS KICKED OFF HIS FEET AGAIN. HE HEARD HERMIONE SCREAM WITH PAIN AND FALL TOO.

HARRY GRIPPED FOR HIS WAND, BLINKING BLIND JUST OF HIS EYES

"DUMBLEDORE!" HE WHISPERED.

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THE HANDLIGHT SHOWED HIM THE TRUNK OF A THICK TREE; THEY HAD CHASED

SCARERS INTO THE SHADE OF THE WHIPPING WILLOW AND ITS BRANCHES WERE CREAKING AS THOUGH IN A HIGH WIND, WHIPPING BACKWARD AND FORWARD THE STEP THEM GOING NEARER.

AND THERE, AT THE BASE OF THE TRUNK, WAS THE DEE, DRAGGING REEN BACKWARD INTO A LARGE GAP IN THE BARKS -- REEN WAS FIGHTING FURIOUSLY, BUT HIS HEAD AND THROAT WERE SLIPPING OUT OF SIGHT --

"REEN!" HARRY SHOUTED, TRYING THE FEELER, BUT A HEAVY BRANCH WHIPPED LETHALLY THROUGH THE AIR AND HE WAS FORCED BACKWARD AGAIN.

ALL THEY COULD SEE NOW WAS ONE OF REEN'S LEGS, WHICH HE HAD PUNCHED AROUND A BARK IN AN EFFORT THE STEP THE DEE FROM PULLING HIM FARTHER UNDERGROUND -- BUT A HORRIBLE CRACK CUT THE AIR LIKE A GLASS CUT; REEN'S LEG HAD BROKEN, AND A MOMENT LATER, HIS FOOT VANISHED FROM SIGHT.

"HARRY -- WE'VE GOT TO GO FOR HELP --" HERMIONE GASPED; SHE WAS BLEEDING THEM; THE WILLOW HAD CUT HER ACROSS THE SHOULDER.

"NOW THAT THING'S BIG ENOUGH TO EAT HIM; WE HAVEN'T GOT TIME --"

"HARRY -- WE'RE NEVER GOING TO GET THROUGH WITHOUT HELP --"

ANOTHER BRANCH WHIPPED DOWN AT THEM, THINGS CLENCHED LIKE BOKKLES.

"IF THAT DEE CAN GET IN, WE CAN," HARRY PARTED, DARTING HERE AND THERE, TRYING TO FIND A WAY THROUGH THE VICIOUS, SWISHING BRANCHES, BUT HE COULDN'T GET AN INCH NEARER THE TREE BARKS WITHOUT BEING IN RANGE OF THE TREE'S KNEES.

"HI, HELP, HELP," HERMIONE WHISPERED FRANTICALLY, DANCING L.J. CERTAINLY IN THE SPOT, "PLEASE..."

CRIBBAGE HANDS DARTED FORWARD, HE SLITHERED BETWEEN THE BATTERING BRANCHES LIKE A SNAKE AND PLACED HIS FRONT PAWS UPON A BARK IN THE TRUNK. ABRUPTLY, AS THOUGH THE TREE HAD BEEN TURNED THE MARKER, IT STOPPED MOVING. NOT A LEAF TWITCHED OR SHOOK.

"CRIBBLES-I-ANDS!" FERMINE WHISPERED UNCERTAINLY. SHE NOW GRASPED HARRY'S ARM PAINFULLY HARD. "HE'D DID HE DNEH --?"

"HE'S FRIENDS WITH THAT DNEH," SAID HARRY GRIMLY. "I'VE SEEN THEM TOGETHER, COME HN -- AND KEEP THEIR HANDS HLT --"

THEY COVERED THE DISTANCE THE THE TUNNEL IN SECONDS, BUT BEFORE THEY HAD REACHED THE GAP IN THE ROOFS, CRIBBLES-I-ANDS HAD SLID INTO IT WITH A FLICK OF HIS RATTLECRUSH-TAIL. HARRY WENT NEXT; HE CRAWLED FORWARD, HEADFIRST, AND SLID DOWN AN EARTH-SLEEP THE THE RATTLE OF A VERY LOW TUNNEL.

CRIBBLES-I-ANDS WAS A LITTLE WAY ALONG, HIS EYES FLASHING IN THE LIGHT FROM HARRY'S HAND. SECONDS LATER, FERMINE SLITHERED DOWN BESIDE HIM.

"WHERE'S RHN?" SHE WHISPERED IN A TERRIFIED VOICE.

"THIS WAY," SAID HARRY, SETTING OFF, KENT-BACKED, AFTER CRIBBLES-I-ANDS.

"WHERE DOES THIS TUNNEL COME HLT?" FERMINE ASKED KREATHELESSLY FROM BEHIND HIM.

"I DNEH'T DNEH... IT'S MARKED HN THE MARALDER'S MAP BUT FRED AND GEORGE SAID NEH HNE'S EVER GETTEN INTO IT... IT GHEES OFF THE EDGE OF THE MAP, BUT IT LHHKED LIKE IT WAS HEADING FOR FHEGMEADE..."

THEY MOVED AS FAST AS THEY COULD, KENT ALMOST DNEH; AHEAD OF THEM, CRIBBLES-I-ANDS'S TAIL KHEKED IN AND HLT OF VIEW. HN AND HN WENT THE PASSAGE; IT FELT AT LEAST AS LONG AS THE HNE THE FHEGMEADES... ALL HARRY COULD THINK OF WAS RHN AND WHAT THE RHEHMHLS DNE MIGHT BE DOING THE HIM... HE WAS DRAWING KREATH IN SHARP, PAINFUL GASTS, RUNNING AT A CRHLEH... AND THEN THE TUNNEL BEGAN THE RISE; MOMENTS LATER IT TWISTED, AND CRIBBLES-I-ANDS HAD GONE. INSTEAD, HARRY COULD SEE A PATCH OF DIM LIGHT THROUGH A SMALL OPENING.

AND THEN THE TUNNEL BEGAN THE RISE; MOMENTS LATER IT TWISTED, AND

CRIBBLES-I-ANDS HAD GONE. INSTEAD, HARRY COULD SEE A PATCH OF DIM LIGHT THROUGH A SMALL OPENING.

HE AND FERMINE PAUSED, GASPING FOR KREATH, EDGING FORWARD, BOTH RAISED THEIR HANDS THE SEE WHAT WAS BEYOND.

IT WAS A REEM, A VERY DISORDERED, DUSTY REEM, PAPER WAS PEELING FROM THE WALLS; THERE WERE STAINS ALL OVER THE FLOOR; EVERY PIECE OF FURNITURE

WAS

WAS BROKEN AS THOUGH SOMEONE HAD SMASHED IT. THE WINDHLS WERE ALL BOWED UP.

HARRY GLANCED AT HERMINE, WHO LOOKED VERY FRIGHTENED BUT NEEDED. HARRY PULLED HIMSELF UP TO THE FLOOR, STARING AROUND. THE REEM WAS DESERTED, BUT A DOOR TO THEIR RIGHT STOOD OPEN, LEADING TO A SEVERELY HALLWAY. HERMINE SUDDENLY GRABBED HARRY'S ARM AGAIN. HER WIDE EYES WERE TRAVELING AROUND THE BOWED WINDHLS.

"HARRY," SHE WHISPERED, "I THINK WE'RE IN THE STRIPPING SHED."

HARRY LOOKED AROUND. HIS EYES FELL ON A BOWED CHAIR NEAR THEM. LARGE CHAIRS HAD BEEN THROWN UP TO IT; ONE OF THE LEGS HAD BEEN RIPPED OFF ENTIRELY.

"GHOSTS DIDN'T DO THAT," HE SAID SILENTLY.

AT THAT MOMENT, THERE WAS A CREAK OVERHEAD. SOMETHING HAD MOVED UPSTAIRS. BOTH OF THEM LOOKED UP AT THE CEILING. HERMINE'S GRIP ON HARRY'S ARM WAS SO TIGHT HE WAS BEING PULLED IN HIS FINGERS. HE RAISED HIS EYEBROWS AT HER; SHE NODDED AGAIN AND LET GO.

INSTANTLY AS THEY COULD, THEY CROPT UP INTO THE HALL AND UP THE CRUMBLING STAIRCASE. EVERYTHING WAS COVERED IN A THICK LAYER OF DUST EXCEPT THE FLOOR, WHERE A WIDE SHINY STRIKE HAD BEEN MADE BY SOMETHING BEING DRAGGED UPSTAIRS.

THEY REACHED THE DARK LANDING.

"NOW," THEY WHISPERED TOGETHER, AND THE LIGHTS AT THE END OF THEIR HANDS WENT UP. ONLY ONE DOOR WAS OPEN. AS THEY CROPT TOWARD IT, THEY HEARD MOVEMENT FROM BEHIND IT; A LOW MEAN, AND THEN A DEEP, LOW PURRING. THEY

EXCHANGED A LAST LOOK, A LAST NOD.

LAND FELD TIGHTLY BEHIND HIM, F-JARRY KICKED THE DOOR WIDE OPEN,

THEN A MAGNIFICENT PHEASANT BED WITH GLISTY HANGINGS LAY CROSSWISE,

FLIPPING BEHIND AT THE SIGHT OF THEM. THEN THE PHEASANT BESIDE HIM, CLUTCHING

HIS LEG, WHICH STUCK OUT AT A STRANGE ANGLE, WAS REIN.

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F-JARRY AND F-ERMINEE DASHED ACROSS THE HALL.

"REIN -- ARE YOU OKAY?"

"WHERE'S THE DOG?"

"NOT A DOG," REIN MEANED, HIS TEETH WERE GRITTED WITH PAIN. "F-JARRY, IT'S  
A TRAP --"

"WHAT --"

"HE'S THE DOG... HE'S AN ANIMALIS."

REIN WAS STARING OVER F-JARRY'S SHOULDER, F-JARRY WHEELED AROUND, WITH A  
SNAP, THE MAN IN THE SHADOWS CLOSED THE DOOR BEHIND THEM.

A MASS OF FILTHY, MATTED HAIR HUNG THE HIS EYES. IF EYES HADN'T BEEN  
SHINING OUT OF THE DEEP, DARK SOCKETS, HE MIGHT HAVE BEEN A CORPSE. THE  
WAXY SKIN WAS STRETCHED SO TIGHTLY OVER THE BONES OF HIS FACE, IT LOOKED  
LIKE A SKULL. HIS YELLOW TEETH WERE BARED IN A GRIN. IT WAS STIRLING  
BLACK.

"EXPELLIARMUS!" HE CRIED, POINTING REIN'S HAND AT THEM.

F-JARRY'S AND F-ERMINEE'S HANDS SPENT OUT OF THEIR HANDS, HIGH IN THE AIR,  
AND BLACK CAUGHT THEM. THEN HE TOOK A STEP CLOSER, HIS EYES WERE FIXED  
ON F-JARRY.

"I THOUGHT YOU'D COME AND HELP YOUR FRIEND," HE SAID HARSHLY.

HIS VOICE SOUNDED AS THOUGH HE HAD BEEN SINCE THE FIRST OF LIVING  
IT. "YOUR FATHER WOULD HAVE DONE THE SAME FOR ME. BRAVE OF YOU! NOT THE  
RUN FOR A TEACHER. I'M GRATEFUL... IT WILL MAKE EVERYTHING MUCH

EASIER..."

THE TALINT ABELT HIS FATHER RANG IN HARRY'S EARS AS TELLICH BLACK HAD BELLEVED IT, A BRILLING HATE ERUPTED IN HARRY'S CHEST, LEAVING NO PLACE FOR FEAR, FOR THE FIRST TIME IN HIS LIFE, HE WANTED HIS HAND BACK IN HIS HAND, NOT TO DEFEND HIMSELF, BUT TO ATTACK... THE KILL, WITHOUT DOWELING

284

WHAT HE WAS DOING, HE STARTED FORWARD, BUT THERE WAS A SUDDEN MOVEMENT ON EITHER SIDE OF HIM AND TWO PAIRS OF HANDS GRABBED HIM AND HELD HIM BACK... "NO, HARRY!" HERMIONE GASPED IN A PETRIFIED WHISPER, THEN, HOWEVER, SPEAK THE BLACK.

"IF YOU WANT TO KILL HARRY, YOU'LL HAVE TO KILL US THREE!" HE SAID FIERCELY, TELLICH THE EFFORT OF STANDING UPRIGHT WAS DRAINING HIM OF STILL MORE ENERGY, AND HE SWAYED SLIGHTLY AS HE SPEAKED. SOMETHING FLICKERED IN BLACK'S SHADOWED EYES.

"BE QUIET," HE SAID QUIETLY THEN, "YOU WILL DAMAGE THAT LEG EVEN MORE."

"DID YOU HEAR ME?" RON SAID WEABLY, TELLICH HE WAS CLINGING PAINFULLY TO HARRY TO STAY UPRIGHT, "YOU'LL HAVE TO KILL ALL THREE OF US!"

"THERE'LL BE ONLY ONE MURDER HERE TONIGHT," SAID BLACK, AND HIS GRIN WIDENED.

"WHO'S THAT?" HARRY SPAT, TRYING TO WRENCH HIMSELF FREE OF RON, AND HERMIONE, "DIDN'T CARE LAST TIME, DID YOU? DIDN'T MIND SLAUGHTERING ALL THESE MUGGLES WHO GET AT PETTIGREW... WHAT'S THE MATTER, GONE SILENT IN AZKABAN?"

"HARRY!" HERMIONE WHIMPERED, "BE QUIET!"

"HE KILLED MY MOM AND DAD!" HARRY REARED, AND WITH A FLICK OF EFFORT HE BROKE FREE OF HERMIONE'S AND RON'S RESTRAINT AND LUNGED FORWARD -



HE HAD FORGOTTEN ABILITY MAGIC -- HE HAD FORGOTTEN THAT HE WAS SHORT AND  
SKINNY AND THIRTEEN, WHEREAS BLACK WAS A TALL, FULL-GROWN MAN -- ALL  
HARRY KNEW WAS THAT HE WANTED THE FLIRT BLACK AS BADLY AS HE COULD AND  
THAT HE DIDN'T CARE HOW MUCH HE GOT FLIRT IN RETURN --  
PERHAPS IT WAS THE SENSE OF HARRY DOING SOMETHING SO STUPID, BUT BLACK  
DIDN'T RAISE THE HANDS IN TIME -- ONE OF HARRY'S HANDS FASTENED OVER HIS  
WASTED WRIST, PULLING THE HAND TIPS AWAY; THE BONES OF HARRY'S OTHER  
HAND COLLIDED WITH THE SIDE OF BLACK'S HEAD AND THEY FELL, BACKWARD,  
INTO THE WALL -

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BERMIONE WAS SCREAMING; RHN WAS YELLING; THERE WAS A BLINDING FLASH AS  
THE HANDS IN BLACK'S HAND SENT A LOT OF SPARKS INTO THE AIR THAT MISSED  
HARRY'S FACE BY INCHES; HARRY FELT THE STUNNED ARM UNDER HIS FINGERS  
TWISTING MADLY, BUT HE KNEW HIM, HIS OTHER HAND PUNCHING EVERY PART OF  
BLACK IT COULD FIND,

BUT BLACK'S FREE HAND HAD FOUND HARRY'S THROAT

"NHH," HE HISSED, "I'VE WAITED TOO LONG --"

THE FINGERS TIGHTENED, HARRY CROOKED, HIS GLASSES ASKED,

THEN HE SAW BERMIONE'S ARM SWING OUT OF NOWHERE, BLACK LET GO OF HARRY  
WITH A GRUNT OF PAIN; RHN HAD THROWN HIMSELF ON BLACK'S HAND HAND AND  
HARRY HEARD A FAINT CLATTER --

HE ALMOST FELL ON THE TANGLE OF KIDIES AND SAW HIS OWN HAND ROLLING  
ACROSS THE FLOOR; HE THREW HIMSELF TOWARD IT BUT

"ARCH!"

CRIBBET-HANDS HAD THROWN THE PRAY; BOTH SETS OF PRIST CLAWS HAD SLID  
THEMSELVES DEEP INTO HARRY'S ARM; HARRY THREW HIMSELF, BUT CRIBBET-HANDS  
HAD DARTED TOWARD HARRY'S HAND --

"DID YOU DENY IT?" ROARED HARRY, AND HE AIMED A KICK AT CRIBBS' HANDS THAT

MADE THE CAT LEAP ASIDE, SPITTING; HARRY SNATCHED UP HIS HAND AND TURNED

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"GET OUT OF THE WAY!" HE SCREAMED AT BEN AND FERMINE.

THEY DIDN'T NEED TELLING TWICE, FERMINE, GASPING FOR BREATH, HER LIP BLEEDING, STRAMBLER ASIDE, SNATCHING UP HER AND BEN'S HANDS, BEN CRAWLED THE THE ALUM-PESTER AND COLLAPSED INTO IT, PANTING, HIS WHITE FACE REDDENING WITH GREEN, BOTH HANDS CLUTCHING HIS BROKEN LEG.

BLACK WAS SPRAWLED AT THE BOTTOM OF THE WALL, HIS THIN CHEST RISE AND FELL RAPIDLY AS HE WATCHED HARRY WALKING SILENTLY NEARER, HIS HAND POINTING STRAIGHT AT BLACK'S HEART.

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"GIVE ME THE KILL ME, HARRY?" HE WHISPERED.

HARRY STOPPED RIGHT ABOVE HIM, HIS HAND STILL POINTING AT BLACK'S CHEST, WHISPERING DOWN AT HIM. A LIVID ERLISE WAS RISING AROUND BLACK'S LEFT EYE AND HIS NECK WAS BLEEDING.

"YOU KILLED MY PARENTS," SAID HARRY, HIS VOICE SHAKING SLIGHTLY, BUT HIS HAND HAND WHITE STEADY.

BLACK STARED UP AT HIM WITH THESE SLANDER EYES.

"I DIDN'T DENY IT," HE SAID VERY QUIETLY, "BUT IF YOU KNOW THE WHOLE STORY,"

"THE WHOLE STORY?" HARRY REPEATED, A FLUTTERING FEELING IN HIS EARS. "YOU TOLD THEM THE VERDICT, THAT'S ALL I NEED TO KNOW."

"YOU'VE GOT TO LISTEN TO ME," BLACK SAID, AND THERE WAS A NOTE OF URGENCY IN HIS VOICE NOW. "YOU'LL REGRET IT IF YOU DON'T... YOU DON'T UNDERSTAND..."

"I UNDERSTAND A LOT BETTER THAN YOU THINK," SAID HARRY, AND HIS VOICE SOUNDED MORE THAN EVER. "YOU NEVER HEARD HER, DID YOU? MY MOM... TRYING TO

STEP YHDERMERT KILLING ME... AND YELI DID THAT... YELI DID IT...."

BEFORE EITHER OF THEM COULD SAY ANOTHER WORD, SOMETHING GINGER STREAKED PAST F-JARRY; CRIBBIX-IANDS LEAPT INTO BLACK'S CHEST AND SETTLED HIMSELF THERE, RIGHT OVER BLACK'S HEART. BLACK BLINKED AND LEECHES DOWN AT THE CAT.

"GET OFF," HE MURMURED, TRYING TO PUSH CRIBBIX-IANDS OFF HIM.

BUT CRIBBIX-IANDS SANK HIS CLAWS INTO BLACK'S REEKS AND WOULDN'T SHIFT. HE TURNED HIS LELY, SEHAST-IED FACE TO F-JARRY AND LEECHES UP AT HIM WITH THESE GREAT YELLEN EYES. THEN HIS RIGHT, F-JERMINE GAVE A DRY SEE.

F-JARRY STARED DOWN AT BLACK AND CRIBBIX-IANDS, HIS GRIP TIGHTENING ON THE WAND. SEE WHAT IF HE HAD THE WILL TO KILL THE CAT THEN? IT WAS IN LEAGUE WITH BLACK.... IF IT WAS PREPARED TO DIE, TRYING TO PROTECT BLACK, THAT

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WASN'T F-JARRY'S BUSINESS.... IF BLACK WANTED TO SAVE IT, THAT ONLY PROVED HE CARED MORE FOR CRIBBIX-IANDS THAN FOR F-JARRY'S PARENTS....

F-JARRY RAISED THE WAND. NOW WAS THE MOMENT TO DO IT, NOW WAS THE MOMENT TO AVENGE HIS MOTHER AND FATHER, HE WAS GOING TO KILL BLACK, HE HAD TO KILL BLACK. THIS WAS HIS CHANCE....

THE SECONDS LENGTHENED, AND STILL F-JARRY STOOD FROZEN THERE, WAND POISED, BLACK STARING UP AT HIM, CRIBBIX-IANDS IN HIS CHEST. RHN'S RAGGED BREATHING CAME FROM NEAR THE BED; F-JERMINE WAS BLITE SILENT.

AND THEN CAME A NEW SOUND -

MUFFLED FOOTSTEPS WERE ECHOING UP THROUGH THE FLOOR -- SOMEONE WAS MOVING DOWNSTAIRS.

"LOOK UP THERE!" F-JERMINE SCREAMED SUDDENLY. "LOOK UP THERE -- STIRLIS

BLACK - HELIX!"

BLACK MADE A STARTLED MOVEMENT THAT ALMOST DISLODGED CRIBBLESFHANDS; HARRY GRIPPED HIS WAND CERVICALLY -- DID IT NEVER SAY A VOICE IN HIS HEAD -- BUT THE FOOTSTEPS WERE THUNDERING UP THE STAIRS AND HARRY STILL HADN'T HEARD IT.

THE MOMENT OF THE CRASH FIRST HAPPEN IN A FLASH OF RED SPARKS AND HARRY WHEELED AROUND AS PROFESSOR KLIPIN CAME FLYING INTO THE ROOM, HIS FACE BLEEDLESS, HIS WAND RAISED AND READY, HIS EYES FLICKERED OVER RON, LYING ON THE FLOOR, OVER HERMION, COWERING NEXT TO THE MOMENT, THE HARRY, STANDING THERE WITH HIS WAND COVERING BLACK, AND THEN THE BLACK HIMSELF, CRUMPLED AND BLEEDING AT HARRY'S FEET.

"EXPPELLIARMUS!" KLIPIN SCREAMED.

HARRY'S WAND FLEW BACK MORE HOT THAN HIS HAND; SHE DID THE THEN HERMION WAS HOLDING, KLIPIN CALLED THEM ALL DEFTLY, THEN MOVED INTO THE ROOM, STARING AT BLACK, WHO STILL HAD CRIBBLESFHANDS LYING PROTECTIVELY ACROSS HIS CHEST, HARRY STOOD THERE, FEELING SUDDENLY EMPTY, HE HADN'T HEARD IT, HIS NERVE HAD FAILED HIM, BLACK WAS GOING THE OTHER WAY BACK THE OTHER DEMENTERS.

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THEN KLIPIN SPEAK, IN A VERY TENSE VOICE.

"WHERE IS HE, SIRILIS?"

HARRY LOOKED BLINDLY AT KLIPIN, HE DIDN'T UNDERSTAND WHAT KLIPIN MEANT.

WHO WAS KLIPIN TALKING ABOUT? HE TURNED THE LOOK AT BLACK AGAIN.

BLACK'S FACE WAS WHITE EXPRESSINGLESS, FOR A FEW SECONDS, HE DIDN'T MOVE AT ALL. THEN, VERY SILENTLY, HE RAISED HIS EMPTY HAND AND POINTED STRAIGHT AT RON. MYSTIFIED, HARRY GLANCED AROUND AT RON, WHO LOOKED BEMUSED.

"BUT THEN..." KLIPIN MUTTERED, STARING AT BLACK SHE INTENTLY IT SEEMED HE WAS TRYING TO READ HIS MIND, "... WHY HASN'T HE SHOWN HIMSELF YET? NEVER? UNLESS" -- KLIPIN'S EYES SUDDENLY WIDENED, AS THOUGH HE WAS SEEING SOMETHING BEHIND BLACK, SOMETHING NONE OF THE REST COULD SEE, "... UNLESS

HE WAS THE HUNK... UNLESS YELI SWITCHED... WITHOUT TELLING ME?"

VERY SILENTLY, HIS STUNNED GAZE NEVER LEAVING LUPIN'S FACE, BLACK NEEDED,

"PROFESSOR," HARRY INTERRUPTED WILDLY, "WHAT'S GOING ON --?"

BUT HE NEVER FINISHED THE QUESTIONS, BECAUSE WHAT HE SAW MADE HIS VEHICLE

DIE IN HIS THREAT, LUPIN WAS LOWERING HIS HAND, GAZING FIXED AT BLACK,

THE PROFESSOR WALKED THE BLACK'S SIDE, SEIZED HIS HAND, PULLED HIM TO HIS

FEET SHE THAT CRIBBED-HANDS FELL TO THE FLOOR, AND EMBRACED BLACK LIKE A

BROTHER,

HARRY FELT AS THOUGH THE BROTHER HAD DROPPED OUT OF HIS STOMACH,

"DIDN'T BELIEVE IT!" HERMIONE SCREAMED,

LUPIN LET GO OF BLACK AND TURNED TO HER, SHE HAD RAISED HERSELF OFF THE

FLOOR AND WAS POINTING AT LUPIN, WILD-EYED, "YELI -- YELI --"

"HERMIONE --"

"-- YELI AND HIM?"

"HERMIONE, CALM DOWN --"

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"I DIDN'T TELL ANYONE!" HERMIONE SHRIEKED, "I'VE BEEN CHEERING UP FOR

YELI --"

"HERMIONE, LISTEN TO ME, PLEASE" LUPIN BEHEATED, "I CAN EXPLAIN --"

HARRY COULD FEEL HIMSELF SHAKING, NOT WITH FEAR, BUT WITH A FRESH WAVE

OF FLURY,

"I TRUSTED YELI," HE BEHEATED AT LUPIN, HIS VEHICLE WAVING, OUT OF

CONTROL, "AND ALL THE TIME YELI'VE BEEN HIS FRIEND?"

"YELI'RE LYING," SAID LUPIN, "I HAVEN'T BEEN SIRILIS'S FRIEND, BUT I AM

NEED -- LET ME EXPLAIN..."

"NO!" HERMIONE SCREAMED, "HARRY, DON'T TRUST HIM, HE'S BEEN HELPING

BLACK GET INTO THE CASTLE, HE WANTS YELI DEAD THEN -- HE'S A WEREWOLF?"

THERE WAS A RINGING SILENCE. EVERYONE'S EYES WERE FLEW IN FLIPIN, WITH  
LOOKED REMARKABLY CALM, THOUGH RATHER PALE.

"NOT AT ALL UP THE YOUR USUAL STANDARD, HERMIONE," HE SAID, "ONLY ONE LEFT  
OF THREE, I'M AFRAID, I HAVE NOT BEEN HELPING SIRIUS GET INTO THE CASTLE  
AND I CERTAINLY DIDN'T WANT HARRY DEAD. AN EDD SNIFFER PASSED OVER HIS  
FACE, "BUT I WON'T DENY THAT I AM A WEREWOLF."

REIN MADE A VALIANT EFFORT TO GET UP AGAIN BUT FELL BACK WITH A WHIMPER  
OF PAIN. FLIPIN MADE TOWARD HIM, LOOKING CONCERNED, BUT REIN GASPED, "GET  
AWAY FROM ME, WEREWOLF!"

FLIPIN STOPPED DEAD, THEN, WITH AN EFFORT, HE TURNED TO HERMIONE  
AND SAID, "THEY LONG HAVE YOU KNOWN?"

"YES," HERMIONE WHISPERED, "SINCE I DID PROFESSOR SNAPE'S ESSAY..."

"HE'LL BE DELIGHTED," SAID FLIPIN CHEERILY, "HE ASSIGNED THAT ESSAY HELPING  
SOMEONE WHO'D REALIZE WHAT MY SYMPTOMS MEANT... DID YOU CHECK THE LUNAR  
CHART AND REALIZE THAT I WAS ALWAYS ILL AT THE FULL MOON? OR DID YOU  
REALIZE THAT THE KEGGART CHANGED INTO THE MOON WHEN IT SAW ME?"

END

"BOTH," HERMIONE SAID QUIETLY.

FLIPIN GAVE A LAUGH.

"YOU'RE THE CLEVEREST WITCH OF YOUR AGE I'VE EVER MET, HERMIONE."

"I'M NOT," HERMIONE WHISPERED, "IF I'D BEEN A BIT CLEVERER, I'D HAVE  
TOLD EVERYONE WHAT YOU ARE!"

"BUT THEY ALREADY KNOW," SAID FLIPIN, "AT LEAST, THE STAFF DO."

"DUMBLEDORE FIRED YOU WHEN HE KNEW YOU WERE A WEREWOLF, REIN GASPED, "IS  
HE MAD?"

"SOME OF THE STAFF THOUGHT SO," SAID FLIPIN, "HE HAD THE WHOLE VERY HARD TO  
CONVINCE CERTAIN TEACHERS THAT I'M TOLERABLE --"

"AND HE WAS WRITING!" HARRY YELLED, "YOU'VE BEEN HELPING HIM  
ALL

THE TIME?"

HE WAS POINTING AT BLACK, WHO SUDDENLY CROSSED THE THE PLASTER RED  
AND SAND BENT IT, HIS FACE HIDDEN IN ONE SHADING HAND. CRIBBET-LEADS LEAPT  
UP BESIDE HIM AND STEPPED BENT HIS LAP, PLURING. REIN EDGED AWAY FROM  
BENT HE THEM, DRAGGING HIS LEG.

I HAVE NOT BEEN HELPING SIRILIS," SAID LUPIN. "IF YOU'LL GIVE ME A  
CHANCE, I'LL EXPLAIN. BENT --"

HE SEPARATED HARRY'S, REIN'S AND HERMIONE'S HANDS AND THREW EACH BACK THE  
ITS OWNER; HARRY CALIGHT HIS, STUNNED.

THERE, SAID LUPIN, STICKING HIS OWN HAND BACK INTO HIS BELT "YOU'RE  
ARMED, WE'RE NOT. NOW WILL YOU LISTEN?"

HARRY DIDN'T KNOW WHAT TO THINK, WAS IT A TRICK?

"IF YOU HAVEN'T BEEN HELPING HIM," HE SAID, WITH A FLIRTLIS GLANCE AT  
BLACK, "HOW DID YOU KNOW HE WAS HERE?"

"THE MAP," SAID LUPIN. "THE MARAUDER'S MAP, I WAS IN MY OFFICE EXAMINING  
IT --"

271

"YOU KNOW HOW TO WORK IT?" HARRY SAID SUSPICIOUSLY.

"OF COURSE I KNOW HOW TO WORK IT," SAID LUPIN, WAVING HIS HAND  
IMPATIENTLY. "I HELPED WRITE IT. I'M MENDING -- THAT WAS MY FRIENDS'  
NICKNAME FOR ME AT SCHOOL."

"YOU WRITE --?"

"THE IMPORTANT THING IS, I WAS WATCHING IT CAREFULLY THIS EVENING,  
BECAUSE I HAD AN IDEA THAT YOU, REIN, AND HERMIONE MIGHT TRY AND SNEAK  
BENT OF THE CASTLE THE VISIT HAGRID BEFORE HIS HIPPOGRIF WAS EXCITED.  
AND I WAS RIGHT, WASN'T I?"

HE HAD STARTED THE PACE UP AND DOWN, LEERING AT THEM, LITTLE PATCHES OF

GLIST RESE AT HIS FEET.

"THEY MIGHT HAVE BEEN WEARING THEIR FATHER'S HED CHEAD, F-JARRY--"

"F-JELLY D'THEY KNOW ABOUT THE CHEAD?"

"THE NEXTER HF TIMES I SAW JAMES DISAPPEARING UNDER IT...", SAID LLIPIN, WAVING AN IMPATIENT HAND AGAIN. "THE POINT IS, EVEN IF THEY'RE WEARING AN INVISIBILITY CHEAD, THEY STILL SEEMED LIP BEN THE MARALIDER'S MAP. I WATCHED THEM CROSS THE GREENLANDS AND ENTER F-JAGRID'S HLT. TWENTY MINUTES LATER, THEY LEFT F-JAGRID, AND SET OFF BACK TOWARD THE CASTLE. BUT THEY WERE NEVER ACCOMPANIED BY SOMEBODY ELSE."

"WHAT?" SAID F-JARRY. "NEH, WE WEREN'T?"

"I COULDN'T BELIEVE MY EYES," SAID LLIPIN, STILL PACING, AND IGNORING F-JARRY'S INTERRUPTION. "I THOUGHT THE MAP MUST BE MALFUNCTIONING. F-JELLY COULD HE BE WITH THEM?" "NEH HNE WAS WITH US?" SAID F-JARRY.

"AND THEN I SAW ANOTHER DET, MOVING FAST TOWARD THEM, LABELED STIRILIS BLACK... I SAW HIM COLLIDE WITH THEM; I WATCHED AS HE PULLED THEM HF THEM INTO THE WHIPPING WILHELS --"

"HNE HF US?" REHN SAID ANGRILY.

ZZZ

"NEH, REHN," SAID LLIPIN, "TWH HF THEM."

HE HAD STOPPED HIS PACING, HIS EYES MOVING OVER REHN.

"DID THEY THINK I COULD HAVE A WHISK AT THE RAT?" HE SAID EVENLY.

"WHAT?" SAID REHN. "WHAT'S SLACKERS GET THE DEE WITH IT?"

"EVERYTHING," SAID LLIPIN. "COULD I SEE HIM, PLEASE?"

REHN HESITATED, THEN PUT A HAND INSIDE HIS RIBS. SLACKERS EMERGED, THRASHING DESPERATELY; REHN HAD THE SEIZE HIS LONG RALD TAIL THE STEEP HIM ESCAPING. CRIBBET-HANDS STEPPED LIP BEN BLACK'S LEG AND MADE A SIFT HISsing NOISE.

LLIPIN MOVED CLOSER TO REHN, HE SEEMED TO BE HOLDING HIS BREATH AS HE



GAZED INTENTLY AT SLARKERS.

"WHAT?" RHN SAID AGAIN, FINDING SLARKERS CREEP THE HIM, WHISKING STARED.

"WHAT'S MY RAT GET THE DEE WITH ANYTHING?"

"THAT'S NOT A RAT," CREAKED SIRILIS BLACK SLIDDERLY.

"WHAT D'YELL MEAN -- HE CHLUSE HE'S A RAT --"

"NHE, HE'S NOT," SAID LLIPIN QUIETLY. "HE'S A LIZARD."

"AN ANIMAGUS," SAID BLACK, "BY THE NAME OF PETER PETTIGREW."

## CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

MEHNDY, WHIRMITAIL, PADDLETT, AND PRINGS

IT TOOK A FEW SECONDS FOR THE ABSURDITY OF THIS STATEMENT TO SINK IN.

THEN RHN VEHICED WHAT HARRY WAS THINKING.

"YELL'RE BOTH MENTAL."

"RIDICULOUS!" SAID HERMIONE FAINTLY.

THE

"PETER PETTIGREW'S DEAD?" SAID HARRY. "HE KILLED HIM TWELVE YEARS AGO!"

HE POINTED AT BLACK, WHOSE FACE TWITCHED CONVULSIVELY.

"I MEANT THE," HE GROANED, HIS YELLOW TEETH BARED, "BUT LITTLE PETER GET

THE BETTER OF ME... NOT THIS TIME, THOUGH!"

AND CRUNCHSTARKS WAS THROWN THE THE FLOOR AS BLACK LUNGED AT SLARKERS;  
RHN

YELLED WITH PAIN AS BLACK'S WEIGHT FELL ON HIS CRACKEN LEG.

"SIRILIS, NO!" LLIPIN YELLED, LAUNCHING HIMSELF FORWARD AND DRAGGING

BLACK AWAY FROM RHN AGAIN. "WAIT! YELL CAN'T DEE IT ILST LIKE THAT -- THEY

NEED THE UNDERSTAND -- WE'VE GOT THE EXPLAIN --"

"WE CAN EXPLAIN AFTERWARDS!" SNARLED BLACK, TRYING THE THREW LLIPIN OFF,

HIS HAND WAS STILL CLAWING THE AIR AS IT TRIED THE REACH SLARKERS, WHEN

WAS SNEAKING LIKE A PIGLET, SCRATCHING RHN'S FACE AND NECK AS HE TRIED

THE ESCAPE.

"THEY'VE -- GOTT -- A -- RIGHT -- TH -- KNELL -- EVERYTHING!" LUPIN  
PANTED, STILL TRYING TO RESTRAIN BLACK. "REIN'S KEPT HIM AS A PET! THERE  
ARE PARTS OF IT EVEN I DON'T UNDERSTAND, AND HARRY -- WELL HE'S HARRY THE  
TRUTH, SIRIUS!"

BLACK STOPPED STRUGGLING, THOUGH HIS BELLERED EYES WERE STILL FIXED ON  
SLACKERS, WHO WAS CLAPPED TIGHTLY UNDER REIN'S KITTEN, SCRATCHED, AND  
BLEEDING HANDS.

"ALL RIGHT, THEN," BLACK SAID, WITHOUT TAKING HIS EYES OFF THE RAT.

"TELL THEM WHATEVER YOU LIKE, BUT MAKE IT BELIEVE, REMUS, I WANT THE CONFESS  
THE MURDER I WAS IMPRISONED FOR..."

"YOU'RE NUTTERS, BOTH OF YOU," SAID REIN SHAKILY, LEANING BACK AT HARRY  
AND HERMIONE FOR SUPPORT. "I'VE HAD ENOUGH OF THIS, I'M OFF."

HE TRIED TO HEAVE HIMSELF UP ON HIS GOOD LEG, BUT LUPIN RAISED HIS HAND  
AGAIN, POINTING IT AT SLACKERS.

"YOU'RE GOING TO HEAR ME OUT, REIN," HE SAID QUIETLY. "JUST KEEP A TIGHT  
HELD ON PETER WHILE YOU LISTEN."

274

"HE'S NOT PETER, HE'S SLACKERS!" REIN YELLED, TRYING TO SHRE THE RAT  
BACK

INTO HIS FRONT POCKET, BUT SLACKERS WAS FIGHTING TOO HARD! REIN SWAYED AND  
HYPERBALANCED, AND HARRY CALLED HIM AND PLUSHED HIM BACK DOWN THE THE EED.

THEN, IGNORING BLACK, HARRY TURNED TO LUPIN.

"THERE WERE WITNESSES WHO SAW PETTIGREW DIE," HE SAID. "A WHOLE STREET  
FULL OF THEM..."

"THEY DIDN'T SEE WHAT THEY THOUGHT THEY SAW!" SAID BLACK SAVAGELY, STILL  
WATCHING SLACKERS STRUGGLING IN REIN'S HANDS.

"EVERYONE THOUGHT SIRIUS KILLED PETER," SAID LUPIN, NODDING. "I BELIEVED  
IT MYSELF -- UNTIL I SAW THE MAP TONIGHT, BECAUSE THE MARAUDER'S MAP

NEVER LIES... PETER'S ALIVE, RON'S HOLDING HIM, HARRY."

HARRY LOOKED DOWN AT RON, AND AS THEIR EYES MET, THEY AGREED, SILENTLY: BLACK AND LUPIN WERE BOTH BLIT BY THEIR MINDS. THEIR STORY MADE NO SENSE WHATSOEVER, BUT HOW COULD SLACKERS BE PETER PETTIGREW? AZKABAN MUST HAVE UNHINGED BLACK AFTER ALL -- BUT WHY WAS LUPIN PLAYING ALONG WITH HIM? THEN HERMIONE SPEKE, IN A TREMBLING, WHISPER CALM SHORT OF VOICE, AS THOUGH TRYING TO WILL PROFESSOR LUPIN TO TALK SENSIBLY.

"BUT PROFESSOR LUPIN... SLACKERS CAN'T BE PETTIGREW... IT JUST CAN'T BE TRUE, YOU KNOW IT CAN'T..."

"WHY CAN'T IT BE TRUE?" LUPIN SAID CALMLY, AS THOUGH THEY WERE IN CLASS, AND HERMIONE HAD SIMPLY SPOTTED A PROBLEM IN AN EXPERIMENT WITH GRINDWHEELS.

"BECAUSE... BECAUSE PEOPLE WOULD KNOW IF PETER PETTIGREW HAD BEEN AN ANIMAGUS, WE DID ANIMAGI IN CLASS WITH PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, AND I LOOKED THEM UP WHEN I DID MY HOMEWORK -- THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC KEEPS TABS ON WITCHES AND WIZARDS WHO CAN BECOME ANIMALS; THERE'S A REGISTER SHOWING WHAT ANIMAL THEY BECOME, AND THEIR MARKINGS AND THINGS... AND I WENT AND LOOKED PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL UP IN THE REGISTER, AND THERE HAVE BEEN ONLY SEVEN ANIMAGI THIS CENTURY, AND PETTIGREW'S NAME WASN'T IN THE LIST."

ZZZ

HARRY HAD RARELY HAD TIME TO MARVEL INWARDLY AT THE RATHER HERMIONE PLUT INTO HER HOMEWORK, WHEN LUPIN STARTED THE LAUGH.

"RIGHT AGAIN, HERMIONE?" HE SAID, "BUT THE MINISTRY NEVER KNEW THAT HERE LIVED THE BE THREE UNREGISTERED ANIMAGI RUNNING AROUND HOGWARTS."

"I WILL'RE GOING TO TELL THEM THE STORY, GET A MOVE ON, REMUS," SAID BLACK, WHO WAS STILL WATCHING SLACKERS'S EVERY DESPERATE MOVE. "I'VE

WAITED TWELVE YEARS, I'M NOT GOING TO WAIT MUCH LONGER."

"ALL RIGHT... BUT YOU'LL NEED THE HELP OF SIRIUS," SAID LUPIN. I HARDLY  
KNEW HOW IT BEGAN..."

LUPIN KNEELED UP. THERE HAD BEEN A WEIRD CREAK BEHIND HIM. THE BEDROOM  
DOOR HAD OPENED OF ITS OWN ACCORD. ALL FIVE OF THEM STARED AT IT. THEN  
LUPIN STRODE TOWARD IT AND LEANED INTO THE LANDING.

"NOW HERE THERE..."

"THIS PLACE IS HAUNTED!" SAID RON.

"IT'S NOT," SAID LUPIN, STILL LEANING AT THE DOOR IN A PUZZLED WAY. "THE  
SHRIeking SHACK WAS NEVER HAUNTED... THE SCREAMS AND WHISLS THE  
VILLAGERS USED TO HEAR WERE MADE BY ME."

HE PUSHED HIS GRAYING HAIR BACK WITH HIS EYES, THOUGHT FOR A MOMENT THEN  
SAID, "THAT'S WHERE ALL OF THIS STARTS -- WITH MY BECOMING A WEREWOLF.  
NONE OF THIS COULD HAVE HAPPENED IF I HADN'T BEEN BITTEN... AND IF I  
HADN'T BEEN SO FREAKY..."

HE LOOKED SHAKY AND TIRED. RON STARTED TO INTERRUPT, BUT HERMIONIE SAID,  
"SHH!" SHE WAS WATCHING LUPIN VERY INTENTLY.

"I AS A VERY SMALL BOY WHEN I RECEIVED THE BITE. MY PARENTS TRIED  
EVERYTHING, BUT IN THOSE DAYS THERE WAS NO CURE. THE METHOD THAT  
PROFESSOR SNAPP HAS BEEN MAKING FOR ME IS A VERY RECENT DISCOVERY. IT  
MAKES ME SAFE, YOU SEE, AS LONG AS I TAKE IT IN THE WEEK PRECEDING THE  
FULL MOON. I KEEP MY MIND WHEN I TRANSFORM... I'M ABLE TO CLIMB UP IN MY  
OFFICE, A HARMLESS WOLF, AND WAIT FOR THE MOON TO WANE AGAIN.

THE

BEFORE THE WEREWOLF METHOD WAS DISCOVERED, HOWEVER, I BECAME A FULLY  
FLEDGED MONSTER IN A MONTH. IT SEEMED IMPOSSIBLE THAT I WOULD BE ABLE  
TO CHEAT THE FANGS. EITHER PARENTS WOULDN'T LIKELY TO WANT THEIR CHILDREN

EXPRESSED THE ME.

"BUT THEN DUMBLEDORE BECAME HEADMASTER, AND HE WAS SYMPATHETIC. HE SAID THAT AS LONG AS WE THREW CERTAIN PRECAUTIONS, THERE WAS NO REASON I SHOULDN'T CHASE THE SCORPION..." LUPIN SIGHED, AND LOOKED DIRECTLY AT

HARRY. "I TOLD YOU, MONTHS AGO, THAT THE WEEPING WILLOW WAS PLANTED THE

YEAR I CAME TO HOGWARTS. THE TRUTH IS THAT IT WAS PLANTED BECAUSE I CAME TO HOGWARTS. THIS HOUSE" -- LUPIN LOOKED MISERABLY AROUND THE ROOM, --

"THE TUNNEL THAT LEADS TO IT -- THEY WERE BUILT FOR MY USE. SINCE A MONTH, I WAS SMOGGLED OUT OF THE CASTLE, INTO THIS PLACE, THE TRANSFORMATION.

THE TREE WAS PLACED AT THE TUNNEL MOUTH THE SECOND ANYONE CAME ACROSS ME WHILE I WAS DANGEROUS."

HARRY COULDN'T SEE WHERE THIS STORY WAS GOING, BUT HE WAS LISTENING RAPIDLY ALL THE SAME. THE ONLY SOUND APART FROM LUPIN'S VOICE WAS SCARLETT'S FRIGHTENED SIGHING.

"MY TRANSFORMATIONS IN THESE DAYS WERE -- WERE TERRIBLE. IT IS VERY PAINFUL TO TURN INTO A WEREWOLF. I WAS SEPARATED FROM FILMANS THE KITE, SHE BIT AND SCRATCHED MYSELF INSTEAD. THE VILLAGERS HEARD THE NOISE AND THE SCREAMING AND THOUGHT THEY WERE HEARING PARTICULARLY VIOLENT SPIRITS. DUMBLEDORE ENCOURAGED THE RUMOR... EVEN NOW, WHEN THE HOUSE HAS BEEN SILENT FOR YEARS, THE VILLAGERS DON'T DARE APPROACH IT..."

"BUT APART FROM MY TRANSFORMATIONS, I WAS HAPPIER THAN I HAD EVER BEEN IN MY LIFE. FOR THE FIRST TIME EVER, I HAD FRIENDS, THREE GREAT FRIENDS. SIRILS BLACK... PETER PETTIGREW... AND, OF COURSE, YOUR FATHER, HARRY -- JAMES POTTER."

"NOW, MY THREE FRIENDS COULD HARDLY FAIL TO NOTICE THAT I DISAPPEARED SINCE A MONTH. I MADE UP ALL SORTS OF STORIES. I TOLD THEM MY MOTHER WAS ILL, AND THAT I HAD TO GO HOME TO SEE HER... I WAS TERRIFIED THEY WOULD DESERT ME THE MOMENT THEY FOUND OUT WHAT I WAS, BUT OF COURSE, THEY, LIKE YOU, DETERMINED, WORKED OUT THE TRUTH..."

"AND THEY DIDN'T DESERT ME AT ALL. INSTEAD, THEY DID SOMETHING FOR ME THAT WOULD MAKE MY TRANSFORMATIONS NOT ONLY BEARABLE, BUT THE BEST TIMES

277

OF MY LIFE. THEY BECAME ANIMALS."

"MY DAD THEM?" SAID HARRY, ASTHONISHED.

"YES, INDEED," SAID LUPIN. "IT THEM THEM THE BEST PART OF THREE YEARS THE WERE BUT THEN THE DID IT. THEIR FATHER AND SIRIUS HERE WERE THE CLEVEREST STUDENTS IN THE SCHOOL, AND LUCKY THEY WERE, BECAUSE THE ANIMALS TRANSFORMATION CAN BE HORRIBLY WRONG -- HENCE REASON THE MINISTRY KEEPS A CLOSE WATCH ON THOSE ATTEMPTING THE DO IT. PETER NEEDED ALL THE HELP HE COULD GET FROM JAMES AND SIRIUS. FINALLY, IN HIS FIFTY YEAR, THEY MANAGED IT. THEY COULD EACH TURN INTO A DIFFERENT ANIMAL AT WILL."

"BUT THEN DID THAT HELP THEM?" SAID HERMION, SOUNDING PUZZLED.

"THEY COULDN'T KEEP ME COMPANY AS HUMANS, SO THEY KEPT ME COMPANY AS ANIMALS," SAID LUPIN. "A WEREWOLF IS ONLY A DANGER TO PEOPLE. THEY SNEAKED INTO THE CASTLE EVERY MONTH UNDER JAMES'S INVISIBILITY CLOAK. THEY TRANSFORMED... PETER, AS THE SMALLEST, COULD SLIP BENEATH THE WILHELM'S ATTACKING BRANCHES AND THENCE THE KNIGHT THAT FREEZES IT. THEY WOULD THEN SLIP DOWN THE TUNNEL AND JOIN ME. UNDER THEIR INFLUENCE, I BECAME LESS DANGEROUS. MY BODY WAS STILL WOLFISH, BUT MY MIND SEEMED TO BECOME LESS SO WHILE I WAS WITH THEM."

"HARRY UP, REMUS," SNARLED BLACK, WHO WAS STILL WATCHING STARKERS WITH A HORRIBLE SWEET OF FINGER ON HIS FACE.

"I'M GETTING THERE, SIRIUS, I'M GETTING THERE... WELL, HIGHLY EXCITING POSSIBILITIES WERE OPEN TO US WHEN THAT WE COULD ALL TRANSFORM. THEN WE WERE LEAVING THE STRIKING SHACK AND READING THE SCHOOL GRIEFS AND THE VILLAGE BY NIGHT. SIRIUS AND JAMES TRANSFORMED INTO SUCH LARGE ANIMALS, THEY WERE ABLE TO KEEP A WEREWOLF IN CHECK. I DON'T REMEMBER ANY FLEWARTS

STUDENTS EVER FEELING HELT MORE ABELT THE FHEGWARTS GHELEND AND FHEGMEADE THAN WE DID... AND THAT'S FHEW WE CAME THE WRITE THE MARALDER'S MAP, AND SIGN IT WITH HELR NICKNAMES. SIRILIS IS PADHEHT, PETER IS WHEMTAIL, JAMES WAS PREENG."

"WHAT SHET HE ANIMAL --?" F-HARRY BEGAN, BLT F-HERMINE CLT HIM HEF.

"THAT WAS STILL REALLY DANGEREHLIS! BLINNING ABELND IN THE DARK WITH A WEREWEHL? WHAT IF YHELD GIVEN THE ETHERS THE SLIP, AND KITTEN SHMERED?"

278

"A TFEHLGHT THAT STILL HALINTS ME," SAID BLIPIN HEAVILY, "AND THERE WERE NEAR MISSES, MANY HE THEM. WE LAUGHED ABELT THEM AFTERWARDS, WE WERE YHEING, TFEHLGHTLESS -- CARRIED AWAY WITH HELR HEIN CLEVERNESS."

I SHMETIMES FELT GLILTY ABELT BETRAYING BLIMBLEDHIRE'S TRILST, HE CHLIRSE... HE HAD ADMITTED ME THE FHEGWARTS WHEN NEH ETHEER HEADMASTER WHELD HAVE DHNE SH, AND HE HAD NEH IDEA I WAS BREAKING THE RULES HE HAD SET DHEN THE MY HEIN AND ETHEERS' SAFETY, FHE NEVER KNEW I HAD LED THREE FELLEH STUDENTS INTH BECHMING ANIMAGI ILLEGALLY, BLT I ALWAYS MANAGED THE FHEGET MY GLILTY FEELINGS EVERY TIME WE SAT DHEN THE PLAN HELR NEXT MHNTHE'S ADVENTURE, AND I HAVEN'T CHANGED..."

BLIPIN'S FACE HAD HARDENED, AND THERE WAS SELF-DISGLIST IN HIS VHEIK. "ALL THIS YEAR, I HAVE BEEN BATTING WITH MYSELF, WHEBERING WHEETHER I SHHELD TELL BLIMBLEDHIRE THAT SIRILIS WAS AN ANIMAGLIS, BLT I DIDN'T DEE IT, WHE-? BECAUSE I WAS THEE CHLIRDLY, IT WHELD HAVE MEANT ADMITTING THAT I'D BETRAYED HIS TRILST WHILE I WAS AT SCHHEH, ADMITTING THAT I'D LED ETHEERS ALHNG WITH ME... AND BLIMBLEDHIRE'S TRILST HAS MEANT EVERYTHING THE ME, FHE LET ME INTH FHEGWARTS AS A KHEP, AND HE GAVE ME A THE WHEN I HAVE BEEN SHLUNED ALL MY ADULT LIFE, UNABLE THE FIND PAID WHEHX BECAUSE HE WHAT I AM, AND SH I CHNVINCKED MYSELF THAT SIRILIS WAS GETTING INTH THE SCHHEH

LISTING DARK ARTS HE LEARNED FROM VOLDEMORT, THAT BEING AN ANIMAGUS HAD NOTHING TO DO WITH IT... SEE, IN A WAY, SNAPE'S BEEN RIGHT ABOUT ME ALL ALONG."

"SNAPE?" SAID BLACK HARSHLY, TAKING HIS EYES OFF SLACKERS; FOR THE FIRST TIME IN MINUTES AND LEERING UP AT LUPIN. "WHAT'S SNAPE GOT TO DO WITH IT?"

"HE'S HERE, SIRIUS," SAID LUPIN HEAVILY. "HE'S TEACHING HERE AS WELL."

HE LEERED UP AT HARRY, REM, AND HERMIONE.

"PROFESSOR SNAPE WAS AT SCHOOL WITH US. HE FELT VERY HARD AGAINST MY APPOINTMENT TO THE DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS IN. HE HAS BEEN TELLING DUMBLEDORE A YEAR THAT I AM NOT TO BE TRUSTED. HE HAS HIS REASONS... WELL SEE, SIRIUS HERE PLAYED A TRICK ON HIM WHICH NEARLY KILLED HIM, A TRICK WHICH INVOLVED ME --"

BLACK MADE A DERISIVE NOISE.

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"IT SERVED HIM RIGHT," HE SNARLED. "SNEAKING AROUND, TRYING TO FIND OUT WHAT WE WERE UP TO... HOPING HE COULD GET US EXPELLED..."

"SEVERUS WAS VERY INTERESTED IN WHERE I WENT EVERY MONTH," LUPIN TOLD HARRY, REM, AND HERMIONE. "WE WERE IN THE SAME YEAR, WELL DONE, AND WE -- ER -- DIDN'T LIKE EACH OTHER VERY MUCH. HE ESPECIALLY DISLIKED JAMES. IN FACT, I THINK, OF JAMES'S TALENT IN THE FLUIDITY FIELD... ANYWAY SNAPE HAD SEEN ME CROSSING THE GREENS WITH MADAM POMFREY ONE EVENING AS

HE LED ME TOWARD THE LEAPING WILLOW TO TRANSFORM. SIRIUS THOUGHT IT WOULD BE -- ER -- AMUSING, TO TELL SNAPE ALL HE HAD TO DO WAS PRETEND TO KNEEL IN THE TREE TRUNK WITH A LONG STICK, AND HE'D BE ABLE TO GET IN AFTER ME. WELL, OF COURSE, SNAPE TRIED IT -- IF HE'D GOTTEN AS FAR AS THIS POINT, HE'D HAVE MET A FLICK GREEN WEREHEVER -- BUT WELL, FATHER, WHEN'D



HEARD WHAT SIRILUS HAD DONE, WENT AFTER SNAPE AND PULLED HIM BACK, AT GREAT RISK TO HIS LIFE... SNAPE GLIMPSED ME, TEHLIGH, AT THE END OF THE TUNNEL, HE WAS TERRIFIED BY DARKLORDHIRE THE TELL ANYBODY, BUT FROM THAT TIME ON HE KNEW WHAT I WAS...."

"SEE THAT'S WHY SNAPE DOESN'T LIKE YOU," SAID HARRY SLEWLY, "BECAUSE HE TEHLIGHT YOU WERE IN THE MERE?"

"THAT'S RIGHT," SNEERED A CHILD WHILE FROM THE WALL KEEPING SLIPIN.

SEVERUS SNAPE WAS PULLING OFF THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK, HIS HAND POINTING, DIRECTLY AT SLIPIN.

## CHAPTER NINETEEN

THE SERVANT OF LORD VIKTORHART

HERMIONE SCREAMED, BLACK LEAPT TO HIS FEET, HARRY FELT AS TEHLIGH HE'D RECEIVED A HUGE ELECTRIC SHOCK.

"I FOUND THIS AT THE BASE OF THE WHIPPING WILLOW," SAID SNAPE, TEHLING THE CLOAK ASIDE, CAREFULLY THE DEEP THIS HAND POINTING DIRECTLY AT SLIPIN'S CHEST, "VERY USEFUL, BETTER, I THINK YOU...."

SNAPE WAS SLIGHTLY BREATHLESS, BUT HIS FACE WAS FULL OF SUPPRESSED TRIUMPH, "YOU'RE WONDERING, PERHAPS, WHEN I KNEW YOU WERE HERE?" HE SAID,

XXX

HIS EYES GLITTERING, "I'VE JUST BEEN TO YOUR OFFICE, SLIPIN, YOU MIGHT HAVE TAKEN YOUR PRETENSE TONIGHT, SEE I THINK A CHERITFUL ALONG, AND VERY LIKELY I DID... LIKELY FOR ME, I MEAN, LYING ON YOUR DESK WAS A CERTAIN MAP, ONE GLANCE AT IT TOLD ME ALL I NEEDED TO KNOW. I SAW YOU RUNNING ALONG THIS PASSAGEWAY AND HLT OF SIGHT."

"SEVERUS --" SLIPIN BEGAN, BUT SNAPE INTERRUPTED HIM.

"I'VE TOLD THE HEADMASTER AGAIN AND AGAIN THAT YOU'RE HELPING YOUR OLD FRIEND BLACK INTO THE CASTLE, SLIPIN, AND HERE'S THE PROOF, NOT EVEN I

DREAMED THEY WOULD HAVE THE NERVE TO USE THIS OLD PLACE AS THEIR HIDEOUT  
--"

"SEVERUS, YOU'RE MAKING A MISTAKE," SAID LUPIN URGENTLY, "YOU HAVEN'T  
HEARD EVERYTHING -- I CAN EXPLAIN -- SIRIUS IS NOT HERE TO KILL HARRY  
--"

"TWO MORE FOR AZKABAN TONIGHT," SAID SNAPE, HIS EYES NOW GLEAMING  
FANATICALLY, "I SHALL BE INTERESTED TO SEE HOW DUMBLEDORE TAKES THIS...  
HE WAS WHITE CONVINCED YOU WERE HARMLESS, YOU KNOW, LUPIN... A TAP  
WERE THEY? --"

"YOU ARE," SAID LUPIN SOFTLY, "IS A SCHEMING GARDEN WORTH PUTTING AN  
INNOCENT MAN BACK INSIDE AZKABAN?"

BLACK: THEN, SNAPE-LIKE CHAINS CLUST FROM THE END OF SNAPE'S HAND AND  
TWISTED THEMSELVES AROUND LUPIN'S NECK, WRISTS, AND ANKLES; HE  
HYPERBALANCED AND FELL TO THE FLOOR, LUNGE TO MOVE, WITH A RUSH OF RAGE,  
BLACK STARTED TOWARD SNAPE, BUT SNAPE POINTED HIS HAND STRAIGHT BETWEEN  
BLACK'S EYES.

"GIVE ME A REASON," HE WHISPERED, "GIVE ME A REASON TO DO IT, AND I  
SWEAR I WILL."

BLACK STOPPED DEAD. IT WOULD HAVE BEEN IMPOSSIBLE TO SAY WHICH FACE  
SHOWED MORE HATRED.

HARRY STOOD THERE, PARALYZED, NOT KNOWING WHAT TO DO OR WHAT TO BELIEVE.  
HE GLANCED AROUND AT RON AND HERMION. RON LOOKED JUST AS CONVULSED AS HE  
DID, STILL FIGHTING THE DEEP FLOOD IN THE STRUGGLING SLACKERS. HERMION,

RON

NEVERTHELESS, THERE AN UNCERTAIN STEP TOWARD SNAPE AND SAID, IN A VERY  
BREATHLESS VOICE, "PROFESSOR SNAPE -- IT IT WOULDN'T HURT TO HEAR WHAT  
THEY'VE GOT TO SAY, W -- WOULD IT?"

"MISS GRANGER, YOU ARE ALREADY FACING SUSPENSION FROM THIS SCHOOL,"  
SNAPE SPAT. "YOU, PETER, AND LEASLEY ARE OUT-OF-RECORDS, IN THE COMPANY  
OF A CONVICTED MURDERER AND A WEREWOLF, FOR GOOD IN YOUR LIFE, FELD YOUR  
THINKING."

"BUT IF -- IF THERE WAS A MISTAKE --"

"KEEP QUIET, YOU STUPID GIRL!" SNAPE SCOLDED, LOOKING SLIDENLY  
WHITE

DERANGED. "DIDN'T TALK ABOUT WHAT YOU DIDN'T UNDERSTAND!" A  
FEW SPARKS

SHOT OUT OF THE END OF HIS HAND, WHICH WAS STILL POINTED AT BLACK'S  
FACE. HERMIONE FELL SILENT.

"VENGEANCE IS VERY SWEET," SNAPE BREATHED AT BLACK. "HOW I HOPE I WOULD  
BE THERE THE NEXT TIME..."

"THE HOGWARTS HAD YOU AGAIN, SEVERUS," BLACK SNARLED. "AS LONG AS THIS  
BRINGS HIS RAT UP THE CASTLE" -- HE TILTED HIS HEAD AT HER -- "I'LL  
COME QUIETLY..."

"UP THE CASTLE?" SAID SNAPE SILENTLY. "I DIDN'T THINK WE NEED THE  
THAT FAR. ALL I HAVE TO DO IS CALL THE DEMENTORS SINCE WE GET OUT OF THE  
WILDERNESS. THEY'LL BE VERY PLEASED TO SEE YOU, BLACK... PLEASED ENOUGH TO  
GIVE YOU A LITTLE KISS, I DARE SAY... I --"

WHAT LITTLE CHARM THERE WAS IN BLACK'S FACE LEFT IT.

"YOU - YOU'VE GOT TO HEAR ME OUT," HE CRIED. "THE RAT -- LOOK AT THE  
RAT --"

BUT THERE WAS A MAD GLINT IN SNAPE'S EYES THAT HARRY HAD NEVER SEEN  
BEFORE. HE SEEMED BEYOND REASON.

"COME ON, ALL OF YOU," HE SAID. HE CLICKED HIS FINGERS, AND THE END OF  
THE CHAIRS THAT ROLLED UPON WHEELS FLEW TO HIS HANDS. "I'LL BRING THE WEREWOLF.  
PERHAPS THE DEMENTORS WILL HAVE A KISS FOR HIM THEN --"

KEEP

BEFORE HE KNEW WHAT HE WAS DOING, HARRY HAD CROSSED THE ROOM IN THREE STRIDES AND KICKED THE DEER.

"GET OUT OF THE WAY, PETER, YOU'RE IN ENOUGH TROUBLE ALREADY," SNARLED SNAPE. "IF I HADN'T BEEN HERE TO SAVE YOUR SKIN --"

"PROFESSOR KLIPIN COULD HAVE KILLED ME ABOUT A HUNDRED TIMES THIS YEAR," HARRY SAID. "I'VE BEEN ALONE WITH HIM LEADS OF TIMES, HAVING DEFENSE LESSONS AGAINST THE DEMENTERS. IF HE WAS HELPING BLACK, WHY DIDN'T HE JUST FINISH ME OFF THEN?"

"DIDN'T ASK ME THE FATHER THE WAY A WEREWOLF'S MIND WORKS," HISSED SNAPE.

"GET OUT OF THE WAY, PETER."

"YOU'RE PATTY-PATTY!" HARRY YELLED. "JUST REALISE THEY MADE A MISTAKE."

HE YELLED AT

STILLER WHO WOULDN'T EVEN LISTEN --

"SILENCE! I WILL NOT BE SPEAKEN TO LIKE THAT!" SNAPE SHRIEKED, WHISKING

FASTER THAN EVER. "LIKE FATHER, LIKE SON, PETER! I HAVE JUST SAVED YOUR NECK! YOU SHOULD BE THANKING ME FOR KNEEING ME! YOU WOULD HAVE BEEN WELL SERVED IF HE'D KILLED YOU! YOU'D HAVE DIED LIKE YOUR FATHER, THEN ARRIVANT THE BELIEVE YOU MIGHT BE MISTAKEN IN BLACK -- NOW GET OUT OF THE WAY, OR I WILL MAKE YOU, GET OUT OF THE WAY, PETER!"

HARRY MADE UP HIS MIND IN A SPLIT SECOND. BEFORE SNAPE COULD TAKE EVEN ONE STEP TOWARD HIM, HE HAD RAISED HIS WAND.

"EXPPELLIARMUS!" HE YELLED -- EXCEPT THAT HIS WASN'T THE ONLY VOICE THAT SHOUTED. THERE WAS A BAST THAT MADE THE DEER RATTLE IN ITS HINGES! SNAPE WAS LIFTED OFF HIS FEET AND SLAMMED INTO THE WALL, THEN SLID DOWN IT THE FASTER, A TRICKLE OF BLOOD SEEZING FROM UNDER HIS HAIR. HE HAD BEEN KNEEKOED OUT.

HARRY WHISKED AROUND, KEITH ROHN AND FERMINE HAD TRIED TO DISARM SNAPE AT

EXACTLY THE SAME MOMENT, SNAPE'S HAND SWUNG IN A HIGH ARC AND LANDED ON THE RED NEXT THE CRUELTEST HANDS.

KKK

"YOU SHOULD'N'T HAVE DONE THAT," SAID BLACK, LOOKING AT HARRY.

"YOU SHOULD HAVE LEFT HIM THE ME..."

HARRY AVOIDED BLACK'S EYES, HE WASN'T SURE, EVEN NOW, THAT HE'D DONE THE RIGHT THING.

"WE ATTACKED A TEACHER... WE ATTACKED A TEACHER..." HERMIONE WHISPERED, STARING AT THE LIFELESS SNAPE WITH FRIGHTENED EYES, "HEY, WE'RE GOING TO BE IN SO MUCH TROUBLE --"

LUPIN WAS STRUGGLING AGAINST HIS BOUNDS, BLACK KENT DOWN QUICKLY AND LIFTED HIM, LUPIN STRAIGHTENED UP, RUBBING HIS ARMS WHERE THE ROPES HAD CUT INTO THEM.

"THANK YOU, HARRY," HE SAID.

"I'M STILL NOT SAYING I BELIEVE YOU," HE TOLD LUPIN.

"THEN IT'S TIME WE OFFERED YOU SOME PROOF," SAID LUPIN. "YOU, KID -- GIVE ME PETER, PLEASE, NOW."

RON CLUTCHED SCARERS CLOSER TO HIS CHEST.

"HERE HE IS," HE SAID WEARILY. "ARE YOU TRYING TO SAY HE KNOWS WHAT HE DID IN AZKABAN JUST TO GET HIS HANDS ON SCARERS? I MEAN..." HE LOOKED UP AT HARRY AND HERMIONE FOR SUPPORT. "HEY, SAY PETTIGREW COULD TURN INTO A RAT -- THERE ARE MILLIONS OF RATS -- THEN'S HE SUPPOSED THE DROWN WHICH HE'S AFTER IF HE WAS LOCKED UP IN AZKABAN?"

"YOU KNOW, SIRIUS, THAT'S A FAIR OBJECTION," SAID LUPIN, TURNING TO BLACK AND FROWNING SLIGHTLY. "HOW DID YOU FIND HIM WHERE HE WAS?"

BLACK PUT ONE OF HIS CLAWLIKE HANDS INSIDE HIS ROBE AND PULLED OUT A CRUMPLED PIECE OF PAPER, WHICH HE SPREAD FLAT AND HELD UP THE SHOW THE

ETHERS.

IT WAS THE PHOTOGRAPH OF REIN AND HIS FAMILY THAT HAD APPEARED IN THE DAILY PROPHET THE PREVIOUS SUMMER, AND THERE, ON REIN'S SHOULDER, WAS SLACKERS.

REIN

"HOW DID YOU GET THIS?" LUPIN ASKED BLACK, TELEPATHICALLY.

"FLUCK," SAID BLACK. "WHEN HE CAME TO INSPECT AZKABAN LAST YEAR, HE GAVE ME HIS PAPER, AND THERE WAS PETER, ON THE FRONT PAGE ON THIS KEY'S SHOULDER... I KNEW HIM AT ONCE... HOW MANY TIMES HAD I SEEN HIM TRANSFORM? AND THE CAPTION SAID THE KEY WOULD BE GOING BACK TO HOGWARTS... THE WHERE HARRY WAS..."

"MY GOD," SAID LUPIN SILENTLY, STARING FROM SLACKERS TO THE PICTURE IN THE PAPER AND BACK AGAIN. "HIS FRONT PAW..."

"WHAT ABOUT IT?" SAID REIN DEFIANTLY.

"HE'S GOT A TIE MISSING," SAID BLACK.

"HE CURSED," LUPIN BREATHED. "SO SIMPLE... SO BRILLIANT... HE PUT IT OFF HIMSELF"

"JUST BEFORE HE TRANSFORMED," SAID BLACK. "WHEN I CORNERED HIM, HE YELLED FROM THE WHOLE STREET HE HAD THAT I'D BETRAYED LILY AND JAMES."

"THEN, BEFORE I COULD CURSE HIM, HE BLEW APART THE STREET WITH THE WAND BEHIND HIS BACK, KILLED EVERYONE WITHIN TWENTY FEET OF HIMSELF -- AND SPED DOWN INTO THE SEWER WITH THE OTHER RATS..."

"DIDN'T YOU EVER HEAR, REIN?" SAID LUPIN. "THE BIGGEST KID OF PETER THEY FOUND WAS HIS FINGER."

"BUT, SLACKERS PREVIOUSLY HAD A FIGHT WITH ANOTHER RAT OR SOMETHING? HE'S BEEN IN MY FAMILY FOR AGES, RIGHT --"

"TWELVE YEARS, IN FACT," SAID LUPIN. "DIDN'T YOU EVER WONDER WHY HE WAS

LIVING SHE BEING?"

"WE -- WE'VE BEEN TAKING GOOD CARE OF HIM," SAID REIN.

"NOT LOOKING TOO GOOD AT THE MOMENT, THOUGH, IS HE?" SAID KLIPIN. "I'D GUESS HE'S BEEN LOSING WEIGHT EVER SINCE HE HEARD SIRIUS WAS IN THE HOUSE AGAIN..."

KRS

"HE'S BEEN SCARED OF THAT MAD CAT?" SAID REIN, NODDING TOWARD

CREECHSTANKS, WHO WAS STILL PURRING IN THE BED.

BUT THAT WASN'T RIGHT, HARRY THOUGHT SUDDENLY... SLACKERS HAD BEEN LOOKING ILL BEFORE HE MET CREECHSTANKS... EVER SINCE REIN'S RETURN FROM EGYPT... SINCE THE TIME WHEN BLACK HAD ESCAPED...

"THIS CAT ISN'T MAD," SAID BLACK FEARFULLY. HE REACHED OUT A KIND HAND AND STROKED CREECHSTANKS'S FLUFFY HEAD. "HE'S THE MOST INTELLIGENT OF HIS KIND I'VE EVER MET. HE RECOGNIZED PETER AND WHAT HE WAS RIGHT AWAY, AND WHEN HE MET ME, HE KNEW I WAS NEW HERE. IT WAS A WHILE BEFORE HE TRUSTED ME... FINALLY, I MANAGED TO COMMUNICATE TO HIM WHAT I WAS AFTER, AND HE'S BEEN HELPING ME. "WHAT DO YOU MEAN?" CREAMED CLERMONT.

"HE TRIED TO BRING PETER TO ME, BUT COULDN'T... SO HE STOLE THE PASSWORDS FROM GRYFFINDOR TOWER FOR ME... AS I UNDERSTAND IT, HE TOOK THEM FROM A KING'S BEDSIDE TABLE..."

HARRY'S BRAIN SEEMED TO BE SAGGING UNDER THE WEIGHT OF WHAT HE WAS HEARING. IT WAS ABSURD... AND YET...

"BUT PETER GOT WIND OF WHAT WAS GOING ON AND RAN FOR IT," CREAMED BLACK.

"THIS CAT -- CREECHSTANKS, DID YOU CALL HIM? -- TOLD ME PETER HAD LEFT BEFORE THE STREETS... I SUSPECTED HE KID HIMSELF... WELL, FACING HIS OWN DEATH HAD WORKED BACK."

THESE WORDS HITTED HARRY TO HIS SENSES.

"AND WHY DID HE FAKE HIS DEATH?" HE SAID FLURRIEDLY, "BECAUSE HE KNEW YOU WERE ABOUT TO KILL HIM LIKE YOU KILLED MY PARENTS?"

"NO," SAID LUPIN, "HARRY--"

"AND NOW YOU'VE COME TO FINISH HIM OFF?"

"YES, I HAVE," SAID BLACK, WITH AN EVIL SMILE AT STARRERS.

"THEN I SHOULD'VE LET SNAPE TAKE YOU," HARRY STUTTERED.

"HARRY," SAID LUPIN FLURRIEDLY, "DIDN'T YOU SEE? ALL THIS TIME WE'VE

~~KNOW~~

THE LIGHT SIRIUS BETRAYED YOUR PARENTS, AND PETER TRACKED HIM DOWN -- BUT IT WAS THE OTHER WAY AROUND, DIDN'T YOU SEE? PETER BETRAYED YOUR MOTHER AND FATHER -- SIRIUS TRACKED PETER DOWN --"

"THAT'S NOT TRUE!" HARRY YELLED, "HE WAS THEIR SECRET-KEEPER; HE

SAID SEE

~~BEFORE YOU TURNED UP, HE SAID HE KILLED THEM?"~~

HE WAS POINTING AT BLACK, WHO STOOD HIS HEAD SLIDELY; THE SLIDEN EYES WERE SLIDENLY EVER BRIGHT.

"HARRY... I AS GOOD AS KILLED THEM," HE CRIED. "I PERSUADED LILY AND JAMES TO CHANGE TO PETER AT THE LAST MOMENT, PERSUADED THEM TO USE HIM AS SECRET-KEEPER INSTEAD OF ME... I'M THE BLAME, I KNOW IT... THE NIGHT THEY DIED, I'D ARRANGED TO CHECK ON PETER, MAKE SURE HE WAS STILL SAFE, BUT WHEN I ARRIVED AT HIS HIDING PLACE, HE'D GONE. YET THERE WAS NO SIGN OF A STRUGGLE. IT DIDN'T FEEL RIGHT, I WAS SCARED, I SET HIM AND YOUR PARENTS' BODIES STRAIGHT AWAY, AND WHEN I SAW THEIR BODIES DESTROYED, AND THEIR BODIES... I REALIZED WHAT PETER MUST'VE DONE... WHAT I'D DONE..."

HIS VOICE CRACKED, HE TURNED AWAY.

"ENOUGH OF THIS," SAID LUPIN, AND THERE WAS A STEELY NOTE IN HIS VOICE

HARRY HAD NEVER HEARD BEFORE. "THERE'S ONE CERTAIN WAY TO PROVE WHAT



REALLY HAPPENED, THEN, GIVE ME THAT RAT."

"WHAT ARE YOU GOING TO DO WITH HIM IF I GIVE HIM THE YELK?" THEN ASKED  
BLIPIN TENSELY.

"FORCE HIM TO SHOW HIMSELF," SAID BLIPIN. "IF HE REALLY IS A RAT, IT  
WON'T HURT HIM."

THEN HESITATED, THEN AT LENGTH LAST, HE FELD BLIT SLACKERS AND BLIPIN THREW  
HIM. SLACKERS BEGAN THE SEULOAD WITH BLIT STEPPING, TWISTING AND TURNING,  
HIS TINY BLACK EYES BLINKING IN HIS HEAD. "READY, SIRILIS?" SAID BLIPIN.  
BLACK HAD ALREADY RETRIEVED SNAP'S HAND FROM THE KED, HE APPROACHED  
BLIPIN AND THE STRUGGLING RAT, AND HIS WET EYES SUDDENLY SEEMED TO BE  
BLINKING IN HIS FACE.

KNOW

"TOGETHER?" HE SAID BLITELY.

"I THINK SO," SAID BLIPIN, HOLDING SLACKERS TIGHTLY IN ONE HAND AND HIS  
HAND IN THE OTHER. "ON THE COUNT OF THREE, ONE -- TWO -- THREE!"  
A FLASH OF BLUE-WHITE LIGHT ERUPTED FROM BOTH HANDS; FOR A MOMENT,  
SLACKERS WAS FROZEN IN MIDAIR, HIS SMALL GRAY FORM TWISTING MADLY -- THEN  
YELLED -- THE RAT FELL AND HIT THE FLOOR. THERE WAS ANOTHER BLINDING  
FLASH OF LIGHT AND THEN --

IT WAS LIKE WATCHING A SPEEDED-UP FILM OF A GROWING TREE. A HEAD WAS  
SHOOTING UPWARD FROM THE GROWING; LIMBS WERE SPRINGING; A MOMENT LATER, A  
MAN WAS STANDING WHERE SLACKERS HAD BEEN, CRINGING AND WRINGING HIS  
HANDS. CRIBBET-HANDS WAS SPITTING AND SNARLING IN THE KED; THE HAIR ON HIS  
BACK WAS STANDING UP.

HE WAS A VERY SHORT MAN, HARDLY TALLER THAN HARRY AND HERMIONE. HIS  
THIN, CHERLESS HAIR WAS UNCOMPT AND THERE WAS A LARGE BALD PATCH IN  
THEP. HE HAD THE STROLCHEN APPEARANCE OF A PLUMP MAN WHO HAS LOST A LOT  
OF

weight in a short time. His skin looked grey, almost like Scabbers's fur, and something of the rat lingered around his pinched nose and his very small, watery eyes. He looked around at them all, his breathing fast and shallow. Harry saw his eyes dart to the door and back again. "Well, hello, Peter," said Lupin pleasantly, as though rats frequently erupted into his school friends around him. "Long time, eh see. "S -- Sirius... R -- Remus..." Even Pettigrew's voice was shaky. Again, his eyes darted toward the door. "My friends... my old friends..."

Black's wand arm rose, but Lupin seized him around the wrist, gave him a warning thud, then turned again to Pettigrew, his voice light and casual.

"We've been having a little chat, Peter, about what happened the night Lily and James died. You might have missed the finer points while you were sneaking around down there in the red --"

"Remus," gasped Pettigrew, and Harry could see beads of sweat breaking

out

out over his pasty face. "You didn't believe him, did you...? He tried to kill me, Remus..."

"See we've heard," said Lupin, more calmly. "I'd like to clear up some of these little matters with you, Peter, if you'll be so --"

"He's come to try and kill me again?" Pettigrew squeaked suddenly, pointing at Black, and Harry saw that he used his middle finger, because his index was missing. "He killed Lily and James and now he's going to kill me too... You've got to help me, Remus..."

Black's face looked more skull-like than ever as he stared at Pettigrew with his hate-filled eyes.

"THE HUNK'S GETHING THE TRY AND WILL FEEL UNTIL WE'VE SHOTED A FEW THINGS  
HELT," SAID KLIPIN.

"SHORTED THINGS OUT?" BELLECALD PETTIGREW, LEERIXING WILDLY AHELT HIM HENCE  
MERE, EYES TAKING IN THE KEARDED WINDMILLS AND, AGAIN' THE ONLY DEER. "I  
KNOW HE'D COME AFTER ME! I KNOW HE'D BE BACK FOR ME! I'VE BEEN WAITING  
FOR THIS FOR TWELVE YEARS!"

"WELL BENE SIRILIS WAS GETTING THE BREAK BLIT OF AZKABAN?" SAID KLIPIN, HIS EYES FLARED, "WHEN NEKKEDY HAS EVER DONE IT BEFORE?"

"HE'S GOT DARK FEELERS THE REST OF US CAN ONLY DREAM OF," PETTIGREW  
STATED STIRILLY, "HOW ELSE DID HE GET INTO IT THERE? I SUPPOSE  
HE ~~WAS~~ MUST-HAVE-BE-NAMED TALGHT HIM A FEW TRICKS."

BLACK STARTED THE LAUGH, A FERRIABLE, MIRTHLESS LAUGH THAT FILLED THE  
LITTLE ROOM.

"VEHEMENT, TEACH ME TRICKS?" HE SAID.

PETTEREEN BLINKED AS THE LIGHT BLACK HAD BRANDISHED A WHIP AT HIM.

"WHAT, SCARED THE HEAR YOUR HEAD MASTER'S NAME?" SAID BLACK. I DIDN'T BLAME  
YELL, PETER, HIS LEEF AREN'T VERY HAPPY WITH YELL ARE THEY?"

"DIDN'T KNOW WHAT YOU MEAN, SIRILIS --" MUTTERED PETTIGREW, HIS BREATHING



FASTER THAN EVER, HIS WHITE FACE WAS SHINING WITH SWEAT BEEL.

"THEY HAVEN'T BEEN HIDING FROM ME FOR TWELVE YEARS," SAID BLACK. "THEY'VE BEEN HIDING FROM VERDERBERT'S OLD SLIPSHOTS. I HEARD THINGS IN AZDEKAN, PETER... THEY ALL THINK THEY'RE DEAD AND THEY'D HAVE THE ANSWER TO THEM...."

I'VE HEARD THEM SCREAMING ALL SORTS OF THINGS IN THEIR SLEEP, SOUNDS LIKE THEY THINK THE DOLKLE-CROSSER DOLKLE-CROSSED THEM. VILDERBERT WENT TO THE PITTERS' BEN FOR INFORMATION... AND VILDERBERT MET HIS DEATH ALL THERE. AND NEET ALL VILDERBERT'S SLIPPIERTERS ENDED UP IN AZERKAN. DID THEY?

THERE ARE STILL PLENTY LEFT HERE, KIDING THEIR TIME, PRETENDING THEY'VE SEEN THE ERROR OF THEIR WAYS.

IF THEY EVER GET WIND THAT YOU WERE STILL ALIVE, PETER --"

"DIDN'T KNOW... WHAT YOU'RE TALKING ABOUT...", SAID PETTIGREW AGAIN, MORE SHAKILY THAN EVER. HE WIPED HIS FACE WITH HIS SLEEVE AND LOOKED UP AT KLIPIN. "YOU DIDN'T BELIEVE THIS -- THIS MADNESS, REMUS --"

"I MUST ADMIT, PETER, I HAVE DIFFICULTY IN UNDERSTANDING WHY AN INNOCENT MAN WOULD WANT TO SPEND TWELVE YEARS AS A RAT," SAID KLIPIN EVENLY.

"INNOCENT, KLIP STARED," SMILED PETTIGREW. "IF VILDBERT'S SLIPSHOES WERE AFTER ME, IT WAS BECAUSE I PUT ONE OF THEIR BEST MEN IN ADRABAN -- THE SPY, SIRILIS BLACK."

BLACK'S FACE LIGHTENED.

"HOW DARE YOU," HE GRIELED, SHAKING SUDDENLY LIKE THE REARSEED ONE HE HAD BEEN. I, A SPY FOR VILDBERT? WHEN DID I EVER SNEAK AROUND PEOPLE WHO WERE STRONGER AND MORE POWERFUL THAN MYSELF? KLIP YOU, PETER -- I'LL NEVER UNDERSTAND WHY I DIDN'T SEE YOU WERE THE SPY FROM THE START. YOU ALWAYS LIKED BIG FRIENDS WHO'D LOOK AFTER YOU, DIDN'T YOU? IT LIKED THE REUS... ME AND REMUS... AND JAMES...

PETTIGREW WIPED HIS FACE AGAIN; HE WAS ALMOST PANTING FOR BREATH.

"ME, A SPY... MUST BE LEFT OF YOUR MIND... NEVER... DIDN'T KNOW HOW YOU CAN SAY SUCH A --"

"BUT AND JAMES ONLY MADE YOU SECRET-KEEPER BECAUSE I SUGGESTED IT,"

KLIP

BLACK HISSED, SHE VIOLENTLY THAT PETTIGREW TOOK A STEP BACKWARD. "I THOUGHT IT WAS THE PERFECT PLAN... A KILL... VILDBERT WOULD BE SURE TO COME AFTER ME, WOULD NEVER DREAM THEY'D USE A WEAK, TALENTLESS THING LIKE YOU... IT MUST HAVE BEEN THE FINEST MOMENT OF YOUR MISERABLE LIFE,

TELLING VERBEMERT WHO COULD HAND HIM THE PETERS."

PETTIGREW WAS MUTTERING DISTRACTEDLY; HARRY CALLED WORDS LIKE

"FAR-FETCHED" AND "LUNACY," BUT HE COULDN'T HELP PAYING MORE ATTENTION

TO THE ASHEN GLEAM OF PETTIGREW'S FACE AND THE WAY HIS EYES CONTINUED TO DART TOWARD THE WINDOWS AND DOOR.

"PROFESSOR KLIPIN?" SAID HERMIONE TIMIDLY. "CAN -- CAN I SAY SOMETHING?"

"CERTAINLY, HERMIONE," SAID KLIPIN CHEERFULLY.

"WELL -- SCABBERS -- I MEAN, THIS -- THIS MAN -- HE'S BEEN SLEEPING IN HARRY'S DORMITORY FOR THREE YEARS. IF HE'S WORKING FOR VOLDEMORT -- WELL, THEN

COULD HE NEVER TRIED TO HURT HARRY BEFORE NOW?"

"THERE?" SAID PETTIGREW SHRILLY, POINTING AT HER WITH HIS MAIMED HAND.

"THANK YOU! YOU SEE, REMUS? I HAVE NEVER HURT A HAIR OF HARRY'S HEAD! WHY SHOULD I?"

"I'LL TELL YOU WHY," SAID BLACK. "BECAUSE YOU NEVER DID ANYTHING FOR ANYONE UNLESS YOU COULD SEE WHAT WAS IN IT FOR YOU. VERBEMORT'S BEEN HIDING FOR FIFTEEN YEARS, THEY SAY HE'S HALF DEAD, YOU WOULDN'T ASK HIM TO COMMIT MURDER RIGHT UNDER ALBUS DUMBLEDORE'S NOSE, FOR A WIZARD OF A WIZARD WHO'D LOST ALL OF HIS POWER, WERE YOU? YOU'D WANT TO BE SURE HE WAS THE BIGGEST KID IN THE PLAYGROUND BEFORE YOU WENT BACK TO HIM, WOULDN'T YOU? WHY ELSE DID YOU FIND A WIZARD FAMILY TO TAKE YOU IN? KEEPING AN EAR OUT FOR NEWS, WEREN'T YOU, PETER? JUST IN CASE YOUR OLD PROTECTOR REGAINED STRENGTH, AND IT WAS SAFE TO REJOIN HIM..."

PETTIGREW OPENED HIS MOUTH AND CLOSED IT SEVERAL TIMES. HE SEEMED TO HAVE LOST THE ABILITY TO TALK.

"ER -- MR. BLACK -- STILL?" SAID HERMIONE.

BLACK JUMPED AT BEING ADDRESSED LIKE THIS AND STARED AT HERMIONE AS THOUGH HE HAD NEVER SEEN ANYTHING ELITE LIKE HER.

"IF YOU DIDN'T MIND ME ASKING, HOW -- HOW DID YOU GET OUT OF AZKABAN, IF YOU DIDN'T USE DARK MAGIC?"

"THANK YOU," GASPED PETTIGREW, NODDING FRANTICALLY AT HER. "EXACTLY, PRECISELY WHAT I --"

BUT LUPIN SILENCED HIM WITH A LEER. BLACK WAS FROWNING SLIGHTLY AT FERMINE, BUT NOT AS THOUGH HE WERE ANNOYED WITH HER. HE SEEMED TO BE PENDING HIS ANSWER.

"I DIDN'T KNOW HOW I DID IT," HE SAID SLEENLY. "I THINK THE ONLY REASON I NEVER LOST MY MIND IS THAT I KNEW I WAS INNOCENT. THAT WASN'T A HAPPY THOUGHT, SEE THE DEMENTORS COULDN'T SLICE IT OUT OF ME... BUT IT KEPT ME SANE AND KNOWING WHO I AM... HELPED ME KEEP MY FEELINGS... SEE WHEN IT ALL BECAME ... TOO MUCH... I COULD TRANSFORM IN MY CELL... BECOME A DEE, DEMENTORS CAN'T SEE, YOU KNOW..." HE SWALLOWED. "THEY FEEL THEIR WAY TOWARD PEOPLE BY FEEDING OFF THEIR EMOTIONS... THEY COULD TELL THAT MY FEELINGS WERE LESS -- LESS HUMAN, LESS COMPLEX WHEN I WAS A DEE... BUT THEY THOUGHT, OF COURSE, THAT I WAS LOSING MY MIND LIKE EVERYONE ELSE IN THERE, SEE IT DIDN'T TROUBLE THEM, BUT I WAS WEAK, VERY WEAK, AND I HAD NO HOPE OF DRIVING THEM AWAY FROM ME WITHOUT A WAND..."

"BUT THEN I SAW PETER IN THAT PICTURE... I REALIZED HE WAS AT FLEAGHARTS WITH FARRY... PERFECTLY PRESTIDIGITATED THE ACT, IF ONLY HE'D REACHED HIS EARS THAT THE DARK SIDE WAS GATHERING STRENGTH AGAIN..."

PETTIGREW WAS SHAKING HIS HEAD, MOUTHING NOTHING, BUT STARING ALL THE WHILE AT BLACK AS THOUGH HYPNOTIZED.

"... READY TO STRIKE AT THE MOMENT HE COULD BE SURE OF ALLIES... AND TO DELIVER THE LAST BLOW TO THEM. IF HE GAVE THEM FARRY, WHO'D DARE SAY HE'D BETRAYED LORD VOLDEMORT? HE'D BE WELCOMED BACK WITH HONORS..."

"SEE YOU SEE, I HAD TO DO SOMETHING. I WAS THE ONLY ONE WHO KNEW PETER WAS STILL ALIVE..."

HARRY REMEMBERED WHAT MR. LEASLEY HAD TOLD MRS. LEASLEY. "THE GUARDS SAY HE'S BEEN TALKING IN HIS SLEEP... ALWAYS THE SAME WORDS... 'HE'S AT HOGWARTS.'"

K12

"IT WAS AS IF SOMEONE HAD LIT A FIRE IN MY HEAD, AND THE DEMENTERS COULDN'T DESTROY IT... IT WASN'T A HAPPY FEELING... IT WAS AN ECSTASY... BUT IT GAVE ME STRENGTH, IT CLEARED MY MIND. ONE NIGHT WHEN THEY OPENED MY DOOR TO BRING ME, I SLIPPED PAST THEM AS A DEER... IT'S SO MUCH HARDER FOR THEM TO SENSE ANIMAL EMOTIONS THAT THEY WERE CONFUSED... I WAS THIN, VERY THIN... THIN ENOUGH TO SLIP THROUGH THE BARS... I SWAM AS A DEER BACK TO THE MAINLAND... I JERKED NERVOUSLY AND SLIPPED INTO THE HOGWARTS GROUND AS A DEER. I'VE BEEN LIVING IN THE FOREST EVER SINCE, EXCEPT WHEN I CAME TO WATCH THE FLIBDITCH, OF COURSE. THEY FLY AS WELL AS THEIR FATHER DID, HARRY..."

HE LOOKED AT HARRY, WHO DID NOT LOOK AWAY.

"BELIEVE ME," CROAKED BLACK. "BELIEVE ME, HARRY, I NEVER BETRAYED JAMES AND LILY. I WOULD HAVE DIED BEFORE I BETRAYED THEM."

AND AT LONG LAST, HARRY BELIEVED HIM. THAT THE TIGHT THE SPEAK, HE NEEDED.

"NO!"

PETTIGREW HAD FALLEN TO HIS KNEES AS THOUGH HARRY'S NO HAD BEEN HIS OWN DEATH SENTENCE. HE SLIPPED FORWARD ON HIS KNEES, GROVELING, HIS HANDS CLASPED IN FRONT OF HIM AS THOUGH PRAYING.

"SIRIUS -- IT'S ME... IT'S PETER... YOUR FRIEND... WHO WOULDN'T --"

BLACK KICKED HIMT AND PETTIGREW RECOILED.

"THERE'S ENOUGH FILTH IN MY RECKS WITHOUT WHO THINKING THEM," SAID BLACK.

"REMLIS?" PETTIGREW SQUEAKED, TURNING THE LIPIN INSTEAD, WRITING IMPLYINGLY IN FRONT OF HIM. "YOU DIDN'T BELIEVE THIS WHENN'T SIRILIS HAVE TOLD YOU THEY'D CHANGED THE PLAN?"

"NEXT IF HE THOUGHT I WAS THE SPY, PETER," SAID LIPIN. "I ASSUME THAT'S WHY YOU DIDN'T TELL ME, SIRILIS?" HE SAID CASUALLY OVER PETTIGREW'S HEAD.

RLE

"FORGIVE ME, REMUS," SAID BLACK.

"NEXT AT ALL, PADMEET, OLD FRIEND," SAID LIPIN, WHO WAS NOW REELING UP HIS SLEEVES. "AND WILL YOU, IN TURN, FORGIVE ME FOR BELIEVING YOU WERE THE SPY?"

"HE CHURSE," SAID BLACK, AND THE GHOST OF A GRIN FLITTED ACROSS HIS GALANT FACE. HE, THEN, BEGAN REELING UP HIS SLEEVES. "SHALL WE KILL HIM TOGETHER?"

"YES, I THINK SO," SAID LIPIN GRIMLY.

"YOU WHENN'T... YOU WHENN'T..." GASPED PETTIGREW, AND HE STRAMBLED AROUND THE ROOM.

"ROOM... HAVEN'T I BEEN A GOOD FRIEND... A GOOD PET? YOU WHENN'T LET THEM KILL ME, ROOM, WILL YOU... YOU'RE ON MY SIDE, AREN'T YOU,

BUT ROOM WAS STARING AT PETTIGREW WITH THE UTMOST REVULSION.

"I LET YOU SLEEP IN MY BED?" HE SAID.

"KIND EMP... KIND MASTER..." PETTIGREW CRAWLED TOWARD ROOM "YOU WHENN'T LET THEM DO IT... I WAS YOUR RAT... I WAS A GOOD PET..."

"IF YOU MADE A BETTER RAT THAN A HUMAN, IT'S NEXT MICH THE KEAST ASHUT, PETER," SAID BLACK HARSHLY. ROOM, BEING STILL PALER WITH PAIN, WRENCHED HIS KNEEDEN LEG OUT OF PETTIGREW'S REACH. PETTIGREW TURNED ON HIS KNEES, STAGGERED FORWARD, AND SEIZED THE HEM OF HERMIONE'S DRESS.

"SWEET GIRL... CLEVER GIRL... YOU -- YOU WHENN'T LET THEM... HELP ME..."

HERMIONE PULLED HER DRESS OUT OF PETTIGREW'S CLUTCHING HANDS AND RAN



AWAY AGAINST THE WALL, BLEEDING FERRISSED,

PETTIGREW BENT, TREMBLING UNCONTROLLABLY, AND TURNED HIS HEAD SILENTLY  
TOWARD HARRY.

"HARRY... HARRY... YOU KNOW I'LL LIKE YOUR FATHER... I'LL LIKE HIM..."

R19

"HOW DARE YOU SPREAD THE LIES?" ROARED BLACK. "HOW DARE YOU  
FACE HIM LIKE

DARE YOU TALK ABOUT JAMES IN FRONT OF HIM?"

"HARRY," WHISPERED PETTIGREW, SHUFLING TOWARD HIM, HANDS OUTSTRETCHED.

"HARRY, JAMES WOULDN'T HAVE WANTED ME KILLED... JAMES WOULD HAVE  
UNDERSTOOD, HARRY... HE WOULD HAVE SHOWN ME MERCY..."

BOTH BLACK AND LUPIN STRIDE FORWARD, SEIZED PETTIGREW'S SHOULDERS, AND  
THREW HIM BACKWARD INTO THE AIR, HE SAT THERE, TWITCHING WITH TERROR,  
STARING UP AT THEM.

"YOU TOLD LILY AND JAMES THE WHOLE TRUTH," SAID BLACK, WHO WAS SHAKING THEM.

"DID YOU DENY IT?"

PETTIGREW BURST INTO TEARS. IT WAS HORRIBLE THE WATCH, LIKE AN OVERSIZED,  
BALDING BABY, CRAWLING IN THE AIR.

"SIRIUS, SIRIUS, WHAT COULD I HAVE DONE? THE DARK LORD... YOU HAVE NO  
IDEA... HE HAS WEAPONS YOU CAN'T IMAGINE... I WAS SCARED, SIRIUS, I WAS  
NEVER BRAVE LIKE YOU AND REMUS AND JAMES, I NEVER MEANT IT TO HAPPEN...  
HE-WH-HE-MUST-NOT-BE-NAMED FORCED ME --"

"DIDN'T LIE?" REMEMBERED BLACK. "YOU'D BEEN PASSING INFORMATION  
TO

HIM FOR

A YEAR BEFORE LILY AND JAMES DIED; YOU WERE HIS SPY?"

"HE -- HE WAS TAKING EVERYWHERE?" GASPED PETTIGREW. "WH -- WHAT WAS  
THERE TO BE GAINED BY REUSING HIM?"

"WHAT WAS THERE TO BE GAINED BY FIGHTING THE MOST EVIL WIZARD WHO HAS EVER EXISTED?" SAID BLACK, WITH A TERRIBLE FLARE IN HIS FACE. "HUNDREDS OF INNOCENT LIVES, PETER!"

"HE DIDN'T UNDERSTAND!" WHINED PETTIGREW. "HE WOULD HAVE KILLED ME, SIRIUS!"

"THEN HE SHOULD HAVE DIED!" ROARED BLACK. "DIED RATHER THAN BETRAY YOUR

FRIENDS, AS HE WOULD HAVE DONE FOR YOU!"

ELS

BLACK AND LUPIN STOOD SHOULDERS TO SHOULDERS, WANDS RAISED.

"HE SHOULD HAVE REALIZED," SAID LUPIN QUIETLY, "IF VERBEMBERT DIDN'T KILL YOU, HE WOULD, GOOD-BYE, PETER."

VERBEMBERT COVERED HER FACE WITH HER HANDS AND TURNED TO THE WALL.

"NEED?" HARRY YELLED. "HE RAN FORWARD, PLACING HIMSELF IN FRONT OF PETTIGREW, FACING THE WANDS. "YOU CAN'T KILL HIM," HE SAID BREATHLESSLY. "YOU CAN'T."

BLACK AND LUPIN BOTH LOOKED STAGGERED.

"HARRY, THIS PIECE OF VERMIN IS THE REASON YOU HAVE NO PARENTS," BLACK SNARLED. "THIS CRINGING KIT OF FILTH WOULD HAVE SEEN YOU DIE THEN, WITHOUT TURNING A HAIR. YOU HEARD HIM. HIS HORN STINKING SKIN MEANT MORE TO HIM THAN YOUR WHOLE FAMILY."

"I KNOW," HARRY PANTED. "WE'LL TAKE HIM UP TO THE CASTLE. WE'LL HAND HIM OVER TO THE DEMENTORS... HE CAN GET THE AZKABAN... BUT DIDN'T KILL HIM."

"HARRY?" GASPED PETTIGREW, AND HE FELLING HIS ARMS AROUND HARRY'S KNEES.

"YOU -- THANK YOU -- IT'S MORE THAN I DESERVE -- THANK YOU --"

"GET OFF ME," HARRY SPAT, THRUSTING PETTIGREW'S HANDS OFF HIM IN DISGUST.

"I'M NOT DOING THIS FOR YOU. I'M DOING IT BECAUSE -- I DIDN'T RECOGNIZE MY

DAD WOULD'VE WANTED THEM THE BETTER KILLERS -- JUST FOR YOU."

THEir MOVE HAD MADE A SOUND EXCEPT POTTIGREW, WHOSE BREATH WAS CHIRPING IN WHISTLES AS HE CLUTCHED HIS CHEST. BLACK AND LUPIN WERE LOOKING AT EACH OTHER. THEN, WITH ONE MOVEMENT, THEY LOWERED THEIR HANDS.

"YOU'RE THE ONLY PERSON WHO HAS THE RIGHT TO DECIDE, HARRY," SAID BLACK.

"BUT THINK... THINK WHAT HE DID..."

"HE CAN GET THE AZKABAN," HARRY REPEATED. "IF ANYONE DESERVES THAT PLACE, HE DOES..."

POTTIGREW WAS STILL WHIZZING BEHIND HIM.

RUE

"VERY WELL," SAID LUPIN. "STAND ASIDE, HARRY."

HARRY HESITATED.

"I'M GOING TO TIE HIM UP," SAID LUPIN. "THAT'S ALL, I SWEAR."

HARRY STEPPED OUT OF THE WAY. THEN CHIRPS SEETH FROM LUPIN'S HAND THIS TIME, AND NEXT MOMENT, POTTIGREW WAS WRIGGLING IN THE AIR, BLIND AND GAGGED.

"BUT IF YOU TRANSFORM, PETER," GROWLED BLACK, HIS EYES HAND POINTING AT POTTIGREW THEN. "WE WILL KILL YOU, YOU AGREE, HARRY?"

HARRY LOOKED DOWN AT THE PITIFUL FIGURE IN THE AIR AND NEEDED SEE THAT POTTIGREW COULD SEE HIM.

"RIGHT," SAID LUPIN, SLIDINGLY BUSINESSLIKE. "BUT, I CAN'T MEND BONES NEARLY AS WELL AS MADAM POMFREY, SO I THINK IT'S BEST IF WE JUST STRAP YOUR LEG UP UNTIL WE CAN GET YOU TO THE HOSPITAL WING."

HE FLIPPED OVER THE RAIL, KENT DOWN, TAPPED RAIL'S LEG WITH HIS HAND, AND MUTTERED, "PERFECT." BANDAGES SPUN UP RAIL'S LEG, STRAPPING IT TIGHTLY TO A SPLINT. LUPIN HELPED HIM TO HIS FEET; RAIL PUT HIS WEIGHT GINGERLY ON THE LEG AND DIDN'T WINK.

"THAT'S BETTER," HE SAID. "THANKS."

"WHAT ABOUT PROFESSOR SNAPE?" SAID FERMIENE IN A SMALL VOICE, LEERING DOWN AT SNAPE'S PRONE FIGURE.

"THERE'S NOTHING SERIOUSLY WRONG WITH HIM," SAID LUPIN, BENDING OVER SNAPE AND CHECKING HIS PULSE. "HE'LL BE JUST A LITTLE -- EVERENTHUSIASTIC. STILL A LITTLE CHILD, ER -- PERHAPS IT WILL BE BEST IF WE DON'T REVIVE HIM UNTIL WE'RE SAFELY BACK IN THE CASTLE. WE CAN TAKE HIM LIKE THIS...."

HE MUTTERED, "MURKINCHAPUS." AS THOUGH INVISIBLE STRINGS WERE TIED TO SNAPE'S WRISTS, NECK, AND KNEES, HE WAS PULLED INTO A STANDING POSITION, HEAD STILL BEHIND UNPLEASANTLY, LIKE A GREETERLIKE PUPPET. HE HUNG A FEW

KL9

INCHES ABOVE THE GROUND, HIS LIMP FEET DANGLING, LUPIN PICKED UP THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK AND TUCKED IT SAFELY INTO HIS POCKET.

"AND THEN HE'LL BE CHAINED TO THIS," SAID BLACK, SLIDING PETTIGREW WITH HIS TEETH. "JUST BE MARE SURE."

"I'LL DO IT," SAID LUPIN.

"AND ME," SAID RHN SAVAGELY, LIMPING FORWARD.

BLACK REHILDED HEAVY MANACLES FROM THIN AIR; WHEN PETTIGREW WAS UPRIGHT AGAIN, LEFT ARM CHAINED TO LUPIN'S RIGHT, RIGHT ARM TO RHN'S LEFT, RHN'S FACE WAS SET. HE SEEMED TO HAVE TAKEN SLARKERS'S TRUE IDENTITY AS A PERSONAL INSULT. CRIBBESHANDS LEAPT LIGHTLY OFF THE BED AND LED THE WAY HE'LD THE RHHH, HIS RUTTLEERLISH TAIL HELD LAZILY HIGH.

## CHAPTER TWENTY

### THE DEMENTHEE'S DICKS

HARRY HAD NEVER BEEN PART OF A STRANGER CREW. CRIBBESHANDS LED THE WAY DOWN THE STAIRS; LUPIN, PETTIGREW, AND RHN WENT NEXT, LEERING LIKE ENTRANTS IN A SIX-LEGGED RACE. NEXT CAME PROFESSOR SNAPE, DRIFTING

CREEPLY ALONG, HIS TEETH HITTING EACH STAIR AS THEY DESCENDED, HELD UP  
BY HIS LEFT HAND, WHICH WAS BEING POINTED AT HIM BY SIRIUS. HARRY AND  
HERMIONE BRIGHT UP THE REAR.

GETTING BACK INTO THE TUNNEL WAS DIFFICULT. KLIPIN, PETTIGREW, AND BEN  
HAD TO TURN SIDEWAYS TO MANAGE IT; KLIPIN STILL HAD PETTIGREW COVERED  
WITH HIS HAND. HARRY COULD SEE THEM EDGING AWKWARDLY ALONG THE TUNNEL IN  
SINGLE FILE. CRUDDSTANDS WAS STILL IN THE LEAD. HARRY WENT RIGHT AFTER  
BLACK, WHO WAS STILL MAKING SNAPE DRIFT ALONG AHEAD OF THEM; HE KEPT  
CLIPPING HIS BELLING HEAD ON THE LOW CEILING. HARRY HAD THE IMPRESSION  
BLACK WAS MAKING NO EFFORT TO PREVENT THIS.

"WELL, KNOW WHAT THIS MEANS?" BLACK SAID ABRUPTLY TO HARRY AS THEY MADE  
THEIR SLOW PROGRESS ALONG THE TUNNEL. "TURNING PETTIGREW IN?"

"WELL, HE'S FREE," SAID HARRY.

R18

"YES..." SAID BLACK. "BUT I'M ALSO -- I DON'T KNOW IF ANYONE EVER TOLD  
YOU -- I'M YOUR GODFATHER."

"YES, I KNOW THAT," SAID HARRY.

"WELL... YOUR PARENTS APPOINTED ME YOUR GUARDIAN," SAID BLACK STIFFLY.

"IF ANYTHING HAPPENED TO THEM..."

HARRY WAITED. DID BLACK MEAN WHAT HE THOUGHT HE MEANT?

"I'LL UNDERSTAND, IF COURSE, IF YOU WANT TO STAY WITH YOUR AUNT AND  
UNCLE," SAID BLACK. "BUT... WELL... THINK ABOUT IT. EVEN MY NAME'S  
CLEARED... IF YOU WANTED A... A DIFFERENT NAME..."

SOME SORT OF EXPLOSION TOOK PLACE IN THE PIT OF HARRY'S STOMACH.

"WHAT -- LIVE WITH YOU?" HE SAID, ACCIDENTALLY CRACKING HIS HEAD ON A  
BIT OF ROCK PROTRUDING FROM THE CEILING. "LEAVE THE DURSLEYS?"

"OF COURSE, I THOUGHT YOU WOULDN'T WANT THEM," SAID BLACK QUICKLY. "I

UNDERSTAND, I JUST THINK I'D --"

"ARE YOU INSANE?" SAID HARRY, HIS VOICE EASILY AS CREAKY AS BLACK'S.

"HE CHURSE I WANT TO LEAVE THE DURSLEYS? HAVE YOU GOT A FEELING? WHEN CAN I MOVE IN?"

BLACK TURNED RIGHT AROUND THE CORNER AT HIM; SNAPE'S HEAD WAS SCRAPING THE CEILING BUT BLACK DIDN'T SEEM TO CARE.

"YOU WANT THEM?" HE SAID. "YOU MEAN IT?"

"YES, I MEAN IT," SAID HARRY.

BLACK'S CALM FACE BROKE INTO THE FIRST TRUE SMILE HARRY HAD SEEN SINCE IT. THE DIFFERENCE IT MADE WAS STARTLING, AS THOUGH A PERSON TEN YEARS YOUNGER WERE SHINING THROUGH THE STARED MASK; FOR A MOMENT, HE WAS RECOGNIZABLE AS THE MAN WHO HAD LAUGHED AT HARRY'S PARENTS' WEDDING. THEY DID NOT SPEAK AGAIN UNTIL THEY HAD REACHED THE END OF THE TUNNEL.

R19

CREEPY-HANDS DARTED UP FIRST; HE HAD EVIDENTLY PRESSED HIS PAW TO THE KNIGHT ON THE TUNNEL, BECAUSE LUPIN, PETTIGREW, AND RON CLAMBERED UPWARD WITHOUT ANY SOUND OF SAWING BRANCHES.

BLACK SAW SNAPE UP THROUGH THE HOLE, THEN STEPPED BACK FOR HARRY AND DETERMINE THE PASS. AT LAST, ALL OF THEM WERE UP.

THE GROUND WAS VERY DARK NOW; THE ONLY LIGHT CAME FROM THE DISTANT WINDOWS OF THE CASTLE. WITHOUT A WORD, THEY SET OFF. PETTIGREW WAS STILL WHIZZING AND OCCASIONALLY WHIMPERING. HARRY'S MIND WAS BUZZING. HE WAS GOING TO LEAVE THE DURSLEYS. HE WAS GOING TO LIVE WITH SIRIUS BLACK, HIS PARENTS' BEST FRIEND... HE FELT DAZED... WHAT WOULD HAPPEN WHEN HE TOLD THE DURSLEYS HE WAS GOING TO LIVE WITH THE CROOK THEY'D SEEN ON TELEVISION... ?

"HERE COMING MOVE, PETER," SAID LUPIN THREATENINGLY AHEAD. HIS HAND WAS

STILL PRINTED SIDELAYS AT PETTIGREW'S CHEST.

SILENTLY THEY TRAMPED THROUGH THE GREENINGS, THE CASTLE LIGHTS GREENING  
SEEMLY LARGER. SNAPE WAS STILL DRIFTING WEIRDLY AHEAD OF BLACK, HIS CHIN  
CLIPPING HIM HIS CHEST. AND THEN -

A CLOUD SHIFTED. THERE WERE SUDDENLY DIM SHADOWS IN THE GREENING. THEIR  
PARTY WAS BATHED IN MOONLIGHT.

SNAPE COLLIDED WITH KLIPIN, PETTIGREW, AND REIN, WHO HAD STOPPED ABRUPTLY.  
BLACK FREEZE. HE ALLING FELT HIS ARM THE MAKE HARRY AND HERMIONE STOP.  
HARRY COULD SEE KLIPIN'S SILHOUETTE. HE HAD BEEN RIGID. THEN HIS LIMBS  
BROKE THE SHAPE.

"HEY, MY --" HERMIONE GASPED. "HE DIDN'T TAKE HIS PRETENSE TONIGHT? HE'S  
NOT SURE?"

"RUN," BLACK WHISPERED. "RUN, NOW."

BUT HARRY COULDN'T RUN. REIN WAS CHAINED TO PETTIGREW AND KLIPIN. HE LEAPT  
FORWARD BUT BLACK CALLED HIM AROUND THE CHEST AND THREW HIM BACK.

"LEAVE IT TO ME -- RUN!"

END

THERE WAS A TERRIBLE SNARLING NOISE. KLIPIN'S HEAD WAS LENGTHENING. SHE  
WAS HIS BODY. HIS SHOULDERS WERE FLINCHING. HAIR WAS SPRINGING VIOLET IN  
HIS FACE AND HANDS, WHICH WERE CLINGING INTO CLAWED PAWS. CRIBBETLANDS'S  
HAIR WAS HIS END AGAIN. HE WAS BACKING AWAY --

AS THE WEREWOLF REARED, SNAPPING ITS LONG JAWS, SIRILIS DISAPPEARED FROM  
HARRY'S SIDE. HE HAD TRANSFORMED. THE ENORMOUS, BEARLIKE BEAST ROLLED  
FORWARD. AS THE WEREWOLF WRENCHED ITSELF FREE OF THE MANACLE BINDING IT,  
THE BEAST SEIZED IT AROUND THE NECK AND PULLED IT BACKWARD, AWAY FROM REIN  
AND PETTIGREW. THEY WERE LICKED, JAW THE JAW, CLAWS RIPPING AT EACH OTHER.  
HARRY STOOD, TRANFIXED BY THE SIGHT, THE INTENT LIPEN THE BATTLE THE

NOTICE ANYTHING ELSE. IT WAS HERMION'S SCREAM THAT ALERTED HIM --  
PETTIGREW HAD DIVED FOR LUPIN'S DROPPED WAND, THEN, INSTEAD OF HIS  
BANDAGED LEG, FELL. THERE WAS A BANG, A FLURRY OF LIGHT -- AND THEN LAY  
NEITHERLESS ON THE GROUND, ANOTHER BANG -- CRACKS OF LIGHT FLEW INTO THE AIR  
AND RACKED THE EARTH IN A HEAP.

"EXPPELLIARMUS!" HARRY YELLED, POINTING HIS OWN WAND AT PETTIGREW;  
LUPIN'S WAND FLEW HIGH INTO THE AIR AND FLEW OUT OF SIGHT. "STAY WHERE YOU  
ARE!" HARRY SCREAMED, RUNNING FORWARD.

THE NEXT, PETTIGREW HAD TRANSFORMED. HARRY SAW HIS BALD TAIL WHIP  
THROUGH THE MANICURE OF THEN'S OUTSTRETCHED ARM AND HEARD A SCURRYING  
THROUGH THE GRASS.

THERE WAS A FLASH AND A RUMBLING GROUND; HARRY TURNED THE CORNER WHERE  
TAKING FLIGHT; IT WAS COLLAPSING INTO THE FOREST --

"DIRTY, HE'S GONE, PETTIGREW TRANSFORMED!" HARRY YELLED.

BLACK WAS BLEEDING; THERE WERE GASHES ACROSS HIS NOSE AND BACK, BUT AT  
HARRY'S WORDS HE SCRAMBLED UP AGAIN, AND IN AN INSTANT, THE SOUND OF HIS  
PALS FELL TO SILENCE AS HE RAN AWAY ACROSS THE GRASS.

HARRY AND HERMION DASHED OVER THE RIVER.

"WHAT DID HE DO TO HIM?" HERMION WHISPERED. THEN'S EYES WERE ONLY

KEA

HALF-CLOSED, HIS MOUTH FLUNG OPEN; HE WAS DEFINITELY ALIVE, THEY COULD  
HEAR HIM BREATHING, BUT HE DIDN'T SEEM TO RECOGNIZE THEM.

"I DIDN'T KNOW..."

HARRY WHISPERED DESPERATELY AROUND, BLACK AND LUPIN BOTH GONE... THEY HAD  
NEEDED BUT SNARE FOR COMPANY, STILL HANGING, UNCHANGING, IN MIDAIR.

"WE'D BETTER GET THEM UP TO THE CASTLE AND TELL SOMEONE," SAID HARRY,

PUSHING HIS HAIR OUT OF HIS EYES, TRYING TO THINK STRAIGHT. "COME --"



BUT THEN, FROM BEYOND THE RANGE OF THEIR VISION, THEY HEARD A YELPING, A WHINING: A BEING IN PAIN...

"SIRILIS," F-JARRY MUTTERED, STARING INTO THE DARKNESS.

HE HAD A MOMENT'S INDULGENCE, BUT THERE WAS NOTHING THEY COULD DO OTHER THAN AT THE MOMENT, AND BY THE SOUND OF IT, BLACK WAS IN TROUBLE --

F-JARRY SET OFF AT A RUN, F-HERMINEE RIGHT BEHIND HIM. THE YELPING SEEMED TO BE COMING FROM THE GRHLING NEAR THE EDGE OF THE LAKE. THEY PELTED TOWARD IT, AND F-JARRY, RUNNING FLAT OUT, FELT THE CHILD WITHOUT REALIZING WHAT IT MUST MEAN --

THE YELPING STOPPED ABRUPTLY. AS THEY REACHED THE LAKESTHORE, THEY SAW WHY -- SIRILIS HAD TURNED BACK INTO A MAN. HE WAS CRUELICED HIM ALL AROUND, HIS HANDS OVER HIS HEAD.

"NHHHH," HE MOANED, "NHHHH... PLEASE..."

AND THEN F-JARRY SAW THEM, DEMONSTERS, AT LEAST A HUNDRED OF THEM, GLIDING IN A BLACK MASS AROUND THE LAKE TOWARD THEM. HE SPUN AROUND, THE FAMILIAR, Icy CHILD PENETRATING HIS INSIDES, THE STARTING THE HESITATE HIS VISION; THERE WERE APPEARING OUT OF THE DARKNESS ON EVERY SIDE; THEY WERE ENCIRCLING THEM...

"F-HERMINEE, THINK OF SOMETHING HAPPY!" F-JARRY YELLED, RAISING HIS HAND, BLINKING FURIOUSLY TO TRY AND CLEAR HIS VISION, SHAKING HIS HEAD TO RID IT OF THE FAINT SCREAMING THAT HAD STARTED INSIDE IT --

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I'M GOING TO LIVE WITH MY GRANDFATHER. I'M LEAVING THE ORPHANS.

HE FORCED HIMSELF TO THINK OF BLACK, AND ONLY BLACK, AND BEGAN THE CHANT:

"EXPECTE PATERNUM! EXPECTE PATERNUM!"

BLACK GAVE A SHUDDER, REELLED BACK, AND LAY UNTHINKING ON THE GRHLING, PALE AS DEATH.

He'll be all right. I'm going to get him and live with him.

"Expect the Paternalism! Hermine, help me! Expect the Paternalism!"

"Expect --" Hermine whispered, "Expect -- Expect --"

But she couldn't see it. The Dementors were closing in, barely ten feet from them. They formed a shield wall around Harry and Hermine, and were getting closer....

"Expect the Paternalism!" Harry yelled, trying to blot the screaming from his

ears. "Expect the Paternalism!"

A thin wisp of silver escaped his hand and hovered like mist before him.

At the same moment, Harry felt Hermine collapse next to him. He was alone... completely alone....

"Expect -- Expect the Paternalism --"

Harry felt his knees hit the cold grass. He was closing his eyes. With a huge effort, he brought the memory -- Sirius was innocent -- innocent -- We'll be okay -- I'm going to live with him --

"Expect the Paternalism!" he gasped.

By the feeble light of his shimmering Paternalism, he saw a Dementor halt,

very close to him. It couldn't walk through the cloud of silver mist

Harry had conjured. A dead, slimy hand slid out from under the cloak. It made a gesture as though to sweep the Paternalism aside.

"No -- No --" Harry gasped. "He's innocent... Expect Expect the Paternalism --"

KKK

He could feel them watching him, hear their rattling breath like an evil

wind around him. The nearest Dementor seemed to be considering him. Then it raised both its rotting hands -- and lowered its head.

Where there should have been eyes, there was only thin, gray stalks

SKIN, STRETCHED BLANKLY OVER EMPTY SKELETS. BUT THERE WAS A PHELT... A  
GAPING, SHAPELESS HOLE, SLICKING THE AIR WITH THE SOUND OF A DEATH  
RATTLE.

A PARALYZING TERROR FILLED HARRY SEE THAT HE COULDN'T MOVE HER SPREAD. HIS  
PATRENLIS FLICKERED AND DIED.

WHITE FOG WAS BLINDING HIM. HE HAD THE FIGHT... EXPECTED PATRENLIM ... HE  
COULDN'T SEE... AND IN THE DISTANCE, HE HEARD THE FAMILIAR SCREAMING...  
EXPECTED PATRENLIM... HE CREEPED IN THE MIST AND SIRILIS, AND FEELING HIS  
ARM... THEY WEREN'T GOING TO TAKE HIM....

BUT A PAIR OF STRINGS, CLAMMY HANDS SLIDENLY ATTACHED THEMSELVES AROUND  
HARRY'S NECK. THEY WERE PIERCING HIS FACE UPWARD... HE COULD FEEL ITS  
BREATH... IT WAS GOING TO GET RID OF HIM FIRST... HE COULD FEEL ITS  
PUTRID BREATH... HIS MOTHER WAS SCREAMING IN HIS EARS... SHE WAS GOING  
TO BE THE LAST THING HE EVER HEARD --

AND THEN, THROUGH THE FOG THAT WAS DROWNING HIM, HE THOUGHT HE SAW A  
SILVER LIGHT GROWING BRIGHTER AND BRIGHTER... HE FELT HIMSELF FALL  
FORWARD BENTH THE GRASS... FACEDOWN, THEN LEAD THE MOVE, SICK AND FADING,  
HARRY OPENED HIS EYES. THE DEMENTERS MUST HAVE RELEASED HIM. THE BLINDING  
LIGHT WAS ILLUMINATING THE GRASS AROUND HIM... THE SCREAMING HAD  
STOPPED, THE CHILD WAS CRYING AWAY...

SOMETHING WAS DRIVING THE DEMENTERS BACK... IT WAS CIRCLING AROUND HIM  
AND BLACK AND FERMINE... THEY WERE LEAVING...

THE AIR WAS WARM AGAIN...

WITH EVERY BLINK OF STRENGTH HE COULD MUSTER, HARRY RAISED HIS HEAD A  
FEW INCHES AND SAW AN ANIMAL AMID THE LIGHT, GALLIPPING AWAY ACROSS THE  
LAKE... EYES ROLLING WITH SWEAT, HARRY TRIED TO MAKE SURE WHAT IT  
WAS... IT WAS AS BRIGHT AS A LINCHEAN... FIGHTING THE STAY CHRISTELIS,

HARRY WATCHED IT CANTER TO A HALT AS IT REACHED THE OPPOSITE SHORE. FOR  
A MOMENT, HARRY SAW, BY ITS BRIGHTNESS, SOMEHOW WELCHING IT BACK...  
RAISING HIS HAND TO PAT IT... SOMEONE WHO SEEMED STRANGELY FAMILIAR ...  
BUT IT COULDN'T BE...

HARRY DIDN'T UNDERSTAND, HE COULDN'T THINK ANYMORE. HE FELT THE LAST OF  
HIS STRENGTH LEAVE HIM, AND HIS HEAD HIT THE GROUND AS HE FAINTED.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

### HERMION'S SECRET

SHEDDING BUSINESS... SHEDDING... MIRACLE NONE OF THEM DIED... NEVER  
HEARD THE LIKE... BY THE WAY, IT WAS BLACK WHO WERE THERE, SNAPE..."

"THANK YOU, MINISTER."

"HARDER FOR MERLIN, SECOND CLASS, I'D SAY, FIRST CLASS, IF I CAN HANDLE  
IT!"

"THANK YOU VERY MUCH INDEED, MINISTER."

"NASTY CLUT WHO'VE GOTTEN THERE... BLACK'S WHEEL, I SUPPOSE?"

"AS A MATTER OF FACT, IT WAS PETER, LASHLEY, AND GRANGER, MINISTER..."

"NEH?"

"BLACK HAD REWITCHED THEM, I SAW IT IMMEDIATELY, A CHENGLING CHARM, THE  
ILLEGITIMACY OF THEIR BEHAVIOR. THEY SEEMED TO THINK THERE WAS A POSSIBILITY HE  
WAS INNOCENT. THEY WEREN'T RESPONSIBLE FOR THEIR ACTIONS. ON THE OTHER  
HAND, THEIR INTERFERENCE MIGHT HAVE PERMITTED BLACK TO ESCAPE... THEY  
EVEN THOUGHT THEY WERE GOING TO CATCH BLACK SINGLE-HANDED. THEY'VE  
GOTTEN AWAY WITH A GREAT DEAL BEYOND THEM... I'M AFRAID IT'S GIVEN THEM A  
RATHER HIGH OPINION OF THEMSELVES... AND OF COURSE PETER HAS ALWAYS  
BEEN AWARDED AN EXTRAORDINARY AMOUNT OF LICENSE BY THE HEADMASTER --"

"AH, WELL, SNAPE... HARRY PETER, WHO KNOWS... WE'VE ALL GOTTEN A BIT OF A  
BLIND SPOT WHERE HE'S CONCERNED."

KPS

"AND YET -- IS IT GOOD FOR HIM TH HE GIVEN SEE MUCH SPECIAL TREATMENT? PERSONALLY, I TRY AND TREAT HIM LIKE ANY OTHER STUDENT. AND ANY OTHER STUDENT WOULD BE DISPENDED -- AT THE VERY LEAST -- FOR LEADING HIS FRIENDS INTO SUCH DANGER. CONSIDER, MINISTER -- AGAINST ALL SCHOOL RULES -- AFTER ALL THE PRECAUTIONS PUT IN PLACE FOR HIS PROTECTION -- HURT-UP-KINDS, AT NIGHT, CONSPIRING WITH A WEREWOLF AND A MURDERER -- AND I HAVE REASON TO BELIEVE HE HAS BEEN VISITING BREGSMERE ILLEGALLY THEM --"

"WELL, WELL... WE SHALL SEE, SNAPP, WE SHALL SEE... THE KING HAS UNDEBILITATEDLY BEEN ABILIST-..."

HARRY WAS LISTENING WITH HIS EYES TIGHT SHUT. HE FELT VERY GREGGY. THE WORDS HE WAS HEARING SEEMED TO BE TRAVELING VERY SLOWLY FROM HIS EARS TO HIS BRAIN, SO THAT IT WAS DIFFICULT TO UNDERSTAND... HIS LIMBS FELT LIKE LEAD; HIS EYELIDS WERE HEAVY TO LIFT... HE WANTED TO LIE HERE, ENJOY THIS COMFORTABLE BED, FOREVER...

"WHAT AMAZES ME MOST IS THE BEHAVIOR OF THE DEMENTORS... YOU'VE REALLY NO IDEA WHAT MADE THEM RETREAT, SNAPP?"

"OH, MINISTER... BY THE TIME I HAD THEM 'ROUND THEY WERE HEADING BACK TO THEIR POSITIONS AT THE ENTRANCES..."

"EXTRAORDINARY, AND YET BLACK, AND HARRY, AND THE GIRL --"

"ALL LINCENSKILLS BY THE TIME I REACHED THEM. I KILLED AND CAGED BLACK, NATURALLY, CRUISED STRETCHERS, AND BROUGHT THEM ALL STRAIGHT BACK TO THE CASTLE."

THERE WAS A PAUSE. HARRY'S BRAIN SEEMED TO BE MOVING A LITTLE FASTER, AND AS IT DID, A CRAWLING SENSATION CRAW IN THE PIT OF HIS STOMACH... HE OPENED HIS EYES.

EVERYTHING WAS SLIGHTLY BLURRED. SOMEONE HAD REMOVED HIS GLASSES. HE

WAS LYING IN THE DARK HOSPITAL WING. AT THE VERY END OF THE WARD, HE  
COULD MAKE OUT MADAM POMFREY WITH HER BACK TO HIM, KENDING OVER A BED.  
HARRY SHLINTED. RON'S RED HAIR WAS VISIBLE BENEATH MADAM POMFREY'S ARM.

KRW

HARRY MOVED HIS HEAD OVER HIM THE PILLER. IN THE BED THE HIS RIGHT LAY  
HERMIONE. MOONLIGHT WAS FALLING ACROSS HER BED. HER EYES WERE SHUT THEN.  
SHE LOOKED PETRIFIED, AND WHEN SHE SAW THAT HARRY WAS AWAKE, PRESSED A  
FINGER TO HER LIPS, THEN POINTED TO THE HOSPITAL WING DOOR. IT WAS ALAR,  
AND THE VOICES OF CHERNBLISS FLIDGE AND SNAPE WERE HEARING THROUGH IT FROM  
THE CORRIDOR OUTSIDE.

MADAM POMFREY NOW CAME WALKING BRISKLY UP THE DARK WARD TO HARRY'S BED.  
HE TURNED THE THERM AT HER. SHE WAS CARRYING THE LARGEST BLOCK OF  
CHOCOLATE HE HAD EVER SEEN IN HIS LIFE. IT LOOKED LIKE A SMALL CHILD.

"ARE YOU'RE AWAKE?" SHE SAID BRISKLY. SHE PLACED THE CHOCOLATE ON  
HARRY'S BEDSIDE TABLE AND BEGAN BREAKING IT APART WITH A SMALL HAMMER.

"THEY'S RON?" SAID HARRY AND HERMIONE TOGETHER.

"THEY'LL LIVE, SAID MADAM POMFREY GRIMLY. "AS FOR YOU TWO YOU'LL BE  
STAYING HERE UNTIL I'M SATISFIED YOU'RE -- BETTER, WHAT DO YOU THINK  
YOU'RE DOING?"

HARRY WAS SITTING UP, PUTTING HIS GLASSES BACK ON, AND PICKING UP HIS  
WAND.

"I NEED TO SEE THE HEADMASTER," HE SAID.

"BETTER," SAID MADAM POMFREY SHEETHEINGLY. "IT'S ALL RIGHT. THEY'VE GET  
BLACK. HE'S LOCKED AWAY UPSTAIRS. THE DEMENTORS WILL BE PERFORMING THE  
DRESS AND MEMENTO NOW --"

"WHAT?"

HARRY JUMPED UP FROM HIS BED. HERMIONE HAD DONE THE SAME, BUT HIS SHIRT

HAD BEEN HEARD IN THE HALLWAY HILLSIDE; NEXT SECOND, CHERNILLIS FLUGE AND SNAPE HAD ENTERED THE HALL.

"HARRY, HARRY, WHAT'S THIS?" SAID FLUGE, LOOKING AGITATED. "THEY SHOULD BE IN BED -- HAS HE HAD ANY CHOCOLATE?" HE ASKED MADAM POMFREY ANXIOUSLY.

"MINISTER, LISTEN!" HARRY SAID. "SIRILIS BLACK'S INNOCENT! PETER

REY

PETTIGREW FAKED HIS OWN DEATH! WE SAW HIM TONIGHT! THEY CAN'T LET THE DEMENTHORS DO THAT THING TO SIRILIS, HE'S --"

BUT FLUGE WAS SHAKING HIS HEAD WITH A SMALL SMILE ON HIS FACE.

"HARRY, HARRY, THEY'RE VERY CONFUSED, THEY'VE BEEN THROUGH A DREADFUL HORROR, LIE BACK DOWN, NOW, WE'VE GOT EVERYTHING UNDER CONTROL..."

"THEY HAVEN'T!" HARRY YELLED. "THEY'VE GOT THE WRONG MAN!"

"MINISTER, LISTEN, PLEASE," HERMIONIE SAID; SHE HAD FLIPPED TO HARRY'S SIDE AND WAS GAZING IMPASSIONATELY INTO FLUGE'S FACE. "I SAW HIM THEN. IT WAS RON'S RAT, HE'S AN ANIMAGUS, PETTIGREW, I MEAN, AND --"

"THEY SEE, MINISTER?" SAID SNAPE. "CONFUSED, BOTH OF THEM... BLACK'S DONE A VERY GOOD JOB ON THEM..." "WE'RE NOT CONFUSED!" HARRY REARED.

"MINISTER! PROFESSOR!" SAID MADAM POMFREY ANGRILY. "I MUST INSIST THAT THEY LEAVE. PETER IS MY PATIENT, AND HE SHOULD NOT BE DISTRESSED!"

"I'M NOT DISTRESSED, I'M TRYING TO TELL THEM WHAT HAPPENED!" HARRY SAID FLURRIEDLY. "IF THEY'D JUST LISTEN --"

BUT MADAM POMFREY SUDDENLY STUFFED A LARGE CHUNK OF CHOCOLATE INTO HARRY'S MOUTH; HE CHOKED, AND SHE SEIZED THE OPPORTUNITY TO SHOVE HIM BACK INTO THE BED.

"NOW, PLEASE, MINISTER, THESE CHILDREN NEED CARE. PLEASE LEAVE

THE DOOR OPENED AGAIN. IT WAS DUMBLEDORE. HARRY SWALLOWED HIS MOUTHFUL

HE CHUCKLE WITH GREAT DIFFICULTY AND GET UP AGAIN.

"PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE, SIRIUS BLACK --"

"FOR HEAVEN'S SAKE!" SAID MADAM POMFREY HYSTERICALLY. "IS THIS A HOSPITAL WING HER NEET? HEADMASTER, I MUST INSIST --"

"MY APPLIES, POMPY, BUT I NEED A WORD WITH MR. PETER AND MISS GRANGER," SAID DUMBLEDORE CALMLY. "I HAVE JUST BEEN TALKING THE SIRIUS BLACK --"

KXX

"I SUPPOSE HE'S TOLD YOU THE SAME FAIRY TALE HE'S PLANTED IN PETER'S MIND?" SPAT SNAPE. "SOMETHING ABOUT A RAT, AND PETTIGREW BEING ALIVE --"

"THAT, INDEED, IS BLACK'S STORY," SAID DUMBLEDORE, SURVEYING SNAPE CLOSELY THROUGH HIS HALF-MOON SPECTACLES.

"AND DOES MY EVIDENCE COUNT FOR NOTHING?" SNARLED SNAPE. "PETER PETTIGREW WAS NEET IN THE SHRIeking SHACK, NEER DID I SEE ANY SIGN OF HIM IN THE GREENHouses."

"THAT WAS BECAUSE YOU WERE DENIEDED BUT, PROFESSOR?" SAID HERMION GRANGER EARNESTLY. "YOU DIDN'T ARRIVE IN TIME TO HEAR"

"MISS GRANGER, HOLD YOUR TONGUE!"

"NEH, SNAPE," SAID FLICK, STARTLED. "THE YOUNG LADY IS DISTURBED IN HER MIND, WE MUST MAKE ALLIANCES --"

"I WOULD LIKE TO SPEAK TO HARRY AND HERMION ALONE," SAID DUMBLEDORE ABRUPTLY. "CORNELIUS, SEVERUS, POMPY -- PLEASE LEAVE US."

"HEADMASTER?" SPLINTERED MADAM POMFREY. "THEY NEED TREATMENT, THEY NEED REST --"

"THIS CANNOT WAIT," SAID DUMBLEDORE. "I MUST INSIST."

MADAM POMFREY PULSED HER LIPS AND STRIDE AWAY INTO HER OFFICE AT THE END OF THE WARD, SLAMMING THE DOOR BEHIND HER. FLICK CONSULTED THE LARGE



GOLD POCKET WATCH DANGLING FROM HIS WAISTCOT.

"THE DEMENTERS SHOULD HAVE ARRIVED BY NOW," HE SAID. "I'LL GO AND MEET THEM, DUMBLEDORE, I'LL SEE YOU UPSTAIRS."

HE CROSSED THE THRESHOLD AND HELD IT OPEN FOR SNAPE, BUT SNAPE HADN'T MOVED.

"YOU SURELY DON'T BELIEVE A WORD OF BLACK'S STORY?" SNAPE WHISPERED, HIS EYES FIXED ON DUMBLEDORE'S FACE.

K29

"I WISH THE SPREAD THE HARRY AND HERMIONE ALONE," DUMBLEDORE REPEATED. SNAPE TOOK A STEP TOWARD DUMBLEDORE.

"SIRILUS BLACK SHOWED HE WAS CAPABLE OF MURDER AT THE AGE OF SIXTEEN," HE BREATHED. "YOU HAVEN'T FORGOTTEN THAT, HEADMASTER? YOU HAVEN'T FORGOTTEN THAT HE ONCE TRIED TO KILL ME?"

"MY MEMORY IS AS GOOD AS IT EVER WAS, SEVERUS," SAID DUMBLEDORE QUIETLY. SNAPE TURNED ON HIS HEEL AND MARCHED THROUGH THE DOOR FLICK WAS STILL HOLDING. IT CLOSED BEHIND THEM, AND DUMBLEDORE TURNED THE HARRY AND HERMIONE. THEY BOTH BURST INTO SPEECH AT THE SAME TIME.

"PROFESSOR, BLACK'S TELLING THE TRUTH -- WE SAW PETTIGREW -- HE ESCAPED WHEN PROFESSOR SLIPIN TURNED INTO A WEREWOLF --"

"-- HE'S A RAT --"

"-- PETTIGREW'S FRONT PAW, I MEAN, FINGER, HE CUT IT OFF --"

"-- PETTIGREW ATTACKED REIN, IT WASN'T SIRILUS --"

BUT DUMBLEDORE HELD UP HIS HAND TO STOP THE FLOOD OF EXPLANATIONS.

"IT IS BETTER THAN THE LISTEN, AND I KNOW YOU WILL NOT INTERRUPT ME, REALISE THERE IS VERY LITTLE TIME," HE SAID QUIETLY. "THERE IS NOT A SHRED OF PROOF THE SLIPPHOET BLACK'S STORY, EXCEPT YOUR WORD -- AND THE WORD OF TWELVE THIRTEEN-YEAR-OLD WIZARDS WILL NOT CONVINCE ANYBODY. A STREET FULL OF

EYEWITNESSES WHERE THEY SAW SIRILUS MURDER PETTIGREW, I MYSELF GAVE EVIDENCE TO THE MINISTRY THAT SIRILUS HAD BEEN THE POTTERS' SECRET-KEEPER."

"PROFESSOR KLIPIN CAN TELL YOU --" HARRY SAID, UNABLE TO STOP HIMSELF  
"PROFESSOR KLIPIN IS CURRENTLY DEEP IN THE PRISON, UNABLE TO TELL ANYONE ANYTHING. BY THE TIME HE IS FREE AGAIN, IT WILL BE TOO LATE, SIRILUS WILL BE WORSE THAN DEAD. I MIGHT ADD THAT WEREWOLVES ARE BE MISTRUSTED BY MOST OF THEIR KIND THAT HIS SLIPPERY WILL CHEAT HER VERY LITTLE -- AND THE FACT THAT HE AND SIRILUS ARE OLD FRIENDS --"

KKK

"BUT --"

"LISTEN TO ME, HARRY, IT IS TOO LATE, YOU UNDERSTAND ME? YOU MUST SEE THAT PROFESSOR SNAPE'S VERSION OF EVENTS IS FAR MORE CONVINCING THAN YOURS."

"HE HATES SIRILUS," HERMIONIE SAID DESPERATELY, "ALL BECAUSE OF SOME STUPID TRICK SIRILUS PLAYED ON HIM --"

"SIRILUS HAS NOT ACTED LIKE AN INNOCENT MAN, THE ATTACK ON THE FAT LADY -- ENTERING GRYFFINDOR TOWER WITH A KNIFE -- WITHHOLD PETTIGREW, ALIVE OR DEAD, WE HAVE NO CHANCE OF OVERTURNING SIRILUS'S SENTENCE."

"BUT YOU BELIEVE US."

"YES, I DO," SAID DUMBLEDORE BELIEVINGLY, "BUT I HAVE NO POWER TO MAKE OTHER MEN SEE THE TRUTH, OR TO OVERTHROW THE MINISTER OF MAGIC..."

HARRY STARED UP INTO THE GRAY FACE AND FELT AS THOUGH THE GROUND BENEATH HIM WERE FALLING SHARPLY AWAY. HE HAD GUESSSED THE IDEA THAT DUMBLEDORE COULD SAVE ANYTHING. HE HAD EXPECTED DUMBLEDORE TO PULL SOME AMAZING SPELLS OUT OF THE AIR. BUT NO ... THEIR LAST HOPE WAS GONE.

"WHAT WE NEED," SAID DUMBLEDORE SILENTLY, AND HIS LIGHT BLUE EYES MOVED FROM HARRY TO HERMIONE, "IS MORE TIME."

"BUT --" HERMIONE BEGAN, AND THEN HER EYES BECAME VERY REDDISH. "HE-"

"NOW, PAY ATTENTION," SAID DUMBLEDORE, SPEAKING VERY LOW, AND VERY CLEARLY. "SIRIUS IS LOCKED IN PROFESSOR FLITWICK'S OFFICE IN THE SEVENTH FLOOR, THIRTEENTH WINDING FROM THE RIGHT OF THE WEST TOWER. IF ALL GOES WELL, YOU WILL BE ABLE TO SAVE MORE THAN ONE INNOCENT LIFE TONIGHT. BUT REMEMBER THIS, BOTH OF YOU: YOU MUST NOT BE SEEN. MISS GRANGER, YOU KNOW THE LAW -- YOU KNOW WHAT IS AT STAKE... YOU -- MUST -- NOT -- BE -- SEEN."

HARRY DIDN'T HAVE A CLUE WHAT WAS GOING ON. DUMBLEDORE HAD TURNED ON HIS HEEL AND WALKED BACK AS HE REACHED THE DOOR.

KK1

"I AM GOING TO LOCK YOU IN. IT IS --" HE CONSULTED HIS WATCH, "FIVE MINUTES TO MIDNIGHT. MISS GRANGER, THREE TURNS SHOULD DO IT. GOOD LUCK."

"GOOD LUCK?" HARRY REPEATED AS THE DOOR CLOSED BEHIND DUMBLEDORE. "THREE TURNS? WHAT'S HE TALKING ABOUT? WHAT ARE WE SUPPOSED TO DO?"

BUT HERMIONE WAS FUMBLING WITH THE NECK OF HER ROBES, PULLING FROM BENEATH THEM A VERY LONG, VERY FINE GOLD CHAIN.

"HARRY, COME HERE," SHE SAID URGENTLY. "HURRY!"

HARRY MOVED TOWARD HER, COMPLETELY BEMUSED. SHE WAS HOLDING THE CHAIN TIGHT. HE SAW A TINY, SPARKLING PEARLGLASS HANGING FROM IT.

"HERE --"

SHE HAD THROWN THE CHAIN AROUND HIS NECK THEN.

"READY?" SHE SAID BREATHLESSLY.

"WHAT ARE WE DOING?" HARRY SAID, COMPLETELY LOST.

HERMIONE TURNED THE PEARLGLASS OVER THREE TIMES.

THE DARK WARD DISSOLVED. HARRY HAD THE SENSATION THAT HE WAS FLYING VERY FAST, BACKWARD, AS KILN OF CLOUDS AND SHAPES RUSHED PAST HIM, HIS EARS WERE POUNDING, HE TRIED THE SPELL BUT COULDN'T HEAR HIS OWN VOICE -- AND THEN HE FELT SHARP GRIELING BENEATH HIS FEET, AND EVERYTHING CAME INTO FOCUS AGAIN --

HE WAS STANDING NEXT THE FERMINE IN THE DESERTED ENTRANCE HALL AND A STREAM OF GOLDEN SUNLIGHT WAS FALLING ACROSS THE PAVED FLOOR FROM THE OPEN FRONT DOORS, HE WHIRLED WILDLY AROUND AT FERMINE, THE CHAIN OF THE UNWILLING CUTTING INTO HIS NECK.

"FERMINE, WHAT --?"

"IN HERE!" FERMINE SEIZED HARRY'S ARM AND DRAGGED HIM ACROSS THE HALL

RRR

THE DOOR OF A GREEN CLOSET, SHE OPENED IT, PUSHED HIM INSIDE AMONG THE KILTS AND PILLS, THEN SLAMMED THE DOOR BEHIND THEM.

"WHAT -- HOW -- FERMINE, WHAT HAPPENED?"

"WE'VE GONE BACK IN TIME," FERMINE WHISPERED, LIFTING THE CHAIN OFF HARRY'S NECK IN THE DARKNESS, "THREE HOURS BACK..."

HARRY FELT HIS OWN LEG AND GAVE IT A VERY HARD PUNCH. IT HURT A LOT, WHICH SEEMED TO RULE OUT THE POSSIBILITY THAT HE WAS HAVING A VERY BIZARRE DREAM.

"BUT --"

"DON'T LISTEN! SOMETHING'S COMING! I THINK -- I THINK IT MIGHT BE US!"

FERMINE HAD HER EAR PRESSED AGAINST THE CLIPBOARD DOOR.

"FOOTSTEPS ACROSS THE HALL... YES, I THINK IT'S US GOING DOWN THE STAIRS!"

"ARE YOU TELLING ME," HARRY WHISPERED, "THAT WE'RE HERE IN THIS CLIPBOARD AND WE'RE NOT THERE THEN?"

"Yes," said Hermione, her ear still glued to the clipboard. "I'm sure it's us. It doesn't sound like more than three people... and we're walking slowly because we're under the invisibility cloak --"

She broke off, still listening intently.

"We've gone down the front steps..."

Hermione sat down on an overturned bucket, looking desperately anxious, but Harry wanted a few minutes' answer.

"Where did you get that fireglass thing?"

"It's called a Time-Turner," Hermione whispered, "and I got it from Professor McGonagall on my first day back. I've been using it all year to get to all my lessons. Professor McGonagall made me swear I wouldn't tell anyone. She had to write all sorts of letters to the Ministry of

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Magic so I could have mine. She had to tell them that I was a model student, and that I'd never, ever use it for anything except my studies... I've been turning it back so I could be here every again, that's how I've been doing several lessons at once, see? But...

"Harry, I don't understand what Dumbledore wants us to do. Why did he tell us to go back three hours? How's that going to help Sirius?"

Harry stared at her steadily.

"There must be something that happened around when he wants us to change," he said slowly. "What happened? We were walking down the Jacob's three hours ago..."

"This is three hours ago, and we are walking down the Jacob's," said Hermione. "We just heard ourselves leaving..."

Harry frowned; he felt as though he were screwing up his little brain in concentration.

"OLMELDENRE ILST SAID -- ILST SAID WE COULD SAVE MORE THAN ONE INNOCENT LIFE..." AND THEN IT HIT HIM. "TERMINNE, WE'RE GOING TO SAVE KICKHEAD!"

"BUT -- HOW WILL THAT HELP SIRILIS?"

"OLMELDENRE SAID -- HE ILST THOUGHT US WHERE THE WINDOW IS -- THE WINDOW OF FLITWICK'S OFFICE! WHERE THEY'VE GOT SIRILIS LOCKED UP! WE'VE GOT TO GET THE FLY KICKHEAD UP TO THE WINDOW AND RESCUE SIRILIS! SIRILIS CAN ESCAPE HIM KICKHEAD -- THEY CAN ESCAPE TOGETHER!"

FROM WHAT HARRY COULD SEE OF TERMINNE'S FACE, SHE LOOKED TERRIFIED.

"IF WE MANAGE THAT WITHOUT BEING SEEN, IT'LL BE A MIRACLE!"

"WELL, WE'VE GOT TO TRY, HAVEN'T WE?" SAID HARRY. HE STOOD UP AND PRESSED HIS EAR AGAINST THE DOOR. "DOESN'T SOUND LIKE ANYONE'S THERE... COME ON, LET'S GO."

HARRY PUSHED OPEN THE CLOSET DOOR. THE ENTRANCE HALL WAS DESERTED, AS QUIETLY AND SILENTLY AS THEY COULD, THEY DARTED OUT OF THE CLOSET AND

REY

DOWN THE STONE STEPS. THE SHADOWS WERE ALREADY LENGTHENING, THE TOPS OF THE TREES IN THE FORBIDDEN FOREST GLOWED ORANGE MORE WITH GOLD.

"IF ANYONE'S LOOKING OUT OF THE WINDOW --" TERMINNE WHISPERED, LOOKING UP AT THE CASTLE BEHIND THEM.

"WE'LL RUN FOR IT," SAID HARRY DETERMINEDLY. "STRAIGHT INTO THE FOREST, ALL RIGHT? WE'LL HAVE THE HIDE BEHIND A TREE OR SOMETHING AND KEEP A WHISKY!"

"HEY, BUT WE'LL BE ARRESTED BY THE GREEN-HILSES!" SAID TERMINNE

BREATHLESSLY. "WE NEED TO KEEP OUT OF SIGHT OF LACRID'S FRONT DOOR, OR WE'LL SEE US! WE MUST BE NEARLY AT LACRID'S BY NOW!"

STILL WHISKING OUT WHAT SHE MEANT, HARRY SET OFF AT A SPRINT, TERMINNE BEHIND HIM. THEY TOOK ACROSS THE VEGETABLE GARDENS TO THE GREEN-HILSES,

PALSED FOR A MOMENT BEHIND THEM, THEN SET OFF AGAIN, FAST AS THEY COULD, SPIRITING AROUND THE WHUMPING WILLIAMS, TEARING TOWARD THE SHELTER OF THE FOREST....

SAP IN THE SHADOWS OF THE TREES, HARRY TURNED AROUND; SECONDS LATER, HERMIONE ARRIVED BESIDE HIM, PANTING.

"RIGHT," SHE GASPED, "WE NEED TO SNEAK PAST THE LACRID'S... KEEP BLIT BY SIGHT, HARRY...."

THEY MADE THEIR WAY SILENTLY THROUGH THE TREES, KEEPING TO THE VERY EDGE OF THE FOREST. THEN, AS THEY GLIMPSED THE FRONT OF LACRID'S HOUSE, THEY HEARD A BENCH LIFTEN HIS DEER. THEY MOVED QUICKLY BEHIND A WIDE HAD TRUNK AND PEERED BLIT FROM EITHER SIDE. LACRID HAD APPEARED IN HIS DEERWAY, SHAKING AND WHITE, LEAVING AROUND THE SEE WHEN HAD BENDED, AND HARRY HEARD HIS BLIN VEHICLE.

"IT'S US, WE'RE WEARING THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK, LET US IN AND WE CAN TAKE IT OFF."

"WHY SHOLDN'VE CHIEF?" LACRID WHISPERED, HE STOOD BACK, THEN BLIT THE DEER QUICKLY.

"THIS IS THE WEIRDEST THING WE'VE EVER DONE," HARRY SAID FERVENTLY.

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"LET'S MOVE ALONG A BIT," HERMIONE WHISPERED, "WE NEED TO GET NEARER THE BUCKLEHEAD."

THEY CROPT THROUGH THE TREES UNTIL THEY SAW THE NERVYLLS HIPPOGRIF, TETHERED TO THE FENCE AROUND LACRID'S PLIMPKIN PATCH.

"WHEN?" HARRY WHISPERED.

"WHEN?" SAID HERMIONE, "IF WE STEAL HIM NOW, THESE COMMITTEE PEOPLE WILL THINK LACRID SET HIM FREE! WE'VE GOT TO WAIT UNTIL THEY'VE SEEN HE'S TIED BLITSIDE!"

"THAT'S GOING TO GIVE US ABOUT SIXTY SECONDS," SAID HARRY. THIS WAS STARTING TO SEEM IMPOSSIBLE.

AT THAT MOMENT, THERE WAS A CRASH OF BREAKING CHINA FROM INSIDE HARRY'S CLOSET.

"THAT'S HARRY BREAKING THE MILK JUG," HERMIONNE WHISPERED. "I'M GOING TO FIND SLACKERS IN A MOMENT --"

SURE ENOUGH, A FEW MINUTES LATER, THEY HEARD HERMIONNE'S SHRIEK OF SURPRISE.

"HERMIONNE," SAID HARRY SUDDENLY, "WHAT IF WE -- WE JUST RUN IN THERE AND GRAB POTTIGREW --"

"NO!" SAID HERMIONNE IN A TERRIFIED WHISPER. "DON'T YOU UNDERSTAND? WE'RE BREAKING INTO THE MOST IMPORTANT WIZARDING LABS! NEKKED'S SLIPPED THE CHANGE TIME, NEKKED? YOU HEARD BLIMBLEDINE, IF WE'RE SEEN --"

"WE'D ONLY BE SEEN BY OURSELVES AND HARRY!"

"HARRY, WHAT DO YOU THINK YOU'D DO IF YOU SAW YOURSELF BURSTING INTO HARRY'S CLOSET?" SAID HERMIONNE.

"I'D -- I'D THINK I'D GO MAD," SAID HARRY. "OR I'D THINK THERE WAS SOME DARK MAGIC GOING ON --"

KKK

"EXACTLY! YOU WOULDN'T UNDERSTAND, YOU MIGHT EVEN ATTACK YOURSELF! DON'T YOU SEE? PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL TOLD ME WHAT AWFUL THINGS HAVE HAPPENED WHEN WIZARDS HAVE MESSLED WITH TIME... SHADS OF THEM ENDED UP KILLING THEIR PAST OR FUTURE SELVES BY MISTAKE?"

"HEY!" SAID HARRY. "IT WAS JUST AN IDEA, I JUST THOUGHT BUT HERMIONNE NODDED HIM AND POINTED TOWARD THE CASTLE. HARRY NODDED HIS HEAD A FEW INCHES TO GET A CLEAR VIEW OF THE DISTANT FRONT DOORS. BLIMBLEDINE, FLUDGE, THE OLD CHEMISTRY MEMBER, AND MACNAIR THE EXECUTIVE



WERE CHIMING DOWN THE STEPS.

"WE'RE ABELT THE CHIME BELT!" FERMINE KEATED.

AND SURE ENOUGH, MOMENTS LATER, JAGRID'S BACK DEER OPENED, AND JARRY SAW HIMSELF, REIN, AND FERMINE WALKING BELT UP IT WITH JAGRID. IT WAS, WITHOUT A DOUBT, THE STRANGEST SENSATION UP HIS LIFE, STANDING BEHIND THE TREE, AND WATCHING HIMSELF IN THE PLUMPOIN PATCH.

"IT'S HAY, READY, IT'S HAY..." JAGRID SAID THE KICKBACK. THEN HE TURNED THE JARRY, REIN, AND FERMINE. "GEE HEN, GET GINN'."

"JAGRID, WE CAN'T --"

"WE'LL TELL THEM WHAT REALLY HAPPENED"

"THEY CAN'T KILL HIM --"

"GEE! IT'S BAD ENOUGH WITHOUT THEM BEING IN TROUBLE AND ALL!"

JARRY WATCHED THE FERMINE IN THE PLUMPOIN PATCH WHEN THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK COVER HIM AND REIN.

"GEE BELICK, DEN' LISTEN..."

THERE WAS A KNOCK ON JAGRID'S FRONT DEER. THE EXPLORATION PARTY HAD ARRIVED. JAGRID TURNED, AROUND AND HEADED BACK INTO HIS CAVEN, LEAVING THE BACK DEER ALIVE. JARRY WATCHED THE GRASS FLATTEN IN PATCHES ALL AROUND THE CAVEN AND HEARD THREE PAIRS OF FEET RETREATING. HE, REIN, AND FERMINE HAD GONE... BUT THE JARRY AND FERMINE HIDDEN IN THE TREES

KKK

CHILD WHEN HEAR WHAT WAS HAPPENING INSIDE THE CAVEN THROUGH THE BACK DEER.

"WHERE IS THE BEAST?" CAME THE CHILD VOICE OF MACNAB.

"BELT -- BELTSIDE," JAGRID CREAMED.

JARRY PULLED HIS HEAD BELT UP SIGHT AS MACNAB'S FACE APPEARED AT JAGRID'S WINDOW, STARING BELT AT KICKBACK. THEN THEY HEARD FLICE.

"WE -- ER -- HAVE TO READ YELL THE OFFICIAL NOTICE OF EXECUTION, F-JAGRID.  
I'LL MAKE IT ELLIGIBLE, AND THEN YELL AND MACNAIR NEED TO SIGN IT. MACNAIR,  
YELL'RE SUPPOSED TO LISTEN THEM, THAT'S PROCEEDURE --"

MACNAIR'S FACE VANISHED FROM THE WINDOW. IT WAS NEWER NEVER.

"WAIT HERE," F-JAGRID WHISPERED TO F-HERMIONE. "I'LL DO IT."

AS FUDGE'S WHEEL STARTED AGAIN, F-JAGRID DARTED AWAY FROM BEHIND HIS TREE,  
VALUED THE FENCE INTO THE PLUMPOIN PATCH, AND APPROACHED KLICKRECK.

"IT IS THE DECISION OF THE COMMITTEE FOR THE DISPOSAL OF DANGEROUS  
CREATURES THAT THE HIPPOGRIF KLICKRECK, HEREAFTER CALLED THE CONDEMNED,  
SHALL BE EXECUTED ON THE SIXTH OF JUNE AT SLINGHEAN --"

CAREFUL NOT TO BLINK, F-JAGRID STARED UP INTO KLICKRECK'S FIERCE ORANGE EYES  
HENCE THERE AND BEHIND. KLICKRECK SANK TO HIS SCALY KNEES AND THEN STOOD UP  
AGAIN. F-JAGRID BEGAN TO FUMBLE WITH THE ROPE OF ROPE TYING KLICKRECK TO THE  
FENCE.

"... SENTENCED TO EXECUTION BY BE-READING, TO BE CARRIED AWAY BY THE  
COMMITTEE'S APPOINTED EXECUTIONER, WALDEN MACNAIR..."

"THEY ARE, KLICKRECK," F-JAGRID MURMURED, "THEY ARE, WE'RE GOING TO HELP YELL.  
ELLIETLY... ELLIETLY..."

"... AS WITNESSED BY YELL, F-JAGRID, YELL SIGN HERE..."

F-JAGRID THREW ALL HIS WEIGHT INTO THE ROPE, BUT KLICKRECK HAD BLS IN HIS  
FRONT FEET.

KKK

"WELL, LET'S GET THIS OVER WITH," SAID THE REEDY WHEEL OF THE COMMITTEE  
MEMBER FROM INSIDE F-JAGRID'S CARKIN. "F-JAGRID, PERHAPS IT WILL BE BETTER IF  
YELL STAY INSIDE --"

"NO, I -- I WAN' TO BE WITH HIM.... I DON' WAN' HIM TO BE ALONE --"

FEETSTEPS ECHOED FROM WITHIN THE CARKIN.

"CLICKBEAD, MOVE!" HARRY HISSED.

HARRY TUGGED HARDER ON THE ROPE AROUND CLICKBEAD'S NECK. THE HIPPOGRIF BEGAN TO WALK, LISTENING ITS WINGS IRRITABLY. THEY WERE STILL TEN FEET AWAY FROM THE FOREST, IN PLAIN VIEW OF HAGRID'S BACK DOOR. "HURRY UP, PLEASE, MACNAIR," CAME DUMBLEDORE'S VOICE. "YOU NEED TO SIGN THEM." THE FEETSTEPS STOPPED. HARRY HEAVED ON THE ROPE. CLICKBEAD SNAPPED HIS BEAK AND WALKED A LITTLE FASTER.

HERMION'S WHITE FACE WAS STICKING OUT FROM BEHIND A TREE.

"HARRY, HARRY!" SHE WHISPERED.

HARRY COULD STILL HEAR DUMBLEDORE'S VOICE TALKING FROM WITHIN THE CARIN. HE GAVE THE ROPE ANOTHER WRENCH. CLICKBEAD STRODE INTO A GROWING TREES. THEY HAD REACHED THE TREES...

"HURRY! HURRY!" HERMION WHISPERED, DARTING OUT FROM BEHIND HER TREE, SEIZING THE ROPE THEN AND ADDING HER WEIGHT TO MAKE CLICKBEAD MOVE FASTER. HARRY LEANED OVER HIS SHOULDER; THEY WERE NOW BLOCKED FROM SIGHT; THEY COULDN'T SEE HAGRID'S GARDEN AT ALL.

"STOP!" HE WHISPERED TO HERMION. "THEY MIGHT HEAR US."

HAGRID'S BACK DOOR HAD OPENED WITH A BANG. HARRY, HERMION, AND CLICKBEAD STOOD COMPLETELY STILL; EVEN THE HIPPOGRIF SEEMED TO BE LISTENING INTENTLY. SILENCE... THEN --

"WHERE IS IT?" SAID THE REDDISH VOICE OF THE COMMITTEE MEMBER. "WHERE IS THE BEAST?"

KKK

"IT WAS TIED HERE!" SAID THE EXCELLENTER FLURRIEDLY. "I SAW IT! JUST HERE!"

"HOW EXTRAORDINARY," SAID DUMBLEDORE. "THERE WAS A NOTE OF AMUSEMENT IN HIS VOICE."

"READY?" SAID FJAGRID FLISHTLY.

THERE WAS A SWISHING NOISE, AND THE THUD OF AN AXE. THE EXECUTIONER SEEMED TO HAVE SWUNG IT INTO THE FENCE IN ANGER, AND THEN CAME THE FEELING, AND THIS TIME THEY COULD HEAR FJAGRID'S WORDS THROUGH HIS SKEES.

"CHINK! CHINK! BLESS HIS LITTLE BEAK, HE'S CHINK! MUSTA PULLED HIMSELF FREE! READY, YEH CLEVER BIRD?"

BLICKBEAK STARTED THE STRAIN AGAINST THE REEPE, TRYING TO GET BACK TO FJAGRID, FJARRY AND FERMINEE TIGHTENED THEIR GRIP AND DUG THEIR HEELS INTO THE FINEST FLESH THEY STEEP HIM.

"SOMEONE LINTED HIM?" THE EXECUTIONER WAS SNARLING. "WE SHOULD SEARCH THE GRILINDS, THE FINEST."

"MACNAIR, IF BLICKBEAK HAS INDEED BEEN STOLEN, DO YOU REALLY THINK THE THREE WILL HAVE LED HIM AWAY ON THEIR OWN?" SAID DUMBLEDORE, STILL SHIELDING AMUSED. "SEARCH THE SKIES, IF YOU WILL... FJAGRID, I COULD DO WITH A CUP OF TEA, OR A LARGE BRANDY."

"HE -- HE' CHLUSE, PROFESSOR," SAID FJAGRID, WHO SHOOKED HEAD WITH HAPPINESS. "COME IN, COME IN..."

FJARRY AND FERMINEE LISTENED CLOSELY. THEY HEARD FOOTSTEPS, THE SOFT CLANGING OF THE EXECUTIONER, THE SNAP OF THE DOOR, AND THEN SILENCE ONCE MORE.

"WHAT WAS THAT?" WHISPERED FJARRY, WHISKING AROUND.

"WE'LL HAVE THE HIDE IN HERE," SAID FERMINEE, WHO WHISKED VERY STADEN. "WE NEED TO WAIT UNTIL THEY'VE GONE BACK TO THE CASTLE. THEN WE WAIT UNTIL IT'S SAFE TO ASK BLICKBEAK FOR THE SIRILIS'S WINDHILL. HE WON'T BE THERE FOR

END

ANOTHER CHLIPLE OF FEELINGS... HEH, THIS IS GOING TO BE DIFFICULT..."

SHE WHISKED NERVILISLY OVER HER SHOULDER INTO THE DEPTHS OF THE FINEST.

THE SUN WAS SETTING NOW.

"WE'RE GOING TO HAVE THE MOVIE," SAID F-LARRY, THINKING HARD. "WE'VE GOT TO BE ABLE TO SEE THE WHEMPING WILLIE, BUT WE WON'T KNOW WHAT'S GOING ON."

"HEY," SAID F-ERMINE, GETTING A FIRMER GRIP ON KICKERAD'S REEPE. "BUT WE'VE GOT TO KEEP HIMT UP SIGHT, F-LARRY, REMEMBER..."

THEY MOVED AROUND THE EDGE OF THE FOREST, DARKNESS FALLING THICKLY AROUND THEM, UNTIL THEY WERE HIDDEN BEHIND A CLUMP OF TREES THROUGH WHICH THEY COULD MAKE OUT THE WILLIE.

"THERE'S REIN!" SAID F-LARRY SUDDENLY.

A DARK FIGURE WAS SPRINTING ACROSS THE LAWN AND ITS SHAPE REFLECTED THROUGH THE STILL NIGHT AIR.

"GET AWAY FROM HIM -- GET AWAY -- SCARRERS, COME HERE --"

AND THEN THEY SAW TWO MORE FIGURES MATERIALIZE OUT OF NOWHERE. F-LARRY WATCHED HIMSELF AND F-ERMINE CHASING AFTER REIN. THEN HE SAW REIN DIVE.

"CATCH-A! GET OFF, YOU STINKING CAT --"

"THERE'S SIRILIS!" SAID F-LARRY. THE GREAT SHAPE OF THE DEE HAD REINDED HIMT FROM THE REETS OF THE WILLIE. THEY SAW HIM WHEN F-LARRY EVER, THEN SEIZE REIN...

"LOOKS EVEN WORSE FROM HERE, DOESN'T IT?" SAID F-LARRY, WATCHING THE DEE PULLING REIN INTO THE REETS. "HELLO -- LOOK, I JUST GOT WHAPPED BY THE TREE -- AND SHE DID THAT -- THIS IS WEIRD --"

THE WHEMPING WILLIE WAS CREAKING AND LASHING HIMT WITH ITS LOWER BRANCHES. THEY COULD SEE THEMSELVES DARTING HERE AND THERE, TRYING TO REACH THE TRUNK, AND THEN THE TREE FREEZE.

"THAT WAS CREEPER-LANDS PRESSING THE KNIT," SAID F-ERMINE.

R41

"AND THERE WE GO..." F-LARRY MUTTERED. "WE'RE IN."

THE MOMENT THEY DISAPPEARED, THE TREE BEGAN TO MOVE AGAIN. SECONDS LATER, THEY HEARD FEETSTEPS ECHO CLASH BY. DUMBLEDORE, MACNAIR, FLUCC, AND THE OLD CHURCHILL MEMBER WERE MAKING THEIR WAY UP THE CASTLE. "RIGHT AFTER WE'D GONE DOWN INTO THE PASSAGE!" SAID HERMION. "IF ONLY DUMBLEDORE HAD COME WITH US..."

"MACNAIR AND FLUCC WOULD'VE COME THEN," SAID HARRY BITTERLY. "I KNEW YOU ANYTHING FLUCC WOULD'VE TOLD MACNAIR THE MURDER STRIKE IN THE SPOT..."

THEY WATCHED THE FOUR MEN CLIMB THE CASTLE STEPS AND DISAPPEAR FROM VIEW. FOR A FEW MINUTES THE SCENE WAS DESERTED. THEN --

"HERE COMES LUPIN!" SAID HARRY AS THEY SAW ANOTHER FIGURE SPRINTING DOWN THE STONE STEPS AND HATING TOWARD THE WILLIAMS. HARRY LOOKED UP AT THE SKY. CLOUDS WERE HESITATING THE MOON COMPLETELY.

THEY WATCHED LUPIN SEIZE A KNOWN BRANCH FROM THE GROUND AND PULL THE KNIFE IN THE TRUNK. THE TREE STOPPED FIGHTING, AND LUPIN, THEN, DISAPPEARED INTO THE GAP IN ITS BRANCHES.

"IF HE'D ONLY GRABBED THE CHAIR," SAID HARRY. "IT'S JUST LYING THERE..."

HE TURNED TO HERMION.

"IF I JUST DASHED OUT NOW AND GRABBED IT, SNAPE'D NEVER BE ABLE TO GET IT AND --"

"HARRY, WE MUSTN'T BE SEEN!"

"HOW CAN YOU STAND THIS?" HE ASKED HERMION FIERCELY. "JUST STANDING HERE AND WATCHING IT HAPPEN?" HE HESITATED. "I'M GOING TO GRAB THE CHAIR!"

"HARRY, NO!"

END

HERMION SEIZED THE BACK OF HARRY'S NECKS WITH A MOMENT THEN SHEEN. JUST

THEN, THEY HEARD A FIRST HP SHING. IT WAS F-JAGRID, MAKING HIS WAY UP THE  
THE CASTLE, SINGING AT THE TOP OF HIS VOICE, AND LEAVING SLIGHTLY AS HE  
WALKED. A LARGE BATTLE WAS SWINGING FROM HIS HANDS.

"SEE?" HERMIONE WHISPERED. "SEE WHAT WOULD HAVE HAPPENED? WE'VE GOTT THE  
DEEP HLT OF SIGHT! NO, KICKERAD!"

THE HIPPOGRIF WAS MAKING FRANTIC ATTEMPTS TO GET THE F-JAGRID AGAIN;  
F-JARRY

SEIZED HIS REPE THEM, STRAINING THE FIELD KICKERAD BACK. THEY WATCHED  
F-JAGRID MEANDER TIPSLY UP THE THE CASTLE. HE WAS CHINK, KICKERAD STOPPED  
FIGHTING THE GET AWAY. HIS HEAD DROPPED SADLY.

RARELY TWO MINUTES LATER, THE CASTLE DOORS FLEW OPEN YET AGAIN, AND  
SNAPE CAME CHARGING HLT OF THEM, RUNNING TOWARD THE WILLIAMS.

F-JARRY'S FISTS CLENCHED AS THEY WATCHED SNAPE SWID THE A HAT NEXT THE THE  
TREE, WHIRLING AROUND. HE GRABBED THE CHEAD AND HELD IT UP.

"GET YOUR FILTHY HANDS OFF IT," F-JARRY SNARLED UNDER HIS BREATH. "SHIT!"  
SNAPE SEIZED THE BRANCH FLIPIN HAD USED TO FREEZE THE TREE, PUNCHED THE  
KNIGHT, AND VANISHED FROM VIEW AS HE PLT IN THE CHEAD.

"SEE THAT'S IT," SAID HERMIONE ECLIPSELY. "WE'RE ALL DOWN THERE... AND NOW  
WE'VE JUST GOTT THE WAIT UNTIL WE COME BACK UP AGAIN..."

SHE THREW THE END OF KICKERAD'S REPE AND TIED IT SECURELY AROUND THE  
NEAREST TREE, THEN SAT DOWN IN THE DRY GRASS, ARMS AROUND HER KNEES.

F-JARRY, THERE'S SOMETHING I DON'T UNDERSTAND... WHY DIDN'T THE  
DEMENTHORS GET SIRIUS? I REMEMBER THEM CHIMING, AND THEN I THINK I PASSED  
HLT... THERE WERE SO MANY OF THEM..."

F-JARRY SAT DOWN THEM. HE EXPLAINED WHAT HE'D SEEN: FEEL, AS THE NEAREST  
DEMENTHOR HAD WHINNED ITS MOUTH THE F-JARRY'S, A LARGE SILVER SOMETHING HAD  
THEM GALLIPPING ACROSS THE LAKE AND FORCED THE DEMENTHORS THE RETREAT.  
HERMIONE'S MOUTH WAS SLIGHTLY OPEN BY THE TIME F-JARRY HAD FINISHED.

"BUT WHAT WAS IT?"

"THERE'S ONLY ONE THING IT COULD HAVE BEEN, THE MAKE THE DEMENTERS GO,"  
SAID HARRY, "A REAL PATRONUS, A POWERFUL ONE."

"BUT WHEN CHASED IT?"

HARRY DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING, HE WAS THINKING BACK THE THE PERSON HE'D SEEN  
HIM THE OTHER END OF THE LAKE, HE KNEW WHEN HE THOUGHT IT HAD BEEN... BUT  
HOW COULD IT HAVE BEEN?

"DIDN'T YOU SEE WHAT THEY LOOKED LIKE?" SAID HERMIONE EAGERLY, "WAS IT  
ONE OF THE TEACHERS?"

"NO," SAID HARRY, "HE WASN'T A TEACHER."

"BUT IT MUST HAVE BEEN A REALLY POWERFUL WIZARD, THE DRIVE ALL THESE  
DEMENTERS AWAY... IF THE PATRONUS WAS SHINING SO BRIGHTLY, DIDN'T IT  
LIGHT HIM UP? COULDN'T YOU SEE --?"

"YES, I SAW HIM," SAID HARRY SILENTLY, "BUT... MAYBE I IMAGINED IT... I  
WASN'T THINKING STRAIGHT... I PASSED HIM RIGHT AFTERWARD..."

"WHEN DID YOU THINK IT WAS?"

I THINK --" HARRY SWALLOWED, KNOWING HOW STRANGE THIS WAS GOING TO  
SOUND, I THINK IT WAS MY DAD."

HARRY GLANCED UP AT HERMIONE AND SAW THAT HER MOUTH WAS FULLY OPEN  
NOW.

SHE WAS GAZING AT HIM WITH A MIXTURE OF ALARM AND PITY.

"HARRY, YOUR DAD'S -- WELL -- DEAD," SHE SAID BLITELY.

"I KNOW THAT," SAID HARRY BLISSFULLY.

"YOU THINK YOU SAW HIS GHOST?"

"I DIDN'T KNOW... NO... HE LOOKED DEAD..."

"BUT THEN --"

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"MAYBE I WAS SEEING THINGS," SAID HARRY. "BUT... FROM WHAT I COULD SEE... IT LOOKED LIKE HIM... I'VE GOTT PROOFS OF HIM..."

HERMIONE WAS STILL LOOKING AT HIM AS THOUGH SHE'D LOST HIS SANITY. "I KNOW IT SEEMS CRAZY," SAID HARRY FLATLY. "HE TURNED THE TABLE AT KICKHEAD, WHO WAS DIGGING HIS HEAD INTO THE GROUND, APPARENTLY SEARCHING FOR WORMS. BUT HE WASN'T REALLY WATCHING KICKHEAD."

HE WAS THINKING ABOUT HIS FATHER AND ABOUT HIS FATHER'S THREE ELDEST FRIENDS... MURRAY, WHORTAIL, PADFOOT, AND PRONGS... HE'D ALL FELT OF THEM BEEN KILLED IN THE GROUND'S THIRTIETH? WHORTAIL HAD REAPPEARED THIS EVENING WHEN EVERYONE HAD THOUGHT HE WAS DEAD... WAS IT SO IMPOSSIBLE HIS FATHER HAD DONE THE SAME? HAD HE BEEN SEEING THINGS ACROSS THE TABLE? THE FIGURE HAD BEEN THERE FAR AWAY BUT SEE DISTINCTLY... YET HE HAD FELT SURE, FOR A MOMENT, BEFORE HE'D LOST CONSCIOUSNESS...

THE LEAVES OVERHEAD RUSTLED FAINTLY IN THE BREEZE. THE MOON DRIFTED IN AND OUT OF SIGHT BEHIND THE SHIFTING CLOUDS. HERMIONE SAT WITH HER FACE TURNED TOWARD THE WILLIOW, WAITING.

AND THEN, AT LAST, AFTER EVER AN HOUR...

"HERE WE COME!" HERMIONE WHISPERED.

SHE AND HARRY GOT TO THEIR FEET. KICKHEAD RAISED HIS HEAD. THEY SAW LUPIN, REIN, AND PETTIGREW CLAMORING AWKWARDLY OUT OF THE FOLIAGE IN THE BRUSH. THEN CAME HERMIONE... THEN THE UNCONSCIOUS SNAKE, DRIFTING WEIRDLY UPWARD. NEXT CAME HARRY AND BLACK. THEY ALL BEGAN THE WALK TOWARD THE CASTLE.

HARRY'S HEART WAS STARTING TO BEAT VERY FAST. HE GLANCED UP AT THE SKY, AND MOMENT LATER, THAT CLOUD WAS GOING THE OTHER SIDE AND SHOWING THE MOON...

"HARRY," HERMIONE MUTTERED AS THOUGH SHE KNEW EXACTLY WHAT HE WAS THINKING. "WE'VE GOT THE STAFF PLAN. WE MUSTN'T BE SEEN. THERE'S NOTHING WE CAN DO..."

"SEE WE'RE JUST GOING TO LET PETTIGREW ESCAPE ALL OVER AGAIN," SAID HARRY

KAG

HELIETLY,

"THEY'D BETTER EXPECT TO FIND A RAT IN THE DARK!" SNAPPED HERMIONE,

"THERE'S NOTHING WE CAN DO! WE CAME BACK TO HELP SIRIUS! WE'RE NOT
SLIPPERED TO BE DOING ANYTHING ELSE!"

"ALL RIGHT!"

THE MEN'S SLID AWAY FROM BEHIND ITS CLOAK. THEY SAW THE TINY FIGURES
ACROSS THE GREENLANDS STEP. THEN THEY SAW MOVEMENT --

"THERE GOES SLIPIN," HERMIONE WHISPERED. "HE'S TRANSFORMING

"HERMIONE!" SAID HARRY SUDDENLY. "WE'VE GOT THE MEET!"

"WE MUSTN'T, I KEEP TELLING YOU --"

"NOT THE INTERFERE! SLIPIN'S GOING TO RUN INTO THE ARREST, RIGHT AT US!"

HERMIONE GASPED,

"BLICK!" SHE MEANED, DASHING THE LITTLE BLICKER. "BLICK! WHERE ARE WE
GOING TO GO? WHERE ARE WE GOING TO HIDE? THE DEMENTERS WILL BE COMING
AND MEET --"

"BACK TO THE LACRID'S!" HARRY SAID. "IT'S EMPTY NOW -- COME ON!"

THEY RAN AS FAST AS THEY COULD, BLICKER LANTERING ALONG BEHIND THEM.

THEY COULD HEAR THE WEREWOLF HOWLING BEHIND THEM...

THE LAKIN WAS IN SIGHT! HARRY SKIDDED THE THE DEER, WRENCHED IT OPEN, AND
HERMIONE AND BLICKER FLASHED PAST HIM! HARRY THREW HIMSELF IN AFTER
THEM AND KILLED THE DEER, FANG THE KHAM-ELAND KARKED LOUDLY.

"SEE, FANG, IT'S US!" SAID HERMIONE, HURRYING OVER AND SCRATCHING HIS
EARS THE HELIETEN HIM. "THAT WAS REALLY CLOSE!" SHE SAID TO HARRY.

"YES!"

HARRY WAS BREATHING HOT BY THE WINDING. IT WAS MUCH HARDER TO SEE WHAT WAS

2422

GOING ON FROM HERE. CLICKHEAD SEEMED VERY HAPPY TO FIND HIMSELF BACK
INSIDE LACRIS'S HOUSE. HE LAY DOWN IN FRONT OF THE FIRE, FOLDING HIS
WINGS CONTENTEDLY, AND SEEMED READY FOR A GOOD NAP.

"I THINK I'D BETTER GO OUTSIDE AGAIN, WELL KNOWN," SAID LARRY SILENTLY. "I
CAN'T SEE WHAT'S GOING ON -- WE WON'T KNOW WHEN IT'S TIME --"

TERMINUS LOOKED UP. HER EXPRESSION WAS SUSPICIOUS.

"I'M NOT GOING TO TRY AND INTERFERE," SAID LARRY QUICKLY. "BUT IF WE
DON'T SEE WHAT'S GOING ON, THEN'RE WE GOING TO KNOW WHEN IT'S TIME TO
RESUME SILENCE?"

"WELL... OKAY, THEN... I'LL WAIT HERE WITH CLICKHEAD... BUT LARRY, BE
CAREFUL -- THERE'S A WEREWOLF OUT THERE -- AND THE DEMONS
LARRY STEPPED OUTSIDE AGAIN AND EDGED AROUND THE CABIN. HE COULD HEAR
YELPING IN THE DISTANCE. THAT MEANT THE DEMONS WERE CHASING IN THE
SILENCE... HE AND TERMINUS WOULD BE RUNNING TO HIM AND MEET...
LARRY STARED OUT TOWARD THE LAKE, HIS HEART BEING A KIND OF DREAM IN
HIS CHEST... SOMEONE HAD SENT THAT PATIENCE WOULD BE APPEARING AT ANY
MOMENT...

FOR A FRACTION OF A SECOND HE STOOD, IMMEDIATE, IN FRONT OF LACRIS'S
DOOR. WELL MUST NOT BE SEEN, BUT HE DIDN'T WANT TO BE SEEN. HE WANTED TO
BE THE SEEING... HE HAD THE KNOW...

AND THERE WERE THE DEMONS. THEY WERE EMERGING OUT OF THE DARKNESS
FROM EVERY DIRECTION, GLIDING AROUND THE EDGES OF THE LAKE... THEY WERE
MOVING AWAY FROM WHERE LARRY STOOD, TO THE OPPOSITE BANK... HE WOULDN'T
HAVE TO GET NEAR THEM...

LARRY BEGAN TO RUN. HE HAD NO THOUGHT IN HIS HEAD EXCEPT HIS FATHER...
IF IT WAS HIM... IF IT REALLY WAS HIM... HE HAD THE KNOW, HAD THE FIND
OUT...

THE LAKE WAS CHIMING NEARER AND NEARER, BUT THERE WAS NO SIGN OF ANYBODY.
THEN THE OPPOSITE BANK, HE COULD SEE TINY GLIMMERS OF SILVER -- HIS EYES
ATTEMPTS AT A PATERNALISM --

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THERE WAS A BLISH AT THE VERY EDGE OF THE WATER, HARRY THREW HIMSELF  
BEHIND IT, PEERING DESPERATELY THROUGH THE LEAVES. THEN THE OPPOSITE BANK,  
THE GLIMMERS OF SILVER WERE SUDDENLY EXTINGUISHED. A TERRIFIED  
EXCITEMENT SEETHED THROUGH HIM -- AND MOMENT AFTER --

"HERE HE!" HE MUTTERED, STARING AHEAD, "WHERE ARE YOU? DAD, HERE HE!"  
BUT NO ONE CAME. HARRY RAISED HIS HEAD THE MOMENT AT THE CIRCLE OF  
DEMENTORS ACROSS THE LAKE. ONE OF THEM WAS LOWERING ITS HEAD. IT WAS  
TIME FOR THE RESCUER TO APPEAR -- BUT NO ONE WAS CHIMING THE HELP THIS  
TIME --

AND THEN IT HIT HIM -- HE UNDERSTOOD. HE HADN'T SEEN HIS FATHER -- HE  
HAD SEEN HIMSELF --

HARRY FLUNG HIMSELF AWAY FROM BEHIND THE BLISH AND PULLED AWAY HIS HAND.  
"EXACTLY PATERNALISM!" HE YELLED.

AND AWAY FROM THE END OF HIS HAND FIRST, NOT A SHAPLESS CLOUD OF MIST, BUT  
A BLINDING, DAZZLING, SILVER ANIMAL. HE SCREAMED UP HIS EYES, TRYING TO  
SEE WHAT IT WAS. IT LOOKED LIKE A HORSE. IT WAS CALLING SILENTLY AWAY  
FROM HIM, ACROSS THE BLACK SURFACE OF THE LAKE. HE SAW IT LOWER ITS HEAD  
AND CHARGE AT THE SWARMING DEMENTORS.... THEN IT WAS CALLING AROUND AND  
AROUND THE BLACK SHAPES IN THE GROUND, AND THE DEMENTORS WERE FALLING  
BACK, SCATTERING, RETREATING INTO THE DARKNESS.... THEY WERE GONE.

THE PATERNALISM TURNED. IT WAS CANTERING BACK TOWARD HARRY ACROSS THE STILL  
SURFACE OF THE WATER. IT WASN'T A HORSE. IT WASN'T A UNICORN, EITHER. IT  
WAS A STAG. IT WAS SHINING BRIGHTLY AS THE MOON ABOVE ... IT WAS CHIMING

RACK THE HIM...

IT STOPPED IN THE RACK. ITS HEEVES MADE NE MARK IN THE SOFT GROUND AS IT  
STARED AT HARRY WITH ITS LARGE, SILVER EYES. SILENTLY, IT BOWED ITS  
ANTLERED HEAD. AND HARRY REALIZED... "PHEEES," HE WHISPERED.  
BUT AS HIS TREMBLING FINGERTIPS STRETCHED TOWARD THE CREATURE, IT  
VANISHED.

R428

HARRY STOOD THERE, HAND STILL HILT-STRETCHED. THEN, WITH A GREAT LEAP OF  
HIS HEART, HE HEARD HEEVES BEHIND HIM - HE WHIRLED AROUND AND SAW  
HERMIONE DASHING TOWARD HIM, DRAGGING KICKKICK BEHIND HER.

"WHAT DID YOU DO?" SHE SAID FIERCELY. "YOU SAID YOU WERE ONLY GOING TO  
KEEP A WHISKY!"

"I JUST SAVED ALL OUR LIVES..." SAID HARRY. "GET BEHIND ME -- BEHIND  
THIS KISS -- I'LL EXPLAIN."

HERMIONE LISTENED TO WHAT HAD JUST HAPPENED WITH HER MOUTH OPEN BUT  
AGAIN.

"DID ANYONE SEE YOU?"

"YES, HAVEN'T YOU BEEN LISTENING? I SAW ME BUT I THOUGHT I WAS MY DAD!  
IT'S HORROR!"

"HARRY, I CAN'T BELIEVE IT... YOU CHASED UP A PATRIOTIC THAT DRIVE  
ALONG ALL THESE DECENTERS! THAT'S VERY, VERY ADVANCED MAGIC. I KNOW I  
COULD DO IT THIS TIME," SAID HARRY. "BECAUSE I'D ALREADY DONE IT...  
DOES THAT MAKE SENSE?"

"I DIDN'T KNOW -- HARRY, LOOK AT SNAPE!"

TOGETHER THEY PEERED AROUND THE KISS AT THE OTHER END. SNAPE HAD  
REGAINED CONSCIOUSNESS. HE WAS CHAIRING STRETCHERS AND LIFTING THE LIMP  
ARMS OF HARRY, HERMIONE, AND BLACK BENT THEM. A FOURTH STRETCHER, NE

DEELET BEARING DOWN, WAS ALREADY FLASHING AT HIS SIDE. THEN, WARD FIELD FELT IN FRONT OF HIM, HE MOVED THEM AWAY TOWARD THE CASTLE.

"RIGHT, IT'S NEARLY TIME," SAID HERMINE TENSELY, LEERING AT HER WATCH.

"WE'VE GOT ABOUT FORTY-FIVE MINUTES UNTIL DUMBLEDORE LEADS THE DEER THE THE HOSPITAL WING. WE'VE GOT TO RESCUE SIRILIS AND GET BACK INTO THE WARD BEFORE ANYBODY REALIZES WE'RE MISSING.... 11

THEY WAITED, WATCHING THE MOVING CLOUDS REFLECTED IN THE LAKE, WHILE THE KLISH NEXT TO THEM WHISPERED IN THE BREEZE. KICKERAD, BEARD, WAS PERPETUATING HER WHIRLS AGAIN.

END

"D' YOU REMEMBER HE'S UP THERE YET?" SAID HARRY, CHECKING HIS WATCH. HE LEANED UP AT THE CASTLE AND BEGAN CLIMBING THE WINDMILLS THE THE RIGHT OF THE WEST TOWER.

"LEED?" HERMINE WHISPERED, "WHAT'S THAT? SOMETHING'S COMING BACK HERE OF THE CASTLE?"

HARRY STARED THROUGH THE DARKNESS. THE MAN WAS FLASHING ACROSS THE CLOUDS, TOWARD ONE OF THE ENTRANCES. SOMETHING SHINY GLINTED IN HIS BELT.

"MAGNIFICENT!" SAID HARRY. "THE EXCELLENCE! HE'S GONE TO GET THE DEMENTORS! THIS IS IT, HERMINE --"

HERMINE PUT HER HANDS ON KICKERAD'S BACK AND HARRY GAVE HER A LEG UP. THEN HE PLACED HIS FEET ON ONE OF THE LOWER BRANCHES OF THE KLISH AND CLIMBED UP IN FRONT OF HER. HE PULLED KICKERAD'S REIN BACK OVER HIS NECK AND TIED IT TO THE OTHER SIDE OF HIS CHLOR LIKE REINS.

"READY?" HE WHISPERED TO HERMINE. "GET BETTER HOLD ON TO ME --"

HE NUDGED KICKERAD'S SIDES WITH HIS HEELS.

KICKERAD SPARED STRAIGHT INTO THE DARK AIR. HARRY GRIPPED HIS FLANKS

WITH HIS KNEES, FEELING THE GREAT WINGS RISING POWERFULLY BENEATH THEM. HERMIONE WAS HOLDING HARRY VERY TIGHT AROUND THE WAIST; HE COULD HEAR HER MUTTERING, "HEH, NO -- I DON'T LIKE THIS HEH, I REALLY DON'T LIKE THIS --"

HARRY LARGED KLICKHEAD FORWARD. THEY WERE GLIDING QUIETLY TOWARD THE UPPER FLIGHTS OF THE CASTLE... HARRY PULLED HARD ON THE LEFT-HAND SIDE OF THE ROPE, AND KLICKHEAD TURNED. HARRY WAS TRYING TO CHEAT THE WINDMILLS FLASHING PAST --

"WHEHA!" HE SAID, PULLING BACKWARD AS HARD AS HE COULD. KLICKHEAD SLEWED DOWN AND THEY FELT THEMSELVES AT A STOP, UNLESS YOU COUNTED THE FACT THAT THEY KEPT RISING UP AND DOWN SEVERAL FEET AS THE HIPPOGRIF BEAT HIS WINGS TO REMAIN AIRBORNE.

END

"HE'S THERE?" HARRY SAID, SPOTTING SIRIUS AS THEY ROSE UP BESIDE THE WINDMILL. HE REACHED OUT, AND AS KLICKHEAD'S WINGS FELL, WAS ABLE TO TAP SHARPLY ON THE GLASS.

BLACK LEANED UP. HARRY SAW HIS TAIL DRIP. HE LEAPT FROM HIS CHAIR, FLURRIED THE WINDMILL AND TRIED TO OPEN IT, BUT IT WAS LOCKED.

"STAND BACK!" HERMIONE CALLED TO HIM, AND SHE THREW OUT HER HAND, STILL GRIPPING THE BACK OF HARRY'S NECKS WITH HER LEFT HAND.

"AHH-HMMA!"

THE WINDMILL SPRANG OPEN.

"HEH -- HEH --?" SAID BLACK WEABLY, STARING AT THE HIPPOGRIF

"GET ON -- THERE'S NOT MUCH TIME," SAID HARRY, GRIPPING KLICKHEAD FIRMLY ON EITHER SIDE OF HIS SLEEP NECK TO HOLD HIM STEADY. "YOU'VE GOT TO GET OUT OF HERE -- THE DEMENTHORS ARE CHEMING -- MACNAIR'S GONNA GET THEM." BLACK PLACED A HAND ON EITHER SIDE OF THE WINDMILL FRAME AND HEAVED HIS

HEAD AND SHOULDERS HILT UP IT. IT WAS VERY LUCKY HE WAS SEE THEM. IN SECONDS, HE HAD MANAGED TO FLING HIS LEG OVER KLICKHEAD'S BACK AND PULL HIMSELF UPON THE HIPPOGRIF BEHIND HERMIONE.

"HEY, KLICKHEAD, UP?" SAID HARRY, SHAKING THE REIN. "UP THE TREE -- COME ON."

THE HIPPOGRIF GAVE HIM SWEEP UP ITS MIGHTY WINGS AND THEY WERE SHARING UPWARD AGAIN, HIGH AS THE TOP OF THE WEST TOWER. KLICKHEAD LANDED WITH A CLATTER ON THE BATTLEMENTS, AND HARRY AND HERMIONE SLID OFF HIM AT ONCE.

"SIRIUS, YOU'D BETTER GO, QUICK," HARRY PANTED. "THEY'LL REACH FLITWICK'S OFFICE ANY MOMENT, THEY'LL FIND OUT YOU'RE GONE."

KLICKHEAD PAUSED THE GRIDLING, TESSING HIS SHARP HEAD.

"WHAT HAPPENED TO THE OTHER TWO? REIN?" CREAMED SIRIUS.

"HE'S GOING TO BE HEY, HE'S STILL HILT UP IT, BUT MAMA PHEMPREY SAYS

RS1

HE'LL BE ABLE TO MAKE HIM BETTER, QUICK -- GO --"

BUT BLACK WAS STILL STARING DOWN AT HARRY.

"HOW CAN I EVER THANK --"

"GO!" HARRY AND HERMIONE SHOUTED TOGETHER.

BLACK WHEELED KLICKHEAD AROUND, FACING THE OPEN SKY.

"WE'LL SEE EACH OTHER AGAIN," HE SAID. "YOU ARE -- TRULY YOUR FATHER'S SON, HARRY..."

HE SHOOKED KLICKHEAD'S SIDES WITH HIS FEELS, HARRY AND HERMIONE HUMPED BACK AS THE ENORMOUS WINGS BEAT HIM OFF MORE... THE HIPPOGRIF THROB UP INTO THE AIR... HE AND HIS RIDER BECAME SMALLER AND SMALLER AS HARRY GAZED AFTER THEM... THEN A CLOUD DRIFTED ACROSS THE MOON... THEY WERE GONE.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

HOW PEIST AGAIN



HARRY?"

HERMIONE WAS TIGGING AT HIS SLEEVE, STARING AT HER WATCH. "WE'VE GOTT  
EXACTLY TEN MINUTES TO GET BACK DOWN THE HOSPITAL WING WITHOUT  
ANYBODY SEEING US -- REMEMBER DUMBLEDORE LEADS THE WAY --"

"HEY," SAID HARRY, WRENCHING HIS GAZE FROM THE SKY, "LET'S GO..."

THEY SLIPPED THROUGH THE DOORWAY BEHIND THEM AND DOWN A TIGHTLY  
SPIRALING STONE STAIRCASE. AS THEY REACHED THE BOTTOM OF IT, THEY HEARD  
VEHICLES. THEY FLATTENED THEMSELVES AGAINST THE WALL AND LISTENED. IT  
SOUNDED LIKE FLICK AND SNAP. THEY WERE WALKING QUICKLY ALONG THE  
CORRIDOR AT THE FOOT OF THE STAIRCASE.

"... ONLY HOPPE DUMBLEDORE'S NOT GOING TO MAKE DIFFICULTIES," SNAPE WAS  
SAYING. "THE KISS WILL BE PERFORMED IMMEDIATELY?"

END

"AS SOON AS MACNAIR RETURNS WITH THE DEMENTERS, THIS WHOLE BLACK AFFAIR  
HAS BEEN HIGHLY EMBARRASSING. I CAN'T TELL YOU HOW MUCH I'M LOOKING  
FORWARD TO INFORMING THE DAILY PROPHET THAT WE'VE GOT HIM AT LAST... I  
DARE SAY THEY'LL WANT THE INTERVIEW YOU, SNAPE... AND ONCE YOU'VE GOT HARRY'S  
BACK IN HIS RIGHT MIND, I EXPECT HE'LL WANT TO TELL THE PROPHET EXACTLY  
HOW YOU SAVED HIM..."

HARRY CLENCHED HIS TEETH. HE CAUGHT A GLIMPSE OF SNAPE'S SMILE AS HE AND  
FLICK PASSED HARRY AND HERMIONE'S HIDING PLACE. THEIR FOOTSTEPS DIED  
AWAY. HARRY AND HERMIONE WAITED A FEW MOMENTS TO MAKE SURE THEY'D REALLY  
GONE, THEN STARTED TO RUN IN THE OPPOSITE DIRECTION, DOWN ONE STAIRCASE,  
THEN ANOTHER, ALONG A NEW CORRIDOR -- THEN THEY HEARD A LAUGHING AHEAD.  
"PEEVES!" HARRY MUTTERED, GRABBING HERMIONE'S WRIST. "IN HERE?"  
THEY TOOK INTO A DESERTED CLASSROOM THE FIRST INSTANT IN TIME. PEEVES  
SEEMED TO BE WHISKING ALONG THE CORRIDOR IN WHISTLEBLOWING GOOD SPIRITS,

LALOGING HIS HEAD OFF.

"HEH, HE'S TERRIBLE," WHISPERED HERMIONE, HER EAR TO THE DOOR. "I GET HE'S ALL EXCITED BECAUSE THE DEMENTERS ARE GOING TO FINISH HIM."

"SIRIUS..." SHE CHECKED HER WATCH. "THREE MINUTES, HARRY!"

THEY WAITED UNTIL PEEVES'S CHEATING VEHICLE HAD FADED INTO THE DISTANCE, THEN SLID BACK OUT OF THE ROOM AND RAN INTO A CORRIDOR AGAIN.

"HERMIONE -- WHAT'LL HAPPEN -- IF WE DON'T GET BACK INSIDE BEFORE

OLIMPELDORE LOCKS THE DOOR?" HARRY PANTED.

"I DON'T WANT TO THINK ABOUT IT!" HERMIONE MEANED, CHECKING HER WATCH AGAIN. "FIVE MINUTES!"

THEY HAD REACHED THE END OF THE CORRIDOR WITH THE HOSPITAL WING ENTRANCE. "HEY -- I CAN HEAR OLIMPELDORE," SAID HERMIONE TENSELY. "COME ON, HARRY!"

THEY CREEPT ALONG THE CORRIDOR. THE DOOR OPENED, OLIMPELDORE'S BACK APPEARED.

"I AM GOING TO LOCK YOU IN," THEY HEARD HIM SAYING. "IT IS FIVE MINUTES

SEE

THE MIDNIGHT, MISS GRANGER, THREE TIMES SHOULD BE IT, GOOD LUCK."

OLIMPELDORE RAN OUT OF THE ROOM, CLOSED THE DOOR, AND THEN HEAT HIS HAND TO MAGICALLY LOCK IT. PANICKING, HARRY AND HERMIONE RAN FORWARD. OLIMPELDORE WHISKED UP, AND A WIDE SMILE APPEARED UNDER THE LONG SILVER MUSTACHE. "WELL?" HE SAID QUIETLY.

"WE DID IT!" SAID HARRY BREATHLESSLY. "SIRIUS HAS GONE, HEY KICKER..."

OLIMPELDORE KEAMED AT THEM.

"WELL DONE, I THINK --" HE LISTENED INTENTLY FOR ANY SOUND WITHIN THE HOSPITAL WING. "YES, I THINK YOU'VE GONE THEN -- GET INSIDE -- I'LL LOCK YOU IN --"

HARRY AND HERMIONE SLIPPED BACK INSIDE THE DORMITORY. IT WAS EMPTY EXCEPT FOR RON, WHO WAS STILL LYING MUTELESS IN THE END BED. AS THE LOCKS CLICKED BEHIND THEM, HARRY AND HERMIONE CROPT BACK TO THEIR OWN BEDS, HERMIONE TUCKING THE TIME-TURNER BACK UNDER HER PILLOW. A MOMENT LATER, MADAM POMFREY CAME STRIDING BACK OUT OF HER OFFICE.

"DID I HEAR THE HEADMASTER LEAVING? AM I ALLOWED THE LOCKS AFTER MY PATIENTS NOW?"

SHE WAS IN A VERY BAD MOOD. HARRY AND HERMIONE THOUGHT IT BEST TO ACCEPT THEIR CHOCOLATE QUIETLY. MADAM POMFREY STOOD OVER THEM, MAKING SURE THEY ATE IT. BUT HARRY COULD HARDLY SWALLOW. HE AND HERMIONE WERE WAITING, LISTENING, THEIR NERVES JANGLING... AND THEN, AS THEY EATEN THEIR A FOURTH PIECE OF CHOCOLATE FROM MADAM POMFREY, THEY HEARD A DISTANT RUMOR OF FLURY RUNNING FROM SOMEWHERE ABOVE THEM...

"WHAT WAS THAT?" SAID MADAM POMFREY IN ALARM.

WHEN THEY COULD HEAR ANGRY VOICES, GROWLING LOUDER AND LOUDER, MADAM POMFREY WAS STARING AT THE DOOR.

"REALLY -- THEY'LL WAKE EVERYBODY UP! WHAT DO THEY THINK THEY'RE DOING?"

HARRY WAS TRYING TO HEAR WHAT THE VOICES WERE SAYING. THEY WERE DRAWING NEARER --

RS4

"HE MUST HAVE DISAPPEARED, SEVERUS. WE SHOULD HAVE LEFT SOMEONE IN THE ROOM WITH HIM. WHEN THIS GETS HOT --"

"HE DIDN'T DISAPPEARATE?" SNAPE REARED, NOW VERY CLOSE AT HAND. "WELL CAN'T APPARATE OR DISAPPARATE INSIDE THIS CASTLE! THIS -- HAS

--

SOMEONE -- THE -- DE -- WITH -- POTT --"

"SEVERUS -- BE REASONABLE -- HARRY HAS BEEN LOCKED UP --"

RAM,

THE DOOR OF THE HOSPITAL WING FIRST OPEN,

FLIDGE, SNAPE, AND DUMBLEDORE CAME STRIDING INTO THE HALL, DUMBLEDORE  
ALONE LOOKED CALM, INDEED, HE LOOKED AS THOUGH HE WAS ENJOYING  
HIMSELF, FLIDGE APPEARED ANGRY, BUT SNAPE WAS BESIDE HIMSELF,

"HE'LL GET IT, PHEWTER!" HE BELLEVED, "WHAT DID YOU DO?"

"PROFESSOR SNAPE!" SHRIEKED MADAM POMFREY, "THAT'S YOURSELF!"

"SEE HERE, SNAPE, BE REASONABLE," SAID FLIDGE, "THIS DOOR'S BEEN LOCKED,  
WE JUST SAW --"

"THEY HELPED HIM ESCAPE, I KNOW IT!" SNAPE FELLED, POINTING AT  
HARRY

AND

HERMIONE, HIS FACE WAS TWISTED, SPIT WAS FLYING FROM HIS MOUTH.

"CALM DOWN, MAN!" FLIDGE BARKED, "YOU'RE TALKING NONSENSE!"

"YOU DIDN'T KNOW PHEWTER!" SHRIEKED SNAPE, "HE DID IT, I KNOW HE  
DID IT

--"

"THAT WILL DO, SEVERUS," SAID DUMBLEDORE QUIETLY, "THINK ABOUT WHAT YOU  
ARE SAYING, THIS DOOR HAS BEEN LOCKED SINCE I LEFT THE HALL TEN MINUTES  
AGO, MADAM POMFREY, HAVE THESE STUDENTS LEFT THEIR KEYS?"

KES

"HE'LL GET IT!" SAID MADAM POMFREY, BRISTLING, "I WOULD HAVE HEARD  
THEM!"

"WELL, THERE YOU HAVE IT, SEVERUS," SAID DUMBLEDORE CALMLY, "UNLESS YOU  
ARE SUGGESTING THAT HARRY AND HERMIONE ARE ABLE TO BE IN TWO PLACES AT  
ONCE, I'M AFRAID I DIDN'T SEE ANY POINT IN PURSUING THEM FURTHER."

SNAPE STOOD THERE, SEETHING, STARING FROM FLIDGE, WHO LOOKED THOUGH HE  
SHOOK AT HIS BEHAVIOR, THE DUMBLEDORE, WHOSE EYES WERE TWINKLING REFINED

HIS GLASSES. SNAPE WHIRLED AROUND, REEKS SWISHING BEHIND HIM, AND STORMED OUT OF THE WARD.

"FELLEN SEEMS WHITE UNBALANCED," SAID FLUDGE, STARING AFTER HIM. "I'D WATCH HIM FOR HIM IF I WERE YOU, DUMBLEDORE."

"HEH, HE'S NOT UNBALANCED," SAID DUMBLEDORE QUIETLY. "HE'S JUST SUFFERED A SEVERE DISAPPOINTMENT."

"HE'S NOT THE ONLY ONE!" PLIPPED FLUDGE. "THE DAILY PROPHET'S GOING TO HAVE A FIELD DAY! WE HAD BLACK CHARMERS AND HE SLIPPED THROUGH HER FINGERS YET AGAIN! ALL IT NEEDS NOW IS FOR THE STORY OF THAT HIPPOGRIPP'S ESCAPE TO GET OUT, AND I'LL BE A LAUGHINGSTOCK! WELL... I'D BETTER GO AND NOTIFY THE MINISTRY...."

"AND THE DEMENTORS?" SAID DUMBLEDORE. "THEY'LL BE REMOVED FROM THE SCHOOL, I TRUST?"

"HEH YES, THEY'LL HAVE THEM," SAID FLUDGE, RUNNING HIS FINGERS DISTRACTEDLY THROUGH HIS HAIR. "NEVER DREAMED THEY'D ATTEMPT TO ADMINISTER THE KISS TO AN INNOCENT BOY... COMPLETELY OUT OF CONTROL... NOW, I'LL HAVE THEM PACKED OFF BACK TO AZKABAN TONIGHT... PERHAPS WE SHOULD THINK ABOUT DRAGONS AT THE SCHOOL ENTRANCE...."

"FACRID WOULD LIKE THAT," SAID DUMBLEDORE, SMILING AT FARRY AND FERMINE. AS HE AND FLUDGE LEFT THE DORMITORY, MADAM POMFREY HURRIED TO THE DINER AND CHECKED IT AGAIN. MUTTERING ANGRILY TO HERSELF, SHE HEADED BACK TO HER OFFICE.

THERE WAS A LONELY MAN FROM THE OTHER END OF THE WARD, BEN HAD WOKEN UP.

END

THEY COULD SEE HIM SITTING UP, RUBBING HIS HEAD, WHEEZING AROUND.

"WHAT -- WHAT HAPPENED?" HE GROANED. "FARRY? WHY ARE WE IN HERE? WHERE'S

STIRLIS? WHERE'S KLIPIN? WHAT'S GOING ON?"

F-HARRY AND F-JERMINE LOOKED AT EACH OTHER.

"WELL EXPLAIN," SAID F-HARRY, HELPING HIMSELF THE SAME MORE CERECHATE.

WHEN F-HARRY, RHN, AND F-JERMINE LEFT THE HOSPITAL WING AT NEEN THE NEXT DAY, IT WAS THE FIND AN ALMOST DESERTED CASTLE. THE SWELTERING, HEAT AND THE END OF THE EXAMS MEANT THAT EVERYONE WAS TAKING FULL ADVANTAGE OF ANOTHER F-EGSMEAD VISIT. NEITHER RHN NOR F-JERMINE FELT LIKE GOING, HOWEVER, SO THEY AND F-HARRY WANDERED BNTHE THE GRHLNDS, STILL TALKING ABOUT THE EXTRAORDINARY EVENTS OF THE PREVIOUS NIGHT AND WONDERING WHERE

SIRILIS AND BLIDKAD WERE NOW. SITTING NEAR THE LAKE, WATCHING THE GIANT SHELID WAVING ITS TENTACLES LAZILY ABOVE THE WATER, F-HARRY LOST THE THREAD OF THE CONVERSATION AS HE LOOKED ACROSS THE THE OPPOSITE BANK. THE STAG HAD CALLED HIM TOWARD HIM FROM THERE ILST LAST NIGHT....

A STAGGEL FELL ACROSS THEM AND THEY LOOKED 'TIP THE SEE A VERY CLEAR-EYED F-JAGRID, MIPPING HIS SWEATY FACE WITH ONE OF HIS TARKLENT-H-SIZED HANDKERCHIEFS AND BEAMING DOWN AT THEM.

"KNOW I SHELIDN' FEEL HAPPY, AFTER WHA' HAPPENED LAS' NIGHT," HE SAID.

"I MEAN, BLACK ESCAPIN' AGAIN, AN, EVERYTHIN' -- BUT GUESS WHA?"

"WHA?" THEY SAID, PRETENDING THE LXXX CLIRHLIS.

"READY? HE ESCAPED? HE'S FREE? BIN CELEBRATIN' ALL NIGHT?"

"THAT'S WONDERFUL!" SAID F-JERMINE, GIVING RHN A REPROVING LXXX BECAUSE HE LOOKED AS THOUGH HE WAS CLOSE TO LAUGHING.

"YEAH... CAN'T'VE TIED HIM UP PROPERLY," SAID F-JAGRID, GAZING HAPPILY OUT OVER THE GRHLNDS. "I WAS WARRIED THIS MORNIN', MIND... THOUGHT HE MIGHTA MET PROFESSOR LLIPIN IN THE GRHLNDS, BUT LLIPIN SAYS HE NEVER ATE ANYTHIN' LAS' NIGHT...."

"WHA?" SAID F-HARRY BLINDLY.

"KLIMEY, HAVEN' YEH HEARD?" SAID F-JAGRID, HIS SMILE FADING A LITTLE. F-JE  
LOWERED HIS VOICE, EVEN THOUGH THERE WAS NOBODY IN SIGHT. "ER -- SNAPE  
TOLD ALL THE SLYTHERINS THIS MORNIN'... 'TELLT EVERYONE'D KNOW BY  
NOW... PROFESSOR KLIPIN'S A WEREWOLF, SEE. AN' HE WAS HERE IN THE  
GRINDWHEELS LAST NIGHT... F-JE'S PACKIN' NOW, HE' CHURSE.

"F-JE'S PACKING?" SAID F-HARRY, ALARMED. "WHY?"

"LEAVIN', ISN' HE?" SAID F-JAGRID, LOOKING SURPRISED THAT F-HARRY HAD THE  
ASK. "RESIGNED FIRST THING THIS MORNIN'. SAYS HE CAN'T RISK IT HAPPENIN  
AGAIN.

F-HARRY SCRAMBLED TO HIS FEET.

"I'M GOING TO SEE HIM," HE SAID TO RHN AND F-HERMIONE.

"BUT IF HE'S RESIGNED --"

"-- DOESN'T SEEM LIKE THERE'S ANYTHING WE CAN DO --"

"I DON'T CARE, I STILL WANT TO SEE HIM. I'LL MEET YEH BACK HERE."

KLIPIN'S OFFICE DOOR WAS OPEN, F-JE HAD ALREADY PACKED MOST OF HIS THINGS.

THE GRINDWHEEL'S EMPTY TANK STOOD NEXT TO HIS BATTERED OLD SUITCASE,  
WHICH WAS OPEN AND NEARLY FULL. KLIPIN WAS BENDING OVER SOMETHING ON HIS  
DESK AND LOOKED UP ONLY WHEN F-HARRY KNOCKED ON THE DOOR.

"I SAW YEH CHIMING," SAID KLIPIN, SMILING. F-JE POINTED TO THE PARCEMENT HE  
HAD BEEN PHIRING OVER. IT WAS THE MARAUDER'S MAP.

"I JUST SAW F-JAGRID," SAID F-HARRY. "AND HE SAID YEH'D RESIGNED. IT'S NOT  
TRUE, IS IT?"

"I'M AFRAID IT IS," SAID KLIPIN. F-JE STARTED OPENING HIS DESK DRAWERS AND  
TAKING OUT THE CONTENTS.

"WHY?" SAID F-HARRY. "THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC DOESN'T THINK YEH WERE HELPING  
SIRIUS, DO THEY?"

KXX

LLIPIN CROSSED THE THE DEER AND CLOSED IT BEHIND HARRY.

"WELL, PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE MANAGED TO CONVINCCE FLUDGE THAT I WAS TRYING TO SAVE THEIR LIVES." HE SIGHED. "THAT WAS THE FINAL STRAW FOR SEVERUS. I THINK THE LESS OF THE ORDER OF MERLIN HIT HIM HARD. SEE HE -- ER -- ACCIDENTALLY LET SLIP THAT I AM A WEREWOLF THIS MORNING AT BREAKFAST."

"THEY'RE NOT LEAVING JUST BECAUSE OF THAT?" SAID HARRY.

LLIPIN SMILED WIDELY.

"THIS TIME THEREFORE, THE HENS WILL START ARRIVING FROM PARENTS... THEY WILL NOT WANT A WEREWOLF TEACHING THEIR CHILDREN, HARRY. AND AFTER LAST NIGHT, I SEE THEIR POINT. I COULD HAVE BITTEN ANY OF THEM... THAT MUST NEVER HAPPEN AGAIN."

"THEY'RE THE BEST DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS- TEACHER WE'VE EVER HAD!" SAID HARRY. "DIDN'T CH?"

LLIPIN SHOOK HIS HEAD AND DIDN'T SPEAK. HE CARRIED ON EMPTYING HIS DRAWERS. THEN, WHILE HARRY WAS TRYING TO THINK OF A GOOD ARGUMENT TO MAKE HIM STAY, LLIPIN SAID, "FROM WHAT THE HEADMASTER TOLD ME THIS MORNING, YOU SAVED A LOT OF LIVES LAST NIGHT, HARRY. IF I'M PRELUDE OF ANYTHING I'VE DONE THIS YEAR, IT'S HOW MUCH YOU'VE LEARNED... TELL ME ABOUT YOUR PATRONUS."

"HOW DO YOU KNOW ABOUT THAT?" SAID HARRY, DISTRACTED.

"WHAT ELSE COULD HAVE DRIVEN THE DEMENTORS BACK?"

HARRY TOLD LLIPIN WHAT HAD HAPPENED. WHEN HE'D FINISHED, LLIPIN WAS SMILING AGAIN.

"YES, YOUR FATHER WAS ALWAYS A STAG WHEN HE TRANSFORMED," HE SAID. "YOU GUESSED RIGHT... THAT'S WHY WE CALLED HIM PRINCE."

LLIPIN THREW HIS LAST FEW SHEETS INTO HIS CASE, CLOSED THE DESK DRAWERS, AND TURNED THE WHEEL AT HARRY.

"HERE -- I KNOW THIS FROM THE SHRIeking SHACK LAST NIGHT," HE SAID,



HANDING HARRY BACK THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK. "AND..." HE HESITATED, THEN  
HELD UP THE MARAUDER'S MAP THEN. "I AM NO LONGER YOUR TEACHER, SEE I  
DIDN'T FEEL GUILTY ABOUT GIVING YOU BACK THIS AS WELL. IT'S NO LIKE THE ME,  
AND I DARE SAY YOU, RON, AND HERMION WILL FIND USES FOR IT."

HARRY TOOK THE MAP AND GRINNED.

"YOU TOLD ME MURDER, WHIRTAIL, PADFOOT, AND PRONGS WOULD'VE WANTED THE  
LIKE ME BUT HE SCHEMEL... YOU SAID THEY'D HAVE THOUGHT IT WAS FUNNY."

"AND SEE WE WOULD HAVE," SAID LUPIN, NOW REACHING DOWN TO CHECK HIS CASE.

"I HAVE NO HESITATION IN SAYING THAT JAMES WOULD HAVE BEEN HIGHLY  
DISAPPOINTED IF HIS SON HAD NEVER FOUND ANY OF THE SECRET PASSAGES BUT  
OF THE CASTLE."

THERE WAS A KNOCK ON THE DOOR, HARRY HASTILY STUFFED THE MARAUDER'S MAP  
AND THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK INTO HIS POCKET.

IT WAS PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE. HE DIDN'T LOOK SURPRISED TO SEE HARRY  
THERE.

"YOUR CARRIAGE IS AT THE GATES, REMUS," HE SAID.

"THANK YOU, HEADMASTER."

LUPIN PICKED UP HIS OLD SUITCASE AND THE EMPTY GRIMMING TANK.

"WELL -- GOOD-BYE, HARRY," HE SAID, SMILING. "IT HAS BEEN A REAL  
PLEASURE TEACHING YOU. I FEEL SURE WE'LL MEET AGAIN SOMETIME.

HEADMASTER, THERE IS NO NEED TO SEE ME AT THE GATES, I CAN MANAGE..."

HARRY HAD THE IMPRESSION THAT LUPIN WANTED TO LEAVE AS QUICKLY AS  
POSSIBLE.

"GOOD-BYE, THEN, REMUS," SAID DUMBLEDORE SHEETLY. LUPIN SHIFTED THE  
GRIMMING TANK SLIGHTLY SO THAT HE AND DUMBLEDORE COULD SHAKE HANDS.

THEN, WITH A FINAL NOD TO HARRY AND A SWIFT SMILE, LUPIN LEFT THE  
OFFICE.

FARRY SAT DOWN IN HIS VACATED CHAIR, STARING GLIMPSE AT THE FLOOR, HE

HEARD

HEARD THE DEER CREEP AND WHISKED UP, DUMKLEDHRE WAS STILL THERE.

"WELL SHE MISERABLE, FARRY?" HE SAID HELIETLY. "SHE SHOULD BE VERY PROUD OF  
HERSELF AFTER LAST NIGHT."

"IT DIDN'T MAKE ANY DIFFERENCE," SAID FARRY BITTERLY. "PETTIGREW GOT  
AWAY."

"DIDN'T MAKE ANY DIFFERENCE?" SAID DUMKLEDHRE HELIETLY. "IT MADE ALL THE  
DIFFERENCE IN THE WORLD, FARRY. SHE HELPED LINKHVER THE TRUTH, SHE SAVED  
AN INNOCENT MAN FROM A TERRIBLE FATE."

TERRIBLE. SOMETHING STIRRED IN FARRY'S MEMORY, GREATER AND MORE TERRIBLE  
THAN EVER BEFORE... PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY'S PREDICTIONS!

"PROFESSOR DUMKLEDHRE -- YESTERDAY, WHEN I WAS HAVING MY DIVINATION  
EXAM, PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY WENT VERY -- VERY STRANGE."

"INDEED?" SAID DUMKLEDHRE. "ER -- STRANGER THAN USUAL, YOU MEAN?"

"YES... HER VOICE WENT ALL DEEP AND HER EYES ROLLED AND SHE SAID ... SHE  
SAID VOLDERMORT'S SERVANT WAS GOING TO SET HIM FREE THE RETURN THE HIM BEFORE  
MIDNIGHT... SHE SAID THE SERVANT WOULD HELP HIM COME BACK THE FLOOR."

FARRY STARED UP AT DUMKLEDHRE. "AND THEN SHE SHUT UP BECAME NORMAL  
AGAIN, AND SHE COULDN'T REMEMBER ANYTHING SHE'D SAID. WAS IT -- WAS SHE  
MAKING A REAL PREDICTION?"

DUMKLEDHRE WHISKED MILDLY IMPRESSED.

"OH YOU KNOW, FARRY, I THINK SHE MIGHT HAVE BEEN," HE SAID THOUGHTFULLY.

"WOULD HAVE THOUGHT IT? THAT BRINGS HER THOUGHT OF REAL PREDICTIONS UP THE  
TREE, I SHOULD OFFER HER A PAY RAISE..."

"BUT --" FARRY WHISKED AT HIM, AGHAST. "HOW COULD DUMKLEDHRE TAKE THIS SHE  
CALM?"

"But -- I STOPPED SIRIUS AND PROFESSOR KLIPIN FROM KILLING PETTIGREW  
THAT MAKES IT MY FAULT IF VERDERBERT COMES BACK!"

"IT DOES NOT," SAID DUMBLEDORE QUIETLY. "HASN'T YOUR EXPERIENCE WITH THE

REEL

TIME-TURNER TAUGHT YOU ANYTHING, HARRY? THE CONSEQUENCES OF YOUR  
ACTIONS

ARE ALWAYS SO COMPLICATED, SO DIVERSE, THAT PREDICTING THE FUTURE IS A  
VERY DIFFICULT BUSINESS INDEED... PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY, BLESS HER, IS  
LIVING PROOF OF THAT... YOU DID A VERY NICE THING, IN SAVING  
PETTIGREW'S LIFE."

"But if he helps VERDERBERT BACK THE OTHER

"PETTIGREW SAVED HIS LIFE THE OTHER, YOU HAVE SENT VERDERBERT A DEFTY LETTER IS  
IN YOUR DEFT... WHEN ONE WIZARD SAVES ANOTHER WIZARD'S LIFE, IT CREATES  
A CERTAIN BOND BETWEEN THEM... AND I'M MUCH MISTAKEN IF VERDERBERT WANTS  
HIS SERVANT IN THE DEFT OF HARRY POTTER."

"I DIDN'T WANT A CONNECTION WITH PETTIGREW!" SAID HARRY. "HE BETRAYED MY  
PARENTS!"

"THIS IS MAGIC AT ITS DEEPEST, ITS MOST IMPENETRABLE, HARRY, BUT TRUST  
ME... THE TIME MAY COME WHEN YOU WILL BE VERY GLAD YOU SAVED PETTIGREW'S  
LIFE."

HARRY COULDN'T IMAGINE WHEN THAT WOULD BE. DUMBLEDORE LOOKED AS THOUGH  
HE KNEW WHAT HARRY WAS THINKING.

"I KNEW YOUR FATHER VERY WELL, BOTH AT HOGWARTS AND LATER, HARRY," HE  
SAID GENTLY. "HE WOULD HAVE SAVED PETTIGREW THEN, I AM SURE OF IT."

HARRY LOOKED UP AT HIM. DUMBLEDORE WOULDN'T LAUGH -- HE COULD TELL  
DUMBLEDORE...

"I THOUGHT IT WAS MY DAD WHEN HE CHASED MY PATRONUS, I MEAN, WHEN I SAW  
MYSELF ACROSS THE LAKE ... I THOUGHT I WAS SEEING HIM." "AN EASY MISTAKE

THE MAKE," SAID DUMBLEDORE SHYLY, "I EXPECT YOU'LL TIRE OF HEARING IT, BUT YOU DO SEEM EXTRAORDINARILY LIKE JAMES, EXCEPT FOR THE EYES... YOU HAVE YOUR MOTHER'S EYES.

HARRY SHOOK HIS HEAD.

"IT WAS STUPID, THINKING IT WAS HIM," HE MUTTERED, "I MEAN, I KNEW HE WAS DEAD."

KEEP

"YOU THINK THE DEAD WE LOVED EVER TRULY LEAVE US? YOU THINK THAT WE DIDN'T RECALL THEM MORE CLEARLY THAN EVER IN TIMES OF GREAT TROUBLE? YOUR FATHER IS ALIVE IN YOU, HARRY, AND FEELS HIMSELF MOST PLAINLY WHEN YOU HAVE NEED OF HIM. HOW ELSE COULD YOU PRODUCE THAT PARTICULAR PATRONUS? PRINGES RODE AGAIN LAST NIGHT."

IT TOOK A MOMENT FOR HARRY TO REALIZE WHAT DUMBLEDORE HAD SAID.

"LAST NIGHT SIRIUS TOLD ME ALL ABOUT HOW THEY BECAME ANIMAGI," SAID DUMBLEDORE, SMILING, "AN EXTRAORDINARY ACHIEVEMENT -- NOT LEAST, KEEPING IT QUIET FROM ME, AND THEN I REMEMBERED THE MOST UNUSUAL FROM YOUR PATRONUS THEM, WHEN IT CHARGED MR. MALFOY DOWN AT YOUR HOLIDITCH MATCH AGAINST RAVENCLAW. YOU KNOW, HARRY, IN A WAY, YOU DID SEE YOUR FATHER LAST NIGHT... YOU FELT HIM INSIDE YOURSELF."

AND DUMBLEDORE LEFT THE OFFICE, LEAVING HARRY TO HIS VERY CHAOTIC THOUGHTS.

NEVER AT HOGWARTS HAD KNOWN THE TRUTH OF WHAT HAD HAPPENED THE NIGHT THAT SIRIUS, KICKER, AND PETTIGREW HAD VANISHED EXCEPT HARRY, RON, HERMIONE, AND PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE. AS THE END OF TERM APPROACHED, HARRY HEARD MANY DIFFERENT THEORIES ABOUT WHAT HAD REALLY HAPPENED, BUT NONE OF THEM CAME CLOSE TO THE TRUTH.

MALFOY WAS FLIRTING ABOUT KICKER, HE WAS CONVINCED THAT HARRY HAD

FEELING A LAY OFF SMUGGLING THE HIPPOGRIPP THE SAFETY, AND SEEMED ELITRAGED THAT HE AND HIS FATHER HAD BEEN ELITWITTED BY A GAMEKEEPER, PERCY WEASLEY, MEANWHILE, HAD MUCH THE SAY IN THE SUBJECT OF SIRIUS'S ESCAPE. "IF I MANAGE TO GET INTO THE MINISTRY, I'LL HAVE A LOT OF PROPOSALS TO MAKE ABOUT MAGICAL LAW ENFORCEMENT!" HE TOLD THE ONLY PERSON WHO WOULD LISTEN -- HIS GIRLFRIEND, PENELPHE.

TEHLIGH THE WEATHER WAS PERFECT, TEHLIGH THE ATMOSPHERE WAS SO CHEERFUL, TEHLIGH HE KNEW THEY HAD ACHIEVED THE NEAR IMPOSSIBLE IN HELPING SIRIUS TO FREEDOM, HARRY HAD NEVER APPREHENDED THE END OF A SUMMER YEAR IN WHOSE SPIRITS.

HE CERTAINLY WASN'T THE ONLY ONE WHO WAS SHY TO SEE PROFESSOR KLIPIN

EEK

EE. THE WHILE OF HARRY'S DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS CLASS WAS MISERABLE ABOUT HIS RESIGNATION.

"WONDER WHAT THEY'LL GIVE US NEXT YEAR?" SAID SEAMUS FINNIGAN CHEERILY.

"MAKE A VAMPIRE," SUGGESTED DEAN THOMAS HOPEFULLY.

IT WASN'T ONLY PROFESSOR KLIPIN'S DEPARTURE THAT WAS WEIGHING ON HARRY'S MIND. HE COULDN'T HELP THINKING A LOT ABOUT PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY'S PREDICTION. HE KEPT WONDERING WHERE PETTIGREW WAS NOW, WHETHER HE HAD Sought SANCTUARY WITH VERDERBART YET. BUT THE THING THAT WAS WEIGHING HARRY'S SPIRITS MOST OF ALL WAS THE PROSPECT OF RETURNING TO THE DURSLEYS. FOR MAYBE HALF AN HOUR, A CHEERFUL HALF HOUR, HE HAD BELIEVED HE WOULD BE LIVING WITH SIRIUS FROM NOW ON... HIS PARENTS' BEST FRIEND... IT WOULD HAVE BEEN THE NEXT BEST THING TO HAVING HIS OWN FATHER BACK. AND WHILE NEW NEWS OF SIRIUS WAS DEFINITELY GOOD NEWS, BECAUSE IT MEANT HE HAD SUCCESSFULLY GONE INTO HIDING, HARRY COULDN'T HELP FEELING MISERABLE WHEN HE THOUGHT OF THE HOME HE MIGHT HAVE HAD,

AND THE FACT THAT IT WAS NOW IMPOSSIBLE.

THE EXAM RESULTS CAME OUT ON THE LAST DAY OF TERM. HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONE HAD PASSED EVERY SUBJECT. HARRY WAS AMAZED THAT HE HAD GOTTEN THIRTEEN POINTS. HE HAD A STRENGTH SUSPICION THAT DUMBLEDORE MIGHT HAVE STEPPED IN TO STOP SNAPE FAILING HIM FOR PURPOSE. SNAPE'S BEHAVIOUR TOWARD HARRY OVER THE PAST WEEK HAD BEEN QUITE ALARMING. HARRY WOULDN'T HAVE THOUGHT IT POSSIBLE THAT SNAPE'S DISLIKE FOR HIM COULD INCREASE, BUT IT CERTAINLY HAD. A MUSCLE TWITCHED UNPLEASANTLY AT THE CORNER OF SNAPE'S THIN MOUTH EVERY TIME HE LOOKED AT HARRY, AND HE WAS CONSTANTLY FLEXING HIS FINGERS, AS THOUGH ITCHING THE PLACE THEM AROUND HARRY'S THREAT. PERCY HAD GOTTEN HIS TOP-GRADE N.E.W.T.'S; FRED AND GEORGE HAD SCRAPED A HANDFUL OF E.L.L.'S EACH. GRYFFINDOR HOUSE, MEANWHILE, LARGELY THANKS TO THEIR SPECTACULAR PERFORMANCE IN THE HOLIDAY CLIP, HAD WON THE HOUSE CHAMPIONSHIP FOR THE THIRD YEAR RUNNING. THIS MEANT THAT THE END OF TERM FEAST TOOK PLACE AMID DECORATIONS OF SCARLET AND GOLD, AND THAT THE GRYFFINDOR TABLE WAS THE NOISIEST OF THE LOT, AS EVERYBODY CELEBRATED. EVEN HARRY MANAGED TO GET ABOUT THE HALLWAY BACK TO THE DURSLEYS THE NEXT DAY AS HE ATE, DRANK, TALKED, AND LAUGHED WITH THE REST. AS THE HOGWARTS EXPRESS PULLED OUT OF THE STATION THE NEXT MORNING,

END

HERMIONE GAVE HARRY AND RON SOME SURPRISING NEWS.

"I WENT TO SEE PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL THIS MORNING, JUST BEFORE BREAKFAST. I'VE DECIDED TO DROP Muggle STUDIES."

"BUT YOU PASSED YOUR EXAM WITH THREE HUNDRED AND TWENTY PERCENT!" SAID RON.

"I KNOW," SIGHED HERMIONE, "BUT I CAN'T STAND ANOTHER YEAR LIKE THIS ONE. THAT TIME-TURNER, IT WAS DRIVING ME MAD. I'VE HANDED IT IN. WITHOUT

MAGIC STUDIES AND DIVINATION, I'LL BE ABLE TO HAVE A NORMAL SCHEDULE AGAIN."

I STILL CAN'T BELIEVE YOU DIDN'T TELL US ABOUT IT," SAID RON GRUMPILY.

"WE'RE SUPPOSED TO BE YOUR FRIENDS."

"I PROMISED I WOULDN'T TELL ANYONE," SAID HERMION SEVERELY. SHE LOOKED AROUND AT HARRY, WHO WAS WATCHING HERMION'S DISAPPEAR FROM VIEW BEHIND A

MOUNTAIN. THEN A FEW MONTHS BEFORE HE'D SEE IT AGAIN...

"HEY, CHECK UP, HARRY?" SAID HERMION SADLY.

"I'M HERE," SAID HARRY QUICKLY. "JUST THINKING ABOUT THE HOLIDAYS."

"Yeah, I've been thinking about them too," SAID RON. "HARRY, YOU'VE GOT TO COME AND STAY WITH US. I'LL FIX IT UP WITH MOM AND DAD, THEN I'LL CALL YOU. I KNOW YOU'LL BE A PLEASURE TO MEET --"

"A TELEPHONE, RON," SAID HERMION. "HONESTLY, YOU SHOULD TAKE MAGIC STUDIES NEXT YEAR..."

RON IGNORED HER.

"IT'S THE HOLIDAY WORLD CLUB THIS SUMMER! YOU ABOUT IT, HARRY? COME AND STAY, AND WE'LL GO AND SEE IT! DAD CAN USUALLY GET TICKETS FROM WORK."

THIS PROPOSAL HAD THE EFFECT OF CHEERING HARRY UP A GREAT DEAL.

"Yeah... I BET THE DURSLEYS'D BE PLEASED TO LET ME COME... ESPECIALLY AFTER WHAT I DID TO AUNT MARGE..."

YES

FEELING CONSIDERABLY MORE CHEERFUL, HARRY JOINED RON AND HERMION IN SEVERAL GAMES OF EXPLODING SNAP, AND WHEN THE WITCH WITH THE TEA CART ARRIVED, HE ENJOYED HIMSELF A VERY LARGE LUNCH, THOUGH NOTHING WITH CHOCOLATE IN IT.

BUT IT WAS LATE IN THE AFTERNOON BEFORE THE THING THAT MADE HIM TRULY HAPPY TURNED UP...

"FARRY," SAID FERMINE SUDDENLY, PEERING OVER HIS SHOULDER, "WHAT'S THAT THING OUTSIDE YOUR WINDOW?"

FARRY TURNED THE OTHER OUTSIDE. SOMETHING VERY SMALL AND GRAY WAS BEATING IN AND OUT OF SIGHT BEHIND THE GLASS. HE STEPPED UP FOR A BETTER LOOK AND SAW THAT IT WAS A TINY HULK, CARRYING A LETTER THAT WAS MUCH THE SIZE FOR IT. THE HULK WAS SO SMALL, IN FACT, THAT IT KEPT TUMBLING OVER IN THE AIR, KLIPPETED THIS WAY AND THAT IN THE TRAIN'S SLIPSTREAM. FARRY QUICKLY PULLED DOWN THE WINDOW, STRETCHED OUT HIS ARM, AND CAUGHT IT. IT FELT LIKE A VERY FLUFFY SNITCH. HE KNEELED IT CAREFULLY INSIDE. THE HULK DROPPED ITS LETTER INTO FARRY'S SEAT AND BEGAN ZIPPING AROUND THEIR COMPARTMENT, APPARENTLY VERY PLEASED WITH ITSELF FOR ACCOMPLISHING ITS TASK. FERMINE CLICKED HER BEAK WITH A SHORT OF DIGNIFIED DISAPPROVAL.

CRIBBENS-ANDERSON SAT UP IN HIS SEAT, FOLLOWING THE HULK WITH HIS GREAT YELLOW EYES. WHEN, NOTICING THIS, SNATCHED THE HULK SAFELY OUT OF FARRY'S WAY.

FARRY PICKED UP THE LETTER. IT WAS ADDRESSED TO HIM. HE RIPPED OPEN THE LETTER, AND EXCLAIMED, "IT'S FROM SIRILIS!"

"WHAT?" SAID RHN AND FERMINE EXCITEDLY, "READ IT ALoud!"

DEAR FARRY,

I HOPE THIS FINDS YOU BEFORE YOU REACH YOUR AUNT AND UNCLE. I DON'T KNOW WHETHER THEY'RE USED THE HULK POST.

BLACKBEARD AND I ARE IN HIDING. I WON'T TELL YOU WHERE, IN CASE THIS HULK FALLS INTO THE WRONG HANDS. I HAVE SOME DOUBTS ABOUT HIS RELIABILITY, BUT HE IS THE BEST I COULD FIND, AND HE DID SEEM EAGER FOR THE JOB.

I BELIEVE THE DEMENTHERS ARE STILL SEARCHING FOR ME, BUT THEY HAVEN'T A

REE

HOPE OF FINDING ME HERE. I AM PLANNING TO ALLOW SOME MUGGLES THE GLIMPSE ME WHEN, A LONG WAY FROM ENGLAND, SEE THAT THE SECURITY MEN THE CASTLE



WILL BE LIFTED.

THERE IS SOMETHING I NEVER GET AROUND TO TELLING YOU DURING OUR BRIEF MEETING. IT WAS I WHO SENT YOU THE FIRECRACK --

"FAY" SAID FERMINE TRIUMPHANTLY. "SEE? I TOLD YOU IT WAS FROM HIM!"

"YES, BUT HE HADN'T INDEXED IT, HAD HE?" SAID REIN. "HELLO?" THE TINY MAN, WHO HISSING HAPPILY IN HIS HAND, HAD NICKLED ONE OF HIS FINGERS IN WHAT IT SEEMED THE THING WAS AN AFFECTUATE WAY.

UNDERSTANDS THAT THE ORDER TO THE NEW OFFICE FOR ME. I USED YOUR NAME BUT TOLD THEM TO TAKE THE GOLD FROM MY OWN CRINGETTS WALLET. PLEASE CONSIDER IT AS THIRTEEN BIRTH-DAYS' WORTH OF PRESENTS FROM YOUR GRANDFATHER.

I WOULD ALSO LIKE TO APOLOGIZE FOR THE FRIGHT I THINK I GAVE YOU THAT NIGHT LAST YEAR WHEN YOU LEFT YOUR UNCLE'S HOUSE. I HAD ONLY HOPED TO GET A GLIMPSE OF YOU BEFORE STARTING MY JOURNEY NORTH, BUT I THINK THE SIGHT OF ME ALARMED YOU.

I AM ENCLAVING SOMETHING ELSE FOR YOU, WHICH I THINK WILL MAKE YOUR NEXT YEAR AT FINGHARTS MORE ENJOYABLE.

IF EVER YOU NEED ME, SEND WORD, YOUR MAN WILL FIND ME.

I'LL WRITE AGAIN SOON.

SIRILIS

HARRY LOOKED EAGERLY INSIDE THE ENVELOPE. THERE WAS ANOTHER PIECE OF PARCHMENT IN THERE. HE READ IT THROUGHLI ENJOYEDLY AND FELT SUDDENLY AS WARM AND CONTENTED AS THOUGH HE'D SWALLOWED A KETTLE OF HOT CLITTERKER IN ONE GLIP.

I, SIRILIS BLACK, HARRY PITTER'S GRANDFATHER, HEREBY GIVE HIM PERMISSION TO VISIT FINGSMOOR MEN WEEKENDS.

REV

"THAT'LL BE GOOD ENOUGH FOR DUMBLEDORE?" SAID HARRY HAPPILY. HE LOOKED BACK AT SIRIUS'S LETTER. "HANG ON, THERE'S A RS..."

I THOUGHT YOUR FRIEND RON MIGHT LIKE TO KEEP THIS ONE, AS IT'S MY FALUT HE NEH LONGER HAS A RAT.

RON'S EYES WIDENED. THE MINUTE ONE WAS STILL FEELING EXCITEDLY. "KEEP HIM?" HE SAID UNCERTAINLY. HE LOOKED CLOSELY AT THE ONE FOR A MOMENT; THEN, TO HARRY'S AND HERMIONE'S GREAT SURPRISE, HE HELD HIM HELT FOR CROOKSHANKS THE SNIFF.

"WHAT DO YOU RECKON?" RON ASKED THE CAT. "DEFINITELY AN ONE?" CROOKSHANKS PLIRED.

"THAT'S GOOD ENOUGH FOR ME," SAID RON HAPPILY. "HE'S MINE."

HARRY READ AND REREAD THE LETTER FROM SIRIUS ALL THE WAY BACK INTO KING'S CROSS STATION. IT WAS STILL CLUTCHED TIGHTLY IN HIS HAND AS HE, RON, AND HERMIONE STEPPED BACK THROUGH THE BARRIER OF PLATFORM NINE AND THREE-QUARTERS. HARRY SPOTTED UNCLE VERNON AT ONCE. HE WAS STANDING AT GOOD DISTANCE FROM MR. AND MRS. WEASLEY, EYING THEM SUSPICIOUSLY, AND WHEN MRS. WEASLEY HIJGED HARRY IN GREETING, HIS WORST SUSPICIONS ABOUT THEM SEEMED CONFIRMED.

"I'LL CALL ABOUT THE WHEEL CLIP?" RON YELLED AFTER HARRY AS HARRY KID HIM AND HERMIONE GOOD-BYE, THEN WHEELED THE TRILLY BEARING HIS TRUNK AND FRODO'S CASE TOWARD UNCLE VERNON, WHO GREETED HIM IN HIS USUAL FASHION. "WHAT'S THAT?" HE SNARLED, STARING AT THE ENVELOPE HARRY WAS STILL CLUTCHING IN HIS HAND. "IF IT'S ANOTHER FROM FOR ME THE SIGN, YOU'VE GHT ANOTHER ---"

"IT'S NOT," SAID HARRY CHERFULLY. "IT'S A LETTER FROM MY GRANDFATHER."

"GRANDFATHER?" SPLITTERED UNCLE VERNON. "YOU HAVEN'T GHT A GRANDFATHER?"

"YES, I HAVE," SAID HARRY KNIGHTLY. "HE WAS MY MUM AND DAD'S BEST FRIEND. HE'S A CONVICTED MURDERER, BUT HE'S BEEN HELT BY WIZARD PRISON AND HE'S IN THE ALIN. HE LIKES TO KEEP IN TOUCH WITH ME, THOUGH... KEEP

XXX

LIP WITH MY NEWS... CHECK IF I'M HAPPY..."

AND, GRINNING BROADLY AT THE LOOK OF FURROWED EYED LITTLE VERNON'S FACE,

HARRY SET OFF TOWARD THE STATION EXIT, B-E-B-E RATTLING ALONG IN FRONT OF

HIM, FOR WHAT LOOKED LIKE A MUCH BETTER SUMMER THAN THE LAST.

THE END